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SUPPLEMENT 10

The Cappadocian Fathers: Forerunners and Contemporaries

by

CLAUDIO MORESCHINI



PEETERS
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THE CAPPADOCIAN FATHERS: FORERUNNERS AND CONTEMPORARIES

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Allen Brent and Markus Vinzent

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Preface

My first work dealing with the Cappadocian Fathers dates back to 1973, when I published a study on Platonism by Gregory Nazianzen – and the irony of fate is that in that same year Reinhard Hübner published an article on Basil's theology … but, of course, Hübner's was truly 'bahnbrechend'. Since then up to the present time, anno Domini 2020 – *grande mortalis aevi spatium* – I have continued to work on the Cappadocians, and I say this not to write a biography, which rightly would be of no concern to anyone, but because I myself have had the opportunity to see the changes in interests, and also – something no less significant – how different research methods have been used on the subject. Still in the 1970s the Cappadocians were considered a monolith made up of three theologians, headed by Basil, followed by Gregory of Nyssa, a theologian-philosopher, and then by Gregory Nazianzen, theologian-rhetorician, in fact, more rhetorician than theologian. Amphilochius and, above all, Evagrius, were isolated and had nothing to do with Basil and the two Gregorys. Of course, I am not speaking strictly and absolutely about the differences and the intents of the critics… Since then, German scholars have insisted above all on the theology of the Cappadocians, also dealing with the theological environment of the fourth century, considering it with a historical method (which is typical of their researches) and discovering and highlighting minor, and above all anonymous, figures. The scholars of the United States of America, on the other hand, investigated in a more innovative way than their predecessors, and less historically, while French criticism was especially attentive to personal aspects – not biography, but the individual personality of the Cappadocians. English criticism is mainly interested in the historical, social and political – therefore, not just religious – aspects of Basil and the two Gregorys in Cappadocia and Constantinople in the fourth century. And finally, the Italian scholars also slowly devoted themselves to these researches and studies, above all as regards both the theological and historical-political aspects. The art of the Cappadocians was, at the beginning, known in a superficial way: the influence of rhetoric and sophistication on them was certainly acknowledged, but it was studied in a mechanical way, according to the narrow method of 'searching for the sources'. But also in this field, finally, there is an innovation: the Cappadocians were *also* literati, and this is generally admitted, even if in this field there is a lack of comprehensive studies. The problem, however, is now of interest, and even those who investigate the theology dedicate some sections of their work to their art. The French and, in part, the Italians, have also insisted on this problem. The results achieved in the critical editions seem less extensive: if the glorious GNO has almost come to an end, and only one of the most important works of the Nyssen is missing, for Gregory Nazianzen (apart from the more reliable than complete editions of the published homilies by the Sources Chrétiennes, or others – especially

poems) critical editions, conducted with the same criteria as the GNO, do not yet exist, because scholars get lost in the minutiae of Georgian, Arabic, Syriac translations; and for Basil the situation is even worse (we hope that a recent initiative of a global critical edition will soon be completed). Things are even worse for Evagrius, whose works are published, also in an excellent way, but independently of each other, depending on whether they have come down to us in Greek or translated into Eastern languages. And it is very interesting to see that young scholars, or students of great masters, are among those who contribute most to the solution of problems.

I am indebted to my friend Markus Vinzent for the generosity with which he accepted this study. Exhaustive research on the Cappadocians is certainly impossible, but he felt that an investigation conducted in a way which could be described as 'transversal' could be accepted. And I am also grateful to him for something else: he has renounced the unfortunately prevailing system of peer-reviewers, which reaches the deformations of 'blind peer-reviewers', and of simple or double blind peer-reviewers. The peer-reviewer was Markus Vinzent, director of the series, and I think that is enough. Markus revised my text by 'grooming it', as the French say, and above all by correcting the content. He made some objections: some of which I followed, while, for others I thought my interpretation was more correct. Perhaps I was wrong, because I should have followed all his suggestions, but I believe that a free discussion is better than a correction imposed by unknown people.

Alongside Markus Vinzent, I also thank Prof. Dr. Reinhard Hübner, a scholar with whom I was able to discuss my views, receiving from him some confirmations and encouragements that are precious to me. Finally, I thank those who, in Pisa, with great commitment and ability, have translated my original Italian into English: Prof. Elizabeth Mac Donald, Prof. Noor Giovanni Mazhar, and David Braithwaite.

Introduction

In a previous work of mine[1] I observed that up until the 20th century it had been traditional to consider the theology of the Cappadocians in a unitary manner, and I concluded that there are various good reasons to consider the Cappadocians as a group. They were united by a network of family and regional ties; they shared significant involvement in the defence of some crucial theological principles.[2]

Nevertheless, I also noted that despite this, we should not allow these similarities to conceal their differences. Karl Holl, in a study that still carries weight,[3] had stated that the theology of the Cappadocians did not come about overnight. They did not adopt a unitary stance with regard to the crucial issues of their time. Although their 'Gedankenbildung' does not lack its own internal cohesion, substantial differences did exist: one of the most well-known was that between Basil and Gregory Nazianzen with regard to pneumatology.[4] Holl's intuition had little success: subsequent studies (von Balthasar, von Ivanka, Danielou[5]) concentrated their attention almost exclusively on Gregory of Nyssa, in whom they identified a precursor of their own personal philosophical tendencies, namely those dating from the 1930s-1950s, and they paid no attention to Cappadocian theology as a whole. Brooks Otis' reaction derives from this,[6] as he wished to re-establish the 'coherent system' of the three, even if he then concentrated only on certain points (the resurrection of the body and angelology) and excluded theology, since, in his opinion, the system of the Cappadocians should not be considered only as a theological system: he reacted against an interpretation that was due to the fact that the great scholars of the 19th century had mostly been theologians (Harnack, Loofs, Seeberg and Holl).

Just thirty years ago Hanson was still observing that, 'Gregory of Nazianzus differs in some points from Basil, but in none of great importance. His articulation

[1] C. Moreschini, 'Is it possible to speak of "Cappadocian Theology" as a system?' (2017).

[2] As Christoph Markschies asserted, 'Unterschiede innerhalb der kappadozischen Trinitätstheologie haben weder deren Spätantike Protagonisten noch deren Zeitgenossen wirklich wahrgenommen. Es handelt sich um eine weitgehend neuzeitliche Fragestellung', see his 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' in *Alta Trinità Beata* (2000), 227; see also S.P. Bergjan, *Theodoret von Cyrus und der Neunicänismus* (1994), 58-9.

[3] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 116. In any case Holl also speaks of 'the great Cappadocians' (who are the three that everyone knows, and to whom he adds Amphilochius), and interprets their theology jointly. His interpretation of the Cappadocian Fathers which starts with the theology of Basil, who was the other three's master, to a large extent still holds.

[4] *Ibid.* 159.

[5] H.U. von Balthasar's *Présence et Pensée* (1942); J. Daniélou, *Platonisme et Théologie Mystique* (1944); E. von Ivanka, *Hellenisches und Christliches* (1948).

[6] B. Otis, 'Cappadocian Thought as a coherent System' (1958).

of Trinitarian doctrine is clearer, rather more forceful and expressive than that of his friend, as becomes a great stylist,[7] but that is all'.[8] The most recent criticism, instead, is in agreement in stating that 'Cappadocian theology' does not exclude a considerable range of variety of solutions. Reinhard Hübner maintains that the 'theology of the Cappadocians' was never either organic or uniform: the writings of Basil, Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa do not constitute a monolithic block (as it appeared from the meaning of *ousia* according to Basil or Nyssen).[9] Andrew Radde-Gallwitz and Mark DelCogliano have observed that 'all the Cappadocians developed different types of theology with some shared tenets'[10] and that 'for too long Basil's theology was studied as part of a more or less monolithic "Cappadocian" theology rooted in Athanasian thought, which is to say that Basil's thought was most often considered inseparable from that of his fellow Cappadocians Gregory of Nyssa and Gregory of Nazianzus … the usefulness of the category of the "Cappadocian Fathers" has rightly come under suspicion'.[11] John McGuckin states that the *communis opinio* whereby for centuries one has spoken of the 'Cappadocian Fathers' was a consequence of Gregory's Oration 43,[12] in which Gregory speaks of Basil as if he were an intimate friend and master: 'Such a seamless unity is something that can only be sustained on the most careless and generic reading of the texts. Nicenes they may have been, but the details of what that meant both in Christology and Trinitarian Thought calls for a far greater degree of shading'.[13]

Another point on which current criticism agrees is that Gregory of Nyssa is 'the most subtle and intriguing' of all Cappadocians.[14] Nyssen took on Basil's role after his death in the area of ecclesiology and theology, defending him from criticism and expanding his doctrinal intuitions, and he can be considered as the true heir of Basil.[15] All this is indeed true, but, first of all, this difference

[7] This is the *communis opinio* about Gregory of Nazianzus, considered more a rhetorician than a theologian.

[8] R.P.C. Hanson, *The Search for the Christian Doctrine* (1988), 714.

[9] R. Hübner, 'Gregor von Nyssa als Verfasser der sog. Ep. 38 des Basilius' (1972), 464 (= *id*., *Kirche und Dogma im Werden* [2017], 246-7). Subsequently, Hübner also stated that what is lacking in the Cappadocians is a kind of 'consistent terminology and coherent thinking' ('konsistenter Begrifflichkeit und kohärentem Denken'), and this was because the post-Nicene Trinitarian doctrine is 'in the making' ('im Werden'), so that neither the history of the previous theology nor philosophy could come up with adequate categories. This is also accepted by V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung der Trinitätslehre* (1996), 324 and K. Corrigan, 'Οὐσία and ὑπόστασις' (2008), 115.

[10] A. Radde-Gallwitz and M. DelCogliano, *St. Basil of Caesarea, Against Eunomius* (2011), 18-9.

[11] *Ibid*. 17.

[12] This interpretation appears to me to be highly speculative.

[13] J.A. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 374.

[14] S. Coakley, 'Introduction – Gender, Trinitarian Analogies, and the Pedagogy of The Song' (2003), 1. See also J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of* Nyssa (2000), 17-9 and L. Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy* (2004), 250-1.

[15] A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 15-7, and prior to this, *id*., *Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nyssa* (2009), 16 and 175-6.

has been perceived above all in Trinitarian theology (and perhaps also in Pneumatology), and, what is more, in a random manner. Consequently, other aspects of their thought (for instance, Christology or asceticism, or various issues that can generically be considered philosophical) have been studied mostly in relation to Basil or Gregory of Nyssa.

It is my intention, therefore, to explore the extent to which Cappadocian theology is not monolithic – and that their works are not only about theology!

1. *Only Theology?*

Another issue that needs to be considered is that so far studies have only focused on the religious aspect and have shown little interest in the Cappadocians' literary output.[16] The range of research, therefore, has to be widened: the Cappadocians were not just theologians and homilists, and they did not write works destined to be read only by Christians. Cultivated people with a background in *paideia*, which was the same as for non-Christian writers (and this is as true for the Greek East as for the Latin West), they wished to have access to the literary forms that were most useful for their didactic activities (for example, in homilies), or also rhetorical use (for example, in epistolography or poetry): thus, literary activity should not be considered as extraneous to their speculative thought, even though they were famous above all for the latter rather than the former. Their interest in philosophy can be traced to their openness to pagan *paideia*, which had a long tradition in Christianity, ever since the School of Alexandria.[17]

2. *Gregorius Nazianzenus Rhetor?*

Recent studies, as well as confirming that Cappadocian theology is not uniform, agree on another characteristic: their attention is focused on Gregory of Nyssa and to a lesser extent on Basil, who is held to be the acknowledged master by his brother, as well as by his friend, Gregory of Nazianzus (but this friendship was not exempt from disagreements). Scholars have shown interest in the rhetoric of the Cappadocians only as far as Gregory of Nazianzus is concerned – with a negative evaluation. From 1970 onwards Nazianzen was studied apart, but only because he was considered to be of a theologically inferior level. Unlike Gregory of Nyssa, Gregory of Nazianzus did not so obviously depend on Basil and managed to mark out his own path.[18] This path was

[16] Some specific research on Gregory of Nyssa's literary abilities, normally considered the least gifted among the Cappadocians, has been carried out by Matthieu Cassin and Andrew Radde-Gallwitz; within the context of late antique epistolography, their epistolography has been studied by Bradley Storin and others.

[17] The interest of the Cappadocians in philosophy has been ascertained to the point that, in my opinion, there is a risk of going to the opposite extreme and considering them almost Neo-Platonists.

[18] A. Radde-Gallwitz and M. DelCogliano, *St. Basil of Caesarea* (2011), 18.

not considered of a high level. The fact that Gregory of Nazianzus' writings are not studied as carefully as those of Basil or Gregory of Nyssa stems from a lack of regard (sometimes manifest, sometimes concealed): Gregory of Nazianzus' speculations appear to have been limited by a lack of critical and speculative intelligence, which becomes apparent in his peculiar way of tackling problems, that is, in a rhetorical-homiletic manner, which differs from Basil's and Gregory of Nyssa's 'treatise-like' approach. Already in 1952 Prestige had synthesised this interpretation when he defined Gregory as 'an inspired popularizer',[19] and only a few voices were raised against this (such as that of Claudio Moreschini).[20] This interpretation is unsatisfactory: if Gregory of Nazianzus' form of communication is indeed 'rhetorical', this does not mean that it is 'illogical': Nazianzen presents his doctrines in rhapsodic form, but they are no less acute than those of Basil or Gregory of Nyssa. This evaluation of Gregory's writings was contested by McGuckin,[21] who observes that only rarely was any attempt made to penetrate below the surface of the text and little consideration was accorded to the dialectical nature of its context. The *communis opinio* of scholarly criticism is that Gregory Nazianzen is a pure rhetorician, or, according to more superficial and sentimental evaluations, he was a self-effacing and 'romantic' man of letters, ready to yield before any difficulties and to retire into solitude, and therefore incapable of facing the difficulties posed by the controversies of his time.[22] Only in isolated instances has recent criticism (Francis Gautier, Christopher Beeley) reconsidered Gregory Nazianzus' theological abilities in a positive vein.[23] His dynamic and concrete character and the importance of his efforts to organize a Trinitarian theology have been underlined not only by McGuckin,[24] but also by Francis Gautier, who wrote an intellectual biography of Gregory that confutes the commonplaces regarding him and presents numerous personal interpretations.[25]

Susanna Elm has also advanced a positive assessment of Gregory Nazianzen' *paideia*.[26] Gregory is as much a 'son of Hellenism' as Julian. He sets his defense of Christianity against the hard defense of Hellenism, which was Julian's ideal; but common to both was the defense of the *logoi*, of the idea of God, of the

[19] G.L. Prestige, *God in Patristic Thought* (1925), 234.

[20] Cl. Moreschini, *I Padri Cappadoci* (2008).

[21] J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001).

[22] Recently, Mark Edwards, who has dedicated most of his chapter on the Cappadocians and Aristotle to Gregory of Nyssa, also dedicated a page to Basil, see his *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2019), 112 and half a page to Gregory Nazianzen (*ibid.* 113).

[23] Chr.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus on the Trinity* (2008), 10 n. 28: 'The prevalent view that Basil is the major source for Gregory's work … must be thoroughly reconsidered'.

[24] J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 146, 189, 239 and 277.

[25] Fr. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002). Unfortunately Gautier did not continue to pursue his studies.

[26] S. Elm, *Sons of Hellenism, Fathers of the Church* (2012).

world, of the Roman Empire and of Greek *paideia*. Here criticism goes to the opposite extreme: Elm's suggestion is correct, but she pays no attention to Gregory's Christian formation. It is not possible to interpret his formation by only taking into account his disputes with the Emperor Julian and staying 'Greek' like him. Elm fails to bear in mind the greatest part of Gregory Nazianzus' output, which is subsequent to his *Invectivae in Iulianum*. Another issue has been of interest above all to historians: out of *petitio principii* they consider Gregory Nazianzen only as a Bishop who had to manage political issues and his rhetoric as a mean useful to framing himself in a positive manner for political ends ('a self-made Holy Man'), with no reference whatsoever to his religious thought.[27]

3. *Other Cappadocians?*

Another question that arises is the need to clarify who exactly the 'Cappadocian Fathers' were.[28] Naturally, concerning Amphilochius' relations with Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus, Holl opened up the road,[29] even if Amphilochius has not been studied with any great interest, and effectively remains on a lower level compared to Basil and the two Gregories, both in the area of the Trinity and the issue of Christology.[30]

In my opinion the presence of Evagrius Ponticus too among the Cappadocians is justified, at least as far as one part of his doctrine is concerned.[31] The *Realien* of his biography (Evagrius was nominated lector by Basil, deacon by Gregory of Nazianzus, who then entrusted him to bishop Nectarius when he had to leave the Council of Constantinople; Evagrius is recalled by Gregory Nazianzen in his testament[32]) are all in favour of this addition.[33] Socrates (*HE* IV 23), gives us many details; Sozomen's account is shorter, but clear (*HE* VI 30): 'Evagrius was educated in philosophy and Holy Scripture by Gregory, Bishop of Nazianzus'. When he recalls the teaching he had been given by 'our wise master'

[27] This, for example, is what Federico Fatti, 'In ossequio alle leggi dell'encomio' (2004) and Neil McLynn, 'A Self-Made Holy Man' (1998) maintain.

[28] There have also been those who suggested considering Eunomius as one of the Cappadocian Fathers on account of his background (Oltiseris, where he was born, lay on the border between Galatia and Cappadocia).

[29] Followed also by Ch. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 196 n. 2 and 228.

[30] A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria del IV secolo* (2017).

[31] I asserted this in my previous work, Cl. Moreschini, *I Padri Cappadoci* (2008), but István Perczel had already suggested it, I. Perczel, 'Notes sur la pensée' (2002).

[32] For the text of this document see PG 37, 389-96; J. Beaucamp, *Le testament de Grégoire de Nazianze* (1988).

[33] On the basis of ancient sources modern scholars repeat that Evagrius was a disciple of Gregory of Nazianzus, J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (1997), 276-7; F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 87 and 93; Guillaumont and Casiday and, of course, others.

(*Praktikòs* 89), Evagrius is definitely referring to Gregory of Nazianzus, and in the conclusion of the same treatise he advocates 'the prayers and intercession of Gregory the Just, who planted me, and the holy Fathers, who now water me' (that is, the desert Fathers, with whom he was then staying).[34] Palladius (*Hist. Laus*. 38) also provides us with a great deal of information about Evagrius:[35] he was born in Pontus, in the city of Ibora, and was the son of a *chorepiscopus*; Basil nominated him as a liturgical reader and, after Basil's death, he was welcomed by Gregory of Nazianzus, who was an extremely cultivated man and noted his intellectual prowess, and nominated him deacon. Subsequently, during the Council of Constantinople, Gregory entrusted him to Bishop Nectarius, since Evagrius was more than capable of combatting all the heresies. Gregory and the desert Fathers (following the tradition of Origen) are therefore the basis of his cultural formation. Claudio Moreschini followed Guillaumont for Evagrius' biography and doctrine,[36] and Augustine Casiday also underlines Evagrius' formation with Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus.[37]

For this reason, the position taken by those who trace a parallel between Evagrius' and Gregory of Nyssa's doctrine[38] does not seem tenable to us. It is absurd to believe that the fact that Gregory of Nyssa went to Jerusalem in 381 might have prompted him to also go to Alexandria, where he could have been Evagrius' master; as a matter of fact, Evagrius was not in any case in Alexandria, but much farther away in the desert of the Egyptian hinterland.[39] Gregory of Nyssa's *Epistle* 2 is very clear in this regard (ch. 12): Gregory had been sent to Jerusalem and Arabia by a Council (we do not know exactly which one: perhaps the Council of Antioch in 379); if he had also gone to Alexandria, what better occasion than this to announce it? Furthermore, in ancient times travelling was not as easy as it is now, when one can lengthen one's journey for a range of reasons, including tourism, and even if Alexandria *now* seems to us to be quite near Jerusalem, to the ancients this was not the case.

[34] These historical testimonies have been well studied by A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 33-8.

[35] The longest version of Palladius' text is also credible. His account is definitely trustworthy because it derives from relationships based on firsthand knowledge of Evagrius, as Antoine Guillaumont explains, presenting Evagrius' biography, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 14-75. From this it may clearly be seen that Evagrius had direct links with Basil and Gregory Nazianzen; however, despite there not being any direct sources in this regard, it is likely that Evagrius may also have met Gregory of Nyssa.

[36] Cl. Moreschini, *I Padri Cappadoci* (2008), 72-6, 200-2.

[37] A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology of Evagrius Ponticus* (2013).

[38] K. Corrigan, *Evagrius and Gregory* (2009), completely removed from any historically-driven issues; I.L.E. Ramelli, 'Evagrius and Gregory: Nazianzen or Nyssen?' (2013).

[39] For that matter, Ramelli's bibliography is hurried because she is not even *au fait* with the crucial paper by Antoine Guillaumont, which skilfully unites theological analyses and the *Realien* of the person and biography of Evagrius. Nor does she appear to be familiar with Claudio Moreschini, *I Padri Cappadoci* (2008), which explains the relationship between Evagrius and the other Cappadocians.

The choice itself of the monastic life on the part of Evagrius, which Palladius recounts for us, has a precise direction – that of a very different type of monasticism to the one Basil had embraced.[40] Evagrius went off into the desert, where fifteen years previously (but only for a brief time) Basil had also gone; Basil, however, had returned to Cappadocia in order to found his own personal type of 'monasticism'. Moreover, in the Egyptian ascetic ambience Origenism was widespread, which Evagrius in fact learned so that subsequently he came to be known as one of its most important representatives.[41] Thus, Evagrius brought criticism on himself (but more out of hearsay than for any concrete knowledge) from Jerome in the west and, in the east, he was condemned by the ecumenical council in Constantinople of 553.[42] This division of Evagrius' life into two parts (one of which with the masters in Cappadocia and the other with the ascetics in the desert, where he had moved following a spiritual crisis) produced a split in his thought: Evagrius partly followed Gregory of Nyssa's doctrine and, above all, Gregory Nazianzen', who had re-elaborated Origenism in a personal way, and partly that of the Egyptian ascetics, among whom Origenism had been conserved far more thoroughly. In this study, this division also affected the structure of the part dedicated to Evagrius. Obviously, any investigation into Evagrius' theological, philosophical and ascetic doctrines would require a study in itself, so they are here considered only in terms of any problems that might link him to the other Cappadocians. According to Guillaumont, any contact between Evagrius and Gregory of Nyssa as far as his ascetic doctrines are concerned may have derived from the fact that Evagrius was a disciple of Macarius the Egyptian[43] who, in his turn, was a friend of Gregory Nyssen. This hypothesis is too tortuous: I suppose that Evagrius, for so long as he stayed in Constantinople, didn't learn only the doctrines of Gregory Nazianzen, but also those of Gregory Nyssen. Indeed, Nyssen had already written important treatises before Evagrius left Constantinople in 382, so Evagrius could have come in contact with them: in 379 *De opificio hominis*, which contains Nyssen's anthropology; between 380 and 381 the first two books of *Contra Eunomium*, which were crucial for his theology, and *De anima et resurrectione*, where he discusses the doctrine of apocatastasis, perhaps that same year; in addition, Gregory of Nyssa had been one of the most important

[40] Basil, however, is at one point mentioned by Evagrius as 'the pillar of truth, Basil of Cappadocia' (*Gnost*. 45).

[41] The Egyptian desert was not just a place where ignorant people lived; on this topic see the recent L. Larsen and S. Rubenson (eds), *Monastic Education in Late Antiquity* (2018).

[42] See A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 46-61; obviously, 'Origen's thought' is distinguished from 'Origenism', that is, the collection of doctrines that can be traced back to Origen starting from the end of the 4th century and which developed subsequently without Origen being directly responsible for this. Regarding this problem see Elizabeth Clark, *The Origenist Controversy* (1992), which, however, unjustifiably involves Evagrius in this 'Origenism': see Casiday's observations in this regard, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 46-51.

[43] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 55.

bishops participating in the Council in 381. For this reason, it is not strange that some of Gregory of Nyssa's doctrines, such as those I have indicated, are effectively found in Evagrius alongside those of Gregory Nazianzen. In other words, in order to identify the relationship between Gregory of Nyssa and Evagrius there is no need to have recourse to hypothetical journeys and equally hypothetical geographical scenarios.

This is sufficient for Evagrius to be considered a Cappadocian, not only for his place of birth but also for his thought.[44] According to Julia Konstantinovsky, the lack of a personal relationship between Evagrius and Gregory Nazianzen in the last part of Evagrius' life may point to a rift with Gregory and the culture of the Cappadocians.[45] This is excessive: the doctrinal differences ought not to be interpreted as a controversy, but rather as fundamental change in Evagrius' thought, whose interests definitely changed after he settled in the desert (which was all but inevitable), but some of the doctrines that he acquired from his masters in Cappadocia remained, even if re-elaborated – and it could not have been any different, given that Evagrius, despite being their disciple, had his own lively and independent personality. Therefore, I do not agree with Konstantinovsky's claim, whereby Evagrius was initially a 'metropolitan theologian', then 'a desert wise man', an Origenist among Origenists,[46] and that his choice of living in the desert led to the break with Gregory.[47]

From all this, it seems permissible to consider Evagrius Ponticus as being one of the Cappadocians as well. Even though his personal affairs and the end of his life, which, among other things, occurred when Gregory Nazianzen was already dead, place him more within Egyptian rather than Cappadocian monasticism.

[44] For this reason, I have not reconsidered *in extenso* all of the bibliography dedicated to Evagrius, but only what, in my opinion, is the best. I used the crucial studies by Guillaumont and Casiday; plus that by Julia S. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), in which, however, I do not understand the unjustifiable controversy with and position against Guillaumont and other 'Catholic' critics, according to which their interpretation may have been unduly influenced by confessional input, based on the anathemas of the Council of Constantinople in 553 (as if 'Catholic' doctrine is to be identified with the deliberations of a council that took place fifteen centuries ago!). Against Guillaumont's 'Catholic' interpretation, to which are attributed positions that Guillaumont did not hold, such as 'the all-pervasive Cappadocian influence upon Evagrius' (Guillaumont of all people, who recovered texts from the Syriac ambience!), Konstantinovsky juxtaposes her own, which is indeed far more confessionally determined, and either arrives at the same conclusions as Guillaumont (such as recognizing the links between Evagrius, Basil and Gregory Nazianzen) or, to avoid these, has recourse to extremely 'allegorical' interpretations. Confessional convictions ought to remain outside historical interpretations. Despite these reservations, overall Konstantinovsky's study is very useful and informed. Criticism of Evagrius' interpretation of Christology put forward by Refoulé and Guillaumont, however, have also been advanced by Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 189-204.

[45] *Ibid*. 14-5.

[46] *Ibid*. 18-9.

[47] *Ibid*. 27.

Finally, I shall make some reference, if brief, to the theology of Apollinaris, a Nycene with whom the Cappadocians were well acquainted and whom they initially appreciated on account of his Trinitarian theology,[48] just as they subsequently disputed his Christology. Unfortunately, the Trinitarian theology of Apollinaris is still far less known than that of the Cappadocians because of its fragmentary nature and, above all, the uncertainty regarding the attribution to him of apocryphal works such as *Contra Sabellianos*, attributed to Athanasius, and the fourth and fifth books of *Contra Eunomium* by Basil.[49] But I deal with this issue in another contribution of mine.[50]

In conclusion, the intention of this study is to highlight the cultural and theological formation of the Cappadocians through their differences and through the various means with which they then deal better with the same issues. Consequently, I do not wish to consider, as has usually occurred, mainly Trinitarian theology, because their culture was not only theological, but also very wide-ranging. I believe that realising the differences in their conceptions is very useful for grasping their importance on a historical level, no less than underlining their similarities: it is in this harmonious chain of theology, philosophy and literature that the most important aspect of their personalities lies. A *concordia discors* may also have favoured the development of Christian thought, and definitely the variety of its manifestations has been no less fruitful than any homogeneity.

[48] Still in Epistle 244,3 from 376, Basil considers Apollinaris as orthodox.

[49] V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung* (1996), 31-7. Elm tries to point out the importance of Apollinaris for the theological formation of Gregory Nazianzen, considering that Apollinaris' *KMP* was written in 362, 'Apollinarius of Laodicaea and Gregory of Nazianzus' (2015), 7-8. The influence of Apollinaris is likely, but the parallelisms found by Elm remain external, and the use of certain technical terms is not specific to Apollinaris or Nazianzen: for instance, Elm states that the verb θεόω is used only by Gregory Nazianzen and Apollinaris (fr. 147 Lietzmann) (*ibid.* 9 and n. 28).

[50] Cl. Moreschini, 'Pseudo-Basil against Eunomius and Cappadocian Theology' (2021).

Chapter I

Paideia and Christianity

In the 4th century, for a Christian to be educated in the 'pagan' culture taught at school was not perceived to be a problem, unlike the period preceding Constantine when the juxtaposition between Athens and Jerusalem seemed to determine the life choices that ensued following conversion (but things should not be taken *aux pieds de la lettre*, not even for that era). During the Cappadocian era the difficult relationship between Christianity and the *Paideia* tradition depended, basically, on the *petitio principii* that only Christian revelation always and unassailably constituted the truth, to which every other doctrine had to give way, insofar as it lacked any intrinsic value. In practice, however, for learned Christians, and not only for bishops or theologians, *paideia* and its models had long since palled, so school opened up the two most important disciplines for free men: rhetoric and philosophy.

For that again, the mutual tolerance between pagans and Christians was not such a rare thing. A great deal has been written about this, so that what is taken into consideration here is only the position of the pagans and the Christians facing the religious problem, above all the most important question of all: which god should be worshipped. Themistius' conciliating example – pagan – dates back to these years and was no different to the emperor Jovian's approach, who was a Christian, a convinced Christian, given that he received a 'dogmatic' letter from both Athanasius and Apollinaris, who were two Nicene bishops that more than the others had had to suffer on account of the religious policy of Julian's predecessor, Constantius.

Themistius' Oration 5 (Ὑπατικός, εἰς τὸν αὐτοκράτορα Ἰοβιανόν) was pronounced in the Senate of Constantinople in the year 364, on the occasion of Jovian's "edict of toleration",[1] which revoked the anti-Christian edicts issued by Julian in the preceding two years. This edict was intended to establish religious tolerance towards the Christians, so the two religions (69C: ἑκατέρα θρησκεία) were no longer in conflict, nor was there any reason for them to be. Themistius was pleased with this tolerance. God, he stated, ensured that the human soul's predisposition to religion was inherent in all, but wanted that the τρόπος τῆς θεραπείας depended on the will of the individual (7,68A). Freedom of religion meant that there was a competition in religiousness between the various peoples of the empire. The emperor also held that the great, true judge of this competition is only one, the unknown god, but that many roads

[1] On this law cf. recently M. Marcos, 'Emperor Jovian's Law' (2014), with an extensive bibliography that also included material from previous studies; also M.C. De Vita, 'Una nobile gara di pietà' (2014).

lead to him.[2] The Lord of the Universe himself is pleased with this variety of religions: he wants the various peoples (Syrians, Greeks, Egyptians) to worship him in the way each of them pleases (9,70A).

Although Themistius speaks of freedom of religion, not of the unique god,[3] in substance, he also states that a supreme god exists, who is superior to the gods of the various peoples of the empire. When he states that Syrians,[4] Greeks and Egyptians all worship the gods of their own nations, Themistius does not hold that each of these gods identifies with the supreme god, but distinguishes them from him, because it is precisely the supreme god who wants these gods to be worshipped.

1. *Athens*

As an indication of how Christian society did not manifest any real opposition to paganism there is the education of Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus in Athens, along with the fact that they (and their families) did not think it ill-advised, despite being Christian, to study in a city noted for its cultural tradition and the presence at that time of pagan philosophy. Before going to Athens, Gregory had studied in Caesarea in Cappadocia (Hieron., *Vir. illustr.* 113),[5] and subsequently in Alexandria. It is also strange that Gregory should remember Alexandria only in passing (*Carm.* II 1,11,129), and attribute greater importance to Athens, despite the fame of Clement, Origen and, more recently, Athanasius.[6] It has often been said that the stay in Alexandria enabled Gregory to acquaint himself with Origenism, but Gregory himself says nothing in this regard.

Basil and Gregory's studies in Athens were, however, an isolated case, at least on the basis of what we know.[7] It is also interesting that, despite not having

[2] The similarity between these images and Symmachus' famous affirmation (*Relatio* III 9): *uno itinere non potest perveniri ad tam grande secretum* is evident.

[3] See, e.g. A.H. Armstrong, 'The Way and the Ways' (1984), 8-9; C. Ando, 'Pagan Apologetics and Christian Intolerance' (1996), 179-80; I. Sandwell, 'Pagan Conceptions of Monotheism' (2010), 101-26, and, more generally, M. Frede, 'The case for pagan monotheism' (2010), 53-81; A. Fürst, 'Monotheism between cult and politics' (2010), 82-99; A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 253.

[4] These 'Syrians', according to M. Marcos, 'Emperor Jovian's Law' (2014), 163 n. 51, are the Christians, called by the name of their country of origin, as was usual with pagans (for example, Celsus and Julian). However, I find it strange that in 363 they were still not called Christians, the name that became more common, so that I believe Themistius is actually talking about the people of Syria, who worshipped their own gods like the Greeks and Egyptians did theirs.

[5] L. Lugaresi, 'Studenti cristiani e scuola pagana' (2004), 805 n. 64.

[6] This had already been observed by K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 120n. Gregory, however, recalls a detail that definitely must have been obtained *in loco*, that is, a particular way the Alexandrians had of taking an oath (*Orat.* 21,28).

[7] An education in Athens corresponded to the typical educational norms of a young man of good family, destined for a lay career, according to J.A. McGuckin, *St Gregory of Nazianzus*

studied in Athens, Gregory of Nyssa acquired a philosophical education that was superior to that of Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus: this points to the fact that it could also be procured elsewhere (for example, in Caesarea in Cappadocia), or by other means such as books, as opposed to a school.[8]

Athens represented a cultural ideal that could, however, be interpreted differently depending on the convictions of the individuals in question, whether pagan or Christian. The emperor Julian stayed there for reasons that had nothing in common with Gregory or Basil: in Athens it was possible for him to come into contact with pagan priests, probably those of the sacred mysteries.[9] Gregory, who was an eye-witness to Julian (and most likely also to his interests) is more hostile to him and his philosophical-religious concepts than the other Cappadocians were.[10] For these same reasons, twenty years after

(2001), 35; nonetheless, we do not know of any other cases of the education of young Christians in Athens and it does not seem possible to make any comparison with the centuries preceding the fourth, both because it was above all the westerners who went to Athens, and because this does not seem to have been a frequent habit among Christians. Bernardi has attempted to explore the relationship between Gregory Nazianzen and his father Gregory the Elder, and clarify what Gregory's early education may have consisted of, along with the reason why, following his education in Caesarea, he continued his studies in Athens, but his observations remain hypothetical, J. Bernardi, *Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (1995), 102-11.

A history of Gregory's and Basil's cultural formation in A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 127-35. Gautier is innovative, F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 268-70, even if hypothetical (e.g. Gregory appears to have assiduously attended the courses by Prohaeresius in Athens).

Biographical details, still under discussion, will not be taken into account: for instance, whether Gregory was baptised in Athens so as to keep faith with the vow made during the crossing from Alexandria to Greece, due to a seastorm, J. McGuckin, *St Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 55; whether the baptism was a sort of initiation ceremony (*ibid*. 63-74); on Gregory's baptism see J. Bernardi, *Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (1995), 112 n. 12; A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 157-8; S. Rubenson, 'The Cappadocians on the Areopagus' (2006), 113-32, 114 n. 4; Aaron Wenzel maintains that Gregory is taken with the ideal of Athens even more than Libanius, who was interested above all in underlining the importance of Antioch for studies, 'Libanius, Gregory of Nazianzus' (2010).

[8] On Gregory of Nyssa's cultural formation see also M. Cassin, '34a Grégoire de Nysse' (2018), 536-9.

[9] Greg. Nazianz., *Orat*. 5,23; Gregory by no means approved of mysteric experience (*Orat*. 4,59); A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 146-7 and 158-9. On the Athenian schools in the imperial era, see W.H. Liebeschütz, 'Hochschule' (1991), 869-70 and 874-5.

[10] A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 168 n. 18 has studied the links between Basil and Julian, which however remain hazy. The Basil to whom Julian's letter n. 32 is sent cannot be identified with the bishop of Caesarea and is a subsequent forgery, as R. Pouchet rightly points out in *Basile le Grand* (1992), 174-5. John Malala (*Hist*. 13,25) and the *Chronicon Paschale* (552,10-2 Dindorf), in wishing to attribute a link also between Basil and Julian, refer that Basil appears to have been highly esteemed by Julian and that he is alleged to have corresponded with him. This desire for falsification is answered by the correspondence between Julian and Basil (letters nn. 40 and 41 of Basil's epistolary), which was invented due to the fame Basil had as an intrepid defender of the faith. All these apocryphal letters conflict with the chronology and are probably an encomiastic reconstruction of the figure of Basil. For the same reason the

his anti-Julian diatribe, Gregory discusses the paganism in Athens in detail (*Orat*. 43,21), stating that in that city it had both celebrators and defenders[11] and underlining the fact, to praise Basil and himself, that instead of corrupting them, it had just served to strengthen their Christian faith.

It is not therefore possible that Basil and Gregory sought in Athens a religious education that they had not found in Cappadocia: in the 4th century Athens was a city of little importance, except for its past, and it had remained outside the Trinitarian debates: they may have gone there because they were attracted by its fame and its literary tradition. We do not know who Basil's and Gregory's masters were. The ambience of the rhetoric masters in Athens is described by Eunapius, according to whom Athenian decadence meant the decadence of the whole of Greece (*VS* 6,2,6), but Athens remained a bastion of pagan culture (*VS* 18,1), as was Eunapius himself. For Prohaeresius, who was Christian, Gregory wrote an epitaph (n. 5), which testifies to his friendship with this Sophist and perhaps also his disciples. Prohaeresius' master in Athens had been a certain Julian, who came from Cappadocia (Eunapius, *VS* IX, 1,1).[12] Prohaeresius attracted many scholars from Pontus and nearby regions to his school (Eunapius, *VS* X 3,12) and Breitenbach posits that Basil and Gregory attended it.[13] It is not demonstrable, even if not unlikely, that Himerius was their master,

Julian who was a friend of Basil's and about whom Sozomen speaks (*HE* VI 2,2–5), cannot be identified as the emperor. See P. Van Nuffelen, 'Deux fausses lettres' (2002), 131-50; *contra:* J. Bouffartigue, 'L'authenticité de la lettre 84' (2005), 231-42; F. Aceto, 'Note sull'autenticità dell'ep. 84' (2008), 187-206. The topic of the friendship between Julian and Basil was taken up by Federico Fatti in a highly informed study *Giuliano a Cesarea* (2009), which nevertheless lacks definitive proof that they were acquainted during the reign of Julian. While Gregory of Nazianzus, as transpires from *Oration* 5 (ch. 23), declares that he met Julian, it is likely that Basil did too, who at that time was in Athens with Gregory; nevertheless, he never mentions him and it is impossible to draw any conclusions from this fact.

[11] See Jean Bernardi, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 42-43* (1992), 166 n. 3: with the exception of Prohaeresius, the masters who taught in Athens were all pagan. I would also add that there is a particularly difficult passage in this oration: *Orat*. 43,1,1-5 which is very difficult to interpret, so much so that Bernardi thought that it contains an interpolation; there has been an attempt to explain it by L. Bossina and F. Fatti, 'Gregorio a due voci' (2004), 74-8. I add that the difficulty was also acknowledged by Maximus the Confessor, who tried to explain it in *Amb. Ioh*. 70, but he did not succeed either.

[12] On Prohaeresius' Cappadocian origins, see R. Penella, *Greek Philosophers* (1990). The links between Prohaeresius and Gregory were not particularly close, despite Prohaeresius being a Christian and Gregory having written an epitaph on him, as has been said, J. Bernardi, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 42-43 (1992), 157. Lugaresi also doubts that Prohaeresius was an important master for Gregory, 'Studenti cristiani e scuola pagana' (2004), 806 n. 69. It is certain, however, that in *Oration* 43 Gregory makes no mention of him (nor does he mention any other master, since he wishes to underline the fact that neither he nor Basil needed any masters, not even Christian ones).

[13] A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 149. Basil's encomium also represents an auto-celebration of Gregory himself, C. Castelli, 'Gregorio di Nazianzo nell'*Epitafio per Basilio il grande*' (2005).

as among his students there were Cappadocians.[14] In any case, neither Himerius nor Prohaeresius mention Basil or Gregory.

In conclusion, Gregory and Basil sought traditional *paideia* in Athens, which could have been of use either in Nazianzus or in Caesarea in order to be a Christian orator, despite the fact that their home education had been strictly Christian: Gregory of Nyssa tells how it was 'forbidden' in his house to speak of pagan fairy tales or myths[15] and Macrina (Greg. Nyss., *Macrin*. 3) was educated in this way, as was Gorgonia, sister of Gregory of Nazianzus (Greg. Nazianz. *Orat*. 18,10).

2. *Athens and* Paideia

For Basil, Athens had a different meaning compared to what it had for Gregory. Already during the course of his education in his native land, Gregory had been interested in literature,[16] and so he celebrates Athens at various times: in the eulogy to Basil (*Orat*. 43,11), in *Epist*. 46,2 (where he explicitly mentions the fact that both he and Basil spent time together in Athens), and in *Epist*. 188,1 and 189,2 (where he recalls two friends of his, who also studied in Athens, Stagirius and Eustochios). Overall, therefore, it may be said that to Gregory, both in his youth and when recalling it after thirty years, Athens appeared to be the seat of culture and the length of his stay there (about ten years, while Basil stayed there only for about five on account of a personal crisis) means that Gregory found it to be to his liking, even if he presented Basil as if he shared his sentiments (*Orat*. 43,13). His stay in Athens is recounted by Gregory in the epitaph for Basil, which must be interpreted cautiously, as a re-elaboration by Gregory of how much, in 382, he was thinking of Basil.[17] The description of their life in Athens is in many respects disappointing: Gregory speaks of his

[14] The identification of Basil with the Cappadocian mentioned in Himerius' speech 18 is uncertain: L. Lugaresi, 'Studenti cristiani e scuola pagana' (2004), 805-6. The absence of any mention of Himerius may be due to the different religious faith, according to O. Vox, 'Su Gregorio di Nazianzo e Imerio' (2017), 151 n. 4, but this does not seem possible because pagans were still being nominated with ease by Basil, Nazianzen and Nyssen. Greater details, which however do not manage to arrive at a definitive conclusion, may be found in the study by Vox, for example on Candidianus (Nazianzen, *Epist*. 10), on whom also see U. Criscuolo, 'Sull'epistola 10' (1985), 115-20.

[15] Of course, these statements should not be taken literally, but it is likely that the education of a Christian woman would have been stricter than that of a man: learned aristocratic women in Rome, of whom Jerome speaks, or Olympias in Constantinople, were a rarity.

[16] Cf. Greg. Naz., *De vita sua* (*carm*. II 1,11,112-20). Of course, Gregory also hastens to explain that his interest in literature did not cancel his Christian education and that he rejected the fashionable oratory of that time.

[17] That Basil's epitaph written by Gregory Nazianzen is completely trustworthy, is currently increasingly a matter of doubt: the most recent critics agree that Gregory wanted to give Basil an image in conformity with his concepts, and that he intended to present himself as his only real friend and collaborator. See the studies by F. Fatti and N. Mc Lynn (*inter alios*) and, above all,

friendship with Basil, but only mentions what he wanted to be known; he does not, however, mention much about their life at that time and in that city,[18] he does not give us the name of any of his teachers and tells us nothing about the specific nature of his studies, or what was being taught in the schools. His interpretation of that episode dating from their youth is that in any case it is possible to perfect oneself in the Christian virtues even in a pagan city, thus finding an equilibrium between *paideia* and a Christian education. He interprets Basil's education in the same way, despite the fact that Basil cut short his stay in Athens: already in his native land, Basil had been renowned for his eloquence and his philosophy and had been educated in *enkyklios paideia* and the worship of God. His early studies led to his subsequent achievements. Thanks to this education, Basil became greater than any other orator, Sophist or philosopher, even if he had not attended their schools; but above all, he was a priest even before the priesthood. But for Basil, the *logoi* that he learnt at school were secondary and he needed them only in order to perfect Christian philosophy, because they too are necessary for demonstrating Christian concepts: an intellect that is incapable of speaking is akin to the movement of a paralysed person. Initially Basil went to Byzantium, which was famous for its oratory, and then (love for) God and his voracity for discourses led him to Athens, where the Sophistic was so in vogue.[19]

With the passing of time Basil and Gregory understood that philosophy was the main object of their search. In spite of living in an environment that was filled with profane erudition, which might easily lead to pride filling the soul, they kept themselves free of this and dedicated themselves principally to acquiring the virtues, 'to living with their eye on future hopes while remaining detached from earth before ever leaving it'. They attended both the pagan and the Christian schools, gaining the attention of their teachers, and had gained a name for themselves not only in Athens, but also in Greece, so much so that they expected to be given the chair of rhetoric: this is what Gregory claims in *De vita sua* (II,1,11,249-62),[20] but this seems unlikely for two twenty-five-year olds and the claim shows signs of the rhetorical *auxesis* that was so typical of Gregory. At a certain moment (around 355) Basil said that Athens was basically 'vain happiness' (κενὴν μακαρίαν) (Greg. Naz., *Orat*. 43,18): this means that his interest in *paideia* had disappeared. The only testimony by Basil in this regard is his *Epistle* 1, which manifests the intention of following the 'philosopher' Eustathius, that is, his spiritual master, around 358-360: Basil

on the cultural activity by Gregory after his retreat from the Council of Constantinople, B. Storin, 'In a silent way' (2011).

[18] S. Rubenson, 'The Cappadocians on the Areopagus' (2006), 113-5. In fact, Gregory speaks about the habits of the Athenian students, but he mostly gives details on their behaviour.

[19] *Orat*. 43,10-5.

[20] *Orat*. 43,22. This is the interpretation of various scholars, above all F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 278.

had sought him out determinedly for several years, and so after he had left Athens.

On the basis of this fact (and, naturally, also of subsequent events in Basil's life) critics think they can identify a difference in Gregory's and Basil's behaviour: Gregory appears to have been far more in favour of Athens, and he recalls its symbolic and cultural significance with enthusiasm, while at a certain point Basil was disgusted by it, recalling Athens as a place of sloth in *Epistle* 223,2 fifteen years later, and this epistle too was sent to Eustathius.[21] It is likely that his previous attendance of Libanius' school in Constantinople was not a positive experience. Gregory, instead, recalled with pleasure, even in subsequent years, his experiences in Athens and continued to celebrate the glory of this city, the symbol of *paideia*, and, in his view, also of Christian *paideia*.[22] Despite his criticism, which at times is harsh, of the philosophical schools and of Greek mythology,[23] he avoided any open refusal of Athens; he blames the students for the mania for Sophistics (43,15), but not the city.

This contrast should not, however, be taken in an absolute sense. Once he had returned to his own country, Basil dedicated himself to the teaching of rhetoric, achieving success with this (and becoming proud), so much so that he was chided by Macrina, who dissuaded him from this profession (Greg. Nyss., *Macr*. 6): thus, his formation was not all that different to Gregory's. On a theoretical level Basil was not, even in subsequent years, and as the *Address to young men* and the letters to Diodorus (*Epist*. 135 and 160) show, all that hostile to pagan culture; he was not so even when he dedicated himself to writing the *Rules*.[24] In all likelihood Basil's life and formation present, as with other Christians, the usual dualism between Christian culture and pagan culture, which was still present in the 4th century, even in an environment as culturally aware as that of the Cappadocians, manifesting in a conflict between an anti-pagan theoretical conception and the practical implementation of the Christian

[21] On Basil's stance, see Ph. Rousseau, *Basil of Caesarea* (1994), 27-92; F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 279: 'more anxious to confirm his Christian identity, he shows more scorn for the profane culture that he found in the Athenian schools and he feels disgusted by the coarseness of the students' demeanour'; S. Rubenson, 'The Cappadocians on the Areopagus' (2006), 119-21.

[22] In *Orat*. 21,12, Gregory alludes reprovingly to the fact that Greek philosophy had penetrated Christianity, but the criticism regards Pyrrho and the Sceptics, and he uses the traditional arguments and tone; in any case he does not criticize Athens. Other references to Athenian schools may be found in *Carm*. II 1,12, 303-8; II 1,10,198-213.

[23] It is too hypothetical that 'his positive judgement on Athens can also explain why he does not mention the story of Paul on the Areopagus', S. Rubenson, 'The Cappadocians on the Areopagus' (2006), 123, 127-8. Beeley thought that Basil and Gregory learnt philosophy and interpreted Neo-Platonism in a more original way than Gregory Nyssen precisely during their stay in Athens, Chr. Beeley, 'The Holy Spirit in the Cappadocians' (2010), 105, but there is no concrete proof to support this.

[24] As confirmation of this, one might allege the fact that Basil had a cultural friendship with Libanius; but his epistolary with him is, I maintain, a fake, as will be explained subsequently.

life. Gregory demonstrates this very contradiction, when he chides his friends, Gregory of Nyssa (*Epist*. 11) and Candidianus (*Epist*. 10) for dedicating themselves to the profession of rhetorician (Gregory of Nyssa may have intended to walk in his father's footsteps and thus attain the same social standing).[25] Therefore, the reproofs coming from Macrina and Gregory have to be understood only in the sense that profession of a public activity, such as that of a rhetorician, had an official significance, and was thus pagan because it was countenanced by the civic authorities in a society that the Cappadocians, and certainly many others with them, wanted to be Christian, but was still not completely so (and in the sense that they wanted, would never be so). In other words, pagan literature could be cultivated, but not taught because teaching had a clearer and an obvious, social significance. The refinement of the rhetorical teaching received is clear in the Cappadocians (in Basil, above all in his homilies, where the didactic tone is at times like that of a master of rhetoric). Gregory of Nazianzus himself – and rightly so – considered Basil to be a refined and elegant man of letters: Basil knew profane disciplines (astronomy, geometry, mathematics, medicine) to an extent that he was not considered an expert, but well enough and not excessively, which did not conflict with his Christian devotion.[26] The judgement that Gregory gives about Basil's work also highlights their persuasive efficacy, thanks to rhetoric (43,67):

Whenever I handle his *Hexaemeron*, and take its words on my lips, I am brought into the presence of the Creator, and understand the words of creation, and admire the Creator more than before, when my sight was my only teacher. Whenever I take up his polemical works, I see the fire of Sodom by which the wicked and rebellious tongues are reduced to ashes, or the tower of Chalane, impiously built, and righteously destroyed. Whenever I read his writings on the Spirit, I find the God whom I possess, and grow bold in my utterance of the truth, from the support of his theology and contemplation. His other treatises, in which he gives explanations for those who are shortsighted, by a threefold inscription on the solid tablets of his heart, lead me on from a mere literal or symbolic interpretation to a still wider view, as I proceed from one depth to another, calling upon deep after deep, and finding light after light, until I attain the highest pinnacle. When I study his panegyrics on our athletes, I despise the body, and enjoy the society of those whom he is praising, and rouse myself to the struggle. His moral and practical discourses purify soul and body, making me a temple fit for God, and an instrument struck by the Spirit, to celebrate by its strains the glory and power of God. In fact, he reduces me to harmony and order, and changes me by a Divine transformation.

[25] Gregory himself admits that he dedicated himself to this worldly profession too zealously, as well as barely tolerating his mother, Emmelia's devotion to the saints, which certainly must have been unattractive to a lay person (even if not pagan), but which had started to spread throughout Cappadocia; he was won over to it (along with a greater religious commitment) by a vision, which he recounts in *In quadraginta martyres*, PG 46, 785A.

[26] *Orat*. 43,23.

3. *The Cappadocians and the Sophists*

Socrates (*HE* IV 26,6) and Sozomenos (*HE* VI 17) give the certainly erroneous information, which can easily be explained by the well-known fact that Libanius was a master in Antioch, that Basil and Gregory were pupils of Libanius in Antioch.[27] In a letter to Libanius, Gregory of Nyssa also says that Basil was his disciple (*Epist*. 13,4).[28] Basil probably did study with Libanius, but not in Antioch, where he had never been, but rather in Constantinople, where Libanius was living in 348-349: this is stated by Gregory of Nazianzus, who was certainly better informed than Socrates and Sozomenos.[29]

The epistolary exchange between Basil and Libanius (if it is authentic) must be subsequent to the years when Basil was a student and subsequent to his departure from Athens, that is, after 355; it must be the period when Basil was teaching rhetoric: Gregory of Nazianzus admits that quite some time passed before Basil was 'converted' to the philosophical life (*Orat*. 43,25) and an epistolary exchange presupposes that two people are more or less at the same level.

In Libanius' epistolary, nn. 501 and 647 are letters sent to Basil: scholars of Libanius generally hold them not to be authentic.[30] In Basil's epistolary the letters to Libanius and the latter's answers are far more numerous (nn. 335-359). Since the 16th century much has been written on the exchange of letters between Basil and Libanius; to limit myself to the opinion of the most recent scholars, only some of those conserved in Basil's corpus are held to be authentic.[31] Fedwick accepts nn. 335-341, 344, 346 and 358;[32] Pouchet nn. 335-340;[33] Gautier maintains that at least n. 336 from Libanius to Basil is authentic.[34] Whatever the case may be, in this group of letters, those after n. 340 (with the exclusion of n. 359) are manifestly false, not only because they are banal, but above all because they are inconclusive and lack any real content: they are merely an exchange of compliments in the manner of the apocryphal epistolary

[27] They would allegedly have been pupils of Libanius after their stay in Athens, the duration of which was not the same for both of them.

[28] See A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 169. In this passage Gregory of Nyssa speaks of Basil and his 'masters' in the plural, so that it could be that Gregory of Nyssa meant Basil and Libanius, of whom Basil had been a disciple: A.M. Silvas, *Gregory of Nyssa* (2007), 154 n. 204.

[29] *Orat*. 43,14. McGuckin seems to maintain that Basil went to Constantinople after leaving Athens, *Saint Gregory* (2001), 79 to the end, but this is not attested.

[30] R. Cribiore, *The School of Libanius* (2007), 100-4; A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 192, n. 151.

[31] R. Cribiore, *The School of Libanius* (2007), 101; H.-G. Nesselrath, 'Libanio e Basilio di Cesarea' (2010), 338-52, 347-50; *id*., 'Libanius', (2010), 56-7.

[32] P.J. Fedwick, 'A Chronology of the Life' (1981), 3-19, 5.

[33] R. Pouchet, *Basile le Grand* (1992), 151-75, above all, 159-66.

[34] F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 336.

(even if famous and at times, nowadays, blindly re-evaluated) between Seneca and Paul. Nesselrath rightly maintains that the entire exchange of letters between Basil and Libanius, despite its existence being attested to already in the 6th century, is a forgery.[35] In his opinion, it has the function, in the contrast between pagan *paideia* and Christian *paideia*, of underlining the superiority of Basil over Libanius, who was the most renowned exponent of paganism, but the content of the letters (very banal, as we stated) does not correspond to the philosophy of either of the men. Therefore, this is a forgery, just like the epistolary exchange between the emperor Julian and Basil, even if it was far more famous.[36]

In order to confirm that it is indeed a forgery, it may be useful to consider some details from *Letter* n. 336 by Libanius, which has been deemed authentic also by Gautier. It replies to a previous one from Basil. It appears to be the first letter from Libanius since Basil, having left Athens, returned home. Libanius is informed of the fact that Basil is pursuing a way of life that is far nobler than he had imagined, that is, he is not seeking fame or riches through the courts and the imitation of older rhetoricians, or the teaching of rhetoric to the sons of the rich. Libanius recalls that Basil had left his school to go to Athens; he rejoices, therefore, in the fact that instead of earning money, Basil is now trying to become God's friend (Θεῷ φίλος).[37] What can be deduced from this is that Basil had abandoned the teaching of rhetoric and had withdrawn to lead an ascetic life, and so Libanius' letter was probably written around 360. But how could Libanius have appreciated a decision that clashed head-on with his activities and ideals as a pagan?

In letter 339 Basil informs Libanius that at that time

> we associate with Moses and Elias and such blessed men, who communicate their thoughts to us in a barbarian tongue, and it is what we learn from them that we give

[35] H.-G. Nesselrath, 'Libanio e Basilio di Cesarea' (2010), 349-50.

[36] Some examples of the banality of the letters in question. N. 501 by Libanius shows that Basil, after leaving Athens, taught rhetoric for a time in the place of the Sophist Alkimos in Nicomedia (R. Pouchet is also against the authenticity of this letter, *Basile le Grand* [1992], 409 note). *Letter* 647 alludes to an exchange of letters between Libanius and Basil and to the interest that Basil had for some of Libanius' students, above all whether those coming from Cappadocia were getting on well in Athens. Basing himself on this fact, Cribiore maintains that it can be said that this letter is authentic, because the search for students was effectively a real necessity for a master of rhetoric in the 4th century, even one as famous as Libanius. But for me, this interest was not typical of Basil. Therefore, according to Cribiore, the letters by Basil that may be authentic are nn. 335, 336, 337, which are concerned with this problem, while there are serious reservations regarding nn. 339 and 340; all the rest is a forgery, R. Cribiore, *The School of Libanius* (2007), 101 n. 84. But, as has been said, Nesselrath is right to judge the entire epistolary as being spurious.

[37] While Libanius speaks of 'God', this does not mean that he understood the nature of Basil's religious intentions; rather, it means that in his opinion there is no difference between the Christians' God and that of the pagans (henotheism).

utterance to – in substance true (νοῦν μὲν ἀληθῆ), though in style unlearned, as indeed these present words show. For even if we did learn something from you, time has caused us to forget it.[38]

To whom is Basil teaching these things? If this letter is authentic, Basil is teaching them to the first ascetic communities he was organizing: in any case, he adds that in those years if he, Basil, had indeed learnt anything from Libanius, he had at this stage forgotten it. Libanius replies (n. 340) specifically referring to the fact that Basil expected to have forgotten his teaching: this is not true, he says, because the *logoi* that Basil is now following, that is, those of the Christian writers, are still Greek *logoi*, not Christian. Libanius concludes by wishing that Basil might be able to keep his Christian books, in which the style is deficient, but the content superior; he is sure, however, that 'of that which has always been ours and was formerly yours the roots not only remain but will remain as long as you live, and no lapse of time could ever excise them, not even if you should almost wholly neglect to water them'. This concession to the importance of the Christian *logoi* is also untypical of both Libanius' character and profession.

In conclusion, it is not easy to see what Basil learnt from Libanius during his school years: only something generalized, such as the ability to construct his writings rhetorically, but no influence on his style or his thought; certainly, the correspondence that has been attributed to them does not help us to understand this topic either.[39]

Gregory of Nazianzus does not seem to have had much direct contact with Libanius: he sent him a letter (n. 236, of uncertain date) to recommend a young man to him who wanted to enter his school.

Ideological motives, instead, may have influenced Gregory's demeanour towards Libanius: they took totally opposite views of the death of Julian. After the death of the emperor, Gregory wrote two orations *Against Julian* (*Orat*. 4 and 5). The first is in defense of Christian *paideia* against the theory of 'Hellenism' elaborated by Julian, according to which culture, which was the product over the centuries of Greek civilization, belongs exclusively to the Greeks, that is, to the pagans,[40] and not to the Christians, who are of more recent origin

[38] Trans. Roy J. De Ferrari, LCL (London, Cambridge Mass., 1934), here and in all the citations of Basil's letters.

[39] Even now there is no research into Basil's style. There is an old-fashioned one by Yves Courtonne, *St. Basile et l'Hellenisme* (1934). The more recent study by Kustas is muddled and lacks a clear expository and interpretative line, George L. Kustas, 'Saint Basil and the Rhetorical Tradition' (1981). Kustas presents the favourable judgements by Photius on Basil's style (*Biblioth.* codd. 141-144; 43; 177, 191): 'a fluent and brilliant style'.

[40] Ἕλλην was the term with which the Hellenistic Jews, and thus the Greek-speaking Christians, named the pagans.

and, insofar as they descend from Judaism, were removed from Greekness. Since *Oration* 4 focuses on the propaganda during Julian's reign, it may be speculated that Gregory, in writing it, was thinking of *Orations* 13 and 12 by Libanius, in which Libanius praised the restoration of paganism wished for by the emperor, claimed the possession of *paideia* exclusively for 'Hellenism' and the necessity of removing extraneous elements from it, that is, Christians and Persians. Gregory was spurred to write *Oration* 5 for other reasons: perhaps he had feared the divinization *post mortem* of the Apostate by the pagan aristocracy that mourned him. Above all, he focused on Julian's death, about which he had been recently informed, and he analysed what led up to it and caused it. The main cause was his attempt to rebuild the Temple of Jerusalem in the spring of 363. In *Against the Galileans* (and elsewhere) the emperor asserted the superiority of Judaism over Christianity, first of all because it did not make any claims to universality and thus did not come into conflict with the Graeco-Roman tradition, and then also because it was ancient, while Christianity was a very recent development and, as both pagans and Jews thought, almost like a sect, or a degenerate offshoot of Judaism. The destruction of the Temple meant for Christian apologetics that God, having first accepted Israel, then rejected it on account of its unfaithfulness, and this therefore constituted proof of the guilt of Judaism, so that Christianity then took its place. Instead, Julian wished to rebuild the Temple, and in this project Gregory sees a clearly anti-Christian agenda (*Orat*. 5,3-7), while Ammianus Marcellinus (*Hist*. 23,1) sees only the emperor's desire to leave an enduring symbol of himself. The reconstruction, however, was interrupted on account of what Gregory defined as a prodigy, that is, the manifestation of physical phenomena such as earthquakes and underground fires, which blocked the works, and testified to God's hostility to the project and the emperor. For Gregory, the rebuilding of the Temple coincides with Julian's failed attempt to reinvigorate the pagan religion. For that again, one must not think that the Jews themselves were all that enthusiastic about the fact that a pagan was rebuilding their Temple.

The anti-Persian expedition also had, according to the pagans, a strong religious significance: Libanius tells how Julian had stopped off in Antioch to make sacrifices and other divinatory practices so as to be sure of the god's assistance and thus hearten the soldiers just before the expedition (*Orat*. 18,167-9). Gregory recalls this episode (*Orat*. 5,3-4), seeing in it confirmation that the expedition had failed precisely because Julian had stupidly entrusted it to his gods. The conclusion of this decision was the death of the emperor. After his death, the pagans considered him a philosopher, a hero for *paideia*, and a testament to faith in the gods and the immortality of the soul. Libanius (*Orat*. 18,176) interpreted Julian's death-bed testament as an example of love for the State and his subjects; many years later Ammianus Marcellinus (*Hist*. 25,3,15-23) gives a similar interpretation. Gregory does not accept the pagan interpretations and he juxtaposes them with a personal story of his own. He knows that the emperor

was perhaps killed deliberately by one of his soldiers, because in the army there was a sense of exasperation against him, since he placed no value on the lives of his subordinates (*Orat*. 5,13). Gregory, therefore, rejects Julian's charisma, perhaps to confute Libanius' praise. He wishes to show that Julian was not a genius capable of achieving success in whatever human activity he turned his hand to, as Libanius had inferred; in fact, he was the opposite of what he wanted to be, that is, the philosopher-king, who represented an ideal in the political literature of the 4th century.[41]

On the other hand, Libanius is present in a more significant manner, devoid of controversy and, above all, more influential, in the letters that Gregory of Nyssa sent to him, the authenticity of which is beyond doubt. Gregory of Nyssa had also completed studies in rhetoric; consequently, in *Epistle* 11,1 (which was not, however, sent to Libanius, but to the 'scholastic' Eupatrius) he repeats a traditional phrase: 'Your zeal for external literature was proof for us of your lack of interest in the divine lessons' (trans. Silvas). In the same way, Gregory writes to Libanius that his masters were Paul and John, and the other apostles

[41] This topic has been widely written about, so that I shall limit myself to the more recent contributions: J. Bernardi, 'Grégoire de Nazianze critique de Julien' (1976); U. Criscuolo, 'Gregorio di Nazianzo e Giuliano' (1987); M. Kertsch, 'Eine Libanius-Reminiszenz' (1992); L. Lugaresi, *Contro Giuliano l'apostata* (1993), 7-48; *id*., Gregorio di Nazianzo, *La morte di Giuliano l'Apostata* 9-83; *id*., 'Giuliano imperatore e Gregorio di Nazianzo' (1998), 293-334; *id*., 'Giuliano imperatore e Gregorio di Nazianzo' (2000); *id*., 'Studenti cristiani' (2004), 829-32; Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 204-7 (where I wonder to what extent Gregory, who lived in a small city in Cappadocia, could have been familiar with the emperor's thought: he cites *Misopogon*, but does not know *Contra Galilaeos*); V. Limberis, '"Religion" as the cipher for identity' (2000). With this collection of studies and research, Lugaresi anticipates most of the concepts that Susanna Elm was to make (2012). According to Elm Emperor Julian is the 'son of Hellenism', who is surrounded by many pagan figures and scholars, such as Themistius, Libanius, Salustius. On the other side one can locate Julian's enemy – who was yet so similar to him in many respects – Gregory of Nazianzus, the rhetor, as he still was in those years, who contributed so much to impressing the label of 'Apostate' on Julian. She considers Pagans and Christians indifferently as members of the same Late Antique society. The 'sons of Hellenism' and the 'Fathers of the Church' are two faces of the same cultural phenomenon; the dualism between pagan *paideia* and Christian faith, which are so often considered alone, cannot determine in toto the characters of members of the same society. Therefore, Gregory of Nazianzus is as much a 'son of Hellenism' as Julian. Gregory opposes his defense of Christianity to the hard defense of Hellenism, which was Julian's ideal but common to both was the defense of the *logoi*, of the idea of God, of the world, of the Roman Empire and of Greek *paideia* (although this was not exactly the reason why 'Gregory of Nazianzus was honored as Gregory the Theologian', as is said by Elm on p. 335). Elm's description of the 'Weltanschauung' of these 'sons of Hellenism' fits Julian well, but the description of Gregory (the book is constructed as a diptych, whose parts alternate between Julian and Gregory) is not likewise successful, also because the book takes into account only the first years of Gregory's literary career, until 365 (*Orations* 5 and 6) (Cl. Moreschini, *ThLZ* 138/6 [2013], 693-6). Other reviews of Elm's book: R. Brendel (2013); C. Noce, R. Chiaradonna, C. Tavolieri (2016).

and prophets (*Epist*. 13,4); nevertheless, he does not limit himself to this *topos* against pagan culture, but rather adds that he did not have more important masters than Basil and, therefore, through Basil, Libanius himself: this is a sign of courtesy towards a famous master of rhetoric, which leads one to think that there was no clear-cut separation between pagan and Christian ambiences (13,4-6). With the same respectful intention towards Libanius, Gregory of Nyssa also sent him *Letter* n. 14, which was crafted with sufficient care as to be appreciated by a master of rhetoric.[42]

Letter 15, which also focuses on the links between Libanius and Gregory of Nyssa, also demonstrates that there was no clear-cut separation between the world of pagan rhetoric and that of the Cappadocians. It is sent to two students, John and Maximian, who are supposed to introduce Libanius to *Contra Eunomium*.[43] This letter and the interest that Gregory of Nyssa had in the judgement of a rhetorician 'outside Christianity' is typical of Gregory's culture, who, in any case, was guided in this approach by his brother, Basil. In fact, Basil – as his *Letter* 20 attests – had sent a copy of his *Contra Eunomium* to an unknown Sophist, Leontius. The presence of the Sophists in Basil's and Gregory's cultural interests is therefore particularly significant.[44] From *Letter* 15 it emerges that Gregory of Nyssa had not sent *Contra Eunomium* only to the Christian churches, but also to a much wider-ranging audience of Sophists and men of letters: proof of this can be seen in the embellishments and details of a literary nature. Gregory describes Eunomius as being like Circe, bewitching the soul of his disciples, who in their turn cannot manage to reason with their own heads (*CE* III 2,78) (and so what takes places here is a 'réécriture de l'histoire homérique'[45]); Eunomius accumulates and puts together various images, using a typical Sophist procedure,[46] to the extent that Cassin has suggested a new evaluation of Eunomius' style, which ought to be defined by means of the criticism and the irony that Gregory directed at him. Secondly, Gregory of Nyssa highlights (and he could not have done this if he had not been competent in rhetoric), the artificial and superficial style of Eunomius. Isocrates and Philo are the victims of Eunomius' sacking (III 5,24), who in addition imagines that he is a

[42] Gregory of Nyssa's epistolary is better crafted than either his treatises or his homilies. For the chronology of events narrated therein, see G. Pasquali, 'Le lettere di Gregorio di Nissa' (1923) (this work is still useful). Both *Letters* 13 and 14 belong to a precise moment in the life of Gregory of Nyssa, because it appears that Gregory sent them to Libanius after he met him in Antioch, where he had gone in 379 to attend a counsel being held there, and therefore when he was no longer young, A. Silvas, *Gregory of Nyssa* (2007), 152. According to Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Lettres* (1990), 23-6, Gregory, instead, went to Antioch in 378. But the chronological difference is small and, in any case, what counts is that Gregory did not meet Libanius because he had been his student, but because he wished to hear his judgement.

[43] See M. Cassin, *L'Écriture de la controverse* (2012), 118-27.

[44] *Ibid*. 127-33.

[45] *Ibid*. 136-89.

[46] *Ibid*. 141-8.

new Demosthenes (III 10,50; cfr. 78). Cassin's conclusion is important not only for Gregory, but also for Christian literature: 'loin d'être des ouvrages techniques, les œuvres des auteurs chrétiens de l'Antiquité tardive s'inscrivent dans un contexte culturel et littéraire où elles n'occupent pas une place à part, comme si elles faisaient partie d'une littérature scientifique close sur elles-mêmes, mais sont écrites par leurs auteurs de façon à être intégrées parmi les autres productions des écrivains de l'époque'.[47] This is where their importance stems from in terms of Gregory of Nyssa's cultural interests.[48]

Finally, another pupil of Libanius was Gregory Nazianzus' cousin, Amphilochius of Iconium, who was in Antioch in 361-364, as may be evinced from the *Epistles* 634 and 671 Förster which were sent by Libanius to Amphilochius the Elder. In *Epistle* 1543, from 374, Libanius is sorry that Amphilochius the Younger has chosen a different way of living, but he congratulates him on becoming a bishop, because in this way he will have an opportunity to use his rhetorical skills (obviously in the homilies).[49]

Gregory of Nazianzus was in contact with other important men of letters, despite the fact that they were pagan, such as Themistius, a famous and authoritative philosopher also at the imperial court (he sent him *Epist*. 24, from 365-369, and *Epist*. 38 from 369). Regarding Themistius, we said (p. 11-2) that he urged religious tolerance in his *Oration* addressed to Emperor Jovian.

In conclusion, for the Cappadocians there was no problem in having contacts with individual pagans, just that their religious ideas were not to be accepted. Contacts with the Sophists, that is, with the pagan culture of their time, cannot have been too difficult: these contacts did exist, but with the necessary caution and theoretical stances.

4. Paideia *and Rhetoric*

Basil was definitely more detached from pagan culture than either Gregory of Nazianzus or Gregory of Nyssa – but not, I feel, openly hostile. Instead, Philip Rousseau accentuates Basil's opposition,[50] but in my view it was discreet and regarded above all the external aspects of rhetoric, the same that Gregory of Nazianzus, instead, cultivated and which are also present in Gregory of Nyssa's epistolary. Rousseau presents some details of Basil's life and works that appear to confirm his interpretation. It is worth while reconsidering them.

[47] *Ibid*. 189.

[48] *Epistles* 26 and 27 also reconstruct these links, see A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 79; regarding knowledge of Plato's *Cratylus* and the Sophistic (*ibid*. 135-8); M. Ludlow, 'Contra Eunomium III 10' (2014), 598-601.

[49] See A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 16-7.

[50] Ph. Rousseau, *Basil of Caesarea* (1994), 27-92.

I do not believe that *Epistle* 1, sent to Eustathius, is a declaration of hostility towards *paideia* and the 'philosophy' taught in Athens;[51] rather, it is a declaration that, for Basil, philosophy was even more important than the rhetoric that he was teaching at that time in Caesarea: this is something he repeated often, without becoming openly confrontational.[52] While it is true that Basil left Athens a few years prior to Gregory, it is also true that once he had returned to Cappadocia, for a certain time he was a master of rhetoric, achieving a level of fame that he took pride in. Therefore, it is not true that he rejected rhetoric.[53] Subsequently he criticized pagan culture more than once, but not in a harsh way and rather generically, which is very different to the Christian writers of the 2nd and 3rd centuries. In any case, Gregory (although exaggerating for encomiastic reasons) states that at the end of his stay in Athens, Basil was more or less an expert in all the disciplines – the various liberal arts that were cultivated in late antiquity.

> Who had such power in Rhetoric, which breathes with the might of fire, different as his disposition was from that of rhetoricians? Who in Grammar, which perfects our tongues in Greek and compiles history, and presides over meters and legislates for poems? Who in Philosophy, that really lofty and high reaching science, whether practical and speculative, or in that part of it whose oppositions and struggles are concerned with logical demonstrations; which is called Dialectic, and in which it was more difficult to elude his verbal toils, if need required, than to escape from the Labyrinths? Of Astronomy, Geometry, and numerical proportion he had such a grasp, that he could not be baffled by those who are clever in such sciences: excessive application to them he despised, as useless to those whose desire is godliness… Medicine, the result of philosophy and laboriousness, was rendered necessary for him by his physical delicacy, and his care of the sick. From these beginnings he attained to a mastery of the art, not only in its empirical and practical branches, but also in its theory and principles (*Orat*. 43,23, trans. Ph. Schaff).[54]

[51] This is so also for Jean Gribmont, who reads *Letter* n. 1 in light of the subsequent *Epistle* 223, J. Gribomont, 'Eustathe le philosophe' in Saint Basile, *Evangile et Eglise* (1984), 108-16.

[52] A. Breitenbach also shows, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 171, the extremely rhetorical style of the epistle, in which there is an abundance of reminiscences by pagan authors. Fatti maintains that not *Epistle* 1 but *Epistle* 2 by Basil presents his ascetic programme (which, according to Fatti, is typical of Eustathius), F. Fatti, 'Monachesimo anatolico' (2010), 68-9.

[53] It is likely that also Gregory's father considered that profession to be important for his son's career in Nazianzus. It is uncertain, however, whether it continued after his ordination, as his orations against Julian testify which 'smack more of the rhetor's podium than the preacher's pulpit', N. McLynn, *The Two Gregories* (2018), 227-8.

[54] Gregory had expressed his own ideal of the Christian life some years earlier, in his funeral oration for his brother, Caesarius. Regarding the secular disciplines cultivated by Caesarius, Gregory observes that he 'gathered all that was helpful – I mean that he was led by the harmony and order of the heavenly bodies to reverence their Maker – and avoided what is injurious; not attributing all things that are or happen to the influence of the stars, like those who raise their own fellow-servant, the creation, in rebellion against the Creator, but referring, as is reasonable, the motion of these bodies, and all other things besides, to God. In arithmetic and mathematics, and

According to Rousseau, in Basil's homily *In psalmum* 45,8 (PG 29, 429B) there is a hostile reference to the episode of Paul's oration on the Areopagus, and thus to Athens, pagan philosophy and the 'curiosity' that is typical of philosophy, but this was a *topos*.[55] Basil continued to be interested in pagan literary culture to the extent that his Christian formation allowed him to, even if not to the same extent as Gregory of Nazianzus. Mention has already been made of the letter he sent to the Sophist Leontius in 364: he behaves like a Sophist with a Sophist, complaining that his friend has not written to him as often as he would like. Basil is sorry to have to tell him that he cannot compete with him on account of his demanding duties and because 'the stain, as it were, that I have taken on by my tiresome association with the vulgar makes me naturally reluctant to address you sophists, who will become vexed and impatient unless you hear something worthy of your own wisdom'. In *Epistle* 74, to Martinianus, in 371, Basil portrays the cultural decadence of his time in dark colours, and he draws on a wealth of allusions to Homer, history and pagan philosophy. In the homily *In principium Proverbiorum* (2; PG 31, 388BC), one of his first, he states that the deeper meaning of the *Proverbs* can only be grasped by the most refined people. In *Epistle* 90,2 and 204,5 he perceives a link between pagan education and the error of the Arians, but this too is traditional, ever since the era of apologetics.

Having once decided to dedicate himself to 'philosophy', Basil traces the rules of his writing back to the principle of moral utility. As he says in the homily *In Gordium martyrem* (2; PG 31, 492B), 'the teaching most appropriate to God knows nothing of the rhetorical rules of praise, but instead of praise, takes into consideration the testimony of the facts'. But the incompatibility between Scripture and Christian doctrine was a *topos* and this statement is similar to what Gregory the Great pronounced two centuries later in a different environment: he stated that *restricting* Christian doctrine along the lines of the grammarian Donatus was out of the question (*Epist. ad Leandrum* 5). Basil certainly wonders how Christianity and the classical curriculum of his studies might be reconciled. The *Address to young men* is his most renowned work on this problem. It was probably written when Basil had reached full maturity, and in it he weaves together numerous citations and reminiscences from pagan poetry, choosing new items from mythology, along with items from the more popular side of literature. Basil advances his critical stance towards pagan literature, which must be a valid introduction to the knowledge of Scripture. He does not

in the wonderful art of medicine, in so far as it treats of physiology and temperament, and the causes of disease, in order to remove the roots and so destroy their offspring with them, who is so ignorant or contentious as to think him inferior to himself, and not to be glad to be reckoned next to him, and carry off the second prize?' (*Orat.* 7,7, trans. adapt. Schaff).

[55] The same applies to the critical reference to the impiety of the Stoics and Epicureans in *De Spiritu sancto* 17,42.

place asceticism in second place, but, given the destination of the work, he presents it in a very different way to how he recommends it and applies it in the writings specifically focusing on it; thus, Basil justifies utility, which may be found on pagan pages, but provided that it detaches us from the world through the exercise of the virtue that purifies, as Stoic and Platonic philosophy maintained, with the task of 'becoming God'. Faced with pagan wisdom, which was for the most part lacking in value, Basil urges us to accept the Christian conception of life. Therefore, the *Address to young men* wishes to detach from the pure and simple study of literature by underlining the greater importance of Christian morality. Despite the title (*Address to young men on the right use of Greek literature*), the work does not in fact deal with the right relation between classical culture and Christian faith. Fourth-century Christians did not see a contrast between their culture and religion, and pagan culture and religion. Despite the declarations of principle that a Christian could not draw any advantage from pagan literature without falling into superstition and idolatry, in practice the problem was easily overcome. The important thing was that pagan literature led to worthwhile fruits (2,8). Basil is content to just touch on the fact that there are some affinities between paganism and Christianity, and that these were present in the teaching common to both pagans and Christians.

Rousseau overstates the case by concluding that the *Address to young men* is to a certain extent inconclusive and that its logic is often weak. The work is aimed at a narrow readership, that is, young people that are already Christian, and so it cannot teach the whole Christian community. Above all, it contains nothing new, nothing that is not already in Basil's other writings. Gribomont himself maintains that its importance has been overestimated and that the work, despite its fame, is backward with respect to its era.[56]

In *Address to young men* Basil follows the pedagogical principles of Origen, which had been disseminated by Origen's panegyric, attributed to Gregory Thaumaturgus, and by *Letter* 1 by Origen himself, which was sent to him.[57] Origen had maintained that it was necessary to choose from among the pagan literary texts, which had been read in school, those texts that possessed a true educational value; and he also maintained that the individual Christian had to make use of his own critical spirit by choosing whatever was of value in pagan literature. Following Origen, Basil links this necessity of making a choice to the principle of 'knowing yourself', which leads to the consequence of interior purification and spiritual freedom, thanks to which the Christian manages to

[56] See J. Gribomont, 'Notes biographiques sur S. Basile le Grand', in *id*., *Saint Basile Évangile et Église* (1984), 139-40. L. Lugaresi, 'Studenti cristiani e scuola pagana' (2004), 804-13 also thinks that it is incongruent to urge young people to adopt Christian behaviour without it having been explained to them, because of their young age, just what this behaviour is (an objection that is perhaps too subtle).

[57] See M. Naldini, Basilio di Cesarea, *Discorso ai giovani* (1984), 30-57.

free himself from enslavement to riches and fame. Basil is certainly less interested in traditional *paideia*, which he holds to be superseded, even if it does not come in for an outright condemnation. In Basil 'that which for other Christian authors, especially from the Latin area, constituted frequently dramatic dissension, was resolved with quiet determination within a well-balanced conscience that was at once steady and innovative'.[58]

Basil discusses the problem of the pagan culture to which a Christian may refer also in his homilies. In these Basil takes on a didactic approach along the lines of the teaching of rhetoric he used to carry out before being baptised and converting to the ascetic life. *In principium Proverbiorum*[59] begins by reconsidering the three Biblical books attributed to Solomon: *Proverbs*, *Ecclesiastes*, the *Song of Songs*, and their function:[60]

> the *Proverb* represents an education for our customs and a correction for our passions; in other words, a life teaching that contains numerous suggestions as to what has to be done; *Ecclesiastes* has to do with the study of nature (φυσιολογία) and reveals to us the vanity of the things of this world, so that we do not search for transient things and we do not waste the thoughts of our soul on pointless things. Finally, the *Song of Songs* shows how the soul may become perfect: indeed, it shows harmony between the bride and groom, that is, between the soul and the Logos God (1; PG 31, 388AB).

Basil then distinguishes between the usual, most common meaning of proverb (παροιμία) according to the pagans (οἱ ἔξωθεν), for whom it indicates those things that are commonly said to be in the οἶμος (that is, in the street), and the Christian meaning, for whom a proverb is a 'useful speech, uttered with moderate obscurity (μετ' ἐπικρύψεως μετρίας), which in its depths contains a great thought (πολλὴν τὴν διάνοιαν).' It is necessary, therefore, to see what the meaning of the book of *Proverbs* is, and why, as with the other books, the name of Solomon has been added to them (2,388CD). Not only this, for the name of Solomon's father is also added ('proverbs of Solomon, son of David, who reigned over Israel'), insofar as the fact that the person writing that text was a king is important: the warnings and the exhortations are, in this case, even more compelling (2,389AB).

Proverbs enable us to know what wisdom is, which is defined by Basil along Stoic lines as 'the science of human and divine things and their causes' (3,389C).

[58] See M. Naldini, 'La posizione culturale di Basilio Magno' (1983), 200.

During the Renaissance, thanks to a Latin translation carried out by Leonardo Bruni in 1402-1403, the *Address to young men* achieved widespread fame because it was considered to be a justification of pagan literature put forward by one of the most illustrious Church Fathers.

[59] The length of the homily (PG 31, 386C-424A) and its content make us think that the current edition does not correspond to what Basil actually said before his listeners; rather, it may be a subsequent revision.

[60] The distinction is traditional, and also taken up by Gregory of Nyssa in his homilies on *Ecclesiastes* and the *Song of Songs*.

It was a proverb (*Prov*. 8:27-30) that made known the wisdom of God, σοφία ἀρχήγονος, which manifests in the creation of the world (it is the most discussed passage in the Arian controversy). There also exists human wisdom, thanks to which we call 'wise' (that is, 'expert') those who cultivate their art, as is explained in *Proverbs* (*Prov*. 1:26). *Proverbs* in Scripture detach us from human wisdom (ch. 4-5), because it is not necessary to seek out every discipline (6,397B). The disciplines constitute *paideia*. According to Scripture, Moses is said to have been instructed in every form of knowledge by the Egyptians (*Acts* 7:22). Which form of *paideia* is the most useful? Some people dedicate themselves to geometry, which was discovered by the Egyptians, others to astrology, which was discovered by the Chaldeans, or, basically, they dedicate themselves to studying 'shapes and shadow' (the text is ambiguous: does it perhaps mean the vanity of human things?). Poetry cannot exist without μῦθος (which is something false: ᾧν ὕλη τὸ ψεῦδός ἐστιν);[61] rhetoric without the art of saying; and Sophisms without paralogisms. Faced with these vain and useless sciences, παιδεία is indeed important for leading us to the science of God. Anybody who studies *Proverbs* can gain knowledge of φρόνησις, which is one of the 'general virtues' (γενικαὶ ἀρεταί) and which Basil defines along Stoic lines: prudence is wisdom thanks to which we can know good things, bad things, and things that are neither the one nor the other (ἐπιστήμονες γινόμεθα ἀγαθῶν καὶ κακῶν καὶ οὐδετέρων). Still working along Stoic lines, Basil distinguishes between theoretical wisdom and practical wisdom. Demonstrating his interest in grammar, he explains what the origin of the term φρόνιμος is, which derives paronymically from φρονέω. Why are the serpent in *Gen*. 3:1 and the dishonest factor in *Matth*. 10:16 called φρονιμώτατος? They are called 'prudent' because they knew of good things, but also of both good and bad things. The term φρόνιμος has, therefore, two meanings, one good and one bad (6,400A). Instead, the real φρόνησις enables the Christian to follow the path of good and avoid evil, to follow upright discourse and avoid sophisms; it teaches him constancy and how not to neglect what is necessary. *Proverbs* are a great help for protecting us from insidious discourse, because true discourse is upright (7,400C), and for fighting false science (401A); they are also necessary to understand what true justice is (8,401BC), which is also defined along Stoic lines: 'an approach that distributes what it is according to merit' (ἕξις ἀπονεμετικὴ τοῦ κατ' ἀξίαν). Learned pagans (οἱ ἔξωθεν σοφοί) have also spoken at length about justice. It may change according to the habits and education of the various peoples (401D). It is not necessary to follow all of Basil's preaching in this homily, in which, as has been seen, there are elements typical of the teaching of rhetorics in the focus on grammar and philosophy.

[61] Which had also been stated by Nazianzen (see pp. 47-8).

The approach in the homily *In psalmum primum* (PG 29, 209A-228B) is similarly rhetorical, in which Basil, demonstrating his learning, underlines the importance of Scripture also at a literary level. The *Psalms* are not only useful, but also pleasing to read, and in any case the pleasantness does not damage Christian teaching (2,213AC). This pleasantness is like honey placed around a glass to make the medicine easier to take (2,212B-213A) (a well-known rhetorical *topos*).[62]

Basil's classical education also appears in the ascetic writings:[63] the teaching of the Gospel is surely exclusive, but the philanthropia of philosophical ascendance leaves its mark. Some aspects of monastic life are understood in the style of philosophical 'tranquillity' (*Reg. fus.* 5,1; PG 31, 919B):

> we can observe neither the commandment of the love of God itself nor that referring to our neighbour, nor any other commandment, if our minds keep wandering hither and yon. It is not possible to master an art or science if one is always starting on fresh subjects, nor even to excel in any single one without recognizing what pertains to the end in view.[64]

Other philosophical elements are collected in the *Rules*. They are doctrine, ideas, and concepts that do not derive from any particular philosophy, though conceptions dating back to Stoicism predominate. They derive from a vulgar stoicism, that which was the object of study in the schools of rhetoric, and not in the philosophical Schools; Basil could have found these doctrines in the schools of Constantinople or Athens. He recommends, therefore, avoiding attachment to life (προσπάθεια τοῦ κόσμου) (*Reg. fus.* 5,2; PG 31, 921A), προσπάθεια also being a word used by Gregory of Nyssa in his *De virginitate*, which indicates the same attachment of the body to the allurements of life (4,8; 6,1; 8 etc.). This recommendation is tied to that of Christ (*Matth.* 16:24; *Luke* 14:33) that one must renounce the world and earthly affections (*Reg. fus.* 8,1; PG 31, 936AB).

Satan, he asserts, is not the direct author of sin, but avails himself of 'the natural motions already present in the soul, sometimes also of the passions which are prohibited (to the Christians)' (*Reg. brev.* 75; PG 31, 1136A).

The interrogation of the brief *Rule* 233 employs the term κατόρθωμα to indicate correct behaviour: 'If between the many right actions that one has accomplished, one is missing, why will he not obtain salvation?' This is the question of the ascetics of the community (PG 31, 1238C); the term κατόρθωμα is also repeated in *Reg. fus* 8,3 940A (κατορθοῦσθαι) within the

[62] This interpretation by Basil was also approved in the Latin West a few years later by St. Ambrose (p. 340).

[63] On this topic on Basil see Claudio Moreschini, 'Greek Paideia and Christian Asceticism in Basil of Caesarea's doctrine of the body' (2018), 267-82, 275-81.

[64] Trans. M.M. Wagner (Fathers of the Church, 1963), here and subsequently.

discourse seen above concerning the necessity of not squandering oneself in vain occupations.

To the question: 'How must we behave with those who avoid grave sins, but perform less serious ones with indifference?', Basil responds that Scripture does not justify this distinction (*Reg. brev.* 293; PG 31, 1288C) and that the judgment of God is identical for each act of disobedience *(De iudicio Dei* 4; PG 31, 661B): Basil makes recourse to an opinion that is common in Stoicism, that is, the one according to which all sins are equal, but he modifies it starting from different presuppositions.

Together with the Stoic tenets, images of Platonic origin frequently employed also in the literature of the imperial era, also appear: the soul of he who is prey to the passions is, so to speak, immersed in the quagmire (βόρβορος: see Plat., *Phaed.* 69c) (*Reg. fus.* 8,3; PG 31, 940B); pleasure is the lure of evil (Plat., *Tim.* 69d), as is said in a passage in which Basil highlights the importance of continence (ἐγκράτεια) (*Reg. fus.* 17,2; PG 31, 964B):

> Continence, then, destroys sin, quells the passions, and mortifies the body even as to its natural affections and desires. It marks the beginning of the spiritual life, leads us to eternal blessings, and extinguishes within itself the desire for pleasure. Pleasure, indeed, is evil's special allurement through which we men are most likely to commit sin and by which the whole soul is dragged down to ruin as by a hook.

The body, when it becomes sick with a physical illness, must be cured: for the soul too, when it falls ill following a passion, a cure is necessary, and the cure consists of punishment. One of the most frequent images in the *Regulae* is that of the analogy between the illnesses of the body and those of the soul: the cure for the passions (that is, for sins) is carried out in imitation of the cure of the body, which is applied by physicians (*Reg. fus.* 51; PG 31, 1040C):

> The same is true, also, of the medical art. In as much as our body is susceptible to various hurts, some attacking from without and some from within by reason of the food we eat, and since the body suffers affliction from both excess and deficiency, the medical art has been vouchsafed us by God, who directs our whole life, as a model for the cure of the soul, to guide us in the removal of what is superfluous and in the addition of what is lacking.

This example is repeated frequently in the rules: 'The example of the members of the body which we have usefully applied so often is appropriate also to the question before us' (*Reg. fus.*; PG 31, 1004A).

The fact that correction has a therapeutic function in the Basilian conception is also suggested by the use of the substantive θεραπεία, which recurs multiple times, and which in some cases indicates precisely a cure aimed at healing a hurt soul. In the same way, the verb θεραπεύω often refers to an ethical-spiritual cure and healing. Basil, therefore, draws on the model of the spiritual cure with medicine many times, both in the field of the *Regulae* themselves (all of

Reg. fus. 55 is dedicated to the medicine of the body), and in his homilies (*Hom. in psalmum primum* 1-2; PG 29, 216B; *Hom. in illud: attende tibi ipsi* 1; PG 31, 200C).

The cure for illness of the soul is realized first of all with the confession of one's sins. Confession is very important for spiritual healing and should not be done to anyone, but exclusively to the one to whom the administration of the mysteries of God is entrusted. The cure must follow the same criteria used in manifesting illnesses of the body. Therefore, just as people do not reveal their physical diseases to all people, nor to the first comer, but to the expert in curing them, so also the confession of sins must be made to those who are able to cure them, as it is written: 'We who are strong ought to put up with the failings of the weak and not to please ourselves' (*Rom.* 15:1) (*Reg. br.* 229; PG 31, 1236A). Developing the image of the monastic community as the human body, and recovering elements of the stoic-cynical diatribe about the necessity of dominating one's feelings precisely in relations with one's subordinates, Basil affirms that 'the superior should not administer a rebuke to wrongdoers when his own passions are aroused; for, by admonishing a brother with anger and indignation, he does not free him from his faults but involves himself in the error'.

When the analogy between illnesses of the body and illnesses of the soul is used, Basil resumes an image that was proper to stoicism. It had been established both by Chrysippus (SVF III 471) and Seneca, according to whom we are born into this condition of living subject to illnesses of the soul, no less numerous than those of the body. Seneca (who was certainly not known by Basil) believes that philosophy is so necessary for the health of the soul that we must refrain from any other affair that may detract from it. In Seneca we find the same emphasis given to the confession of sins that we have seen in Basil.[65] Therefore, it is not far-fetched to argue that Basil's considerations on the therapeutic value of correction may be placed precisely in the Stoic tradition.

Basil's approach in examining pagan literature, as may be seen from *Address to young men*, was taken from his friend and spiritual disciple Amphilochius of Iconium, who urges us to keep the pure richness of the Christian word, although studying the doctrines and the writings of pagan poets and historians; in any case, some of these have stylistic beauty:

> But you must read all the *logoi* in a sensible manner, skillfully gathering from them whatever may be useful to you and sensibly avoiding whatever is damaging in each of them, imitating the work of the intelligent bee, which lands on each flower and with great wisdom harvests whatever is useful therein, mastering its own nature. But on the basis of your own reasoning, you have to abundantly gather in a harvest from whatever

[65] See Seneca, *Epist.* 53,8.

books may be useful. If, instead, a book is harmful, you must understand what it is that is rotten and promptly abstain from it. … Any books that have been written to praise virtue, or vice versa, to blame vice, you must learn from them diligently, remember the content and the gracefulness of the style. Instead, anything written about the gods is just wicked tales in lengthy lies, teachings about demons, tales worthy of laughter and tears: keep away from these, as you would from snares and traps. Inquire about the gods and any discourse about them, as the former are ridiculous while the discourse is pleasant; despise the gods, who love pleasure, but praise the discourse because it comes from a unique source; flee the thorns and pick the rose. This is the best rule for discourse involving anybody who is not within the Christian fold (*Iamb. ad Seleucum* 33-64).[66]

Gregory of Nazianzus had a still stronger interest in pagan culture, which was demonstrated not only by his imitation of pagan writers and poets, but also by a theoretical justification of his activity.[67] Cyprian, the martyr, he asserts, while still a pagan, was 'the flower of youthfulness, the monument of nature, a bastion of learning not only in philosophical studies but in the other disciplines and any of their divisions'.[68] Later on, Gregory divides oratory in three groups: those destined to moral edification, those whose subject matter is the teaching of Christian dogma, and those which celebrate the lives of illustrious men (*Orat.* 24,13). According to George Kennedy,[69] these three categories correspond to the deliberative genre (in which Cyprian advises his listeners on a course of action), the judiciary genre (because both present and past human activities are judged according to the teachings of Scripture), and the epideictic. The first two categories may take the form of homilies or sermons on a theme. He states:

I believe every person of good sense will admit that culture is the greatest good that men possess: I am not referring only to its highest form, that is, the culture that we Christians share, which, in despising all ornamentation and vanity in speech, thinks only of man's salvation and the beauty of intangible reality; rather, I am also referring to profane culture, which is despised by most Christians because it is insidious and deceptive and leads us far from God. Well then, these people are wrong. In fact, neither the sky, the earth, the air, nor other such things, ought to be despised merely because some people use them for evil ends; rather, we should just avoid what is dangerous, while availing of what is useful to life and serves us well, and not making created things rebel against their Creator; we ought to understand our Maker through the things that He has made and, as the divine Apostle says (*Rom.* 1:20; 2*Cor.* 10:5-6), by submitting every thought to Christ; just as, moreover, neither fire nor food, nor iron, nor any other such things are (as far as we know) useful or harmful in and of themselves, but become so

[66] Seleucus was a nephew of Olympias, a relative of Amphilochius; the *Iambi ad Seleucum* also contain instructions of a theological nature, which will be examined subsequently.

[67] On this topic, further analysis may be found in: Claudio Moreschini, *I Padri Cappadoci* (2008), 82-9.

[68] *Or.* 24,6 trans. Vinson, here and in the following passages.

[69] See George A. Kennedy, *Greek Rhetoric under Christian Emperors* (1983), 217.

only insofar as they appear this way to whoever uses them, so much so that some reptiles are useful for preparing healing poultices, in the same way, we accept the side to these disciplines that pertains to research and contemplation, while we reject whatever leads to demons and error and the pit of perdition. Indeed, we need these disciplines to worship God because we learn what is best from that which is worst and we make of whatever constitutes their weaknesses a point of strength in our Christian doctrine. In other words, we ought not to despise culture only because this suits some of us; in fact, people who think like this should be considered obtuse and ignorant, as they want everyone to behave just like them so that under the appearance that we all share they may hide their own peculiarities so that they may not be unmasked on account of their ignorance (*Orat*. 43,11).

Both in his prose works and his verse, Gregory deliberately and extensively uses pagan literature to increase the efficacy and dignity of Christian literature, even if he does not manage to avoid the *topos* of the superiority of the Christian *logos*, which is a vehicle for the truth, over the pagan, which is merely exterior and misleading. He confirms this in a retrospective reflection on his life:

I was trying to make these bastard letters[70] of assistance to me, a support to what are the true letters, so that those who are only familiar with an obtuse and vain facility with words might not take pride in this facility, which may be seen in the shouting that comes from the throats of the orators. It certainly never entered my head to place anything before the doctrines I had learned (*De vita sua* II 1,11,112-20).[71]

Gregory asserts that he had studied with a measure of success in Alexandria (*ibid*. 129); once he had returned home, he turned to the *logoi* (that is, he taught rhetoric), but he was not interested in receiving applause or theatrical, showy oratory, which was instead appreciated by the masters (that is, the experts in rhetoric) in the schools to which the young flocked (οὐ γὰρ κρότων ἔμοιγε καὶ ψόφων λόγος / οὐ δὲ βλακευμάτων καὶ λυγισμάτων / οἷς οἱ σοφοὶ χαίρουσιν ἐν πλήθει νέων*)* (*ibid*. 267-9*)*. 'First of all, I chose this principle from philosophy: for the greater glory of God, throw away everything else along with the toils of the *logoi*, as do those who give away their belongings (270-3)'. There then follow obscure and allusive words: 'But, as I have already said, I have danced for my friends (τοῖς φίλοις ὠρχησάμην)': Gregory most likely means that he practised the art of rhetoric, which his friends liked, but that this was like training for his fights in defence of the faith, or preparatory initiation to even greater mysteries (ἀγώνων ὥσπερ ἐγγυμνάσματα / ἢ καὶ προτέλεια μειζόνων μυστηρίων), that is, the study of the *logoi* was a preparation for the Christian mysteries.[72]

[70] That is, pagan literature.

[71] On this passage, see also K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 237 and A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 172.

[72] According to some, this means baptism.

There was only one thing that was dear to him, the glory in the discourses, which he had collected from the East and the West, and Athens, the pride of Greece.[73] He laboured over these intensely and at length, but he forced these discourses to bow down before Christ and yield to the Logos of the great God, for this Logos truly resides in each many-sided word sought after by the human mind (*De rebus suis* II 1,1,96-101).[74]

The importance of oratory consists in the fact that the human logos is united to the Logos of God, and from Him it derives: for this reason, oratory must be both religious and human at one and the same time (*Orat*. 24,19; 25,1; 38,6; 39,2; 41,1 etc.):[75]

This is what I offer to God; this do I dedicate, my sole remaining possession, my sole wealth. The rest I have made over to the commandment and the Spirit, and in exchange for all I once had I have taken 'the pearl of great value' (*Matth*. 13:4-6) … and as devotee to the Word, I cling to the Word alone and would never willingly neglect this possession, but on the contrary, honor it and embrace it and take more pleasure in it than in all other things combined that delight the multitude; and I make it the partner of my whole life and my good counselor and companion, and my guide on the road to heaven and my eager confederate; and because I reject all gratification here below, this is what, after God, or rather, in addition to Him, receives all my outpoured affection; for it is the Logos, he alone, who through our mind makes God accessible to us and through whom God is apprehended in His truth and is cherished and grows within us. I have said that *wisdom* was *my sister* (*Prov*. 7:4) and … I seek the gifts of wisdom and of the Logos who illumines the faculty of reason within us and lights our steps on the path of God (*Orat*. 6,5).[76]

And at the end of his preaching in Constantinople, recalling his activity as a pastor who had rebuilt the community of the faithful when it had almost been destroyed (his 'crown', as he calls it), he says:

As far as this crown is concerned ('what I say, I do not say according to the Lord' [2*Cor*. 11:17], yet still I say it), I am one of those who has contributed to its weaving. Part of it is the effect of my words – not words that we have tossed off recklessly, but words spoken with love, not meretricious words as a certain verbal and moral

[73] Other evocations of Greece by Nazianzen may be found in *Anthol*. *Palat*. VIII 80 = *epitaph*. II 1,94 and *epitaph*. 119,35-38, A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 179-80. On the epigrams see also F.E. Consolino, 'ΣΟΦΙΗΣ ΑΜΦΟΤΕΡΗΣ ΠΡΥΤΑΝΙΝ' (1989).

[74] See Jean Bernardi, Saint Grégoire de Nazianze, *Œuvres poétiques* (2004), 140 n. 32; A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 175.

[75] See C. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 98-9. This accounts for the emperor Julian's hostility, who attributed exclusively to the 'Greeks', that is, to the non-Christians, the discovery and use of the *logoi* (*ibid*. 244-5). F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 171-5 speaks, for Gregory, of a 'literary priesthood, and accentuates the significance of the religious aspect, maintaining that for Gregory, the logos is a form of ascesis' (*ibid*. 189-95). My observations were further developed by Carmelo Crimi, 'Parola e scrittura in Gregorio Nazianzeno' (2011).

[76] Trans. M. Vinson (The Fathers of the Church 107) (Washington, 2004).

prostitute has suggested, slandering us), but very sober ones. Part of this is the offspring and fruit of my spirit, in the way only the Spirit can give birth to those who are leaving the body behind. I am sure that the my well-wishers among you – perhaps even all of you – will also be my witnesses, since we have cultivated the harvest in all of you. … We do not teach in an uncivilized way, we do not pelt our enemies with insults, which is what most people do, fighting not against arguments but against those who propose them; at times, too, they cover over the weakness of their reasoning with invective (*Orat*. 42,12-3).[77]

Gregory dedicates a lengthy treatise to his oratorical activity in Constantinople in the poem *De se ipso et episcopis* (II 1,12,71-308; PG 37, 1171-88), where, returning to some considerations in *Orations* 27 and 36, he rejects the loquacity to which not only heretics and men of literature were prone, but also ignorant people, and underlines the greater profundity and richness of thought in his oratory.[78] Once in Athens, he took no notice of either the applause or the blame, or of the dull yet contorted declamations with which the Sophists delighted crowds of the young. Aware of his particularity as a Christian writer, Gregory is polemical with pagan Sophistic, even if this principled stance (which is shared by all Christian writers) did not have an absolute practical application, nor does it signify a total renunciation of rhetoric. Thus, Gregory first of all wishes to practice meditation and to scorn, compared to God, everything else, along with the trouble spent on the discourses (267-308).

In two similar poems (II 2,4 and II 2,5) Gregory praises the force and power of the *mythoi*,[79] which are an instrument donated to man by God, which can produce amazing results during assemblies, judgements and *encomia*:

The grammar that hones the discourse and the barbarian sound is of no little value, and it is the best defense of the noble Greek language, as well as logical devices, behind which hides the truth which a closely argued dispute brings before everyone's eyes; the devices through which the best form good customs … and what wise men, with their winged minds and subtle reflections, investigating the depths wherever their bent takes them, have examined and entrusted to books: they have come to know the elements and, above all, the mind of the ineffable God, how He guides everything and where He leads them, what the outcome will be for the whole cosmos, adorned within by many ornaments (*Carm*. II 2,4,58-75).

For this reason

Words are crucial for human life: it is words that separate me from animals; with them I have built cities and I made the laws and I praise almighty God; with them I raise on high the glory of His noble virtue; with them I keep at bay the bitter violence of evil;

[77] Trans. B.E. Daley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2006).

[78] Further details on this poem in A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene Athen"* (2003), 176.

[79] Crimi notes that 'Gregory often uses, drawing on the epic language, the word *mythos* as an equivalent of *logos*, divesting it of its usual negative connotation as "untrue word", "fictitious discourse"', 'Parola e scrittura' (2011), 358.

with them I separate the worlds, that is, the heavenly realm, and the one which proceeds, here in this life, towards dissolution, and I separate the body and the soul… Indeed, those realities were marked by God and fixed by the logos of the wise men and strengthened by faith… Words are also a great remedy for the passions; with them I can subjugate the wrath that boils and is a fog to the intellect; with them I quieten the troubles and I place a limit on joy; I do not get cast down because of pain, nor do I exult about success, since I place on the balance a remedy to the other: hope in affliction, terror in exaltation. The word guides kings and draws on the people; its glory lies in the squares and dominates during banquets, dampens wars and makes man meek… (*Carm.* II 2,5, 165-221; 264-6).[80]

In addition to the pride involved in practicing the noble art of speech-making, the essence of which derives directly from the divine Word and is confirmed by the Spirit, Gregory is aware of the fact that his *logoi* are different to the others, precisely because they originate in the intelligence, which draws man closer to God. If then they have this origin, they cannot be meretricious, that is, they are not said (or written) only to give pleasure, but rather to teach, even though this does not mean that the speech of the Christian orator must necessarily be plain and unadorned: Gregory's own approach is evidence of this. Therefore, it is speaking for the sake of speaking, devoid of any doctrinal content, that is the object of the famous satirical description in *Oration* 27. He asks:

Why have I made this digression, too elaborated, I daresay, for the general ear, but in tune with the prevalent fashion in sermons, a fashion which despises noble simplicity and substitutes tortuous conundrums? (*Orat.* 28,11).[81]

Gregory's oration deeply affected his listeners, so much so that, spurred on by their enthusiasm, the faithful of Constantinople led him in a procession to take possession of the church of the Holy Apostles, which up to then had been in the hands of the Arians (*De vita sua* II, 1,11,1325-95). But his oratory also gave rise to criticism; he was far more vulnerable than Basil to the judgement of the masses, and his friends and enemies:

But since it is our sermons that are the *casus belli*, along with this exceptional and invidious (ἐπίφθονος)[82] tongue of ours, which, trained in pagan, we have refined with Christian learning, sweetening the bitter and undrinkable water of Marah (*Exod.* 15:23-5) with the tree of life (*Orat.* 36,4).[83]

[80] These two poems are distinct from each other in their structure because they represent a discussion invented by Gregory between Nicobulus Junior and Nicobulus Senior, but basically, as far as the theme of culture is concerned, they say the same thing.

[81] Trans. Fr. Williams, in Frederick W. Norris, *Faith Gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991).

[82] Or 'odious': the passive meaning of ἐπίφθονος is attested to, cf. LSJ; 'envieuse' is also Gallay's translation.

[83] Trans. M. Vinson, this and the next passage.

His oratory is said to be 'vain and odious': while it is beautiful, it provokes the hatred of the other Christians, along with the fact that it is educated by the oratory of the pagans: the Christian community criticises Gregory for the formal care he takes with his speech, which they consider to be of pagan origin (that is, Sophistic). Nevertheless, his 'pagan' eloquence has been ennobled by the divine content of his oration, and with life-giving wood he has rendered sweet the bitter undrinkable water of Marah, that is, he has modified the techniques and content of pagan oration by inserting Christian content. He asks:

> You cherish the very thing for which we are attacked. Why did we not embrace the vapid culture, sterile and decadent? In view of its popularity why indeed do we adopt a strange and outlandish philosophy[84] and hold our ground against the voices raised in opposition, when we should have rejected our intellectual pursuits out of hand and given irrationality the name of faith? Believe me, this is the course I should actually have chosen on my own as a fisherman – the facile justification of ignorance that most people use – if instead of my eloquence I had been given the power to work miracles (*Orat*. 36,4).

Gregory's literary programme, that of dedicating the art of the *logos* to Christian doctrine, was therefore criticized by the Christians themselves. Just as in *Oration* 36 he defends the particular character of his orations, similarly in an important poem (*In suos versus*: II 1,39; PG 37, 1329-36) he justifies his own poetry.[85] He sees that it is a time when everyone is writing and following their own inclinations, with the result that the world is full of chatter. Consequently, Gregory is forced to give everyone just one piece of advice: abandon the mania for oration and dedicate yourselves to the study of Scripture (vv. 1-11). But since this is impossible, he too must dedicate himself to oration: regardless of how good or bad the result is, oration is dear to him because it is to this verse that he entrusts his anguish (vv. 18-24), but not because through it he wishes to obtain empty worldly glory, as the wicked imply (vv. 18-27). It is, however, necessary to follow some rules when writing *logoi*. First of all, one should not write too much; then one should write for the young and all those who take particular pleasure in oration, so as to provide them with a sweet medicine, that of persuasion.[86] In this way the poet can lead young people towards what is most useful for them and sweeten the bitterness of the Commandments with art (vv. 36-41). The sinew of the bow, when it is

[84] 'Creed' is what Vinson translates, but Gregory is referring to his 'philosophy', which has a particular meaning.

[85] Poems are, for Gregory, a τετραφάρμακον in the Epicurean manner, G. D'Ippolito, 'La poesia come tetrafarmaco' (2008). These poems of programmatic content were examined in Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e Letteratura* (1997), 217-24; on II 1,39 Čelica Milovanovič-Barham, 'Gregory of Nazianzus: *Ars Poetica*' (1997) advances some similar observations.

[86] This is the *topos* of poetry as an instrument of persuasion and pedagogy, insofar as it facilitates the learning of moral precepts, which would otherwise have difficulty in being accepted.

pulled back, must be relaxed.[87] In any case, Gregory is quite capable of coming up with songs and ditties: if his orations are not liked, he too is capable of turning out pleasant compositions (v. 40). Thirdly, Gregory composes verses because he does not want the pagans to overtake the Christians in poetry (vv. 48-9), even if, strictly speaking, for a Christian rhetorical ornaments and beauty are to be found only in Scripture (vv. 50-1). There is nothing excessively long in his oratory, nothing that might come across as unbearably cloying; nor is there anything pointless (vv. 61-2). Some of the considerations he puts forward in his poetry derive from Scripture, others from profane literature (v. 64), no matter whether he is praising what is good or criticizing what is not, or whether he is dealing with teachings, rulings, or brief phrases, which may be remembered because they create a beautiful effect when they are put together. The metre used by Gregory has been criticized, but only by the ignorant writers of iambs and the literary rejects (vv. 69-70),[88] incapable, in any case, either of imitating or still less improving on the person they criticize. There are also many metred compositions in Scripture, as is pointed out by the experts among the Hebrews (vv. 82-5).[89] Singing accompanied by the cithara, as occurs in the *Psalms*, allows the text to have a metre; the singer produces a sense of delight, which is a means to achieving rectitude, and tries, through the songs, to promote good behaviour among his listeners. An example of this beneficial influence produced by poetry is Saul, who was liberated of the evil spirit thanks to David's song (1*Sam*. 18:10; 19:9). In the same way, young people of his time could be persuaded to establish contact with God through pleasure, which however must be 'austere' (vv. 90-1). Indeed, they can be induced to meditate on God only gradually. Therefore, in Christian compositions, there should be a good mix of pleasure and austerity. Subsequently, once the inclination to virtue has been strengthened, orations with an educational character can omit the pleasure component and focus only on the demanding moral content.

[87] This is a proverb: see Phaedr. III 14,10.

[88] Indeed, it is strange that Gregory had little esteem for iambic poetry, since he himself had written numerous poems in the iambic metre. Č. Milovanovič-Barham, 'Gregory of Nazianzus: *Ars Poetica*' (1997), 503-4, thinks that the Church condemned iambic poetry because it was typical of the language of tragedy, which in the 4th century had been reduced to a pantomime. However, this does not explain why Gregory used it. It may be that Gregory used it since he himself was the first to consider it to be not as elevated a poetical genre as dactylic poetry; it was necessary for poetry of a polemical nature or, in any case, didactic, on account of its similarity to prose.

[89] At approximately the same time, Jerome also thought he could identify the presence of the metre of pagan poetry in the *Psalms* (*Epist*. 53,8): this represented an attempt to reassess the OT in relation to criticism from the pagans, who despised the Christians' sacred Scripture insofar as they failed to comply with their aesthetic canon. While maintaining this pagan viewpoint, Jerome formulates a positive judgement about Scripture, stating that it contains the elements that make up pagan poetry – the only poetry that at the time was known.

The poem *De se ipso et episcopis* (II 1,12,267-321; PG 37, 1185-9)[90] is of a similar programmatic character. Our orations, says Gregory, are composed of external expression and content: the former is, so to speak, the raiment, while the second is the body. In some compositions both these aspects are good, while in others only one of the two is; or both the natural input is deficient, which is at the root of the external expression, as well as the culture, which represents the content of the composition. Gregory is not interested so much in the external aspect of his poetic compositions, as in the internal, the content: indeed, it is in Christian doctrine that salvation lies. Nevertheless, Christian doctrine must also be adequately expressed and manifested (vv. 267-78). In conclusion, one must speak like ordinary people; if one is not capable of doing this, one should present the content to the public, along with the Christian doctrines, because even a prosaic, uncultivated mode of expression is acceptable (v. 295), as long as the doctrinal content is elevated (v. 301); external elegance is not important (v. 302), just as Plato's famous eloquence (v. 305) is not important either. Thus, Gregory wishes to avoid the criticism of pandering to Sophistic ornamentation and, in accordance with an ancient Christian *topos*, appear to be interested only in the content: but he perceives that his intention is not easy and that his expectation of being able to dedicate himself to elaborate oratory imbued with the decorum of the right doctrine was not appropriate to the ideal of simplicity. In any case, the beauty of orations whose doctrine is open to condemnation has to be rejected (a reference to Sophistic and pagan literature); it is necessary to be 'philosophers' and express oneself in a simple manner, for one can be certain of achieving the desired result even if one does not speak in a stylized manner (vv. 306-8). The topics for Christian literary teaching are the Trinity, the angels, the world, divine Providence, the body and soul, the two laws, the Incarnation of Christ, death and resurrection, and retribution in the hereafter (vv. 309-21).

Gregory repeats this cultural programme in the poem *In silentium ieiunii*, which was written for Lent in 382 AD: he rejects the themes of pagan poetry, not only the frivolous ones in erotic poetry, but also the more elevated ones found in epic and educational poetry. He wishes to make use of his abundant talent for poetry in order to put in place 'a consistent renunciation of whatever classical poetry had declaimed in all its forms, epic, didactic, and lyric'[91] (II 1,34; PG 37, 1307-22).[92]

[90] See Gregor von Nazianz, *Über die Bischöfe* (1989).

[91] See S. Costanza, 'Gregorio di Nazianzo e l'attività letteraria' (1984), 233.

[92] His self-imposed silence regards, therefore, his activity as a sacred orator and the fact he dedicated himself to writing, F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), mostly 206-13. On his dedication to writing in the period subsequent to Constantinople, see also N. McLynn, 'A Self-Made Holy Man' (1998), 477-9. Gregory's poetic activity has aroused remarkable interest over the last few years. Previously it was seen as a renunciation of public and literary activity and a retreat into solitude and asceticism, while now it is held that Gregory's return to his homeland, after the period in

According to Bernard Wyss,[93] Gregory has to be assigned one of the highest places among Greek Christian writers. As a person possessed of innate oratorical talents, Gregory has the gift of conquering the soul of his listeners through strong pathos, depending on the circumstances; he had a firm grasp of literary language that was devoid of stifling classicism, capable of displaying virtuoso playfulness in every register of rhetorical technique. As far as style is concerned, Gregory's orations, in which sentences are made up of brief phrases and contain figures of speech and new meanings, may be classified as what is usually known as 'moderate Asianism'.[94] Gregory assimilated these characteristics of his poetic style in the schools or rhetoric. This is also testified to by the fact Byzantine rhetoricians frequently use it, alongside the classical orators from Greece: Michael Psellos places Gregory alongside Demosthenes.[95]

Amphilochius of Iconium also had a special interest in rhetoric and so his homilies were extremely well crafted from a formal point of view. In his homilies there are frequent pathetic movements, allocutions and exclamations.

5. Paideia *and Philosophy*

As a rule of thumb, for the Cappadocians a critical attitude towards philosophy is also true, but their criticism is repetitive and traditional. The inadequacy of profane culture is also underlined by the most 'philosophical' of the three of them, Gregory of Nyssa (*Macrin.* 3); in *An.* (GNO III/III, 8,12-9,6) he dissents from the Sceptics and the Epicureans. While profane philosophy is capable of penetratingly investigating various issues (yet unfortunately it based its investigations into the problem of the soul only on appearances), 'we (Christians) are not at liberty to say whatever we feel like saying, since the sacred Scriptures contain the rule and law regarding every doctrine' (*An.* GNO III/III 33,6-14).[96]

Constantinople, meant active participation in literature, thanks also to the presence in Nazianzus and Cappadocia of literary circles to which the Sophists also belonged, and from which pagans were not excluded *a priori*. This would further explain, according to McLynn, Gregory's uncertainties and reservations when faced with Basil's approach to asceticism, N. McLynn, 'Among the Hellenists' (2006).

[93] Bernard Wyss, 'Gregor II, Gregor von Nazianz' (1983), 799-800.

[94] According to the *Suda* (s.v. Γρηγόριος, I 541,18-20 Adler [Lipsiae, 1928]), the rhetorician Polemon of Laodicea (88-145 AD: on him see Philostr., *VS* I 25) influenced Gregory's style. On Gregory's style in his orations see also A. Hofer, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 24-5.

[95] Examples of his rhetorical art (both in prose or poetry) are the *variatio*, through which Gregory presents in continuously varied ways elements that are intrinsically similar, but above all a stylistic device that was typical of late antiquity, and that is, allusiveness. Gregory of Nazianzus requires a great deal of attention because he narrates obliquely and indirectly, he leaves the reader to the task of interpreting the events and facts that he merely implies.

[96] Other testimonies of this attitude may be found in M. Canévet, *Grégoire de Nysse et l'herméneutique biblique* (1983), 65-81.

In his turn, Basil is critical of Aristotle and Chrysippus (*CE* I 5 and I 12).[97] Gregory of Nazianzus harshly criticizes Greek philosophy at the end of *Oration* 27, and elsewhere, using a frequent *topos*, he confirms that he used to speak 'more like a fisherman than Aristotle' (*Orat*. 23,12). Gregory Nyssen, however, admits that there might be cases in which profane culture, including philosophy, may be of benefit to Christians. There are numerous interesting passages in this regard in *The Life of Moses*:

> There is something fleshly and uncircumcised in what is taught by philosophy's generative faculty; when that has been completely removed, there remains the pure Israelite race. For example, pagan philosophy says that the soul is immortal. This is a pious offspring. But it also says that souls pass from bodies to bodies and are changed from a rational to an irrational nature. This is a fleshly and alien foreskin. And there are many other such examples. It says there is a God, but it thinks of him as material. It acknowledges him as Creator, but says he needed matter for creation. It affirms that he is both good and powerful, but that in all things he submits to the necessity of fate. And one could describe in some detail how good doctrines are contaminated by profane philosophy's absurd additions. When these are completely removed, the angel of God comes to us in mercy, as if rejoicing in the true offspring of these doctrines (*Moys*. II 39-41).
> The loftier meaning is therefore more fitting than the obvious one. It commands those participating through virtue in the free life also to equip themselves with the wealth of pagan learning by which foreigners to the faith beautify themselves. Our guide in virtue commands someone who 'borrows' from wealthy Egyptians to receive such things as moral and natural philosophy, geometry, astronomy, dialectic, and whatever else is sought by those outside the Church, since these things will be useful when in time the divine sanctuary of mystery must be beautified with the riches of reason (*Moys*. II 115).[98]

The Pharaoh's daughter was barren and therefore had to accept Moses as a son:

> For truly barren is profane education, which is always in labor but never gives birth. For what fruit worthy of such pangs does philosophy show for being so long in labor? Do not all who are full of wind and never come to term miscarry before they come to the light of the knowledge of God, although they could as well become men if they were not altogether hidden in the womb of barren wisdom? Now after living with the princess of the Egyptians for such a long time that he seemed to share in their honors, he must return to his natural mother. Indeed he was not separated from her while he was being brought up by the princess but was nursed by his mother's milk, as the history states. This teaches, it seems to me, that if we should be involved with profane teachings

[97] B. Sesboüé maintains that for Basil philosophy had a purely exploitative value: it had to provide him with the tools of language, which he liberally availed of, and some of which he reformulated in 'a deliberately Christian syntax; Basil has a purely instrumental conception of philosophy: through it he recovers the remains of the Egyptians', B. Sesboüé, *Basile de Césarée Contre Eunome* (1982), 76. But this interpretation of philosophy was traditional and where necessary Basil himself contradicted it, thus demonstrating his sophisticated philosophical education.

[98] Trans. Abraham J. Malherbe and Everett Ferguson (New York, 1978).

during our education, we should not separate ourselves from the nourishment of the Church's milk, which would be her laws and customs. By these the soul is nourished and matured, thus being given the means of ascending the height (*Moys*. II 11-2).

In conclusion, the following statement by Basil is applicable to all the Cappadocians: 'We admit that the word of truth also uses these (philosophical) expressions in many passages, but we state that freedom of the Spirit is not a slave to the mental narrowness of the pagans' (*Spir. sanct*. 4,6,77A).[99]

The common interpretation of 'philosophy' is that for the Cappadocians it signifies 'Christian life' or 'the contemplation of Christian truth'.[100] But for Nazianzen the word 'philosophy' has a greater range of meanings: for instance, φιλοσοφεῖν and θεολογεῖν are almost equivalent for him, though φιλοσοφεῖν occurs with greater frequency.[101] The Christian philosopher is not defined by his isolation from the spirit of the times, nor by his life in the desert; rather, he is defined by his interior solitude, which may be identified with monotropy, exclusive dedication and service to God, which presupposes celibacy. One may be a solitary, even though one is surrounded by the spirit of the times, and living like an outsider.[102]

In addition to these basic senses, in Gregory φιλοσοφεῖν also carries a controversial meaning. He uses the terms φιλόσοφος and φιλοσοφεῖν ironically in order to describe himself and his lifestyle in a way that differs from that of the powerful and the cultivated, the 'intelligent' inhabitants of Constantinople. 'But I am so old-fashioned and such a philosopher as to believe that one heaven is common to all; and that so is the revolution of the sun and the moon!'[103] In other passages Gregory speaks of philosophy in order to distinguish his own views from those of his opponents: 'Since I have argued with you in a petty way about these matters, I will now proceed to take a larger and more philosophic

[99] Susanna Elm rejects the usual interpretation of 'philosophy' according to the Cappadocians and asserts that Gregory's philosophy is effective philosophy, S. Elm, *Sons of Hellenism* (2012). According to Gregory the philosopher is the *iatròs* of the soul (166-8); the bishop, who is also a philosopher, must 'lead the true philosophical life of active involvement in the affairs of the *politeia* for the benefit of the *oikumene* of the now-Christian Romans' (*ibid*. 8; see also 12 n. 35 and 172-4); philosophy and *paideia* remain linked, as is natural for a Greek (*ibid*. 36). Nazianzen's second *Oration* is interpreted in its entirety by Elm through philosophy (*ibid*. 155-7). Philosophy united with political leadership is Gregory's aim (*ibid*. 264-5): this is a new and challenging interpretation, but in it the religious side of a Christian bishop appears to be underestimated.

[100] As evidenced by the old study (now in need of updating and further analysis) by Anne Marie Malingrey, *Philosophia* (1961).

[101] On this topic see Cl. Moreschini, 'Gregory Nazianzen and Philosophy' (2012).

[102] F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 29 and 82.

[103] *Orat*. 33,9, trans. Schaff. See also *Or*. 33,15: 'This too I reckoned and still reckon with myself, and you decide if it is not correct. I have often discussed it (ἐφιλοσόφησα) with you before'; *Orat*. 36,4: 'Why indeed did we adopt a strange and outlandish creed … why did we make discussions (ἐφιλοσοφοῦμεν) strange and abnormous' (said with irony about himself) (trans. Vinson).

view of them'.[104] In reply to some offensive comments made by his enemies regarding his provincial origins ('Your city, you say to me, is a little one, or rather is no city at all, but only a village, arid, without beauty, and with few inhabitants'[105]), Gregory writes:

> If like the just man I do not become my own accuser right away (*Prov*. 18:17), at any rate I gladly receive healing from another… But, my good friend, this is my misfortune, rather than my fault, if indeed it be a misfortune. If it is against my will, I am to be pitied for my bad luck, if I may put it so; but if willingly, then I am a philosopher (*Orat*. 33,6).

Another example of a polemical use of the term 'philosopher' is the popular one meaning 'to speak with subtlety, yet without ever coming to a conclusion': '[the doctor] discoursing learnedly on your disease (φιλοσοφῶν περὶ τῆς νόσου μετὰ τὸν θάνατον) after you are dead' (which is surely easy to do).[106]

While Nazianzen condemns pagan philosophy like Basil and Gregory Nyssen, his judgements on it are far more varied. Sometimes he expresses his condemnation of philosophy by traditional means. So, there are plentiful examples in his two *Invectives against Julian*, where he derides Plato, Chrysippus, the Peripatetics, the austere Stoa, as well as the artifice of philosophical language, geometry, discussions of justice, and even the principle that it is better to suffer an offense than to commit one. Julian learned these things from his noble instructors (in other words, theurgists such as Maximus of Ephesus) and the defenders and legislators of the realm, those whom he found at the crossroads and in the slums (the Cynics), masters in impiety and not eloquence (*Orat*. 4,43). The philosophers imagine inexistent and ideal cities, yet adore the splendor of tyrannies (an allusion to Plato and his submission to Dionysius, the tyrant of Syracuse). Philosophers teach many erroneous doctrines: the nonexistence of God and His Providence, that everything moves by chance, by necessity or by astral movement, and that the stars are moved by unknown movers in unknown locations. Other philosophers support hedonism. All of them, immersed in the mud and the shadows of error, are as incapable of teaching as demons, and they are unable to raise themselves to a level worthy of their

[104] *Orat*. 33,11, trans. Schaff.

[105] *Orat*. 33,6, trans. Schaff. The passage where Gregory says of himself that he is an outsider must not be interpreted as if he wished to make a reference to Cappadocia and his (asserted by his enemies) humble background, according to F. Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 191, but rather in the sense of him being an outsider in the world, in the ascetic sense. Yet this 'outsider status' with respect to the world would not have been criticized by Gregory's enemies, while it is known that in the imperial age, Cappadocia, which was an outlying region, was considered (and effectively partly was) rather uncivilized, noted more for its horses than its culture.

[106] *Orat*. 40,11, trans. Schaff. To indicate a pointless discussion of a problem, see *Orat*. 41,2: however, if there be any more lofty reason than this [the number seven], let others discuss it (φιλοσοφείτωσαν). Other examples may be found in *Orat*. 36,6; 38,8 and 10; 39,8,11; 39,17; 40,3; 41,1.

intelligence. Or, even if they did glimpse some truth, because they did not have the *Logos* and God guiding them, they were swayed by things which were easier to believe because of their proximity to the thought of common people and the ignorant.[107]

Famous philosophers are the object of Gregory's scorn:[108] Crates, Antisthenes, Diogenes, Epicurus, Socrates, Aristotle, Cleanthes, Anaxagoras, and Heraclitus. Gregory speaks ironically of Julian's ideal to unite the reign under philosophy.[109] He condemns Pythagoras, the Orphics, and Plato for his doctrine of ideas, metensomatosis, anamnesis and ephebic love; Epicurus, and also Aristotle for his restricted view of providence, his subtlety, his ideas concerning the mortality of the soul, and the meanness of his doctrines; the arrogance of the Stoa, and the gluttony and vagrancy of the Cynics, the Atomists for their doctrines of fullness and void.[110] There are polemical allusions to Sextus Empiricus, Pyrrho, and the Skeptics' stance of 'contesting everything':[111] 'and babbling is reputed culture, and, as the book of the *Acts* says of the Athenians,[112] we spend our time in nothing else but either to tell or to hear some new thing'.[113] He condemns the futility of the arts of *paideia*, syllogisms, letters and geometry, as well as marvelling at the movement of the stars.[114] After his death, Caesarius will therefore not devote his time to the medicine of Hippocrates and Galen or their adversaries, or to the geometry of Euclid, Ptolemy and Heron, or to the boasts of Plato, Aristotle, Pyrrho or other characters like Democritus and Heraclitus, Anaxagoras, Cleanthes and certain other philosophers from the solemn Stoa or the Academy.[115]

Gregory's hostile stance toward philosophy is considerably more lively and interesting when he turns his attention to contemporary philosophical movements and the mystery cults. He refers to 'all the details about the gods and the sacrifices and the idols and demons, whether beneficent or malignant, and all the tricks that people play with divination, evoking gods, or souls, and the power of the stars'.[116] In Constantinople there is 'our much touted sophistic, or grammatic (not to say philosophy), a pursuit that is all the rage among our young people'.[117] His polemic with Julian encapsulates his indictment of philosophy and paganism. Julian was misled by the impiety of the Asian philosophers (most

[107] *Orat*. 4,44.
[108] *Orat*. 4,72.
[109] *Orat*. 4,45.
[110] *Orat*. 27,10.
[111] *Orat*. 21,12.
[112] *Act*. 17:21.
[113] *Orat*. 21,12, trans. Schaff.
[114] *Orat*. 25,7.
[115] *Orat*. 7,20.
[116] *Orat*. 27,9, trans. Schaff.
[117] *Orat*. 22,3, trans. Vinson.

likely local Neo-Platonists, descendants of Iamblichus' teachings) and was pressed by them into dedicating himself to astrology, horoscopes, divination and the magical arts.[118] To this false philosophy, Julian joined the mystery cults which encouraged self-mutilation, Phrygian orgies and Mithraism,[119] secret ceremonies,[120] Orphism, nocturnal rites,[121] and astrology, whose only redeemable aspect was the star that guided the three Magi to Bethlehem.[122] These are all details that derive from a direct acquaintance with Julian's works.

More importantly, Gregory criticizes the Neo-platonic interpretation of ancient myths, to which Julian ascribed. The myths had been challenged as immoral by the pagans themselves, yet the allegorical interpretation that had been put forward for their justification was not convincing (*Or*. 4,114). Even though allegory was practiced by Christians, in the sense proposed by Julian and his friends, pagan allegorical exegesis was arbitrary. Gregory admits that Scripture also has an external meaning, but the most important meaning is the deeper one which educates the faithful. In any case, how would Julian behave if invited to educate the pagans with his authoritative texts such as Homer, Hesiod, and the Orphics, which constitute a series of immoral stories?

> And yet these stories, if true, you should not be ashamed of; but you ought to glory in them, or at any rate to prove that they are not shameful. And what good is there in taking refuge in the word 'fable' as a veil for shame; for a fable is the resource not of those who are confident in their cause, but of those giving it up. But if these tales are fictions, in the first place let them show us their undisguised theologians, so that we can deal with them; and next let them explain how it is not silly to boast of the very things of which they feel ashamed: and the things that it was possible to conceal from the vulgar (for education does not belong to all), to make these public to everybody's eyes, by means of statues and figures.[123]

Old Testament stories must also be interpreted allegorically, but in any case their first meaning is not an immoral one. It is inadmissible that God's doctrine be unseemly and unworthy of its hidden meaning (*Orat*. 4,118). On the contrary, with the pagans the hidden meaning of myths is unbelievable and the immediate one is dangerous. Nevertheless, on one occasion Gregory admits that the

[118] *Orat*. 4,31; 5,20.
[119] *Orat*. 4,70.
[120] *Orat*. 5,30.
[121] *Orat*. 5,31.
[122] *Orat*. 5,5. This detail, that the only star that had truly predicted the future was that of the three Magi, also appears in the *Carmina Arcana* (5,53-69). The comet, which appeared at Christ's birth, signified the submission of pagan astrology to Christian religion. See D.A. Sykes, Cl. Moreschini and L. Holford-Strevens, St. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Carmina Arcana* (1997), *ad locum*.
[123] *Orat*. 4,116, trans. adapt. King (London, 1888).

pagans' allegorical interpretations do have their own logic, as when they declare that their god is an *energheia* (*Orat*. 31,16).[124]

These polemical remarks are certainly based on a solid foundation, and they are not trite repetitions of traditional motifs. Gregory could have read some of Julian works or, perhaps, Salustius' *On the Gods and the World*. In any case, he was informed as to what was said by the men of pagan letters, in the court of Julian and outside of it, in order to defend the deeper meaning of myth through allegorical interpretation. That the pagans allegorically interpreted their myths was a well-known fact for several centuries. Macrobius (*Comm. in somn. Scip*. I 2,7-21) refers to a statement by Porphyry in which he asks which parts of philosophy might use myths. Julian poses the same question in a lengthy section in his *Against the Cynic Heraclius*. Like Macrobius (*Comm. in somn. Scip*. I 2,17), he evokes Porphyry's statement that 'nature loves to hide itself' (*Heracl*. 11,216C).[125] Julian's thinking is that scandalous myths are helpful to certain philosophical procedures. The more absurd and unseemly the myth, the more necessary is an allegorical interpretation, and people of lively intellect are stimulated to discover the true meaning. We find a similar statement in another of Julian's orations (*Mater deor*. 10,170a), which had already been expressed by Maximus of Tyrus (*Diss*. 4,6a) and by Plutarch (*Vit. et poes. Homeri* 6); Proclus (*Comm. Resp*. I 44,14-15) also asserts it, in all probability deriving from Iamblichus.

In conclusion, the problem is one common to most Christian writers: does a true philosophy exist outside of Christianity? For the Cappadocians, only in part. Only Christianity possesses the truth, and pagan philosophy is nothing other than a lower form of knowledge; it may provide, at best, some conceptual instruments which clarify and deepen what Christianity possesses from revelation and tradition. Frederick W. Norris views philosophical rhetoric as essential to the cultural formation of Gregory who, unlike other Christian writers, was educated in Athens. The rhetoric that Gregory studied was that of the Second Sophistic, in which philosophy played a significant role. Furthermore, various neo-Platonic commentators of Aristotle considered his *Rhetoric* and his *Poetics* part of his logic. Accordingly, Norris has detected the presence of logical methods derived from philosophical rhetoric, such as the *enthymeme*, in various passages of Gregory's *Theological Orations*. This could be the way that 'faith gives fullness to reasoning', as Norris has titled his commentary.[126]

[124] For this reason it has been objected, J. Pepin, *Mythe et Allégorie* (1976), 474; K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical Exempla* (1996), 265 that in Julian Gregory criticizes the very exegetic method that he uses; but Gregory does not only refer to the method, but also to the content of the allegorical interpretation.

[125] On this topic, see J. Bouffartigue, *L'empereur Julien* (1992), 338-9.

[126] See F.W. Norris, *Faith Gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991), 17-39. With this interpretation, Norris develops G.A. Kennedy's hypothesis (*Greek Rhetoric* [1983], 215-39), who had limited himself to pointing out the most openly rhetorical elements of Gregory's rhetoric.

6. *Christian Formation: Origenism*

While most of the Cappadocians' cultural formation seems to have taken place outside Cappadocia (in Alexandria; Athens; Constantinople), the environment where they were first educated cannot be neglected either. It is held that Origen's influence, which arrived through the teachings of Gregory the Thaumaturge, was strong there, even if Gregory the Thaumaturge as a theologian is now considered to be less important than was previously the case, and the historical reliability of Nyssen's homily *In Gregorium Thaumaturgum* has been strongly criticized. In any case, Gregory is remembered clearly by Basil (*Epist*. 28 and 204,2), who wishes to underline the orthodoxy, which can be traced back *ab antique*, of both his family and himself.[127]

Simonetti observes that 'while scarce, the documentation in our possession has enabled us to trace a doctrinal line that, for the most part and despite some obvious gaps, is quite continuous, goes from Origen's stay in Cappadocia down through various intermediaries and with inevitable, even considerable adjustments, to Basil, thus testifying to the vitality of the tradition in that region'.[128] The importance of a personality such as Dianius, bishop of Caesarea emerges: while it is not of the first order, it has usually been considered minimal; yet he was the bishop who consecrated Basil as a priest, who, despite criticizing him for adhering to the homoean symbol of the Council of Constantinople in 360 AD, partly excuses him, imputing his error to the simplicity of his soul (that is, little intelligence) (*Epist*. 51,2). As a testimony to Origenism in Cappadocia, the *Philocalia* may also be remembered, which confirms the Origenistic formation of the two compilers.[129] The first fourteen sections of *Philocalia* focus above

[127] See J. Gribomont, 'L'origénisme de Saint Basile', in Saint Basile *Évangile et Église* (1984), 229-42.

[128] See M. Simonetti, 'Origene dalla Cappadocia ai Cappadoci' (2002), 13-28, 23.

[129] The traditional hypothesis, attributing the *Philocalia* to both Basil and Gregory, has been challenged by Marguerite Harl, who maintains that *Letter* 115,3, sent by Gregory to Theodorus, bishop of Tyana, does not constitute proof in favour of the attribution, even if Gregory himself recalls (in *Epist*. 6, from 361 AD) their joint work on the Scriptures, and that the authors of the *Philocalia* remain anonymous. In fact, according to Harl, Gregory accompanies his *Letter* 115 with the manuscript of a work that he calls 'Origen's *Philocalia*', made up of 'extracts from the works of Origen that were useful for the *philologoi*', and this collection could provide its reader with a memory of Gregory and the venerable Basil. To conclude, Harl maintains that it is better to speak of 'Philocalists'; the collection was destined, however, for a cultivated audience in Cappadocia, M. Harl in Origène, *Philocalie*, 1-20 (1983), 20-41. E. Junod also challenges the attribution of the *Philocalia* to Basil and Gregory, and maintains that it arose during the anti-Origenist controversy, in order to save Origen's doctrines, 'Basile de Césarée et Grégoire de Nazianze' (1988), 349-60, with which Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 250 n. 135 agrees. What Harl has observed is too subtle and does not convince me: Gregory clearly says that he sent Theodorus 'an exemplar of *Philocalia* so that Theodorus would also have a memory of Basil': why would he have had to remind Theodorus of himself and Basil if he was simply sending a copy of a text prepared by others? Simonetti also finds the criticism of its authenticity

all on problems regarding biblical hermeneutics, while the following six are taken from Origen's *Contra Celsum* and tackle some issues that might have embarrassed Christians in front of non-believers. The last ones, instead, regard free will and the will of God. It is not clear what readership this work was meant for. It seems to be a 'vade mecum' of useful texts for responding to various questions. It is unlikely that Basil and Gregory would have made personal use of it, because they had access to complete material by Origen. Perhaps the *Philocalia* was meant for the ascetics for whom Basil was the master. Whatever may be the case, it is not a particularly creative or profound work; on the contrary, it was of a practical nature and clearly meant to make Origen's important texts available in a rapidly consultable format.

Origen was a master of both theology and philosophy: this is how it may be explained that Gregory of Nyssa is more competent in philosophy, despite the fact that he did not go either to Athens, as Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus did, or to Alexandria, like Gregory of Nazianzus, or to Constantinople, like Basil, precisely because of them all, he was the one who knew Origen best.[130] Unfortunately, Gregory of Nyssa's cultural formation remains a mystery, and only conjectures can be made about it: it is strange that of the three Cappadocians, the one who was most clearly a philosopher (and in no way inferior as a theologian) should be the person who never left Cappadocia during the years of his formation. Therefore, it must have been possible to acquire in-depth philosophical knowledge in Caesarea in Cappadocia, even if Gregory of Nyssa speaks very little about himself, less indeed than Basil and far less than Gregory of Nazianzus.[131]

Evagrius Ponticus, as we said,[132] also lived in the cultural ambience of the Cappadocians: he received his formation from Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus when they had already matured and made their life choices; indirectly, through Basil and the two Gregories, he began to learn about Origenism. The same can be said of Amphilochius, due to his friendship to Basil and Nazianzen. Understanding Evagrius' Origenism is made more difficult by the fact that at the age of thirty-five he abandoned Constantinople (and probably Cappadocia as well) and retired to the desert of Egypt: one might wonder if having changed his way of life and his cultural environment produced a change

exaggerated, 'Origene dalla Cappadocia' (2002), 26 n. 28, as does Gautier, *La retraite* (2002), 289 n. 1. Finally, Christoph Markschies briefly refers to the *Philocalia* in the context of Basil's theology, *Alta Trinità Beata* (1994), 206, observing that, when in *Letter* 6 Gregory says he participated with Basil in the writing of the rules concerning virtue and shared with him the zeal for divine oracles and the work of exegesis, he is referring precisely to the program of the *Philocalia*.

[130] See above, p. 13.

[131] J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa* (2000), 9-12.

[132] See introd., p. 5-8.

in his Origenian formation. Considering his theology, and his eschatology, in which subordinationism and the doctrine of apocatastasis played a large part, it would seem that the opposite is true, if only because the desert of Egypt was the place where Origenism continued to thrive. Also with regard to the interpretation of the Scriptures, in my view, it does not seem that the change was total; however, according to Casiday, Evagrius's exegesis during the desert period seems to have been in part different, due to greater attention being paid to 'historical' details. But that a clear distinction should not be made between 'history' and 'theoria' for Evagrius (or even for others) was rightly stated by Casiday himself.[133]

7. *Origenism and Exegesis*

A hundred and fifty years after Origen's death, not following his exegesis had become impossible: it was open to discussion not only the extent to which one could interpret it by following (or not following) his method but as Markus Vinzent suggested to me 'also in which way one interpreted and followed him, as can be seen from the early discussion between Asterius and Marcellus who both claim Origen as their point of reference, while at the same time accusing the other of reading him wrongly'. The extent to which, for the Cappadocians, the three types of exegesis attributed to Origen are employed, also remains uncertain.[134] Establishing a precise standard to follow the *theoria* or the 'history' was practically impossible, and the Cappadocians followed both of these.[135] Thus, they employ Origen's spiritualism with no difficulty, without, however, having his strong interest in learned and philological issues, which they occasionally mention but do not go into.[136] It is a *communis opinio* that Gregory of Nyssa insisted on spiritualistic exegesis, while Basil preferred historical interpretation. In actual fact, all the Cappadocians accept spiritualism and, to a certain extent, literalism, and within this general tendency it is not possible to distinguish

[133] Apart from the useful considerations of Guillaumont, see the recent intelligent synthesis by A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology of Evagrius Ponticus Beyond Heresy* (2013), 100-32.

[134] In this regard, there is only a complete study of Gregory of Nazianzus: K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 259-60 maintains that Gregory uses all three types of Origen's exegesis, even though I feel this is doubtful.

[135] K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 285, states that 'to me, Gregory's position within the assumed opposition Alexandria – Antioch is indubitable: nowhere in his hermeneutics do we find an inescapable indication of the Antiochene tradition, perhaps with the exception of his avoidance of the term. Conversely, many points show him to fit in with the Origenist tradition'. In fact, in Gregory's time it was not yet possible to speak of a true Antiochene exegesis and, as I have tried to point out, the same type of Origenist exegesis was, for the Cappadocians, open to literalist and moral interpretative possibilities.

[136] An isolated instance: Gregory of Nyssa, *Cant. Hom.* II (GNO VI 67,8-68,2).

stances that openly diverge from each other.[137] In any case, not even Origen had been purely a spiritualist.

Basil's exegetic activity, among whose works there are no true biblical commentaries in the traditional sense, is closely linked to the teaching that mostly took the form of homilies, as is the case with the *Homilies on the Psalms* and the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron*. Regarding the exegesis carried out in the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron*, generally their literalism and anti-allegorism have been underlined, and indeed this criterion is part of his way of understanding *Genesis*, which in the early centuries of Christianity had come in for special study. But Basil's literalism takes more the form of a polemic against an excess of allegory rather than representing a true exegetical method. In *Hexaem. hom.* II 2,1 Basil argues against the 'falsifiers of truth', who with an unbridled allegorical approach identified the invisible and unformed earth of *Gen.* 1:2 with uncreated matter that was independent of God and eternal like Him, and thus advancing an ontological dualism that destroys the genuine concept of creation and offends the freedom of God the creator. For the same reason Basil confutes those who interpret the darkness, which is mentioned in that scriptural passage, as evil (II 4-5): this type of exegesis, in fact, led to the dualistic, Gnostic and Manichean conception of the substantial and original reality of evil. He rejects the anagogical sense of the exegesis of certain 'writers of the Church', who in the waters of *Gen.* 1:6 saw the spiritual and incorporeal powers: high up were the good powers, and below those of the abyss, the evil ones (III 9,7).[138] Origen had effectively proposed this interpretation, but perhaps Basil is not alluding to him and does not wish to attribute to Origen all the errors of the allegorists.[139] The harshest criticism against them occurs in IX 1,10, where Basil states that he is well acquainted with the rules of allegory, but he refuses to accept the exegetical distortions of the sacred text carried out by those who presume to be more learned than the Word of the Spirit.[140] Against the perverse interpretation of these learned men, Basil firmly reiterates that scriptural teaching is simple, it is not a scientific treatise; rather, it has been set forth by God 'for the edification and perfecting of our souls'. To sum up,

[137] On Cappadocian exegesis, see the synthesis made by Manlio Simonetti, *Lettera e/o allegoria* (1985), 140-56.

[138] See further on, pp. 149-50.

[139] However, beyond Didymos of Alexandria, it is not easy to find out just who these allegorists are. According to Girardi, they may have been some scholars close to Peter of Sebasteia, Gregory of Nyssa's brother, who pressurized Gregory for a markedly spiritualistic exegesis after the lack of an explanation from Basil regarding the creation of man, M. Girardi, 'L'esegesi esamerale di Basilio di Cesarea' (2002), 112. But there is no concrete support for this hypothesis.

[140] As occurred with the interpretation of the nether waters in *Gen.* 1:2, this controversy regards the distorted interpretation, not by Origen, but by some allegorists who dedicate themselves exclusively to allegory, without taking into account the first level, which is the literal one. In Girardi's opinion, Basil takes a balanced stance between the two tendencies (*ibid.* 95-100).

Basil criticizes any peculiar interpretations that attempt to find arbitrary meanings in the sacred text, which in their turn have nothing to do with scriptural teaching. When he does not wish to correct mistakes made by others, Basil sticks to the text, but he does not banalize the literal meaning, which instead often becomes a starting point from which to explore metaphors and moral teachings. In this case he makes use of symbolism and classification and accepts a limited use of metaphor in the allegorical process.

It has been suggested that Basil's position may have evolved, from his youthful adhesion to Origenist-style exegesis, which was subsequently attenuated through contact with Antiochene masters such as Diodorus of Tarsus, whom he knew, and for pastoral reasons, until it cleaved to literalism, which was clearly expressed in the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron*.[141] Nevertheless, he simply limits himself to advancing an interpretation, on its own or as an alternative to others, but he does not formulate theoretical principles.[142] Following a tendency that seems to be inspired by the first level of Origen's exegesis, in his homilies on the Old Testament Basil states that various episodes in the narration are 'history', but he also attempts a spiritual and allegorical interpretation, if not even a mystical one. However, Basil follows the literalist method throughout his homilies, and so any evolution towards the literalism of the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron* has to be discounted.[143] As has been said, it is used above all to rebut the allegory used by certain doctrinal deviations, such as Gnosticism and Manichaeism. Basically, in Basil's exegesis the literal interpretation precedes, as if it was an introduction and in accordance with the framework of two-level readings, the moral and spiritual exegesis.[144] Therefore, Basil does not reject the allegorical method, but only what he saw as its abuse: he is not an allegorist in the strictest sense, but neither is he an Antiochene *ante litteram*. He too avails of the so-called *defectus litterae*, the etymological symbolism of Hebrew names and common names, the accumulation of second-level interpretations for the same passage, and to variants of manuscripts and translators in order to enrich a spiritual and allegorical interpretation. In other words, on several occasions he considers a Hebrew-style literal interpretation of the sacred text to be inadequate, unless this is superseded by the coming of Christ, and a spiritual interpretation that is more elevated and more profound. Chap. 21

[141] See J. Gribomont, 'L'origenisme de saint Basile' (1984).

[142] See M. Girardi, 'Appunti per una definizione dell'esegesi allegorica' (1993); 'Erotapocriseis neotestamentarie' (1994); *Basilio di Cesarea interprete della Scrittura* (1998); 'Basilio di Cesarea e Origene' (1999).

[143] See M. Simonetti, *Lettera e/o allegoria* (1985), 142.

[144] *Hom. in princ. Prov.* 4 (PG 31, 393A) may be considered an example of interpretation: the Κρατήρ, which is mentioned in *Prov.* 9:2 and 5 ('she hath mingled her wine… Come, eat of my bread, and drink of the wine which I have mingled') 'is the common and general sharing of goods, so that it is possible for anyone, in accordance with each person's ability and need, to draw on these in equal shares'.

of *De Spiritu sancto* underlines the importance of a spiritual interpretation insofar as it represents the ultimate and definitive meaning of Scripture. Consequently, the simplicity and brevity of the Scriptural Word are of no use to the distracted, inexpert, or presumptuous reader. The introduction to *De Spiritu sancto* (1,2) urges us to study Scripture, and it seems as if in those words it is possible to catch an echo of Origen.

The function and the justification of exegesis, and more particularly of allegorical exegesis, are discussed by Gregory of Nazianzus already at the outset of his career as a sacred orator, specifically when, in an attack on the emperor Julian, he also takes into account the allegorical method applied by pagan intellectuals (see above, p. 47-8). Gregory's interest in the problem of exegesis becomes more relevant when it is remembered that at the time he was writing, Basil had as yet uttered, among the ones that have reached us, only a few homilies of a moral nature.

In 383 AD with *Orations* 44 and 45, Gregory brought to a close his activity as a Preacher. The last years of his life were active and not, as was thought previously, only dedicated to asceticism: he dedicated himself to gathering and re-elaborating his previous orations, selecting the ones he felt were the best: in fact, his preaching had occurred over a period of twenty years and it may have been more abundant than we have any means of reconstructing from the forty-four homilies that have reached us. In selecting the homilies that most interested him, Gregory wished to present himself to his readers as the ideal bishop.[145]

Nevertheless, despite having been a sacred orator like Basil and Gregory of Nyssa, it is strange that Gregory did not select his orations of an exegetical nature to be inserted into the corpus for publication. The only exception to this is n. 37, dedicated to *Matthew* 19:1-12, on becoming eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of heaven, along with an extensive section of the oration *On Easter* (45,12-22), in which he interprets and classifies all the particulars of the Jewish Passover. Consequently, in the history of Christian exegesis, Gregory hardly exists. This fact contrasts with what one would logically suppose, that is, that Gregory's preaching should have mostly contained scriptural exegesis and, above all, with the fact that Jerome, according to what he himself says (*Vir. ill.* 117), seems to have learnt the art of interpreting Scripture for which he, Gregory, was famous in his own time, from Gregory of Nazianzus. In any case, n. 37 fits to Gregory's moderate asceticism, which does not reject marriage.

In fact, Gregory of Nazianzus also examines the function of the exegesis of a Christian text, but he does so – as with all his doctrines – in a brief, rhapsodic

[145] See J. Bernardi, *La prédication des Pères Cappadociens* (1968), 254. The previous judgements on Gregory Nazianzen's use of the art of oratory are not very useful: they have been summarized by K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 250-1.

manner. Indeed, he does not better explain his statement of wanting to interpret both the Old and the New Testament in a spiritual sense (πρὸς τὸν νοῦν ἄγων ἀπὸ τοῦ γράμματος ὥσπερ τὴν παλαιὰν καὶ τὴν νέαν) (*Orat*. 42,16). With a detailed analysis of *Oration* 37, and partly following some observations made by Gallay,[146] Bernardi underlined how, despite its exegetical content, in actual fact it contains very few exegetical elements. Indeed, in this context Gregory seems to be concerned with something very different, and that is, presenting personal convictions that have little to do with the Gospel passage that he was commenting on; on the contrary, he uses the scriptural passage as a springboard for, in a very unsystematic way, advancing the most varied of theses, which are the very ones that make up most of his preaching during the Constantinople period: the defense of orthodoxy, the confutation of the Arians, the exaltation of the idea of virginity even at the cost of devaluing marriage.[147] It may be that these characteristics were constant in Gregory's exegesis, that is, by dedicating himself to the education of the people through an explanation of what was important at that time, keeping the actual scriptural exegesis in the background, which precisely for this reason he did not consider to be sufficiently significant, to the extent that he did not include exegetical homilies in his collection.

This does not mean, however, that Gregory was not aware of having to follow an exegetical method. Gregory clearly indicated its principles:

> As far as we are concerned, we follow a middle path between those who are completely obtuse in spirit and those who are too prone to speculation and anagoge; we certainly do not wish to remain still and inert; nor, however, do we wish to research more than is necessary…, since the first approach is rather too Jewish and lowly, while the second is worthy of an interpreter of dreams. Hence, both the one and the other are equally erroneous (*Orat*. 45,12; PG 637CD).

He intends to follow a 'middle way', along the lines of his approach in the theological field to the two opposite deviations of Arianism and Sabellianism. Since the oration that contains this exegetic statement is the last oration made by Gregory, this statement is 'a sort of spiritual testament'.[148] But Gregory had already stated this same principle at the start of his career, in *Orat*. 2,49, criticizing those who demanded that scriptural interpretation be devoid of literal exegesis, and that everything must be understood in a spiritual way (καὶ οὐδαμοῦ τὸ γράμμα καὶ πάντα δεῖ νοηθῆναι πνευματικῶς).[149] In the same oration Gregory explains the episode of Jonah (*Orat*. 2,106-9) in a spiritual way, after protesting (almost as a foreshadowing of what he was to say two years later in

[146] See P. Gallay, 'La Bible dans l'œuvre de Grégoire de Nazianze' (1984).

[147] See J. Bernardi, *Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (1995), 278-84.

[148] See P. Gallay, 'La Bible dans l'œuvre de Grégoire de Nazianze' (1984), 323.

[149] Naturally there are numerous examples of Gregory's spiritual interpretations, such as the traditional case regarding the interpretation of the names of Christ (ex. *Orat*. 2,98; 28,3.11.13; 30,17.18).

an argument with Julian) that biblical stories have a deeper meaning, unlike pagan myths, the only purpose of which is that of giving pleasure (*Orat*. 2,104). Indeed, the purpose of the biblical tale is to provide useful moral teachings (2,105). For this reason the episode with Jonah is remarkable and requires an adequate interpretation: Gregory may have inferred this from Origen, to whom he refers when he mentions 'a man who is an expert on these topics' (2,107). Gregory's explanation does indeed coincide in many places with Jerome's, which definitely derives from Origen.[150]

In *Oration* 14, *On the Love of the Poor* (PG 35, 857A-910C), Gregory advances a moral interpretation of *Micah* 2:10, which he considers to be a forerunner of *John* 14:31, in the sense that the prophet's statement: 'Arise ye, and depart; for this is not your rest: because it is polluted', and that of Christ: 'Arise, let us go hence', do not refer to a material movement from one place to another, but rather mean that Christ's followers have to leave this world and worldly goods in order to turn to heavenly goods and the heavens themselves (21,885AB). Subsequently (38,910A), Gregory interprets in an equally moral way *Isaiah* 58:9 (ἐὰν ἀνέλῃς σύνδεσμον καὶ χειροτονίαν): these words mean that one should be generous without being tied to limits, without making calculations and choices when one gives to the poor, and the same interpretation is presented a few years later, in 374 AD, in the funeral oration on the death of his father (18,20; PG 35,1008D): his father used to donate, 'removing any limit and choice', that is, with nothing holding him back and without looking to see who was asking. In conclusion, these are in fact moral teachings: Demoen examines other similar ones[151] and highlights the fact that Gregory often used a 'typical' interpretation.[152]

Oration 30 is of greater importance. In it Gregory examines and explains a dossier of scriptural passages in a pro-Nicene sense; these were considered by the Arians as proof favourable to their cause and were widespread in the controversies of the time. One of these passages concerns the 'submission' of the Son to the Father at the end of time (1*Cor*. 15:28). Gregory of Nyssa's interpretation, who dedicated an entire homily to this passage, is better known, but Gregory of Nazianzus' one, despite being different, deserves to be known as well because it is very personal. If the Son is submitted to the Father only at the end of time, the Eunomians observe, that means he is not so now – and this is impossible. Therefore, the submission has to be attributed to Christ insofar as he is a man who epitomises in himself all of humanity:

> So long as I am an insubordinate rebel with passions which deny God, my lack of submission will be referred to Christ. But when all things are put in submission under him, when transformed they obediently acknowledge him, then will Christ bring me

[150] This is what Y.-M. Duval rightly explains, *Le livre de Jonas* (1973), 242-5.
[151] K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 268-83.
[152] *Ibid*. 249.

forward, me who has been saved, and make his subjection complete. In my view Christ's submission is the fulfillment of the Father's will (*Orat*. 30,5).[153]

In fact, there is no actual submission even now: indeed, thanks to the complete unity of will among the Persons, 'as we said before the Son actively produces submission to the Father, while the Father wills and approves submission to the Son. Thus it is that he effects our submission, makes it his own and presents it to God' (*ibid*.).

In addition, Christ's cry on the cross: 'My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?' (*Mark* 15:34) is interpreted by Gregory as the submission, through Christ, of all of humanity:

> He is not forsaken either by the Father or, as some think, by his own godhead, which closes up, afraid of suffering, and abandons the sufferer… No, in himself, as I have said, he expresses our condition. We had once been the forsaken and disregarded; then we were taken and now are saved by the suffering of the impassible. He made our thoughtlessness and waywardness his own, just as the *Psalm*, in its subsequent course, says – since the 21st *Psalm* clearly refers to Christ (*ibid*.).

Interpreting *John* 5:19: ('The Son can do nothing of himself, but what he seeth the Father do: for what things soever he doeth, these also doeth the Son likewise'), Gregory begins the discussion at a remove (*Orat*. 30,10), with an examination of the various meanings that may be found in the expressions 'to be able or not to be able' and excludes the possibility that a world of Ideas, in a Platonic sense, of the Father might exist, which, in imitating it, the Son (as if he were a Platonic-type demiurge) does what he wishes; therefore, he advances his own interpretation (30,11): 'Clearly the Father indicates the outline, whilst the Word makes a finished product, of the same facts. He acts not like an ignorant slave, but with a master's knowledge – to put it more appropriately, like the Father'. Wishing to differentiate and yet unite the activity of the Son and the Father, Gregory separates the two moments of 'doing': the former, which is completely ideal and intellectual, is what gives shape in the mind to the models of a thing and an action, while the second is what concretely accomplishes the models. At the root of this relationship between the two aspects probably lies the tradition, which Gregory himself knows (*Orat*. 29,17), that the Son, the creator Logos, is within the Father, so that he cannot create anything that the Father has not already thought of. This does not mean any inferiority of the Son, but rather a perfect correspondence between the power and the will of the Father and those of the Son. He states this also by interpreting *John* 6:38 ('For I came down from heaven, not to do mine own will, but the will of him that sent me') (*Orat*. 30,12).

[153] Trans. L. Wickham and F. Williams, in *Faith gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991), here and subsequently for the so-called 'Theological Orations'.

The issue tackled a little further on (*Orat*. 30,15-6), and which would be taken up again by Augustine, is usual part of a discussion between pro-Nicenes and Arians; that is, that the Son does not know when the last day and the last hour will be, for only the Father knows this (*Mark* 13:32). Gregory presents the most common explanation, which is to be found in other pro-Nicene writers; that is, the Son does not know insofar as he is a man, but he does know as God; according to Gregory, the explanation he advances in Chap. 16 is more profound: 'Let us, as in every other case, pay honour here to the parent by referring knowledge of the highest things to him as a cause'. Gregory attributes this exegesis to 'one of the scholars of our times (τῶν καθ' ἡμᾶς φιλολόγων τις)', perhaps Basil (*Epist*. 236,1-2).[154] Indeed, no one possesses this knowledge, except for the First Nature, that is, the Father. In *Orat*. 30,13, interpreting 'and Jesus said unto him, Why callest thou me good? none is good, save one, that is, God' (*Luke* 18:19), Gregory observes that Jesus is speaking to a doctor of the law, and so he excludes humankind, but he does not exclude himself from the goodness of God. In both cases, however, Gregory summaries and modifies Basil's extensive treatise of *Epistle* 236.[155]

Gregory of Nyssa's exegesis has been studied far more than that of the other Cappadocians, and mostly with results on which everyone has agreed. Origenistic spiritualism has always been considered to be its principal characteristic, even though at times there are elements of literalism. The way in which Gregory of Nyssa presented his citations have been briefly examined by Michel Aubineau,[156] who, drawing on Werner Jaeger's observations,[157] partly corrected them. Jaeger had stated that in *De virginitate*, a youthful work, Gregory of Nyssa may have still been under the influence of the rhetoric he had taught up until a short while prior to this, so that he was trying to maintain a defence of virginity by availing more of philosophical texts rather than scriptural ones. Aubineau responded by discovering a huge quantity of hidden citations of biblical expressions, which had eluded the previous editors, as well as Jaeger himself; ultimately, he declared that it was possible to speak of a 'phénomène d'osmose' between biblical culture and Gregory of Nyssa's

[154] This is what Gallay understands, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 27-31* (1978), 259.

[155] Some of the exegesis put forward by Gregory in *Oration* 30 were taken up again by Evagrius in the so-called *Epistula fidei* (apud Bas., *Epist*. 8,4-10). Nevertheless, Evagrius adds other biblical passages, advancing personal interpretations. The biblical passages commented on are: *John* 6:57 ('I live by the Father') and 14:28 ('for my Father is greater than I'); *Prov*. 8:22 ('The Lord created me in the beginning of his way, before his works of old'); 1*Cor*. 15:28 (the submission of the Son to the Father). Both Gregory of Nazianzus' passages and those of Evagrius are examined by L. Lugaresi, '"Non disprezziamo l'economia"' (2000), 102-10. On the exegetical criteria employed in this epistle, cf. P. Géhin, 'La place de la *Lettre sur la foi*' (2000), 25, 36-42.

[156] See Grégoire de Nysse, *Traité de la virginité* (1966), 118-22.

[157] See W. Jaeger, *Two rediscovered Works* (1954), 122-3.

profane culture.[158] Gregory of Nyssa's exegesis may be distinguished on the basis of the literary genre and the destination of the various works: the homilies represent a way of expressing oneself in the short term, and therefore the exegeses are introduced in a more 'informal' manner (which may be arbitrary), or in any case in such a way as not to hide the shift from one stylistic register to another. The treatises, instead, are more pondered and the use of the philosophy found in them, and its subsequent confirmation through Scripture, is carried out with greater caution and circumspection.

Gregory of Nyssa, like Basil, also rejects excessive allegory when he criticises certain spuriously 'spiritual' interpretations of the most commonly used scriptural terms: in *Hexaem*. chs 21 and 77 (GNO IV/I) he takes up similar statements made by Basil in *Homeliae in Hexaemeron* against the absurd spiritualistic interpretations. In *Contra Eunomium* III 4,53 he also firmly supports literalism: but here too, as always, this means literalism when interpreting a word and not a general exegetical method. This is so because Gregory appreciates the literal meaning of the first chapter of *Genesis* 'in a different, less rigid way compared to his brother, and confirmation of this comes from the parallel work "The Creation of Man", where the Platonic factor is strong'.[159] However, in those same years the *Homilies on the Beatitudes* and *On the Lord's Prayer* are permeated by the criterion of identifying the necessity of spiritual elevation as the basis of his exegesis, despite the fact that it was to all intents and purposes quite a literal reading of the text.

In the treatise *On the Inscriptions of the Psalms* Gregory outlines for the first time the exegetical criteria that he will apply subsequently: when a literal interpretation of the Bible is not useful on the moral level, by seeking a solution to the so-called *defectus litterae*, the exegete has to turn to an allegorical interpretation. It is valid only if it is based on the criterion of consequentiality (ἀκολουθία) that is, the necessity of tracing a rigorous logic in the facts and ideas within the biblical text. He puts these hermeneutical pre-requisites into action by re-elaborating principles of neo-Platonic exegesis, already present in Origen, Eusebius of Caesarea, and Philo of Alexandria.

In *Homilies on Ecclesiastes* Gregory of Nyssa states programmatically that he follows Origen, from whom he takes the succession *Proverbs – Ecclesiastes*, with the reading of which progress may be made in knowledge and perfection. In order to achieve this, he notes – unlike in the previous treatises – that it is absolutely crucial to move beyond the literal or strictly moral meaning, which otherwise would often be unacceptable for a Christian: some exegetes, indeed, had believed that it is possible to find the presence of Epicureanism in *Ecclesiastes*, basing this on the biblical writer's exhortation to grasp the moment and

[158] Grégoire de Nysse, *Traité de la virginité* (1966), 121.
[159] See M. Simonetti, *Lettera e/o Allegoria* (1985), 145-56.

find pleasure, because all is vanity. Instead, Gregory of Nyssa is inspired by Platonism, insofar as he sees in earthly things the essential characteristic of the created world, to which he juxtaposes transcendent reality.

In the *Homilies on the Song of Songs*, his last exegetical work, Gregory resumes the spiritual exegesis of this book started by Origen: the spiritual meaning is the most important, and it regards mystical asceticism. He underlines every particular of the sacred text in a mystical sense, reuniting in the one context all spiritual experiences, such as an ecstatic vision, the 'sober inebriation' that enfolds the soul caught up in ecstasy, the ascent to God, the unceasing cleaving to the object of love (*epéktasis*), and the continual disappointment caused by the infiniteness of God and the finiteness of humanity.

According to some scholars,[160] Gregory of Nyssa follows Iamblichus' exegetical criteria and feels that a Christian interpretation has to keep its sights on the specific intent (σκοπός) and the consequentiality (ἀκολουθία) of the demonstration; but this connection with Iamblichus seems to me to be unlikely, and in any case unprovable: the need to find a σκοπός and follow an ἀκολουθία seems obvious for any exegete, nor is there concrete proof (despite what some think) that Gregory made use of Iamblichus.

Despite having dedicated himself to very diverse types of Biblical texts (*Song of Songs*, *Ecclesiastes*, *Exodus*) he highlights the principal thrust of his speculation. 'The craft employed in the formal elaboration is much greater than in Origen, Eusebius or Didymus.' (Simonetti). It should be borne in mind, however, that – as will be said subsequently – the in-depth range of exegesis in the most important homilies is not found in numerous other homilies, which were occasional works. In conclusion, 'Gregory was above all spiritual, like Origen and Didymus, and therefore naturally inclined to promote spiritual exegesis, that is, largely allegorizing the sacred text, following in the wake of Origen'.[161] Gregory is not against allegory, but he remains an Origenist spiritualist, tempered by the equilibrium that was a legacy from Basil, and the caution prompted by the controversies of his time.

Neither does Evagrius limit himself to the literal interpretation of the sacred text. Following the Alexandrine school and his master, Gregory of Nazianzus, he holds that the spiritual meaning of Scripture may be accessed only by those who have undergone the requisite purification.[162] Those who are still under the sway of their passions may read from the sacred text (as, indeed, did demons), but without being able to grasp its real significance (*KG* VI 37). Evagrius' claim is also traditional that above and beyond the literal meaning, Scripture

[160] First among whom, Jean Daniélou, in his collected works, *L'Être et le temps* (1970).

[161] See M. Simonetti, *Lettera e/o Allegoria* (1985), 146-7; M. Girardi, 'Annotazioni alla esegesi di Gregorio Nisseno' (1995) follows Simonetti's interpretation.

[162] See below, pp. 207-8.

also contains an ethical meaning, that of the contemplation of nature (that is, 'physical', as he says), and ultimately, that of theology (*Schol. Psalm.* 76,21), that is, gnosis, which is the perfect science.[163] Already in the *Epistula fidei*, if it does date back to the beginning for Evagrius when he was still in contact with Gregory of Nazianzus, Evagrius was interested in exegesis, which he carried out in the Origenist manner, as has been demonstrated by Paul Géhin.[164]

[163] On the scriptural interpretation by Evagrius, see A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 59 and 309-19. On the literal interpretation, *ibid.* 311; on the spiritual interpretation, which must follow three criteria, *ibid.* 312.

[164] P. Géhin, 'La place de la *Lettre sur la foi*' (2000), 36-42.

Chapter II

Literary Genres

Among the literary genres that were most in vogue during the 4th century, Sophist oratory, epistolography, and poetry stand out:[1] for Christians the homily corresponded to oration, and epistolography and poetry were carried out also by the Cappadocians. It has been claimed that 'Christian bishops succeeded to the place of the epideictic orators of the Second Sophistic',[2] and that, thanks to their predication, the Cappadocians managed to 'restore to traditional rhetoric its popular platform, supported by institutional authority',[3] but epistolography and poetry (and not only the didactic kind), which the Cappadocians practised, were a 'novelty'. More particularly, the novelty of poetry was a merit exclusively of Gregory of Nazianzus, with some limited participation on the part of Amphilochius. They certainly delivered homilies (as well as writing letters) more frequently than their written compositions that have reached us may lead one to think: it is likely that they thought it was not fitting to show a public output (the homilies) or a private one (the letters) if it was not adequately polished on a literary level, or sufficiently important in terms of its content.[4]

1. *The Homily*

Despite the fact that some examples of homilies can be found right from the beginnings of Christianity, in the 4th century homilies had become an essential activity, irreplaceable for anyone who had a role of responsibility within the Church: it may be said that no one, from the Cappadocians to Chrysostomus, from Hilary to Ambrose and Augustine, avoided the duty of preaching to the Christian community and educating it. Jacques Fontaine defined the homily as the 'mass-media' of the Christian world at that time.

[1] Regarding this, see e.g. G.A. Kennedy, *Greek Rhetoric* (1983); A. Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric of the Empire* (1991); *ead*., 'Education and Literary Culture' (1997), 667-9. Brian E. Daley, 'Building a New City. The Cappadocian Fathers' (1999), 438-40, has focused on the topic of the Cappadocians.

[2] A. Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric of the Empire* (1991), 135.

[3] *Ibid*. 130. To be strictly accurate, however, Evagrius should be excluded, as there is nothing to show he wrote homilies.

[4] That the Cappadocians made a selection of their homilies, and that this selection had a precise aim (showcasing whatever seemed the most opportune aspect of themselves) was confirmed by Jean Bernardi, *La prédication des Pères Cappadociens* (1968), 91, 144, 147-8, 165-8 etc. Once he had returned to Nazianzus following the Council in 381, Gregory may have edited his homilies in order to publish them: this is also demonstrated by the fact that some of them, in the edition that we are now reading, contain details that could not have been a part of an oral delivery. See also K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 69.

The method by which the homilies were usually composed was described by Gregory of Nyssa (*Cant. Hom*, prol.; GNO VI, 13,9-20), and it is highly likely that what he described was normal practice: the first draft was pronounced in church, and then probably enlarged at the moment it was delivered to his audience; the stenographers recorded the recitation, and the author intervened subsequently on the stenographic record in order to give the homily its definitive form.[5] Consequently, it is possible that the final re-elaboration may have greatly modified the initial redaction, but traces of the oral exposition may still be found. The re-elaboration in a written form might have occurred either shortly after the moment of its pronouncement or subsequently, when the author was thinking about publishing it. It has been observed that *Oration* 43 by Gregory Nazianzen, containing Basil's commendation, requires about three hours when it is read out aloud, which means that it is impossible the written redaction could correspond to the oral one. Others show signs of subsequent insertions (*Homily* n. 18 by Gregory of Nazianzus on the death of his father in its written redaction).[6] Some homilies, such as the second and the two *Invectivae* by Gregory of Nazianzus on the death of the emperor Julian (*Orat*. 4 and 5) take the form of a treatise and most likely were never pronounced but only written. A similar re-elaboration occurred for some epistles, which became didactic epistles and therefore were not reserved only for the person to whom they had been sent, such as the three theological epistles by Gregory of Nazianzus or nn. 3, 5, and 26 by Gregory of Nyssa, but for this procedure there already existed a pagan tradition of philosophical epistles.

The Ambience and the Public

A comprehensive study of Christian homilies as literary genre is still lacking to this day. Jean Bernardi's was the first on the Cappadocians, and, inevitably, it seems a little dated: but it is in any case fundamental.[7] A brief contribution by Andreas Spira considers only a particular type of homily, the 'religious oration';[8] and then Anthony Meredith has considered above all the theme of charity in Cappadocian preaching.[9]

Naturally, the audience for these homilies varied depending on the places. R. MacMullen examines above all the audience for John Chrysostom, and maintains that it was capable of understanding his teachings;[10] it was made up

[5] Gregory of Nazianzus also recalls the stenographs involved in his homilies: they were located outside the main body of the church and their work was not visible to the public (γραφίδες φανεραὶ καὶ λανθάνουσαι) (*Orat*. 42,26).

[6] See p. 88-9.

[7] J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968).

[8] See A. Spira, 'Volkstümlichkeit und Kunst' (1985), 65-70, as far as the literary genre is concerned. But it is certain that more in-depth and wide-ranging research is needed.

[9] A. Meredith, 'The three Cappadocians on Beneficence' (1998).

[10] R. MacMullen, 'The Preacher's audience' (1989).

of wealthy people against whom the preacher juxtaposed the poor that were not present at his sermon, and in whose favour he spoke. In no city was the church, or the churches, capable of holding a significant part of the population: only a select audience would fit into the church. Furthermore, the same social classes would attend the sermons: the preachers found themselves faced with the city leadership, the highest social classes, and therefore also the most cultivated ones. In Basil's and Gregory of Nazianzus' homilies, the preacher often addresses the wealthy or learned man, even though Basil's and Gregory of Nyssa's homilies have their fair share of references to people of more humble and less cultivated extraction. Gregory of Nazianzus (*Orat.* 14,14; PG 35, 877A) speaks of 'us', that is, of the preacher and the listeners, just like Chrysostom, setting them apart from the poor, who were not present in the church. While women were present, there had to be far fewer of them than the men, nor was it usual to address them directly. Given that their presence is attested to in John Chrysostom's audience, it is possible to imagine that the same applied (even though there are no precise indications to support this) among the Cappadocians' audience; in any case, there must have been very few of them.

As Gregory of Nyssa informs us (*In Hexaem.* 4; GNO IV/I, 4, 9,16-11,2), the audience Basil spoke to was also varied: he adapted his oration to everyone's talents and abilities, whether they were cultivated or of more humble extraction (artisans, women, the elderly, and children), who made up most of his audience and were not capable of understanding doctrinal subtleties, but 'had to be guided by the hand so that they would arrive at an understanding of the greatness and goodness of the Creator of the Universe'. At times he addresses an audience that is not very cultivated, because he apologizes when saying difficult things (*Hexaem. Hom.* IV 2): Bernardi is amazed that in a city as small as Caesarea ordinary people seem to have followed the difficult teachings contained in the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron*.[11] Since some points of those homilies require substantial intellectual effort to grasp, such as the first two homilies, which discuss the science and cosmology of pagan philosophies, it is likely that not all of the audience were capable of following his reasoning. For that again, ordinary relatively uneducated people could in some way overcome the difficulty of paying attention of demanding topics because at opportune moments the preacher managed to add digressions full of curious details, wonderful, captivating news, until a rapport was created with his audience that was sometimes made manifest with lively words. However, there were also cultivated people who required an oration that was up to standard: they were interested in philosophical doctrines and science, such as astronomy, botany, and zoology.[12] In the first six homilies, objections are repeatedly brought up by

[11] About the audience of Basil see J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 33-41, 48-54 etc.

[12] Nevertheless, I would limit the number of learned men or philosophers that could have been present in Caesarea.

these intellectuals, which cause not a few difficulties for Basil, who usually has little sympathy for them and prefers to cut their objections short by having recourse to the Scriptures. Gregory of Nyssa concludes that Basil managed to arouse and keep the general attention and that 'most of the ordinary audience understood his preaching, and those who had an above-average level of culture admired him'.

The varied nature of the audience is less obvious in the homilies of Gregory of Nazianzus, for which there are no contemporary testimonies, but only those of Gregory himself. Among these, the homilies of the Constantinople period demonstrate that they were pronounced in front of a more expert audience in terms of theology, but, in general, they are not characterized by a lively and immediate engagement with his listeners. Leemans states that Gregory of Nyssa's audience most likely had a composite nature, since there might be hard-core Christians, wavering Christians, and pagans,[13] but overall Farrugia's opinion may be accepted that the listeners of his homilies most likely did not know his theological treatises, and that Gregory was well aware he was teaching them with simpler and less refined intellectual instruments.[14]

Cappadocian preaching has two levels, which cannot easily be separated from each other. On the one hand they follow an anti-literalist approach, which is highly suitable for an audience with little grasp of exegetical subtleties (and this can be seen above all in Basil's homilies), while on the other they draw on Origen's spiritualist interpretations, but in a varied way depending on the circumstances and the topics (and this is a feature of Gregory of Nyssa's exegetical homilies). Basil and Gregory of Nyssa (Gregory of Nazianzus feels this necessity less) often realize that the less cultivated people in the audience require certain expressions of the Holy Scripture to be adequately explained and presented in a simple manner. This does not mean that certain interpretations showcased in the homily were not of a remarkable refinement, which the Cappadocians used to communicate with the more intellectually elevated social classes. Their cultural level was certainly good if they were capable of understanding

[13] See J. Leemans, 'A Preacher-Audience Oriented Analysis' (2001); *id*., 'Celebrating the martyrs' (2001). On Gregory of Nazianzus' audience, also K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical Exempla* (1996), 64-5. On the educational level of Gregory of Nazianzus' audience, *ibid*. 133-5. The study by Christian Schäublin, 'Zum paganen Umfeld' (1994) focuses above all on the western homiletics, even though it touches on the novelty of the homily as such (*ibid*. 27) and its rhetorical aspects (*ibid*. 28-9). Richard Lim's observations (*Public Disputation* [1995] are obvious, according to whom the Cappadocians were not averse to dialectical subtleties, and so they could count on an audience that understood them. Lim observes (*ibid*. 138) that 'two opposing ways of life existed: the dialectician and the monk' (that is, Eunomius / the Cappadocians). The polemic between the Cappadocians and Eunomius may also contain traces of personal hostility, caused by the difference in social class (for example, see what Gregory of Nyssa has to say about Aetius and Eunomius' life in *CE* I 38-58), but it is excessive to conclude (*ibid*. 142) that their hostility was due to the 'social gulf'.

[14] J. Farrugia, HAMAPTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 248.

certain difficult doctrines and a degree of literary sophistication, wherein the preacher used poetic recollections and words – and in this regard too Gregory of Nazianzus is more refined than Basil or Gregory of Nyssa. Finally, a homily is often linked to a contingent circumstance, to which the orator makes frequent reference for didactic purposes, such as when he blames clerics prompted by worldly interests.

As an eminently oral work, the homily also manifests its form through the questions and exhortations that the preacher addresses to his listeners. This more colloquial aspect is usual in the homilies of Basil and Gregory of Nyssa, while in the homilies of Gregory of Nazianzus, who is more detached from his audience and whose homilies are more elaborate, it is rarer.

Homiletic activity is what best corresponds to the cultural and oratorical formation of Gregory of Nazianzus: Basil and Gregory of Nyssa dedicated the substance of their thoughts to their treatises and epistles, while their homiletics is almost exclusively of a moral and exegetical nature. Gregory of Nazianzus preferred homilies to treatises, and his body of work consists of forty-five orations, of which – apart from the spurious n. 35 – only one (n. 37) is of an exegetical nature, and not many of them are of a strictly moral nature. According to Bernardi,[15] the *corpus* of the forty-five orations is the result of a choice on the part of Gregory himself, who wanted to make known certain aspects of his preaching instead of others. To this end, he excluded the homilies of an exegetical nature (even if he was no less famous for these than the other Cappadocians, as Jerome's praise attests to, who had listened to him in Constantinople as a Scriptural exegete),[16] and he appears to have selected the orations that describe the perfect bishop he wanted to be considered. However,

[15] Gregory dedicated himself to the re-elaboration of the homilies and their organization in a corpus at the end of his life, during his retreat in Nazianzus, which, despite the solitude, was a period of intense cultural activity, J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 257-9: during that period Gregory appears to have also inserted the details that, when read now, contrast with the circumstances in which the oration appears to have been uttered. Therefore, Bernardi initially hypothesizes that Gregory's orations were not written only with 'sincerity': subsequent criticism (Fatti, McLynn) leads the concept of 'rhetorical re-elaboration' to its extreme consequences. On Gregory's activity in this area, see also F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 231-9; re-elaborated in this way, his orations might have served the purpose of providing the preacher with models of eloquence for the various occasions of his ministry (*ibid*. 186). This re-elaboration is interpreted (with some exaggeration) by N. McLynn, 'A Self-Made Holy Man' (1998) and F. Fatti, 'In ossequio alle leggi dell'encomio' (2004), 648-9, not in the sense that Gregory wanted to present himself as the ideal bishop, but as a 'holy man'. Gautier's opinion is acceptable, according to whom confiance and familiarity were expedients of the Second Sophistic to establish a relation between the orator and his public, F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 381.

[16] In *De viris ill*. 117, Jerome insists above all on Gregory's literary gifts and exegetical keenness: *vir eloquentissimus … et quo scripturas explanante didici*; other details in *Epist*. 50,1, 52,8 etc: this will be discussed further below (p. 325). I would not give so much importance to the fact that Gregory does never mention Jerome, as if Gregory's and Jerome's ideals of episcopacy were completely opposite, see F. Fatti, 'In ossequio alle leggi dell'encomio' (2004), 647 n. 100,

a process of evolution is evident in them, insofar as those dating from the period in Constantinople have greater theological content and are also more ornate in rhetorical terms: addressing the inhabitants of the capital, the orator had often to confront heretics, and not infrequently Arians must have been present at his homilies, as may be deduced from the frequent allusions to them. Instead, in Nazianzus, Gregory may have seen that considerations of a theological nature were perceived by his audience as being less urgent, and undoubtedly his audience was less cultivated and less informed than that in Constantinople (at the most, he destined them for the monastic circles of Cappadocia).[17] In that small city Gregory never had the chance, nor did he feel the need, to write an oration on moderation, which might be used in discussion (*Oration* 32), whereas this was necessary in Constantinople, where there were Nicenes, Pneumatomachians and followers of Eunomius; or the first of the theological orations (n. 27), which asserts that 'not to everyone does it belong to philosophise about God, and not before every audience, nor at all times, nor on all points; but on certain occasions, and before certain persons, and within certain limits'. This is a condemnation of the subtleties used in disputations and the mania for theological controversy, which were typical of the citizens of Constantinople.

Moral Intent

The homily is a didactic text *par excellence* and its teaching addresses above all moral themes in order to accompany the faithful on the Christian path: in order to accomplish this, the homilist also uses topics that have a very weak link with the scriptural text being quoted. Moral teaching is very strong in Basil and Gregory of Nyssa, while it appears weaker in Gregory of Nazianzus, whose homilies have a very different character. For this reason it may be said that Basil and Gregory of Nyssa were homilists in the true sense of the word, unlike Gregory of Nazianzus, whose homilies have a more markedly literary and personal character; furthermore, his homiletics features a far wider variety of content than that of the other Cappadocians.[18]

following an observation by Kelly: let us remember that the Greeks never mention (it might be said) the Latins, and this occurrence persists into the Christian cultural era.

[17] On the humble conditions and the provincial audience of Gregory in Cappadocia, see also F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 185.

[18] K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical Exempla* (1996), 63-4 lists: autobiographical orations, that is: apologetics, *psogoi*, eulogies and epitaphs, occasional orations, pastoral orations on feast days, eulogies for saints and martyrs, theological orations (27-31: also 32 [?]), morals (n. 14) and exegetics. Demoen's study is the widest ranging of Gregory of Nazianzus' oratory: the equivalent is lacking for Basil and Gregory of Nyssa, although some considerations are offered by J. Farrugia, HAMAPTIA *in the Homilies* (2015).

In his *Homilies on the Psalms*, Basil 'commente la parole de Dieu avec une objectivité exceptionnelle: les indices chronologiques sont donc à peine sensibles, et presque toujours discutables'.[19] They often contain colloquial moments and lively preaching. The method of explaining every verse and every word, omitting nothing, did not allow a preacher to comment on the lengthier psalms, so that the length of the biblical text influenced his choice. Furthermore, joyful psalms or those praising God are not subject to explanations. It has been attempted to find a theme linking all these homilies: according to Bernardi,[20] Basil may have chosen texts that reflected the difficulties he was facing, but this is denied by Gribomont,[21] in whose opinion Basil was responding to 'mystical' intentions, so to say:[22] he does not only deal with moral and philosophical topics, he does not demonstrate the caution and severity evident in his other ascetic works, speaking, rather, of God, Christ, and the Church. But this mystical and spiritual teaching does not rule out the fact that Basil, as the two Gregories, was sensitive to the times he lived in.

Among Basil's homilies, it is above all the so-called twenty-four *Homilies on miscellaneous subjects* that have a moral content, which were delivered on various occasions and different moments. Bernardi tends to attribute the most socially-aware homilies to Basil's priestly activity, which pave the way among the people for his election to the bishopric: this election was contested by the bishops of Cappadocia and nearby regions, as well as by the ruling class. Instead, dogmatic discussions are more frequent in homilies delivered during his episcopacy, and above all in the later ones.[23] In these homilies some details characterize the Cappadocian ambience: in it there is superstition and other practices incompatible with Christian life; children's behaviour is not beyond reproach, either at school or otherwise; parents have no interest in Christian preaching; the new-rich, superficial and vacuous, have filled the cities. Many homilies are dedicated to criticizing social customs (*De ieiunio* 1 e 2). N. 13 is an exhortation not to delay baptism, like n. 40 by Gregory of Nazianzus and another by Gregory of Nyssa (*Adversus eos qui baptismum differunt*). The habit of putting off baptism was extremely widespread, even in Caesarea; Gregory of Nazianzus' own brother, Cesarius, and his sister Gorgonia, received it at a very late stage.

The didactic thrust is strong. A detailed examination is not possible here, so only a few details will be presented. The purpose of Basil's emphasis on animal

[19] J. Gribomont, 'Notes biographiques sur S. Basile le grand' (1984), 125.

[20] J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 67, 73 etc. I shall not venture into the area of Basil's spurious homilies, some of which have more recently been re-attributed to him, see M. DelCogliano, 'Basil of Caesarea's *Homily on Psalm 115* (CPG 2910)' (2017).

[21] J. Gribomont, *Saint Basile Évangile et Église* (1984), 126.

[22] J. Gribomont, *In tomum 29 Patrologiae Graecae adnotationes* (1959).

[23] J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 61-7; this is questioned (but without a cogent reason, I feel) by Gribomont, *ibid*. 128.

characteristics was to educate a simple and rural audience: in *Hom. in Psalm* 28,6 (PG 29, 300A) Basil observes that the deer is not wounded by serpents; rather, he recovers from the viper's bite, 'as those who have observed these phenomena say'. This is so true that the deer is almost always framed in a good way in Scripture (300B) and heals anybody who notices his presence through the sense of smell (7,300C). The deer, therefore, represents the just man.[24] The goat (κριός) is cited in the psalm διὰ τὸ ἡγεμονικόν (300B), that is, because it guides all the other sheep. Or Basil explains that cedar is a type of wood that does not rot (5,293B); however it possesses one significant negative feature (293CD), because cedar also indicated Mount Lebanon, which may be interpreted as the place of idolatry (293D): both these explanations are also provided by Gregory of Nyssa (*Cant. Hom.* 7; GNO VI, 209,3-15). The unicorn is an extremely strong animal, as Job says (*Hiob* 39:10) (5,296BC); it is an animal that loves freedom and is free (296C).

People also need to be educated on what a psalm is. Using the common distinction between literal meaning and spiritual significance, Basil explains that the sacred text may be distinguished by the corporeal aspect (κατὰ τὸ σωματικόν) and the intelligible aspect (κατὰ τὸ νοητόν) (*in Psalm.* 29,1; PG 29, 306C; also in *Psalm.* 33,6; PG 29, 340B). Concretely considered, psalms were sung at the time of Solomon, while when interpreted spiritually, psalms indicated the Word of God, the Logos, and the consecration of his house, which has been decked out in a new and incredible way. Indeed, in this psalm many things are said as if it was the Lord speaking (ἐκ προσώπου τοῦ Κυρίου) (*in Psalm.* 29,1; PG 29, 308A). Perhaps that house that the psalm mentions may be the Church, which was built by Christ, as it says in 1*Tim.* 3:15. Then, the dedication of the Church consists of a 'renewal of the intellect' by means of the Holy Spirit, and thus all Christians, who form the body of Christ's Church. Divine harmony, in this case, is not what delights the ear, but what inhibits evil spirits (see also 3,312C). Basil also explains (3,308C) how the anthropomorphisms in Scripture ought to be understood (which undoubtedly was useful for an audience of ordinary people such as that in Cappadocia): men imagine God in the same way as each of them prepares their own mind (308C-309A). One must make a distinction between indignation and wrath in God (4,313AB; 6,320A). What are the four virtues? Basil defines them in accordance with Stoicism (5,316C). What is beauty (317AB)? It consists of the symmetry and harmony of one's thoughts; strength consists of the capacity to accomplish the things that are suggested by the theoretical virtues. Therefore, Basil distinguishes (317B) between θεωρητικαὶ ἀρεταί and ἀθεώρητοι ἀρεταί, which are beauty and

[24] On the deer, an animal favoured by Scripture and the Fathers on account of its positive qualities (meekness, agility, hostility to serpents), all of which lends itself to allegory, see M. Girardi, 'Il cervo in lotta col serpente' (1987); M.P. Ciccarese, *Animali simbolici* (2002).

strength. There are also types of wickedness ἀθεώρητοι, such as αἰσχρότης and ἀσθήνεια.

Because of his great interest in teaching, as well as the fact that he had been a master of rhetoric, Basil also likes to present observations of a grammatical nature: in order to explain the 'Creation', he maintains that in Scripture it often also means 'enhancement' (μετακόσμησις) and 'improvement' (βελτίωσις) (*in Psalm.* 33,6,340A). Or he explains that the term ἐκζητῆσαι is stronger than ζητῆσαι (*hom. in Psalm.* 33,3,357D); other examples of this kind could also be cited.

Homily n. 3 (*In illud: attende tibi ipsi*; PG 31, 197C-217B) comments on *Deut.* 15:9 and demonstrates Basil's philosophical culture, although not at a particularly profound level. Man is made up of his intellectual part, insofar as he has been created in the image of God; the body, instead, is part of the things that we possess. These words respond to a Platonic-based conception of reality, in which man, as such, is essentially a soul, not a body and soul together. Only man has an upright position (*status rectus*) among all the animals, since he was created to know God, a doctrine that gained widespread circulation in Christian apologetics. Similarly, the motif of the perfectibility of the human body in all its parts comes from both Stoic morality and Christian apologetics, the latter deriving from the former, and these are a testament to the presence of the perfect rationality of its creator.

In his *Homilies on the Hexaemeron*, as has already been said, Basil has to tackle even more difficult topics. The controversy with 'the learned Greeks' on account of their interpretation of the origin of the world follows the usual framework among Christians: underlining the absurdity and reciprocal opposition of the various philosophies, in order to unmask their false teaching. There was a succession of various interpretations on the part of the pagans, each of which confuted the previous one, so that there is no need to demonstrate their falseness. The sources for these homilies may be traced right back to the beginnings of Christian and Judeo-Christian speculation. In fact, with *De opificio mundi* and *Legum allegoriae*, Philo had established a mediation between Hellenism and biblical Judaism also with regard to cosmology and anthropology, and many of the themes dealt with by Basil appear in the writings of the apologists. The cursory glance that Basil gives to them was due to contingency: he was preaching at that time, not writing a scientific treatise. But there are also some demotic scientific concepts, which usually introduce and communicate an ethical meaning.[25]

[25] The presence of pagan philosophical doctrines in the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron* has been an object of research since Carl Gronau, *Poseidonios und die jüdisch-christliche Genesisexegese* (1914); since then a great deal has been written, so that it is sufficient to recall the most recent studies by J. Pepin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964); M. Naldini, Basilio di Cesarea, *Sulla Genesi* (1990) and Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009).

Gregory of Nyssa's homilies, with the exclusion of the most difficult ones, dedicated to biblical texts (*Eccl. Cant. Beat.* and *Dom. orat.*),[26] are studied far less compared to those of the other two Cappadocians: they are undoubtedly geared more for a mass audience and are not destined for men of letters, while revealing very little of the preacher himself; but they do tell us, even if indirectly, something about his audience.[27] Their strong point lies precisely in this greater simplicity. For this reason, and in order to strike his audience, Gregory of Nyssa describes in concrete and dramatic tones the various sins and perverse effects that they produce on the individual and on society.[28] He frequently warns of the danger of the passions and tries to clarify the way in which they insinuate themselves into the human soul:

> Each of the passions in us, when it takes control, becomes master of the person enslaved, and like an oppressive tyrant, having seized the citadel of the soul, it uses our own subordinates to maltreat its victim, employing our own mental processes as agents for its purpose. So anger, so fear, cowardice, insolence, the sensations of pain and pleasure, hatred, contentiousness, pitiless unkindness, malice, flattery, grudges and insensitivity, and all the passions in us which are reckoned negative, make up a list of tyrants and masters who to win power reduce the soul to slavery like a captive of war (*Beat* III, 106, 7-18) (trans. Farrugia, 104).

The damage to humankind from the passions was introduced to human nature by Adam and Eve and the passions are inherited by humanity, passing from one generation to the next:

> At the outset it is from passion we get our origin, with passion our growth proceeds, and into passion our life declines; evil is mixed up with our nature through those who from the first allowed passion in, those who by disobedience gave house-room to the

[26] The importance of these homilies for understanding Gregory of Nyssa's mystical and theological thought is well known. As far as the *Homilies on the Song of Songs* are concerned, recently on the Trinitarian theology in its connection with *epektasis* see V.H. Drecoll, 'Spuren von Trinitätstheologie' (2018); on pneumatology see G. Maspero, 'The *In Canticum* in Gregory's Theology: Introduction and *Gliederung*' (2018); on Christology M. Brugarolas, 'The Incarnate Logos' (2018). Sarah Coakley, 'Gregory of Nyssas on Spiritual Ascent' (2018) maintains that in the *Homilies on the Song of Songs* Gregory of Nyssa presents a new conception of his 'theology', which contrasts with the 'trinitarian' one from his 'apologetics' period (that is, the period of *Contra Eunomium*), and that therefore the different conception of the Trinity that Drecoll found in these homilies is without foundation. In my opinion, without taking into account Drecoll's interpretation, the 'theology' in the *Homilies on the Song of Songs* is not in fact a 'new' theology, just as the doctrine of *epektasis*, which ever since the time of Daniélou had been found above all in these homilies, is no different to the Trinitarian theology. Nor are the 'gender' issues, which Coakley finds here, of any particular significance. In order to explain this new metaphorization, as well as the use of imagery, I would tend to underline the difference between homily and treatise.

[27] An attempt to describe Gregory of Nyssa's homiletics was made by A.A. Mosshammer, 'Gregory of Nyssa as Homilist' (1999), in which he outlines Gregory's 'experience as preacher and pastor'.

[28] See J. Farrugia, HAMARTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 250-93.

disease. Just as with each kind of animal the species continues along with the succession of the new generation, so that what is born is, following a natural design the same as those from which it is born, so from man man is generated, from passionate passionate, from the sinful its like. Thus, in a sense sin arises together with those who come into existence, brought to birth with them, growing with them, and at life's end ceasing with them (*Beat Hom.* VI, 145,1-13) (trans. Farrugia, *ibid.*).

Other examples of this kind, which describe the passions in a rhetorical manner, are frequent in *Homilies on Beatitudes*, which are aimed more at the masses than other homilies of an exegetic nature.[29]

Gregory illustrates the damage man does to himself when he does not resist becoming a slave to the passions. Uncontrolled passions (Gregory ascribes to the doctrine that the passions, which are not guilty in themselves, have to be directed to a good end)[30] damage the soul, estranging it from God. Since God is devoid of passions, a creature in thrall to them cannot unite with Him. Passions torment humankind and are increased through pleasure; this way humanity worsens its condition on account of a succession of wrong decisions and choices. God wanted the tunics of skin with which our first parents clothed themselves after sinning (*Gen.* 3:21) to stave off passions: instead, in yielding to the passions, humankind substituted those God-given tunics with the vices of lust and conceit, and sought after honours that pass and the satisfactions of the flesh (*Or. Dom.* V; GNO VII/II, 65,2-10).[31] Having defected from God and received these woes in punishment, the state of sinful humanity is pitiful. In several homilies the bishop takes the opportunity to describe the state of the sinner in order to exhort his listeners to seriously consider renouncing their sinful ways. Sin makes man a slave to his own impulses, a prisoner of his own desires and this leads Gregory to remind his flock that man has been created from dust and that he has no reason to boast about himself. Sinners are like weak persons who are drawn by a torrent of mud; they are no better than prisoners, debtors and slaves, because sin has subdued human nature since its power was always on the increase from the time when it was introduced in creation.

In the homily *In diem luminum* (GNO IX, 224,11-2), Gregory describes a man who has grown old in a state of sin and bad habits, which have left a mark on him. Because of his weakness, the man grew accustomed to sin, and now it seems impossible to him to get free of it (*In diem natalem*; GNO X/II, 244,6-9). The sinner has closed his ears to the announcement of redemption, just like the Jews closed their ears so they wouldn't hear the martyrdom of Stephen.[32]

[29] *Ibid.* 106-10.

[30] See also p. 185.

[31] Note the different interpretation of the tunics of skin, which in his treatises Gregory of Nyssa defines in a more Origen-like manner as an inclination to evil.

[32] *Ibid.* 91.

There are two types of sin: those involving an action and those involving a thought, because not all sins are caused by the body, even though they are carried out by means of the same (*Beat. Hom.*; GNO VII/II 5 125,8-16). The body is not just the means by which the soul commits a sin, but actually the origin and cause of it, because it produces a passion and a disturbance of the mind (*Sanct. Pasch.*; GNO IX, 267,10-3, 24-5).[33]

The terrible description of Satan and his followers (*Steph.*; GNO X/I, I 76,1-2; *Beat.* VII; GNO VII/II, 148,5; *Cant.* II; GNO VI, 55,14; *Cant.* VII; GNO 243,21; *Cant.* VIII; GNO 255,23) is a theme that may startle an ordinary audience (and which became widespread in monastic literature, but is missing in Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus). Satan, or one of his acolytes, is to be found everywhere: in temples, in people, in public bath houses. He is the enemy *par excellence* of all those who want to live virtuously, and has been called in various ways: enemy, adversary, thief of souls, liar and father of lies, Beelzebub, Mammon.[34] The devil sinned in the beginning because of his pride, with the result that he lost the glory that God had gifted him (*Beat.* VIII; GNO VII/II, 322-5). He is, however, one of God's creatures; in fact, he was the first rational creature to have free will, but he used it to do evil, so that he became the author of evil for the whole universe. One of the means he uses to confound humanity is to drive it mad and make it disbelieve in the final resurrection:

> If there is no resurrection and death is the limit of life, then ignore my accusations and blames, give the murderer unhindered power, send forth the adulterer in freedom to plot against marriage, let the arrogant run riot against others, let no one censor the abuser, let the perjured swear continuously, for death awaits even the man who keeps his word, let another person cheat by lies as much as he wants, for truth brings forth no fruit, let no one have pity on the poor, for compassion is without pay. These thoughts create a confusion that is worse than the deluge and cast out all sensible thoughts, provoking thoughts of madness and plunder. If in fact there is no resurrection, there neither is judgement, if judgement is abolished, fear of God is cast out with it. And wherever fear does not chasten, there the devil dances around with sin (*Sanct. Pasch.*; GNO IX, 265, 1-14) (trans. Farrugia).

Other aspects of Gregory of Nyssa's preaching have been described by Farrugia: the imagery of evil and sin[35] and the characteristics of the various vices[36] mean that his homilies appeal to the masses.

In Gregory of Nyssa too the didactic aim is strong.[37] Like Basil, Gregory maintains that one must not neglect elements even of grammar and linguistics,

[33] *Ibid.* 92.
[34] *Ibid.* 126-34.
[35] *Ibid.* 134.
[36] *Ibid.* 250-98.
[37] In the homilies on the *Song of Songs*, Gregory provides richer details than Origen, according to Dünzl, Gregor von Nyssa, *In Canticum Canticorum Homiliae* (1994), 54. This is due, as I

in order not to lose sight of the real significance of the text. For instance: on occasion he extends an invitation to those who are listening to him, so that they can properly understand the biblical verse that he is commenting on: 'Let none of the listeners judge the distinction between *what has been* and *what has been done* as verbosity and pointless repetition' (*Eccl. Hom.*; GNO V, 296,4).

Or else he feels that it is necessary to inform his audience of the latest scientific novelties. Let us look at a few examples of the homilies on the *Song of Songs*. To demonstrate that the aspiration to virginity is innate in all living beings, he notes (*Cant. hom.* IV; GNO VI, 111,7-12) that, because of a necessity of nature, the heron hates mating, and for this reason it is a symbol of purity. The dove's (III, 79,1-4) behaviour is similar, as Origen had already said (*Comm. Cant.* II,155,16-20).[38] The roe deer (V, 143,6-11) destroys fierce wild beasts and makes serpents flee with its breath and the absolutely unique appearance of its skin: this information is also in Pliny the Elder (*NH* VIII 118). For this reason, the Logos has been compared to a fawn, insofar as it tramples and destroys the pride of its enemies. The bee (according to *Prov.* 6:8ac) is a symbol of Wisdom: whoever wishes to learn wisdom has to take lessons from the bee (*Cant. hom.* IX, 269,1-10). On the basis of *Cant.* 2:8 ('behold, he cometh leaping upon the mountains, skipping upon the hills'), Gregory of Nyssa compares (certainly, arbitrarily) this 'skipping' on the part of the Bridegroom to the behaviour of the gazelle (δορκάς). And since the gazelle has sharp eyes, as its name shows, which derives from the verb δέρκομαι, so too does the Logos see (θεάομαι) everything, and so it is θεός (V, 141,5-15):[39] indeed, the divine Bridegroom is the Logos.

The references to plants and flowers have a similar didactic function: the cypress and the cedar (IV, 109,7; 111,10-2); the lily (114,3-9); the apple tree (116,3-13): all these trees contain the 'mystery' of purity. The pomegranate, with such a hard, acidic peel, but then pleasing to the taste (VII, 230,10-7), symbolises the virtues of continence, as Gregory repeats in the coeval *De vita Moysis* (II, 192-3). The experts have discussed at length the virtues of other plants. *Cant.* 4:14 lists all the scented trees that may represent the bride's scent. The symbolic meaning of the crocus (IX, 284,16-285,14) is presented by Gregory

have said, to the fact that the literary genres are different: Gregory delivered homilies in a spoken style, while Origen elaborates a comment that is far removed from it.

[38] See Baehrens' annotations, *ad locum*; Langerbeck also adds Arist., *Hist. anim.* 613a14: 'the dove and the wood pigeon always have the same male, and they do not allow any other male to come near them'.

[39] As is known, this is an essential doctrine for Gregory's concept of the Trinity, as well as for his attempt to explain the name 'God', which can be applied to each divine Person. So, therefore, a name of this kind, not a proper name, see also *Ad Ablabium* (GNO III/I, 44,10-6 etc.); G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 4-56. But it is obvious that the rapid glance contained in the homily is brief and simple, while Gregory of Nyssa had dedicated a good part of his theological treatises to this example.

of Nyssa in a non-categorical way, thus leaving his audience to choose whether to accept it or not. Since it has three stamens that are joined together, the crocus flower may be taken as a symbol of the Trinity. Cinnamon 'surpasses (it is said) all the other plants in terms of its scent, to the extent that the Law uses it to indicate the scent of priesthood' (*Exod*. 30:23) (IX, 286,1-2). Cinnamon has numerous and incredible effects (a longer citation gives a clearer idea of Gregory's teaching in this regard) (IX, 286,2-15).

Finally, there is also information about science. In this case too Gregory bases himself on what the experts on the human body have to say (IV, 105,11-6; VII, 218,17) to teach how the vision of things comes into being in the eye. Painting is also a science (I, 28,7: κατὰ τὴν γραφικὴν ἐπιστήμην), which teaches how the various colours have to be mixed in order to achieve a portrait: in it the colours are no longer clearly separable, but rather come together to produce an image.

The noblest science, logically, is medicine, which had already had a function in the previous *Homilies on Ecclesiastes*. As Françoise Vinel has observed, philosophical and medical knowledge were considered to be similar and to be connected.[40] Some philosophical currents (for instance, Stoicism) use the analogy with medicine in order to explore the relationship between body and soul and define the illnesses of the soul in parallel to the illnesses of the body.[41] The *Homilies on Ecclesiastes* also show that Gregory knows medicine (for example *Eccl. Hom.* VI 7: 'the doctors say that…'); in the *Homilies on The Song of Songs* science and medicine explain the heart and its function (III, 94,12); the neck, the trachea, bones and the shoulder (VII, 233-5).

Oration 14 (*De pauperibus amandis*)[42] by Gregory Nazianzen has a strong ethical thrust, which was to become one of his most famous (Jerome also recalls it, *Vir. ill.* 117). It is extremely long (it takes ninety minutes to deliver, according to calculations), so that (and as with others) it is unlikely to correspond

[40] See Grégoire de Nysse, *Homélies sur l'Ecclésiaste* (1996), 43-4.

[41] The frequency of the examples gathered from medicine, observes Vinel, suggests the hypothesis that Gregory had been instructed in this discipline. M. Aubineau, Grégoire de Nysse, *De la virginité* (1966), 47 even talks of Gregory's practical education in medicine. In my view, these examples are not sufficient to confirm the hypothesis of a medical background, because they are more hearsay than anything else, and unfounded. The parallelism between the illnesses of the soul and those of the body can also be found in Basil's *Regulae* (see above, p. 32-3).

[42] According to Gregory of Nazianzus' Byzantine commentator, Basilius Minimus, this homily may be connected with the construction, brought about by Basil, of the so-called Basiliade in Caesarea; so it appears to have been delivered in 373 (*Orat*. 43,63). Nevertheless, the description that Gregory gives of the lepers contains no allusion to any building that could house them subsequently. The chronological collocation is also rejected by B.J. Matz, 'Deciphering a Recipe' (2012), 50-1. According to Matz, the homily instead focuses on the fact that love for the poor represents the road to Christian perfection, so much so that Gregory insists on speaking about Christian virtues. Bernardi thus brings forward the dating to about 368-369 (*La prédication* [1968], 104-6). See also J. McGuckin, *St Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 147-9.

to the actual oral redaction. This re-elaboration is also borne out by the extensive use made of biblical citations and allusions (154 in all), which Gregory uses to underline his line of thought, to the extent that he is almost hidden behind such a display of citations. This oration unites the praise of charity and a dramatic description, permeated with all the pathos of which Gregory was capable, of the conditions in which the lepers, rejected by everyone, found themselves.[43] The topics in this homily are also used by Gregory in the poem *Adversus opum amantes* (I, 2,18; PG 37, 856-84) and by Basil in the *Homilia dicta tempore famis et siccitatis* (PG 31, 304D-328C), on the occasion of the same calamity, and it is no less rhetorically charged than Gregory's.

Gregory of Nyssa also preached in favour of the poor in his homilies *In illud quatenus uni ex his fecistis* (GNO IX, 111-27) and *De beneficentia* (GNO IX, 93-108). Unlike in Gregory of Nazianzus, the style of Gregory of Nyssa's homilies is simple, indeed, even stylistically poor. There are also topics such as the recommendation to fast and the imitation of God: God is the model for every beneficial activity. Finally, the reproof made to the rich for the exhibition of their wealth and their ignorance of the duties that fall to them, among which is that of helping the poor, is not new. But overall these two orations by Gregory of Nyssa are far colder and less close to reality than those by Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus on the same topic.[44]

Twenty-one homilies by Amphilochus have reached us, but some of these are spurious.[45] In them the theological part is weak and dealt with in a cursory way, except in the tenth homily, which I shall look at later. They contain dialogues, monologues and apostrophes,[46] and they feature a colloquial style that often contains an address to a heretic or another important person: these addresses are far more frequent in Amphilochius than in the other Cappadocians. Take, for instance, the second homily, where there is a great abundance of rhetorical colour, but, overall, it comes across as naive and superficial. It contains enthusiastic praise for virginity and marriage, and underlines the figure of Christ the physician. The exegesis is simple, with basic interpretations of Jewish words: for example, the Hebrew Ἄννα means 'the fame of a person's

[43] The description has an obvious purpose: that of forcing the Christians to contribute with generous offerings to the maintenance of the poor, see B.J. Matz, 'Deciphering a Recipe' (2012), 59.

[44] The two homilies by Gregory Nyssen and Gregory Nazianzen (n. 14) and that by Basil (nn. 6, 7, 8) on the topic of the poor are considered by Daley to be contemporaneous (despite this dating conflicting with what is commonly accepted for the works of Gregory of Nyssa), and characterized by a very precise charity programme, that of the founding of the Basiliade, B.E. Daley, 'Building a New City' (1999).

[45] With regard to the problem of the authenticity of these homilies, see A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 52-9. I shall only be considering the authentic homilies, in the edition by M. Bonnet and S. Voicu, Amphiloque d'Ikonium, *Homélies* (2012); *Homélies (6-10). Fragments. Lettres* (2012).

[46] A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 188 n. 363, 190 n. 366, 191 n. 370.

ways'. In conclusion, moral interests in Amphilochius' homilies outweigh the ascetic ones: weddings and virginity, second marriage, penitence. All this manifests the attitude of one who, in his life, had fought against the Encratites and other similar sects.

Hagiographic Intent

Orations in honour of the martyrs often have the characteristics of a panegyric and 'may be placed halfway between the ancient authentic *acts* and the Medieval *passions*: of the former they conserve the basic historical truthfulness, while of the latter they foreshadow the themes of praise and the element of rhetorical amplification of the virtues of the holy man, to the point that they were then perceived as models of their kind'.[47] The deceased, even though he is not a martyr, is nevertheless a particularly deserving person. Basil's hagiographic homilies are all dedicated to local saints: *In martyrem Iulittam* (n. 5),[48] *In Gordium* (n. 18), *In S. Mamantem* (n. 23), *In quadraginta martyres* (n. 19). Nevertheless, shortly after having praised the martyr and evoked his life and death (usually in a very generic way, because he may not have known greater details regarding the saints he was speaking about) Basil embarkes on various considerations of a moral nature: for instance, in the homily in honour of the martyr Gordius, Basil recommends a brave attitude in order to oppose both death threats and flattery.

In his homilies on the martyrs, Gregory of Nyssa also underlines courage by drawing on a military lexis. But the pedagogical intent is even more evident than in Basil: Gregory wants to show that it is possible for humankind to detach itself from evil, despite its fallen nature. Since most celebrated martyrs were soldiers, the use of a warriorlike lexis is normal, and they are represented as waging war on evil. This type of language is also used for the homilies on St Stephen, who, despite not being a real martyr, was in any case a defender of faith. In these homilies Gregory Nyssen maintains that the evil the saints fought was, basically, the same that made Adam and Eve perish; but, while they yielded, the martyrs succeeded in triumphing (*Steph.*; GNO X/I, 1,76,13-7).[49]

Theological Problems

Theological orations by Basil and Gregory of Nyssa are, unlike those of Gregory Nazianzen, brief: evidently, Basil was not keen on discussing theology with

[47] M. Girardi, in Basilio di Cesarea, *I martiri* (1999), 18.

[48] According to J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 79-80, praise for the martyr may perhaps have the intent to exhort people to stand firm, in an era of persecution such as that under the Arian emperor Valens. I feel that Gribomont is right to doubt this.

[49] J. Farrugia, HAMARTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 88.

the people of Caesarea,[50] who were probably not in a position to understand it. He outlines Trinitarian problems in a simple manner, that is, without having recourse to the theological formulation discussed by him in the treatises. Nevertheless, the few homilies of a theological nature by Basil explain, even if in a colloquial tone, important topics, which I will consider with regard to Trinitarian theology. *Homily* n. 15 *De fide* (PG 31, 676-92) is a profession of faith meant for the Arians present in his audience and it is dedicated above all to the divinity of the Holy Spirit. Addressing an audience that was not learned, Basil outlines the important issues by thinking that everyone believes in the Trinity of the divine persons, and underlines the absolute incomprehensibility of God by having recourse, in the first chapter, to so-called negative theology. But it is an extremely simple negative theology, in accordance with what was required by the non-elevated tone of the homily as educational oration for ordinary people. The same may be said of *Homily* n. 16 (*In illud: In principio erat Verbum*; PG 31, 472-81) and the longer *Contra Sabellianos, et Arium, et Anomaeos* (n. 24; PG 31, 600-17), which dates from the final years of Basil's preaching: at that moment, in fact, the Arian danger became less serious and Basil thought that a pacification might be possible.

Scholars in the 19th and 20th centuries usually judged Gregory of Nazianzus' theological homilies critically because they considered Gregory to be more a rhetorician than a thinker; but it is clear that speaking rhetorically does not imply, in itself, insufficient speculative abilities, merely a different framework of thought, organized in oratorical forms rather than in the form of a treatise.[51] Consequently, Gregory's theological doctrines, to which I shall turn in chapter four, clash with the commonly accepted definition of Gregory as a superficial and showy rhetorician.

An example of the union of theological and rhetorical ability is to be found in the so-called 'Theological Orations' (nn. 27-31). In some parts Gregory speaks 'in the manner' of the cynical diatribe, outlining his doctrine through a question-and-answer format. Basil also uses this style in his homilies, but almost exclusively for moral issues, while Gregory Nazianzen uses it for a tougher topic, that is, Trinitarian theology. At times, Gregory attempts an all-out imitation of Plato's dialogues in *Oration* n. 27.[52] Gregory wishes to satirize the society of Constantinople and criticize those people, ignorant and superficial but numerous, who debated Trinitarian problems while watching the circus or during

[50] This is what R.M. Hübner rightly maintains, *Die Schrift des Apolinarius von Laodicea* (1989), 2. In fact, Basil was not a systematic theologian, according to Hübner.

[51] These critical judgements, according to which rhetoric cannot be mixed with thought (and even less so with theological thought) have been challenged by Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997) and J. McGuckin, *St Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001).

[52] This also occurs in some sections of *Oration* 2 (see, for instance 2,50), of *Oration* 36, and also others.

banquets. The criticism is not unfounded, because the motif may also be found in many writings by Athanasius and in the homily, similar in content, by Gregory of Nyssa (*De deitate Filii et Spiritus sancti et in Abraham*; GNO X/2, 1996). But if we compare Nazianzen's 'theological orations' to works with similar content, such as those by Athanasius, not only does the literary elaboration place Gregory clearly at a higher level, but it also shows that his theological speculation was not inferior. Gregory rarely inserts Trinitarian formulae, only two or three times, into his theological homilies, such as, for instance, what is considered to be the typical formula of the Cappadocians ('one substance, three hypostases'); rather, he uses more or less brief sections of a catechetical nature to outline his doctrine (for example, *Orat*. 25,15-8).[53] Compared with Gregory Nazianzen's *Theological orations*, those by Gregory Nyssen on the same topics appear to be rather mediocre, for example, the afore-mentioned *De deitate Filii et Spiritus sancti*, which is a polemic against the Arians and the Pneumatomachians.[54]

Homiletics and Mysticism

Instead, what is more frequent in Gregory Nyssen's homiletics is the ethical and mystical nature of his exhortations: this is so above all in his most elaborate homilies, such as those on *Qohelet* and the *Song of Songs*. In any case, the structure and method is that of the homily, and different to a treatise: the treatises are meant for people of expertise, of whom there are unlikely to have been many, while the homily is destined for a more mixed kind of audience of the non-learned or even ignorant.[55] Gregory instructs the people about some of the most important themes in his thought, but the form retains its oral set up and lacks an objective tone. An example of this is the discussion on Christology, which is outlined without falling into arguments or controversies with the heretics, unlike, for example what occurs in the treatises such as *Contra Eunomium* and *Antirrheticus* against Apollinaris. In *Cant. hom*. IV (GNO VI, 108,1-4)

[53] This also occurs in *Orat*. 42,16, as will be seen.

[54] A general study of Gregory Nyssen's homiletics, after Bernardi's *La prédication* (1968) is the cited one by J. Farrugia, HAMAPTIA *in the Homilies* (2015); A.A. Mosshammer, 'Gregory of Nyssa as Homilist' (1999) examines only a few homilies by Gregory.

[55] Instead, according to Canévet we are dealing here with the theologizing of the spiritual motifs in the *Song of Songs*, M. Canévet, 'Exégèse et théologie dans les traités spirituelles' (1971). This interpretation by Canévet inevitably means reducing the homilies to a remarkable abstractness, as Dünzl, Gregor von Nyssa, *In Canticum Canticorum Homiliae* (1994), 60 rightly observes. According to Canévet, it frequently occurs that a verse from the *Song of Songs* is the pretext for theological instruction – yes, but what kind of teaching? Of a scientific nature or homiletic? The homiletic aspect of these explanations is also pointed out by M. Laird, 'Under Solomon's tutelage' (2003), 80. Nevertheless, Laird maintains that the first homily has its own particular characteristic, because it has a function that is closer to an actual commentary.

Gregory interprets the words of *Cant*. 1,16 'our bed is green' in the sense that, metaphorically, the bed means the physical 'mixing' of human nature with the divine being, just as in the material bed the physical union takes place between man and woman.[56] The term 'mixing' (κρᾶσις) is used almost constantly in *Contra Eunomium* to indicate Christ's incarnation, that is, the union of human nature with the divine nature.[57] Perfect illumination takes place thanks to the mixing (συνανάκρασις) of light itself with our nature (*ibid*. V; GNO VI, 145,6-9), when the real light shines on those sitting in the darkness and shadow of death. 'The home', into which the bride wants to bring the bridegroom (*Cant*. 5:4-5) represents human life, while the bridegroom's hand (*Cant*. 1:4) symbolizes the creating hand of the universe which has stopped in the house, shrinking down to the small and humble reality of our lives. For this reason, one wonders how it was that God appeared in the flesh, how it was that the Logos became flesh, how there could have been a birth in a state of virginity and a state of virginity in the mother, how light united (καταμίγνυται) with the darkness and life mixed (κατακίρναται) with death (XI; GNO VI, 338,2-12). A Christological definition typical of Gregory Nyssen (τὸ θεοδόχον σῶμα, 'the body [of the virgin] that received God into itself') is also present twice (XIII; GNO VI, 388,22 and 391,2).[58] Another aspect of this homiletic-spiritual approach is the fact that Mariology, which is not frequent in Nyssen's theological treatises, is dealt with more extensively in these homilies, where Gregory brings the focus back to the Eve-Mary symbolism (XIII; GNO VI, 388,19-390,8).

Neither was Amphilochius interested in homilies of a doctrinal nature; those of a moral or liturgical bent do not discuss theological issues, they mention no heresies and they are devoid of technical terms (not even 'consubstantial'). His interests revolve around the incarnated Christ, whose human circumstances he evokes movingly, but without providing doctrinal support, which however drew in the other Cappadocians.

Liturgical Occasions

Alongside the *Orations* 38-40 by Gregory Nazianzen (*In Theophaniam, In sancta lumina, In baptismum*), three sermons *on Easter* were delivered by Gregory of Nyssa, according to Daniélou and Bernardi's dating in 379, in 382 and in 388 (GNO IX, 245-70; 309-11). The importance of the feast prompted Gregory Nyssen to make some observations of a doctrinal nature, not unlike what Gregory

[56] Also V (GNO VI, 180,9): the bridal bed indicates the union of the Logos with the human body.

[57] More at p. 286-7.

[58] Also in *Catech*. 32 (GNO III/IV, 78,9: θεοδόχος ἄνθρωπος) and 37 (GNO III/IV, 97,16: θεοδόχος σάρξ).

Nazianzen does. In the first sermon Gregory Nyssen examines the problem of the resurrection of the body and, as an adversary of the Docetists, he sees this manifested precisely in the resurrection of Christ. In the second he tackles the meaning of the three days that passed between the Passion and the Resurrection and he discusses how Christ might have managed to be contemporaneously in the netherworld and in heaven, at the Father's right hand together with the good thief; why the Christian Easter does not coincide with the Jewish Passover; why Christ had to die on the cross; and what the meaning of Joseph of Arimathea's act of pity was. Gregory Nyssen also wrote a homily on Ascension (GNO IX, 323-7), which according to Daniélou is very likely the most ancient celebration of this feast,[59] and one on Pentecost (GNO X/II, 281-92), which picks up, in regard to the divinity of the Holy Spirit, Gregory Nazianzen's reasoning again on the progressive revelation of Christian truth: *Psalm* 94 represents, in his opinion, a precedent of the doctrine of the Spirit.

Liturgical homilies were also written by Amphilochius of Iconium – indeed, they seem to have been the preacher's principal topic. Amphilochius' interest in liturgical celebrations has been studied by Karl Holl,[60] who has highlighted how Amphilochius also celebrated Christ's birth on 25th December, and that (like Gregory Nyssen) he already knew of the feast of St Stephen the protomartyr.[61]

Biographical and Personal Intent

A biographical slant is typical of Gregory Nazianzen's homilies, and it is as important for him as his theological and moral interests.[62] For this reason his oratorical output cannot be considered 'homiletic' in the traditional sense and differentiates itself from Basil's and Gregory Nyssen's moral type, as well as from Origen's, which is dedicated almost exclusively to biblical exegesis. When he speaks to his audience, Gregory Nazianzen often lets it know his own interpretation of whatever events have befallen him. The issue regarding Maximus, for instance, would most likely not have been considered, by Basil and Gregory Nyssen, as a topic suitable for a homily. Instead, the orations dedicated to a person that Gregory has had dealings with, or a situation in which he wound up finding himself, are plentiful. The manuscript tradition has given these homilies an unusual title, but not arbitrary, since it is based on an accurate reading of the text: 'To himself' (εἰς ἑαυτόν).

[59] A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 340 n. 307, however, asserts the opposite.
[60] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 58-83 and 104-15.
[61] *Ibid.* 107-11.
[62] It will be necessary, at least shortly, to return to the biographical aspects, which are definitely evident, in Gregory Nazianzen's homilies.

Homily 10 represents an example of this kind of approach, in which he wishes to make it known in an indirect way[63] the extent to which his family members, indeed his friends (Basil first of all) and his fellow citizens have offended him by expecting him to be consecrated bishop of Sasima. Gregory regrets the 'violence' and the 'tyranny' he has had to suffer at the hands of those he loved most, that is, his father and Basil, and to whom, precisely for this reason (he reflects, pleased with the clash of his affections), as well as for the obedience due to those with greater authority than him, he could not refuse his assent.[64]

In *Oration* 26, delivered after the sad conclusion of the misplaced trust in Maximus, Gregory initially condemns his mistake and defends himself.[65] This, indeed, is one of his most personal orations. *Oration* 33 is also remarkable, which is similar in structure, but is constructed in the form of antitheses because it juxtaposes himself and the faithful against the Arians, whom Gregory takes to task for their violence and assaults; using a strongly sarcastic tone, he then blames himself and the faithful for the violence of the heretics. The injustices he displayed to the Arians consist in being poor, humble, and weak, while his enemies, the Arians, are dazzling and powerful. This justifies, in fact, the title given to this oration, 'To himself': he admits the humbleness of his background (a *topos* used with irony, because in fact Gregory came from a wealthy noble family, but here, insofar as he is a provincial, he juxtaposes himself against the proud inhabitant of the capital city), his situation as a foreigner (Chap. 8),[66] his unfulfilled wish for solitude, and the tyranny experienced (Chap. 9).

The last oration 'to himself' (n. 36) has a longer title: 'To himself, and against those who said that he aspired to the see of Constantinople'. Here too, as the form of the title shows, the part effectively dedicated to himself is the first. Gregory uses the fact that the enthroning ceremony on the see of Constantinople, which took place in November 380, despite being wanted by the emperor Theodosius, was the consequence of public demand and certainly not due to his intrigue or ambition. But Gregory traces this public demand, the political significance of which is clear, to the efficacy of his *logoi*. The *logoi*, and nothing else, he claims, led to the public's enthusiasm, and certainly

[63] The ambiguity, which takes the form of hinting and not explicitly stating, is a form of Sophistry.

[64] This homily was delivered on the occasion of a saint's feast day, at which Gregory of Nyssa was also present; Gregory of Nazianzus attempts to bring him over to his side after the clash he had with Basil, see N. McLynn, 'The Two Gregories. Towards Nyssen from Nazianzen' (2018), 36-8.

[65] Fatti maintains that the issue of Maximus was extensively elaborated by Gregory subsequently, after his retreat to Nazianzus, 'In ossequio alle leggi dell'encomio' (2004), 655-7. In general, it seems to me that this critical tendency is excessive in underlining this rhetorical re-elaboration.

[66] Also in *Orat*. 26,4 ('I, the cowardly and over-cautious shepherd, accused of being slack because I have tried to be safe!') (trans. B. Daley) and *Orat*. 36,6-7.

not the external qualities of his person, which in him do not exist: and so, (how sincerely?) he repeats, with a level of irony comparable to that found in *Oration* 33, the negative considerations that regard his own person. Therefore, Gregory passes on to the second topic of his oration, that of never having aspired to the see of Constantinople. The problem is framed on the level of personal relationships between the bishop and his flock, and introduces a lengthy yet lively dialogue with his critics, in which Gregory can defend himself and speak about himself.[67]

This approach is also present in other homilies of his, dedicated to his self-defence. The most famous is the second, which in fact bears the title *Apologia*, as can be read in Rufinus' translation into Latin, or, in full: *In Defence of his Flight to Pontus and His Return, After His Ordination to the Priesthood*, alongside that *On Priesthood* and other similar ones. Gregory had to justify his abandonment of his priestly duties, which is what he was guilty of doing when he followed his desire for asceticism, fleeing from Nazianzus and taking refuge in the solitude of Pontus with Basil. It opens with an ironic tone: 'I have been beaten and I acknowledge my defeat; I have been subdued by the Lord and I implored Him' (ch. 1), concluding: 'Here is the justification for my flight, a justification that perhaps has overstepped the mark' (ch. 102). This oration is extremely long, indeed at time heavy-going; basically, it is a treatise, as well as being verbose, which is a consequence of the subsequent re-elaboration. Here too Gregory manifests his personal motives: the desire to withdraw from the world, described in the Platonic manner (ch. 6-7), his love of philosophy and, unusually for a public oration, his feelings:[68]

> My second thought (which motivated my return) and my task are constituted by the grey hairs and weakness of my sainted parents, who suffer more because of me than the passing of time. I speak of the patriarch Abraham, present here, a most precious person for me, whom I include among the angels; I speak of Sarah, she who gives birth to us spiritually into the teaching of the faith. I had wished to be a rock for them in their old-age and a support for their weakness, first of all, and, in any case, I had achieved what I had set out to do proportionate to my strength, even at the expense of philosophy, the most precious of possessions and titles to me (ch. 103).

[67] L. Lugaresi, 'Studenti cristiani' (2004), 814-20 maintains that, for Gregory, the *logoi* were not as important as he would have us believe, insofar as Gregory, like Basil, appears to give greater importance to action. In point of fact, the one thing does not exclude the other.

[68] Gautier also examines orations 1, 2 and 3, highlighting their biographical aspects, F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 220-7. It should be remembered that the intent of self-defence, which is found in the poem *De vita sua* and other poems written after the conclusion of the council in Constantinople, is for the purpose of criticizing, despite never mentioning him, Nectarius, who had succeeded Gregory, and Maximus, who had not desisted in his hostility to Gregory, J. McGuckin, 'Autobiography as Apologia' (2001), 169-76; B. Storin, 'In a silent way' (2011), 255-6. Gregory wrote his polemical poems against the bishops for his self-defence after his resignation from the Council: *ibid*. 253-7.

In *Oration* 9 Gregory has to justify himself for having placed too many delays and doubts between himself and taking possession of the detested bishopric of Sasima, and he turns to his father and Basil, who were present at the oration and are the two 'tyrants':

> Teach me this art of guiding my flock, O friends; indeed, from now on, pastors for me and companions in my pastoral activities. Give me the distinguishing marks of this art, you who are our common father, and who with your great age have prepared many pastors, placing one after the other in succession; and it is also you who tests and judges my philosophy… You, who was more human among the sheep (if you will allow me to say so), when we used to take part in the irrational meadow, than among the shepherds, when we were held to be worthy of the spiritual meadow. You have what you wanted: our subjugation; and you have defeated the invincible (ch. 4).[69]

The biographical aspect is present even in the theological and liturgical orations, as well as (*pour cause*) in Basil's epitaph: as he had been his friend, Gregory can justify his past life and mistakes (which, in his opinion were not errors), confirming the legitimacy of his own behaviour. It is generally thought that Gregory only wished to celebrate his friend, but not all the passages in which Gregory defends himself and criticizes Basil have been taken into account.

This 'personal' aspect of Gregory's homilies was underlined by previous scholarship (Paul Gallay and Claudio Moreschini), but it has been re-examined and critiqued by more recent scholars: it is thought, in fact, that what Gregory says about himself does not necessarily derive from 'sincerity', but rather is the result of a clever construction of his own figure, destined for a reading public that was supposed to see in him the perfect bishop (as McLynn thinks) or the ascetic bishop (as Gautier thinks). However, this does not mean that 'sincerity' is fake. The choice of themes to be dealt with is entirely personal.

Funeral Orations

Funeral orations were normally composed according to a canonical framework from the rhetorical treatises. They were comprised of an introduction, which specified the occasion in which they were being given; then came the eulogy for the deceased person, whose antecedents were praised (if they had been famous) as well as the parents; and finally, the eulogy of the person (him- or herself), their body, intelligence, morality (manners, behaviour, actions); the story went up as far as the death of the person being celebrated, at which point the orator ideally addressed the deceased person, and in a concrete manner, with exhortations and advice, the surviving company; at the end came the

[69] For an examination of *Orations* 9-12, concerning the issue of Sasima, see F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 333-43.

conclusion, with a prayer to God that he might gather the deceased person's soul to Him. Gregory's funeral orations have been carefully studied in recent years.[70] Gregory follows these rhetorical norms faithfully, but he characterizes them in a Christian sense: he suppresses the parts he considers to be inappropriate, such as references to physical beauty, and he does not linger over the relatives' laments; he enlarges the parts that seem to him to be more genuinely Christian, such as those illustrating the virtues of the deceased person, as well as introducing a great number of new elements that would normally have belonged to other literary genres, such as stories about miracles, accidents, and descriptions. This novelty in the area of literary genres is also noticeable in Gregory Nyssen's *Vita Macrinae*, which is, according to the genre, a biography, but in many places a funeral eulogy.[71] S. Elm notes, therefore, that the orations for Caesarius and Gorgonia are new because they present the deceased as models of the perfect Christian, who was a public official (Caesarius), and the perfect marriage, perfect wife and Christian mother (Gorgonia): instead Menander Rhetor allowed a eulogy for a deceased woman only if it was her husband, or it was allowed for the wives of the emperors. Thus, Gorgonia is praised for her *sophrosyne* and her *kosmiotes*.[72] Calvet-Sebasti has observed that Julian the Emperor had already stated (*Euseb.* 2) that it was just as right to write a eulogy for a virtuous woman as for a man,[73] and subsequently Elm highlighted the shared rhetorical elements in Julian's and Gregory's orations.[74]

Gregory delivered the oration for the death of his brother Caesarius (n. 7) in 368. Despite the intent to write a eulogy, he is forced to tell – and therefore justify – an undeniable truth: Caesarius had enjoyed all the advantages of this world and had committed the error of not detaching himself with sufficient firmness from his pagan life, of whose mendacious honours he had partaken. He did not choose 'philosophy' as Gregory had wanted; Gregory absolves him, saying that this life choice is not obligatory for a Christian, it is just that it is the best. In any case, the privileges did not manage to corrupt Caesarius. In this case, therefore, Gregory has to have great rhetorical ability at his disposal in order to be able to write a funeral eulogy that conforms to Christian doctrine.[75]

[70] Correspondences between Gregory's orations and the genres in oratory have been put forward by George Kennedy, *Greek Rhetoric* (1983), 217 and Kristoffel Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical Exempla* (1996), 70 n. 134.

[71] On the structure of the funeral oration in antiquity the bibliography is extremely wide-ranging; here is one example: G. Kennedy, *Greek Rhetoric* (1983), and F.E. Consolino, 'Il discorso funebre' (1993).

[72] Illustrated by Federico Fatti, '"Fu casta senza superbia"' (2011).

[73] See M.-A. Calvet-Sebasti, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 6-12* (1995), 61.

[74] S. Elm, 'Gregory's women' (2006), 187-8; A. Monaci Castagno, 'Discorso agiografico' (2006).

[75] For this homily, Th. Hägg, 'Playing with expectations' (2006), 137. This is a 'eulogy that tends to hagiography', observes Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 320-2. For an in-depth discussion of the oration on the death of Caesarius, see M.A. Calvet Sebasti in Grégoire de Nazianze,

At the beginning he underlines his pride for the nobility of the family to which he and Caesarius belonged, instead of the sorrow for the death of his brother: he avails of the chance to demonstrate that his family was honoured by God's favour. Gregory lived a philosophical life (*Orat*. 7,9) based on devotion to the true God;[76] Caesarius was on a par with this, despite having cultivated pagan virtues such as φιλανθρωπία and παρρησία towards Julian.[77] The purpose of the epitaph is to exalt Gregory's family: before his birth, his mother had devoutly prayed to God to have a son, and had promised that, if her intention was granted, she would have dedicated the baby to Him, just like Anna did with her son, Samuel: this means that Gregory's birth had also been wanted by God.[78]

The same profound rhetorical re-elaboration, with a view to a hagiographical reconstruction of the deceased person and the family to which he belonged, may be found in the funeral oration for his sister Gorgonia (*Orat*. 8). While Gregory had been a constant presence in Caesarius' life, he knew little about his sister.[79] Thus, while the praise for the brother has an intimate and family tone, that for Gorgonia is generic (even though stylistically excellent) praise for a woman and could be adapted to any Christian. Gorgonia possessed to the absolute maximum all the truly 'feminine' qualities: scorn for the false beauty given by make-up and pointless ornaments,[80] mercy and intelligence demonstrated in knowing the right moment to speak or hold one's tongue, σωφροσύνη (ch. 8) and 'philosophy' (ch. 15 and 21),[81] the virtue of being dedicated only to God, donating generously to the churches, the poor and those in need, and knowing that she was storing up treasure for herself in heaven. However, while in carrying out these actions Gorgonia did not move beyond the canon of the perfect woman described in the Old Testament, she achieved something

Discours 6-12 (1995), 43-53; J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 26-34 and 156-65; F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 320-3.

[76] S. Elm, 'Gregory's women' (2006), 190.

[77] *Ibid*. 189-91.

[78] Insofar as he the son of these people, Gregory is 'a messenger filled with the Divinity's *nous*' (*Carm*. II 1,55,19-20) (S. Elm). God is capable of protecting his spiritual children from the attacks of the wicked, and therefore of carrying out the true duties of the philosopher who is also priest (*Carm*. II 1,12,751-8) (it is better to say 'of the priest, who is also a philosopher'). However, Elm's reference to the Platonic dialogues in this regard is less than convincing (*ibid*. 190 n. 73).

[79] So posits McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 26-30; R. Van Dam, *Families and Friends* (2003), 85; *contra* Th. Hägg, 'Playing with expectations' (2006), 144-5 nn. 36-8. A decision is hard to make, because it is based only on personal impressions.

[80] A traditional theme, which Gregory also repeats in *Carm*. I 2,29.

[81] M.A. Calvet Sebasti, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 6-12* (1995), 61-8. Like the beauty of the pagan Marcella, to whom Porphyry sent a letter (*Marc*. 3,33), so Gorgonia's beauty consists in her rejection of exterior signs of beauty (*Orat*. 8,3 and 10), S. Elm 'Gregory's Women' (2006), 188. But all this, more than a sign of the philosophy of the time, had been traditional in Christian literature since the time of Clement, so much so that Gregory also alludes to εὐτεκνία, which I do not believe was suitable for a pagan woman philosopher.

more, because she lived in poverty like an ascetic,[82] like the Christian philosophers, and so she also possessed the virtues typical of men, forcing her body to die before death, in order to free herself of the chains of this world. Her life is full of miracles, right up until the final moment which, in the hagiographic tradition, is of crucial importance: Gorgonia, in fact, dies while praying, and says the line of a psalm; Gregory of Nyssa also recounts that Macrina died while praying to God, and shares her prayer. In conclusion, Gorgonia is one of the exemplary Christian women of this era: Macrina, Olympias, spiritual daughter of John Chrysostom, Gregory's mother, Nonna. They are all determined, virile, generous women, full of faith and zeal; in an era and a society that expected them to be only wives and mothers locked away behind the four walls of the home, they were entrusted with the task of bringing salvation to their husbands and children. 'A man's life, then, is built up as a linear succession of deeds and events, each apt to reveal his innate virtues; a woman's life, Gregory seems to imply, is a timeless continuum, in which her various virtues manifest themselves concurrently'.[83] The eulogy for Gorgonia is the first Christian biography of a woman, written ten years before the *Life of Macrina* by Gregory of Nyssa. The lives of the holy women are a product of the union not only of panegyric literature and biography, but also martyrology and narrative.[84]

'Such sophisticated play with the form is still more evident in Gregory's other two funeral orations', observes Hägg.[85] Gregory the Elder died in the spring of 374. The funeral oration for him (n. 18) is of great interest for the reconstruction it provides of his biography: Gregory the Elder, with the authority accruing to him with age and his status as father and bishop, had imposed some difficult decisions on his son, but he had also provided him with the model for an ascetic life. Both the citizens of Nazianzus and his mother, Nonna, as well as Basil, who had come especially from Caesarea, were all present for the eulogy. It is Basil that Gregory addresses in the opening and the final peroration. The consolation is for Nonna, and she too receives great praise from Gregory.[86] In ch. 40 there is a reference to his mother's death, which was to occur a few years later: these words obviously cannot have been uttered at that time; rather, they have to be interpreted *ex eventu*. Speaking of his father's

[82] J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 166.

[83] Th. Hägg, 'Playing with expectations' (2006), 145. On the topic see also V. Harrison, 'Male and Female' (1990), 455-6 (on Gorgonia), 460-5 (on the other women Gregory knew); V. Burrus, 'Life after death: The martyrdom of Gorgonia' (2006), 154-8.

[84] Nevertheless, it should not be forgotten that Gregory's is in any case a *logos epitaphios*.

[85] Th. Hägg, 'Playing with expectations' (2006), 138; in the oration for the death of his father, 'there is a masterly balance between panegyric idealization and lifelike character description' (*ibid.* 147). See also Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 352-4; McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 223 defines the oration as 'a magnificent example of Greek oratory'.

[86] See A. Monaci Castagno, 'Discorso agiografico' (2006), 179-81.

fight against heretics, Gregory says that they were supported by the impiety of the emperor (ch. 37): as Valens was the object of this allusion, it is very unlikely that these words would have been spoken in public before his death, which occurred in 378. Bernardi, therefore, speculated that the text of this oration is also a subsequent reworking.[87] Gregory also says, perhaps to prevent any objections on this topic, that because of his habits his father was a Christian even before he became one officially, and he forgives him for having incautiously subscribed to a formula of the philo-Arian faith. Gregory manages to balance in an exemplary manner the idealization required in a panegyric and the actual reality of the facts, which presented us with a less than perfect character. Consequently, he dwells above all on the positive aspects, such as his father's firm opposition to Emperor Julian, his influence on the affairs of the church in Caesarea, his merit in having strongly favoured the election of Basil to the bishopric (and with a touch of malice, Gregory reminds Basil, who is there listening, just how unpopular he was).

For quite some time now, it has been taken as a given that, while not false, the reconstruction Gregory makes in *Oration* 43 of the figure of Basil, on the anniversary of his death after he had returned to Cappadocia, and 1st January 382 in Caesarea,[88] was definitely written with his own objectives in mind. The text, which is extremely long, makes no obvious reference to Helladius, Basil's successor as bishop of Caesarea, with whom both Gregory Nyssen and Gregory Nazianzen had a bad relationship. But other arguments also show that, in its current form, it was not exactly the same funeral oration held in public: as has been seen above (p. 82), Gregory inserts ample passages that concern him directly, such as his biography alongside that of the deceased person: this is inappropriate, according to the norms of rhetoric, just as the criticism he directs at Basil is likewise (he recalls his tyranny). It is likely also for this reason, and not only on account of its length, that the text that has reached us constitutes a revised version, corrected and amply extended, of the funeral oration that had actually been delivered. Furthermore, Gregory's intention is not only that of praising a friend who had also been a great bishop, above all it is that of showing the figure of the perfect bishop, which is exactly what the members of the recently concluded council of Constantinople, who had obliged Gregory to resign, had not been. To this end, Gregory discusses Basil's particular forms of excellence, starting with his moral virtues such as austerity (ch. 60), continence (ch. 61), his union of solitary and community life (ch. 62), the care of the poor

[87] J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 126.

[88] F. Fatti, 'In ossequio alle leggi dell'encomio' (2004), 648-50; J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 373-4. Given its length, it seems quite logical to suppose that it was rewritten subsequently, J. Bernardi, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 42-43 (1992), 31-2. On the politico-ecclesiastical situation in which this oration can be collocated, a situation that is pertinent to Gregory of Nazianzus' epistolary, cf. N. McLynn, 'Gregory Nazianzen's Basil' (2001).

(ch. 63), and finally, his humility (ch. 64). In ch. 65 Gregory begins to illustrate Basil's writings, recalling the *Homilies on the Hexaemeron* and his activities in defence of the divine 'economy' (that is, the problem of the divinity of the Spirit).[89] Basil is a model of virtue and intelligence, and Gregory deliberately places himself alongside a personage that had certainly become famous only a few years after his death.[90]

Basil did not write funeral homilies, and those by Gregory Nyssen are stylized and cold. Rhetoric is present in these too, but it is not the rhetoric of Gregory Nazianzen; it is simple and less elaborate. Gregory of Nyssa is far more reserved than Gregory Nazianzen when he recounts his own life. An oration by him, which took place in 381 during the council (perhaps commissioned by Meletius who was overseeing it), *On his Ordination*, bears a misleading title because in fact it does not speak at all of his episcopal ordination, but is rather a sort of address to the council Fathers, along with a lamentation of the dogmatic divisions existing within the Church.[91] In the same way, it is reasonable to expect that with the funeral oration for Basil, delivered the year before that by Gregory Nazianzen, and that is, in 381, Gregory Nyssen would have expressed some feeling, not only of admiration, but also of affection for his own brother. However, in actual fact this oration is also solemn and perfunctory, but what to Bernardi seems to be a defect is actually the answer to a precise necessity, that of presenting Basil as a perfect Christian and bishop.[92] In evoking

[89] The word indicates the way in which Gregory interpreted Basil's pneumatology, because Basil never uses it in connection with this problem.

[90] See McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 56. On this funeral oration, recent criticism has insisted above all on the 'political' intentions of Gregory, which he outlined through his rhetorical skill. See A. Meredith, 'Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa on Basil' (2001) (the importance of the news given to us by Gregory about Basil, unlike that given to us by Gregory Nyssen); C. Castelli, 'Gregorio di Nazianzo nell'*Epitafio*' (2005); F. Fatti, 'Nei panni del vescovo' (2006), 232-8; Neil McLynn interprets Gregory Nazianzen's political situation and the presence of Helladius as Basil's successor as bishop in Caesarea, referencing Gregory Nazianzen's epistolary and the figure of Nicobulus the younger ('Gregory Nazianzen's Basil' [2001]).

[91] More exactly, the homily is a strong criticism above all of the Pneumatomachians, whose 'heresy' was one of the principal theological mistakes discussed by the Council; the Pneumatomachians wanted to be recognized as a movement that had taken an intermediary position between Arians and Cappadocians, M.A.G. Haykin, *The Spirit of God* (1994), 193-201, which Nyssen did not admit.

[92] This is the opinion of Pierre Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Éloge de Grégoire le Thaumaturge* (2014), 47-55, who concludes that, given Gregory Nyssen's audience, in this oration what is missing is θρῆνος, a real sense of grief for the deceased person. In my opinion, the compositional freedom that Maraval finds in this eulogy is not so much a point of merit as a flaw in its rhetorical composition, and in any case the need to describe Basil as the perfect bishop does not require – unless for rhetorical reasons – every personal feeling to be silenced. Meredith also maintains that this oration is very poor in its reconstruction of Basil's biography, and he attributes

the succession of Christian feast days after Christmas, Gregory tries to place the anniversary of Basil's death on the same level as that of the saints Stephen, Peter and James, John the Baptist, and Paul. While Gregory of Nazianzus presented Basil to the audience, even transforming his friend's character and interpreting the facts in such a way as to make them favourable to him, Gregory of Nyssa puts forward the figure of the perfect Christian, who has put into practice all the virtues, detaching himself from worldly goods out of love for the poor;[93] however, from this oration only very little can be reconstructed of Basil as a person or of his life.

Gregory of Nyssa wrote other funeral orations: for Gregory Thaumaturgus, Meletius, Basil, Princess Pulcheria, daughter of the Emperor Theodosius, and his wife, Flaccilla. Some of these people were of a far higher social class than Gregory Nyssen's relatives, and so the tone, which tends to praise and eulogize, is much more solemn; while also being perfunctory and less sincere. The oration for Meletius' death (which occurred during the Council in 381) underlines, of course, the deceased person's virtues, but diplomatically does not mention the schism in Antioch, in which the interests of other important bishoprics were at stake, and so it is of little historical interest. The orations for the death of the Princess Pulcheria and the Empress Flaccilla, which followed each other in quick succession in the second half of 385, contain no traces of sincerity, since the people involved were outside Gregory Nyssen's circle, and the funeral orations only contain traditional topics (the vanity of human things, the ephemeral nature of power in this world etc). That year the bishop of Constantinople was Nectarius who, deeming himself to be unfit for this task, entrusted it to Gregory.

Finally, the most famous funeral homily of Gregory Nyssen (*De mortuis*, GNO IX) has nothing in common with those by Gregory of Nazianzus. In it, Gregory Nyssen exhorts the faithful not to give way to excessive grief at the loss of their dear ones and the topic provides him with the occasion to tackle for the first time the problem of apocatastasis. Thus, it is a homily that unites paraenetic and consolatory elements with theological ones. The homily *De deitate filii et Spiritus Sancti et in Abraham* (GNO X/II) is similar, which is difficult to classify in a precise literary genre.[94] It does not seem, however, that this oscillation of the genres of homily needs to be considered as a real lack of

the cause of this to the fact that Gregory Nyssen was, for personal reasons, closer to his sister Macrina than to his brother, A. Meredith, 'Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa' (2001), 166-7. Nevertheless, this did not stop Gregory Nyssen from being the continuation and the heir to Basil's doctrines.

[93] See A. Meredith, 'Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa' (2001), 164-6; J. Farrugia, HAMAPTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 183-4; about Basil and Nyssen see G. May, 'Einige Bemerkungen über das Verhältnis' (1972).

[94] On it, see M. Cassin, 'De deitate filii et spiritus sancti et in Abraham' (2011), 278-80; A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 220. This homily is weak on a theological level, as Radde Gallwitz also admits (*ibid*. 230).

artistry on the part of Gregory of Nyssa, but rather as a deliberate touch, as his most famous homily will show: a panegyric in honour of Gregory Thaumaturgus.

Hybridization of (Literary) Genres

The so-called 'hybridization of (literary) genres' represents one of the features of late antique literature, and a very interesting example may be found among Gregory of Nyssa's homilies. In writing the *Vita Gregorii Thaumaturgi*, and despite its title, he composed not only a biography (rather lacking in credible historical data, the author was not to blame for this), but also a panegyric, delivered before the Christian community in Neocaesarea in Pontus, probably in 380 (GNO X/I, 3,1-2).[95] The occasion was, as normally happened, the celebration of the saint's feast day. The text, given its length (nearly 57 pages in the Otto Lendle's edition), was therefore greatly reworked subsequently by the author. Consequently, the edition of this funeral oration is also most likely meant not for listeners, but rather for readers; this is confirmed by the fact that it contains a profession of faith attributed to Gregory Thaumaturgus, but which definitely does not belong either to him or his era, because it conforms to the symbol of Nicaea (there is nothing, however, to prevent it having also been delivered to listeners during Gregory Nyssen's homily in Neocaesarea). Thanks to the previously mentioned hybridization of genres, there is a smooth transition from biography to hagiography,[96] as the title also confirms: *On the life and miracles of our Father among the saints, Gregory Thaumaturgus*, even if, of course, it is not certain that the title of a homily is the author's own choice.

After a strongly rhetorical opening that demonstrates the author's ability, used to the forms of ornate prose in the composition of official eulogies, Gregory Nyssen introduces the historical elements required in the eulogy carried out in the form of a preterition[97] ('let no one think that, because I have nothing important to recount about the homeland or antecedents of that great man, I find fault') (6,22-7,1): the mention of the region (Pontus Euxinus: p. 7,5) and the homeland (the city of Caesarea: p. 7,15).[98] What is essential for a Christian is therefore confirmed: divine and human wisdom, his capacity to perform

[95] For these historical details, see P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Éloge de Grégoire le Thaumaturge* (2014), 14-8.

[96] Gregory Thaumaturgus' panegyric also has a parenaetic and moral function, about which, see L. Pernot, *La rhétorique de l'éloge* (1993-1994), 720 and 794. The one by Gregory Nazianzen in honour of Basil also had the same purpose, that is, it wanted to present the figure of the ideal bishop.

[97] This procedure is also followed in the homily for the death of Basil, where Gregory proposes a comparison between Basil, St Stephen and Peter, James and John (GNO X/I, 109-34) (see above, pp. 89-90).

[98] The town is presented with a strongly eulogizing description: 'the city to which an emperor famous among those who have held power in Rome demanded that it be given the name "Caesar", on the basis of his own name, captured by the love and desire for this region' – and so, not just a city like any other.

miracles (the reason for his name), which was the consequence of his moral perfection. All these – and above all the fact that Gregory Thaumaturgus collaborated respectfully with the Church hierarchy – are the typical reasons of 4th-century Christianity, as well as of Gregory Nyssen himself.[99]

Despite the fact that his parents had died when he was still young, Gregory demonstrated his good sense (p. 8,10), his character demanded, which was that of the *puer senex*, according to what David had said (*Psalm* 91[92]:12): 'The righteous shall flourish like the palm tree'. His good sense was evident in his search for wisdom and temperance, his modesty and meekness, his scorn for money, and in other Christian virtues (p. 9,3). After studying pagan wisdom, Gregory dedicated himself to true wisdom (p. 9,16), almost following the *cursus* of the studies that Origen had requested in his own school in Alexandria, initially, and in Caesarea subsequently; this is illustrated for us in the *Thanksgiving Oration for Origen*, attributed, in fact to Gregory Thaumaturgus.[100] He distinguished between pagan and Christian wisdom, in the way Moses did, who 'was learned in all the wisdom of the Egyptians' (*Acts* 7:22), but his true wisdom was different (p. 10,3).[101] Gregory, therefore, went to Origen's school,[102] demonstrating in this way not only his love of learning and hard work, but also the self-control and restraint of his conduct (p. 13,9-14), after which time he completed his studies in Alexandria, a city that more than others in the Christian East, represented culture, even more than Athens, which had remained pagan and specialized in the philosophical school. But Alexandria was also a city frequented, as well as by philosophers and learned men, also by all sorts of people and prostitutes, as was the case with every kind of great city: nevertheless, thanks to his lively and keen intelligence, with a prompt answer Gregory managed to reduce to silence a prostitute that had been jeering him in front of his schoolmates (p. 10,22). When Gregory returned home, Christianity still did not exist in Pontus. He wished to retreat from the world, but since everyone turned to him and pleaded with him to take part in public life, he decided to break off every type of human connection and practice silence, just as Moses had done – indeed, he appears to have been superior to Moses, because Moses had united 'philosophy' with married life, while Gregory had espoused only

[99] 'The story was shaped to suit the tastes of an author and an audience in the 380s, and much of the shaping may be the author's own', Lane Fox rightly observes: Robin Lane Fox, *Pagans and Christians* (1986), 530.

[100] The connection of the *Thanksgiving Oration to Origen* with this eulogy lies beyond the scope of this research. The historical problems concerning Gregory Thaumaturgus and Gregory of Nyssa are discussed by P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Éloge de Grégoire le Thaumaturge* (2014), 24-35.

[101] See also *Vit. Moys.* II 10-2.

[102] According to Nyssen, Firmilian of Caesarea also went to Origen's school: this may be seen perhaps from Eusebius' information (*HE* VI 27), who says that Firmilian appears to have frequented Origen for a time in order to learn Christian doctrine better from him. Firmilian, in any case, was already bishop in 230s, and thus already an adult when Gregory Thaumaturgus was still an adolescent.

wisdom (p. 14,1-15,5). In the traditional style of Christian language, he is called an 'athlete' who, with the help of the alliance with heaven, struggles against demons (p. 19,21-20,19) so that he can bring about the evangelization of Pontus, and his struggle was so noble as to seem miraculous. Once he had chosen 'philosophy', he gave away everything, except virtue and faith (p. 25,19-23). He then became 'master of his people' (p. 26,2), preaching poverty and urging people to consider as their own only themselves and their own virtuous life. With the help of the Spirit, he trained, taught, healed and advised (p. 27,8-28,25). His judgement was as precious as that of Solomon (p. 28,25).

All this means that Gregory had reached Christian perfection, as was demonstrated by the facts: when he entered Neocaesarea his eyes and expression were so fixed as to arouse wonder in those who saw him (p. 25,7-13). This scene recalls the description of the entrance of an emperor or a saint into cities, when this 'stillness' was always noted as a sign of natural superiority over any events.[103] Gregory was capable of working miracles during a dispute between two brothers over the possession of some marshland. All pleas for peace and agreement having fallen on deaf ears, and with a definite risk of violence ensuing, Gregory worked a miracle, no differently to Moses who, with his staff, split the waters of the sea in two so the Hebrews could pass. Indeed, Gregory dried up all that land, which thus became unusable and pointless. The two brothers, convinced by Gregory's supernatural powers, made peace and the sign that in the past a lake had existed there can be seen to this day (29,19-32,11). Gregory worked other miracles (32,12-35,6; 43,18-44,11; 48,12-50,10 etc), but the greatest occurred during a traditional feast, certainly of pagan origin (54,23-57,4).[104] A crowd of pagans had filled the amphitheatre to watch a show: only Gregory had refused to take part because, as his faith demanded, he could not take part in anything in honour of demons. The audience, which had thronged the amphitheatre, was invoking Zeus, crying: 'Give us more space!' These words meant that they wanted a larger amphitheatre; Gregory condemned this idolatrous show and his voice rang out: 'And so you shall have more space.' A plague arrived that decimated the population, so much so that the survivors did indeed have more space:[105] this prophesy and what Gregory did during the epidemic explained the great success of Christianity.

The demons that tormented Gregory, however, are not those that torment ascetics and the desert fathers, and which we encounter in the lives of the

[103] Such, for instance, was the emperor Constantius's entrance into Rome, as described by Ammianus Marcellinus (XVI 10,9-10).

[104] On the places of pagan cult in Pontus, the study by Lane Fox, *Pagans and Christians* (1986), 534-6 is well documented. See also recently C.O. Tommasi, 'Competing religions in competing landscapes' (2021). Gregory Thaumaturgus' panegyric, therefore, is constructed on real historical details, and is not only a re-elaboration that conforms to the tastes of the time of Gregory Nyssen.

[105] This is a historical detail because a plague did indeed lay waste the eastern Mediterranean in the second half of the 3rd century.

Ancorite saints of the time: they are still an element of pagan society, that is to say, the gods that inhabit the temples, require sacrifices and victims, and consider the sacred building to be their exclusive domain, from whence they also emit oracles and foresee the future (20,23). Some long accounts are dedicated to Gregory's activity in miraculously banishing these demons, amounting to a real *aristeia* (24,13), a hero's struggle against enemies, which concludes with victory. In their turn, the priests of the temples try to prevent the man of God, Gregory, from entering them when, heading towards the city, he meets them (20,18-25), but by using the sign of the cross, Gregory turns the house of abomination into a Christian 'house of prayer' (*Matth.* 21:13);[106] or, indeed, by showing his extraordinary power, he forces them back into the temple: he forces the demons to do what he wants, and what they too wanted but could not do, when Gregory prevented them (22,2-10). The temple priest then realises that there is a superior power at Gregory's side and asks a miracle of him: this consists in 'an absolutely incredible thing', that is, ordering an extremely heavy block of stone to shift, as if it were alive, from one place to another.[107]

Gregory of Nyssa also presents another topical theme of ancient Christianity: the anti-Jewish diatribe. Gregory Thaumaturgus unmasks some Jews that astutely wanted to extort money from him (41,21-42,23): the theme is traditional in Christian antisemitism and underlines Jewish astuteness, greed for money, and their attitude. Due to this attempt to trick the Thaumaturgus, one Jew is cut down by sudden death; while this punishment could have seemed harsh, observes Gregory of Nyssa, one must remember Peter who, like the Thaumaturgus, had been tricked by the Jews, in particular by Ananias, and in the same way one of them had been struck down by sudden death (*Acts* 5:1-11) (42,23-43,14).

For his preaching activity, Gregory needed a formula of faith, insofar as the Pontus was at that time tormented (just like in his own time, Nyssen observed) by schisms and heresies, and so this formula had to be perfect because it came from a saint: for this reason the formula was divinely inspired by a figure that was superior to humans. Thus, his 'credo' is also a miracle. The scene of the teaching of the formula is carefully prepared and laid out in detail at length (16,15-17,22). One night, while Gregory was meditating, an old man appeared to him dressed like a bishop; in the sweetness of his face and his demeanour, he bore the signs of great virtue. Amazed, Gregory asked him who he was and why he had come. The old man allayed his fears and told him that he had come at God's will so that Gregory would be shown the right faith and he pointed to another person wearing women's clothes. The room was flooded with light,

[106] Just like when Christ drives out the demons from the possessed, forcing them into a herd of swine that throws itself into the sea and dies (*Mark* 5:1-20).

[107] This may represent an echo of Christ's phrase about the 'faith that moves mountains' (*Mark* 11:22-4).

despite it being the middle of the night, to the extent that Gregory could not keep his eyes open. Therefore, he could only listen to what the two people were saying among themselves, and thanks to their names he managed to understand who they were: the woman revealed to him the old man was the apostle John and urged him to give the formula of the true faith; then John said that he would do this willingly as a favour to the Lord's Mother,[108] and he immediately wrote down the divine mystery: Gregory received it and left it as a legacy to Cappadocia (the reference to the orthodoxy of Gregory's descendants is obvious: the families of Basil and Gregory of Nyssa). That 'credo' was a gift from God, thanks to which right up to our own days Christians in Pontus and Cappadocia have been educated by the saints, remaining untouched by any heretical perversity. The words of the mystery, 'were inscribed by his own hand and even today are conserved in the church in Caesarea; the tables on which he wrote may compete with those made by God – those of the Law given to Moses' (19,7-8):

> One God, the Father of the living Word … perfect parent of a perfect being, Father of an only-begotten Son. One Lord, one from one, God from God, sign and image of the divine nature, working Word, wisdom that enfolds the subsistence of the universe and creative power of all of creation, true son from true father, uncorruptible from uncorruptible, immortal from immortal, eternal from eternal. One Holy Spirit, which has existence from God and appeared through the Son … perfect image of the perfect Son, which is the life cause of the living, sanctity donor of sanctification, in whom God the Father is made manifest, who is above everything and in everything, and in whom God the Son is made manifest, who runs through everything. Perfect Trinity, undivided and unsundered in the glory and eternity and the kingdom (14,24-15,25).

This 'credo' cannot be by Gregory Thaumaturgus because it is obvious that it proposes the doctrines of consubstantiality and the pneumatology of Basil and Gregory Nyssen, but neither should one think that it represents a falsification. In all likelihood, Gregory Thaumaturgos, if he did in fact had written one, may have composed it in accordance with the doctrines of his master, Origen;[109]

[108] This, then, is the woman's name: each of them reveals the name of the other as a sign of mutual respect.

[109] It is considered a falsification of Gregory Nyssen's by Luise Abramowski, 'Das Bekenntnis des Gregor Thaumaturgus' (1976), and Michel van Esbroek, 'The Credo of Gregory the Wonderworker' (1989) (this paper is based on different arguments than those of Abramowski). P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Éloge de Grégoire le Thaumaturge* (2014), 21 agrees with them and thinks that Gregory Nyssen could have composed this falsification only after Basil's death, and in order to obtain the authority to reconcile the followers of Atarbius, bishop of Neocaesarea, to himself, with whom Basil had clashed on account of his sabellianism. Manlio Simonetti, 'Una nuova ipotesi su Gregorio il Taumaturgo' (1988), 39-40, seems more convincing to me, as he thinks that falsifying the whole credo would have been too difficult, as it would have been obvious; instead, the falsification regarded only the final articles, those dedicated to the Holy Spirit, which may have been added by Basil (this last point, however, did not convince me: why by Basil and

thecredo in the biography might be a re-elaboration, carried out by Gregory Nyssen himself, of an ancient credo existing in Pontus and attributed to Gregory Thaumaturgus.

With the intention of connecting the saint's life to the Church hierarchy, Nyssen says that Gregory met Firmilian, bishop of Caesarea, and decided to become his disciple and thus learn about Origen's doctrines (13,4-22): Bishop Firmilian was known also in the West[110] and with these words Nyssen wanted to underline the existence of an agreement between Gregory's preaching and the ecclesiastical hierarchy. Gregory also met the bishop of Amasea, called Phaidimos, who, inspired by the Holy Spirit, wanted to consecrate him as a bishop against his will (another detail that fits into the frame of usage in the 4th century and recalls what Basil did to Gregory of Nazianzus). Unconcerned by the fact that Gregory was not present in the city, but lived a three-day walk from there, Phaidimos entrusted Caesarea to him, which up to that point had been under the error of idols, to the extent that there were no more than seventeen that had accepted the word of faith (15,6-16,3).

Once he had become bishop, Gregory rightfully intervened in the life of the Church. The Christians in the city of Comana invited him to intervene in the election of a bishop. This was the same practice followed in the 4th century, when the bishops from nearby bishoprics gathered in order to proceed to the nomination of a bishop: this is what those from Cappadocia and nearby bishoprics had done for Basil, and Nyssen must have remembered this clearly. The nobles in Pontus had chosen their own high-ranking candidate, but Gregory Thaumaturgus preferred a poor coalman to him, by the name of Alexander, who turned out to be a 'philosopher', despite wearing the poor clothes of the ordinary working man (36,11-40,13).[111] Therefore, a person who practices ascesis is the better bishop: both Basil and Gregory Nyssen could have fitted this description, and indeed Gregory of Nazianzus also thought along the same lines: according to him, it is not good for the Church to prefer wealth to sanctity of life in a bishop.

Gregory is a 'man of God' (30,11), he is not a desert saint, but a saint of the Church. Following the change in customs and ideas introduced to Cappadocia by him, everyone contributed to erecting a temple in honour of God that is still in Caesarea (28,1-11) and which is the foundation of his holiness; it was the

not Gregory Nyssen himself?) Subsequently Simonetti has recognized the importance of the objections by Abramowski, but he concludes with a *non liquet*: 'I am therefore of the opinion that as things currently stand with regard to Gregory Thaumaturgus, there is no solution to this difficulty', M. Simonetti, 'Gregorio il Taumaturgo e Origene' (2007), 24.

[110] Firmilian sent a letter to Cyprian of Carthage, translated into Latin and conserved as n. 75 of his epistolary.

[111] To such an extent that this coalman was capable of speaking the educated Greek of the cultivated classes, even if he was not able to follow the rules of Atticism, that is, the linguistic puritanism admired in imperial-age Greek culture…

only one to remain intact in the midst of the general ruination that hit all the other buildings in the place, following the earthquake that subsequently occurred. The afore-mentioned 'credo' was also housed in this church, written by him in his own handwriting. The first wealthy man to allow Gregory to use his home was a certain Musonius (26,13): at the time of Gregory Nyssen and Basil, a man by the same name had lived in Neocaesarea and had been the bishop of that city. Basil mentioned him with words of praise on his death in 368 (*Epist*. 28), and recalls that 'he conserved the tradition (*paradosis*) of the great Gregory and his successors' (*Epist*. 210,3).

Despite the persecution by Decius, Gregory was not martyred and his relics did not become the objects of a cult, which is something that Nyssen briefly mentions (Nyssen had no interest in the cult of relics). Once the persecution had finished, in his capacity as an institutional bishop, Gregory Thaumaturgus tried to establish feast days throughout the region in honour of the martyrs of the persecution (52,24-53,18): thus, it was the bishops who had encouraged the cult of the saints and the martyrs in Cappadocia. Gregory had introduced them, so that the converted might have something to substitute the pagan feasts they had been used to up to that point. Consequently, the institution of these feasts in honour of the martyrs appeared like a concession made to ineradicable habits in a region, as well as a pedagogic procedure that was supposed to lead people, over time, to a more profound moral awareness.

Finally, it is usual for a biography to embellish the narration with rhetorical descriptions, which serve the purpose of underlining the hero's virtues. Decius' persecution is described with a rhetorical tone and colour, as was required by the norms of the panegyric (p. 44,2-47,2). Gregory Thaumaturgus advises Christians to flee (42,2-16)[112] and aids the persecuted with his prayers. Then there is a miracle, which is explored in great detail and set out with an interest that may safely be called 'novelish' on account of its taste for the macabre, the gruesome, and the unusual (50,19-52,20). Having learned what was happening in the city, where Christians were being tortured, one of Gregory's servants wanted to go and see for himself. Gregory warned him of the danger, but the servant insisted, saying that Gregory's prayers entrusting him to God would be sufficient. He reached the city as evening approached and to refresh himself after the journey, he made his way to a bathing spot in a river. But in that place there lived a demon which, under cover of darkness, killed men: from these statements it is possible to deduce some facts, such as how bodies of water were often considered sacred to the local deities (who were identified with demons by the Christians), and that bathing spots, as places of immorality, were naturally considered places where a demon resided, as well as the fact that demon violence took place above all in the dark. The guardian himself of the

[112] This is what Basil's, Macrina's and Gregory Nyssen's antecedents all did.

bathing spot warned the Christian not to spend the night in that place, but he was not afraid, having made the sign of the cross. All the events and dreadful wonders that the lives of the saints normally describe occurred. Frightful crashing noises, terrifying visions, cries, threats from invisible beings: but the servant faced all this bravely, as he had as protection the word of Gregory Thaumaturgus, who, even if far away, had entrusted him to God, and so he returned home safe and sound.

With this panegyric, which is composed according to the norms of the literary genre, yet is also a 'life of the saint', to the faithful to whom he preached, Gregory Nyssen presented the ideal bishop, who converts the crowds, not through the word, but with the example of his austerity and his miracles. Such an account seems likely to arouse more wonder than imitation. Nyssen probably considered Gregory Thaumaturgus as a 4th-century model bishop. Clearly, all this negatively impacted the historical reality, but in the hagiographic models the historical reality need not be sought after like an *idolum*.

In conclusion, the strongly oratorical aspect of this biography enables a literary elaboration, which at times is particularly accentuated: this homily can be considered on a par with the Sophistic *logos* of the time – here the comparison with Gregory Nazianzen's homilies again becomes possible. It is above all the *ekphraseis* that manifest this elaboration; the *ekphraseis* are frequent not only in Gregory Nyssens's more demanding homilies in literary terms, but also in his treatises, where they constitute a rhetorical element that cannot easily be amalgamated into an objective approach to dealing with the problem.

2. *Epistolography*

Greek-language Christian culture prior to the Cappadocians had neglected epistolography (Origen's letters are few and not particularly significant); the Cappadocians use it as was usual at their time, when it was practised by Libanius, Themistius, and the Emperor Julian.

Antonio Garzya's contribution on the topic of late antique epistolography is still valid.[113] Some of its characteristics highlighted by Garzya can be found in Basil's and Gregory Nazianzen's letters (Gregory Nyssen does not seem to have been taken into consideration by Garzya). First of all, the concept – so distant from the modern world – of the 'learned epistle', which enjoyed widespread fame (such as the philosophical-theological epistle). As far as the method of writing letters is concerned, Garzya claims that 'certain attempts are frequent … to Christianize generically one or other of the received topics [sc. from the scholastic tradition]: less frequent, but still existing, are those where

[113] A. Garzya, *Il mandarino e il quotidiano* (1985), 121.

a certain situation is given a theological tone; a different structure underpinning a text is obvious, depending on whether the recipient is Christian or pagan: but neither these nor other features detract from the intimate fusion which in late antique Christian epistolography may be perceived between the traditional element and the Christian element'.[114] Nevertheless, some unusual features distinguish 4th-century Cappadocian epistolography from its pagan counterpart: the presence of greater 'realism' when compared with the strong and sought after rhetorical bent in Libanius, Themistius, as well as Synesius in the Greek ambience and Symmachus in the Latin one, which imbues their correspondence with a sense of repetitiveness and superficiality. But realism is not achieved at the expense of the literary elaboration, which comes across as far more varied, when compared to Libanius, Themistius and Synesius.

The importance and the characteristics of Basil's epistolary are well known: it is crucial for historical, theological, and even the author's own personal problems; it provides us with a view of the social, political and religious situation in Cappadocia and, like a series of concentric circles within which is located the See of Basil's bishopric, Caesarea, it enables us to know Asia Minor, the Christian East and West, to whom the author turned authoritatively: thus, it is an epistolary that is above all of a historical nature.[115]

The epistolary of Gregory of Nazianzus is very different because it is dedicated above all to individual people and events. While Basil's epistolary contains theological doctrines, Gregory of Nazianzus', as has already been seen with his homilies, is relevant for its biography. As usually occurred, the author himself of the letters put together a collection of the letters he considered important. Gregory of Nazianzus may have been the first among Greek Christian writers to occupy himself personally with the collection of his personal correspondence, most likely during his retreat to Arianzus as, freed from onerous Church administration and immersed in a 'stillness devoid of anxiety' (*Epist*. 131,2), he reflected on events in his life. He wished to give his epistolary a strongly literary character, and its organization may have been older than that of Basil's epistolary. From Gregory's own testimony it can also be seen that the original collection included some letters from Basil to Gregory in reply to Gregory to Basil, which have gone lost.[116]

[114] *Ibid*. 121

[115] The study by Robert Pouchet, *Basile le Grand* (1992), is invaluable in order to understand this epistolary.

[116] See A. Breitenbach, *Das "wahrhaft goldene" Athen* (2003), 199 n. 173. The issue of the presence of Basil's letters in Gregory's epistolary, and of Gregory's letters in Basil's epistolary, has been discussed by Neil McLynn, 'Gregory Nazianzen's Basil' (2001), 183-93, but it lies outside the scope of this research. See also, on this topic, the important book by B.K. Storin, *Self-Portrait in three Colors. Gregory of Nazianzus's Epistolary Autobiography* (2019).

Gregory himself wished to define the norms that ought to characterize an epistolary (not necessarily Christian). While he was preparing the collection, he decided to make a gift of as many letters as possible to his great-nephew Nicobulus, so that as he read them, Nicobulus might be able to identify their principal characteristics.[117] In *Epistle* 54 he gives advice on how letters should be written, and more precisely on the way in which 'laconicism' may be practised; that is, expressing oneself briefly and effectively, something for which the Spartans were famous. Three other letters may be connected to this: n. 52 (which is the dedicatee letter of the collection), n. 53 (about his devotion to Basil), n. 51 (on the principles to be followed in epistolography), n. 54, just mentioned, which completes the treatise on the principles outlined in n. 51. The four letters provide a succinct instance of teaching which outlines three crucial principles: concision (συντομία), which should not be taken for brevity, but a norm regarding a happy medium, so that one can avoid 'being verbose when writing, in cases, for example, not much of facts has to be written about' or 'using few words, when there are many of them' (*Epist*. 51,2); clarity (σαφήνεια), which enables an epistolary text to satisfy the expectations both of an uncultivated man as well as the learned one, 'the former because clarity is understood by the people, and the latter, instead, because he is above it' (*Epist*. 51,4); grace (χάρις), obtained through the rare and prudent use of rhetorical devices, which can contribute to filling out the discourse 'with a sweet flavour'. Gregory himself demonstrates this: concluding the letter to Nicobulus on the rules for the epistle, he states the principle that modesty is appropriate, and refers to an unknown tale: an eagle which, unique among birds, shows that it is in possession of the 'greatest beauty … it does not believe it is beautiful at all' (*Epist*. 51,7). Gregory Nazianzus' epistles represent a concrete manifestation of the rules that Gregory seems to have gained, rather than from ancient rules of epistolography, but from his own way of conceiving of and writing literary texts. Imitation of the 'laconic eloquence', for instance, is not only a theoretical norm, illustrated by a comparison between Homer's 'extremely concise style' and the verbosity of the poet Antimachus (*Epist*. 54), but it is an effective criterion for making careful choices of topics and facts to be recounted, with the intention of not exceeding the 'appropriate measure', which would

[117] We do not know the size of the collection that Gregory sent to Nicobulus. It seems that it did not included all the letters he had written up to that point, because in *Epistle* 52, Gregory says he has gathered 'all the letters he could', which means that some must have been left out, just as, on the other hand, there is no reason to doubt that he did write others and he did keep them after he sent the collection to Nicobulus. After Gregory's death it went the way it so often does: an anonymous redactor gathered all the similar material he could find and put it in the initial collection, both the individual letters from the last years of Gregory's life and those preceding the collection, that is, prior to 383-384 and which Gregory had kept apart. However, it cannot be ruled out that the redactor may well have been Gregory himself. On the topic see the afore-mentioned article by McLynn and Storin's, *Self-portrait in three colours* (2019).

otherwise damage the efficacy of the epistle. This choice must also be made when new words are formed which, together with other stylistic expedients, allow a concept to be condensed into a few syllables, the utterance of which does not therefore require a superfluous use of many words. While a simple and linear style of syntax makes a crucial contribution to the criterion of clarity, this does not require the abandonment of enriching the epistle by rhetorical devices such as chiasmus, alliteration, homeoteleuton, etymological devices and oxymorons, aphorisms and exemplary tales, which contribute to the 'grace' of the letters that are 'useful for educating with rules and mottos wherever possible' (*Epist*. 52,3).

The most recent interpretative tendency, in identifying the presence of propaganda motifs in Gregory's homilies, all ably hidden, advises against taking the epistles as anything personal either, or still less, taking them in a 'sincere' way. This has been applied even to Gregory's epistolary[118] by Storin, who has hypothesized the presence therein of some elements that are required to frame Gregory in the way he himself would have wanted: highlighting his friendship with Basil, the absence of letters during the period in Constantinople (so that, ultimately, Gregory was named by tradition as 'Gregory of Nazianzus' and not 'Gregory of Constantinople'), the urging to philosophy and above all to eloquence and culture, manifested with the refinement of style and the abundance of citations, along with allusions to classical authors, poets and prose writers. Storin also interprets the brief corpus of letters to Nicobulus as a group of letters that sets its sights on other characters connected to Nicobulus, that is, a non-apparent audience, just as certain orations may have an undeclared purpose above and beyond the stated one. Therefore, more than Nicobulus, Gregory wanted to address people he did not like, such as Bishop Helladius, or people with whom he had a superficial relationship, such as the Sophists Stagyrius and Eustochius and the rhetorician Eudoxius: 'Gregory likely intended the collection to be read by a similar, if not the same, audience as his other post-Constantinopolitan writings: bishops, priests, imperial and provincial officials, local notables, teachers of rhetoric, students, friends, and even family members throughout Cappadocia, Asia Minor, and Constantinople – people who were personally present at the council in 381, or at least people who had heard rumors of Gregory's weakness'.[119] This interpretation of the letters – like that of the homilies, which I mentioned above – is possible, but not demonstrable. It is true, nevertheless, that not only should sincerity be sought in Gregory's letters, but also other interests.

A wealth of philosophical motifs fill the letters sent to his friends Sophronius (nn. 29, 37, 39, from 365-369; n. 93, from 383) and Philagrius (nn. 30-6, with

[118] B.K. Storin, 'The Letter Collection of Gregory of Nazianzus' (2017).

[119] *Ibid*. 84. Storin's works, however, are a remarkable investigation into the letter collections that circulated in antiquity and which then constitute the corpus of Gregory's epistolary.

references to the grief following his brother Caesarius' death:[120] and so from 369; then, subsequently, nn. 80, 87 and 92, around 383).[121] Letters nn. 24 (from 365-369) and 38 (from 369) (to the philosopher Themistius) are to important men of letters, even if pagan; n. 236, of uncertain date, is sent to Libanius giving a recommendation of a young man that wanted to gain admission to his school.

The disappointment occasioned him by Emperor Theodosius, who had no scruple in substituting him as soon as the legitimacy of his election came under doubt during the council in 381, was never referred to by Gregory, despite the fact that an undercurrent of disappointment is clearly recognizable in the letters sent to the newly elected bishop of Constantinople and his successor, Nectarius, whom he addresses with a panegyristic tone, not managing, however, to keep the irony hidden:

> It was needful that the Royal Image should adorn the Royal City. For this reason it wears you upon its bosom, as was fitting, with the virtues and the eloquence, and the other beauties with which the Divine Favour has conspicuously enriched you. Us it has treated with utter contempt, and has cast away like refuse and chaff or a wave of the sea. But since friends have a common interest in each other's affairs, I claim a share in your welfare, and feel myself a partaker in your glory and the rest of your prosperity. Do you also, as is fitting, partake of the anxieties and reverses of your exiles, and not only (as the tragedians say) hold and stick to happy circumstances, but also take your part with your friend in troubles; that you may be perfectly just, living justly and equally in respect of friendship and of your friends. May good fortune abide with you long, that you may do yet more good; yes, may it be with you irrevocably and eternally, after your prosperity here, unto the passage to that other world (*Epist*. 88,1-2).[122]

From a Christian viewpoint, Gregory proposes well-known *topoi* from the epistolary practice, such as φιλανθρωπία, the mercy that man – especially the man of power – has to show towards those who are oppressed or are making amends for their faults. The consolatory epistles, such as the one to Philagrius, recommend behaving like philosophers when suffering, that is, being in possession of a virtuous dominion of one's passions. He reproaches Gregory of Nyssa for his 'thirst for honours … unfortunate more than any other demon', caused by his choice, at the beginning of his ecclesiastical career, to abandon the office of lector in order to take up the profession of rhetorician (*Epist*. 11,3). Pride is one of the causes of an action carried out by Basil, after his consecration as bishop of Caesarea, when he did not scruple to use his friends for his own ends, having become indifferent to other's feelings on account of the power accruing from a 'see that placed him far above those he cared for' (*Epist*. 48,2). There

[120] συμφιλοσοφεῖν is one of the topical motifs of late antique epistolography.

[121] On the letters sent by Gregory to his school companions and the Sophists, see N.B McLynn, 'The two Gregories' (2018), 30-1 and 35.

[122] Translated by Charles Gordon Browne and James Edward Swallow, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, Vol. 7 (1894).

are letters of recommendation where, in the vein of *captatio benevolentiae*, *topoi* are used such as praise of the recipient, who is requested beforehand to give a concrete demonstration of his excellence and, in particular, of his religious faith, which is celebrated as the first of his merits. Sometimes there is an explicit urge for conversion, as in the case of the epistle to the Cappadocian functionary, Candidianus, whose gifts of honesty and sagacity, along with the extraordinary 'power' of his eloquence, are celebrated with the hope of one day being able to make these merits even more sublime due to the acquisition of faith in God.[123]

Among the great compositions of the orations and the poems, Gregory Nazianzen's epistolary has not received the consideration it deserves and has aroused less attention among scholars than the others; despite this, it displays all Gregory's refined art and stylistic mastery, even if applied to so different literary genre. The style abounds with so-called 'Gorgian devices', that is, parallelisms, antitheses, equivalent members of the sentence, and internal rhyming. Gregory states (*Epist*. 57,4; 224,2) that he wants to be an 'attic writer', but he does not follow the rigorous Atticism of the Second Sophistic. Alongside the imitation of the Attic language are numerous poetic words, citations and allusions to archaic and classical poets: in brief, his letters are imbued with an extremely refined rhetorical stylization, which strongly contrasts with the simplicity, clarity and lucidity of Basil's language. As has been observed by Giorgio Pasquali, when Christians write to pagans, the ornate input draws on classical citations and allusions, while when writing to Christians, they draw on biblical citations:[124] nevertheless, Gregory Nazianzen rises above this distinction and uses his imagination freely.

Compared to Basil's and Gregory Nazianzen's epistolary, that of Gregory of Nyssa is shorter, but equally deserving of attention, as has recently been seen when Maraval's edition,[125] and a translation by Silvas had been published.[126] The brevity of Gregory Nyssen's epistolary is due to the fact that, unlike Basil's and Gregory Nazianzen's, it is not autobiographical; nor was his life the object of biographical accounts by others: 5th-century historians were already familiar with Basil and Gregory Nazianzus' life, but not with Gregory Nyssen's.[127] However, it displays a remarkable variety of themes and is interesting for its wide-ranging rhetorical capabilities. The letters sent to Libanius and other Sophists are highly significant in terms of showcasing Gregory Nyssen's sense

[123] U. Criscuolo, 'Sull'epistola 10 di Gregorio di Nazianzo' (1985) (on Gregory and Candidianus during the reign of Julian).

[124] G. Pasquali, 'Le lettere di Gregorio di Nissa' (1923), 106.

[125] Grégoire de Nysse, *Lettres* (1990).

[126] Gregory of Nyssa, *The Letters* (2007).

[127] A. Radde-Gallwitz, 'The Letter Collection of Gregory of Nyssa' (2017), 110.

of *paideia*, which was previously mentioned: they are a testament to and unusual interest in the Sophistic. This epistolary, like Gregory Nazianzen's, contains didactic letters, which are crucial for understanding his Christology.

In accordance with this interest for the Sophistic, in his epistolary Nyssen shows a capacity to rhetorically elaborate letters or parts of letters, focusing above all on *ekphraseis* and rhetorical formulas. In Nyssen's letters rhetoric devices reach a higher degree of elaboration than in his treatises and homilies. The *ekphraseis* describe religious feasts (epistle 4) or temples (n. 25, to Amphilochius) or journeys (n. 6, to Bishop Ablabius). Not only does Nyssen display a remarkable descriptive ability, but he also shows that he too (even if to a lesser extent compared to Gregory Nazianzen) possesses a solid rhetorical formation and remarkable literary knowledge. In his interest in rhetoric he appears to be closer to Gregory Nazianzus than his brother Basil, whose style (not only in the epistolary) is far simpler, clearer and more linear, along attic lines, and which avoids rhetorical elaboration. Nor does Nyssen avoid *ekphraseis* in his treatises and homilies (e.g. *Contra Eunomium*, *Eccl. Hom., Cant. Hom., An. et resurr.*), which sometimes can have an overly rhetorical character, to the extent that they become heavy and contrast with their context, which is generally 'objective' and non-elaborate; but at times, as in the *Homily on the Song of Songs* and in *Epistle* 20, they are far more appropriate and convincing.[128] The *ekphrasis* in chap. 3 of *De virginitate* lists the *incommoda nuptiarum*, and is indeed in the true Sophistic manner, and no different from similar instances in Gregory of Nazianzus, Jerome, and others.[129] Consequently, the epistolary – which is Gregory of Nyssa's most significant work from a literary point of view – contrasts with the homilies, whose style is generally not very polished (in the same way as the content is simple), and with the treatises which, because of the depth of the thought, are particularly demanding: in the treatises it seems as if Gregory manages to elaborate his thought with difficulty. As a man of letters, Gregory has not been extensively studied, so that one has to be satisfied with some simple references to him, which may be found in studies dedicated not to the epistolary, but to other problems.[130] Klock's study of this theme ought to be looked at again and explored further.[131]

Evagrius was a disciple of Gregory Nazianzen and Gregory Nyssen also because he wanted to outline his doctrines through letters sent to his friends.

[128] As has been highlighted by Morwenna Ludlow, 'The Rhetoric of Landscape' (2018).

[129] The *ekphrasis* was acknowledged as such by Aubineau, but was unsuccessfully taken as containing a more profound meaning (the opposition between the merits of marriage and its disadvantages) by Michel René Barnes, 'The Burden of Marriage' (2001).

[130] For instance, contributions by M. Ludlow, 'Divine Infinity and Eschatology' (2007), 236.

[131] See Ch. Kock, *Untersuchungen zu Stil und Rhythmus* (1987); P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Lettres* (1990), 43-50.

His epistolary includes 62 letters in the Syriac version, 25 of which also are in an Armenian version, and of some of these, there are large fragments in the original Greek.[132] The people he wrote to are those he met before and after his conversion to monasticism: Melania, Rufinus, Gregory of Nazianzus, Eustachius, Gregory's deacon, on the occasion of Gregory's death, the patriarch of Alexandria, Theophilus. Some are accompaniments to his treatises. All of Evagrius' correspondents are church men who, like him, are often engaged in the monastic life. Sometimes he replies to a correspondent that had sent him a letter, and in his turn he then sends moral advices and explanations of the Christian doctrine. Most of the letters have didactic content, and it is for this that Evagrius' epistolary distinguishes itself from the other Cappadocians.[133]

As Antoine Guillaumont notes,[134] also in the epistolary Evagrius shows himself to be a disciple of Gregory Nazianzen who, in his letters, had outlined the rules of epistolography. The qualities Gregory was looking for may be found in Evagrius' letters: the right measure, concision, and clarity; in any case, letters should not be arid and devoid of gracefulness; they should be ornate, but with no excess; pleasant, but without affectation; and enjoyable through the use of stylistic devices. As Gregory recommended, Evagrius likes quoting proverbs, which he mostly finds among the biblical *Proverbs*, while he does not reject the commonplaces of the traditional epistolary genre.

Theological Epistles

The theological epistles are similar, in Christian thought, to the philosophical epistles in the pagan ambience, and they were first cultivated by Origen. Basil wrote numerous epistles with theological, and thus didactic, content,[135] while both Gregory of Nazianzus (nn. 101, 102, 202)[136] and Gregory Nyssen wrote fewer (nn. 3, 5 and 24).[137] Gregory Nyssen's letter n. 17, the content of which

[132] The best edition and the best introduction to Evagrius' letters is by Gabriel Bunge, Evagrios Pontikos (2013[2]).

[133] On these see also R.D. Young, 'The Letter Collection of Evagrius of Pontus' (2017).

[134] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 140-5.

[135] They are different to those by Gregory Nazianzen and Gregory Nyssen because, despite the profoundly speculative content, the friendship linking him to Amphilochius of Iconium is very much present (the same cannot be said for Nazianzen' letters to Cledonius or Nectarius).

[136] According to K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical exempla* (1996), 64, epistles 101, 102, and 202 by Gregory Nazianzen ought to be collocated in the theological-orations genre: this is why the Editors of the Congregation of St. Maur have put them under the category of 'Orations'. But there is no real literary justification for this change: the epistle is not an oration, and their collocation is in the literary genre of didactic letters, which has been in existence since the times of Epicurus and Seneca.

[137] This has already been noted by P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Lettres* (1990), 16-7; A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 53 defines them as 'summaries'.

is non-theological, yet didactic, to the priests in Nicomedia, comes under this group, just like n. 19 (to an unknown John, about the life and character of his sister Macrina). Pasquali had already noted Gregory of Nyssen's tendency to give the form of a letter even to his shortest treatises.[138]

The so-called *Epistula fidei* by Evagrius should also be collocated among the theological letters, which, instead, is collocated as n. 8 in Basil's epistolary:[139] it reconsiders some of the exegeses proposed by Gregory of Nazianzus in *Oration* 30, which dates from 380, so that this letter may be considered to be the oldest of Evagrius' works to have reached us, prior to his transferral to the desert. On the stylistic level as well, Evagrius greatly imitated Gregory, reutilizing many phrases from his orations, which he must have picked up in Constantinople.[140] The letter is addressed 'to the inhabitants of Caesarea in order to justify his retirement', but it is clear that a fictitious title is involved, because nothing is said in the letter either about the inhabitants of Caesarea or about ἀποχώρησις (which is the title of the letter).[141] It is a brief theological treatise in the form of a letter, along the lines of some treatises by Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa. *Letter* 46 is similar in its letter-treatise form, which was sent by Evagrius to Melania.

Epistle 38 (either by Basil or Gregory of Nyssa) also has the characteristics of an epistolary-treatise. Despite the dedication, it was not sent to one person (Gregory of Nyssa, if sent by Basil, or Peter of Sebaste, if sent by Gregory Nyssen), but rather to several people in a Christian community. Furthermore, its tone is didactic and authoritarian, as can be seen from the opening, which is not appropriate either for Basil (if he were writing to his brother), nor for Gregory Nyssen:

> Seeing that many, in treating of the mysterious doctrine of the Trinity, because they fail to discern any difference between the general conception of substance and that of the persons, come to like notions and think that it matters not whether they use the term "substance" or "person" (and for this reason some of those who accept such things without investigation are pleased to attribute one person to God just as they do one

[138] See GNO II, vii.

[139] It was attributed to Evagrius by R. Melcher, *Der 8. Brief des hl. Basilius* (1923) (which I have not been able to read) and subsequently by others. A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 36, 142 and 337 summarises the letter. Gribomont's commentary of it, Corona Patrum Salesiana (Turin, 1983), 296-7 is very basic.

[140] On the reutilization of phrases and exegeses by Gregory Nazianzen, see L. Lugaresi, 'Non disprezziamo l'economia' (2000). Some of the reutilizations on the part of Evagrius come from *Oration* 2 by Gregory, which was delivered in Nazianzus in 362: Evagrius could not have heard it then, when he was seventeen years old, but in all likelihood it may have been re-elaborated by Gregory in the years subsequently when it became a treatise 'on priesthood' and Evagrius was able to read it in that form.

[141] However, Joel Kalvesmaki, 'The *Epistula fidei* of Evagrius of Pontus' (2012), is of a different opinion regarding the ambience in which Evagrius wrote this letter (see p. 227 n. 70); in any case his relationship with Gregory Nazianzen and Constantinople is confirmed.

substance; and vice versa, those who profess three persons feel obliged to assert as a consequence of this truth the same number of divine substances): for this reason, in order that you too may not fall into the same error, I have composed this brief discussion of the subject by way of a memorandum for you. Now the meaning of these words, to explain it in brief, is as follows.

The tone of the letter is didactic also further on (38,5): 'Accept my words as an illustration merely and adumbration of the truth, not as the very truth of the matter'. For that again, even the author of the subtitle of the epistle had understood that this was more a treatise than an epistle, because he added: 'on the difference between the substance and the hypostasis', and it is considered to be a treatise by modern criticism.[142]

Theorization

The Cappadocians are interested in defining the literary genres they adopt in a theoretical way. It has been seen that Gregory Nazianzen outlined some considerations on style in letters, and Basil likewise with regard to dialogue, even though he did not write any. In *Epistle* 135 (dating from 373) to Diodorus of Tarsus, he expresses his judgement of two books sent to him by Diodorus himself, and ultimately states that his criticism aims to show that he is no mere flatterer: he does not wish to correct the writings Diodorus has sent him, but he does want Diodorus, who will write more, to avoid certain defects. He greatly likes the second of the two for its brevity:[143]

because it is at once closepacked with ideas, and both the objections of our opponents and our answers to them are set forth in the work with the utmost clarity; and its simple and unlaboured style seemed to me to befit the purpose of a Christian, who writes not so much for display as for general edification.

Instead, despite possessing the same efficacy (δύναμις) as the second book in terms of content (πράγματα), the first book displays excessive stylistic ornateness and embellishment, which slow down and impede one's understanding of the line of thought. Diodorus had inserted dialogues into his works,[144] and this had been criticized by his adversaries: according to Basil, these insertions are

[142] J. Zachhuber, 'Nochmals: Der "38 Brief" des Basilius von Caesarea' (2003), 88-90 and A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 115-21 have also observed that the epistle has the characteristics of a treatise. For now, I shall not take into consideration the problem of whether *Epistle* 38 is Basil's or Gregory of Nyssa's.

[143] Basil pretends to appreciate the brevity of the book because at this stage he has little strength and is in poor health.

[144] It is likely that the dialogues were put together on the basis of the objections to the true doctrine of Nicene faith, which had been raised by Diodorus' adversaries, and the answers Diodorus himself had then given to these.

enjoyable because they introduce allurements (γλυκύτητάς τινας διαλεκτικάς), but, however, 'by causing delay and waste of time disrupt the continuity of the thought and loosen the tension of the argumentative attack'. Diodorus himself well knows that even the pagan philosophers that wrote dialogues, such as Aristotle and Theophrastus, discussed the various problems (πράγματα) in a synthetic way (εὐθύς), because they knew that they did not possess the gracefulness of the Platonic style; instead, Plato had also dedicated himself to introducing embellishments, which had the aim of ridiculing the defects of Thrasymachus (his quarrelsomeness), Hippias (his empty-headedness), and Protagoras (his boastfulness). Thus, Basil shows himself to be well informed about the features of Plato's dialogues and the two dialogic forms, which were defined as 'Aristotelian' (wherein the dialogue was reduced to a minimum compared to the treatise) and 'Platonic'. He also knows Plato's dialogues well and is capable of finding what it is that distinguishes them; it is a characteristic of the *Laws* that

> Whenever he introduces indefinite characters (ἀόριστα πρόσωπα)[145] into his dialogues, he uses his interlocutors merely for the sake of giving clarity (εὐκρινείας) to his subject matter and brings nothing else from the characters into the arguments (ταῖς ὑποθέσεσι); just as he did in the *Laws* (*Epist*. 135,1).

Therefore, according to Basil the aim of the Christian writer is that of proposing useful models of speeches, so that if people that are well known for their defects are introduced, it is also appropriate to introduce facts that correspond with these defects and underline them.[146] But if the topic of the dialogue is indefinite (ἀόριστον, that is, of a general nature), introducing objections to the characters leads to opacity and is pointless.

Despite Basil having advised against using it, Gregory of Nyssa uses dialogue, but he uses it exactly as Basil had advised: in fact, he does not underline the dialogic form, but only its content. There are no actual dialogues in *De fato* by Gregory of Nyssa, who sets a discussion with a non-Christian philosopher against astrology within the framework of a letter. Also in *Vita Macrinae* (wherein, as has been said, a sort of hybridization of genres occurs, straddling biography and dialogue) the account concludes with a dialogue section: it is, however, brief, despite the fact that *Vita Macrinae* was written as an imitation of *Phaedo*, and this fact could have justified further extension of the dialogue. Nor is dialogue given greater scope in the other imitation of *Phaedo*, that is, *De anima et resurrectione* (the links between the two works are well known and it is not necessary to go over them). In any case, Gregory Nyssen writes his dialogues following Basil's advice: he does not introduce 'indefinite characters',

[145] This term indicates characters that are not historically definite.

[146] If, in fact, it may be considered our task to find fault with men, adds Basil, in order to limit his statement.

but real ones, such as Macrina and himself; he presents them with their virtues (wisdom, ascesis, devotion to God, Macrina's *apatheia*) and their defects ('ignorance' and disputing the true doctrine by Gregory), just as Plato had presented Thrasimachus and Hippia with their defects. Gregory Nyssen, thus, confirms the characters' traits, describing their behaviour. This is confirmation of his extremely in-depth cultural formation.[147]

3. *Poetry*

Only Gregory Nazianzen (and to a far lesser extent, Amphilochius) dedicated himself to poetry, his commitment to it being on a level with his commitment to prose, writing a large amount of poems and tackling a great variety of themes.[148]

For reasons that are still under discussion, poetry came to the fore relatively late in Christianity, so much so that only in the age when Gregory lived, in the Greek Orient, did a real poetic output emerge. A few decades prior to this Arius had written a poem (*Thalia*) in Sotadic metre, even now not widely known, although the content is quite familiar, with the objective of spreading his heresy; however, this is not enough to consider him a poet. Subsequently, Apollinaris the elder and Apollinaris of Laodicea, because of the persecution of Julian, started composing poetry. Over these singular figures lies the obscurity provoked by the condemnation that struck their heresy and led to the loss of their works. The father was a 'grammarian', as Socrates recounts (*HE* VI 25). The son, defined as a 'Sophist', appears to have re-elaborated the Gospels in the manner of the Platonic dialogues and, according to Sozomen (*HE* VI 25), the Old Testament as well. Like a latter-day Homer, Apollinaris sang the story of the Hebrew people in 24 books, up to Saul. He is said to have written comedies in the style of Menander, tragedies imitating Euripides, and lyric poetry in the style of Pindarus, as well as brief poems to be used as hymns during the divine service or symposiums or work. He is said to have composed a *Metaphrasis Psalmorum*, that is, a poetic rewriting of the *Psalms*.

[147] Thanks to its imitation of *Phaedo*, *De anima et resurrectione* is the work that gave perhaps the greatest indication that Gregory Nyssen was interested in secular culture, see H.M. Meissner, *Rhetorik und Theologie* (1991). Andrew Radde-Gallwitz attributes too much importance to the figure of Macrina, when he thinks that Gregory of Nyssa wished to save Greek culture, by connecting the figure of Macrina with that of Socrates, A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 162-3.

[148] In his letters and homilies Gregory never mentions any of his poetry. Jerome (*Vir. illustr.* 117) knows one: *Liber hexametro versu virginitatis et nuptiarum contra se disserentium*, that is, the current poem I 2,1. Categorizations of the poems have been suggested by K. Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical Exempla* (1996), 61: dogmatic poems, biblical, hymns and prayers, moral poems, gnomologies, *threnoi*, autobiographical and epistolary poems, epigrams (and epitaphs). A general study of Gregory's poetry, focusing above all on the religious content, has been carried out by J.P. Lieggi, *La cetra di Cristo* (2009). But Gregory did not aim at being only a theologian poet.

We know nothing about any of this and the information appears extremely generic; it has also been thought that Gregory Nazianzen imitated Apollinaris, but this is a difficult hypothesis to accept; we only know that Gregory also testifies that Apollinaris used poetry in order to explain his Christology (*Epist*. 101,73).

Literary and Theological Intent in Gregory's Poetry

Gregory's decision was a response to the desire, not only to compose poetry of the utmost excellence, but to activate a well-thought out plan of literary and cultural activity. The composition date of most of his poems is unknown; it seems that most of them were written in the latter part of his life, after his return to Nazianzus in 381; some, however, are prior to this, even going back as far as the period in which Gregory was his father's 'coadjutor' (that is, they were written a little after the question of Sasima).[149] From some words of his (*Carm*. II 1,50,53-4: 'Mould is spreading over my books, my works are unfinished: who will complete then with loving care?') it can be deduced that he did not manage to sort his works definitively.[150] Thus, Gregory of Nazianzus' years, subsequent to the Council of Constantinople, were not dedicated only to ascesis, as an old *communis opinio* had it; rather, Gregory wished to underline his position as a Christian writer, showing that he was capable of using all literary forms in existence, including poetry. In this intention he sets himself apart from the other Cappadocians. Since his compositions can be collocated during his pastoral activity, they are not just the expression of an ascetic approach, but they also possess pedagogical and catechetical purpose. Gregory displays this in some compositions of a programmatic nature. One of them, written for Lent in 382, entitled *In silentium ieiunii* (II 1,34; PG 37, 1307-25), contains his resolve to write Christian poetry, juxtaposing it with the themes of pagan poetry: not only with the frivolous ones in erotic poetry, but also with the more important and heavyweight ones in epic and didactic poetry. Gregory intends to make use of his abundant poetic talent in order to carry out 'a coherent renunciation of whatever classic poetry had sung of in all its forms, epic, didactic, and lyric'.[151] He retreats into study, 'having nothing in common with the gloomy solitude of hermits' (Gautier). It is a cultural retreat, an *otium cum*

[149] According to J. McGuckin, 'Gregory: The Rhetorician as poet' (2006), 203 Gregory composed poetry throughout his life.

[150] The text of *Patrologia Graeca* was sorted by Caillau in the year 1842. It is a good text but divides up the poetry according to content-based criteria, which is not very useful and should be used only as a research aid, since it does not correspond to the chronology, nor to any possible development in Gregory's thought.

[151] See S. Costanza, 'Gregorio di Nazianzo e l'attività letteraria' (1984), 233. Dated research by M. Pellegrino, *La poesia di S. Gregorio Nazianzeno* (1932) and by B. Wyss, 'Gregor von Nazianz. Ein griechisch-christlicher Dichter' (1949), republished (Darmstadt, 1962) with a new

dignitate: this is what the 'monastic' life of the Christian man of letters consists of.[152] However, in order to bear fruit, this retreat has to be founded on a *cursus* of previous studies, which is that of the Sophistic: a man of letters such as Gregory felt himself naturally capable of writing verse, given the close connection between prose and poetry that a rhetorical background suggested and enabled in late antiquity: passing from one field to another cannot have seemed so difficult to him. His poetic output was destined to be read, unlike his homiletic output (this is the *silentium ieiunii*). As in those years Gregory was revising his homilies, so he refused to deliver again a speech, but wanted to write poems not destined to a public. Therefore, Gregory did not dedicate himself exclusively to contemplation, as was once thought, but continued his theological disputations of the Constantinople period: many of his polemical compositions against the bishops aim at framing Nectarius in a negative way, who, at the request of others, had substituted him. In the same way, in his poems Gregory continues to polemicize with Maximus who, it seems, had also written poetry (*Carm.* II, 1,41,55-6; PG 37, 1339-44): 'Gregory's silence, then, was exclusively a verbal silence, not a withdrawal from the full range of human communication'.[153]

The program of Christian culture, outlined by Gregory both in his orations and in his poetry, that I examined above (p. 35-42) therefore also includes his poetry. These crucial topics of the Christian message, this didactic programme, cannot be considered as forms of 'non-poetry', distinct from the 'poetry' of the lyric compositions. In Gregory, even the most personal and lyrical poems are nearly always motivated by an edifying intent. In other words, it can be seen how the distinction made between the two approaches is no longer fruitful; instead, it is important to realize what the cultural programme was of the multi-form Christian type of poetry Gregory planned and achieved. Let us now take some aspects into consideration.

The so-called *Carmina arcana* (I 1,1-11; PG 37, 397-471)[154] are quintessentially religious and theological. The title dates back to the edition by Jacobus Billius (Parisiis 1575)[155] and it is a Latin translation that the editor gave to the Greek

number of pages and an error in the title ('ein griechisch-christlicher *Denker*'), from which, in any case, I shall use citations for greater ease.

[152] F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 403-4, also 407.

[153] B.K. Storin, 'In a Silent Way: Asceticism and Literature' (2011), 246. Gregory had always been famous for his oratory, which explains what a novelty his silence was; on the controversy (*ibid.* 235-6).

[154] Please see what I said previously in Cl. Moreschini, 'Poesia e teologia nei *Carmina Arcana* di Gregorio Nazianzeno' (1997).

[155] Jacques de Billy (1535-1581), abbot of Saint Michel de l'Herm, was a notable scholar of the age of Henry III King of France. He is mentioned in laudatory terms by Guy Le Fèvre de la Boderie, expert of Christian Kabbala, Oriental Languages, and a Christian Poet. In *La Galliade*,

title (Τὰ ἀπόρρητα) he had found in the manuscripts he used, devised by the person who selected and paraphrased them in prose, the Byzantine Nicetas David, who lived in the 9th-10th century. Niceta's choice includes *Carmen* I 1,1-5 and 7-9, and then others that are not strictly theological.[156] In his edition (PG 37), Caillau took up and placed at the beginning of it only the theological ones (that is, 1,1-5 and 7-9), which are all in hexameter and so constitute a homogeneous group: eight poems in all, and eight are published in the most recent edition, that by Moreschini and Sykes:[157] Caillau instead collocated the other poems in Niceta's anthology among other ones of a moral nature. Moreover, in following the criterion of the similarity of topic, Caillau added other poems with similar content to the theological and Christological part of Niceta's anthology (nn. 6 and 10, which however are in Iambic trimeters, and n. 11, which is in elegiac couplets).

In terms of literary genre, *Carmina arcana* comes under the heading didactic poetry, as can be seen from the fact that Gregory uses the specifically didactic metre, the dactyl.[158] *Oracula Chaldaica* could be an instance of this type of poetry, but there is reason to doubt that Gregory Nazianzus knew of it; equally doubtful is what Sykes maintains,[159] namely, that Gregory could have imitated a similar collection of *carmina* with theological and moral content: *Oracula Sibyllina*. Certainly, *Oracula Sibyllina* contains many Judaic and Judeo-Christian doctrines, but it is not possible to say any more than this; I believe that, if we want to find an antecedent to Gregory's theological poems, one should look for it within Christian literature itself.

It is true that after Clement of Alexandria and Methodius, who are considered to be the authors of the first Christian poetry, there were no others in Greek-language Christianity. However, it is also very unlikely that the poetry of Clement and Methodius could have been taken as a model by Gregory. First of all, their poetic compositions are not independent, but are rather part of a prose work that contains them. For this reason, they were not well known as Christian poets. Furthermore, the literary genre in which their poems are collocated is not didactic poetry, but hymns – which is also cultivated by Gregory. For the same reason (leaving aside the content, which by no means favours such an hypothesis…), it cannot have been Arius' *Thalia* that constituted an

edited in second edition in 1582, Le Fèvre de la Boderie asserts: «Et l'honneur des Abbez, le docte De Billy, / lequel noble de sang s'est encore ennobly / avec la pieté qui lui est domestique, et avec l'ornement du sainct sçavoir antique, / et qui a descouvert aux Latins les secrets / *du Theologien unique entre les Grecs*» (vv. 1971-6) (ed. François Roudaut, Paris, 1993).

[156] See Cl. Moreschini, 'Studi sulla tradizione manoscritta dei *Carmina Arcana*' (1995).

[157] St. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana* (1997).

[158] We do not know who cultivated it before him or during his lifetime: Keydell maintains that religious didactic poetry did not exist before Gregory, 'Die literarhistorische Stellung der Gedichte Gregor's von Nazianz' (1953).

[159] D.A. Sykes, 'The *Poemata Arcana*' (1970).

antecedent for Gregory: *Thalia* was written in sotadic metre and was criticized precisely for this reason, because the metre, catchy and easy to declaim, was not considered suitable for a 'high' purpose, which even a heretic should have been pursuing. Indeed, in *Thalia* Christian polemicists criticized not only the heretical ideas but also the metre, which they considered to be typical of poetry of an immoral, immodest nature. If anything, it could be hypothesized that the poems of Apollinaris of Laodicea, which were in fact familiar to Gregory, and who refers to them (specifically in his imitation of the *Psalms*) in *Epist*. 101,71, were a model of Christian didactic poetry.[160] And if the fact that these poems were written by a heretic might nullify the hypothesis that Gregory 'imitated' them. Gregory began writing poems at an earlier date (370-372 AD), when he didn't know Apollinaris' works yet.

Naturally, insofar as it is didactic poetry, *Carmina arcana* suffers from the flaws that often afflict this literary genre: that is, in amounting basically to versified prose. This defect was wrongly considered to be typical of Gregory's poetry by Keydell, who stated that Nazianzen appears to have been guided by the following criterion: 'Whatever I am capable of expressing in prose, I can also express in poetry',[161] and he examined the varied content of his poems, concluding that the same themes are to be found there as in his homilies, where they are expressed in prose: for instance, cynical diatribes, moralizing discussions, and collection of sayings. However, this is not exactly the problem, given that versified prose was, basically, the ideal type of art prose of the Sophistic and being capable of writing both poetry and prose was considered an advantage for a man of letters in late antiquity. Synesius of Cyrene is the most appropriate example. Drawing a parallel between Gregory and Synesius was done by Keydell,[162] but for exactly the opposite reason to what I have put forward: that is, in order to advance an interpretation that by no means does justice to Gregory and repeats many of the commonplaces on Christian literary output: both poets were experts in rhetoric, but Synesius 'is the pure Greek, Greek in his poetry, rooted in turning to the harmony of the universe', while Gregory, who indeed loved Greek rhetoric, which 'gave him power over men and a way

[160] Apollinaris of Laodicea was taken into consideration by R. Cantarella, *Poeti Bizantini* (1992), but only in so far as he came in for criticism from Gregory Nazianzus in *Arcana* 2, who wished to defend Christ's humanity from Apollinaris' objections. However, Sykes has noted, 'The *Poemata Arcana*' (1970), 37 that in that poem, Gregory is not against those who dispute Christ's humanity, but against those who deny his divinity, that is, the Arians. In his turn, Sykes takes Apollinaris into consideration, but only as far as the chronology of Gregory's work is concerned, in order to show that it is subsequent to that of the heretic, without however hypothesizing an imitation of Apollinaris on the part of Gregory (*ibid*.).

[161] R. Keydell, 'Die literarhistorische Stellung' (1953), 138. Keydell's opinion is followed by C. Milovanovic-Barham, 'Gregory of Nazianzus: *Ars Poetica*' (1997), 499-500 – but this is a very limiting view of Gregory's poetic abilities.

[162] R. Keydell, 'Die literarhistorische Stellung' (1953), 142.

of being admired and respected … did not possess the Greek sense of beauty or the value they placed on form'. Keydell's evaluation is emblematic of an erroneous way of judging Gregory:[163] in fact, I am not seeking the inventor (πρῶτος εὑρετής) of Christian poetry, but literary reasons why the same artist wrote both in prose and verse – and the reasons are those outlined above: the defence of the *logoi* in all their forms.[164]

In any case, even if the parallel it seems can be drawn between Gregory and Synesius has its own validity, there are some differences, which must equally be taken into account. Synesius dedicated his poetic output to theological speculation, and his prose output to another part of his thought: he made a choice among the various literary genres, attributing to each of them a particular type of content and a precise function. Instead, Gregory wrote in prose and in verse on the same topics: the content of *Carmina arcana* (like that in many other poetic compositions) can be found in his homilies. This is where Keydell's erroneous impression stems from, that Gregory could write equally in prose and in verse on the same topic, but without a real reason.[165]

Using the same doctrinal content for two different literary genres, such as the homily and the didactic poem, is not absurd: in fact, the addressees were different, and so therefore were the attitude of the poet and the intention of the preacher. While in the homilies Gregory addressed a crowd right in front of him, in his didactic poems he was writing for a close circle of cultivated Christians, capable of appreciating his refined and demanding poetic output: they may even have been people who had already listened to him in the church of Anastasia or the Holy Apostles, and who subsequently were capable of meditating on the theological and philosophical themes, far from the crowds, and who could therefore perceive in the preacher-bishop's didactic *carmen* a more specific characteristic, destined for them, the select few connoisseurs. The homilies, even those as ornate as Gregory's, were destined for

[163] Nor is Francesco Trisoglio convinced by the validity of this example, 'La poesia della Trinità' (1975), 717 n. 44.

[164] The affinity between Gregory's *Carmina arcana* and Synesius' *Hymns* has recently been re-proposed, and mainly on the basis of their content, in various essays by U. Criscuolo, 'Sulla poesia di Gregorio di Nazianzo' (1993); *id*., 'Sinesio di Cirene fra neoplatonismo e teologia patristica' (2012); *id*., 'Un cristiano difficile: Sinesio di Cirene' (2016).

[165] See R. Keydell, 'Die literarhistorische Stellung' (1953), 138. Keydell applies this conviction of his to *Carmina arcana* and the 'Theological Orations'. But Keydell's error is evident when he passes from the affinity of the content to statements like this: 'However, in actual fact the *form* of this dogmatic teaching does not derive from poetry, but from prose, and more precisely from the cycle of the homilies. The theological orations provided him not only with a considerable part of the material, but also with *principle of the composition* (*ibid*. the italics are mine)'. Still less does it seem justifiable to use the accepted fact that, in Gregory's time and already long before that, the poetic form of paraphrase was practised: when a poet wishes to paraphrase a prose text, he does not usually paraphrase one of his own, but an authoritative text belonging to someone else.

a listener in a public audience and not a private reading; this, instead, is what poetry is for.[166]

Carmina arcana constitutes a unity already on the basis of the content and this is confirmed by the existence of internal cross-references between one poem and the previous one;[167] for that again, this is also justifiable in itself at a logical level. The first poem, *On First Principles* (Περὶ ἀρχῶν), is divided into two parts, which seem to contrast with each other: the first part functions as an introduction, while only the second is dedicated to an overview of Trinitarian doctrine. *On First Principles* is not well organized: there is no discussion concerning the Father and so the title is inaccurate: there should have been a poem dedicated to the Father entitled περὶ τοῦ Πατρός. In actual fact, in almost all the manuscripts the poem has the title Περὶ ἀρχῶν, while that of περὶ τοῦ Πατρός is limited to a few testimonies, which may have introduced a different title precisely for the reasons outlined above: Caillau also entitles it περὶ τοῦ Πατρός. One explanation for the absence of an initial poem 'On the Father' may be found in what Gregory says elsewhere (*Orat*. 34,10), that is, the Father's divinity has never been doubted by any heretic, and so he does not maintain it necessary to spend time discussing it. Therefore, the first poem is dedicated to the principles of Christian doctrine, as its title (Περὶ ἀρχῶν) states (a title that closely echoes Origen's and reminds us of Gregory of Nazianzus' Origenism). The discussion of the principles takes place in vv. 25-35 and is preceded by a lengthy introduction (vv. 1-24), which contains the topical theme (this, however, is also present in *Orat*. 28,2) on the necessity that laymen keep away from such a profound and 'secret' topic such as the one Gregory is tackling; the polemical motif is taken up again at the end (vv. 35-9), where the poet anathematizes heretics, who are but dimly illuminated by the light of truth: basically, they are the *prophani* who are intimated to remain at a remove by the pagan poet. What exactly the secret, arcane topic is remains unclear, the topic that laymen have to steer clear of: does it regard the content in the second half of the poem on principles, or does it regard the subsequent poems, on the Son and the Holy Spirit? In this case the introduction is not intended for the whole theological-philosophical entity of *Carmina arcana*, but only the first part of it, specifically the Trinitarian content (n. 1-3): the second part (4: the universe; 5: the angels; 6: providence; 7: the soul; 8: the two Testaments and the coming of Christ) is not the object of the warning in the introduction. Indeed, only the first three contain a profound doctrine that is comprehensible only to he who believes in the teachings of the Church, and therefore effectively require previous purification on the part of the reader. Therefore, it seems to me

[166] This is Gautier's explanation, but it is also the view I ascribed to in my afore-mentioned work (n. 154).

[167] This aspect, which is purely structural, has been underlined by both R. Keydell, 'Ein dogmatisches Lehrgedicht' (1951) and D.A. Sykes, 'The *Poemata Arcana*' (1970).

that the *topos* contained in the introduction (purification is necessary before acceding to the true doctrine about God) is appropriate only for the first three *carmen*. Thus, it cannot be denied that the structure of the first poem is extremely disorganized.[168]

The second and third poem are dedicated, therefore, to the second and third Persons. The doctrine that Gregory outlines, above all as a contrast to Eunomius, even though he is not explicitly mentioned, is that present in two of the theological orations (n. 29 on the Son, and n. 31, on the Holy Spirit); the doctrine in *Oration* 30 is not referred to in the second poem because, as it is dedicated to an examination of the dossier of scriptural passages concerning the Son, it was particularly unsuitable for being reframed in verse. Necessarily, for Gregory the composition of a poem on the Son also required one on the Holy Spirit, and both could not but be placed in close proximity with the previous one, 'on principles'. The teaching on angelic nature, which constitutes the sixth in the series, could have come immediately after the first three, but Gregory wanted to precede it with one on God's providence and this, in its turn, is preceded by a poem on the world. In all likelihood, what motivated this sequence is the crucial distinction between uncreated and created nature, so that angelic substances are thought of as constituting a part of this second type: thus, it was necessary preliminarily to explain the origin of the world, in which angelic nature was also contained. For that again, the cosmology part, presented in the fourth poem, is carried out along two lines of consideration, in the sense that the fundamental problems are, first of all, that of rejecting pagan doctrine (Platonic in particular) on the eternity of the world, and in the second place, that of confuting Manicheism. According to Christian doctrine, the world had been created by God, so Gregory rejects the dualism of the Manichaeans for whom the evil principle gave rise to it.[169] The last part of poem 4 is dedicated to explaining the structure of the world: the world is created nature, and this in its turn can be classified into angelic nature and human nature: according to this division, the world is classified into the angelic world (or intelligible) and the human world (or material). On the world, which is thus organized, divine providence acts, to which poem 5 is dedicated, which, already in the first line, makes a reference to the previous one.[170] To sum up: after the first three *Poemata* on divine

[168] On the first *carmen* in *Carmina arcana*, see C. Nardi, 'Note al *primo carme teologico*' (1990).

[169] This affinity was caught by Keydell, 'Ein dogmatisches Lehrgedicht' (1951), 316; however, I do not feel that the dispute with the Manichaeans takes doctrines, as Keydell suggests, from Basil's *Homiliae in Hexaemeron* (II 4), insofar as it presents altogether traditional considerations.

[170] Also elsewhere, for example: the δὲ in the first line of the second poem cross-references the synthesis of Trinitarian doctrine in the first, while the opening line of the third shows that this poem must necessarily follow the second. Thus, the opening of the fourth poem ('let us also sing of the world', after singing of divine nature) reconnects it, as a juxtaposition, with the three previous ones, and the opening of the fifth, on providence, imagines the material world to be already in existence, to which the fourth poem is dedicated. The seventh seems to be less closely linked than

reality, come another three on created reality, and these are divided into a first group (nn. 4 and 5) dedicated to created material reality, and a second (n. 6), dedicated to created intelligible reality. Juxtaposed with these is the sixth poem, on the intelligible or angelic world. The structure of the poem on providence (n. 5) is complex: providence is justified on the basis of the existence of the world, insofar as it could not have existed without providence having brought it together. But very soon the poet turns to an examination of a widely held doctrine at that time, which Gregory confutes since it contradicts the existence of providence itself, that of astral fatalism, whereby men's actions are guided by the stars. This confutation, which proceeds up to line 53, asserts contemporaneously the doctrine of free will, and concludes by explaining a difficulty that Christianity had fallen into: namely, that after all the birth of Christ had been announced by a star to the Magi, who came from the East, so that even stars might have a role to play in human events.[171] The sixth poem (I 1,7), dedicated to intelligent substances, that is, the angels, which are pure intelligible reality and devoid of any matter, picks up, instead, with greater stringency and strict consequentiality, a theme that was dear to Gregory, worked out by him above all in *Orat*. 29,31 and 38,9: specifically, how can the angels have sinned if they are not composed of matter. Gregory states here as well that even the angels can sin because their perfection does not derive from their substance, while substantial goodness belongs exclusively to God. After the treatise on angelic nature, the poet dedicates himself to examining human reality. The seventh poem, dedicated to the soul, can also be divided into two parts, of which the first disputes the opinions of the pagans (composition of the soul, metempsychosis etc: vv. 1-52); the second introduces Christian doctrine through the story of the creation of man (more particularly, his soul, brought about by the 'breath of God' being inserted into his body, which was formed from the mud of the earth) up to original sin. This account introduces the eighth and last poem, which is dedicated to the two Testaments made by God with man. After sinning, man had abandoned himself to idolatry (as is also said in *Orat*. 39,2-10), from which only the Law given by God to Moses had saved him. This was followed by the new Law, that of Christ: Gregory therefore has to explain the incarnation and the Son of God's struggle with the devil, which he took on in order to redeem all of humanity from the dominion of sin. To access the new Law, introduced by Christ, the purification afforded through baptism is necessary, about which one finds repeated here some considerations that may be read in the homily dedicated to baptism (n. 40).[172]

the previous ones, but Keydell (*ibid*. 316) has rightly noted that the δὲ with which it opens assigns a sequence to it.

[171] An exceptional case of approval, on the part of Christians, of astrology and its function of predicting the future.

[172] One of the most important manuscripts in *Carmina arcana* and indeed Gregory's entire poetic output, the 11th-century Laurentianus plut. VII, 10, contains between line 18 and 19 in

This, then, is the structure of *Carmina arcana*, so that the hypothesis – which after all goes back as far as Nicetas – whereby the series of eight *carmina* with theological, cosmological and moral content was conceived of in an organic and unitary manner. In dedicating himself to a didactic literary genre, destined to the discussion of the more specific problems of the Christian religion, Gregory succeeded in concentrating and ordering in fewer than a thousand lines that which elsewhere, more specifically in the homilies, he had presented with another form in a different way. The concision of the poet-teacher's discourse is stronger and more evident when he explains the problem of the Trinity, or angelic nature, to which, in any case, he had already dedicated his theological orations; the treatise is less rigorous, instead, where the problems of the world, history and the covenant between God and man are dealt with, because here Gregory did not have one of his previous texts before him on which to work. This also means that *Carmina arcana* can be dated after 380, which is the year of the theological orations; in addition, the one discussing the nature of the soul, showing polemical touches towards the heresy of Apollinaris of Laodicea, can be dated around 382, more or less coeval with the epistles that dispute Apollinarianism.

Other types of poetry may be considered briefly. *Against women who wear make-up* (I 2,29), is the most famous in *Carmina moralia*. Luxury and feminine vanity had been a topic ever since Homer and Hesiod's time, and then by the 7th- and 6th-century BC lyric poets, and they had been objects of fun in Greek comedy. Nor did they escape the attention of the moralists of the Hellenistic and Roman world, such as Seneca, Plutarch and Dio Chrysostom. The essential themes of Greek and Latin moralism were taken up again without any difficulty by Christian writers, who considered the reflections of pagan wisdom acceptable in this regard: for example, the juxtaposition of natural beauty, created by God, with artificial beauty, which was the work of the hand of man; the former

Arcana 8 (*On the Testaments and the Coming of Christ*) = I 1,10 in the Caillau edition (PG 37, 458A), who however did not print it, an extensive section of about 60 lines, which illustrates in greater detail the handing down of the ancient Law to Moses, at the time of the rebellion of the Jewish people, guided by Aaron. This section is missing, however, in the other two branches of manuscripts, and it has been asked whether it can be traced back to Gregory or whether it constitutes a body of spurious verses. Wyss (B. Wyss, 'Zu Gregor von Nazianz' [1946]), was the first to deal with this in great detail, and he maintained that they were authentically Gregory's, and the most recent criticism, in his wake, is inclined to consider them his as well, see R. Keydell, 'Ein dogmatisches Lehrgedicht' (1951), 317 n. 1. Nevertheless, as has been observed elsewhere, Cl. Moreschini, 'Studi sulla tradizione manoscritta' (1995), 118, the fact that they are missing in two of the three families of manuscripts in *Carmina arcana* and that they lie in a manuscript such as Laurentianus VII 10, which, despite being of the first order, is however, prone to modifying the text, has made me hesitant to accept Gregory's authorship, so that I am still convinced that they are a subsequent re-elaboration from the Byzantine era. Consequently, they are omitted from the Moreschini edition of *Carmina arcana* (1997).

is truth, while the latter is falseness; the former innate, the latter, grasped from the external world. Natural beauty has no need of make-up, which in fact spoils it. To these reasons from Greek moralism, the Christians added their own considerations: natural beauty is the work of God, who created man in his own image, while artificial beauty is an imposture insinuated by the devil. Given its origin, this imposture is absolutely unacceptable: Christian writers do not hesitate to condemn what is perhaps more a weakness than a serious sin. Gregory inserted himself into this Christian tradition: before him, in the Latin ambience, Tertullian and Cyprian had presented many of the considerations that can be read in Gregory, who touched on the topic, coming down heavily and finding inspiration in ascetic observations, given the occasion in which he was writing, namely, the epitaph of his virtuous sister Gorgonia, who had dedicated her life to abstinence and prayer despite everything her wealthy background could have offered her. However, Gregory was well acquainted with pagan literature, which his refined rhetorical education had opened up to him: Homer, Hesiod, the Alexandrine poets, so that this poem achieves a particularly elaborate effect, with parts that attain truly virtuoso verbal effects. Indeed, this topic, dealt with by the moralists, had also been given a literary form by the poets, whom a cultivated man of letters such as Gregory could not ignore. Luxury, beauty, the sophistication of feminine ornamentation, had been given ample consideration in love poetry, in elegiac poetry, and in comedy. Women who wear make-up are taken to task by the poet in love, who fears that his beloved is making herself beautiful for others; or the comic poet who, to make his audience laugh, pillories make-up and the titivations of the women with whom young men fall in love. This poem, therefore, is definitely among Gregory's most remarkable and one of those that more successfully highlights his artistic ability; it is one of the most erudite poems, and most sensitive to the cultural tradition to which Gregory was the heir.

Remarkable examples of Gregory's ability to write elegiac poetry are I 2,14 and I 2,15, in which the poet poses questions about human nature, passing and fleeting. Poem I 2,14 begins with a narrative sequence that serves to define the time, place and psychological situation of the poet; the description of the *locus amoenus* comes from a long-standing literary-poetic tradition, in which Gregory finds himself immersed in meditation. His one comfort is faith, which is manifested in an invocation of the Trinity, in an exhortation to himself in the hope of resurrection. In the description of nature, Gregory is on a par with the classical models: Homer, Sappho, Theocritus. The subsequent elegy (I 2,15) is dedicated to a consideration of the vanity of human nature: *The insignificance of the exterior man*. The elegy opens with a series of anxiety-ridden questions, which the poet asks himself and God: what does it mean to exist? to be a man? to be Gregory? The inexorable conclusion of every human state, even the most sublime, is that man is merely nothing. Decay and death are the great levellers, both of emperors and beggars. The only surety is embracing Christ. If the body

bends towards the earth, the soul, which is the breath of God, shall return on high. This is what represents true greatness.

A literary-critical assessment of Gregory Nazianzen' poetry would require an overview that still does not exist. Seventy years ago a specialist on Gregory, Bernhard Wyss, showed himself to have little interest in Gregory's poetry,[173] and stated that any philological investigation would, first of all, have to establish exactly what he owed to his Hellenic background.[174] For Gregory, using Greek art simply means using a means of support.[175] Nevertheless, this is not enough: at this stage the most up-to-date criticism on Christian culture, with the aim of establishing its classical legacy, is well aware that it is also necessary to examine how this legacy has been linked with the Christian legacy and re-elaborated in suitable forms: in this case, in poetic form. As used to be commonplace, Wyss still juxtaposed the Greeks against the Christians. His observation, that ancient poetry, and above all that from the age in which Gregory lived, held that the imitation of classical models was not only permitted, but required, is more accurate.[176] For this reason, Gregory takes up the particular lexis of the various literary genres, their dialect and their stylization. The total lack of a Christian poetic tradition, which would have provided him with a stylistic tone and way of expressing himself, certainly worked against him. But despite these limitations, Gregory does not come to our attention as a makeshift poet, and in his poetry he managed to achieve a body of work of great importance in the history of culture: he gave us a first, important attempt to give a form to Christian poetry, consciously taking possession of a literary genre that had up to that point been neglected.

[173] Trisoglio rightly said that Wyss' attitude towards Gregory was 'severe', Francesco Trisoglio, 'San Gregorio di Nazianzo' (1973), 242-3.
[174] B. Wyss, 'Zu Gregor von Nazianz' (1946), 3 n. 10.
[175] *Ibid*. 11.
[176] *Ibid*.

Chapter III
A Christian Philosophy

Extant … libri … Cappadocumque Basilii, Gregorii, Amphilochii: qui omnes in tantum philosophorum doctrinis atque sententiis suos resarciunt libros, ut nescias quid in illis primum admirari debeas, eruditionem saeculi, an scientiam Scripturarum (Hieron., *epist.* 70,4).

Just as the Cappadocians used the literary forms learned at school to speak to their public, composed of Christians and pagans, so they employed philosophy to develop various aspects of their doctrine. The philosophy of non-Christians was not for them – as it had not been for their masters, Clement and Origen – a simple instrument of human reason, but a way to clarify, in an increasingly problematic cultural context replete with debates, the *kerygma* considered true in the pro- or anti-Nicene controversies. It has rightly been said that 'the harmonious integration of theology, philosophy and spirituality' is typical of the 'most pure Cappadocian spirit'.[1] Research on this topic would require a separate study:[2] consequently now we do not reconsider those problems in which we do not find any substantial differences in their thinking[3] (for example, apophatism

[1] See G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), XII; the distinction between philosophy and theology in the Cappadocians is a 'false disjunction of modernity', S. Coakley, 'Introduction – Gender' (2003), 2, provided we do not assert it in an absolute way: suffice it to think of Jerome, quoted here *in exergo*.

[2] Naturally, it is not possible to cite all of them. An entire book was dedicated to the topic by H. Dörrie, M. Altenburger and U. Schramm (eds), *Gregor von Nyssa und die Philosophie* (1976), but the particular contributions are very numerous. Moreover, I mention, just to indicate an essay that was important in its time, H.F. Cherniss, *The Platonism of Gregory of Nyssa* (1930); J.F. Callahan, *Greek Philosophy and the Cappadocian Cosmology* (1958), 29-57; B. Otis, *Cappadocian Thought* (1958), 90-124. More recently: R. Mortley, *From Word to Silence* vol. II (1986); H.R. Drobner and C. Klock (eds), *Studien zu Gregor von Nyssa* (1989); Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e Letteratura* (1997); *id*., *Storia del pensiero cristiano tardoantico* (2014); A. Meredith, 'Plotinus and the Cappadocians' (2003), 63-75; S.R.C. Lilla, *Neuplatonisches Gedankengut* (2004); *id*., *Dionigi l'Areopagita e il platonismo cristiano* (2005); M. Edwards, *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2019). There is an extensive synthesis by Matthieu Cassin, '34a Grégoire de Nysse' (2018), 534-70 (not only dealing with philosophy). The treatment of this subject by W.-D. Hauschild, 'Die Großen Kappadokier' (2018), 1522-69 is, instead, very limited.

[3] Naturally, this does not mean that apophatism or the other problems we have indicated here are obvious or trivial, for an introduction see G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 95-147. The problem of whether God can actually be known, and how, was approached differently from Apologetics onwards: of course, here I am excluding the simplest and least interesting aspect, even if Christian writers did not neglect it, that is, that God is known not through the senses (stated above all against idolatry), but in an intelligible way (and here a simple form of Platonism could have been useful). A really negative theology in the manner of the Areopagite

and the unknowability of God, the need to seek Him through the intellect or through His works, which are manifested in the created world; the disposition of reality, according to a universally accepted Platonic conception, on two levels of unequal value; the linguistic doctrines of Basil and Gregory of Nyssa).[4] We will also see that the *communis opinio* which, in the examination of philosophical doctrines, considers Basil and Gregory of Nyssa almost exclusively and excludes Gregory of Nazianzus, is unjustified.

And in any case, even if there is no longer the opposition between philosophy and theology that was thought to exist in past centuries, the problem is not solved, on the contrary: to what extent have Christian writers resorted to pagan philosophy to discuss, examine and finally resolve the problems under discussion, which were the most difficult problems of Christian doctrine? We must avoid extremes and be careful not to attribute decisive value to apparent parallels with philosophy and not to deduce hastily dependencies and derivations, as has often happened in recent studies, which do not take into account either concrete elements that prevent us from assuming such dependence or 'Realien' which cannot be ignored: for example, what real possibilities did the Cappadocians have of reading certain philosophical texts? Or what interest did they have in doing so, possibly finding in philosophy the solution they were seeking? What was the effective diffusion, outside the philosophical schools, of such 'technical' texts, such as the logical ones of Porphyry (who, according to the most recent studies, seems to have been the philosopher who provided the greatest number of tools to interpret Christian theology) or the 'esoteric' ones of Iamblichus?[5] Before asserting, as is normally – but hastily – done, that the theology of the Cappadocians uses Greek philosophy without problems, it is necessary to clarify these difficulties.

Some Preliminary Questions

For this reason it seems appropriate to bear in mind the prudent, even though in part excessive, considerations which were put forward, a long time ago, by Heinrich Dörrie,[6] who maintained that Christian Platonism had never existed

was not yet conceived by the Cappadocians: it is evident that Basil was not very interested in apophatism, unlike Clement of Alexandria; Gregory of Nyssa adopted the two attitudes, both Basil's and Clement's, A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nyssa* (2009), 129-42, in particular 140-1.

[4] Cf. M. DelCogliano, *Basil of Caesarea's Anti-Eunomian Theory of Names* (2010).

[5] For example, K. Corrigan, 'Οὐσία and ὑπόστασις' (2008), 114-34. We should not speak of 'sources', Kerrigan observed, but of 'trends', but then he too insists on the derivation of the Cappadocians from Porphyry, Plotinus, Iamblichus.

[6] Cf. H. Dörrie, 'Was ist spätantiker Platonismus?' (1971) (= *Platonica Minora* (1976), 508-23, above all 515-22); *id*., 'Gregors Theologie auf dem Hintergrunde' (1976), 21-42.

nor could it exist, because with regard to many problems (for example in cosmology) Christians could not replace their tradition, which dated back to the Scriptures, with the doctrines of the Neo-Platonists. In Platonism there were, moreover, other doctrines that no Christian could accept, as Clement, Eusebius, Athanasius had not accepted them. It is not enough to note that there was an agreement between the Cappadocians and non-Christian philosophers, such as Plotinus and Porphyry: Gregory of Nyssa certainly knew them, but no one reproached him for having been a philosopher by deriving his doctrines from them. We must always ask ourselves how he took up and reworked what he had obtained through his readings. We cannot therefore simply search for sources. In Gregory of Nyssa there are also words removed from the Platonic context, the so-called 'erratic citations' ('Wanderzitate'). For this reason, to note that Platonism is present in the Cappadocian doctrine means tackling the problem superficially. The idea of a Christian Platonism had been a 19th-century Concordist-type of invention, due to the revival of classical studies: it is inappropriate to speak of Platonism, if in Christian Platonism only peripheral realities are taken into account, such as *Bildersprache*, metaphors and comparisons. Faced with an assumption of what is typical of Platonism, the Fathers, with a few exceptions, have always consciously rejected it and subjected the Platonic doctrines to profound changes, which sacrificed what was essential in Platonism. The latter only penetrated Christianity in a few, mostly external, aspects; otherwise, as far as its philosophical and religious substance is concerned, it was overcome. If Christian Platonism is placed alongside paganism in order to establish a comparison, the fundamental point of the problem is not considered in the proper light: we behave as if Platonism consisted of formal elements ('Formalien') easily transferable from one thinker to another, and the fact that the substance of Platonism was never received by Christians is overlooked. It is therefore important to consider how the quotation was made and received in the context. On the contrary, the modifications consciously introduced into Christian thought are decisive. The fundamental doctrines of Platonism, such as the gradation of divinity, the existence of the world without a beginning, the unchangeable manifestation of the Logos, the transmigration of souls and the return of the rational soul to its origin, were all, without exception, rejected by the Church. From Christology and pneumatology the idea that the Son or the Spirit had a lower rank was painstakingly eliminated. For Christians, the work of the Logos is founded on a salvific action and not on a revelation that took place in ancient times. Not the soul that knows, but the soul that believes is certain to return to the Father. Not the knowledge of the intellect, based on the Logos, but the paradoxical act of grace brings about redemption and salvation. Faith in the resurrection of the flesh has a distinctly anti-Platonic imprint; for Platonism, immortality is founded in the supra-individual reality, that is, in the intellectual communion of all intelligent beings, while Christian dogma announces the immortality of the individual, enlightened,

yes, but, in any case, based in the body. Consequently, 'Christians were always anti-Platonic'.

When Dörrie's works were published, a lively debate arose, but it became later obvious that the antagonism between Platonism and Christianity had been presented too starkly by Dörrie and an assessment (providing it was prudent) not only of the differences between Platonism and Christianity, but also of the influence of the former on the latter, was in any case legitimate.[7] The same problem can be found in a different environment and in a different person, such as Ambrose, whose mystical doctrines are strongly influenced by Neo-Platonism: 'Gregory of Nyssa differs from Plotinus in a very similar way (as Ambrose)… There is an adaptation of Platonism in central points, but this kind of adaptation is also a modification and a reduction, seemingly fitting Platonism in the "bed of Procrustes". Platonism and Christianity are not totally opposed ways of thinking, but in Christian theology there is a point that determines the adaptation of Non-Christian material: the concept of God'.[8] Therefore Basil 'is a fine exemple of how the Greek philosophical tradition was appropriated and re-expressed when employed in issues of specifically Christian interest'.[9] Consequently, the Christian writers (and the Cappadocians) reserved for themselves the freedom of criticism of a doctrine which was, nevertheless, useful for deepening the message of tradition and the definition of dogma.[10]

Similarly, John Rist, even if he considered only one problem, that of Plotinus' influence on the Cappadocians, was skeptical about the assumed Platonism of the Cappadocians: reconsidering the *De spiritu*, an anonymous work that contains Plotinus' doctrines and which shows points of contact with those of Basil,[11] Rist affirmed that the presence in Basil of the Neo-Platonic philosophy, and of Plotinus in particular, is very limited and must be accepted only in the few cases in which it is actually ascertained.[12] He subsequently confirms his 'minimalist' interpretation of Plotinus' influence, by also considering (in an inadequate way, in my opinion) the Platonism of Gregory of Nyssa and Gregory Nazianzen (as well as of Marius Victorinus and Augustin).[13] Basil, observes Rist, employed Plotinus (*Enn*. VI 9 indirectly and V 2 directly[14] and perhaps

[7] Cf. C.J. de Vogel, 'Platonism and Christianity' (1985), 1-62.

[8] Cfr. V.H. Drecoll, 'Neuplatonismus und Christentum bei Ambrosius' (2001), 104.

[9] M. DelCogliano, 'Basil of Caesarea versus Eunomius of Cyzicus' (2014), 532.

[10] Recently, and among others, L. Ayres, *Nicaea and ist Legacy* (2004), 388-91; A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea's Anti-Eunomian Theory of Names* (2010), 172-3 do not consider the opposition between Platonism and Christianity to be valid.

[11] P. Henry, *Études Plotiniennes* I. *Les états du texte de Plotin* (1938) and, with some modifications, H. Dehnhard, *Das Problem der Abhängigkeit* (1964) had affirmed Basil's dependence on Plotinus (V 1).

[12] J. Rist, 'Basil's "Neoplatonism"' (1981).

[13] J. Rist, 'Plotinus and Christian Philosophy' (1996).

[14] *Ibid*. 398.

also I 7 and II 9) in the ninth chapter of *De Spiritu sancto* and before the composition of that work (in 375) he knew Plotinus V 1 and IV 7 through Eusebius. Gregory of Nazianzus knew even less of Plotinus and Gregory of Nyssa little more than what is to be found in *De virginitate*; he proposes the doctrine of the infinity of God with much insistence, unlike Plotinus, who was much more reserved[15] but this does not mean that it didn't exist. With good reason, on the contrary Rist observes that the Cappadocians, although writing more than a century after Plotinus, do not only know Neo-Platonism, but also (and perhaps above all) the previous Platonism, which for them was simply 'Platonism':[16] Gregory of Nyssa himself would utilize Middle Platonism more than Neo-Platonism[17] and one should not speak of 'dependence' on Neo-Platonism, but of 'parallelism'.[18]

Criticism, however, has almost always gone in the opposite direction to that proposed by Dörrie and Rist,[19] but in my opinion caution is appropriate especially in the context of Trinitarian theology, even if the Cappadocians certainly knew more about Neo-Platonism than Rist is willing to admit. Furthermore, the Cappadocians took into account the doctrines of the School of Alexandria, where Platonism had already been developed in depth, so that the Platonism they found in Clement and Origen had no less of an impact on them than contemporary Platonism: there are, hence, many Platonic 'voices' in their philosophy.[20]

But in any case, as we will see, philosophy had a partial impact on Trinitarian theology, and this is a very delicate problem, because it is necessary to evaluate the real significance of philosophy in its relationship with the Christian tradition.

[15] *Ibid.* 398-9.

[16] *Ibid.* 387 and 395. Rist repeats all this also in 'On the Platonism of Gregory of Nyssa' (2000), 130-1.

[17] According to Rist, Gregory of Nyssa was the author of *De Spiritu*: 'Basil's "Neoplatonism" (1981), 218; *id.*, 'Plotinus and Christian Philosophy' (1996), 398; *id.*, 'On the Platonism' (2000), 132, but this hypothesis does not have a secure confirmation.

[18] J. Rist, 'On the Platonism' (2000), 135. But then the following statement seems contradictory (and could well be in tune also with the thinking of Gregory of Nazianzus): 'Perhaps … Gregory derived much more from Plotinus and Neoplatonism than the direct quotations would indicate. Perhaps the air he breathed was Neoplatonic as well as Origenist…', *id.*, 'Plotinus and Christian Philosophy' (1996), 400. Previously, on the problem Cl. Moreschini, 'Il platonismo cristiano di Gregorio Nazianzeno' (1974) (where the parallelism – not the sources – between Platonic and Christian doctrines, and the transformation of the latter are shown). I admit, however, that the concept of 'parallelism' appears poorly defined, while that of 'source' is much clearer.

[19] With the exception, as far as I have been able to see, of Silke-Petra Bergjan, *Theodoret von Cyrus* (1994), 74-6.

[20] And finally, it should not be thought that the only philosophy which influenced the Cappadocians was Platonism: Zachhuber observes that 'traditionally, the term "Platonism" was thought to explain practically everything which in patristic writings seemed to be alien to the spirit of Scripture', J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa* (2000), 6. See also M. Edwards, *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2019), 77.

1. *To Talk about God (θεολογία)*

Simplicity

Divine nature, whatever it is, is 'simple', that is, its whole remains the same and does not have in itself parts or differences, because difference means something which is not divine: if it is so, God is imperfect.[21] God's simplicity had already been fully exploited by Philo (*LA* II 2,2-3) and Origen had stated (*Princ*. I 6,4 in Rufinus' translation) that divine nature is an *intellectualis natura simplex*;[22] the God of the universe 'is mind, or that which transcends mind and being, and is simple and invisible and incorporeal' (*CC* VII 38).[23] Clement of Alexandria applied absolute simplicity to the Father as God.[24]

Eunomius (Basil, *CE* II 29) had denied that God could be σύνθετος, and Basil had accepted this affirmation,[25] but he had explained that the 'essence of the simplicity' (λόγος τῆς ἁπλότητος) of God consisted in the fact that 'God is full life, full light and full goodness (ὅλον ἀγαθόν)', and therefore he who is simple according to the substance cannot be composed. For this reason what reveals the peculiarities of God cannot harm the λόγος τῆς ἁπλότητος.

But later, in *Apologia Apologiae* Eunomius reiterated, in controversy with this explanation of Basil, that it was precisely the latter's Trinitarian doctrine that introduced a σύνθετος God (Greg. Nyss., *CE* III 10,46):

> He also makes God composite (σύνθετον) for us, by suggesting that the Light is common, but that they are distinct one from another by certain characteristics and various differences, for what coincides in one shared aspect, but distinguished by certain differences and sets of characteristics, is no less composite.[26]

Gregory defends Basil, rejecting Eunomius' distinction between inaccessible light, which is the Father, and true light, which is the Son: with these words, Gregory says, also Eunomius had admitted that the substance of God is light, and

[21] L. Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy* (2004), 281 and 286 confines himself to a few considerations on the concept of simplicity (he observes that the term is not used with great precision by the pro-Nicenes, but always consistently). For the concept of 'simplicity' see G.Ch. Stead, 'Divine Simplicity', in R. Williams (ed.), *The Making of Orthodoxy* (1989), 255-69; to which relevant objections are made by L. Ayres, *ibid*. 287 note.

[22] *Natura* is φύσις or οὐσία.

[23] Trans. H. Chadwick, Cambridge 1953.

[24] Because He became incarnate, the Son is not 'one' (*Strom*. IV 25,156). Cf. also A. Meredith, 'The divine simplicity' in L.F. Mateo-Seco y J.L. Bastero, *El "Contra Eunomium I"* (1988), 347: now in M. Brugarolas (ed.), *Gregory of Nyssa: Contra Eunomium I* (2018), 348-9.

[25] Also Gregory of Nyssa in controversy with Eunomius and in defending Basil states: 'The uncreated nature … is attested even by our opponents to be the fount of goodness, simple, uniform and uncompounded' (*CE* I 276).

[26] Trans. Stuart Hall in J. Leemans & M. Cassin (eds), Gregory of Nyssa *Contra Eunomium III* (2014).

that 'inaccessible' and 'true' are only peculiarities of it, so 'also what Eunomius says does not argue the divinity to be composite' (*CE* III 10,47).

Also in *De Spiritu sancto* Basil asserts the simplicity of God: God is 'simple' (*Spir. Sanct.* 6,15); 'without parts' (*ibid.* 9,22) 'not composed' (*ibid.* 18,45). Similarly, Gregory of Nazianzus says that 'to be utterly sinless belongs to God, and to the first and uncompounded nature (ἀσύνθετος) (for simplicity [ἁπλότης], is peaceful, and not subject to dissension), and I venture to say also that it belongs to the Angelic nature too';[27] 'uncompounded nature is better' (ἁπλῆ δέ τε φύσις ἀρείων: *Arc.* 4,92);[28] 'the primary pure nature of Godhead is always unchangeable; there are never many realities in place of one' (ἀνθ' ἑνὸς οὔ ποτε πολλά: *Arc.* 6,48). Nyssen states 'the simple, pure and unique nature, immovable and unalterable, which is always the same and never abandons itself … it remains without changing in the good and doesn't see any boundary in itself' (*Cant. Hom.*; GNO VI 158,8-12); 'the nature of the beauty which is simple, immaterial, formless'[29] (*Virg.* 11,2). Simplicity means that 'with the simple (ἁπλῆς) and omnipotent nature (φύσεως) all things are understood as together and simultaneous' (*CE* III 6,17).

The concept of 'divine simplicity' is proper to Neo-Platonism. Plotinus too asserts the absolute simplicity of the One: 'Since, then, the simple nature of the Good appears to be also primal (for all that is not primal is not simple)…' (II 9,1); 'this name (One) is completely indicative of simplicity (ἁπλότητος)' (V 5,6); 'think … that he is the Good … that he is the One (for he is simple and first) (ἁπλοῦν γὰρ καὶ πρῶτον)' (V 5,10).[30]

But a problem arises from the assertion of simplicity: how can it fit with the multiplicity of the divine excellences? According to Radde-Gallwitz 'the Cappadocians attempt to "save the appearences" of religious language, especially its multiplicity and complexity, without evacuating simplicity of its content'.[31]

[27] Trans. Ph. Schaff.

[28] Trans. Donald A. Sykes, St Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana* (1997), here and for the other quotations from the *Carmina arcana*.

[29] A definition of Platonic origin (ἀσχημάτιστος: *Phaedr.* 247c), like the others. Also Greg. Naz., *Arcana* 7,73: θεότης ἀειδής.

[30] We use Armstrong's translation of Plotinus (LCL). Other examples can be found in the *Lexicon Plotinianum* (1980). This is, therefore, the first time that we refer to Plotinus for the doctrines of the Cappadocians, and we will also do it later. It is necessary, therefore, that we specify from now that we do not think that Plotinus was the source of the Cappadocians, but that the problem of simplicity had also been posed by Plotinus, and that this fact indicates a late ancient cultural *koinè*.

I had found that these passages of Plotinus could constitute a parallel with what Gregory of Nazianzus said, Cl. Moreschini, 'Il platonismo cristiano di Gregorio Nazianzeno' (1974), 1384, later also Anthony Meredith, 'The divine simplicity' (2018), 357-70. On the simplicity of God, see also J.P. Kenney, 'The Mystical Monotheism of Plotinus' (1991), 93-111.

[31] See Andrew Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nyssa* (2009), 13: as Gregory of Nyssa was closer to Basil than to Gregory of Nazianzus, Radde-Gallwitz does not take the

He tries to solve the problem by resorting to the relationship between the one and the multiple of Neoplatonic logic, similarly to how Michel René Barnes had proposed to solve the problem of the relationship between the unity and the multiplicity of divine substance.[32] The divine attributes are *propria* (ἰδιότητες or ἰδιώματα in Bas., *Hexaem.* 4,5), they are 'concurrent with' (σύνδρομον) His essence, but they do not complete His essence (συμπληρωτικὰ τῆς οὐσίας) (Bas., *Hexaem.* 1,8):[33] the term τῇ οὐσίᾳ σύνδρομον ('concurrent with the substance') to indicate the ἐνέργεια of the soul was used by Alexander of Aphrodisias (*An.* 3,5).[34] In the same way Nyssen asserts that the divine goods as *propria* do not need to be identical with the divine nature.[35] Simplicity in God means the unity of all His excellences.

However, I do not believe that the Cappadocians considered the problem as precisely as modern critics do, even using the logic of Porphyry: for them it was essential to believe that all the nature of God was divine, so if He possessed all the virtues this did not mean that God was composite.[36] Balàs had already tried to solve the problem of 'composition vs simplicity' by claiming that God possessed what he possesses absolutely and not by participation, like creatures.[37] In fact, Gregory of Nyssa had affirmed that, in God, the absoluteness of individual good things coincides with the absoluteness of being: 'the nature which is above all human thought and above all δυνάμεις is the totality of goodness (τῶν ἀγαθῶν οὖσα τὸ πλήρωμα) (*An.* GNO III / III, 68.9-12)';[38] 'God is the fulness of the good things (πλήρωμα ἀγαθῶν) (*Opif.* 16,184B).[39] In explaining *Eccl.* 3:7 he states that 'the being that truly is is the good in itself' (*Eccl. Hom.* VII,7, GNO V, 406,1-15) and he agrees with Platonism in calling God 'the first good' (*Virg.* 10); goodness is what really exists: 'what really exists is the nature of the good' (τὸ δὲ κυρίως ὂν ἡ τοῦ ἀγαθοῦ φύσις ἐστί) (*An.* GNO III/III, 69,5). In *CE* III 1,49 Nyssen unifies the Christian teaching

latter into consideration. He notes that according to Gregory of Nyssa 'what we know of the divine nature is its goodness, power, wisdom and so forth, and that these properties by their very nature imply unity', A. Radde-Gallwitz, '*Ad Eustathium de Sancta Trinitate'* (2011), 107.

[32] See M.R. Barnes, *The Power of God* (2001), 273-307; A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea* (2009), 184-5.

[33] *Ibid.* 158-85.

[34] *Ibid.* 159.

[35] *Ibid.* 207; cf. also *ibid.* 17.

[36] An example of this abstract discussion in A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea* (2009), 1-18; more logically and simply, L. Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy* (2004), 279-82 observes that the concept of unitarity in God of all potentialities is implicit in the concept of monotheism.

[37] See D.L. Balàs, Μετουσία Θεοῦ. *Man's participation in God's perfections* (1966), 121-30.

[38] Here I develop what I said in Cl. Moreschini, 'Further Considerations on the Philosophical Background' (2014), 603-4.

[39] I am quoting from this work by Gregory of Nyssa according to the indications of the pages of *Greek Patrology*, but I am following the Forbes edition (Burntisland, 1855) for the text.

about God, who is the totality of the good (cf. *John* 1:16: ἐκ τοῦ πληρώματος αὐτοῦ) and the Neoplatonic tenet that God is the first good:

> Yet the one who is in the bosom of the Father never allows the Paternal bosom to be thought empty of himself. So it is not as something external put into his bosom, but because he is the fullness of all goodness, the one who is 'in the beginning' (*John* 1:1) is deemed to be in the Father, not waiting to be generated in him by creation, so that the Father might not ever be deemed wanting in good things. Rather, the one deemed to be in the eternity of the Father's Godhead is forever in him, being Power, Life, Truth, Light, Wisdom, and so on.

Therefore, in God being and all the qualities coincide. This is highlighted above all for the good: being and the good coincide, because the good does not come from outside God, God does not possess it by participation. In fact, participation in the good only applies to created reality (both the material and the intelligible: *CE* I 283-287; *Refut.* 122). The real good is the total good (αὐτὸ τὸ ὄντως ἀγαθόν, ὃ δὴ καὶ πᾶν ἐστιν ἀγαθόν) (*Opif.* 19; PG 44, 197A). Simplicity, therefore, does not exclude, in God, multiplicity, because the various goods of God have to be understood in their totality and therefore have, necessarily, to coincide: there cannot be more than one absolute. Life, truth, light possess, in God, precisely for this reason, the characteristic of 'being in itself'. This is confirmed by the Scriptures (*CE* III 7,51); 'Since therefore God is essentially life, and the Only-begotten God is God and Life and Truth (cf. *John* 11:25; 14:6) and every conceivable thing that is sublime and God-befitting' (*CE* III 6,75). The life of God is 'eternal and absolute life' (*Catech.* 1,6; GNO III/IV, 10,1); it is the real life (*Refut.* 174-175).

Gregory of Nazianzus, instead, thinks that simplicity does not constitute the very nature of God, because, in that case, God could also be comprehensible, which is absurd:

> The Divine, then, is boundless and difficult to contemplate: the only thing completely comprehensible about it is its boundlessness – even though some think that the fact of its simple nature makes it either completely incomprehensible or perfectly comprehensible! Let us, then, investigate what it means to be of a simple nature. Simplicity, after all, is not itself its nature, just as being composite is not the whole nature of composite beings (οὐ γὰρ δὲ τοῦτο φύσις αὐτῷ, ἡ ἁπλότης, εἴπερ μηδὲ τοῖς συνθέτοις μόνον τὸ εἶναι συνθέτοις) (*Orat.* 38,7).[40]

Nazianzen, therefore, ascribes to simplicity a more attenuated meaning than Basil and Nyssen. Evagrius Ponticus, in turn, takes a different position, stating that the simplicity of God is an absolute simplicity and not numerical (*Epistula*

[40] Trans. Brian E. Daley (2006).

fidei = Bas., *Epist*. 8,10, I 34,28-30 Courtonne) (and this holds true above all against tritheism, as we will see later, and also to affirm the divinity of the Holy Spirit (34,30-35)). Also later, when he was a monk in the Egyptian desert, Evagrius repeats that God does not have qualities (*KG* I 1; I 2; II 47; V 62).

Infiniteness

In the first part of the above-mentioned *Orat*. 38,7, Gregory states that God is incomprehensible because He is infinite,[41] and explains His infiniteness as follows: '(God) is always, and gives himself this name when he identifies himself to Moses on the Mountain.[42] For he contains the whole of being in himself, without beginning or end, like an endless, boundless ocean of reality (πέλαγος οὐσίας ἄπειρον καὶ ἀόριστον)' (*Orat*. 38,7).[43] This is repeated in *Arcana* 4,70-2: 'All things stand before God, future, past, and presently existing. For me, time has created division between events which come before and after. But where God is concerned, all things come together into unity and within the arms of his powerful Godhead they are supported (θεῷ δέ τε εἰς ἓν ἅπαντα / καὶ μεγάλης θεότητος ἐν ἀγκοίνῃσι κρατεῖται)'. The future is excluded from God, since the moment when God has something he does not already have cannot occur, while the past and the future can only be applied to corruptible natures.[44]

Infiniteness must be understood as the lack of limit at the beginning and at the end; eternity (αἰών), which belongs to eternal things, 'spread out coextensively with their being' and differs from time (χρόνος), 'measured by the movement of the sun', as the Stoics and Philo of Alexandria had affirmed (*Opif*. 26,4; *Aetern*. 6,4; 52,5-7) (*Orat*. 38,8).[45] As with the concept of simplicity, so with that of eternity and time we find a parallel in Plotinus. Also Plotinus, after reiterating (*Enn*. III 7,1) the usual attribution of eternity to nature that always is and of time to nature that is born and perishes, had assigned eternity to the intelligible world, in which the fullness of being is found, with the absolute exclusion of the future, as it is not possible to conceive, for the intelligible

[41] He repeates it in *Arcana* 5,1-2: 'the infinite great Mind' (ἀπείρων Νοῦς μέγας).

[42] The usual interpretation by the Cappadocians of *Exodus* 3:14, as we will soon see.

[43] The expression πέλαγος οὐσίας would be taken up in the Middle Ages, also in the West (cf. also Dante Alighieri, *Paradiso* I 113: 'per lo gran mar dell'essere'), after Gregory's *Oration* had been translated into Latin. Rufinus translates it as *substantiae pelagus* (see p. 359), and Daley as 'ocean of reality': but would not 'ocean of being' be better? Gregory of Nyssa also used an analogous definition (πέλαγος ἀχανές) for the nature of God (*CE* I 363).

[44] Also in *Orat*. 29,3 Gregory distinguishes between the infinite 'being now' of God, which is eternity, and the finite 'being now', of corruptible nature, which is time, defined by Gregory as the 'movement of the sun', according to Plat., *Tim*. 37d.

[45] See also V. Cvetkovic, 'St. Gregory's argument' (2011), 370-1.

world, an existence to which something is added later that it previously did not have:

That, then, which was not, and will not be, but *is* only, which has being which is static by not changing to the 'will be',[46] nor even having changed, this is eternity. The life, then, which belongs to that which exists and is in being, altogether and full, completely without extension or interval, is that which we are looking for, eternity (III 7,3) (trans. Armstrong).

Plotinus concludes, therefore, that what is always, with the exclusion of the past and the future, is eternity, and that eternal being means really being:

For true being is never being, or being otherwise; and this is being always the same; and this is being without any difference (…). For existing is not one thing and always existing another. … So, too, 'always' is applied to 'existing', that is *aei* to on, so that we say *aei* on, so the 'always' must be taken as saying 'truly existing'; it must be included in the undivided power which in no way needs anything beyond what it already possesses; but it possesses the whole (III 7,6).

On the contrary, time, which is the image of eternity, is linked to the life of the soul and is not the measure of the movement of the stars (*Enn*. III 7,11). Gregory could not accept the doctrine of the cosmic soul, let alone adapt eternity to the soul: eternity, therefore, could only be an attribute of the Divine Intellect.[47]

According to Mühlenberg, the doctrine of the infiniteness of God is typical of Gregory of Nyssa,[48] who had come to the conclusion that God is infinite in opposing Greek philosophy, according to which the term 'infinite' only has a negative value, as a sign of disorder; Origen himself had been uncertain whether to accept the infiniteness of God. Infinitude is not implicit even in the Platonic type of negative theology, which Gregory professed: in fact, to remove from God any qualitative delimitations (being formless, without measure, without matter, without distinction etc.) does not imply it. Also according to Gregory

[46] This concept of being 'static' was also known to Gregory of Nyssa (*CE* I 371): 'But the self-sufficient, eternal nature (…) is perceived by faith alone as before and above these things … but *standing by itself and constituted in itself* (ἐφ'ἑαυτῆς ἑστῶσα καὶ ἐν ἑαυτῇ καθιδρυμένη)', trans. Stuart G. Hall, in L.F. Mateo-Seco and J.L. Bastero, *El "Contra Eunomium I* = Miguel Brugarolas (ed.), *Gregory of Nyssa* [2018]). The concept of στάσις for the One also in Plot. VI 9,11; also in the Homoiousian texts: ὑφεστὸς πάγιον (Epiph., *Haer*. 73,3,6) and ἐν ὑποστάσει παγίᾳ (*ibid*. 73,8,2).

[47] It is noteworthy that this interpretation of mine of Gregory Nazianzen, which would depend upon Plotinus for the two concepts of eternity and time, had already been proposed by Michael Psellos, who in his tract 41 (περὶ αἰῶνος καὶ χρόνου, *Philosophica Minora* I, ed. J.M. Duffy, 1992) explains Gregory's definition by quoting Plotinus (III 7), as he himself declares in concluding: ταῦτά σοι ἐκ τῶν Πλωτινείων ἀδύτων ἠρανισάμην ἐς ὅσον οἷόν τε μετὰ τοῦ σαφοῦς ἐξαγγείλας.

[48] Cf. E. Mühlenberg, *Die Unendlichkeit Gottes bei Gregor von Nyssa* (1966). Subsequently also A.-K. Geljon, 'Divine Infinity in Gregory of Nyssa' (2005) maintains that God's infiniteness comes from His simplicity and immutability.

of Nyssa the human intellect, which always operates on a dimensional level, cannot understand a nature that has no dimensions or limitations either in space or in time, that is eternity (*Eccl. Hom.*; GNO V, 412-3; *CE* I 168; I 276; I 367; II 291). Therefore, he attributes infiniteness to God:

> The blissful and eternal nature, which is superior to all intelligence and which holds all beings within itself, is not contained in anything; nothing can be observed about it, neither time, nor space, nor colour, nor figure, nor shape, nor weight, nor size, nor spatial interval, nor any other delimiting name, thing or concept; on the contrary, all the good that is thought about it is resolved in infinity and indeterminacy; the simple, pure and unique nature, unchangeable and unalterable, which is always in the same state and which never abandons itself … remains indeterminate in the good, and sees no limits in itself (*Cant. Hom.*; GNO VI, 157,14-21 and 158,8-12).[49]

Plotinus had already affirmed that the infiniteness of the One derives from his absolute simplicity: 'This phrase "beyond being" does not mean that it is a particular being […] But if this is what the phrase does, it in no way comprehends the One: it would be absurd to seek to comprehend that boundless nature (τὴν ἄπλετον φύσιν)' (V 5,6).[50] Plotinus had also stated that the unknowability of the One is due to his infiniteness:

> But he is not unlimited like a magnitude either… But he has infinity in the sense of power (τὸ δ'ἄπειρον ᾗ δύναμις ἔχει)… And this has infinity (καὶ τὸ ἄπειρον τούτῳ) by not being more than one and because there is nothing in which anything belonging to it will find its limit: for by being one it is not measured and does not come within range of number (V 5,10-11).[51]

Being and Transcendence

Middle-Platonism, and therefore also the theology of the School of Alexandria, follows two contrasting schemes when it intends defining divine reality: it either

[49] According to Gregory of Nyssa, God is not only infinite, but also infinitely good, because it is an essential condition of God: 'The Divine One is himself the Good (in the primary and proper sense of the word), whose very nature is goodness. This he is and he is so named, and is known by this nature. Since, then, it has not been demonstrated that there is any limit to virtue except evil, and since the Divine does not admit of an opposite, we hold the divine nature to be unlimited and infinite. Certainly, whoever pursues true virtue participates in nothing other than God, because he is himself absolute virtue. Since, then, those who know what is good by nature desire participation in it, and since this good has no limit, the participant's desire itself necessarily has no stopping place but stretches out with the limitless' (*Moys.* prol. 5,5) (trans. A.J. Malherbe and E. Ferguson [New York, 1978]). The incomprehensibility of God derives from this infiniteness, observes Lenka Karfíková, '*Ad Ablabium, quod non sint tres dei*' (2011), 144-5.

[50] Also J. Rist, 'On the Platonism' (2000), 136-42 believes that the concept of infinity for the One is found in Plotinus, but much more limited, and rightly links the importance that Gregory of Nyssa attached to the concept of the infiniteness of God with his doctrine of *epektasis* (*ibid.* 142-7).

[51] On the infinity of the One see also Plot. VI 9,6,10.

coincides with absolute being or is superior to being, according to the interpretation of a famous passage of the Plato's *Republic* (509b), which places the good above being.[52] The neo-Pythagoreans Eudorus and Moderatus had argued that the first principle is superior to both intellect and being; there were various opinions among the Middle Platonists: according to Plutarch the first god is not transcendent to being, but is absolute being and intellect (*de* E 391F-392A; 393A-B; *Is*. 371A); Celsus, instead, had placed the god above the intellect and being (Orig., *Contra Celsum* VII 45). Numenius, according to some due to the influence of Jewish culture,[53] defines the first intellect 'existing in itself' (αὐτοόν) (fr. 17 des Places), while a passage by an unknown hermetic writer, quoted by Lactantius (*Div*. *Instit*. I 6,4), refers to god when he says that 'he who is is without names', because names define him, and therefore limit him.

Such an emphasis can already be found in Philo: God is 'better than the good itself and the beautiful itself" (κρείττων ἢ αὐτὸ τὸ ἀγαθὸν καὶ αὐτὸ τὸ καλόν) (*Opif*. 8); God is καὶ ἀγαθοῦ κρεῖττον (*Praem*. 40). This oscillation between the conception either that God is being in an absolute sense or is also above being, is found, after Philo, also in the Christian Platonists. According to Clement:

> God … being not a subject for demonstration, cannot be the object of science. But the Son is wisdom, and knowledge, and truth, and all else that has affinity thereto. He is also susceptible of demonstration and of description. … And the Son is neither simply one thing as one thing, nor many things as parts, but one thing as all things; whence also He is all things. For He is the circle of all powers rolled and united into one unity. Wherefore the Word is called the Alpha and the Omega (*Strom*. IV 25,156).

Origen considers both solutions acceptable: 'we would have to discover whether God "transcends being in rank and power"[54] or whether he is Himself being' (*Contra Celsum* VI 64); 'since we affirm that the God of the universe is mind, or that he transcends mind and being' (*ibid*. VII 38). In this way Origen does not seem far from Celsus. Also for Origen, the Father is absolutely unknown to human reason (*ibid*. VI 65), while the Son is knowable in His multiplicity, although He is God no differently than the Father:

> Now God is altogether one and simple; but our Saviour, for many reasons, since God set Him forth a propitiation and a first fruits of the whole creation, is made many things

[52] This passage of the *Republic* was used very frequently by the School of Alexandria; also Gregory of Nazianzus, taking up again *Resp*. 508c, stated (*Orat*. 28,30) that 'as a non-Christian writer puts it: "the Sun has the same place in things of sense as God has in things ideal"'. Cf. also *Orat*. 40,5.

[53] Cf. Numenius' famous phrase, recalled by Clement of Alexandria (*Strom*. I 22,150,4), that Plato would have been 'a Moses who spoke Attic'. Nevertheless, Mark Edwards corrected the *communis opinio* as regards the meaning of this expression ('Atticizing Moses?' [1990]).

[54] Plat., *Resp*. 509b.

(ὁ θεὸς μὲν οὖν πάντη ἕν ἐστι καὶ ἁπλοῦν, ὁ δὲ σωτὴρ ἡμῶν διὰ τὰ πολλά, ἐπεὶ προέθετο αὐτὸν ὁ θεὸς ἱλαστήριον καὶ ἀπαρχὴν πάσης τῆς κτίσεως, πολλὰ γίνεται) (*Comm. Ioh.* I 20,119).

An authoritative text for the doctrine of the being of God was *Exod.* 3:14, which is normally interpreted as: 'I am he who is', that is, according to being in the full sense, instead of 'I am that I am'.[55] Philo had already asserted (*Quod det.* 160 and *Mut. nom.* 11) that this statement is equivalent to: 'my nature is to be, not to be adequately named', but, in any case man, even if he cannot know the qualities of God, can at least know His existence (*Somn.* I 231).[56] Thus Philo introduces the distinction, which became constant in the following centuries, between the existence of God, who is the object of rational knowledge, and the essence of God, which transcends not only knowledge, but also being.[57] Origen also refers to *Exod.* 3:14 when he says that the immutable nature of God is conveniently expressed by the name 'he who is' (*Comm. Ioh.* XIII 21,123).

Similarly to Philo and Origen, according to the Cappadocians *Exod.* 3:14 does not simply indicate the existence of God,[58] but the fullness of his being. Gregory of Nyssa states:

> that which is always the same, neither increasing nor diminishing, immutable to all change whether to better or to worse (for it is far removed from the inferior and it has no superior), standing in need of nothing else, alone desirable, participated in by all but not lessened by their participation – this is truly real Being. And the apprehension of it is the knowledge of truth (*Moys.* II 24-5).[59]

[55] M. Harl, 'Citations et commentaires d'Ex 3,14' (1978), 101-4, above all for Basil and Gregory of Nyssa; also M. Canévet, *Grégoire de Nysse et l'herméneutique biblique* (1983), 102. Also in the West, in those years, Jerome (*Epist.* 15,2) knew this meaning: *Deus solus qui aeternus est, hoc est, qui exordium non habet, essentiae nomen vere tenet. Idcirco et ad Moysen de rubo loquitur: Ego sum qui sum: et rursum: Qui est, me misit* – but it is an interpretation proposed everywhere.

[56] Naturally Philo had not said that 'I am He who is' is *the name* of God, but only the way God makes himself known (*Moys.* 2,114). On this subject, see M. La Matina, 'God is not the Name of God' (2011).

[57] The problem was taken up again by Eunomius, who reproached Basil for 'worshipping what he does not know', precisely because Basil maintained that the nature of God was not knowable, but only his existence. Basil replied to this dilemma in *Epistles* 234 and 235 and the discussion was resumed by Gregory of Nazianzus (*Orat.* 30,17-8) precisely to explain that we can worship God, although we do not know His nature.

[58] In enunciating the name 'God', Gregory of Nyssa oscillates between the masculine and the neuter (τὸ θεῖον) forms, as Plato had already done (*Tim.* 38c and 28c), A. Meredith, *The idea of God* (1990), 131-2. The neuter ('the divine being') is also found in *CE* II 70; sometimes the expression that replaces the word 'God' can be understood both as masculine and as neuter (*CE* I 422). Often Gregory of Nyssa uses the term 'nature', which implies that this expression is closer to the use of the neuter, as shown by the series of epithets in *CE* (I 231) and in *Cant. Hom.* (GNO VI, 158,9, 174,3).

[59] Trans. Abraham J. Malherbe and Everett Ferguson (New York, 1978). See also *An.* (GNO III/III 71,7-11).

And Gregory of Nazianzus:

'He who is' and 'God' are in some special way names of his essence … 'He who is' has the superiority here. He used it of himself, in delivering his oracles to Moses on the mountain… Nevertheless it is a relational, not an absolute term…[60] But we are making deeper inquiries into a nature which has absolute existence, independent of anything else. The actual, personal being of God in its fullness is neither limited nor cut short by any prior or any subsequent reality (*Orat*. 30,18).[61]

But according to him (*Orat*. 25,17) the being of God is not the same as the being of the material and created reality and, taking up the affirmation of Origen's *Contra Celsum*, he repeats that God can also be considered above being (*Orat*. 6,12)[62]: 'God is the fairest and most exalted of the things that exist, unless one prefers to think of Him as even transcending all being or to place the sum total of existence in Him, from whom also it flows to everything else'.[63] This union and contrast between fullness of being, which according to Origen is characteristic of the Son, and transcendence of being, which is characteristic of the Father, is no longer acceptable during the Anti-Eunomian controversy.[64] In fact, Gregory of Nyssa states:

Since therefore the Only-begotten God is by nature the Good, or rather beyond every Good (ἐπεὶ οὖν φύσει τὸ ἀγαθόν, μᾶλλον δὲ παντὸς ἀγαθοῦ ἐπέκεινα ὁ μονογενὴς θεός), and the Good is not unintended by the Father, this clearly demonstrates that the bond (συνάφεια) of the Son with the Father is immediate, and also that the will which exists for ever in (ἐνυπάρχον) the good nature is not expelled nor excluded by the inseparable bond (*CE* III 6,18)[65].

[60] In fact the name Θεός cannot be the name of God, because it derives from θέω (cf. Plat., *Crat*. 397d), or from θεάομαι, as Gregory of Nyssa also repeats (*Eustath*.; GNO III/I 14,7; *Abl*.; GNO III/I 44,10, 52,13).

[61] Trans. Lionel Wickham and F. Williams, in *Faith gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991). See also *Orat*. 31,23.

[62] That God is beyond being (ἐπέκεινα τῆς οὐσίας) is also affirmed by a poem found in the corpus of Gregory of Nazianzus' poems (*Hymnus ad Deum* I 1.29,1; PG 37, 507-8), but which is probably spurious: 'O you who are beyond all things (ὦ πάντων ἐπέκεινα)'.

[63] Trans. Vinson.

[64] This distinction is criticized by G. Stead, 'Ontology and Terminology in Gregory of Nissa' (1976). A. Meredith, *The Idea of God* (1990), 127-8 seems to follow Stead, but specifies that 'Stead starts from a "primary conception" of God and assumes that everything Gregory has to say about it must agree with that conception', and also S. Coakley, 'Introduction – Gender' (2003), 7. Dörrie, to highlight the contrast between Christianity and Platonism on the problem of the being of God, maintains that in the seventh of the homilies on *Ecclesiastes*, Gregory abandons the Neo-Platonic conception that God is superior even to being, because it is at variance with Christianity, H. Dörrie, 'Gregors Theologie auf dem Hintergrunde' (1976), 36-7, but this definition not only is not in contrast with Christianity, but, as we have seen, dates back to Origen.

[65] Trans. Stuart G. Hall, in Johan Leemans & Matthieu Cassin (eds), Gregory of Nyssa *Contra Eunomium III* (2014).

As we see, that God is beyond goodness is affirmed by Nyssen, but there is no difference between the Father and the Son: ὃ περὶ τὸ πρῶτον ἀγαθὸν καὶ τὸ ἐπέκεινα παντὸς ἀγαθοῦ θεωρεῖται (*Virg*. 10,1); τοῦτο τοίνυν τὸ ἀγαθὸν ἤτοι ὑπὲρ τὸ ἀγαθὸν αὐτό τε ὡς ἀληθῶς ἐστι (*Eccl. Hom*.; GNO VII 406,9-18); Θεὸς … παντὸς ἀγαθοῦ τοῦ νοουμένου τε καὶ καταλαμβανομένου ἐπέκεινα ὤν (*Opif*. 16; PG 44, 184A); τὸ ἀληθῶς ἀγαθὸν ἤτοι τὸ ἐπέκεινα τοῦ ἀγαθοῦ (*in Psalm*. I 1; GNO V, 26,12); *Beat*. 8; GNO VII/II, 164,13-14; *An*.; GNO III/III, 68,18-69,4; *Refut*. 8. According to Aubineau,[66] Gregory deduced his theory of God's absolute transcendence from Plotinus (*Enn*. I 6,9), rather than from Philo. It is difficult to establish whether it was one or the other writer, as they were both known to Gregory of Nyssa. In any case, transcendence is also a prerogative of the Son, not only of the Father.[67] It can be concluded, therefore, that, within the common doctrine on God, Basil prefers to insist on attributing to God the fullness of being and that Gregory of Nazianzus and, even more, Gregory of Nyssa insist on transcendence also to being, in the tradition of Origen, thus also taking up again the idea that transcendence does not only concern being, but also the good.

In conclusion, Eunomius believed that the title of 'he who is' should only be used to refer to the Father, while the Son would be 'not existing, nor strictly existing', 'he who is in the bosom of Him who is, he who is "in the beginning", and who is "with God"' (Greg. Nyss., *CE* III 8,34; see also 8,43; 9,34; *Refut*. 20 e 29). Basil replies also attributing to the Son being 'he who is': 'he who found, in the response that he gave to his servant Moses who questioned him, the specific denomination *for himself* and suitable for his eternity' (*CE* II 18, 609A).[68] Gregory of Nyssa takes up Basil's criticism of Eunomius: the one who led the Jews out of Egypt was not an angel, but it was the Lord Himself, Who had the function of the angel (*CE* III 9,27). By adding *Exod*. 3:14 to *Phil*. 2:9 ('Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name'), Gregory of Nyssa explains that the Son is said to be 'angel' in as much as he manifests the Father, while he is said to be 'existing' in as much as he does not have a name that makes his essence known, but he is superior to any meaning produced by names (*CE* III 9,41).[69]

[66] See Grégoire de Nysse, *Traité de la virginité* (1966), 373.

[67] Thus, also 'God's eternal and "undistended" life is not that of the intelligible world (Plotinus), but of the Holy Trinity', D. Balàs, 'Eternity and Time in Gregory of Nyssa's *Contra Eunomium*' (1976), 147.

[68] D. Balàs, Μετουσία Θεοῦ (1966), 102 and 107.

[69] The section of *CE* III 6,3-10 focuses on explaining *Exod*. 3:14, and Gregory of Nyssa confirms his interpretation with the support of other Scriptural passages, such as *Is*. 44:6 ('I am the first, and I am the last; and beside me there is no God') and *Psalm*. 102:25-6 ('Of old hast thou laid the foundation of the earth: and the heavens are the work of thy hands.They shall perish, but thou shalt endure').

2. *Cosmology*

In the *In Hexaemeron* Gregory intends to put forward his explanation of the creation of the world, which had already been discussed by Basil in his homilies, which had evidently become famous in a few years.[70] Writing to his brother Peter, Bishop of Sebasteia, Gregory states that he is composing his work to defend Basil's exegesis from the criticisms that had been made by some unidentified people, who, however, show that they possess a good level of culture:

> They accuse him of not having clearly explained about the sun, namely, why that luminary was created after three days and not together with the other constellations, as it is not possible that the temporal space of the day is delimited by the dawn and evening if there is no sun: it is the sun which, by setting, brings the evening, and, rising, the dawn. Likewise, they do not accept the creation of the two heavens, and say that if the Apostle also names the third heaven, in any case the difficulties remain on this point, since at the beginning only one sky was made,[71] and then the firmament,[72] which is another heaven – that is, it is the result of a later creation, which however was not described by Moses. The hypothesis of the existence of even a third sky, in addition to these two, cannot be demonstrated. In fact, after the firmament another sky was not created, and the beginning, by its nature, does not allow us to imagine something else more ancient. If the sky was created at the beginning, it is clear that the creation began then: Scripture would not have called it the 'beginning' if it had had another beginning previously. In fact, what comes second in the order is not the beginning and is not said to be such. Yet Paul recalls a third heaven, of which however the account of creation does not speak. Therefore, also in this case the allusion to the second heaven is part of the problems to be investigated (*Hexaem.* 3; GNO IV/I, 8,13-9,15).

Certainly, Gregory wanted to defend Basil, not criticize him: but he does so by proposing, in turn, interpretations that are partly different. It is the same attitude as when he wrote the *Contra Eunomium* or the *De hominis opificio*, in which, of course, he defended Basil's work, but put forward his theology. In his *In Hexaemeron* Gregory rejects the universal conflagration (ἐκπύρωσις), which Basil, on the whole, had not considered unacceptable, but had tried to adapt it to a literal interpretation of the 'higher waters' of *Gen.* 1:7: the upper waters serve to prevent the conflagration, which would inevitably occur due to the preponderant presence of fire in the world.[73] In fact Gregory emphasizes that the material elements existing in the world guarantee its equilibrium and he insists more on the unity and immediacy of the creation of the world, because

[70] Also in the Latin West (Ambrose wrote his homilies on the same subject in 386, less than ten years after those of Basil).

[71] Namely, what *Gen.* 1:1 deals with.

[72] Cf. *Gen.* 1:6-7. For this division of the heavens cf. also *Catech.* 12,2 (GNO IV/III, 41,1-2), where the 'places that are above the air' are referred to.

[73] Cf. M. Alexandre, 'La théorie de l'exégèse' (1971).

God's will coincides with the immediate creation without time taking over, while Basil had insisted on the succession of creation. After all, Basil wrote homilies and had to be more 'literal' and simpler, while Gregory was writing a treatise.[74]

Matter

Basil had explained the problem of matter in the *Homilies on Hexaemeron* (II 2) and had simply denied that matter could be a beginning, because if it were, there would be a second beginning coeternal with God; therefore, it was created by God. Matter, according to Basil, is not that of the Platonists, but it is that found in Genesis: it is not co-eternal with God, but it had a beginning, and it is that of the *creatio ex nihilo*. Gregory of Nazianzus also states that matter had a beginning and is not coeternal with God, even if some of his expressions appear ambiguous. According to Anne Richard,[75] instead, Gregory affirms that matter pre-exists the world in its order when he says (*Orat*. 44,4; PG 36, 610D) that God, in creating things, had first created matter and then the form (τὴν ὕλην προϋποστήσας εἰδοποίησεν ὕστερον), while when he created the sun, He first created the form, which is light, and then matter, which is the sun (τὸ εἶδος τῆς ὕλης προϋποστήσατο). This statement is not clear, but I do not think it means that matter pre-exists: matter pre-exists only in the sense that God creates it *before* the form of individual things, not in the sense that God takes the already existing matter, as claimed by the Platonists. The matter of which Gregory speaks is, therefore, that created *ad hoc* by God, when He creates individual things, and is different from the matter of the Platonists. Gregory identifies, as other Christian writers did, matter with what was created before the intelligible reality that was in man (i.e. the world). This is confirmed by the creation of man, about which Gregory says (*Orat*. 38,11): παρὰ μὲν τῆς ὕλης λαβὼν τὸ σῶμα ἤδη προϋποστάσης (scl., God): here the ὕλη is the mud of the earth, which existed previously, because it had been created by God before man. This is also the meaning of the passage of *Orat*. 29,9, where he says that primitive matter subsisted from nothing, even if some invent it unborn (τὴν ἀρχέγονον ὕλην ὑποστᾶσαν ἐξ οὐκ ὄντων, κἄν τινες ἀγένητον ἀναπλάττωσιν). I interpret in the same way 'the first matter created (πρωτόκτιστος ὕλη)' of *Carm*. II 1,13,182 (PG 37, 1241) and 'the second creation (δευτέρα κτίσις)' after the angels of *Carm*. I, II 34,8 (PG 37, 946). It must be considered that *Arcanum* 4 refutes the Platonic doctrine of the pre-existence of matter and ideas.

[74] The difference between a treatise and a homily has already been dealt with in Ch. 2.
[75] A. Richard, *Cosmologie et théologie* (2003), 245-7.

Gregory of Nyssa, however, according to some, came to different conclusions. He considers some of the objections made against Basil by those who had heard his *Homilies*:

> If God is immaterial, where did matter come from? How did the quantum come from the being that is devoid of quantity, the visible from the invisible? How did that which is in any case defined by weight and quantity come from the being that is devoid of size and limit? And all the other characteristics that are seen to be typical of matter: how or whence did he who in his nature possesses nothing of the kind[76] introduce matter? (*Hexaem.* 7,15,10-5).

It is said that Gregory accepted these objections, because he also states:

> And since God can do everything, by means of his wise and powerful will, in view of the implementation of all that exists, He simultaneously created all the elements which together form matter, namely the light, the heavy, the dense, the sparse, the soft, the hard, the damp, the dry, the cold, the heat, the colour, the figure, the circumference, the interval. We mean to say that He created all those things which, considered in and of themselves, are nothing but pure and simple notions and concepts: none of them, in fact, in itself, is matter, but, if all of them come together, the result is matter (*Hexaem.* 7,15,8-16,11).[77]

Consequently, according to Gregory, matter does not exist *per se*, lacking in quality, as the Middle-Platonists had maintained, but exists only when qualities are present in it; and since Gregory said that qualities are not something material (as the Stoics had argued), but something intelligible, he concluded that matter, which is the result of the union of qualities, is also something intelligible. In this way he answered the question: how is it possible that God, who is not material, can create something material?[78]

In fact, this is not Gregory's thought. Even before examining the problem of matter, he had stated that, in God, power concurs with His will (ἐπὶ τῆς θείας φύσεως σύνδρομός ἐστι τῇ βουλήσει ἡ δύναμις) (7,17-8), that is, there is no temporal succession in Him, hence He did not need something (matter) that would precede His act of creation. And above all, the quotation (*Hexaem.*

[76] Namely, nothing material. On this question, cf. J. Pépin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964), 52-5.

[77] Here Gregory of Nyssa touches on a problem that had been faced since Origen's time, precisely to resolve the aporia between the Christian faith, which considered matter created by God, and Greek philosophy, which considered matter uncreated. Origen, in fact, mentions it in *De principiis* IV 4,7, cf. the note by M. Simonetti, Origen, *I Principi* (1968), *ad locum*, and, for this passage of Gregory of Nyssa, M. Alexandre, 'L'exégèse de Gen. I, 1-2a' (1976), 167-9.

[78] See A.H. Armstrong, 'The Theory of the Non-Existence of Matter' (1962); F.X. Risch, Gregor von Nyssa, *Über das Sechstagewerk* (1999), 25-6; Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 411-24; C. Arruzza, *Les mésaventures de la théodicée* (2011), 255-9; A. Marmodoro, 'Gregory of Nyssa on the creation of the world' (2015). Nevertheless, doubt was cast on this interpretation of matter already by Monique Alexandre, 'L'exégèse de Gen. I, 1-2' (1976), 167-8.

7,15,8-16,11) is not a confirmation of the objections of Basil's critics, as has been said, but, on the contrary, it is a response to their objections. God, says Gregory, can do everything, and therefore He can also create matter, because it does not exist independently of the qualities, but only if they are present in it: but God himself creates the qualities. Gregory then examines the problem in greater depth, but according to the *creatio ex nihilo*, whereby matter as a Stoic-Platonic *hypokeimenon* does not exist in itself, but only in so far as it is formed together with the qualities and by the qualities. It follows that it does not exist without qualities, but it does not follow that it is something intelligible. Gregory stresses the omnipotence of God (also something which is Christian and non-Platonic) and believes that it is possible that a material reality can derive from an immaterial being, contrary to the objection which had been raised against him.[79] In his day, the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo* had become almost universally accepted, on account of which it would not be a problem to investigate matter and ask oneself what it is and from whence it came (*Hexaem*. 7,15,8-9). Some scholars affirm that Gregory supports the same conception elsewhere (*Opif*. 23; PG 44, 209D-212A; 24, 213AC; *An*. GNO III/III, 92,7-93,12),[80] but also in those passages Gregory rejects the hypothesis of an intelligible matter and, even more evidently, that matter is coeternal with God, challenging both the pagan philosophers and the Manicheans and resorting to the omnipotence of God.

The Intelligible World

One of the most widespread conceptions in Middle-Platonism was that of the existence of the intelligible world, which had also been accepted by the School of Alexandria. Philo had introduced into his exegesis of the Scriptures the existence of a 'superior', that is, intelligible, world, which is opposed to the sensible one. In fact, God creates the incorporeal sky, the invisible earth, the ἰδέα of air and emptiness, and then the incorporeal substance of water. The waters of which *Gen*. 1:1 speaks belong to the intelligible world, while those of *Gen*. 1:2 belong to the sensible world (*Opif*. 29) and the sky is the first and the purest of the realities (*Opif*. 7,27). First, then, the Maker made an incorporeal heaven, and an invisible earth, and the essential form of air and void (7,29):

> Now that invisible light perceptible only by mind has come into being as an image of the divine Word Who brought it within our ken: it is a supercelestial constellation, fount

[79] Perhaps Köckert means to say this when she notes that 'Die Materie ist nicht mehr *conditio sine qua non* für Körperlichkeit, sondern als Komplex aller Qualitäten' (*Christliche Kosmologie* [2009], 417).

[80] See *ibid*. 414-5. In *Opif*. 24,213C the discourse on matter is made in relation to the resurrection: just as God created the world from nothing (and therefore not from matter), so He can recreate human reality from nothing (that is, bodily matter that has been dissolved by death) and transform it into another condition (εἰς ἄλλην τινὰ μεταστοιχειοῦσθαι κατάστασιν).

of the constellations obvious to sense. It would not be amiss to term it "allbrightness", to signify that from which sun and moon, as well as fixed stars and planets draw, in proportion for their several capacity, the light befitting each of them (ὑπερουράνιος ἀστήρ, πηγὴ τῶν αἰσθητῶν ἀστέρων, ἣν οὐκ ἂν ἀπὸ σκοποῦ καλέσειεν ἄν τις παναύγειαν, ἀφ' ἧς ἥλιος καὶ σελήνη καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι πλάνητές τε καὶ ἀπλανεῖς ἀρύτονται, καθ' ὅσον ἑκάστῳ δύναμις, τὰ πρέποντα φέγγη) (*Opif.* 8,31).[81]

Consequently, there exists an intelligible world (νοητός), which is above the sky (ὑπερουράνιος).[82] Clement of Alexandria, in a few words, takes up Philo's interpretation:

Again the Barbarian philosophy knows the world of thought and the world of sense – the former archetypal, and the latter the image of that which is called the model; and assigns the former to the Monad,[83] as being perceived by the mind, and the world of sense to the number six … and he places in the Monad the invisible heaven and the holy earth, and intellectual light (*Strom.* V 93,4-94,2).

The Middle-Platonic doctrine of the intelligible world was difficult to reconcile with the narrative of *Genesis*, because the biblical text did not speak of it, and this difficulty is perceived in the Cappadocians' treatment of the subject.[84] Basil

[81] Trans. F. Colson, LCL.

[82] See C. Moreschini, 'Il firmamento e le acque sopracelesti' (2016).

[83] According to Clement, the Monad indicates the Logos of God, cf. S.R.C. Lilla, *Clement of Alexandria* (1971), 191.

[84] Corsini rightly observes, Eugenio Corsini, 'Plérôme humaine' (1971), 112 that the intelligible world no longer has any function for the Cappadocians: the Nyssen implements a real revolution in the speculation on the first principles, on the *archai* of Middle Platonic philosophy and early Neo-Platonism; he subverts the hierarchy God – Logos – world, which had also been maintained by Origen and the Arians and the first Pro-Nicene theologians, such as Athanasius. Gregory is the first to draw the logical consequences of the doctrine of consubstantiality and of the perfect equality between the Logos and the Father, since, according to him, the Logos no longer has the function of mediator in the ontological order level. Likewise he eliminates or, at least, radically transforms the functions of the intelligible world, which had been considered as the world of ideas: for Origen, the intelligible world is identified with the Logos, which is the sum of the Father's ideas and constitutes the descent from transcendent reality to being (the intelligible world, in the Logos, is the true being) and from the Logos, as paradigm and creator, to the sensible cosmos. This mediating role of the Logos implied in Origen and in his followers a subordinationism of the Son towards the Father: this had been the position of the Origenists with Arian tendencies, and also of the first defenders of Nicene orthodoxy, who were followers of Origen. Also for Basil (*Hexaem.* I 5) there is still the creation of an intelligible world before the sensible world, while Gregory makes the intelligible world disappear as a link between God and the created world. Gregory, therefore, was the first to see clearly what the crux of the matter was: the wisdom, the will, the power of God constitute a single reality and are enough to explain the creation, without the need for more or less secondary entities that act as intermediaries. Man, therefore, is the link between the two worlds: a doctrine that perhaps is not so new in its formulation, but which certainly is in the radicalism of its application. It is in man that the transition from the higher to the lower order takes place; man is the true 'intermediary' (a title that Middle Platonism and Philo assigned to the second god, intermediate between the first god and

had said little in this regard: 'It appears, indeed, that even before this world an order of things existed of which our mind can form an idea, but of which we can say nothing, because it is too lofty a subject for men who are but beginners and are still babes in knowledge' (*Hexaem.* I 5,1).[85]

But what does this intelligible reality consist of? Gregory of Nyssa tries to interpret it according to Platonism, but he remains vague. The longest discussion, because it has the purpose of teaching catechumens, does not, however, remain very precise (*Catech.* 6, 2-4; GNO III/4, 21,1-22,18). Gregory begins with a general discourse, that is, with the distinction between the intelligible and the sensible. Then he introduces the opposition 'intelligible / sensible nature (νοητὴ / αἰσθητὴ φύσις)', the former, characterized, by being incorporeal, intangible and invisible, the latter, by the contrary:[86] all this is obvious and traditional. Intelligible nature has a place, that is, the thin and mobile substance, whose fate it is to be the part above the world (κατὰ τὴν ὑπερκόσμιον λῆξιν):[87] in fact, this substance has many affinities (πολλὴν … τὴν συγγένειαν) with the intelligible nature. It is thin and mobile: therefore it seems to be the ether or the celestial spheres.[88] Consequently it is not intelligible in the true sense, because the ether and the celestial spheres are material, even if thin and light. The intelligible substance is also present in man and it is in his rationality that the union between the intelligible substance and the sensitive one takes place.

A long passage from *De infantibus* (GNO III/II, 78,5-23) explains that the angelic powers are actually those that inhabit places above the world and the sky (τῆς μὲν ἀγγελικῆς τε καὶ ἀσωμάτου φύσεως, ἥτις τῶν ἀοράτων ἐστίν, ἐν τοῖς ὑπερκοσμίοις τε καὶ ὑπερουρανίοις διαιτωμένης), because the place where they live is immaterial and therefore light (in weight) and corresponds with their light and aerial nature. The intelligent nature, which is that of the

the world); he is the 'image of God ', and no longer 'the image of the image ', as for Origen (*Iohan. Comm.* II 3,20).

On the contrary, Zachhuber thinks that the intelligible world of which Gregory speaks in the *In Hexaemeron* is the world of ideas of the Platonic tradition, even if the connection between the world of ideas and the creation of the material world is closer: 'The place of ideas with Gregory is, I take it, the λόγος of God as it was with Philo and Origen before', J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 148-52, especially 149 n. 16. Neverheless, the function of this intelligible world in the Platonic sense in the context of creation is not clear to me, because Gregory never refers to the ideas of the Logos of God when he explains *Genesis*.

[85] Trans. Schaff.

[86] The same distinction between intelligible and sensible on the basis of visibility and invisibility, is also in *CE* I 270-3 and in *Infant.* (GNO III/II, 77,14 and 78,4-10). See A.A. Mosshammer, 'The created and the increate' (1988), 353-79, republished in M. Brugarolas (ed.), *Gregory of Nyssa* (2018), 383-411.

[87] In *Eustath.* (GNO III/I, 12,6) Gregory says that God's economy is realized in the intelligible creation and in the sensible one (ἐν τε τῇ νοητῇ κτίσει καὶ ἐν τῇ αἰσθητῇ).

[88] This is also the view of Raymond Winling, Grégoire de Nysse, *Discours catéchétique* (2000), 173 n. 3.

soul, is thin, weightless, light and mobile (ἥ τε γὰρ νοερὰ φύσις λεπτή τις καὶ καθαρὰ καὶ ἀβαρὴς καὶ εὐκίνητος), and the celestial body is thin and light and always in motion (τό τε οὐράνιον σῶμα λεπτόν τε καὶ κοῦφον καὶ ἀεικίνητον), on account of which it must be thought that the intelligible world – which however is not explicitly indicated by Gregory in this passage – is above the sky and that the angels dwell in it. In fact, if the celestial body is 'always in motion', we must think of the movement of the celestial spheres, as in the passage of the *Oratio catechetica magna* indicated above, and therefore of something material, but not intelligible.

This inaccuracy is also found in the explanation of the phrase of Christ's prayer 'as in heaven, so on earth' (*Orat.*; GNO VII/II, 48,14-25). It contains a deeper meaning, as the sky is not to be understood as the visible sky, but it is necessary to consider what the creation of God (κτίσις) is. There is the irrational creation and the rational one. The rational creation is divided into that which has a body and that which is devoid of it: the latter is the rational creation, which are the angels, it is intelligible (νοητή), devoid of a body that weighs down, it walks in the region that has been attributed (λῆξις) to it and which is at the top, thanks to its fast and mobile nature it stays in light (in terms of weight) and ethereal places.[89]

It is in the second of the *Homilies on the Beatitudes*, of the same period (379-380), that Gregory distinguishes between the earthly and material world and the celestial vault (οὐρανία ἀψίς), taking up the expression of Plato (*Phaedr*. 246c and 247bc). The celestial vault is ascended by means of steps, with this conclusion: 'Even though one thing may seem to be high in terms of location in space, yet it is below the level of intelligible being (τῆς νοερᾶς οὐσίας), which is impossible for the mind to scale, unless it first transcends by thought those things which the senses can reach' (GNO VII/II, 90,21-4).[90] What this 'intelligible being' is, however, is not specified.

More concrete, even if brief, seems to be the explanation of *CE* II 222: there is a Cause of the whole system and structure, on which the whole nature of the intelligible things depends, from which it gets its origins and causes, to which it looks and returns (οὗ πᾶσα ἡ τῶν νοητῶν ἐξῆπται φύσις … καὶ πρὸς ἐκεῖνο νένευκέ τε καὶ ἐπιστρέφεται καὶ ἐν αὐτῷ διαμένει). There are three passages of the *Homilies on the Song* which are part of this progress of greater concreteness and specification. In *Cant. Hom.* VI Gregory explains that the soul

again awakens and with the imagination (τῇ διανοίᾳ) passes through the intelligible and supramundane nature, which it calls 'city' (τὴν νοητήν τε καὶ ὑπερκόσμιον φύσιν,

[89] Αἰθεριώδης has to be understood in a non-specific sense, with reference to the ether as the 'fifth body', but in the sense of 'immaterial'.

[90] Trans. St. Hall (2015).

ἣν πόλιν κατονομάζει), in which there are Principalities and Powers and Thrones distinct from the Dominions,[91] and the assembly of the realities that are above the world (ἥ τε τῶν ἐπουρανίων πανήγυρις), which the bride calls 'square' … The bride, therefore, in her search, goes through all the angelic order (πᾶσαν ἀγγελικὴν διακόσμησιν) (GNO VI, 182,6-11).

Here, therefore, Gregory does not only speak generically of an intelligible nature, but also of a supramundane nature (ὑπερκόσμιον), and above all he speaks of 'angels'. *In Cant. Hom.* VI (GNO VI, 182,19) he speaks equally of the celestial city and of the intelligible and incorporeal realities, and finally in *Cant. hom.* XV (GNO VI, 446,2-4) there is a description of the 'intelligible and supra-celestial Powers', which were arranged in an order by the will of God (αἱ ἐξουσίαι αὗται ὑπὸ τοῦ θεοῦ τεταγμέναι εἰσὶ καὶ ἡ τάξις τῶν νοητῶν καὶ ὑπερκοσμίων δυνάμεων) which remains forever, without any confusion. Finally, the homily in *Basilium fratrem* means the intelligible world as a place. Basil, who after death rose above the (sensible) world, now he can desire with his soul to go towards what is beyond (εἰς τὸ ἐπέκεινα) and lean over the sensible vault of the sky, and always stay with the intelligible realities and ascend together with the divine powers (ἀεὶ τοῖς νοητοῖς ἐμβατεύειν καὶ συμμετεωροπορεῖν ταῖς θείαις δυνάμεσι) (GNO X/I, 7,131). The intelligible world is, therefore, the non-earthly 'place' where the righteous stay.

Nor does Gregory Nazianzen define exactly the intelligible world and he also basically understands it as the angelic world.[92] There are few indications in this regard. In *Epist.* 101,38 he simply speaks of the intelligible and incorporeal realities, which are the intellect and the human soul, in addition to the divine Trinity and the world, which is a complex consisting of visible and invisible things. In *Orat.* 28,31 he contrasts sensation, namely, sensible reality, with the intelligible nature which is above the world (τὴν νοητὴν φύσιν καὶ ἐπουράνιον), without specifying better what it is. In *Orat.* 38,9 Gregory is a little more detailed and precise, stating that first of all God thinks (ἐννοεῖ) the angelic and celestial powers, which have their own function and which together constitute the κόσμος νοητός; God, after having created this world, creates the κόσμος ὑλικός and visible (38,10); the angels are an 'intelligible creation' (νοουμένη κτίσις) (38,11). The same distinction between the intelligible world, intended for immaterial creatures (angels and human souls) and the sensible world is in *Arcana* 4,93-100. Elsewhere (*Carm.* I 2,10,98-104; PG 37, 687-8) Gregory states:

there are two natures that oppose each other at the two extremities: one close to God and worthy of honour: they call it 'rational' and 'full of intellect' (λογικήν τε καὶ πλήρη νοός), and define it thus for paronymy of the way of speaking (ἐκ λόγου παρωνύμως).

[91] *Col.* 1:16.
[92] For a treatment of this subject, see also A. Richard, *Cosmologie et Théologie* (2003), 136-64.

It stands beside God and is the order of the highest angels and second angels, and is higher than the sensations[93] and the material bodies.

In another poem Gregory explains what the main dogmas of the Christian faith are: God, one and triune, the nature of the angels and the double world (κόσμου δισσοῦ), providence, soul and body, the first and second laws, and the incarnation of the One who is also very far from intelligible realities (τοῦ καὶ νοητῶν πλεῖστον ἐξεστηκότος) (II 1,12,309-25; PG 37, 1187-9).

Gregory of Nazianzus agrees, therefore, with Gregory of Nyssa in identifying the intelligible world with the angelic reality; both use terminology having Platonic flavour, but for them the intelligible world is only non-material reality, which exists outside this world of ours, an οὐρανὸς ἄλλος (*Arcana* 4,93) which is inhabited by angelic powers. They are immaterial, 'intelligent spirits (νοερὰ πνεύματα),[94] or some kind of immaterial, bodiless fire (ἄϋλον καὶ ἀσώματον), or of some other nature, as close as possible to the beings we have mentioned' (*Orat*. 38,9). The angelic world and the material world are called, with rhetorical metalepsis, 'mind and sensation' (νοῦς καὶ αἴσθησις) (38,11). Gregory uses traditional linguistic terms which are substantially different from the original meaning, to indicate simply the otherworldly world. Generally speaking, 'intelligible' can adapt itself both to incorporeal nature (the heavens) and to the beings who live there (the angels), hence man, who is an intelligent creature, can be 'another kind of angel' (*ibid*.).

Of fundamental importance is the fact that the concept of 'intelligible' is different from that of Platonic philosophy, because it indicates something which, although thin and light (in terms of weight), is also material.

Gregory of Nazianzus also knows the Platonic doctrine of the world of ideas, on which Basil and Gregory of Nyssa did not dwell substantially, because they did not consider it functional to Christian cosmology. Gregory of Nazianzus, when he speaks of it, rejects the traditional doctrines of Middle-Platonic cosmology, that ideas are eternal paradigms of sensible reality. The fourth of the *Carmina arcana* is dedicated to the world and its construction by God: Gregory does not intend to reconcile the biblical doctrine of creation with the Platonic one,[95] but simply excludes the Platonic solution. 'Those revered shapes (μορφώματα σεπτά)' which the Platonists imagined were gods never existed, but came into existence thanks to the will of God (*Arcana* 4,5-6). He therefore means that ideas, which are forms of material reality, are not coeternal with God. Further on, Gregory wonders 'to what concern divine reflection was stirred (for I believe that God is neither idle nor ineffectual), before this universe stood in

[93] That is, of the sensible reality, as in *Orat*. 28,31.

[94] In *Orat*. 38,10 they are called νοεραὶ φύσεις (also *Arcana* 4,77: νοερὰ φύσις): considering the angels intelligent realities and not material is traditional.

[95] Some Middle Platonic doctrines, as has been said, persisted even in the fourth century, and were still considered useful by Christian writers.

place and had ordered by visible forms (εἴδεσι κοσμηθῆναι)' (4,60-2). Before the creation of the world God 'was active in contemplation of his own splendour of beauty' (κίννυτο κάλλεος οἷο φίλην θηεύμενος αἴγλην)[96] and the creator Nous (that is, the Father)[97] 'was stirred and gazed within his mighty thoughts upon the forms of the world to come into existence later, a word present to God (κίνυτο καὶ κόσμοιο τύπους οὓς στήσατο λεύσσεν / οἷσι ἑνὶ μεγάλοισι νοήμασι κοσμογόνος Νοῦς)' (4,64-8). All things were potentially present in the Nous, but were brought into effect by the Logos (4,75-6: Νοῦς ὤδινεν ἅπαντα, ῥάγη δ'εἰς ὕστερον ὠδίς, / ὥριος, εὖτε Θεοῖο μέγας Λόγος ἐξεκάλυψεν; 5,2-3). All reality is present in God, because God is eternal, while the fragmentation of things corresponds to time, a measure of created reality. This explanation parallels the one in *Orat*. 38,7.

The Sensible World: The Firmament

In the *Genesis* account, the text of the Septuagint speaks immediately at the beginning (*Gen*. 1:1) of the creation of heaven (οὐρανός), and a little further on (1:6-8) of the creation of the στερέωμα (*firmamentum* in Latin), which had the function of separating the upper waters (those that fall from the sky), from the lower ones (rivers, lakes and sea). However in this passage God also called the firmament 'heaven', so the problem of this repetition arises, if one does not want to admit that the firmament, which, as the word says, is στερεόν (that is, 'solid', 'hard'), is different from the heaven mentioned in *Gen*. 1:1. Philo, after having distinguished between the immaterial world and the material world made in His image (πρὸς παράδειγμα), had stated that the first and the most noble of the parts of the material world is the sky, which God called, according to the etymology, στερέωμα, as it is corporeal: the body, in fact, by its nature is στερεόν, because it is three-dimensional.[98] Another explanation could be that God called στερέωμα the οὐρανός, either because the οὐρανός is the limit (ὅρος) of all things or because it is the first of the visible things (ὁρατά) (*Opif*. 36-7).[99]

Like Philo, Clement of Alexandria, in the continuation of the passage from the *Stromata* cited above, distinguishes an intelligible world and a sensible world:

> And in the material cosmogony He creates a solid heaven (and what is solid is capable of being perceived by sense), and a visible earth, and a light that is seen. Does not Plato hence appear to have left the ideas of living creatures in the intellectual world,

[96] See also *Orat*. 38,7.

[97] In this passage the Nous is understood as the Father, who possesses the ideas of things inside, and the Son as the Logos, who carries out the creation: cf. *ibid*. 75-6, Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 45-7.

[98] On this subject, cf. D.T. Runia, *Philo of Alexandria. On the Creation of the Cosmos* (2001), with a bibliography.

[99] This etymology is also proposed by Philo in *Plant*. 1, and is in Ps. Aristot., *Mund*. 6,400a6-7.

and to make intellectual objects into sensible species according to their genera? (*Strom.* V 94,1-2).

Origen also distinguishes between heaven and firmament (*In Genesim Hom.* 1-2): God first made heaven, of which He said: 'The heaven is my throne' (*Is.* 66:1). Then He created the firmament, that is, the material sky, the στερέωμα. Since each body is stable and consistent, the firmament separated the upper and lower waters. However, after having distinguished the material reality from the intelligible one, Origen gives his exegesis a totally allegorical character that has nothing to do with cosmology:[100] heaven is the intelligible substance on which God rests as on a throne and was made at the beginning and before all things. Instead the other sky, namely the firmament,[101] is corporeal. For this reason the first heaven, which has been defined as "spiritual", is our spirit, which sees and contemplates God, while the other, the corporeal heaven, called "firmament", is our external man, the one who sees with the eyes of the body. Darkness is upon the water of the abyss and upon it dwell the prince of this world and the enemy serpent.[102]

This allegorical interpretation was taken up by the fourth-century Origenists. Didymus of Alexandria distinguishes between active powers (δραστήριοι θεοῦ δυνάμεις), which are indicated by the firmament, because they are 'stable' on earth (οἱ πρακτικοὶ δὲ στερέωμά εἰσιν, ἑδραῖοι τυγχάνοντες),[103] and the contemplative powers (οἱ τὸν θεωρητικὸν ἀσπαζόμενοι βίον), which are indicated by the heavens (*Expositio in Psalmos* 18,2; PG 39, 1268BC).

Epiphanius, a strong anti-Origenist, criticizes these allegorical interpretations (*Pan.*, haer. 64,4,11)[104] and Basil refers to the Origenists, when he speaks of οἱ ἀπὸ τῆς ἐκκλησίας which present absurd interpretations, like this one of the spiritual waters (*Hexaem.* III 9,1); Jerome, in his translation of one of Epiphanius' epistles, confirms this criticism: *dicente Origene de aquis, quae super firmamentum sunt, non esse aquas, sed fortitudines quasdam angelicae potestatis, et*

[100] More details in Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 247-51.

[101] *Firmamentum* is Rufinus' translation of στερέωμα, but it had already been used by Tertullian (*Bapt.* 3). In the fourth century *firmamentum* was the normal translation (Rufinus used it even when translating Origen in *De principiis*) and it is attested to starting from Marius Victorinus and Hilary of Poitiers (see TLL, *ad locum*). It may be interesting to note that Chalcidius, who presents Origen's interpretation of biblical cosmogony (*Comm. Tim.* 276-8), see Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 229-37, 248-55, translates στερέωμα as *soliditas*, probably to differentiate himself from the Vulgate, not considered very literary. This translation of Chalcidius, however, has remained isolated, perhaps because he wrote before Marius Victorinus, Hilary and Rufinus, who proposed *firmamentum*. This etymology is also proposed by Philo in *Plant.* 1, and is in Ps. Aristot., *Mund.* 6,400a6-7.

[102] See Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 266-7.

[103] On Didymus' exegesis and its derivation from Origen for this problem, cf. J. Pepin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964), 391.

[104] 'And then wherever he can (sc. Origen) he resorts to allegorical interpretations, about Heaven, the waters that flow there, the supracelestial ones, and the water that is down here on earth'. See Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 266-7.

rursum aquas, quae super terram sunt, hoc est sub firmamento, esse virtutes contrarias, id est daemones (*Epist.* 51,5,7).[105] Basil opposes the allegorical interpretations of cosmogony, even if he does not exclude some non-material meaning of the text. The entire third homily of *In Hexaemeron* deals with the firmament: this breadth of the discussion is due to the fact that it was unclear what the firmament was, as Basil himself had admitted shortly before, in writing to Amphilochius (*Epist.* 233,2). God creates the firmament, which serves to separate the waters from the waters (*Gen.* 1:6), and it too has been called "heaven" (*Hexaem.* III 2,1). If this heaven were different from the one mentioned in *Gen.* 1:1, there should be two heavens (*ibid.* 3,1). Basil believes this is possible, despite the fact that the Greek philosophers claim that there is only one sky, because all the available matter has been consumed for the creation of the universe.[106] Their opinion is wrong, according to Basil, because there is at least one other heaven, so much so that Paul speaks of a 'third heaven' (cf. 2*Cor.* 12:1) (3,2 and 4), and this observation will be taken up by Gregory of Nyssa. Therefore, the existence of a second sky is confirmed (3,4), contrary to what has been claimed by others:

> If we believe some of those who have preceded us, we have not here the creation of a new heaven, but a new account of the first. The reason they give is, that the earlier narrative briefly described the creation of heaven and earth,[107] while here Scripture relates in greater detail the manner in which each was created.[108] I, however, since Scripture gives to this second heaven another name[109] and its own function,[110] maintain that it is different from the heaven which was made at the beginning;[111] that it is of a stronger nature (στερεωτέρας φύσεως) and of an especial use to the universe (3,7).[112]

However, Basil himself must admit that there is a difficulty in understanding the firmament as a second heaven: in fact, it is not possible that the upper water

[105] Cf. J. Pepin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964), 397-9. Jerome, after becoming a fierce anti-Origenist, writes that among the errors of Origen we find the following: *septimum, quod aquas, quae super coelos in scripturis esse dicuntur, sanctas supernasque virtutes, quae super terram et infra terram, contrarias et daemoniacas esse arbitretur* (*Contra Iohannem Hierosol.*; PL 23, 376), T. Gregory, 'Le acque sopra il firmamento' (2008), 9. After Jerome, also Augustine and then Gregory the Great, *Ezech. Hom.* II 5,4 (PL 76, 987A) and Rabanus Maurus, *Alleg. In Spiritum Sanctum* (PL 112, 861B) mean the upper waters as the angelic powers (passages quoted from J. Pepin, *ibid.* 406-8).

[106] A doctrine of Platonic origin: cf. *Tim.* 28b; 31ab; 32c-33a; M. Naldini, in Basil of Caesarea, *Sulla Genesi* (1990), 334; Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 376 n. 305.

[107] *Gen.* 1:1.

[108] Other testimonies prior to Basil on the relationship between heaven and the firmament and their different denominations (e.g., in Origen) are given by Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 375 n. 297.

[109] That is, στερέωμα.

[110] That is, to separate the upper and lower waters.

[111] That of *Gen.* 1:1.

[112] Precisely, στερέωμα. Trans. Ph. Schaff.

will not fall if it is on a concave surface, such as that of the sky (4,2). For this reason, it is necessary to consider what the nature of the firmament is and why it is placed in the middle (μεσιτεύειν) of the totality of the water, that is, to divide the upper waters from the lower ones (4,4). Certainly the στερέωμα is something solid: στερέωμα is also the condensed air, which is thunder (4,5-6). But this does not mean that what is solid does not leave a passage within it: the firmament has the function of letting the waters that must fall on the earth filter through. According to common opinion, στερέωμα originates from water, but it should not be thought that it is frozen water or crystal, which is said to be formed by an exceptional freezing of water, or the specular stone, which is found in mines.[113] Its function is to divide the waters, hence Basil rejects the spiritual interpretation of Origen and Didymus, and returns to the literal one: water and fire are equally necessary elements, but oppose each other, so that their equilibrium constitutes the fundamental condition for the conservation of the cosmos and to avoid its conflagration, of which Stoic philosophy had spoken (III 5,4-7).

The firmament therefore does not indicate an absolutely rigid and solid substance, endowed with weight and resistance, but a kind of membrane:[114] if it were actually solid, the term στερέωμα would be suitable above all for the earth (III 7,1). The firmament is solid if we compare it with the nature of the realities superior to it (διὰ τὴν φύσιν τῶν ὑπερκειμένων), which is thin and light and not perceptible with the senses; it is something that lets the wet element filter both in the top-down direction, when the wet element is heavier (namely, water), and in the bottom-up direction, when the wet element is lighter (that is, steam) (III 7,2). God called this στερέωμα 'heaven' because it resembles heaven, since both are material (III 8,1). The controversy with Origen and his interpretation of the waters is taken up again in III 9, where the validity of the literal interpretation of the term "water" is reaffirmed.

There is also a reference to the firmament in VIII 7,1, where *Gen*. 1:20 is explained: 'Let the earth bring forth the living creature after his kind, cattle and creeping things, and beast of the earth after his kind; and it was so'. Since birds fly in the air and not in the sky, in this passage the air is called 'heaven' (οὐρανός) because the passage wants to underline its possibility of 'being seen' (ὁρᾶσθαι),[115] and is called στερέωμα, because, if compared with the body of the ether (αἰθέριον σῶμα), it is more dense: in fact, it is subject to greater pressure due to the exhalations that rise upwards (7,2). Therefore, the firmament

[113] Cf. M. Naldini, *Basilio di* Cesarea (1990), 337; C. Scholten, *Antike Naturphilosophie* (1996), 274-5.

[114] Definition of C. Scholten, *Antike Naturphilosophie* (1996), 273; see also Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 378-9, who speaks of the relatively solid, that is, viscous, nature of the firmament.

[115] A Platonic etymology (*Crat*. 396c), as in III 8,6.

does not exist in itself, but is only a word used by the Scriptures to indicate the air.

Gregory of Nyssa proposes an interpretation of the firmament which in part takes up, in part is different from that of Basil, according to his intention, set out in the introduction to *In Hexaemeron*.[116] He repeats that there is a third heaven, even if the Scriptures speak only of two (the οὐρανός and the στερέωμα): in fact Paul ascended to the third (2*Cor*. 12:2-4) (*Hexaem*. 75-6), and that there are waters above the sky, distinct from those below the sky. However, he adds that the waters that are on earth are preserved despite their evaporation (and the longest and most detailed – and certainly tiring – part of the work is dedicated to this demonstration) (*ibid*. 25-74). Gregory, in fact, corrects Basil's interpretation that the waters serve to prevent the conflagration due to the greater power of the fire, because, in his opinion, there is a continuous balance between water and fire, which guarantees the duration of the world – but the explanation is not very different from Basil's.

Also in the interpretation of the firmament Gregory in part follows Basil, in part he disagrees with him. The firmament is not a solid and resistant body, one of the four elements, or another element besides the four (that is, it is not the ether, of which philosophers speak), but it is the culmination of the sensible substance (τὸ ἄκρον τῆς αἰσθητῆς οὐσίας).[117] It is called the 'firmament' by the Scriptures, because, when compared with nature that is eternal, incorporeal and intangible (that is, with the intelligible world), it is solid (and this had been said by Basil). The firmament is therefore the boundary between the upper and the lower waters, and became visible when the fire, initially contained in the matter from which the world is made up, immediately emerged from it and created the light. The circular path of the sphere of fixed stars marks the border between the waters 'in the extreme limit of the visible world'. But a difficulty arises: what is dense and resistant is also heavy, and what is heavy cannot extend upwards. However, the firmament is placed above all sensible creation: it is not possible, therefore, to think that it is something solid and corporeal (*Hexaem*. 18). Also Basil had said that only by comparing it with the intelligible and incorporeal substance everything that belongs to sensible reality is called 'hard', even if it escapes our perception thanks to its thinness. The firmament, as a conclusion, also had the name of 'heaven' from Scripture (*Gen*. 1:8), just as Scripture gave the name of 'day' to light and 'night' to darkness (*Gen*. 1:18).

The separation of the waters, which is implemented by the firmament thanks to its intermediate position, confirms this explanation and is in full accord with

[116] He was certainly addressing more educated readers than those to whom Basil was speaking.

[117] Considering the firmament as the limit of the sensible world is an interpretation which, as has been pointed out by Monique Alexandre, 'La théorie de l'exégèse' (1976), 103, dates back to the Hellenistic tradition (Phil., *Opif*. 37; *Plant*. 4; Ps. Arist., *Mund*. 400a), and is derived from Plato (*Phaedr*. 247bc).

the Scriptures, which say: 'and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters', that is, above the abyss where the waters were. However, the Spirit of God cannot be identified with darkness, because the Spirit is alien to all evil (*Hexaem.* 19). This interpretation is in tune with Basil's (*Hom. Hexaem.* III 9) and is opposed to Origen's: the abyss of the lower waters should not be understood as the complex of evil powers, on which the spirit of evil moved. Consequently, the water, on which the Spirit of God moved, was in the light and was separated from the darkness (*Hexaem.* 31,19-21): it was the upper water, which is different from the running and material waters, which are heavy and move downward. Gregory conjectures that the higher water means the fullness of the intelligible powers (*ibid.* 32,1-7), thus partially following the interpretation of Origen, which had been contested by Basil.[118] This interpretation is not invalidated, he says, by the fact that both the upper and the lower water are called in the same way, that is, 'water': even God, in fact, is called 'a consuming fire' (*Deut.* 4:24), and yet, in this definition, the term 'fire' does not have a material meaning (*Hexaem.* 32,7-19). In conclusion, the firmament, which was called 'heaven' (*Gen.* 1:6), is the boundary (μεθόριον) of sensible created reality, while what extends beyond it is intelligible created reality. In the latter, there is no form, there is no size, there is no position in a place, there is no measure due to intervals, there is no colour, there is no figure, there is no quantity, there is nothing other than what is observed under the sky (*Hexaem.* 20): these are all negations, which are typical of Platonism to describe the intelligible world,[119] but essentially indicate the world of the angels, which is immaterial.

Also on another point, Gregory rejects Origen's interpretation (namely, the tropology 'of those who studied these problems before him') (*Hexaem.* 21), already the subject of Basil's controversy (*Hom. Hexaem.* II 4). As he had said before that the spirit that moved over the abyss of the waters was not the spirit of evil, so he refuses to think that the abyss indicates the powers rebelling against God and the darkness that is above the abyss is the lord of darkness (33,1-5). The Holy Scripture at the end of cosmogony clearly states that God saw that all the things he had made were very beautiful (*Gen.* 1:31). As Basil had said (*Hom. Hexaem.* II 9) that, when he reads the word 'water' in Scripture, he means water, so Gregory asserts that, when he reads the word 'abyss' in Scripture, he thinks that the abyss specifically indicates the mass of the waters, not the spiritual abyss of evil (33,12-4). This is the definition that the Psalm also gives, when it says (*Psalm* 76:17): 'The clouds poured out water: the skies sent out a sound'. Consequently, if Scripture speaks of the separation of the

[118] Cf. J. Pepin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964), 404; M. Alexandre, 'La théorie de l'exégèse' (1976), 183.

[119] This definition of the intelligible substance has many affinities with the one indicated in *An.* (GNO III/III, 24,13-25,3).

waters, which takes place because the firmament was created, an effective separation must be understood. The waters, in fact, are of two kinds: one tends upwards and is light, the other is sensible and heavy (*Hexaem*. 21). In conclusion, the water of which the biblical text speaks with regard to the firmament is not seen and does not flow, it has nothing to do with the place and it does not mix with any quality known by means of sensation. It is therefore a different water from visible water, and is not an intelligible substance; the Spirit of God moved upon it and it is above the heavens. Scripture indicates with the 'firmament' the extreme limit (πέρας) of the sensible substance, beyond which there is nothing that is similar to what is known in the material world (*Hexaem.* 22). In accordance with this explanation Gregory also interprets (*Hexaem*. 75-76) the 'third heaven' (2*Cor*. 12:2-4), of which there was no trace in *Genesis*. Considering the third heaven starting from above, the 'third heaven' of which Paul speaks is the first, namely, that of intelligible realities.[120] The second is the firmament, that is, the highest point of the sensible world, while the third is the sensible and visible one. Paul divides the material world as a whole into three realms, according to Scripture's normal way of expressing itself[121] and calls each of them 'heaven', but places them in reverse order,[122] starting from the lowest: the first is the sky that limits the air, which is heavier, the one which the clouds, winds and birds reach. The second is made up of the great luminaries, which are in the firmament (*Gen*. 1:16): since they are placed lower than that sky which is higher (the 'third heaven'), the Scripture defines 'firmament' and 'heaven' what is beyond the luminaries and is the culmination of the sensible world. Beyond the second heaven there is the third (considered from below), which is the intelligible world. 'So the Apostle, instead of saying that he had gone beyond all sensible nature and had reached the adyta of intelligible reality, indicates with the "third heaven" his passing through these three parts of the universe. He then reached the third heaven, where he saw the beauties of Paradise and listened to the words that human nature does not pronounce' (*ibid*. 76).

That the στερέωμα is the boundary between the intelligible and supracelestial reality and the sensible one, is briefly proposed in the *Contra Eunomium* (II 273). The limit of sensible creation (τὸ πέρας τῆς αἰσθητῆς κτίσεως), after which lies the intelligible and superior section of the world (ἡ νοητή τε καὶ ὑπερκόσμιος λῆξις), if compared with the intangible and incorporeal and which does not have form, is the beginning and the boundary of all material substance (which therefore comes later and is lower).[123] Scripture calls this beginning and limit of all material substance 'firmament' (that is, 'hardness') because it is

[120] As Nyssen had said in *Hexaem.* 32,1-7.
[121] Cf. for example *Phil*. 2:10.
[122] There emerges a certain ambiguity in the Nyssen's exposition.
[123] That is, the beginning, starting from the top, and the border, starting from the bottom.

compared with the reality that cannot be touched, it does not have a body and it does not have form (συγκρίσει τῇ πρὸς τὸ ἀναφὲς καὶ ἀσώματον καὶ ἀνείδεον στερέωμα λέγεται ἡ ἀρχή τε καὶ τὸ πέρας πάσης τῆς ὑλικῆς ὑποστάσεως); when, instead, we consider the circumference that embraces all the underlying realities by which material nature is contained, we call it 'heaven', which is the boundary of all visible things (ὅταν δὲ τὴν τῶν ὑποκειμένων περιοχὴν ἐξετάζωμεν, ᾧ πᾶσα ἡ ὑλικὴ περικρατεῖται φύσις, οὐρανὸν τοῦτον προσαγορεύομεν τὸν τῶν ὁρατῶν πάντων ὅρον γινόμενον). The firmament has the quality and function of being μεθόριος and of being a border (ὅρος), an implicit meaning in the term οὐρανός. Above it is the intelligible substance, as Gregory had said in the Hexameron.

However, this explanation does not avoid a difficulty. The στερέωμα should be hard and resistant and therefore material, as its name says and as Philo and Origen had already interpreted, so much so that its hardness bends downward the movement of the fire that was released by the formless matter and had reached the firmament. But the firmament cannot be hard and heavy, because in this case it would fall downwards (*Hexaem.* 18).[124] In fact, it is the end, the culmination (ἀκρότατον) of sensible nature. For this reason, Risch proposes another solution: the firmament is of a solid nature, not different from that of the sensible world, but much thinner, otherwise it could not be placed above all the heavy bodies.[125] Köckert instead concludes that the firmament, as Gregory understands it, does not belong either to the sensible world or to the intelligible one, and the question of its nature remains open. The firmament is defined only in a negative[126] – which is not better specified by Köckert.

The firmament is placed between the sensible and the intelligible worlds, at the border between the two (μεθόριος): according to Daniélou the term μεθόριος indicates 'a border reality, that participates in the two realities which it separates', or 'the limit between two orders of things between which there is discontinuity'. Μεθόριος also emphasizes the discontinuity between two different orders of things. For example, man is μεθόριος between the sensible and the intelligible worlds, which are opposite to each other (*Cant. Hom.* XI; GNO VI, 333,13-334,2).[127] But not even this solution is useful to us, because this is a logical definition, but both man and firmament are material.

The only possibility is to understand the 'limit' with both meanings, as Monique Alexandre proposed: inasmuch as it is the extreme part of the material world, the firmament is also material, and inasmuch as it is the limit 'le firmament

[124] Cf. also J. Pepin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964), 419 n. 4; Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 451.

[125] Cf. F.X. Risch, Gregor von Nyssa, *Über das Sechstagewerk* (1999), 179-80; Ch. Köckert, *Christliche Kosmologie* (2009), 450 n. 26 and 451 n. 1.

[126] *Ibid.* 452.

[127] J. Daniélou, *L'être et le temps* (1970), 116-8.

est donc à la fois, par voie logique, au sommet du monde sensible et aux confins de la création intelligibile'.[128] In any case, this was an attempt by Nyssen to solve the problem of the extension of the sensible world by defining the concept of 'firmament', with the intention of following Basil; Gregory of Nazianzus had no interest in this problem.

3. *Man*

Protology and Eschatology

The creation of man had not been explained by Basil in his *In Hexaemeron homiliae*, but in the end (IX 6,14) he had said that he would have done so. Some homilies attributed to both Basil and Gregory of Nyssa (PG 30, 9-61 and PG 44, 257-98) take on the task of remedying this omission by Basil. They were written as a continuation of Basil's, but they were not written either by Gregory of Nyssa or Basil. Probably their author was an unknown preacher of Basil's circle, who made use of Basil's material, drawing it from various passages of his works:[129] neither Basil nor Gregory deserves to have such insipid homilies attributed to him; moreover, it is sound to think that more modest preachers also operated in fourth century Cappadocia, besides Nazianzen, Nyssen and Basil.[130] In fact, Stanislas Giet thought that they came from someone who had listened to Basil's homilies.[131] The same interpretation is subscribed to by Gribomont,[132] and, apart from this detail of the 'listener', it is likely that the author knew Basil (in my opinion, more than Gregory of Nyssa). Finally, Monique Alexandre excludes that they can be the Nyssen's, because they are based above all on moral allegory, unlike what happens in the *De hominis opificio*; moreover the Nyssen does not distinguish between 'image' and 'similarity' in anthropology, unlike the author of these homilies, certainly following a long exegetical tradition.[133] In conclusion, E. Amand is right in excluding that they were written by Basil or Gregory of Nyssa.[134]

It was therefore understandable that Gregory shortly after his brother's death tried to complete the work, as stated in the introduction of the *De opificio hominis*, even if independently of Basil: exactly as he does in the *In Hexaemeron*.

[128] M. Alexandre, 'La théorie de l'exégèse' (1971), 103.

[129] In the first homily, it is written simply that man is the image of God, because he possesses reason (6-7, 264AC): this statement also recurs in Basil (*Epist*. 233,1; *Hom. attende tibi ipsi* 3), but it is a common topic.

[130] See the introduction by A. Smets and M. van Esbroek, Basile de Césarée, *Sur l'origine de l'homme* (1970), 13-126, who unconvincingly attribute these homilies to Basil.

[131] St. Giet, Grégoire de Nysse, *Homélies sur l'*Hexaéméron (1946).

[132] J. Gribomont, 'Notes biographiques sur S. Basile le Grand' (1984), 129-30.

[133] M. Alexandre, 'La théorie de l'exégèse' (1971), 108-9.

[134] E. Amand de Mendieta, 'Les états du texte des homélies pseudo-basiliennes' (1949).

Examining, in the section composed of chapters 16 and 17, the passage from *Gen*. 1:26-7, which states that God created man in His image and likeness and that He created him male and female, Gregory proposes an interpretation which, according to von Balthasar[135] and Daniélou,[136] on the one hand, takes up that of Philo of Alexandria (*Opif*. 134-5 and *LA* I 31 and 53-5) and of Origen, in the sense that he speaks of a 'double creation' (the definition, however, is not Origen's, but of some modern scholars), on the other hand, he modifies it by eliminating any concept of pre-existence and also rejecting the distinction between the concept of image and that of similarity, which had still been proposed by the above-mentioned anonymous homilies on the creation of man. The first creation is that in the image and likeness of God, the creation of the original man who is not subject to passion and death, the second that of man who is divided according to sex: God introduced it in foreseeing the fall of man and the ensuing corruption, because man was condemned to the reproduction of the species through sex. It must already be objected, however, that Scripture merely says that the division of the sexes was introduced in imitation of animals as a consequence of sin, not as a manifestation of passion (*Opif*. 16,185AC).

This interpretation was challenged by Corsini,[137] according to whom Gregory does not say that there were two creations, which serve to introduce each of the two aspects of man, but simply that there are two expressions in Scripture to indicate that the creative act of God applied to two different aspects of man. Nor does he say that man 'according to the image' had no sex: he says that in the archetype, that is, in God, there is no sex, and that sex, consequently, is excluded from the condition of man in being 'in the image of God'. Gregory intends to distinguish an ideal and original plan of creation from the fallen state. The first creation does not precede the second in accordance with a mere order of chronological succession, as Origen would have it, but is one and the same with the original plan of creation, conceived by God, whose realization was not prevented by a fall, which actually took place over time, but by the prevision of the future fall. Gregory explains his interpretation in chap. 17 of the *De hominis opificio*: this is not an 'ideal' creation as opposed to the 'historical' one, as if there had been two creations by God, of which the second would have been juxtaposed with the first. Humanity was created by God in the beginning, in its totality. *Catech*. 5 (GNO III/IV, 18,4-15) contains another exposition of the creation of man and his fall, as well as many points dealt with in the *De hominis opificio*, like that of the doctrine of being in the image of God, which only belongs to the intellectual aspect of man, with the exclusion of the distinction of the sexes, and of freedom, as an essential element of the image, but there is no allusion to the two creations of humanity. Therefore *Genesis*

[135] H.U. von Balthasar, *Présence et Pensée* (1942).
[136] Cf. Grégoire de Nysse, *La création de l'homme* (1948).
[137] E. Corsini, 'Plérôme humaine et plerôme cosmique' (1976).

describes, for us who are in time, an event that takes place along through our time (that is, the creation of individual men), but which exists, already accomplished, in God's single creative act, who created all men at once and instantly, in the sense that the whole human race is present in Adam (*Hom. opif.* 16,185C). Therefore God has already created all the beings that make up mankind: those who have already been, those who are, those who will be. The creation of the whole of mankind (πλήρωμα τῶν ἀνθρώπων) means the timeless and instantaneous character of God's creative act (*Hom. opif.* 22,205B). But the πλήρωμα is not placed in the eternity in which God is, but in the διάστημα, which is the unity of space and time in which the life of creation takes place: in the extension of time, creation takes place a little at a time introducing individuals according to a necessary and rational order and concatenation. Also for the cosmos there is, so to speak, a double creation, or, rather, there are two aspects of a single creation, of which one is seen on the side of God, the other on the side of created beings: in fact God created the world in an instant (*Hexaem.* 9; GNO IV/I, 18,1-11). Between the creation of the cosmos and that of man there is only one difference: the development of the world's *pleroma* is foreseen by God as an absolutely logical and necessary succession that starts from the first moment of the act of creation, while the development of the human *pleroma* is foreseen by God as a succession in which the evil movement of freedom, given to man initially as a good, produces the distinction of the sexes, which God has superimposed on man, His image, from the beginning, as he had foreseen sin, which would have prevented the way of reproduction that man would have carried out if he had not disobeyed God. There is, therefore, a modification of the original plan of God, but there are no two men created by God, of whom the one is 'ideal' and the other 'historical': there is only the concrete, historical man, the one we know now in his wretched condition, due to having committed sin. But God, despite having foreseen sin and, for this reason, having introduced the distinction of the sexes, did not make it necessary; the man in paradise, despite already being endowed with sex, could have lived a life of perfection in which there would have been neither male nor female.

Ugo Bianchi opposed this interpretation of Corsini, stating that Corsini neglects the tragedy of the creation of the leather tunics, that is, of corporeality, which did not exist in the first creation of man. The primordial sin of man is truly a second cause of creation, because, through foreknowledge and divine power, it enters the process of creation itself; the double creation derives from the influence exerted by Platonic ontological dualism: on the one hand the opposition between sensible and intelligible, on the other hand, the change for the worse and the inclination to evil are in a certain sense innate in the creature.[138]

[138] U. Bianchi, 'Presupposti platonici e dualistici' (1978), 103-11. The doctrine of double creation was also upheld by K.-H. Uthemann, 'Protologie und Eschatologie' (1999), 441-5.

Therefore, a review of the section of the *De opificio hominis* which concerns the creation of man is necessary.

Gregory himself suggests that the words of the Holy Scripture should be carefully examined. One thing is what is created according to the image, another what is before our eyes, in a condition of anguish (that is, according to the male and the female). In saying: 'So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created He him' the creation according to the image is concluded.[139] Then Scripture takes up the subject again (ἐπανάληψιν ποιεῖται), stating that 'male and female created He them'. The two characteristics are both of man, but they are placed according to a 'before' and an 'after', because first comes what is rational (προτερεύει τὸ νοερόν), as we learned from the story of the creation of man (that is, the first part of *Gen*. 1:27), while the communion and kinship (συγγένεια) with the irrational (that is, the creation of male and female) were added to man later (ἐπιγεννηματικὴν τῷ ἀνθρώπῳ) (*Hom. opif*. 181C). The verb προτερεύει recurs other times in the Nyssen, both in ideal meaning ('to be first with respect to another') and with temporal meaning ('to be before' another). It is this second meaning that is shown by the context of Gregory's reasoning. Corsini, on the other hand, following the translation of Laplace, translates with 'a le premier rang' and therefore accepts the first meaning.[140] But the temporal succession is also affirmed by Gregory in a second passage:

> He Who, as the prophetical writing says, 'knoweth all things before they be' (*Is*. 46:10) following out, or rather perceiving beforehand by His power of foreknowledge (ἐπακολουθήσας, μᾶλλον δέ, προκατανοήσας τῇ προγνωστικῇ δυνάμει) what, in a state of independence and freedom, is the tendency of the motion of man's will, – as He saw, I say, what would be, He devised in advance for His image (ἐπιτεχνᾶται τῇ εἰκόνι), the distinction of male and female, which has no reference to the Divine Archetype, but, as we have said, is an approximation to the less rational nature (*Hom. opif*. 16,14,185A).[141]

And a little further on Gregory adds: 'but the distinction of kind in male and female was added to His work last (*προσκατεσκευάσθη τελευταῖον*), as I suppose, for the reason which follows'. It follows, therefore, that Nyssen, at variance with Corsini's assertion, actually distinguishes a before and after in the creation of man, but this fact does not contradict a fundamental reality, which increasingly emerges in Nyssen and after him: in God there cannot be a before

[139] Τέλος ἔχει ἡ τοῦ κατ'εἰκόνα γεγενημένου κτίσις: this is 'the end of the creation', J. Behr, 'The Rational Animal' (1999), 234 and E. Corsini, 'Plerôme humaine et plerôme cosmique' (1971), 115 n. 1.

[140] See Laplace, Grégoire de Nysse, *La création de l'homme*: 'mais l'esprit tient le premier rang'. Daniélou's note to the passage (2002), 155 n. 1 is at variance with the translation: 'il s'agit de la préexistence intentionnelle, dans la pensée divine, de l'humanité totale qui, elle, n'existera qu'à la fin du temps'.

[141] Trans. Schaff, modified: neither here nor soon after, Schaff puts in evidence the meaning of ἐπι- or προσ-. Cf. also *Opif*. 16,185C.

and after, but everything must have existed simultaneously, and consequently Corsini's interpretation is right, even if not by means of the elimination of the 'temporal' succession, which was considered characteristic of the "double creation". To explain more clearly the contemporary creation of man in accordance with the image and the creation in accordance with the division of the sexes, Nyssen resorts to an interesting image: 'one may see in models those carved (διαγλύφους) shapes which the artificers of such things contrive for the wonder of beholders, tracing out upon a single head two forms of faces (δύο μορφὰς προσώπων)' (18,3,192C). Also later (*Cant*. XV; GNO VI, 457,21-458,3) Gregory affirms that God creates all things without a διάστημα.[142] The Nyssen excludes the temporal succession from the work of God in another fundamental point of anthropogony: 'In saying that "God created man" the text indicates, by the indefinite character of the term (τῷ ἀορίστῳ τῆς σημασίας), all mankind', that is, it says 'man', and not 'Adam' (16,16,185B). So the fullness of humanity (τὸ τῆς ἀνθρωπότητος πλήρωμα) is contained in one body (that of Adam) by the power of the God of the universe, which knows everything in advance.[143] The image of God is not found only in the individual, but his power 'extends throughout the whole human race (ἐφ'ἅπαν τὸ γένος … ἡ τοιαύτη διήκει δύναμις)' (16,17,185C).[144] For this reason, although the name of a single man is used (that is, Adam),[145] Scripture means the totality of humanity, because God can know everything before it is done, and 'to God's power nothing is either past or future (τῇ δυνάμει τοῦ θεοῦ οὔτε τι παρῴχηκεν οὔτε μέλλει)' (16,18,185D). Later Gregory again uses terms that indicate time: it is necessary to examine 'how *after* (μετά) the creation of the image, God *additionally* (ἐπί) devised the difference according to the male and female. This happened *after* (ἐπειδή) God foresaw with His power that the free will (of the protoplasts) would not go straight to the good and that for this reason it would fall far from the angelic life, but would spread in the manner of beasts (189CD). And even further: God said 'grow and multiply' not when (οὐ γὰρ ὅτε) He created according to the image, but when (ἀλλ'ὅτε) He had created the male and the female (22,205A). With Adam, not a part, but simul-

[142] That the alleged double creation is actually a simultaneous creation is also the interpretation of G. Mandolino, '"Like a riddle": double creation and image of God' (2018), 427. Mandolino, however, means the second creation as the creation of the individual man within the human race, following in this the explanation of Zachhuber.

[143] *Dan*. 13:42.

[144] According to Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 158, δύναμις is the immanent principle, present in every member of the species. The expression κατ' εἰκόνα does not mean 'according to the image' (of God) (which is the usual exegesis), but Adam and Eve, in being male and female, were 'in the form of an image', that is, of the universal. A summary of the problem in C. Arruzza, *Les mésaventures de la théodicée* (2011), 219-22, who, however, insists on the effective existence of a double creation in the works of Gregory of Nyssa, especially in *De verginitate*.

[145] The name 'Adam', as it is explained by the Jewish scholars, means 'earthly creature (πλάσμα γήϊνον)'.

taneously the entire totality of human nature was created (ἅπαν ἀθρόως τὸ τῆς φύσεως πλήρωμα: 22,204D). God did not want the creation of men to take place a little at a time and that the number of souls should reach its fullness (ἐπὶ τὸ ἴδιον πλήρωμα)[146] progressively, but having conceived once and for all through his foreknowledge all human nature in its fullness (ἀθρόως αὐτῷ πληρώματι πᾶσαν τὴν ἀνθρωπίνην φύσιν διὰ τῆς προγνωστικῆς ἐνεργείας κατανοήσας) and having honoured it with the equality with the angels, since He foresaw the fall of man, He did not devise the angelic multiplication, but the sexual one (17,189CD). In conclusion, it is not clear what the function of a 'first creation' is, if not that of being a simple concept (a universal, according to Zachhuber's interpretation). But Gregory of Nyssa never means it as a concept.

If, therefore, there were no two creations of man, the man created was simultaneously in the image of God and differentiated according to sex. After having affirmed that the relationship between man and God is not that proposed by Greek philosophy, between microcosm and macrocosm (16,177C-180A), but that enshrined in the biblical text and by the Church, of man created in the image and likeness of God, the Nyssen resumes the examination of the scriptural passage and proposes his doctrine with a certain insecurity, as a hypothesis, as he underlines several times (16,180C and 180D)[147] and with a philological attitude (16,181AB) and also using rhetoric, which he had taught as a young man.

How is it possible, he wonders, that man is like God, two such different realities? First of all, the Holy Scripture intends to reject the opinion of the heretics: since it says that the Only-Begotten God[148] made man in the image of God, it is absolutely impossible to distinguish between the divinity of the Father and that of the Son, that is, between the One who made man (the Son, in fact) and the One in whose image man was made (οὗ κατ'εἰκόνα ἐγένετο) (180D). As regards the problem of the impossibility of a similarity between God and man, first the sacred text says that God created man according to the image (κατ'εἰκόνα), then resumes speaking (ἐπανάληψιν ποιεῖται), stating that He made him male and female. Consequently, the differentiation into male and female is something extraneous to the model (ἔξω τοῦτο τοῦ πρωτοτύπου νοεῖται): the 'prototype' is God (and not the original man according to the interpretation of the 'double creation'), so much so that, as the apostle says (*Gal*. 3:28), there is neither male nor female in Jesus (181A). Gregory, therefore, takes up the traditional interpretation of the similarity between man and God according to the intellect, to which he adds the difference between the sexes, which he regards as something foreign to the similarity itself. This

[146] The term πλήρωμα also in *Opif*. 22,205D.

[147] This is Nyssen's attitude also in the contemporaneous *Hexaem*. 6 (GNO IV/I, 13,7-11), 21 (33,1-7), 23 (35,17-8), about unusual problems, such as those of physics.

[148] That is, the Son, according to a tradition widely attested since the time of apologetics.

implies a doctrine of great importance, namely that man is placed in an intermediate position between the divine nature and that of the brutes: the rational and dianoetic part derives from God and does not include the difference between the sexes, which is 'foreign to the things that are thought about God' (ὅπερ ἀλλότριον τῶν περὶ Θεοῦ νοουμένων ἐστίν), but is not separated from the irrational and corporeal part and both form the man (181BC). The fact that Gregory attributes such an exceptional, intermediary position to human nature must also clarify the rest of the discussion, which does not contain 'tragic' interpretations, as Bianchi says, or pessimistic ones. Gregory therefore repeats the succession of creation, from plants to man (181C), which he had presented before discussing the problem of the creation of man,[149] and explains what the qualities that man possesses thanks to his resemblance to God consist of: this is also a totally 'positive' and optimistic description. God is the good, or even beyond good (ἐπέκεινα ὤν) (16,184A) or the whole reality of the good (πλήρωμα τῶν ἀγαθῶν) (16,184B): man is in his image in all the goods of God, with the exception that God exists without having been created, man was created (184C); he is an image of God just as the Caesar that is imprinted on the coin is an image of the real Caesar (184D), which does not eliminate the great diversity between the two. Once again, this description of the dignity of man is typical of the Nyssen, who certainly admits that there is a sexual reality in man (and therefore subjected to passion), but in his anthropology he shows himself no less optimistic than the other two Cappadocians (and in general than the Greek mentality), underlining that among the goods granted by God to man, there is in the first place free will, which is the only quality that unites man to God himself and allows him, at the same time, to exercise virtue.

In confirmation and further explanation of his thought, Gregory subsequently deals with the objection of some unknown adversaries, namely that the sacred text speaks of human procreation not before sin, but after sin. Therefore, according to them, sin would have been a positive fact, because it allowed the multiplication of man through sexual experience (17,188AB). Gregory's answer is based on Christ's to the Sadducees (*Matth.* 22:30), who taught that the children of the resurrection do not marry, because they have become similar to angels. Also for the angels, in fact, there was a multiplication in number, because there are infinite myriads, which however do not multiply through sexual experience, but in a way that is unknown to us. If we had not deviated from the angelic life through sin, we would not have needed marriage either. It is impossible to say what this mode of growth is, but it would also have been that of the protoplasts that had been created 'slightly lower than the angels'

[149] In the *De anima et resurrectione* it is said that the soul was created by God in the beginning as purely rational, while the irrational aspect (that is, irascible and concupiscible) was an addition due to sin (GNO III/III, 41,11-43,16) – and in any case this addition was not made to cause damage to the soul (42,4-6).

(*Psalm* 8:5) (17,189A).[150] Instead the creation by means of the passions happened according to the way of the beasts, which already existed before man (man having been created last) (18,191A), that is, with the addition of the division of the sexes, which existed in beasts. From the πάθος, produced by the generation through sex, all the other πάθη of human life derive (18,191BC).

John Behr also denies any double creation and asserts that according to Gregory the condition of man contained *ab initio* the division of sexes.[151] He observes that Nyssen places the creation of man in a context, in the first fifteen chapters, dealing with anthropology in a way that excludes any negative vision of materiality in man: in fact, materiality exists because man took it on, when he was the last of God's creations, by incorporating the previously created realities (the bodily and the psychic), on account of which sexuality is not the negative consequence of the fall, but already existed before it.[152] The negative consequence of the fall is the perverse use of materiality itself, that is, of passion, just as elsewhere Gregory affirms that passion cannot be condemned in itself, but only in its perverse use, while if it is used in the right way it can produce positive consequences, as shown by the examples of Phinehas, Daniel, Moses. Human nature has always existed as male and female, even if this characteristic has no relationship with the divine archetype,[153] but it is part of the affinity and communion with irrational animals, which God Himself had created. The rational soul is the completion of the nutritive soul and the sensible soul; the rational form of life, that of the human being, includes all the previous ones. But human beings, since, unlike God, they are unstable by nature, can turn towards the lower reality and make themselves similar to what is irrational, to their difference as male and female, to the bestial need to provide for their succession.[154] The impulses of irrational nature which, for animals, are the essential means for their conservation, when they are transferred to man, become passions (18,192AB). It is above all 'to the animal way of generation' that Gregory attributes the origin of all passions and the subjugation to pleasures, and therefore the wretched state of human nature. Be that as it may, it is 'the evil administration of the mind' that perverts all the irrational impulses, making them passions (18,193B), whereby also sexuality should have been used in a truly rational or angelic way. This angelic way of multiplication of humanity

[150] This solution also implies the other, equally known and debated, but which need not be considered here: the resurrection is the return to the angelic condition (189B).

[151] J. Behr, 'The Rational Animal' (1999), 245-7.

[152] Man develops from the seed to the completed form, because what is potentially (δυνάμει) present in the seed is what will then become implemented in the operation (ἐνέργεια): *Opif.* 29, 236AC.

[153] This relationship consisting substantially in the virtues that Gregory himself describes, and in free will, as mentioned above.

[154] Their succession would otherwise have been analogous to the angelic propagation of which Gregory speaks in chap. 17.

contrasts with the irrational and animal way of generation, hence Gregory, when referring to an angelic way of reproduction of the prelapsarian human species, does not refer to an asexual way of multiplying, but to a rational and truly human use of our created sexuality. He repeats what he considers to be the intent of Christ's words in *Luke* 20:35-6 and considers an alternative form of marriage in Paradise possible (or does not exclude it). The conception manifested in chapters 15 and 16-22 is basically unitary; it is based on man's capacity for elevation or degeneration and, importantly, he never refers to the distinction between male and female in the first section (of chapters 1-15), but in the second; the distinction between male and female is a characteristic that truly belongs to the human being, but in any case it is not limited only to a bestial procreation for the conservation of the species, but should conform with man's rational existence. The distinction between male and female must not be interpreted in its purely beastly use or subject to passion, but according to what the human being should really be, that is, rational.

Up to this point this is Behr's explanation, which has many things in its favour. The very creation of the leather tunics was done with a positive purpose. And yet it is obvious that generation according to sex constitutes a *pathos*, and the Nyssen himself affirms that the other *pathe* derive from the *pathos* of generation through sex. So Behr's optimistic interpretation cannot be absolute, because *pathos* cannot be eliminated from human nature, even if God wants it to be governed by reason, so that it should become positive (in itself pathos is not positive). The problem, therefore, is that of the existence of passion: the sin of man, in fact, was an aberration of his free will – and therefore a purely intellectual fact, that is, an error, according to the stoic definition – that produced the perverse use of passion, suggested by the serpent. But passion (which is not exclusively sexual) can and must be dominated: it is not in itself negative; the perverse use of it, which was produced by the sin of the progenitors, is condemnable. For this reason Smith opposes Behr's interpretation by attributing the distinction of the sexes and the passions to the original fall.[155] So we repeat what we have observed so far: the division into male and female fell within the original plan of God, and was not introduced in view of the fall; the passion implicit in sexual union was foreseen by God, but on condition that, by means of the dominion over passion, it was part of the gradual creation of the world, which placed man at the top. The problem of apocatastasis remains: the man who will be reconstituted at the end of time will be equal not to the man who was able to sin, so that the punishment of the sins committed in this life will be eternal, but to the man created perfect by God.[156]

[155] J. Warren Smith, 'The Body of Paradise' (2006), 214-9 insists above all on this point.

[156] Smith himself introduces a question that I have difficulty in understanding: since the perverse use of passion was caused by original sin, in the eschatological reality a body will be reconstituted without passion: but what is the purpose of this purified body, if it has no function

The explanation given in *De virginitate* (12,2) is no different. Man created according to the image did not inherently possess, in his first creation, the punishable and corruptible element (συνουσιωμένον … ἐν ἑαυτῷ παρὰ τὴν πρώτην γένεσιν τὸ παθητικόν τε καὶ ἐπίκηρον), because if the beauty manifested in man had been different from the archetype, man could not have preserved the image. In this statement the words παρὰ τὴν πρώτην γένεσιν means 'immediately in his creation', not 'in the first creation', opposed to a second. This coincides with what is said in the *De opificio hominis*: *pathos* was attributed to man after his initial condition. The *De virginitate* contains other doctrines of the *De opificio hominis*: man possessed the likeness to God in the autonomy of his free choice (ἐν τῷ ἐξουσίῳ τῆς προαιρέσεως) and was not forced by any external necessity, but was governed according to his own decision (γνώμῃ). The wretchedness of his present condition is derived from the evil that man himself procured, it is not the work of God. Hence the first man, born from the earth (and therefore not the ideal man), of his own will (ἐθελοντής … τῇ ἰδίᾳ προαιρέσει) invented what was against nature, separating himself from virtue and doing evil. Once the consequence of sin had entered human life and the 'divine-shaped' beauty of the soul, created in imitation *of the prototype*, darkened as happens to iron, due to the rust of wickedness, the soul transformed itself into the horrible condition of sin and lost the nobility of being in the image, but clothed itself with the garment of sin.[157]

in reproduction (*ibid.* 226-8)? But Nyssen asserted the reconstitution not of a perfect body without passions, but of a non-material body, of which only its *eidos* will remain. This was very well clarified by Rowan Williams, 'Macrina's Deathbed Revisited' (1993), as we will see later.

[157] A judgment, different from the traditional one, has recently been made about *De virginitate*: Gregory of Nyssa does not intend to stifle sexual instincts, in fact he himself was married. Following the opinion of Mark Hart, 'Reconciliation of Body and Soul' (1990) and 'Gregory of Nyssa's Ironic Praise' (1992), John Behr in the above-mentioned essay suggests not interpreting the *De virginitate* as a work condemning *sic et simpliciter* marriage, but, basing himself on his new interpretation of the *De hominis opificio*, which admits the presence of passions, which are justified if they are controlled by reason, he maintains that the *De virginitate* is not a pure and simple exhortation to sexual abstinence, but an exhortation to use marriage in a rational way and corresponding with the dominion of the passions. I do not agree, however, with Behr when he rejects the traditional interpretation of *De virginitate* as a contrast between marriage and virginity. It is not possible to see in the *De virginitate* a total concordance with the *De opificio hominis*, because the *De virginitate* remains in many respects traditional, persistently using topoi in defence of virginity and the contrast between the latter and marriage (even if virginity must be understood in a broader sense, as is also maintained by Aubineau, Grégoire de Nysse, *Traité de la virginité* (1966), 165-78, that is, virginity from all passion, and therefore also from sin). Furthermore, to say that the Nyssen in *De virginitate* does not seriously criticize marriage, but only wants to be ironic about its difficulties, as Hart maintains, is not convincing and does not take into account the ascetic tendencies of the time, which are also present in other works by Gregory of Nyssa, and is clearly contradicted by the related cases of Gregory of Nazianzus, Jerome and others. Furthermore, virginity constitutes one of the various ways to return to the origin: the parable of the lost drachma is interpreted in *De virginitate* (ch. 13) in the sense of apocatastasis: finding the drachma means finding the image of God in its primitive state, which is currently hidden by the filth of the flesh;

Gregory of Nazianzus does not conceive any 'double creation' and his anthropogony has nothing in common with that of Gregory of Nyssa, but it is more traditional: this does not mean, however, that he does not propose, even if unsystematically, observations which are not trivial. An example is homily 38, dedicated to the birth of Christ, the only slightly more extensive and organic treatment that he wrote about the creation of man. The incarnation of the Son of God, he states, heals the human condition, which had been disfigured and destroyed by the sin of the protoplasts: 'this creature God placed in Paradise – whatever this Paradise was!' (*Orat*. 38,12; in *Arcana* 7,105 Gregory explains that 'the life of heaven is, I think, Paradise').[158] The interpretation of Paradise and Adam is both literal and spiritual. It is not clear how this 'life of heaven' should be understood: Sykes notes that 'the life of heaven means that Adam's status allowed him to share the life of the heavenly beings. There is no suggestion of an extra-terrestrial site for Paradise. Gregory treats this as a real place'. Therefore, Gregory interprets the story of Scripture literally, and maintains that the earthly paradise was on earth, but who these 'heavenly beings' were is not clear: in my opinion they are the angels, and Gregory did not think of a paradise 'on earth'. Interpreting spiritually, he rejects any material element in Paradise and states that Adam in heaven cultivated immortal plants (*Orat*. 38,12; *Arcana* 7,105-6) and the seeds, that is, divine thoughts, both the simplest and the most perfect ones:[159] that is, the theology of the simple, as it is said in *Homily* 32, and the theology of the most perfect, that is, the spiritual. Adam was a "simple" man, as evidenced by the fact that he was naked, that is, without any ambiguity (*Orat*. 38,12; *Arcana* 7,104).[160] Nazianzen takes from Philo his interpretation of the trees of Paradise, which are the symbol of Adam's thoughts

we must, therefore, become like the first man by retracing the stages of the fall in reverse: abandoning the conjunction of the sexes, the extreme stage of exile, earthly wretchedness, the leather tunics, the thoughts of the flesh, the fig leaves of bitter life, the illusions of taste and sight to be united only with God, in the delights of paradise. This is the usual interpretation of 1*Cor* 7. The interpretation of Hart and Behr is also rejected by A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea* (2018), 190-1: marriage is an example of the theology of the good proposed by the Nyssen: it certainly is not a bad thing, and yet it is not a good *in itself*, if it is not compared with other goods. Similarly, Valerie Karras, 'A Re-evaluation of Marriage' (2005) also rejects the idea that *De virginitate* has an ironic attitude towards those who reject marriage and maintains that the Nyssen positively proposes both married life as a life that offers the possibility of a virtuous life as a service (*leitourghia*), and virginity as a positive and active way of life, according to the model of the Nyssen's brother, Basil. In any case, Behr's study has marked a decisive change, as has also been acknowledged by Morwenna Ludlow, who maintains that there was a development from the Nyssen's early works (*Virg*. and *Mort*.) to his subsequent ones (*An*., *Moys*. and *Macrin*.), which see the human body as 'second-best' ('Gregory of Nyssa and the Body' [2006]).

[158] D. Sykes, *Poemata Arcana* (1997), 246.

[159] The verb 'cultivate' (γεωργέω) is used by Gregory of Nyssa (*Opif*. 18,192D) with a symbolic meaning to indicate the right growth of human passions under the care of reason.

[160] This would have been an explanation dating back to Irenaeus, who believed that Adam was a child.

(and perhaps also of the tree of knowledge, which symbolizes the *theoria*).[161] Philo had proposed a similar explanation in *Plant*. 36-40,[162] and he affirmed that it is necessary to employ the allegorical method for this explanation of *Gen*. 2:15 (ch. 36):

> Indeed, the sacred oracles most evidently afford us the clues for the use of this method. For they say that in the garden there are trees in no way resembling those with which we are familiar, but trees of Life, of Immortality, of Knowledge, of Apprehension, of Understanding, of the Conception of the good and evil. And these can be no growths of earthly soil, but must be those of the responsible soul […] We must conceive therefore that the bountiful God plants in the soul as it were a garden of virtues and of the modes of conduct corresponding to each of them, a garden that brings the soul to perfect happiness.[163]

Gregory of Nyssa says that as a consequence of the evil committed, man destroyed his original dignity (*Eccl*. VI, 9; GNO V, 386), he tied himself to materiality (indicated by the 'leather tunics', with which our ancestors dressed themselves according to the account of *Gen*. 3:21) and disfigured the image of God in which man had been made. The meaning of the 'leather tunics', which the Cappadocians derive from the Origenian tradition, is explained by the Nyssen elsewhere (*Catech*. 8; GNO III/IV, 30,5-6): the fall of the first parents indicates the materialization of the man due to the tendency to passion, which leads to death, but the current condition will have to cease with the return to the original condition.

Nazianzen too follows Origen's well-known interpretation of the 'garments of skin' with which God covered the protoplasts after they had become aware of their nakedness, and banished them from Paradise, and suggests that they signify the human body. Nevertheless, Gregory underlines his uncertainty with regard to this interpretation: '(man) was dressed in tunics of skin … coarse, mortal and rebellious flesh, *perhaps*' (*Orat*. 38,12). This is repeated in *Arcana* 7,115: the Son 'clothed his now heavy flesh in coats of skin, becoming his own corpse-bearer' (δερματίνους δὲ χιτῶνας ἐφέσσατο σάρκα βαρεῖαν / νεκροφόρος), where however one does not find the expression of uncertainty ('perhaps') of *Orat*. 38.

[161] C. Moreschini, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 38-41 (1990), 128-9.

[162] Runia asserts that Gregory of Nazianzus never made use of Philo's works, D.T. Runia, *Philo in Early Christian Literature* (1993), 229-33, but instead of perusing Nazianzen's orations or letters, he limits himself to refuting Trisoglio's opinion that Nazianzen had employed Philo in his homily *On the love of the Poor* (n. 14), F. Trisoglio, 'Filone Alessandrino e l'esegesi cristiana' (1985). Runia is right in his confutation of Trisoglio, but it is certain that Gregory took up some of Philo's doctrines, Cl. Moreschini, 'Il platonismo cristiano' (1974), 1371 and 1384; *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 38 and 48.

[163] Trans. Colson – Whitaker, LCL.

Evagrius proposed an anthropogony which, like his other doctrines, was linked to that of Origen. In fact, he did not change Origen's thinking by removing the more daring aspects, as the other Cappadocians had done, but he drew it from the Egyptian monastic environment in which he lived.

God's first creation, he says, was that of the intellects, whose sole purpose was to know Him. But the original peace and unity between God and the intellects were broken by the 'first movement', which produced the separation of the intellect from the first Unity (*KG* III 22). This movement occurred because the intellect enjoyed free will (*KG* VI 75). Following this fall, the intellect became a soul (*Epist. Melan.* 618,1-3 Frankenberg), which is defined as follows: 'the soul is the intellect which, because of its negligence, has fallen out of the Unity and which, because of its neglect, has come down to the rank of practice' (*KG* III 28).[164]

The fall of the intellect, which became a soul, led God to make a second creation: that is, the creation of bodies and material realities. This happened so that the intellect could again obtain, through the contemplation of created beings, the essential knowledge together with its primitive state (*KG* VI 20). The body, in fact, in its present condition, is an indispensable tool: the return to knowledge occurs for the fallen intellect by means of sensible knowledge. Evil, on the other hand, is not intrinsic to the body (*KG* III 53 and 59): the doctrine of the Gnostics and Manichaeans who blaspheme the Creator for having created the body is absolutely to be rejected. The story of *Genesis* concerns the second creation, while the first creation has not been told by anyone (*KG* II 64 and 69). In conclusion, 'all that has been produced has been produced for the gnosis of God, but, among beings, some are first, others second. Gnosis is before the first beings and movement is before the second beings (*KG* I 50 and 61)': 'Before' means 'the cause'.

The fallen intellect, which has become a soul, has lost its unity and is divided into three parts: the rational, the irascible and the concupiscible one (*KG* VI 85). The term "soul" indicates, as often, the set of the three parts, or only the set formed by the irascible and the concupiscible parts; the intellectual part, which corresponds to the primordial intellect which had fallen, is the *nous*.

After the movement by which the intellects separated from the original condition, and after Providence intervened to allow them to acquire some knowledge, the intellects were able to implement the judgment (*KG* VI 75). It is not a punishment, but it is the creation of a world which assigns to each intellect a body corresponding to its state. However, there is no difference in nature between the various categories of second beings: they are distinguished only by the varying composition of their soul and body. In fact, in the angels the intellect and the fire predominate, in men concupiscence and the earth, in the

[164] That is, it fell into the need to practise asceticism to obtain purification.

demons irascibility and the air (*KG* I 68): at this point it is not clear if the different composition of the various intellectual beings depends on the fall from their primitive state or on the mission, entrusted to them by God, to come to the aid of fallen intellects. God's providence does not cease to be exercised in creation and in the various worlds, which are, therefore, not only spatial but also eternal realities (Evagrius uses the two technical words that have this meaning: κόσμος and αἰών).

All rational beings, whatever world they belong to, can, using their freedom, fall or rise: the angels can fall into the demonic state, as Lucifer did (his fall must be understood as the abandonment of the monad: *Epist. fidei* 9, 34,21-5 Courtonne), but they can become archangels due to the progress in gnosis. All rational creatures (therefore also the angels) have a propensity for both good and evil (*Epist. fidei* 9, 33,4-7). Just as men fear becoming demons, so demons fear falling into extreme corruption (*KG* I 57), but in any case the demon is not evil in its essence (*KG* IV 59).

The Final Resurrection and the Return to the Origin

Man's return to his origin is a central theme in Gregory of Nyssa and widely studied.[165] It will happen when the totality of humanity, already thought by God *ab initio*, has come to its completion. Currently, due to its mobile nature, it does not cease to proceed towards its multiplication (*Opif.* 21,1; PG 46, 201B). Once the temporal movement of the growth of humanity will have come to an end, the reconstitution of the universe will take place (τὴν τοῦ παντὸς ἀναστοιχείωσιν), that is, the final resurrection:

> I think that we ought to understand about ourselves, that on passing the limit of wickedness we shall again have our conversation in light, as the nature of good, when compared with the measure of wickedness, is incalculably superabundant. Paradise therefore will be restored, that tree will be restored which is in truth the tree of life; – there will be restored the grace of the image, and the dignity of rule. It does not seem to me that our hope is one for those things which are now subjected by God to man for the necessary uses of life, but one for another kingdom, of a description that belongs to unspeakable mysteries (*Opif.* 21,3-4; PG 46, 201D-204A).[166]

De anima et resurrectione is the first comprehensive and in-depth treatment in Greek Christianity of the final resurrection: the need for an adequate treatment of this problem is clear from the effort that Nyssen puts into writing his treatise,

[165] On this problem, see M. Alexandre, 'Protologie et eschatologie' (1981); K.-H. Uthemann, 'Zur Rezeption des Origenes' (1999), 429-49, with an extensive bibliography (in which, however, wrongly, there is no reference to Corsini).

[166] Also *ibid.* 16,188CD, 189B; *Mort.* GNO IX, 56,16-7; *Pulch.* GNO IX, 472,6-11; J. Daniélou, *L'être et le temps* (1970), 205-26.

which represents one of the most replete in thought among those he composed. The resurrection of the body, in fact, had not yet become dogma, although it was considered such in the symbol of the Council of Constantinople in 381; Gregory of Nazianzen had also said that it belongs to the themes that can be the object of 'philosophy', that is, of discussion according to the Christian faith, such as the existence of the world or of multiple worlds, of matter, of the soul, of rational natures, the good and the bad ones, the final judgment, the retribution, the sufferings of Christ: 'in this area reaching the truth is useful, while not reaching it does no harm (to the faith)' (*Orat*. 27,10).[167] Also in *Carm*. II 1,12, 309-26 (PG 37, 1188-9), Gregory of Nazianzus states what should be the subjects of Christian teaching:[168] the divine monad and the triad, the angels, the intelligible world, providence, the soul and the body, the first and second law, the resurrection and how two realities so opposed to each other like spirit and matter can join together, death and resurrection, the judgment and the future life of the just and of sinners.

Nyssen intends to explain how it is possible that the soul, which is immortal, unites, at the end of time, with the risen body, in order to reconstitute the unity that had occurred on earth (and which according to Origen, on the contrary cannot be reconstituted, because the body will be destined for destruction together with all the matter of this world, all the more so since the pedagogical function of the body will end once the resurrection has taken place). This problem is resolved by Gregory through the principle that intelligible natures are not subject to the laws of the spatial dimension; the intelligible is unextended (ἀδιάστατον), so it does not behave like bodies, which have their location, procured by the natural order of the material elements that constitute them (*An*. GNO III/III, 30,1-15). For this reason, the intelligible, unlike what happens for bodies and their material constituents, when combined with the sensible, is not subject to the order of the elements, each of which, instead, has its own and specific place.[169] The intelligible, transcending every place, can remain tied to the elements of the body even if they are far from each other in space, and does not abandon

[167] D. Winslow, *Dynamic of Salvation* (1979), 37-43 wondered how some of these problems can be considered unimportant for a Christian and examines this passage together with the parallel ones in Gregory, *Orat*. 2,35-6 (where, however, Gregory does not distinguish between established dogmas of faith and doctrines still under discussion) and *Orat*. 40,45, concluding that it cannot be thought that the problem of the salvation of the body was not a basic problem for Gregory. I think that Gallay is right in stating that the Nazianzen simply meant that 'sur ces points tout n'est pas défini, ou plus précisement, que tout n'est pas parfaitement explicite dans l'Écriture', Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 27-31 (1978), 96-7. Also according to Evagrius, the Gnostic, although having the main task of combating heresies, has a certain freedom to discuss the problems that are not yet part of the dogmatic definitions, A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 332.

[168] See above, p. 41.

[169] This is said in *Hexaem*. 22 (GNO IV/I, 34,21-35,3).

them even if they once again become part of their totality, however large the distance that separates them (*ibid*. 31,5-15). This explains how the soul of Lazarus can be in the bosom of Abraham and that of Dives in the underworld, and each being aware of the body to which it had been tied in life.[170] In short, the soul enjoys ubiquity and, thanks precisely to its intelligible nature, transcends every category related to space; moreover it is 'simple' and 'not composed' – a quality, which it derives directly from God, Who is also simple and not composed – because it was made in His image: therefore, even if formed of parts, it does not divide but remains whole in each element in which it finds itself. In fact, what is not composed does not run the risk of dissolving together with what is composed (*ibid*. 27,13-28,21). The union between an intelligible reality like the soul and a material one like the body is totally different from physical unions (*Opif*. 12,157BD): the soul is not 'inside' the body, so as to be contained, nor outside the body, so as to contain it, but it is in contact with the body in a way that cannot be explained (*ibid*. 15,177BC). Probably Nyssen had drawn his doctrine of the soul from Porphyry. Plotinus had already denied that the soul could be tied to the body in any way (IV 3,20).[171] Porphyry deals with the problem of the contrast between what is corporeal, and which, therefore, as such, is determined and limited in the place, and what is incorporeal, which, instead, can never be traced back to the place (*Sent*. 1). For this reason, the incorporeal are not spatially in the body, but following their relationship with the body, not as in a cage, but in power, through which they unite with it. The incorporeal, even if it is united with the body, is not delimited in a spatial sense; the substance of the body, in fact, cannot prevent the soul from being wherever it wants and how it wants (Porph., *Sent*. 27,16-20). Also Nemesius, who takes up neo-Platonic doctrines, such as those of Ammonius and Porphyry, says that the soul, being incorporeal, is not circumscribed in one place, but penetrates entirely throughout the body (*Nat. Hom*. 129-33 Morani). The soul, therefore, is not in the body in the local sense, as the body is in a place, but in the way we say that God is in us. And just as God is everywhere, so the soul is everywhere (*Sent*. 31). Thanks to this quality, proper to the intelligible, the soul can reconstitute a unity with the body, as it possessed it in the moment of creation and in the course of life on earth. This reconstitution is possible because there is a form (εἶδος) in the body itself:

> while the form necessarily remains in the soul as in the impression of a seal, those things which have received from the seal the impression of its stamp do not fail to be

[170] E. Peroli, *Dio uomo e mondo* (2003); *id*., 'Gregory of Nyssa and the Neoplatonic Doctrine of the Soul' (1997). I confine myself to these observations on the problem of the soul-body relationship in Gregory of Nyssa; regarding problems of the body–soul–spirit triad and their functions cf. M.R. Barnes, 'The Polemical Context and Content' (1994), 20-4.

[171] This connection between Gregory of Nyssa and Plotinus has been noted by A. Meredith, 'The Concept of Mind in Gregory of Nyssa' (1989), 45.

recognized by the soul, but at the time of the World-Reformation, it receives back to itself all those things which correspond to the stamp of the form: and surely all those things would so correspond which in the beginning were stamped by the form; thus it is not beyond probability that what properly belongs to the individual should once more return to it from the common source (*opif*. 27,5,225D – but the whole chapter is important because of this problem).[172]

The εἶδος is the stable and immutable part of man, while materiality is something that has been added to it from the outside, in the manner of the skin that, in Naaman the Syrian, had been transformed and healed by Elisha (2*Kings* 5) (*Opif*. 27,4,228A). Consequently,

> does the soul know the natural peculiarities of those atoms whose concourse makes the frame of the body in which it has itself grown, even after the scattering of those atoms. However far from each other their natural propensity and their inherent forces of repulsion urge them, and debar each from mingling with its opposite, none the less will the soul be near each by its power of recognition, and will persistently cling to the familiar atoms, until their concourse after this division again takes place in the same way, for that fresh formation of the dissolved body which will properly be, and be called, resurrection (*An*. 54,16-24).[173]

At the moment of resurrection, the soul is able to recognize the characteristics of the body, which had been around it during life, and therefore can put it on again (*Opif*. 27,228BC). Therefore the εἶδος of the body allows the soul, which is incorporeal, to recognize and attract to itself the elements of the body.

The resurrection is the restitution of our nature in its original condition, that of creation by God himself ('apocatastasis'): this is not an easy problem and is the subject of numerous current studies on Gregory of Nyssa and his antecedents, which we do not now intend to discuss again.[174] Basil and the Nazianzen partly followed and partly diverged from the interpretation of Gregory of Nyssa, who approved and, at the same time, criticized Origenian apocatastasis. Its simplest statement, in accordance with the destination of the work, is in *Catech*. 26 (GNO III/IV, 67,6-12).

Furthermore, according to the Nyssen, apocatastasis cannot mean the return to a celestial city of souls (*An*. GNO III/III, 80,8-97,15; *Opif*. 28,229B-233B), contrary to what pagan doctrine maintained about the pre-existence and transmigration of souls. Nazianzen agrees with Nyssen on the rejection of the

[172] Also *Mort*. (GNO IX, 59,25, 63,1, 64,7). As M. Alexandre, 'Protologie et eschatologie' (1981), 133-4, 146-50 has noted, it is a transposition of the Origenian doctrine, which can be read in *Comm*. *Psalm*. 1, in Methodius (*Resurr*. I 20-4), and Epiphanius (*Pan*. 64,10-6). This body will be 'light and airy' (Greg. Nyss., *An*. 79,15), despite the fact that Methodius (*Resurr*. III 16) criticized this expression, considering it still too Origenian.

[173] Trans. Schaff.

[174] Some of these studies tend to see the presence of the doctrine of apocatastasis almost everywhere in Christian thought.

pre-existence of souls. At the beginning of *Orat*. 37,15 he introduces a polemical note with Origen, whom he nevertheless never mentions:

I fear at this point that some people might get an absurd idea into their heads, for instance that the soul may have lived elsewhere (ἀλλαχοῦ πολιτευσαμένη) and subsequently was connected to this body of ours, and that, depending on its conduct in the other world, some were given the gift of prophecy, while others – those who lived dishonestly – were condemned.

The reference to Origen's doctrine (which is condemned as 'absurd') of the pre-existence of souls is evident:[175] the most relevant passage in this sense is *Princ*. I 7,4.[176] Note that the term πολιτεύειν, which Nazianzen uses, also reappears in Gregory of Nyssa's account in *Opif*. 28,1 and 7, PG 229BD: 'Some of those before our time who have dealt with the question of "principles" think it right to say that souls have a previous existence as a people in a society of their own (ἐν ἰδιαζούσῃ πολιτείᾳ τὰς ψυχὰς προϋφεστηκέναι) … and that they are by reason of wickedness bound to their bodies (εἰ γὰρ διά τινος κακίας ἀποσπασθεῖσα τῆς ὑψηλοτέρας ἡ ψυχὴ πολιτείας…)'. The Nyssen condemns the idea that the soul, once it has stained itself with guilt in a previous life, must be chained to the body as a chastisement. It is attested to by Epiphanius (*Pan*. 64,4,6), as well as Justinian's epistle to Menna (p. 212,20 Schwartz = framm. 13, p. 91 Koetschau; p. 201,31-3: 'in the flesh, as in a jail' (ὡς ἐν δεσμωτερίῳ τῇ σαρκί).[177]

[175] *PA* I 4,7. The Maurists thought that here Gregory was polemicizing with the Pythagoreans and their doctrine of metempsychosis, but Origen was also accused of professing metempsychosis (Hieron., *Epist*. 124,4).

[176] *Oration* 37, Nazianzen's only homily of an exegetical nature, is dedicated to an interpretation of *Matth*. 19:1-12, which concerns 'those who choose to live like eunuchs for the sake of the Kingdom of Heaven', and frequently re-elaborates Origenian motifs: as I observed, Cl. Moreschini, 'Influenze di Origene su Gregorio Nazianzeno' (1979) = *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 97-116, it was natural that, in commenting on *Matthew*, Gregory should draw on the exegesis of the greatest and most renowned commentator of that Gospel (see Orig., *Matth. Comm*. XIV 14 – XV 5). He who receives the gift of prophecy may be, the Nazianzen says, a Jeremiah, sanctified even before he is born (*Jer*. 1:5), while he who receives the chastisement in the pre-earthly life might be Esau. Both these examples are from Origen (*Princ*. I 7,4). Gregory's objection to Origen is suggested by the comment on *Matth*. 19:11 ('Not everyone can receive this saying, but only those to whom it is given'): Gregory excludes from these words any interpretation along Valentinian lines, which might introduce a division into 'psychic', 'material' and 'spiritual' nature. The sentence 'those to whom it was given' only implies a propension (νεῦσις) towards good or evil, which must always be linked to help from God, in order to achieve the objective one has set oneself. It is necessary, therefore, for free will (τὸ ἐφ' ἡμῖν) to exist as well as God's help (τὸ ἐκ θεοῦ) (*Orat*. 37,13-4). Gregory also speaks of ἐπιτηδειότης, like Apollinaris (*Matthäus-Kommentare aus der griechischen Kirche aus Katenenhandschriften* gesammelt und herausgegeben, *TU* 61 [Berlin, 1957], n. 95a12-26), when he interprets the same passage from *Matthew*. M. Kertsch, 'L'esegesi di Mt 19,11-12 in Gregorio Nazianzeno e Giovanni Crisostomo' (1991) observes that Gregory of Nazianzus' interpretation was taken up by John Chrysostom.

[177] It is true that in those Justinian passages reference is made to the 'moon, the stars and the supracelestial waters' (that is, the spiritual powers), but among those intellects there are also rational souls.

The Nyssen does not always explain exactly what the resurrected body is like: now he says that the purified soul will return to being according to the image and likeness, or that 'the body shaped by the hands of God was made what the resurrection of the dead in due time will reveal to be. For such as you may see it, just such it was made at the first' (*Eccl. Hom.* I 13; GNO V, 296,12-20). The risen body will be transformed and spiritualized (*An.*; GNO III/III, 116,11-123,2) and 'since God is neither male nor female … when we are all one in Christ, we will strip ourselves of the signs of this physical difference together with the old man' (*Cant.* VII; GNO VI, 213,1-6).[178]

Also according to Basil, the return of Christ at the end of time will produce the end of the worst element in us and the resurrection of the best element, which will destroy the passions of the body and manifest the peculiarities of the soul. In fact, the biblical passage of *Luke* 2:34 ('this child is set for the fall and rising again of many in Israel; and for a sign which shall be spoken against') is not to be understood in the sense that He is the cause of some to stand up and others to fall (*Epist.* 260,7). 'Nay, just as death, that is, death in the flesh, which was transmitted to us through Adam, was swallowed up by the divine nature (κατεπόθη ὑπὸ τῆς θεότητος), so too sin was destroyed by the righteousness which is in Christ Jesus, so that we in the resurrection resume the flesh that is neither liable to death nor subject to sin' (*Epist.* 261,3).

In the same vein Nazianzen asserts that when the final resurrection shall take place,

> the soul shall once again take from the earth this miserable flesh that is intrinsic to it, which had given it and to which it was then reconsigned… This shall take place in the way that only God knows, who conjoined and then dissolved these substances; the soul's destiny, together with the flesh, is the glory of the hereafter and, as in this life it participated in the evil orderings of the flesh on account of conjoint nature with it (διὰ τὴν συμφύΐαν), so too in the afterlife will it partake in the joys that are its lot, because it will consume all of the flesh, until it renders it like unto itself (ὅλον τὸ σαρκίον εἰς ἑαυτὴν ἀναλώσασα); and together with the flesh it shall form one thing, one spirit, one mind, one God (ἕν καὶ πνεῦμα και νοῦς καὶ θεός), because the mortal and transient

[178] A. Le Boulluec, 'Corporéité ou individualité?' (1995) wondered if, for Gregory of Nyssa, the resurrected body had its own identification after the loss of corporeity, and found, based above all on *De mortuis*, that it consists in joy and love (that is, in two 'passions' that are connected with corporeity). There are two stages in the eschatological life according to the Nyssen: in the first stage the human body still bears the sign of its virtues, while the second will be the eternal stage, in which all will be similar to each other. Here it is clear that the Nyssen refers to universal salvation, see *Mort.* 66,1-3, also J. Farrugia, HAMAPTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 228. About eschaton, see M. Ludlow, *Universal Salvation* (2000), 73-6. V.E.F. Harrison, 'Gregory of Nyssa on Human Unity and Diversity' (2006) distinguishes the 'Temporary Modes of Diversity' (336-9) from the 'Eschatological Diversity' (339-41) and 'Eschatological Unity' (341-4): eschatological unity and diversity characterize the individual. Morwenna Ludlow, 'Gregory of Nyssa and the Body' (2006), 374, also states that in his last works the Nyssen carries out 'a detailed defence of the material identity of the earthly and resurrection bodies'.

aspect will have been absorbed by life (καταποθέντος ὑπὸ τῆς ζωῆς τοῦ θνητοῦ τε καὶ ῥέοντος) (*Orat*. 7,21).

This statement looks to the spiritualisation of the human body in the afterlife,[179] which Origen had put forward, although Nyssen's *De anima et resurrectione* is about fifteen years later than Nazianzen's homily 7, on the death of Caesarios. The soul consumes the body until it becomes itself (ὅλον τὸ σαρκίον εἰς ἑαυτὴν ἀναλώσασα), that is, it dematerializes it and makes it like the soul, and becomes one with it (γενομένη σὺν τούτῳ): therefore, the body is not destroyed, but is transformed.[180] And it is interesting that, similarly to what frequently happens with Gregory of Nyssa's *De anima et resurrectione*, in a scholium it is hastily explained that Gregory 'does not say that the body is destroyed or fused in the soul: God forbid! But rather (is it said that the body dissolves in the soul) insofar as it takes on immutability and a lack of passions (διὰ τὴν ἀτρεψίαν καὶ ἀπαθὲς τοῦ σώματος)'.[181]

Evagrius' eschatology is very similar to that of the Nyssen, either because he learned it from the Nyssen himself or from their common teacher Origen.[182] Also according to Evagrius, men, having returned with their death to the world of angels, will receive and exercise from that moment angelic functions (*KG* III 65). Like angels, they will devote themselves to the salvation of rational creatures. But Evagrius places the world of angels within a development and a 'history' of a metaphysical character:

> While the transformations are numerous, we have only received the knowledge of four transformations… The first is the passage from evil to virtue, the second to the contemplation of the second nature,[183] the third from this contemplation to the knowledge of the rational beings and the fourth is the transition of the universe to the knowledge of the Holy Trinity (*KG* II 4).

[179] The statement of *Orat*. 40,8 ('and moreover we cannot be born a second time and cannot be recreated or brought back to our original condition: καὶ ταῦτα οὐκ οὔσης δευτέρας ἀναγεννήσεως οὐδὲ ἀναπλάσεως οὐδὲ εἰς τὸ ἀρχαῖον ἀποκαταστάσεως') seems to be a negation of apocatastasis. In fact, the Nazianzen simply means that, as long as we are in this life, we cannot return to the original condition of purity, for which baptism is necessary, which purifies from all sins.

[180] Daley believes that the transformation of the human body after resurrection, until it became immaterial and luminous, is analogous to that of the body of Christ when He ascended to heaven, B.E. Daley, '"The Human Form Divine"' (2006), 315-6. But according to Evagrius this happens already in earthly life thanks to contemplation.

[181] It is a pity that this scholium was not mentioned in the critical apparatus of the Sources Chrétiennes edition (n. 405).

[182] This is the opinion of Uthemann, cf. his summary, with many quotations from the works of Evagrius and extensive bibliographical information, K.H. Uthemann, 'Protologie und Eschatologie' (1999), 420-9.

[183] The second nature are the immaterial *logoi* of the things.

The 'knowledge of the Trinity' means union with God. The gnosis of God is gnosis without form, deiform, uniform, coextensive with the substance of the intellect, such as to fill it completely (*KG* IV 49). The union of the unified intellect with the divine Unity takes place in gnosis: the Trinity, in fact, constitutes the 'essential knowledge' (*KG* VI 10 and VI 28; *Epist. Fidei* 7; *Schol. Psalm.* 43,21)[184] and gnosis is unlimited (*KG* III 88) and requires the destruction of the body (*KG* II 6; II 62). Each of the worlds reached through successive transformations grants a certain level of knowledge, but in the end, all beings will reach it (*KG* III 51): the parallelism with Origen and the Nyssen is evident. Much more than the other Cappadocians Evagrius underlines the epistemic or contemplative character of human salvation: 'The kingdom of God the Father is the contemplation of divinity itself' (*Epist. fidei* 22; also *KG* VI 27, S2: 'toute la nature des *logikòi* se prosternera devant le nom du Seigneur, le quel fait connaître le Père qui est en lui').

Christ's saving action, which was exercised in a particular way through His incarnation, ends at the end of time. Even Evagrius, like the other Cappadocians and even before them Origen, bases his eschatology on the pericope of 1*Cor*. 15:24-8, and in particular on the words: 'He must reign until He has put all enemies under His feet': after the establishment of the kingdom of Christ, Christ Himself will hand over the kingdom to the Father and submit to Him, so that God may be all in everyone. To present his interpretation Evagrius uses the symbolic meaning of the days of the week, so this current world is Friday, what will come is Sabbath, during which God rests, and finally the eighth day is that of resurrection. Then Christ will give the essential knowledge.[185]

At the end of every world, for every rational nature, the judgment of God arrives, following which each intellect, according to its progress or its regression in gnosis, enters a new world and receives a new body suitable for it (*KG* II 75).[186] In a first eschatological period, therefore, Christ reigns over all created beings, destroys His enemies' hostility and will make His enemies disappear; rational beings will become His heirs, in drawing closer to the spiritual contemplation of natures. Subsequently Christ, no longer having to make rational beings go through the various contemplations, will devote himself only to the gnosis of God the Father (*KG* VI 33), which will make the intellect go back to its original rank, like the sick man who returns to health (*KG* III 42).

But Evagrius is more radical than the Nyssen and the Nazianzen: according to him with the return to the original condition the body will not be transformed,

[184] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 341.

[185] A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 213. This knowledge is a 'simple knowledge' (*Epist*. 58).

[186] On these aspects of Evagrius' metaphysics, see A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 344-56; J. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 123-30; A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 147-9.

but destroyed (*KG* I 26; III 66),[187] whereby man will only become intellect (*KG* III 6; III 15) and the intellect will be united to God, annihilated without any ontological difference, as an effective abolition between creature and creator (*The Great Letter* 22 and 27).[188] The intellect is stripped of everything added to it due to the first movement, namely the body, name and number (*KG* I 26). The body, in fact, had been donated by Providence to the fallen intellect so that, even if it had deprived itself of the essential gnosis, it could still exercise a form of gnosis, that is, that of sensible knowledge, and rise by its means to a higher degree of knowledge.[189] The change of bodies at the moment of passage into another world will work through a sort of purification, similar to that of fire, which burns evil but not one who is affected by evil (*KG* III 39). In this way the evil will be gradually eliminated and, after the final judgment, will no longer exist.

Together with the body the name will also disappear, because the diversity between angel, man and demon, which existed only provisionally for rational creatures, will disappear (*KG* II 17);[190] then the same happens to the number, and the final Monad will be established. And finally also the universe will disappear, with its succession of centuries. If the movement of the bodies has been subject to time, the transformation of the incorporeal will be exempt (*KG* II 87). Freed from the body and all that is linked to matter, the intellect will reach a condition of total nakedness, necessary to obtain the gnosis of God and the state of perfection, which he had enjoyed before the movement (*KG* III 15; III 6; I 65): this 'nakedness' means that man strips himself of the 'leather tunics'. Consequently, 'there will come a time when the body, soul and intellect will be only one thing because of the change in the will of the intellect … only one thing will be its nature, its substance and its name, which God had known'. When all the intellects have been unified, the equality of gnosis will be realized, because the equality of the substances will have been achieved. Having become equal and united among themselves and with Christ, the creatures will finally reach the gnosis of God, and none will remain excluded; the reconstituted intellect will return to enjoy the essential gnosis, that of God, in view of which it had been created; bliss is the conclusion of gnosis. The eschatological union, however, does not exclude the individuality of the individual intellect.[191]

[187] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 391-3.

[188] *Ibid.* 394-400; A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 68-9; B.E. Daley, 'Evagrius and Cappadocian Orthodoxy' (2016), 41.

[189] The function of impassivity and asceticism in this path will be considered later (p. 205-7).

[190] According to Konstantinovsky names, numbers, worlds were created by Christ, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 121-32; instead Casiday believes that the names of the Son and the Spirit were created by the Father, and therefore will never cease to exist (*Reconstructing the Theology* [2013], 149). It is difficult to choose between the two interpretations.

[191] On the return to escatological unity see A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 384-90; J. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 153-70. Konstantinovsky observes that Evagrius avoids the term 'apocatastasis', *ibid.* 170-2; A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 231-40.

Resurrection: Final Punishment or Reconstitution of the Origin?

The judgment of God, according to Gregory of Nazianzus, takes place in the soul, not in the body. This means 'one's weight or one's lightness within one's conscience, and the examination of God's law, as observed in our life' (*Carm.* I 2,34,254-6). For this reason, the punishments of the body and those of the soul will be spiritual: 'For wrongdoers, the shadows represent being cast far from God; the worm that gnaws and the fire signify the consumption of every material passion' (*ibid.* 256-60). If on the one hand it is clear that "external shadow", which will envelop evildoers, means being cast far from God (ἐκ θεοῦ πεσεῖν), how should the worm and the fire spoken of in the Scriptures be understood? They represent the consumption (τῆξις) of the corporeal passions: so this might point to a transient chastisement, which will cease when the bodily element ceases, once this latter has been consumed by fire. The spirituality of final rewards and punishments is also asserted by the Nazianzen in *Orat.* 16,9:

> Some shall be welcomed by the ineffable light to the contemplation of the Holy and Regal Trinity, which shall illuminate them with greater clarity and purity, and in its totality it shall penetrate the human mind in its totality. This, and this only is what I believe to be the Kingdom of Heaven; for the others instead, together with the other tortures, or rather, even more than the other tortures, there shall be the torture of being cast away by God and the interminable shame of one's own conscience (καὶ ἡ ἐν τῷ συνειδότι αἰσχύνη πέρας οὐκ ἔχουσα).
>
> Eternal beatitude, therefore, is the contemplation of God,[192] and damnation is being cast far from God, the interminable torment of one's conscience (*Orat.* 40,45).

According to the Nyssen, hell consists in a trial that is greater than all those that can be endured in earthly life, and has the purpose of producing the definitive purification of those who have not wanted to face it in this world through the exercise of virtue, asceticism and renunciation of materiality. The harshness of the hellish punishment will be in proportion to the evil that, in this life, has superimposed itself, like a callosity, on the soul of the sinner (*An.* 73,5-74,14), but hell has an exclusively purifying and pedagogical function, it does not fall within the realm of evil, which exists only through free will.

The serious problem therefore arises, of whether in the final resurrection the return to the original condition means *in itself* the return to God of all creatures, and therefore the non-eternity of punishment. Here too, scholars currently disagree. Nyssen does not explicitly pose the question: he asserts, however, that since Christ came to restore humanity and bring it back to its primitive condition, wickedness will not last forever, because this would be a failure of restoration and incarnation (*An.* 51,13; 74,14-75,2).[193] And,

[192] This statement has been extensively developed by Evagrius, as has been seen (p. 176).

[193] In the vast amount of studies on the problem, suffice it to mention the synthesis of Morwenna Ludlow, who believes that Gregory supports the universal salvation of sinners, M. Ludlow, *Universal*

however, as Farrugia[194] observes, 'it emerges as absolutely clear that, *as far as the homilies are concerned*, Gregory does not offer certainty on universal salvation': as has already been seen, in fact, the homiletic teaching of the Nyssen takes place at a simpler level than that of the treatises. For this reason, there is an effective description of hell in *In sanctum Pasch*. (GNO IX, 250, 2-12), and Gregory says that some will be punished after the judgement (*ibid*. GNO IX, 246,17-22) and 'have no hope', that is, they must be considered damned (*Mort*.; GNO IX, 68,14; *Beat. Hom*. I; GNO VII/II, 19,19-20).[195] As a conclusion, 'it is safe to say that Gregory *as a theologian and philosopher* promoted a universalistic view of salvation based on Origen's ideas and on 1*Cor*. 15:28, namely that all human nature (and consequently even its individual members) will be summed up in Christ and saved, but *as a bishop and pastor*, Gregory definitely taught people to believe that a wicked life on earth will result in an eternity of punishment'.[196]

The Nazianzen poses the problem of the final cessation of evil, even if he does not think he can solve it: 'And if we move to meet God, shall all men eventually meet Him? Let us keep this problem for a later time (εἰ δὲ θεοῦ, καὶ ἅπαντας ἐσύστερον; ἄλλοθι κείσθω)' (*Carm*. II, 1,1,522). Also in a homily Nazianzen seems to challenge an eternity of chastisement:

> I know of … the fire that has been prepared also for the devil and his angels and which proceeds from the face of the Lord and will burn all around His enemies: and I also know of a fire that is far worse than this, which is the fire that Scripture speaks of together with the worm that never sleeps: it is the fire that never goes out, but lasts for all eternity and is reserved for the damned (*Orat*. 40,36).[197]

Up to this point Gregory's interpretation is traditional, but he adds: 'All this is part of the destructive power of God, unless one prefers to interpret this in a more favourable way for men, and worthier of He who is their chastiser': that is, in the sense that the chastisement does not have to be eternal.

The idea that punishment in hell will not be eternal is demonstrated by the story of Lucifer, the prince of demons and the symbol of evil: 'Perhaps also

Salvation (2000), 78-85, so also M. Alexandre, 'Protologie et eschatologie' (1981), 140, and, of opposite opinion, the short but solid contribution of Anthony Meredith, who underlines the ambiguity of the concept of apocatastasis in Gregory of Nyssa, and the indisputable fact that the salvation of man is not independent from his moral life and from receiving baptism and the Eucharist, as is stated in the *Oratio catechetica*, which is an important text, because it is intended for Christian education (*Catech*. 36-7 and 40), 'Universal Salvation and Human Response' (2013), 63-7. Not even G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 76-94, 176-200 believes that Gregory thinks that the definitive disappearance of evil in itself implies the salvation of all; he intends apocatastasis not as a return to the initial condition of *purity*, but as a return to the condition of *immateriality*.

[194] J. Farrugia, HAMAPTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 219.

[195] *Ibid*. 230-5.

[196] *Ibid*. 249.

[197] See also *Arcana* 7,82-95.

might Lucifer, for all his stubborn resistance,[198] hereafter pay his penalty, his substance consumed (ὕλης δαπτομένης), when there is requital by fire' (*Arcana* 6,92-3). If the substance of Lucifer is consumed by the fire in the last judgment, it will not be eternally punished, and one will have to think the same *a fortiori* for demons. Evagrius (*Schol.* 62 in *Prov.* 5:14) also states that 'there was a time when evil did not exist and there will be a time when evil will no longer exist'.

Basil also mentions this problem. Some members of the community of ascetes had observed that the passage from *Luke* 12:47-8 ('And that servant, which knew his lord's will, and prepared not himself, neither did according to his will, shall be beaten with many stripes. But he that knew not, and did commit things worthy of stripes, shall be beaten with few stripes') seemed to contradict the claim that there was an eternal punishment: the punishments would be more or less harsh, but not eternal. Basil replies that there are other passages of the Gospel in which the Lord speaks of eternal punishments (*Matth.* 25:41 and 46; *Mark* 9:45 and 48), and concludes:

> it is a cunning of the devil the fact that many men, forgetful of the words of the Lord, which are so numerous and so terrible, imagine a limit to punishment in order to be able to sin with greater impudence. For if there were a limit to eternal punishment, there would also be a limit to eternal life; but if we consider it unthinkable for eternal life, what reason is there to assign a limit to eternal punishment? In fact, the adjective 'eternal' is found in both cases (*Reg. brev.* 267; PG 31, 1264C-1265C).

In another passage Basil pauses to illustrate the punishments in hell, and affirms that 'the most serious punishment of all is disgrace and *eternal* shame (τὴν αἰσχύνην τὴν αἰώνιον)' (*Homily on Psalm* 33,8; PG 29, 372AB). The punishment and shame that await the virgin who has renounced her vows are eternal (*Epist.* 46,5). Basil does not seem to follow (or wish to follow) Origen: for him there is no doubt about the question, which, on the contrary, there had been for Gregory of Nyssa and Gregory of Nazianzus (who too speaks of αἰσχύνη).

The problem of the eternity of punishment also concerns the angels, because they are rational creatures like man and are also subject to change and therefore can turn to both good and evil through passion and free will (Greg. Nyss., *Catech.* 6; GNO IV/IV, 24,20-25,2; *Eccl. Hom.* VIII,2; *Cant.* II; GNO VI, 51,10-9, 55,3-19; Greg. Naz., *Orat.* 38,7; 40,7). Even in angels holiness is not by nature, but is derived from the sanctification received by the Holy Spirit (Basil, *Spir. sanct.* 16,38,137A). Yet they are not created infants and then gradually

[198] In Greek: ἀτειρής. Sykes, *Poemata Arcana* (1997), 213 rightly explains that the adjective does not describe Lucifer's way of punishment (if the punishment were ἀτειρής ['resistent'], it would be eternal), but 'the character of the sufferer'. Similarly, ὕλη does not mean matter in a metaphysical sense, but 'the gross element in Lucifer', that is, its materiality that will be consumed by hellfire, until only its spiritual substance remains. After all, if he had wanted to, God could have destroyed Lucifer, but he leaves him alive to fight with men (*Arcana* 6,83-90).

perfected (like men) but receive their sanctity 'along with their first constitution as a mixture in their very substance' (Basil, *Homily on Psalm* 32,4; PG 29, 333CD): this is why they are so reluctant to do evil. Consequently the angels are not by nature immune from passions and for this reason they have fallen into sin: Basil, the Nazianzen and the Nyssen, do not, however, attribute to the fall of the angels the dramatic nature that Origen had; Evagrius, on the other hand, preserves Origen's general picture and describes the fall of the angel with greater insistence, as a mythical tale, just as very often and with many details he describes the nature and characteristics of the angel, in a way that became famous in monastic literature.[199]

Nazianzen dedicates the entire *Arcanum* 6, 'on rational natures' (περὶ λογικῶν φύσεων) to angelology. This shows that angelology was not an irrelevant problem for those who were, like Gregory, in a tradition dating back to Origen, who had placed both angels and human souls among the rational substances preceding the created world (*Princ*. I 4-8; 2,9-10; 3,2). The Cappadocians had accepted the preexistence of angelic substances to the material world, but not that of rational souls. Gregory tackles above all the problem of the fall of the angels and their transformation into demons, which implies free will and, above all, the possibility of turning to evil: consequently the angels are not immobile and fixed on goodness, as is the divine nature. Indeed their goodness is not of substance, as is God's; rather do they receive it from their Creator (*Arcana* 6,46-66). Gregory is unsure about the reasons for their fall: 'I might have wished them also quite unyielding. But restrain the horse, for all its impetuosity, checking it with the curb of the mind (ἤθελον εἰ καὶ πάμπαν ἀτειρέες· ἀλλ'ἄνεχ' ἵππον / Καὶ μάλα θερμόν ἐόντα, νόου ψαλίοισιν ἐέργων)' (*ibid*. 20-1). Nazianzen is also uncertain as to whether or not Lucifer's chastisement is eternal (*ibid*. 91-2).[200] In his opinion, the final redemption of the demon will take place through the consummation by fire of his matter, which is akin to wickedness.

[199] On the fall of the angels, see A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 352-60.

[200] Morwenna Ludlow, 'Demons, Evil, and Liminality in Cappadocian Theology' (2012), 186-8, follows the thesis of Alden A. Mosshammer, 'Non-Being and Evil' (1990), 327-8. The 'parasitic' character of evil is the cause of the fact that the demon has a condition of 'liminality', which is manifested by the fact that the demon, though being evil, is, however, as a creature of God, a good reality. According to Sykes also the passage of Nazianzen (*Arcana* 7,87), that God 'did dismiss him (Lucifer) to a midpoint between good and evil men' must be understood in this ontological sense; Sykes then speaks of a 'status of Satan', *Carmina arcana* (1997), 212. I doubt, however, that the Cappadocians meant the demon's wickedness in this way; in my opinion, the statement of *Arcana* 7,87: μέσον … ἀγαθῶν τε κακῶν τε does not have an ontological meaning, but is neutral and means that Lucifer (and the demons) are situated half way between good and bad things, with the possibility of choosing. Even Evagrius, in fact, believes that demons can return to being angels, depending on their choice; of course, this possibility of choice is only hypothetical, because, in practice, the demon never chooses good, even if he is able to.

The Created Man

After establishing that man in the image of God is the one present in history, Nyssen wants to clarify what 'being made in the image of God' means.[201] He explains the pertinent sentence from *Genesis* by reconsidering the gradual development of the creation of the universe. After the first chapters of *De opificio hominis*, dedicated to the several phases of the creation of the world, Gregory notes that the highest point is reached with the creation of man, because he is not a mere creature like the others, but is created in the image and likeness of God (*Opif.* 4,1,136C):

> so the human nature also, as it was made to rule the rest, was, by its likeness to the King of all, made as it were a living image, partaking with the archetype (ἀρχέτυπος) both in rank and in name, not vested in purple, nor giving indication of its rank by sceptre and diadem (for the archetype itself is not arrayed with these), but instead of the purple robe, clothed in virtue, which is in truth the most royal of all raiment, and in place of the sceptre, leaning on the bliss of immortality, and instead of the royal diadem, decked with the crown of righteousness; so that it is shown to be perfectly like to the beauty of its archetype in all that belongs to the dignity of royalty.[202]

The essential character of human nature does not reside, as stated by many pagan philosophies, in the connection between microcosm and macrocosm (*ibid.* 16,177D-180B), but in the image of God. The image does not only indicate the whole set of qualities that are in man, but also the panoply of qualities that are in God:

> but the perfect form of goodness is here to be seen by His both bringing man into being (γένεσις) from nothing, and fully supplying him with all good gifts (ἀνενδεῆ τῶν ἀγαθῶν): but since the list of individual good gifts is a long one, it is out of the question to apprehend it numerically. The language of Scripture therefore expresses it concisely by a comprehensive phrase, in saying that man was made "in the image of God": for this is the same as to say that He made human nature participant in all good; for if the Deity is the fullness of good, and this is His image, then the image finds its resemblance to the Archetype in being filled with all good (*ibid.* 16,184B).

As a consequence, the beauty of man is not that of the body, which is material and corruptible, but the unutterable beatitude that is conformable to virtue. Instead of external beauty, man received from God purity (καθαρότης), impassibility (ἀπάθεια), beatitude (μακαριότης), alienation from all evil (κακοῦ

[201] See R. Leys, *L'image de Dieu chez Saint Grégoire de Nysse* (1951), 47-51; W. Völker, *Gregor von Nyssa als Mystiker* (1955), 66-72; G.B. Ladner, 'The Philosophical Anthropology of St. Gregory of Nyssa' (1958); M. Naldini, 'Per un'esegesi del "de hominis opificio" di Gregorio Nisseno' (1973); C. De Salvo, *L'"oltre" nel presente* (1996), 61-3, 75-7, 117-9; M. Streck, *Das schönste Gut* (2005), 130-7; D. Iozzia, *Filosofia emendata* (2006), 98-104.

[202] Trans. Schaff. On the topic see also *Cant. Hom.* II (GNO VI, 68,2-69,9).

παντὸς ἀλλοτρίωσις), and all those attributes of the like kind which help to form the likeness of God in men (*ibid.* 5,1). Man's nature was not subject to passion, because it imitated Him who is free from passion; man was able to speak frankly (παρρησία) and was proud to see God face to face (*Catech.* 6; GNO III/IV, 15-8).

Another indication of the privileged creation of man is his *status rectus*, that is, the ability only he possesses to be upright in order to contemplate heaven and therefore address his thoughts towards God and not towards the world (*Opif.* 8,1,44AB). This doctrine was widespread in ancient culture, both pagan and Christian. Basil himself draws upon it in the homily *In: attende tibi ipsi* (PG 31, 216C). Above all, however, God is νοῦς and λόγος, therefore man is a rational and thinking creature, insofar as he is the image of god (*Opif.* 5,2,137C).

To sum up, the human being represents a *unicum* within creation. Man conforms to God's providence since, according to Genesis, God wanted to create him last. His creation is not due to fate or to a freak of fortune. Man completes the performative process of God's creation by bringing culmination and order to it, yet the sensible-material human realm is not posterior to the intelligent one, nor is the intellectual one prior to matter (as Origen had maintained).[203] Thus, if the Bible states that man was created at the end, this means that perfection lies in the ultimate realms, according to a necessary succession. Indeed, rational nature comprises also the other creatures, and in the rational εἶδος the physical is also implied. Gregory does not omit to stress that there is a substantial difference between image and archetype (*Opif.* 16,184CD). As the most perfect of all creatures, man is endowed with a royal function, which is ἀδέσποτος and αὐτεξούσιος, ruled by its own will (*ibid.* 4,1,136B).[204]

As Gregory of Nazianzus did not dwell in detail on the problem of the creation of man, he does not particularly insist on the excellence that man possesses because he is the image of God. He says that man was created by God as an intermediate link between the intelligible and the material world, he is a 'second world', the microcosm (*Orat.* 38,11): this interpretation is, as we saw, rejected by Gregory of Nyssa, who observes that it came from pagan philosophy. Man as microcosm is rhetorically defined as 'great in its littleness' and is 'spectator (ἐπόπτης) of the visible creation, and an initiate (μύστης) into the intelligible':[205] the word μύστης has a religious meaning, and means that man

[203] J. Daniélou, *L'être et le temps* (1970), 82-3.

[204] Also in the *Hom. in verba: faciamus* (PG 44, 264C) the anonymous author asserts that, consequently to be the image of God, man is able to be in command of himself and to control his own passions.

[205] Intelligible not in the sense of Platonic philosophy, but in the sense that it is all non-sensible reality, both personal (angels, and also God) and abstract.

too, contemplating the intelligible world, becomes totally intelligible and loses his materiality.[206] Then Nazianzen hints at Origen's doctrine, and specifically at the pedagogical function of chastisement and evil (38,12). After the first sin man gained something, 'that is, death and the fact that his sin has ceased to hold sway, so that evil might not be immortal, and in this way chastisement becomes an act of divine philanthropy. I am in fact convinced that this is the way in which God chastises'. What Gregory claims in a more general sense also fits into this context: that evil shall not last forever; rather will it cease along with the conclusion of the chastisement (see above, p. 179-80).

Elsewhere Gregory explains with more moral than rational considerations the origin of man and the difference between body and soul. The struggle that torments the Christian originates from that difference (*Orat*. 14,6-7; PG 35, 865AD): this consideration is Platonizing and does not consider the responsibility of the soul in committing sin. Gregory does not hate the body, but considers it a 'yoke companion' (ᾧ συνεζύγην) of the soul, both enemy and friend. The conflict between soul and body contains a great mystery:

> Is it God's will that since we are part of him and came down from heaven (μοῖραν Θεοῦ καὶ ἄνωθεν ῥεύσαντας),[207] we should always look towards him from the midst of a fight and struggle with the body, so that we might not be lifted up by our own dignity (διὰ τὴν ἀξίαν ἐπαιρόμενοι καὶ μετεωριζόμενοι) and think ourselves so high that we begin to look down on our creator? Is this weakness with which we are joined a kind of training for that dignity (παιδαγωγίαν τοῦ ἀξιώματος), making us aware that we are both the greatest and the most lowly of creatures…?[208]

The conflict between body and soul and the pedagogical function of the struggle between them are again considered in a homily written a few years later. Man is at the same time spirit and flesh: spirit because of grace, flesh because of pride (πνεῦμα διὰ τὴν χάριν, σάρκα διὰ τὴν ἔπαρσιν), the one, that he might always remain in being and glorify his benefactor; the other that he might suffer, and in his suffering come to his senses, and be corrected from his ambitions of grandeur (*Orat*. 38,11). So the body has a pedagogical function, that of lowering man's pride, when he sees that he falls into sin because of the body.[209]

[206] Cf. also the parallel passage of *Arcana* 7,67-8: ἐχέφρωνα μύστην / οὐρανίων.

[207] Let us correct Daley's translation ('drawn in an upward stream'). This phrase attracted the attention of Maximus the Confessor, who wrote, about this subject, the admirable *Ambiguum* 7 against Origenism: Maximus saw that the Origenists of the 6th century had used the sentence 'we are part of him and came down from heaven' in order to propose their doctrine of the enade and the sin of the rational substances, but it is obvious that this was not Gregory's intention.

[208] Trans. Daley.

[209] The Nazianzen did not consider the leather tunics something negative because of their materiality, and the Nyssen had affirmed the same view: they are a remedy against evil (*Mort. GNO* IX, 55,11-8). Man always obtains the attention of God, Who gives him wisdom *after* the fall (*Pasch*. 254,6-9; *Mort*. 57,21-4; 40,218; *Orat. dom. III*; GNO VII/II, 37,22-38,1), even if

4. *Ethics*

Ethics in its philosophical, and more particularly Platonic, form is used extensively by the Cappadocians – naturally, in the organized and systematic form not of Plato's dialogues, but of the Platonism of the imperial age. For this reason we will limit ourselves to highlighting some details in the ethics of Basil and Gregory of Nyssa and some new and different aspects from Platonism in the ethics of Gregory of Nazianzus, namely his approval and, at the same time, his criticism of cynicism.

The Nyssen often affirms the need for a rigorous and total eradication of passion, even if the term ἀπάθεια has now taken on a different meaning, that of asceticism, and is no longer strictly philosophical (the Nyssen, in fact, frequently reconnects it to the ἀπάθεια of God). The non-stoic use of this word is also evident from the fact that Nyssen attributes to the πάθη, on some occasions, a positive meaning based on the behavior of biblical characters, such as David and Phinees, who directed their passions towards the good (*An.* GNO III/III, 38,17-18; *Moys.* II 297-299; *Beat. Hom.* 2, GNO VII/II, 93,10 – 97,11; 6, 146,17 – 147,17). This is due to the fact that God himself, creating our first parents, did not exclude passion from their nature, as seen above,[210] but the good evaluation of the πάθη would have been inconceivable for Stoicism. After all, the use of the terms 'eros' and 'agape' in the Homilies on the Canticle of Canticles attests that the Nyssen attributes to passion also a positive function.[211]

Taking from Greek philosophy the concept of 'virtue' and its various forms and their interpretation in the Christian sense (the so-called 'cardinal virtues') go back, as is known, to the school of Alexandria, on which the use made of them by Gregory of Nyssa depends. In the *Homilies on the Beatitudes* he tries to define the traditional virtues and, in addition to them, those recommended by the Gospel Beatitudes: the identification between the Greek virtues and the 'virtues' of the Gospel is not easy, so Nyssen is forced to explain the virtues of the Beatitudes through definitions of philosophical origin (and therefore extraneous to Christianity). Thus, the 'bliss' of seeing God is identified with the 'assimilation to God' of Platonic origin, because Paul says that 'only God is blessed' (a very vague explanation of 1*Tim.* 6:15), and seeing God is the 'end' of the Christian,

man always has the responsibility for evil; on these contradictory attitudes see J. Farrugia, HAMARTIA *in the Homilies* (2015), 93-9.

[210] See above John Behr's study; and also: R. Williams, 'Macrina's Deathbed Revisited' (1993); J. Warren Smith, *Passion and Paradise* (2004); *id.*, 'Macrina, Tamer of Horses' (2001); *id.*, 'A Just and Reasonable Grief' (2004), 72-4. The subject is particularly important, because it can be extended to human nature, created mutable by God, but not for this reason wicked: indeed, it is precisely mutability and movement that make possible epektasis, or, at least, the possibility of 'moving' towards the good, according to the prohairesis, as it has been well highlighted by the same J. Warren Smith, 'Becoming Men, Not Stones' (2018).

[211] Cf. L. Karfiková, 'The Metaphor of the Mirror' (2018), 268-71.

as Middle Platonism had argued (*Beat.* 1; GNO VII/II, 82,24-5). God is identified with virtue, in the Middle Platonic way (*Moys.*, praef. 7; II 244). The definition of justice ('justice is an attitude that distributes to each his own': *Beat. Hom.* 4; GNO VII/II, 112-3), however, openly draws inspiration from Aristotle (even if he is not named) (cf. Arist., *EN* V 3). Virtue is the happy medium between extremes (*Cant.* IX; GNO VI, 284,5; *Eccl.* VI,2; GNO V, 375,4-5; *Moys.* II 288). The definitions of the πάθη follow Stoicism (above all *SVF* III 409-16): pain is explained 'in the manner' of Stoicism (*Beat. Hom.* 3; GNO VII/II, 102-3); mercy is an affliction (*ibid.* 5; GNO VII/II, 126,21-3 and 25-7),[212] as in the definitions of *SVF* III 100,15 and 101,21; peace is defined in the Stoic manner (*ibid.* 7; GNO VII/II, 154,7-9). And not even the Stoic 'mutual concatenation' of virtues (ἀντακολουθία) is missing (*ibid.* 4; GNO VII/II, 118,22-5).[213]

The Nazianzen's attitude towards pagan ethical philosophy is newer. Of course, he repeats the usual exhortation to guard against the false wisdom of those who are 'on the outside'. True wisdom sets itself against sophistry: 'You savants and philosophers with your majestic cloaks and beards, you professors and teachers (γραμματισταί), avid for public acclaim, I do not see how you can be called wise!'[214]

It is new that, in spite of his Platonism, Nazianzen attempts to define Christian philosophy drawing from Cynic doctrines. Gregory expressed his view following his encounter with Maximus the Cynic in the summer of 380. He delivered two orations, one in praise of Maximus (n. 25), and another (n. 26) after Maximus' intrigues against him were discovered; in oration 25 Gregory identifies Christian morality with Cynicism and probably at the same time he composed the poems which contain cynic tenets. On no other occasion, however, does Gregory identify Christian morality with Cynicism: probably that interpretation had been elicited by a passing enthusiasm for Maximus.

The problem concerning Gregory's use of Cynic doctrines was posed at the end of the nineteenth century by a brief contribution by Rudolf Asmus. It was then picked up briefly by Johannes Geffcken and, more extensively, in a monograph

[212] Mercy is defined as 'voluntary affliction for the evils of others', Cl. Moreschini, 'Gregorio di Nissa, *De beatitudinibus* Oratio VII' (2000), 236; a similar definition can be found in Basil (*Hom. in Psalm.* 114,3; PG 29, 489B): 'mercy is a πάθος for those who have been humiliated without their meriting it'. The Stoic practice of definition also induces Christian writers to formulate similar definitions, in accordance with Scripture. Sometimes they are used not very appropriately: Gregory of Nazianzus applies the Stoic definition of σοφία to divine Wisdom: Wisdom knows everything because it is the knowledge of divine and human things (*Orat.* 30,20).

[213] The concept is also found in Nazianzen (*Orat.* 22,14), and has been studied, for the Nyssen, by S.R.C. Lilla, *Neuplatonisches Gedankengut* (2004), 104-6, who highlights the Platonic and Stoic doctrine of the prime importance of justice among the virtues. A. Radde-Gallwitz, 'Gregory of Nyssa on the Reciprocity of the Virtues' (2007) and *Basil of Caesarea* (2018), 207-11 does not deal with this or with what is said in footnote 212.

[214] *Orat.* 36,12, trans. M. Vinson.

by Joseph Dziech.[215] These studies are now antiquated: they do not deal with the socio-political structure which induced Gregory to be attracted by Cynicism, and they failed to understand what is included under the common name of Cynicism, disregarding the differences between both Christianity and paganism. Since then, for an extensive period of time, the problem has been neglected, and even recent studies on Cynicism have ignored Gregory.[216] As has been rightly observed, 'mere stress on the difficulty of the moral life, if it is not associated with a particular Cynic figure as its exemplar, should not be allowed to count… Perhaps a distortion is practised if these points of contact are made the grounds for assigning them formally to one or another school, and above all if – as has sometime been the tendency – any popularizing text that cannot be attributed securely to one of the great institutionalized schools is for that reason categorized without further ado as 'Cynic'.[217] Besides, Cynic ethics today appear far more problematic than earlier studies suggest.

Nazianzen's *Oration* 25 is an extraordinarily innovative document, because it clearly presents a conciliatory project between Christian morals (which remain in any case above pagan ones) and Cynicism. Gregory contests the false wisdom of other philosophies and sets them against the courage and the sincerity of the Cynic philosopher (*Orat*. 25,2). Maximus is the most perfect of all philosophers and martyrs of truth; his commitment to Christian ethics is immense. He is a dog thanks to his liberal speech (παρρησία) in defense of the upright faith, which was being threatened by the Homoians still in power in Constantinople (*ibid.* 25,3).[218] In this way, Maximus has earned true nobility, which is not that of bloodline, but of true Christian life. For this reason, Maximus is a citizen of the entire earth (Cynic philosophers do not suffer being bounded by restricted borders), even if, as far as his body is concerned, he is a citizen of the city of Alexandria. To better preach his ideas, Maximus prefers the active life to the hermitic one and to exhibit the social relations and the philanthropy of charity. His Christian Cynicism is therefore a polemic against the pride of the Greeks (i.e, the pagans) (*ibid*. 25,5).

Oration 25 also contains a *comparatio vitarum* (ch. 6-7), in the same manner of that found in *Poem* I 2,8.[219] The ethical ideal that Gregory intends to propose

[215] R. Asmus, 'Gregorius von Nazianz und sein Verhältnis' (1894); J. Geffcken, *Kynika und Verwandtes* (1909), 18-9; J. Dziech, *De Gregorio Nazianzeno* (1925); Cl. Moreschini, 'Gregory Nazianzen and Philosophy' (2012).

[216] M.-O. Goulet-Cazet and R. Goulet (eds), *Le cynisme ancien* (1993) and its English translation: R. Bracht Branham and M.-O. Goulet-Caz (eds), *The Cynics: The Cynic Movement in Antiquity* (1997); D. Krueger, 'Diogenes the Cynic' (1993), 39-42.

[217] M.B. Trapp, 'On the Tablet of Cebes' (1997), 171.

[218] According F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 70 n. 3, the 'dog' referred to therein is not the cynic, but 'the dog of God', the Christian as cynic. However the fundamental meaning of the passage does not change.

[219] Gautier (*ibid*. 104 n. 3) states that the *Comparatio vitarum* (I 2,8) is not, as has been thought, a comparison between the contemplative life and the active life, which is resolved in

is that of Cynic philosophy, which devotes its attention exclusively to the education of man. Cynicism is adapted to the historical and social context of Christianity in the fourth century, a time in which the choice of a perfect Christian life was discussed, whether it be the monastic / contemplative life, or the practical life in the midst of society. Gregory proposes a compromise between the two demands: he picks up the moral principles of Cynic philosophy, such as the disdain for worldly goods, the candor of speech, the freedom of the soul in the presence of the powerful, the conviction that one is a 'citizen of the world',[220] and he interprets them in a Christian key: his aim is to explain what is the task of the priest, not of the monk. In Gregory's view, Maximus is indeed a Cynic, but as a Christian he is markedly superior to the famous Cynic philosophers of the past.

The moral themes expressed in *Oration* 25 recur in several of Gregory's poems. Among these, the poem *De virtute* (*Carm.* I 2,10) is significant. Gregory praises the Cynic's cloak (τρίβων) and his cane (*Carm.* I 2,10, 242-72; 286-90), yet Gregory's ideal of the virtuous life is emphatically drawn from Christian asceticism. In order to attain virtue, useful examples can be found in pagan writings:[221] poverty (214-579), asceticism (ἐγκράτεια: 580-616), strength (676-766), temperance (773-897). Gregory uses paradigmatic *topoi* and *chreiai* drawn from a common legacy of *Popularphilosophie*, employing as well stylistic details from the diatribe such as the apostrophe and rhetorical questions. He recalls the most significant Cynics, such as Diogenes and Crates, and presents a series of examples of willed poverty, which was the result of an autonomous decision (244-58). But he is careful to note the Christian perspective that gives them their real significance: 'These examples, therefore, are practically the same as my laws, which allow me to fly to life as a bird,[222] with daily unsown food, to the beauty of lilies, splendidly dressed. They provide a shelter of simple dress, on the condition that we adore the one great God' (259-64).

Cynicism, therefore, must be understood in a Christian sense inasmuch as it condemns human defects. Human insatiability derives from the imperfection of nature, caused by the fall of our progenitors (468-80). It is futile to seek moral doctrines in the tenets and the fictions of the pagans, since only Scripture provides true exhortations to virtue. Worldly goods contrast with those of the afterlife: wealth and fortune's largesse are countered by God and celestial things (449-51); worldly power is countered with Christ's cross. In a *sententia* typical of Gregory's rhetoric, he writes that one should toss away 'everything that is

favour of the former, but between the spiritual life, that is, monasticism, defined by anachoresis from the things of the world, and the worldly life of those who remain attached to earthly things, and therefore is not philosophical.

[220] These are Cynic statements which, as noted above, have occupied many scholars. Among the latest, see G. Dorival, 'L'image des cyniques' (1993), 441.

[221] See Gregory of Nazianzus, *Sulla virtù carme giambico [I,2,10]* (1995), 34-5.

[222] An elaboration of *Matthew* 6:25-8, as is evident.

destined to be eaten by moths and depends on a roll of the dice (467)', namely sumptuous clothing and all that is in the hands of chance. From verse 265 on, Gregory states that the examples of pagan virtue, though admirable, were corrupted by a series of flaws that diminished them, particularly ostentation and gluttony, which presented itself in subtle forms, 'as if some made poverty a subject of pleasure'. To sum up: considering the truth of the moral teachings of Christianity, then, even Cynicism may be criticized, for its impudence, arrogance and ungodliness are unacceptable.

Many other Cynic themes can be found in Gregory's poems, such as the praise of poverty (εὐτέλεια) and the condemnation of luxury (τρυφή), of the pleasures of the belly, of gluttony, of wealth, of glory, of noble birth and so on.[223] The debasement of marriage is another ascetic theme proposed in *Poem* I 2,10,53-6, but it is necessary to distinguish here (more so than elsewhere) between pagan Cynicism and Christian Cynicism. Because the debasement of marriage and sexuality was such a widespread theme in ancient Christianity, it would be arbitrary to trace such a condemnation back to popular pagan philosophy. There is no need to recall the theme of the *incommoda nuptiarum* developed by Jerome or by Nyssen's *De virginitate*. In any case, Christian morality is superior to Cynic philosophy.

As in *Oration* 25, in *Poem* I 2,8, 'The Comparison of Lives', there is a synthesis of Cynicism and Christian ethics by means of a debate between the active and the contemplative lives. It is analogous to a debate found in pagan Cynicism: which is best, the life of the philosopher, the king, the rich man, or the wise man?[224] Each of the two contenders exhibits his individual merits and claims to excellence (*ibid.* 6-18). The poem's conclusion seems obvious: 'if one is not mad' the winner is the contemplative life; but the author also adds: 'If the second type does not possess the first honors, what prevents it from having the second ones? This is not dishonor. In this way life could be secure' (*ibid.* 251-5). The conciliatory proposal between the two types of life is typical of mild Gregory's asceticism. This suggestion is found also in Gregory's panegyric of Athanasius, where he distinguishes between hermitic life and a life dedicated to helping the poor before concluding that there isn't a conflict between the two, and that both should be sought (*Orat.* 21, 19-20 and 6).

After having outlined some fundamental aspects of Gregory's Cynicism, Asmus asked what prompted Gregory to attempt what he considered a real synthesis between Cynicism and Christianity.[225] In Asmus' view, there is a common aim to both systems: the salvation of the human being within society

[223] More in Cl. Moreschini, 'Gregory Nazianzen and Philosophy' (2012).

[224] The debate between the active life and the contemplative life is analogous in form to that which takes place in the first of a series of poems that Gregory composed to celebrate virginal life (*Carm.* I 2,1).

[225] R. Asmus, 'Gregorius von Nazianz' (1894), 330-1.

and within his own conscience. It was a very nineteenth-century assessment (Asmus even uses the term *Kulturkampf*). The Cynic ideal received renewed attention under Julian's dominion, Asmus reasoned. As Cynicism developed and grew from the fragments of the ancient philosophical, theological and political systems, so too did Christianity under Julian and after him: the affinity between the two ideologies consists in this. On this basis, Asmus develops an improbable parallelism between Christianity and Cynicism.[226]

Yet Emperor Julian considered the Cynics analogous to the detested 'Galileans'. Demonstrating his revulsion toward the Cynic Heraclius (*Heracl.* 18, 224a), he confirms his desire to assign the Cynics the name of ἀποτακτιταί, a term used for a sect of Christian encratites (and Julian adds that the name was assigned to them by the impious 'Galileans'). In his oration *Against the Ignorant Cynics* (*Orat.* 12,192d), Julian declares: 'You recognize, I believe, the words of the Galileans', referring to *Genesis* 9:3 (λάχανα χόρτου), on the basis of which Christians felt they were not required to observe restrictions in their diet. Julian scornfully dubs them 'the omnivores'.[227] We also find scorn for such contemptible freedom of the Christians in Julian's *Against the Galileans* (fr. 58,23 and 74,3 Masaracchia). Heraclius was also Egyptian like Maximus (the friend, then enemy of Nazianzen), and, like Maximus he lived a life that was that of a Cynic, but was quite different from that of the Cynics of the past, particularly Diogenes, whom Heraclius accuses of vainglory. Julian contrasts the arrogant and impoverished Cynics of his time with the Cynics of the past, who, on the contrary, were truly free men. The Cynic whom Julian targets in *Against the Ignorant Cynics* possesses, among the many characteristics of his sordid conduct, the vice of admiring the 'macabre life of wretched women' (20,203c), referring to encratite women who lived in the manner of the dead, refusing all the good that life offered. Thus Margarethe Billerbeck states that when he reprimands the Cynics of his time for accusing Diogenes of vanity Julian expresses an opinion that is similar to Gregory's, who accused the great Cynics of the past of ostentation.[228] It is possible, then, that the Cynics targeted by Julian are, like Maximus, Christians.[229]

[226] *Ibid.* 331: 'Virtue must be the field of the Christian as *philanthropia* is the field of the Cynic. The master of one is the Son of God, Jesus Christ, for the others Heracles, son of Zeus. As the apostles follow one, so the Cynics follow the other. Neither knows a home country; both roam from one place to another, teaching and fearing no one. They do not speak to the world's powerful, but to the poor and the oppressed. They speak in the manner of the people. They point to true and eternal goods, beyond the fleeting. They reinforce self-conviction and the patience of the meek with the warning that they must think of true freedom'.

[227] See D. Micalella, Giuliano Imperatore, *Contro i cinici ignoranti* (1988), which contains further details on Julian's critical yet favorable stance toward Cynicism.

[228] And as a consequence, Julian does not approve the Cynicism which in his time degenerated from its original form.

[229] M. Billerbeck, 'Le cynisme idéalisé d'Epictète à Julien' (1993), 335-6; see also a brief note by D. Krueger, 'Diogenes the Cynic' (1993), 42.

Yet such a close resemblance between Cynicism and Christianity is not obvious; rather, it is suggested by the different interpretations (some equivalent and some contrary) given by Gregory of Nazianzus and Julian, whose personalities were, in some respects, similar. As Gilles Dorival has observed,[230] two types of Cynicism in the fourth century have emerged: one that was defined by a specific τέλος and was completely incompatible with Christianity, and one that did not have its own proper τέλος, but was reduced to a form of life, and therefore was compatible with other philosophical τέλη, even a Christian one.

The search for a morality modeled on Cynicism, or perhaps a 'popular philosophy', was much stronger in Gregory of Nazianzus than in Gregory of Nyssa, and even in Basil. Gregory Nazianzen viewed ancient Cynicism, more so than its contemporary forms, as an authoritative source for a life detached from the world, and it was for this reason that he assumed a moderately approving stance toward it. But he did not accept it without reservation, and this is, after all, the customary attitude of Christian culture with respect to that of the Greeks.

Philosophy had a very strong influence on Evagrius, who employs a definition that could be that of many Greek philosophers: 'Christianity is the doctrine of Christ our Saviour, and it consists of practice, physics and theology (πρακτική – φυσική – θεολογική)'. By adapting Greek philosophy to his theology, he divides ethics into πρακτική – θεωρία φυσική – γνῶσις θεοῦ (*KG* III 59; *Schol. Ps.* 78,11).[231]

According to Evagrius, 'practice' corresponds to what in the schema of pagan philosophy is called 'ethics', and, as for Greek philosophers, constitutes the first step, necessary to reach the knowledge of 'physical contemplation' (θεωρία φυσική), which is the rational and passion-free observation of created things, and finally to 'theology', which is the 'science of God'. 'Physical contemplation' and the 'science of God' can be subsumed under one definition, that of 'gnosis', whereby Evagrius reproduces the usual distinction between practice and *theoria*. In his cell the monk leads a practical life, the various stages of which had already been indicated by the school of Alexandria, by Clement and, above all, by Origen. Abstinence, perseverance and impassiveness derive from faith; from those virtues agape is born. 'Practice', therefore, corresponds in many respects to what Evagrius' masters, Basil and especially Gregory of Nazianzus, called 'philosophy'. The 'practice' has this name because it is an incessant work, requiring constant effort; it is action, but above all it is inner action, which concerns the soul.[232] It is the spiritual method that purifies the

[230] G. Dorival, 'L'image des cyniques' (1993), 443.

[231] See A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au desert* (2004), 208-17; J. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 30-3.

[232] The soul, in fact, is exposed to a continuous battle (this is not a new idea: it had already been affirmed by St. Paul), and the battle par excellence is, as seen from the numerous 'lives of

passionate part of the soul, which is divided into the rational, concupiscible and irascible part, the Platonic definition, then passed on to the school of Alexandria and to the Cappadocians: Evagrius (*Pract*. 89) states that he had taken it up 'from our wise teacher', that is, from Gregory of Nazianzus. The two lower parts of the soul unite man and animal and include the various passions; they derive from the fact that the soul is joined to the body. Passions, as the Stoics already claimed, are diseases of the soul, while impassiveness is its health. Evil, however, can also come from the rational part of man.

The conclusion of the struggles and asceticism, that is, of the πρακτική, is represented by ἀπάθεια (*Pract*. 81),[233] a typical word of philosophical language – and of the school of Alexandria and the Cappadocians – to indicate the absence of passions.[234] The lack of passions is the health of the soul, its resurrection (*Schol. Ps*. 17,21; *KG* V 22; VI 21 etc.) and constitutes the ideal of the Gnostic. The lack of passions takes place gradually, and can be perfect or imperfect. The vices – which are manifested by the definition, typical of Evagrius, of 'eight thoughts' – are caused by the concupiscible part of the soul.[235] Virtue has its origin in the rational soul, from which prudence, intelligence and understanding derive (*Pract*. 73). Clement had already said that the perfect man must eradicate *pathe* from himself (*Quis dives* 40,6) and Nazianzen repeated the same statement (*Orat*. 37,21-2),[236] so that Evagrius also says (*De diversis malignis cogitationibus* 25, PG 70, 1229C): ἀπάθειαν δὲ λέγω, οὐ τὴν κατάλυσιν τῆς κατ' ἐνέργειαν ἁμαρτίας, αὕτη γὰρ ἐγκράτεια λέγεται, ἀλλὰ τὴν κατὰ διάνοιαν τοὺς ἐμπαθεῖς λογισμοὺς περικόπτουσαν.

Evil as the Wrong Choice of Free Will

If the soul is free from any constraint and, therefore, naturally able to achieve good and accomplish virtue; if it is made in the image of God and therefore perfect (as, within certain limits, an image can reproduce the archetypal perfection), why does the soul choose evil? The question is even thornier if one considers that, according to Gregory, evil is located at the lowest level of the 'ladder' of existence, that it is even non-existent, so that there is no dualistic opposition between good and evil. Gregory, like almost all fourth-century

the saints', a war against demons. But the subject is typical of Evagrius' asceticism and therefore falls outside our discussion.

[233] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au desert* (2004), 267-70 and 307.

[234] It is difficult to specify whether Evagrius took up the concept of ἀπάθεια from the Cappadocians or from Origen, given how widespread this concept was in both. The derivation from Origen is supported by R. Somos, 'Origen, Evagrius Ponticus' (1999).

[235] About them, their origin and their characteristics, a doctrine that constitutes an essential part of the asceticism of Evagrius, see the texts cited by Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au desert* (2004), 218-9.

[236] On this expression see Cl. Moreschini, Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 32-37* (1985), 48-51.

Christian authors, shows a particular sensibility towards this question and he neatly rejects any dualism.

The doctrine of the non-subsistence of evil is of clear Platonic descent, even though it is not retraceable to Plato. In fact, since dualism located the plenitude of being in the intellectual realm, while leaving only the appearance to the phenomenal world, matter was considered something devoid of existence, as it was the lower level of being. As a consequence, Plotinus had developed two different doctrines in this regard, stating, on one hand, that matter does not exist and, on the other, that it is the source of evil (*Enn.* I [51] 8). Plotinus meaningfully arrives at the same conclusion expressed by Origen, who stated that 'evil is undoubtedly a lacking of goodness' (*Princ.* II 9,2), and 'not-being and nothing are synonymous, and hence those who are not beings are Nothing, and all evil is nothing, since it is Not-being, and thus since it is called Not being it came into existence without the Logos, not being numbered among the all things which were made through Him' (*comm. Ioh.* II 13,99).[237]

Basil wrote a homily to explain that God is not the cause of evil (*Quod Deus non est auctor malorum*: PG 31, 229-54) and that wickedness has no subsistence of its own, a much-debated question, he says (πολυθρύλητον ζήτημα: 2,332B). Evil has its roots only in human free will (3,332C; 5,337D-340A); physical illness is inflicted by God on humans because it has a positive function – an argument of Stoic descent (3,334A) – or performs a pedagogical service, so that others are prevented from acting wickedly (5,340A-341B). God is not responsible for evil, nor does evil have a specific subsistence (ἰδίαν ὑπόστασιν τοῦ κακοῦ). Indeed, wickedness does not subsist as if it were a living being (ὑφεστὼς ὥσπερ τι ζῷον), nor are we able to conceive that it exists with its own substance (οὔτε οὐσίαν αὐτῆς ἐνυπόστατον παραστῆσαι ἔχομεν). Evil, in fact, is the deprivation of goodness (στέρησις κακοῦ), just as blindness the deprivation of sight (5,341C). Man lets evil penetrate into himself, in consequence of an impulse of his freedom (διὰ τὴν αὐτεξούσιον ὁρμήν), which is particularly suited to his rational nature. Since he was created in the image of God, man obtained a free life (αὐθαίρετος), conceives goodness, knows how to enjoy it and is able to do so, provided that he remains stable in his contemplation of it, living in conformity with nature – likewise, he has the faculty (ἐξουσία) of abandoning the good. This happens when the soul, glutted, so to say, from the contemplation of goodness, is weighed down by drowsiness and unites itself to the flesh (6,344BC). Gregory Nyssen also claims that evil originates only from free will (*Beat. Hom.* V; GNO VII/II, 129,16-130,3; *Cant. Hom.* XII; GNO VI, 349,3-6), and he provides a deeper investigation of these Basilian tenets, which are in agreement with the doctrine of the creation of man in the image of God (*An.*; GNO III/III, 69,3-6; *Eccl. Hom.* II; GNO V, 300,21-

[237] Trans. Schaff.

301,2; *Catech.* 5,11-12; GNO III/IV, 20,1-15; 6,7).[238] Nazianzen also denied the ontologic existence of evil in a kind of formula of faith (*Orat.* 40,45), which includes the rejection of Manichaeism, as in *Arcana* 4,31-43.

The question of evil and its substance (or non-existence) has been investigated at great length by Jean Daniélou[239] and Alden A. Mosshammer.[240] Mosshammer, subsuming the former's arguments, asserts that 'the non-being of evil is not an absence in the sense of nothingness, like the non-being out of which God called the creation into being, but a negative condition within being that results from a withdrawal from a being that is already present'.[241] Even if it is non-existent, evil is in any case the cause of a serious calamity, that of making mortal the being created by God in his image. In fact, the evil referred to by Gregory of Nyssa, and, before him, Plotinus (III 2), is not physical, material evil, which is considered to be something 'indifferent', but moral evil. Although Basil and Gregory of Nyssa agree that it does not have an independent force, evil, however, is something 'parasitic' on good or privation of it. The coexistence of evil with good does not make evil less evil, as would happen if good and evil were two quantitative realities, but makes it even more evil (Nyss., *Perf.*; GNO VIII/I, 180).[242]

So then, why does man 'withdraw' from being into evil? Once again, this is explained by employing the doctrine of man created in the image of God, and that of the differences between archetype and image. Man, although the last and therefore most perfect creature, is a material being and is subject to movement. As image of God, man is mutable, whereas the archetype always remains the same (*Opif.* 16,14,184CD). Man is necessarily changeable by nature, because he is an effect of mutation at the very beginning. He came into being from non-being and this implies a sort of mutation, when inexistence is transformed into existence, thanks to God's power. Moreover, mutability derives from the fact that humans imitate the divine nature: imitation, were it not different in some way from the imitated object, would be equal to it. But since the image of God is subject to change, man, if he mutates, does not remain in being. The possibility of such mutation is itself an inequality of the image to its archetype (*Catech.* 21; GNO III/IV, 55-6).

Mutation is, necessarily, a movement towards some different condition. Such a movement is twofold: one is directed towards the good and is perpetual by virtue of the unlimitedness of the good;[243] the other is directed towards evil, whose existence lies precisely in non-existence. Originally good, human nature

[238] Similarly, *Catech.* 21 (GNO III/IV, 55-6); *Cant. hom.* II (GNO VI, 56,8-10).
[239] J. Daniélou, *L'être et le temps* (1970), 135-53.
[240] A.A. Mosshammer, 'Non-Being and Evil' (1990).
[241] *Ibid.* 140. In the same vein C. Arruzza, *Les mésaventures de la théodicée* (2011), 209-19.
[242] M. Ludlow, 'Demons, Evil, and Liminality' (2012), 327-8.
[243] Gregory states this also in the prologue of *De vita Moysis.*

thus mutates towards sin (*Cant. Hom.* V; GNO VI, 147,6-8). Man is intermediate (μέσον ἐστι τὸ ἀνθρώπινον) between the immortal, divine nature and the irrational, brutish life (*Opif.* 16,9,181D). Only God, steadily unyielding in goodness, does good without choosing it.[244]

Since God is a creator, man can create as well, precisely because he is the image of Him. But God, in his perfection and his immutability, creates only goodness, and what he creates is endowed with subsistence; conversely, man, insofar as he is merely an image, and thus inferior to his model, can create not only subsistent realms (good), but also non-subsistent ones (evil), whenever he abandons the divinely accorded good wherein he lives, and whereby he lives. Doing evil is something unavoidable for man, because of his ontological state of creature; but it is also a consequence of his free will, since, while God does not 'want' or 'choose', man must choose between desiring goodness or desiring wickedness. Man is in fact located in the middle (μεθόριος) between material and intelligible realms, between good and evil: in this situation, he must direct himself towards being or towards non-being.

Paola Pisi has outlined a similarity in the way Plotinus and Gregory deal with the condition of the soul.[245] Whereas, according to Plotinus, Nous is immovable, Plotinus' soul is twofold:

> Since its nature is twofold, partly intelligible and partly perceptible, it is better for the soul to be in the intelligible, but all the same, since it has this kind of nature, it is necessarily bound to be able to participate in the perceptible and it should not be annoyed with itself because, granted that all things are not the best, it occupies a middle rank among realities (μέσην τάξιν ἐν τοῖς οὖσιν ἐπισχοῦσαν), belonging to that divine part (θείας μὲν μοίρας οὖσαν), but being on the lowest edge of the intelligible and having a common boundary with the perceptible nature (ὅμορον οὖσαν τῇ αἰσθητῇ φύσει), gives something to it of what it has in itself and receives something from it in return, if it does not use only its safe part in governing the universe, but with greater eagerness plunges into the interior and does not stay whole with whole (*Enn.* IV 8 [6], 7).[246]

Asceticism

The diversity of the formation and conceptions of the Cappadocians regarding asceticism and mysticism is absolutely evident. That we can speak of 'mysticism' only with regard to Gregory of Nyssa, was shown by Jean Daniélou seventy years ago, who linked it to Platonism. And in any case mystical interests seem

[244] J. Daniélou, *L'être et le temps* (1970), 95-115; M. Streck, *Das schönste Gut* (2005), 162.

[245] P. Pisi, *Genesis e phthorà* (1981), 89. Pisi cites also a passage in Gregory of Nazianzus (*Orat.* 38,9), where Gregory states that in the world sin seems bound to happen due to the connection of humans with sensible matter. His explanation, however, is more basic, insofar as he says that the evil done by Adam spread all over human kind, but does not discuss the question of free will and of evil after the fall.

[246] Trans. Armstrong.

to arise in Gregory of Nyssa only in the last years of his life, as they are found substantially only in the *Homiliae in Canticum Canticorum* and in *De vita Moysis*. As for Basil, his asceticism is entirely *sui generis*, far from that of Egyptian and Syriac monasticism, as has been highlighted by critics.[247] Basil's asceticism, while maintaining its peculiarity, does not, however, lose the roots of its cultural and philosophical formation.

Basil condemns the human body as such neither in the *Oratio ad iuvenes* nor in his *Homilies*, but believes that it should be educated in view of its betterment and of life after death.[248] In the *Oratio ad iuvenes* Basil proposes conceptions of a philosophical type, which have Platonic and Stoic origins. In ch. 9 he concludes his considerations on the opportunity of choosing readings that have a moral character. He says that one must not be a slave to his body, if it is not strictly necessary. This concession is significant in the context of the discussion and does express the whole of Basil's asceticism. One needs to free the soul, through philosophy, from the communions with the passions of the body, which is a prison; through self-control the body overcomes the passions. Therefore, Basil does not tell us that we should be free from the body, but that we should free the body from the passions, like the pursuit of refinement in eating and dressing. The purification of the soul consists in despising the pleasures of the senses, like the indecent performances of jugglers, the spectacles in the theatre, or listening to corrupting music. Instead of profane music, one needs to seek sacred music, that of David – and taken to extremes, even that of Pythagoras. Therefore, also for the education of the body and its liberation from the passions, profane philosophy too becomes useful. In conclusion, anyone who does not want to sink into the pleasures of the flesh, as if in a quagmire (Plat., *Phaed*. 69c), must treat his body only enough to acquire virtue. Basil concludes that this is the teaching of Plato (Plat., *Resp*. 498b) who in certain respects had taught in a similar way to what Paul says (*Rom*. 13:14; *Gal*. 5:13 and 16). This is typical of Basil and of the Cappadocians, in opposition to the Desert Fathers: Christians, in accordance with the teaching of Christ, must not despise their body, which has been moulded by God, but they have to control it.

To the body, which tends to rebel from the austerity of Christian life, he recalled the rule established by Paul (1*Tim*. 6:7-8). Continuously repeating these precepts, he says, the Christian will render his body docile and light on the journey to heaven and will have a valuable collaborator in his purpose. If, instead, he allows it to act with arrogance and be satiated with all things daily, like a savage beast, then once it is attracted by the irresistible weights toward earth, it will lie on the ground crying in vain (*Quod rebus mundanis* 6;

[247] Also Mazza as regards the social situation of Basilian monasticism, M. Mazza, 'Monachesimo basiliano' (1983), 79-96.

[248] For this question, see Cl. Moreschini, 'Greek Paideia and Christian Asceticism' (2018).

PG 31, 549C-552B). In fact, the body was the cause of the fall of Adam, who, despite the fact that he was created by God to be full of all wealth, 'preferred to the ideal beauty the delight that the eyes of his body could see, and considered it more valuable than spiritual fruition to fill his belly' (*Quod Deus non est auctor malorum* 7; PG 31, 344C-346A): the expression is generic and unconvincing, if it is to explain the cause of the fall of Adam, but it befitted the simplicity of an explanation delivered in a homily. The fall of the first parents, therefore, was caused by gluttony, and not by a deeper impulse to disobedience; from here the condemnation of the body and of the gullet is also broadly directed in *Reg. fus.* 20 (PG 31, 969C-976A). Accusations and incentives against the body are frequent (and no wonder): the body, like a savage beast drags one down.[249]

In his ascetical writings, Basil is, obviously, more severe towards passions, but also towards desires and affections. They are of no value if compared to the love for God, which is exceedingly important for a Christian and must overcome every human impulse. Nonetheless, in the ascetical writings as well Basil asserts that the body is transitory, but not evil (and this is said precisely in opposition to the more vulgar form of anachoresis) because it is an instrument of the love that the Christian has for God. Basil expresses in Stoic terms the foundation of love for God (*Reg. fus.* 2,1; PG 31, 908BC-909B):[250]

> The love of God is not something that is taught … but simultaneously with the formation of the creature – man, I mean – a kind of rational force was implanted in us like a seed (λόγος σπερματικός), which, by an inherent tendency, impels us toward love. This germ is then received into account in the school of God's commandments, where it is wont to be carefully cultivated and skillfully nurtured and thus, by the grace of God, brought to its full perfection. Wherefore, we, also, … shall endeavor … as power is given us by the Spirit, to enkindle the spark (σπινθήρ)[251] of divine love latent within you.[252]

[249] See the homily *Quod rebus mundanis* 6 (PG 31, 552A).

[250] Regarding the use of philosophical language on the part of Christian monasticism, we can in general say that, while the first monks were illiterate people, later, under the Alexandrian influence, the distant one of Philo, the nearer one of Clement and Origen, certain philosophical and spiritual practices, deeply reminiscent of the Cappadocians, were introduced into Christian and monastic spirituality, so that the Christian ideal is described, defined, and, in part, practiced, adopting the models and the vocabulary of the Greek philosophical tradition. An example of an educated monk is Evagrius Ponticus, who had been the disciple of Gregory of Nazianzus (and not of Gregory of Nyssa, as it has been recently asserted).

[251] The word has the same meaning of αἴθυγμα, which is common in Stoicism and Middleplatonism. Alcinous says that human beings possess αἰθύγματα ('petites étincelles', as Louis translates) at birth for the knowledge of good and evil (*Didask.* 25, 178,8 Whittaker). The word αἰθύγματα corresponds to what Cicero says: *nunc parvulos nobis dedit* (scil. *natura*) *igniculos.* Also Gellius says (*Noctes Att.* XII 5): *postea per incrementa aetatis exorta e seminibus suis ratiost et utendi consilii reputatio et honestatis utilitatisque verae contemplatio.*

[252] Trans. by Sister M.M. Wagner, Basil, *Ascetical Works*, The Fathers of the Church 9 (Washington, 1962).

Developing what he says in this passage, Basil then emphasizes the necessity of love of one's neighbour, basing it on the conceptions that find applications in Stoicism (*Reg. fus.* 3,1; PG 31, 917A): 'Nothing, indeed, is so compatible with our nature as living in society and in dependence upon one another and as loving our own kind. Man is a civilized and gregarious animal, neither savage nor a lover of solitude'.[253]

Basil links the two principal ideals of the Christian, that of the love of God and that of the love of one's neighbour, and explains them by accepting Stoic conceptions.[254] Precisely because man is a 'civilized and gregarious animal', the Rules attribute a greater importance to the 'common life'. The need for community life, in support of which Basil cites *Matth.* 18:16, reveals a precise way of understanding monasticism as a perfectly integrated reality within the ecclesial structure that is hierarchically constituted and not competitive, alternative, or even in contrast with it. This intent is very indicative of Basil's monastic conception, because Basil initiated his asceticism following the example of Eustathius, who was not, in spite of being the son of a bishop and a bishop himself, very inclined to take the structure of the Church into consideration. Although his asceticism partly followed the example of Eustathius, Basil had a greater consideration of the Church than Eustathius had.

It is necessary not to live apart (*Reg. fus.* 6,2; PG 31,921A). Basil insists on the fact that man cannot be autonomous and independent of material necessities and that solitary life is at odds with the requirements of love: here we very much perceive opposition to forms of asceticism in the desert, such as those that were practiced in Egypt and Syria. In fact, Basil states that in solitude fraternal correction, the recognition of one's own sin, and the execution of the evangelical life are not possible. The ideal of this communal life is that of the early community of Christians at Jerusalem (*Acts* 2:32 and 2:44): Basil has no sympathy for the manifestations of isolated zeal.

Likewise, in conformity not only with the Christian tradition, but also with the stoic-cynical one, is the consideration of marriage and the concerns that accompany it as one of the impediments to the actualization of the communal life (*Reg. fus* 5,1; PG 31, 920CD). The bothers of marriage are also listed in the *Sermo asceticus* (2; PG 31, 630AD). In fact, even more than the love of other human beings (in this case, the spouse), love of God is essential (*Reg. fus.* 5,2-3; PG 31, 921BC). The theme of the *molestiae nuptiarum* was widespread in the stoic-cynical diatribe (and in Nazianzen too).

Developing the image of the monastic community as the human body, and recovering elements of the stoic-cynical diatribe about the necessity of

[253] The communal disposition of man, produced by his corporeal nature is also affirmed in the homily *Attende tibi ipsi* 1 (PG 31, 197C).

[254] The peculiarity of this conception of Basil, of resorting to the stoic conception of nature, was already seen by Rousseau, *Basil of Caesarea* (1994), 221.

dominating one's feelings precisely in relations with one's subordinates[255], Basil affirms:

> The superior should not administer a rebuke to wrongdoers when his own passions are aroused; for, by admonishing a brother with anger and indignation, he does not free him from his faults but involves himself in the error. He who shows displeasure in a manner which is the reverse of that which I have indicated clearly proves that he is displeased, not for God's sake, nor because of the offender's peril, but because of his own love of honor and authority. … it is right to show the mercy of fraternal charity on behalf of a brother who is endangering his salvation by sin.[256]

If he is neither converted after much admonition nor cures himself by his own actions with tears and lamentations, being, as the proverb has it, 'his own destroyer', we should, as physicians do, cut him off from the body of the brethren as a corrupt and wholly useless member. Physicians, indeed, are wont to remove by cutting or burning any member of the body they find infected with an incurable disease, so that the infection may not spread further and destroy adjacent areas one after the other (*Reg. fus.* 28,2; PG 31, 989B). Other rules of spiritual medicine are set out in the same passage. This is so much the case that even our enemy can be our physician (*Reg. fus.* 7,1; PG 31, 930A).

When the analogy between illnesses of the body and illnesses of the soul is used, Basil takes up an image that was proper to stoicism. It had been established both by Chrysippus (cfr. *SVF* III 471) and Seneca, according to whom we are born into this condition of living subject to illnesses of the soul, no less numerous than those of the body.[257] Seneca (who was certainly not known by Basil) believes that philosophy is so necessary for the health of the soul[258] that we must refrain from any other affair that may detract from it.[259] In Seneca we find the same emphasis given to the confession of sins that we have seen in Basil.[260] Therefore, it is not far-fetched to argue that Basil's considerations on the therapeutic value of correction are to be placed, for certain verses, precisely in Stoic tradition.

What we have seen so far confirms the particular nature of Basil's interpretation of asceticism. In the writings of Athanasius or Palladius, in the very rich literature that narrates the exploits of the Fathers in the desert of Egypt and of Syria (or what is found in the sayings and the sentences of the ascetics), human passions and the human body are considered in principle the symbol of a

[255] The advice of Basil is similar to that recounted in a famous episode: the philosopher Archytas of Tarentum, having become angry with his farmer, said to him: 'Oh, how much I would punish you if I were not angry!' (cf. Cic., *Tusc.* IV 36,78; *Resp.* I 38,59).

[256] *Reg. fus.* 50 (PG 31, 1040C).

[257] Cf. Sen. *De ira* II 10,3.

[258] Cf. Sen. *Epist.* 15,1-2.

[259] Cf. *ibid.* 8,2.

[260] Cf. *ibid.* 53,8.

decayed and corrupt humanity, and therefore condemned and absolutely mortified. By contrast, Basil remained extraneous to this exaggeration, because his ideal was always strictly connected to the teaching of Scripture, according to which the body is certainly considered an obstacle to spiritual perfection, but is not, in any case, condemned. And, secondly, his classical education led him toward a different monasticism, in which the teaching of the Gospel is surely exclusive (insofar as the love for God cannot be limited by human needs), but the philanthropia of philosophical ascendance leaves its marks.

The asceticism of Gregory of Nazianzus is totally different from that of Basil: it is the contemplative life of the Christian.[261] Our interpretation is confirmed by Francis Gautier, according to whom what distinguishes Gregory from Basil, and, even more, from Evagrius, was the fact that he was not enthusiastic about monastic life.[262] The asceticism that Gregory proposes is a detachment from worldly things, but always remaining in the world; estrangement from the world is not that of the anchorite monk.[263]

Gregory Nazianzen describes the contemplation of Christian truth with images and language strongly influenced by Platonism. From his very first homilies, Gregory recommended the purification of the body and mind, which is the essential condition for the contemplation of God to be possible:

> … to close the doors of my senses, and, escaping from the flesh and the world, collected within myself, having no further connection than was absolutely necessary with human affairs, and speaking to myself and to God, to live superior to visible things, ever preserving in myself the divine impressions pure and unmixed with the erring tokens of this lower world, and both being, and constantly growing more and more to be, a real unspotted mirror of God and divine things, as light is added to light, and what was still dark grew clearer, enjoying already by hope the blessings of the world to come, roaming about with the angels (*Orat.* 2,7[264]).

These statements correspond to those of Plato's *Phaedo* (65c; 66a-c; 67a). Asceticism means closing oneself to avoid sensations, which are the cause of passion, gathering oneself into oneself. Also in this case the parallelism with the *Phaedo* (65e-66e) is evident: we will be able to achieve contemplation of

[261] I had already put forward my considerations in 'Il platonismo cristiano' (1974), 1352-70, which I take up again here, abbreviated; I do not take up from that previous study, however, the considerations relating to the image of light as a concrete manifestation of purification, and to the parallels between Gregory Nazianzen and Plotinus.

[262] Gautier even speaks of 'logos as ascesis' in Gregory, F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 189-91, so that for him literature means asceticism and priesthood (*ibid.* 175-88).

[263] It must be kept in mind that the desire to be detached from the world without being a priest was an ideal that was also valid in the West, as shown by the example of Jerome and Paulinus of Nola.

[264] See also *Orat.* 20,1, a passage clearly derived from this one.

the pure and simple truth 'when we are left in peace by the mud of the outside world and by disorder, and our dominant part will not be upset by the evil and disordered images … because you really have to look for serenity (σχολάσαι) to know God' (*Orat*. 27,3, see *Phaed*. 66bd); the soul must be separated from the body as far as possible (τὸ χωρίζειν ὅτι μάλιστα ἀπὸ τοῦ σώματος τὴν ψυχήν) (*Orat*. 28,12, see *Phaed*. 67c).[265]

The 'purpose of our religion' was foretold by the prophets and those who speak with God (*Orat*. 7,17), but it is also the 'discourse of the wise':

> I believe in the words of the wise, that is, every fair and God-beloved soul, when set free from the bonds of the body, it departs hence, at once enjoys a sense and perception of the blessings that await it, inasmuch as that which darkened it has been purged away, or laid aside – I know not how else to term it – and feels a wondrous pleasure and exultation, and goes rejoicing to meet its Lord, having escaped as it were from the jail of the grievous life here (ὥσπερ τι δεσμωτέριον χαλεπόν) and shaken off the fetters which bound it (τὰς περικειμένας … πέδας) and held down the wings of the mind, and, so to say, enters on the enjoyment of the bliss laid up for it, of which it has even now some conception (*Orat*. 7,21).

This statement has a parallel in two passages from the *Phaedo*: 'if as far as possible we have no dealings and share nothing with the body, except where absolutely necessary, and … cleanse ourselves of it until the god himself releases us[266] (ἐὰν ὅτι μάλιστα μηδὲν ὁμιλῶμεν τῷ σώματι μηδὲ κοινωνῶμεν … ἀλλὰ καθαρεύωμεν ἀπ'αὐτοῦ, ἕως ἂν ὁ θεὸς αὐτὸς ἀπολύσῃ ἡμᾶς)' (67a); 'the soul … released, as it were, from the chains of the body (ἐκλυομένην ὥσπερ δεσμῶν ἐκ τοῦ σώματος)' (67d). Gregory also takes up an expression of Plato (*Phaed*. 67b) in *Orat*. 2,39 and 27,3 ('only he who is pure can touch what is pure and is always equal to itself': καθαρῷ γὰρ μόνον ἁπτέον τοῦ καθαροῦ καὶ ὡσαύτως ἔχοντος), and the Platonic term for 'prison (δεσμωτήριον) of the soul' is found in *Orat*. 17,9 and *Epist*. 195; δεσμός in *Orat*. 43,2; the chains (πέδαι) of the soul in *Orat*. 14,7; PG 35, 865B and 18, 989B.

Gregory exhorts his friend Philagrius to take up an ascetic life:

> you must find in your vulnerability a place to philosophize, and purify your mind now more than ever, and show yourself stronger than the things that hold you in check (τῶν δεσμῶν) … namely, to look down on the body and bodily things, and on all that is fleeting and disturbing and passing away and so to become completely focused on what lies above, to live not for the present world but for the world to come, making this life here what Plato calls "a preparation for death" (θανάτου μελέτην)[267] and loosing the

[265] Cl. Moreschini, 'Il platonismo cristiano' (1974), 1356-62; *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 24-31. Other passages which show the points of contact between Gregory Nazianzen and the *Phaedo* are in C. Moreschini, *ibid.*

[266] Trans. Christopher Emly-Jones and William Preddy, LCL 2017.

[267] Plat., *Phaed*. 81a.

soul as far as possible, from what, in his words, we call either its body or its tomb (εἴτε σώματος εἴτε σήματος) (*Epist*. 31,3-4).[268]

Gregory also employs the concept of 'meditation on death' in *Orat*. 27,7 and *Epist*. 76,1, sent to the Nyssen.[269] The parents of Gregory Nazianzen and Caesarius console themselves for the loss of their son, because 'they have practiced the meditation of dissolution throughout their lives' (τὸν βίον ὅλον μελέτην λύσεως ἐνστησάμενοι) (*Orat*. 7,18). But in this passage Gregory does not exactly use the Platonic expression (μελέτη θανάτου), because he does not speak of the 'exercise of death', but of the 'exercise of dissolution' (μελέτην λύσεως). The term 'dissolution' to indicate death refers to a scriptural passage (*Phil*. 1:23): 'having a desire to depart, and to be with Christ; which is far better'. All this demonstrates that the reading of Plato was customary, at least of the most well-known and literary dialogues, such as the *Phaedo* and the *Phaedrus*, which cannot be traced back only to a rhetorical practice.[270]

Gregory Nazianzen also takes up the doctrine of Platonic origin, which was widespread especially in Middle-Platonism and also in the school of Alexandria, of 'assimilation to God' (cf. *Orat*. 6,14; 8,6; 24,15 etc.).[271] Assimilation to God is also called 'divinization' (*Orat*. 4,71; 21,2; 23,12), or 'becoming God' (*Orat*. 7,23; 17,9; PG 37, 976C; 25,2; *Epist*. 178, 11; *Carm*. I 2,10,141), 'unite oneself with God' (*Orat*. 4,71; 18,11; PG 37, 997C; 21,2; 37,12; 38,7; *Carm*. I 2,10,64-5), and similar expressions (*Orat*. 2,5; 2,71; 2,91; 12,4; 18,4, 989B; 26,7).[272] Holl had observed that the concept of divinization 'is rare in Athanasius, avoided by Basil, and exclusive to Gregory Nazianzen'.[273] Gregory of Nyssa uses it, but more rarely: 'then God was united with our nature so that it could become divine thanks to its union with the divine nature, torn as it was from death and freed from the tyranny of the Enemy' (κατεμίχθη πρὸς τὸ ἡμέτερον τῇ πρὸς τὸ θεῖον ἐπιμιξίᾳ) (*Catech*. 25,2; GNO III/IV, 64,7-10).[274] Virginity 'renders divine' whoever participates in the pure mysteries, because he participates in the purity of God and communicates with his glory (*Virg*. 1).

[268] Trans. Daley, modified.

[269] Who evidently was able to understand it by himself, whereas writing to Philagrius, Gregory had to explain that he was quoting a passage from Plato.

[270] Which had been Pierre Courcelle's interpretation (*Connais-toi toi-même* [1974-1975]), although Courcelle surpasses previous scholars for abundance of quotes and knowledge.

[271] Even with numerous reworkings, interesting from a literary point of view, but essentially irrelevant in terms of content.

[272] Further details in Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 33-5.

[273] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 64. On this problem see also N. Russell, *The Doctrine of Deification* (2006). Christopher A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus on the Trinity* (2008), 116-9 explains it as man's participation in the divine reality in this and in the eschatological life.

[274] The terms κατεμίχθη and ἐπιμιξίᾳ have a christological meaning, which will be discussed on p. 284-6.

Jacob's ladder is the virtuous life, and since God is at the top of the ladder, 'participation in the beatitudes means nothing other than communion with God' (*Beat. Hom.* 5; GNO VII/II, 120,23-124,16; 124,24-6). The sixth beatitude: 'blessed are the pure in heart, because they will see God' introduces us to the knowledge of God (*Beat. Hom.* 6; GNO VII/II, 140,13-144,13).

Contemplation is reserved exclusively for those who have prepared themselves through severe purification:

> Where there is fear (of God), there is observation of the commandments; where the commandments are observed, there is a cleansing of the flesh, that cloud that blocks the soul's vision and keeps it from seeing clearly the rays of divine illumination; but where there is cleansing, there is also illumination and illumination is the fulfillment of desire for those eager to share in the greatest things – or in the greatest Thing, or in That which is beyond the great! (*Orat.* 39,8).[275]

Gregory therefore transforms in a Christian sense the 'purification' of which Plato speaks. Plato had said: 'temperance and justice and courage may be a kind of cleansing of all this sort of qualities, and wisdom itself may be some kind of purification (καὶ αὐτὴ ἡ φρόνησις μὴ καθαρμός τις ᾖ: *Phaed.* 69c)', and Gregory replaces 'prudence', which is a civil virtue, with the virtues that are obtained with purification, that is, with asceticism.[276]

In this relationship between purification and contemplation Gregory follows the teaching of Origen, who says that when 'all parts of the Temple become all gold, this is a symbol of the mind completely perfected with respect to the exact contemplation of the intelligibles' (*Ioh. comm.* X 40,283); 'and to those who are contemplative God is contemplable in the heart, that is to say in the intellect; and not with any heart, but with a purified heart. It is not permitted, in fact, to fix one's gaze on God with a soiled heart, but he must be pure who contemplates the Pure Being as He deserves' (*CC* VI 69); *quod propinquitas sit quaedam menti ad Deum, cuius ipsa mens intellectualis imago sit, et per hoc possit aliquid de deitatis sentire natura, maxime si expurgatior ac segregatior sit a materia corporali* (*Princ.* I 1,7).

Purification, which makes possible contemplation, consists in the elimination of passions: 'once he has become pure from passions he can have the enjoyment of knowledge (ἀπόλαυσις τῆς γνώσεως) (*Selecta in Ps.* 93, XIII, 34 Lommatzsch)'; 'after purifying one's behaviour, one could set out on the path that leads to knowledge (*Matth. comm.* XVI, 7 = 488,11 Klostermann)'; 'no one can know the creator, if he does not have a soul free from passions and does not purify his mind, because only he who have purified his heart can be

[275] Trans. Daley.

[276] The connection between asceticism and contemplation is also found in the Neoplatonic tradition, as Ugo Criscuolo observed, '*Itinerarium mentis*' (1989).

considered worthy of this grace of understanding God and seeing him with more divine eyes' (*Ioh. comm.* XIX 3,17).[277]

But knowledge of God is procured directly by God, it cannot be reached by human force alone: 'God, by means of a certain power, reaches the intellect of each and becomes the cause of the fact that he can think of Him' (*Ps. comm.* 4, XI, 454 Lommatzsch). He who gives the light of knowledge is the Logos (*Ioh. comm.* I 27,181; II 1,10; 24,156 etc.); 'The Saviour, on the other hand, illuminates beings endowed with logos (λογικοί) and with the 'dominant part' (ἡγεμονικόν), so that their intellect can see what are the realities proper to its visual capacity: the Logos is therefore the light of the intelligible world, I mean, of souls endowed with logos who are in the sensible world' (*ibid.* I 25,161). But for Origen the inverse relationship was also valid, that is, the activity of the Christian, if previously nourished by the contemplation of the divine mystery, constitutes, in a certain sense, a second degree of perfection: 'reinvigorated by contemplation to perform the works that await us' (*Orat.* 27, 10); 'there are those who see the Son of God and from this vision draw strength in order never to sin' (*Ioh. comm.* XX 14,110). This concept takes up an ancient Platonic image, that of the sun, which is itself the cause of our seeing, just as God, illuminating the mind of men, is the cause of their knowing. Gregory also uses it, either he himself deriving it from Plato or through Origen: 'God is for those who think and for those things which are thought, for some the former is the cause of thinking, for others the latter the cause of being thought, and He is the culmination of what is thought, towards which every desire is directed' (*Orat.* 21,1).

The Nazianzen seems to be more rigorous than the Nyssen in affirming the need for detachment from the body in the process of ascesis and purification. In the *De opificio hominis* and in the *De anima et resurrectione* the Nyssen, as seen above, does not lay particular emphasis on an original guilt of the body, but believes that it is connected to the soul in all respects, for better or for worse. The need for purification leaves room for the existence of passions, provided they are used rationally and for a justifiable purpose. Even more specifically ascetic works (*De professione christiana*, *De perfectione* and *De instituto christiano*), while insisting more on the need for *imitatio Christi* due

[277] According to Origen Moses and his ascent to the mountain are the symbol of the crowning of the mystical ascent of the soul to God: see *CC* I 19; *Princ.* III 1,22; *Num. hom.* 22,3; *Psalm. hom. 36*, 4,1. Gregory also states that the various degrees of purification correspond to various degrees of closeness to God, and therefore of knowledge of God: if Moses could get closer to God, by reaching the top of the mountain, so does (or rather, tries to do) Gregory; if one has the dignity of Aaron, let him go up with Moses, and remain with him, even if outside the cloud, and be satisfied with this limitation. If one is an old man, like Nadab or Abiud, go up, but stop further, *according to the dignity that comes from his purification*; and thus descending to the most unworthy and most contemptible people, who must keep well away from the mountain (*Orat.* 28,2; similar reasoning already in *Orat.* 2,92-3).

to the influence of Macarius' "great letter", correspond substantially to the "optimistic" anthropology of the theoretical treatises.[278]

Evagrius

Regarding Evagrius Ponticus, scholars debate whether, in conformity with his choice of life, the specific monasticism of the Egyptian tradition prevails over both the form of monasticism, predictor of the medieval organization, proposed by Basil,[279] and over the mysticism of Gregory of Nyssa, and – and even more so – over the philosophical asceticism of Gregory Nazianzen: in that case, by following desert monasticism Evagrius had truly abandoned his master. His works are intended for the most part for those who had made the same choice of life as his and allow us to consider Evagrius as the first theoretician of desert monasticism. For this reason Konstantinovsky believes that with his choice Evagrius deliberately broke any relationship with Gregory Nazianzen, to the extent that he no longer names him, except only once in a letter.[280] On the other hand, other scholars, including Guillaumont, believe that Evagrius also preserved in his writings of the desert period the teaching received from the Cappadocians: he could not completely ignore Basil's asceticism and writings.[281] In our opinion, even in the desert Evagrius takes into account the ascetic doctrines not so much of Basil, but of his master Gregory Nazianzen, although, of course, he develops them, and adds to them his personally constructed tenets.

There are various statements by Gregory Nazianzen that unite 'action' (which of course must be understood in the sense of action as purification of the soul) with contemplation: 'action is the basis for contemplation' (πρᾶξις ἐπίβασις θεωρίας (*Orat.* 20,12); 'action is close to contemplation' (*Orat.* 40,37); contemplation 'leads our intellect to ascend towards that reality to which it is similar' (*Orat.* 4,113), and it is in πρᾶξις that Athanasius exercised himself (*Orat.* 21,4). It allows the most perfect thing of all, the γνῶσις θεοῦ (*Orat.* 20,11). That the practice is asceticism is a statement taken up by Evagrius in

[278] M. Ludlow, 'Christian Formation and the Body–Soul Relationship in Gregory of Nyssa' (2018), 160-78.

[279] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au desert* (2004), 177-8 underlines the difference between Evagrius, who proposed monastic asceticism, and the asceticism of Basil, which is intended for all Christians (as also Gribomont and Rousseau before him).

[280] J. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 12-5. Konstantinovsky, logically, finds that there are numerous similarities between Evagrius and the Cappadocians, even if she then speaks (but unconvincingly) of the 'independence of his (Evagrius') theological position from the Cappadocian views' (*ibid.* 76-7) and is of the opinion that if Evagrius was influenced by anyone, he was, perhaps, by Rufinus or Melania. This seems to me unlikely, and it is contradictory to trace various doctrines of Evagrius even to the sources of Greek philosophy, instead of to the Cappadocians.

[281] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au desert* (2004), 194-7.

the tripartition we have seen (p. 191). As Gregory had recommended the search for tranquillity of the soul to be able to exercise contemplation, so Evagrius also asserts that the foundation of asceticism is ἡσυχία, a term of philosophical language that indicates 'tranquillity of the soul', the *otium* of contemplation, which however is not inaction.[282]

Evagrius also takes up from Gregory Nazianzen the ascending relationship from praxis to contemplation through purification. Practice, in fact, procures ἀπάθεια, which is the purpose of ascetic life and which allows one to exercise θεωρία (*Prakt*. 81); one must detach oneself from the representations of this world (*Prakt*. 17) and the irascible part itself must fight the demons (*Prakt*. 24). Lack of passion is a fundamental condition for prayer (*Prakt*. 64), which is very important in the asceticism of Evagrius.[283] When it has reached perfect impassiveness, the intellect begins to see the light and to obtain 'pure prayer', in which the ascetic will see his intellect similar to the stars. Pure prayer is the culmination of contemplation and allows knowledge of God and participation in Him. Prayer is a part of mysticism, and requires the same purification that Gregory had emphasized as necessary for contemplation.[284]

This spiritual knowledge which comes to us by the grace of God through impassibility makes those who have come to possess it 'gnostic'. This level is reached when the parts of the soul have been healed, and the new man will be reconstituted, in the image of the Creator, in Whom, thanks to holy impassibility, there is no longer male or female, but everything and in everyone is Christ.

One way in which Gregory seeks to clarify the process of human purification in the tension of ascent to the divine is to compare purification with an 'illuminating', with a 'making the soul luminous'; consequently, the soul can access the pure light of God, in a meeting of light with light, in the middle of which the lesser light dissolves (*Orat*. 32,15). He who has received divine illumination more than another becomes 'of a more luminous form' (φωτοειδέστερος) than the other (*Orat*. 28,17); the intellect, which is 'of the same nature as God' (*Orat*. 14,4; PG 37, 864A) or 'similar to God' when it is illuminated by God

[282] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 180-2. Beside *hesychia* there is the compunction and continuous meditation on the presence of the Lord, associated with prayer (*ibid*. 206-8); other ascetic forms of Evagrius (*ibid*. 183-94).

[283] J. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 81; A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 133-66 (very exhaustive).

[284] That prayer makes possible the union of the soul with God is underlined by Guillaumont (*Un philosophe au désert* [2004], 298-9); the relationship between the ascetic and God through prayer in A. Casiday (*Reconstructing the Theology* [2013], 137-8); see also L. Perrone, *La preghiera secondo Origene* (2011), 564-87. Evagrius seems to have derived the concept of prayer not from Gregory, but from Clemens of Alexandria (*Stromat*. VII 7), stating: 'prayer is a conversation of the intellect with God (*Orat*. 3)': pure prayer is not attained only through impassiveness, but through various degrees of contemplation. It is an ascent of the intellect towards God (*Orat*. 35).

(*Orat*. 28,17), becomes 'divine in form' (θεοειδεῖς) (*Orat*. 21,1; 38,7; 39,10).[285] So also Evagrius speaks of the intellect which has the form of a star (νοῦς ἀστεροειδής: *Cogitat*. 43) or of light (νοῦς φωτοειδής: *Skemmata* 25).[286]

In conclusion, asceticism is the tool for ascending to contemplation, according to Gregory: Evagrius follows him by merely changing the terms: purification is 'practice' and contemplation is 'gnosis'.

[285] Cl. Moreschini, 'Il platonismo cristiano' (1974), 1363-5.
[286] I have drawn these suggestions from A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 182.

Chapter IV
Trinitarian Theology

Matto è chi spera che nostra ragione
possa trascorrer la infinita via
che tiene una sustanza in tre Persone.
State contente, umane genti, al quia,
ché se possuto aveste saper tutto,
mestier non era parturir Maria.
(Dante, *Purgatorio* 3, 34-39)

The Trinitarian theology of the Cappadocians was slowly formed over the years and was not provided by them with the same solution, although it was by *communis opinio* summarized in the formula 'one substance – three hypostases'. Furthermore, the symbol of Nicaea seemed to have greater importance for Basil, who found it necessary to defend it, than for the Nazianzen[1] and even less for the Nyssen, both of whom are closer to the council of Constantinople and all, however, are more opposed to Eunomius than to Arius and his followers.[2]

The modern interpretations of the Trinitarian theology of the Cappadocians normally make use of the philosophy contemporary to them, and more particularly of Aristotelian, and, if necessary, Stoic, logic. Holl had already interpreted

[1] It has been said that 'the distinctive terminology and phrasing of Nicaea […] is of limited value in understanding Gregory's (of Nazianzus) doctrine', Ch.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus on the the Unity of Christ* (2008), 10 n. 27; 195 and 213.

[2] The 'Arians' were considered outdated as early as the next generation after Arius, and anti-Nicene theologians often claim to have nothing to do with him. Of course, the bibliography on this problem is infinite. Examining the theological discussions that preceded the Cappadocians Michel René Barnes asserts that the Cappadocian's polemical writings in favour of their theology do not bring into play either the Nicene Creed in general or *homousios* in particular. When in the decade following 370 AD an Eastern reinterpretation of Nicaea was added to a Western reinterpretation of Nicaea that had taken place after 360 AD, as well as heated pro-Nicene debate in Alexandria and the churches in Rome and Gaul, this led to a dominant consensus in favour of a reinterpretation of the Nicene Creed. 'Hypostasis' also ceased to be a term that had been anathematised by Nicaea, becoming instead a necessary term for an orthodox interpretation of the Nicene Creed – and all this occurred without its ever appearing in the Nicene or Constantinople Creed. Barnes therefore once again questions the normative status of *homousios*. The use of *homousios* on the part of the pro-Nicenes may be viewed as a reaction to the clear and consistent way in which the anti-Nicenes so vigorously rejected it. While the debate for the defence of *homousios* was limited to the sphere of Athanasius and the Latin pro-Nicenes, anti-Nicene criticism of the term frequently occurs in the Trinitarian debates, M.R. Barnes, 'The fourth century as trinitarian canon' (1998), 58-61.

Basil's solution as a form of popular Aristotelianism,[3] and this interpretation is often followed in our times.[4] We are therefore faced with the problems we noted in the use of philosophy in the previous chapter, and precisely with regard to the core of the Cappadocian theology, that is, their Trinitarian doctrine.

1. *The 'Neo-Nicene Formula': Marius Victorinus*

It had been hypothesized that the very formula "one substance – three hypostases" was present in the West before the Cappadocians. Marius Victorinus, who wrote the *Adversus Arium* in 361-362 (thus before Basil's works) approves it and assigns it a Greek origin: 'This is expressed by Greeks in this way: there are three hypostases from one substance[5] (*idque a Graecis ita dicitur*: ἐκ μιᾶς οὐσίας τρεῖς εἶναι τὰς ὑποστάσεις)' (*Adv. Arium* III 4). In another passage (*Adv. Arium* II 4) he gives its Latin translation: 'And that is why it was said: From one substance there are three subsistences (*et ideo dictum est: de una substantia tres subsistentias esse*)'. However, Marius Victorinus' formula does not correspond to the formula of the Cappadocians, because it speaks of three hypostases that derive from one substance, not three hypostases that are *in* a substance.[6] Moreover, the definitions that Victorinus proposes elsewhere do not agree with this formula, since they distinguish between *substantia* (of God) and

[3] See Karl Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 131-5 and 146.

[4] Criticized by R. Hübner, 'Der Gott der Kirchenväter und der Gott der Bibel' (2017), 345.

Currently 'social analogy' for inter-Trinitarian relations is also spoken of: see L. Ayres, 'On not three People' (2003); M.R. Barnes, 'Divine Unity and the divided Self' (2003). Sarah Coakley herself also speaks of it, 'Introduction – Gender, Trinitarian Analogies, and the Pedagogy' (2003), where, however, references to 'gender' (*ibid*. 3) seem superfluous to me: if it is admitted that Gregory of Nyssa, when he speaks of 'man' in *Ad Ablabium* uses *anthropos* and not *anèr*, the question of gender does not arise, even if the examples given by Gregory to illustrate his interpretation are all examples of men: but this was normal practice in the ancient world. We disregard this interpretation, although it is true that it seeks to 'surpass the common hermeneutic approach to Nyssian thought that maintains that he starts from the Persons as is typical in the East, instead of from the essence, as would be more typical of the Western tradition', G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), XII.

[5] Trans. by Mary T. Clark, The Fathers of the Church 69 (2001).

[6] Thus A.M. Ritter, *Das Konzil von Konstantinopel* (1965), 285 n. 2 and 288 n. 4; L. Abramowski, 'Trinitarische und Christologische Hypostasenformeln' (1979), 44-5; V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung der Trinitätslehre* (1996), 19-20. Drecoll's opinion has been called into question by M. Simonetti, 'Dal nicenismo al neonicenismo. Rassegna di alcune pubblicazioni recenti' (M. Simonetti, *Studi di cristologia postnicena* [2006], 274-5). But neither is Simonetti convincing, because he believes that Marius Victorinus' formula derives from Porphyry (*a Graecis ita dicitur* can also refer to pagan Greeks, not Christians) (see what we observe below, p. 239). Chr. Markschies addresses correct objections to Simonetti, 'Was ist lateinischer "Neunizänismus"?' (2000), 251-4 and observes that the same formula is used by Eunomius (of course according to his conception) in *Refut*. 33,35 and 36, and for this reason is rejected by Gregory of Nyssa. In any case, the formula of Marius Victorinus, analogous to one of his contemporary Hilary of Poitiers, presupposes the

subsistentia, which is the Latin translation of ὑπόστασις: 'but the Father is by his own subsistence, the Son is by his own subsistence, from the one substance which is from the Father (*sed subsistentia propria et pater et filius est, ab una ex patre substantia*)' (*Adv. Arium* I 39); the Father, the Son and the Spirit 'are one sole substance, while being three subsistences (*unum esse et unam esse substantiam, subsistentias tres*)' (*Adv. Arium* III 9).

In conclusion, the Trinitarian formula that Marius Victorinus knows and which is attributed by him to the Greeks does not have all the importance that some scholars would like to give it, because it is substantially proposed cursorily, and does not agree with his miahypostatic theology, which was still typical of the West around 360.[7] Much less, therefore, is it an antecedent of the formula that is attributed by *communis opinio* to the Cappadocians.

We will now see that not even in the writings of the Cappadocians is the Trinitarian lexicon stable, but rather highly varied, especially in a highly rhetorical writer like Gregory Nazianzen, and only with the passing of the years does it tend to become established: this occurs in Basil's last years, when he wrote the great theological epistles and the *De Spiritu sancto*, and in the years around the council of Constantinople, when Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa, who both also felt the influence of Basil's last works, more so than that of the *Contra Eunomium*, were writing.

2. *The Trinitarian Lexicon of the Cappadocians*

Ousia

It has been stated for a long time that οὐσία and ὑπόστασις, and the terms linked to them (*homousios*, *prosopon* etc.) are used by the Cappadocians in a non-univocal manner and, above all, in a manner that does not correspond to a precise formulation. Another point brought to light by recent studies is that the problem of the meaning of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις does not constitute the central point of their Trinitarian theology.[8] The Cappadocians formulated the Trinitarian theology in different ways and independently of each other, even if they had in common the aim of distinguishing and uniting the divine 'Persons'.

existence of a substance prior to the three persons, as has been well explained by J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa* (2000), 28-31.

[7] Cf. J. Voelker, 'An Anomalous Trinitarian Formula' (2006), 522. Voelker believes that it can be derived from Meletius; it would, however, be a formula of Homoeusian origin, which Zachhuber explains according to his interpretation of universals, J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa* (2000), 21-31.

[8] Chr. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 225 and 231; R. Hübner, 'Basilius von Caesarea und das homousios', in L.R. Wickham and C.P. Bammel (eds), *Christian Faith and Greek Philosophy* (1993), 91, now in: *Kirche und Dogma im Werden* (2017), 377-8.

What was traditionally believed to be a formula is not based on a consolidated system of terms[9] and the concept of 'Trinity' had not yet been clarified through the systematic use of them.

It is therefore opportune in the first place to re-examine the variety of the theological lexicon. Basil himself, who undoubtedly originated, if not the formula, certainly the trinitarian conception, and who introduced, if not explicitly, but certainly clearly, the difference between substance and hypostasis (*CE* I 15 and I 19),[10] in one passage states without using a technical and precise language that 'God is one, because through the two (the Father and the Son) we contemplate one εἶδος, visible in the two' (*Hom. contra Sabellianos et Arium et Anomaeos* 24,4; PG 31, 608C): Basil means that the divine substance of the Father and the Son is one, but the term εἶδος is ambiguous, because it might seem that Basil considers the Trinity as a genus that includes species, which, however, Basil himself denies in *De Spiritu sancto* (17,41),[11] and had denied previously, writing to Apollinaris (*Epist*. 361, 3,221,19-21 Courtonne: ἐφ'ὧν [that is, regarding the Father and the Son) οὔτε γένος κοινὸν ὑπερκείμενον θεωρεῖται οὔτε ὑλικὸν ὑποκείμενον προϋπάρχον).

The use of ὑπερκείμενον and ὑποκείμενον also facilitates the use of ὑποκείμενον as an equivalent of οὐσία when expounding the theology of Nicaea, so that God is ἓν κατὰ τὸ ὑποκείμενον (*CE* I 7, 525 etc.), but he is not ἓν τὸ ὑποκείμενον (*Hom. in illud: In principio erat Verbum* 16,4; PG 31, 480C); Basil wished that Dionysius of Alexandria had limited himself to arguing that the Father and the Son are not ταυτὸν τῷ ὑποκειμένῳ (*Epist*. 9,2, I, 38,16 Courtonne), instead of separating their hypostases. This oscillation between ὑποκείμενον, ousia and hypostasis is found several times in Gregory of Nyssa and the lack of rigour in Basil's terminology had already been noted by Hübner, who, to explain it, denies that Basil wanted to be a philosopher.[12] Ayres attributes, albeit in a very different theological context (which is what we will see further on, that of the origin of the divine Persons), to Gregory of Nyssa a 'happy disregard for what we may call "orthodox precision"'.[13]

[9] As had already been observed by K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 211-2.

[10] See R. Hübner, 'Gregor von Nyssa als Verfasser der sog. Ep. 38 des Basilius' (1972) = (2017), 269-70; *id*., 'Zur Genese der trinitarischen Formel' (2017), 319-20. For an extensive analysis of the *status quaestionis* and Basil's theological formation, *ibid*. 291-325.

[11] R. Hübner (*ibid*. 273) and *id*., 'Ps-Athanasius, Contra Sabellianos' (2017), 412-3 explains the presence of this term in the Trinitarian context as due to the influence of *Contra Sabellianos*, which he believes is the work of Apollinaris of Laodicea, R. Hübner, *Die Schrift des Apolinarius von Laodicea* (1989), 124-5. The unusual definition was probably due to the different situation and to the literary genre of the homily, which was much more imprecise than the treatise.

[12] R. Hübner, *Die Schrift des Apolinarius von Laodicea* (1989), 2 with quotations; *id*., 'Gregor von Nyssa als Verfasser der sog. Ep. 38 des Basilius' (2017), 272-4. Of course, Basil's attitude was not to want to be a philosopher, but the use of philosophy was inevitable, both for him and for the two Gregories.

[13] L. Ayres, 'On not three People' (2003), 8; *id*., *Nicaea and its Legacy* (2004), 363: 'Like most other pro-Nicenes Gregory uses a variety of terminologies for describing the relationship

The theological terminology of Gregory Nazianzen had also been mutable from the beginning. His first three homilies precede Basil's *Contra Eunomium* and are contemporary with Basil's letters to Apollinarius. There does not appear to be a significant influence from Basil and they lack both the term οὐσία, common for Basil, and *homousios*; οὐσία is replaced by other terms of a similar, but more generic, meaning (e.g. θεότης, which could also be used by non-Christians): 'The Father, Son and Holy Spirit, the only divinity and power (τὴν μίαν θεότητά τε καὶ δύναμιν)' (*Orat.* 1,7). We also frequently find θεότης in the later homilies (*Orat.* 6,22; 22,12; 25,16; 30,12), together with δύναμις (*Orat.* 22,12); we find οὐσία only in one later homily (*Orat.* 39,11).[14] The identification between θεότης and οὐσία (with the addition of the δύναμις) is also proposed many years later, in 383, and clarified with the example of splendour (αὐγή), the ray (ἀκτίς) and the sun (*Epist.* 101,68), which indicate the divine Persons.

The use that the Nazianzen makes, like Origen before him (*Princ.* I 1,6), of μονάς to indicate the divine nature is, on the other hand, new. He repeats it in the Constantinople period (*Orat.* 23,8; 25,17; 26,19; 29,2) and later, having returned to Nazianzus (*Carm.* II 1,12,312); following Gregory Evagrius also asserts that God is a μονάς (*Epist. fidei* = Bas., *Epist.* 8, I, 7,30 Courtonne); μονάς is also found in Amphilochius of Iconium (*Iambi* 193) and is then also frequent in Gregory of Nyssa.

The fluctuation in the use of the terms designating Trinitarian theology seems to diminish in Gregory's last orations: the occasion (the statement of a profession of faith, as in oration 23 or preaching at important moments) justifies this greater attention to the words used.

Homousios

Scholars have come to a concordant conclusion on the use of this term. The use of *homousios* on the part of the pro-Nicenes may be viewed as a reaction to the clear and consistent way in which the anti-Nicenes so vigorously rejected it. In *Contra Eunomium* Gregory of Nyssa himself uses *homousios* only once, while recounting the clash between Basil and Valens, but, as is typical of the debate fostered by the Cappadocians, it appears uttered by those who reject it. Unlike the 'Greek Westerner' Athanasius and the Latins, the Cappadocians did not respond to the anti-Nicene attacks on *homousios*, turning the term into the central focus of their argument; on the contrary, *homousios* hardly appears in Cappadocian writings against Eunomius. It appears twenty-five times in

between the divine unity and persons: *ousia*, φύσις, *hypostasis*, and πρόσωπον are all brought into service when it is deemed necessary'.

[14] Its use in *Orat.* 34,9 is generic: Gregory speaks of the *ousia* of God, which can be both the substance and the existence.

Gregory of Nyssa; of the twenty-five cases twelve occur in the writings against Apollinarius and nine in *Contra Eunomium*. Of these nine, three occur among the words of an anti-Nicene (Eunomius or Valens), and four are used lacking any significance in the sense of the Trinity. Similarly, Nicaea is never mentioned in these texts as a norm.[15]

The same fluctuation can be found in Basil.[16] Hübner pointed out the minor importance of *homousios* in the *Contra Eunomium*:[17] this is not surprising, as Basil's 'conversion' from homoiusianism dates back to a few years earlier, and until then he had mainly dealt with practical rules for his monastic life.[18] Basil employs it, with reference to the Trinity, only in *CE* I 20, while he continues to use (I 18 and 27) ἀπαράλλακτον τῆς οὐσίας,[19] which he proposed in the letters to Apollinaris and which he will also use a few years later in epistle 9. Hübner notes that *homousios* is found only in homily 24,4 (*Contra Sabellianos et Arium et Anomaeos*; PG 31, 608A).[20] However, in the same homily Basil also employs the term ἀπαράλλακτον: ἀπαράλλακτον τῆς θεότητος (601C) and τὸ τῆς φύσεως (= θεότητος) ἀπαράλλακτον (604A and 608A). In that same homily he also uses ταυτότης as the equivalent of *homoousios* to indicate the identity of nature of the Son with the Father (604C-605A).

[15] So Michel-René Barnes, 'The fourth century as trinitarian canon' (1998), 58-61 (above, note 2); *id*., 'One Nature, One Power' (1997), 218.

[16] See for instance L. Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy* (2004), 188-91.

[17] R. Hübner, 'Basilius von Caesarea und das *homousion*' (2017), 361-78, 377-8.

[18] Perhaps Basil was still influenced by the Homoiousians. The relationship between Basil and the Homoiusians is discussed. Simonetti is inclined to consider Basil close to the Homoiousians and to exclude any influence of Athanasius, *Studi di cristologia postnicena* (2006), 271-7; R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 316-7 also thinks this, but believes that Basil also followed Athanasius (*ibid*. 374-8). On the other hand, that Basil was a Homoiusian is disputed by J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 50-3; *id*., 'Basil and the three-hypostases tradition' (2001), 82, whereas that he is close to Athanasius is an opinion put forward by M. DelCogliano, 'The Influence of Athanasius and the Homoiousians' (2011). An initial adhesion to Homoiousianism is not excluded, but considerably limited by V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung der Trinitätslehre* (1996), on which see the review by Simonetti (1998). The Nazianzen and the Nyssen are even more distant from Athanasius than Basil had been: very probably in their time the Trinitarian doctrine of Athanasius was no longer current. The celebration of Athanasius by Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 21) contains a treatment that is more historical, with the reference to the council of Antioch, and more concerned with ecclesiastical praxis, when referring to the episcopacy, the priesthood and the monasticism of his time, than theological: Gregory stresses the importance of Athanasius' teaching for pneumatology (*Orat*. 21,33), rather than for the Trinitarian doctrine.

[19] *Epist*. 361, 3, 221,30-1 Courtonne.

[20] According to R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 372-6 in that homily Basil was influenced by Apollinaris, who used *homousios* without difficulty. Gemeinhardt also asserted that Apollinaris influenced Basil, convincing him to use the ταυτὸν κατὰ τὴν οὐσίαν, P. Gemeinhardt, 'Apollinaris of Laodicea: A Neglected Link' (2006), 292-4 and Kelly McCarthy Spoerl thinks that Apollinaris in the *KMP* was clear about the function of the ὁμοούσιος, K. McCarthy Spoerl, 'Apollinarius on the Holy Spirit' (2001), 580-1. In my opinion, however, Basil in that homily, which is late, adapts to the use of *homousios*, which was becoming normal among the pro-Nicenes.

Mark DelCogliano observes that faithfulness to Scripture perhaps helps to explain Basil's well-known reticence towards terms that seemed new to him.[21] Basil, in fact, does not like the term 'begotten', derived from *Acts* 2:36, used since the apologetics and traditional in the Arian controversy (cf. *CE* II 2), and does not like γέννημα; he believes that Eunomius invented ποίημα because *Acts* 2:36 says that the Father 'made' God the Christ. The term 'Son' is more scriptural and 'begotten' does not fully manifest the relationship between the Father and the Son (cf. *CE* II 8).[22] Hübner also observes that Basil never uses the term 'begetter' (γεννήτωρ), which instead is found in the *Contra Sabellianos* of the Pseudo Athanasius,[23] and that he uses γέννημα in homily 24,4 (PG 31, 608A) merely *en passant*.[24]

In conclusion, Hildebrand distinguishes four phases in Basil's development: 1. The years of Basil's homoiusianism (360-365); 2. The transition from *homoiousios* to *homousios* (365-372); 3. The use of *prosopa* for the divine Persons (c. 372); 4. The emergence of 'hypostasis' (375-379), in order to express the three Prosopa.[25] In any case, Hildebrand maintains that the use of *homoios* appears to Basil more and more unsatisfactory, so that the transition to a definite acceptance of the word *homousios*, as well as 'prosopon' and 'hypostasis', occurs gradually, and occasionally even with the complementary presence of the two terms.[26] During the years from 360 AD to 370 AD, it may be seen that Basil gradually distanced himself from those who refused to set out on his road towards a pro-Nicene type of theology. Simonetti states:[27]

I believe that, while not excluding tactical reasons on specific occasions, Basil's attitude towards *homousios* must be above all explained keeping in mind precisely *ep*. 9: the awareness, that is, that the term was equivocal and therefore needed adequate clarification. If after his break with Eustathius, the fact that he not only accepted it but also propagandized it was above all for political reasons, given the precedents of 362 (Alexandria) and 363 (Antioch), but the term never entirely convinced him on a theoretical level. An attitude that has a lot in common with that of Hilary years before. It is in fact mainly in the letters, written occasionally and for purposes of propaganda, that he makes use of the term, while he preferred to make little use of it (Eun.) or not at all (Spir.) in the treatises, which, although also engaged in the polemic, allowed a greater speculative and discursive breadth.

[21] M. DelCogliano, 'Basil of Caesarea on the Primacy of the Name 'Son'' (2011).

[22] *Ibid*. 62-3.

[23] The *Contra Sabellianos* is probably by Apollinaris, R. Hübner, *Die Schrift des Apolinarius von Laodicea* (1989), 75.

[24] According to Hübner (*ibid*. 120-3), this was due to the influence of the *Contra Sabellianos* (very strong throughout the homily) because momentarily Basil did not find another term and knew very well that the people before whom he was speaking could hardly remember the *Contra Eunomium*. This explanation, however, is hypothetical.

[25] S.M. Hildebrand, *The Trinitarian Theology of Basil of Caesarea* (2009), 31.

[26] *Ibid*. 76-82.

[27] In his review of Drecoll (1998), 314.

Nor is *homousios* used exclusively by Gregory of Nazianzus, while other terms have the same meaning for him. One of them is τῆς οὐσίας ταυτότης:[28] God is one on account of the concordance of the Three and of the possession of the same substance (οὐχ ἧττον διὰ τὴν ὁμόνοιαν ἢ τὴν τῆς οὐσίας ταυτότητα) (*Orat.* 6,13),[29] or on account of the sameness of the substance and the power (τῷ ταυτῷ τῆς οὐσίας καὶ τῆς δυνάμεως, καὶ οὗτος ὁ τῆς ἑνώσεως λόγος) (*Orat.* 31,16). In this passage οὐσία and δύναμις are united, and therefore δύναμις indicates the nature of God, as for the Nyssen. Another term equivalent to 'consubstantial' is ἴσον τῆς φύσεως (*Orat.* 30,7). In *Orat.* 23,7 Gregory employs ὅμοιος, saying that the Three are ὅμοιοι τὴν φύσιν καὶ ὁμόδοξοι, meaning 'similar' in a non-rigorous way, as do Basil and Athanasius. *Homousios* is found, however, in *Orat.* 41,12: Gregory explains the existence of the Holy Spirit on the basis of *John* 14:16 (Christ will send 'another Paraclete'). Ἄλλος does not mean 'other than me', but 'another me' (ἄλλος ἐγώ), and therefore the Spirit is lord with Christ and is not separated from him: in fact the term 'other' is not used to indicate what it is extraneous, but that which is consubstantial (ἐπὶ τῶν ὁμοουσίων). Gregory uses in the same way ἄλλος in *Arcana* 1,29-30[30] and in the most famous passage of *Epist.* 101,20-1: in the Trinity we find the distinction and union of ἄλλος καὶ ἄλλος while in the incarnate Christ we find the distinction and union of the two natures (ἄλλο καὶ ἄλλο).

And finally, ὁμοούσιος is not a fundamental term even for Amphilochius, who uses the term 'equal' (ἐπίσος) or 'of the same nature' (φύσις) as the Father, 'of the same honour' (ὁμότιμος) (*Hom.* 5,3-5), and 'similar' (ὅμοιος) (*Hom.* 9,5).[31]

Hypostasis

Just as he avoids 'consubstantial', Basil in *Contra Eunomium* also avoids 'hypostasis' as a Trinitarian term, although in *CE* III 3 he speaks clearly of the three divine hypostaseis and he is certainly able to distinguish between substance and hypostasis[32]: it is likely that this is due to the fact that the difference

[28] However ταυτότης, which Gregory uses in these cases to express the consubstantial, has also a negative meaning, because it indicates Sabellianism (see Bas., *Epist.* 52,3).

[29] *Homousios*, as seen above, is also used by Basil in the homily *Contra Sabellianos et Arium et Anomaeos*, which however is later than the sixth homily of the Nazianzen.

[30] See D. Sykes, St Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana* (1997), 88.

[31] The same oscillation between ὁμοούσιος and ὅμοιος is also present in the pseudo-Basilian *CE* IV 6, 14 etc. (division of paragraphs according to F.X. Risch) (see Cl. Moreschini, 'Pseudo-Basil against Eunomius' [2020], 449). It has been noted that Apollinaris, on the other hand, uses ὁμοούσιος without problems, in accordance with his convinced Nicenism: cf. *KMP* 27; 33-34 (against those who considered that word foreign to the Scriptures).

[32] Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 319 and 324 with bibliography.

between the two terms was still unusual and this terminology was not yet, for him, of primary importance: he did not like the meaning of these terms, both of philosophical origin, and, in his polemic with Eunomius, he preferred to use biblical language.[33] Hübner and Hildebrand arrived at the conclusion that Basil used ousia and hypostasis interchangeably, even if in some cases hypostasis foreshadows the specific use that the term was subsequently to take on.[34]

He achieved this result over the course of many years.[35] While at first (i.e. in *Contra Eunomium*) hypostasis does not differ much from ὕπαρξις, both indicating existence, subsequently hypostasis indicates the τρόπος τῆς ὑπάρξεως, and therefore distinguishes one reality from the other,[36] and ὕπαρξις simply indicates existence. Thus in the homily *Quod deus non est auctor malorum* (ch. 5; PG 31, 341BC) Basil distinguishes the existence of evil (ὕπαρξις τοῦ κακοῦ), which must not be attributed to God, from the specific hypostasis of evil (ἰδία ὑπόστασις τοῦ κακοῦ), which does not exist at all; in the homily *Contra Sabellianos, Arium et Anomaeos* (24,6; PG 31, 613A), he asserts that 'the mode of existence (τρόπος τῆς ὑπάρξεως) of the Spirit' is unknown to us. Here Basil uses τρόπος τῆς ὑπάρξεως, which had been considered typical of Amphilochius to indicate the different 'way of being' of the divine Persons:[37] 'the Father, the Son, the Holy Spirit are names of the mode of being, that is, of relationship, but not purely and simply of substance' (fragm. 15 Oberg)[38]. It is therefore probable that the concept of τρόπος τῆς ὑπάρξεως should be attributed to Basil, rather than to the less known, and certainly a disciple and not a master (despite his friendship with Basil), Amphilochius of Iconium.

In the later theological epistles, Basil established the difference between *ousia* and ὑπόστασις, as in *Epist*. 125 (AD 373), to Eustathius of Sebaste, in *Epist*. 214,3-4 (to the *comes* Terentius) and in *Epist*. 236,6 (to Amphilochius of Iconium). This difference is also clear in the contemporary *De Spiritu sancto*, in which 1*Cor*. 8:6 is quoted (5,7) as testimony to the difference between hypostaseis; in 16,38 Basil speaks of the 'three main hypostaseis' (a debated

[33] This is important as regards the development of Basil's Trinitarian theology: Zachhuber, as has been said, believes that Basil was never Homoiusian, precisely because the Homeousians claimed the existence of three divine hypostases, of which the second and third were subordinate to the first.

[34] S.M. Hildebrand, *The Trinitarian Theology* (2009), 58-65.

[35] Chr. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 205-6.

[36] As also explained by J. Pepin, '῎Υπαρξις et Ὑπόστασις en Cappadoce' (1994), 73.

[37] This had in fact been Holl's thesis, *Amphilochius* (1904), 238-40. Τρόπος τῆς ὑπάρξεως is also in the pseudo-Basilian *Contra Eunomium* IV and in the *KMP* of Apollinaris; it is also used by Basil in *Epist*. 235,2, but not in a theological context.

[38] Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 225 notes that it is unclear whether 'the mode of being' refers to the hypostases or to the reciprocal relations of the hypostaseis (but the problem is the same).

expression, as we shall see); 'Hypostasis' again in 18,44-5; 18,47; 25,59, and again in homily 16 (*In illud: in principio erat Verbum* 4; PG 31, 480B: τοῦ Υἱοῦ τὴν ὑπόστασιν).

Gregory Nazianzen uses 'hypostasis' already in the second homily (2,38), and alongside it the more generic τρία, without the neuter implying a negation of the particular attribute of the Person: *Orat*. 6,22; 22,12; 23,11-2 (the Three – τὰ τρία – are united by the identity of movement and nature: τῷ ταὐτῷ τῆς κινήσεως καὶ τῆς φύσεως); also 34,9; 34,12; 39,11; 40,41 and 42,16. In a real *tour de force* against Homoians, Heterousians and Sabellians Nazianzen juxtaposes τὰ τρία with ἕν (*Orat*. 20,5-6); then (20,7) he conceives 'one God in accordance with the unity and identity of the divine nature (θεότης), of the movement (κίνημα), of the will (βούλημα) and of the identity (ταυτότης) of the substance (οὐσία), and, on the other hand, the three ὑποστάσεις'. Time must not be inserted amongst the entities which are jointly eternal and conserted (συναΐδια καὶ συνημμένα). In the same homily (20,10) he employs several times 'divinity' (θεότης) or 'the unique God' (τὸν ἕνα θεὸν) with 'the three hypostaseis or, if your prefer, persons (τρεῖς ὑποστάσεις εἴτ'οὖν τρία πρόσωπα), each with its peculiarity (ἰδιότης)'.[39] The Three must not be reduced to a μία ὑπόστασις for fear of introducing a multiplicity of gods and τὰ πάντα ought not to be reduced to ἕν. Gregory speaks indifferently of Christ's generation or hypostasis (τοῦ Υἱοῦ εἴτε γέννησιν χρὴ λέγειν εἴτε ὑπόστασιν) and confesses his inability to be more precise.[40] In *Orat*. 39,12 basing himself on 1*Cor* 8:6: 'For us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things, and one Lord Jesus Christ, through whom are all things', to which he adds: 'and one Holy Spirit, in whom are all things', states that the formulas proposed by the apostle to indicate the three divine Persons' 'do not divide natures[41] … but characterize the peculiarities of a single and not confused nature (μιᾶς καὶ ἀσυγχύτου φύσεως)'.[42] Nevertheless, some of the terms Gregory apparently uses without distinguishing them from others (such as ταυτότης, ἴδιον, ἰδιότης) had been used by Basil. Basil also stated that the difference between the Son and the Father is due to ἰδιότης (*Contra Sabell. Ar. Anom.*; PG 31, 605B); had united ἰδιότης with ὑπόστασις (*De Spiritu sancto* 18,45: τὸ ἰδιάζον τῆς ὑποστάσεως) and had denied the heretical σύγχυσις τῆς ὑποστάσεως, which confused the ἰδιότητες (*In illud: in principio erat Verbum* 4; PG 31, 480BC), as the Nyssen will then frequently do (see *exempli gratia* (Bas.) *Epist*. 38,3 (τὸ ἰδίως λεγόμενον); *CE* I 278; *Refut*. 12).

[39] Also: 'a single nature and three ἰδιότητες' (*Orat*. 26,19).

[40] Other formulas of Trinitarian theology in *Orat*. 22,12; 33,16; 34,8.

[41] That is, hypostaseis.

[42] Nature, therefore, indicates first, in the plural, the hypostaseis, and then, in the singular, substance, but it is important that Gregory speaks of 'nature'.

However, this variety and freedom in the use of the terms does not mean indifference to the problem or inability to see meanings: when it is necessary Gregory is able to grasp the terminological differences, for instance those that separated Easterners from Westerners.[43] He asserts that Easterners were able to distinguish accurately between *ousia* and hypostasis (*Orat.* 21,35, in praise of Athanasius), which the Westerners were not:[44]

> We use in an orthodox sense the terms one Essence and three Hypostases, the one to denote the nature of the Godhead, the other the properties of the Three; the Italics mean the same, but, owing to the scantiness of their vocabulary, and its poverty of terms, they are unable to distinguish between Essence and Hypostases, and therefore introduce the term Persons, to avoid being understood to assert three Essences (trans. Browne – Swallow, modified).

As far as Nyssen is concerned, Barnes carried out his investigation into the significance of 'hypostasis' while attempting to achieve a theoretical definition; but he effectively confirmed, with regard to Gregory of Nyssa, what had been observed in Basil. Gregory uses 'hypostasis' to indicate an existing being that possesses a real and separate existence, and this when it is placed in relation to the language of *ousia* or *physis*. The formula 'one *ousia* or *physis* / three *hypostaseis*' points to the joining together of the terms which are to be used, as if one were saying: "when *ousia* and hypostasis are used together to describe the Trinity, we must say: one *ousia*, three hypostaseis". Gregory of Nyssa derives from 'hypostasis' a significant consequence: while Athanasius and his contemporaries use divine 'generation' in order to show that the Father and Son have the same nature, Gregory uses 'generation', and not 'hypostasis' as the basis for distinguishing the three Persons. As he says in *Ad Ablabium* (GNO III/I, 56,3-10): 'the difference between cause and caused is the only means that allows us to understand that one Person is distinct from the Other'. While previously in Nicene theology the reality of the titles 'Father' and 'Son' guaranteed the natural relation (that is, the continuity of nature or essence) between these two, now generation guarantees that there is a difference of the type of existence between the two. This difference is expressed in terms of causality; its nature

[43] As is well known, Gregory frequently uses the topos of the 'via media', which means the Nicene doctrine, as opposed to that of Arius and Sabellius. This topos has been interpreted by de Halleux as something more than a mere cliche, because it would indicate the equidistant position that Gregory would like to assume, to ensure peace between the currents within Neonicenism, between followers of Paulinus and followers of Meletius, in this opposing the attitude of Basil, who had taken a clear position in favour of Meletius, A. de Halleux, '«Hypostase» et «Personne»' (1990), 118-30, 186-94. But Gregory used that topos from his first homilies, when the question of Antioch had not yet arisen.

[44] This difficulty of Westerners in using exact terms in theological discussions was also drawn attention to by Basil (*Epist.* 214,4). And Gregory's negative judgment in that same oration (*Orat.* 21,22) of the formula of the 'like according to the Scriptures', which had been promulgated by the Homoians in the years 350-360, is interesting.

is manifested by 'hypostasis': what is definite is that 'hypostasis' loses some of its specificity.[45]

As a conclusion, we ought not to try to understand Gregory of Nyssa by referring, in the first place, to the development of certain terminological formulations such as 'one *ousia*, three *hypostaseis*'. Ayres underlines the variety of terminology in Gregory of Nyssa for describing the relations between divine unity and the Persons: *ousia, physis, hypostasis, prosopon* are all used interchangeably when the need arises.[46]

Finally, for the use without hesitation of both οὐσία and *prosopon*, Apollinaris seems to be the Eastern theologian closest to the Westerners, as is confirmed by his (supposed) influence on Jerome (p. 323-4).[47]

Prosopon

Prosopon is rather infrequently used by the Cappadocians and without substantial differences in meaning from the term hypostasis. Basil avoids *prosopon* in the Trinitarian theology, because he considers it akin to the Sabellian heresy (*Epist.* 52; 214,3; 236,6), and prefers hypostasis. Later and in isolation, however, in the homily *Contra Sabellianos et Arium et Anomaeos* (ch. 1; PG 31, 601BC) he specifies, against the Sabellians, that Christ's words 'If ye had known me, ye should have known my Father also: and from henceforth ye know him, and have seen him' (*John* 14:7) and 'he that hath seen me hath seen the Father' (*John* 14:9) 'do not indicate the confusion of Persons (σύγχυσιν τῶν προσώπων), but the non-difference of the divine nature (τὸ ἀπαράλλακτον τῆς θεότητος)', i.e. the consubstantial. In the contemporary *De Spiritu sancto* Basil uses *prosopon* condemning 'those who are led astray towards Judaism through the confusion of the persons (διὰ τῆς συγχύσεως τῶν προσώπων), and those who are misled towards Hellenism by means of the opposition of natures (διὰ τῆς τῶν φύσεων ἐναντιότητος)' (30,77).[48] *Prosopon* is therefore used non-exclusively, since it alternates with *physis*.

[45] According to M.R. Barnes, 'Divine Unity' (2003), 52, hypostasis, therefore, is not 'a subject of cognition or volition': this is correct, but this terminology concerns the history of the concept of 'person', and is still foreign to the Cappadocians.

[46] L. Ayres, 'On not three people' (2003), 36; see above, n. 13.

[47] The *KMP* should be dated around the years 355-361, when Athanasius also wanted to defend the consubstantial from the accusation that it was foreign to the scriptures, K. McCarthy Spoerl, 'Apollinarius on the Holy Spirit' (2001), 578-83. Zachhuber re-examines Apollinaris' concept of *homousios* according to the same criteria (derived from Porphyry's logic) and broadens the research also considering theology and Christology, J. Zachhuber, 'Derivative genera in Apollinarius of Laodicea' (2015), 95-8 ('Divine Ousia as a Derivative Genus') and 99-103 ('Theological and Philosophical Background').

[48] See also 18,45 and 20,52. Basil uses 'prosopographic' exegesis in non-theological texts: thus in *Hex. Hom.* 1,6, where he explains the words of the Father to the Son (*Gen.* 1:26), and *Hex. Hom.* 1,14: 'Do you not perceive the duplicity of people in these words?'.

For Nazianzen there is a substantial equivalence between ἰδιότης, hypostasis and *prosopon* (*Orat*. 20,6 and 32,16); hypostasis and prosopon can be used interchangeably, as long as they express the same concept (*Orat*. 39,11; 29,2; 20,10). They indicate the division not according to the natures, but according to the ἰδιότητες (*Orat*. 42,16, where Gregory takes up the Basilian fear that the term ἰδιότης leads to Sabellianism). Explaining the nature of the Son Gregory states that 'hypostasis' and 'person' indicate only the distinctive characters (ἰδιότητες) of the Three (*Orat*. 30,18).

Gregory of Nyssa also uses hypostasis and prosopon interchangeably (*Comm. Notit*.; GNO III/I, 19,1-5; 26,18 and 33,3). If he is the author of Basil's epistle 38, he uses πρόσωπον with reference to *Heb*. 1:3 and *Col*. 1:15: the Son is the form (μορφή) and the πρόσωπον thanks to which the Father is known, and the hypostasis of the Father is known in the form of the Son, because their peculiarity remains clear and serves to distinguish the two hypostaseis (ch. 8, I, 92,20 and 27 Courtonne). Πρόσωπον, here, has the ancient meaning of 'face', because it is equivalent to μορφή.[49] It is possible that the rarity of the use of πρόσωπον was also due to the fact that the concept of 'person' in Trinitarian theology had not yet been well defined and not well distinguished from 'nature', as can be seen much more clearly in Christology.[50]

3. *Some Professions of Faith*

For professions of faith one can consider some of Basil's most important letters, such as n. 125 and those of his last years: they probably influenced the theology of the Nazianzen and the Nyssen, because they constantly and coherently enunciate the relationship between ousia and hypostasis, which Basil then begins to use regularly.

Professions of faith are more frequent in the Nazianzen than in Basil and in the Nyssen, probably because they were suitable for acting in an assembly of the faithful, than in a letter, like those of Basil, or in a treatise, like those of the Nyssen. Gregory presents his first profession of faith in the second homily. This profession is all the more interesting since the homily dates back to 362[51]

[49] Πρόσωπον, like ὁμοούσιος, instead is commonly used by Apollinaris (see *KMP* 14-5), indeed, hypostasis is almost always avoided, because it has a weaker meaning ('subsistence', *KMP* 15). K. McCarthy Spoerl, 'Apollinarius on the Holy Spirit' (2001), 577-8, believes that Apollinaris uses both terms, giving preference to *prosopon*, but not excluding hypostasis, as was the case in a context of discussions open to the use of the two terms, in a period close to the Council of Alexandria in 362. Apollinaris' position was close to that of Athanasius.

[50] Lucian Turcescu, *Gregory of Nyssa and the Concept of divine Persons* (2005), 116-7 believes that the person, according to Gregory of Nyssa, is made up of their various peculiarities and their relations, but essentially maintains the meaning of the ἰδιότητες of individuals.

[51] Unless it was reworked later, as mentioned above, p. 67 n. 15 etc.

and therefore it also predates the *Contra Eunomium* of Basil, who, in that year, asked Apollinaris of Laodicea for explanations regarding the term 'consubstantial'. Gregory states that the theological language 'must not be reduced to only one hypostasis for fear of [giving rise to a] multiplicity of gods.[52] In such a case pure and simple names are maintained, so that it may be understood that Father, Son and Holy Spirit are one and the same' (2,36): this is said against the Sabellians, so subsequently Gregory proposes the intermediate position between the opposite heresies of Sabellius and Arius and goes on to discuss the issue of Tritheism, of which we will speak.[53] He therefore speaks for the first time of 'one God and three hypostaseis' (*Orat*. 2,38), while using the terms ἀγέννητος (2,37) and γεννήτωρ (2,38) to indicate the Father, which Basil does not approve of in the *Contra Eunomium*.[54]

Two years later, in 364, the Nazianzen, concluding the polemic with the monks of Nazianzus, who had rebelled against Gregory the Elder accusing him of Homoianism, enunciated a second confession of faith: 'For they (the divine Persons) are a single entity not in individual reality but in divinity (ἓν γὰρ οὐχ ὑποστάσει ἀλλὰ θεότητι)' (*Orat*. 6,22). Gregory therefore used the term 'hypostasis' from then on and distinguishes it from substance.[55] Then he makes

[52] Here ὑπόστασις has the same meaning as *ousia*: 'only one divine hypostasis', according to the tradition that dated back to Nicaea.

[53] Francis Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 296-302 underlines the importance of this 'creed', which dates back to the early years of Gregory's activity. Gregory is forced to specify the terms because of the revolt of the monks of Nazianzus against Gregory the Elder and Dianius of Caesarea, and therefore to oppose his creed to that proclaimed by the monks themselves. In this regard, the traditional thesis was that both the monks and Gregory contested the Homoian creed of Constantinople of 361, H.Chr. Brennecke, *Studien zur Geschichte der Homöer* (1988), 19-20; 59-60, while some thought of that of the Council of Antioch in 363, J. Bernardi, *Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (1995), 134-5. The 'creed' of the Nazianzen has a Neo-Nicene 'allure': one nature and three hypostases. The fact that Gregory does not use the term *ousia* could mean that he follows the deliberations of the Rimini and Nike councils, and he remains extraneous to a real Nicene creed: in fact he does not speak of *ousia*, but of *physis*. However, it seems to me that not all of Gautier's statements can be accepted. To speak of *physis* and not of *ousia* is, in Gregory, simply equivalent; the third theological disease, which Gregory opposes, that is, tritheism, was, according to Gautier, that of the monks rebelling against Gregory the Elder: Gregory sees in it a kind of deviation from the Eastern tradition, which he endorses, and therefore denounces those who, excessive in their orthodoxy, divide the Trinity into three principles extraneous to each other in the manner of the Greeks. In reality, Tritheism is linked to the Pneumatomachians, as we shall see.

[54] Again in 379 Gregory uses γέννημα in an isolated instance (*Orat*. 23,7).

[55] It is likely that Gregory was now influenced by Basil's *Contra Eunomium*, which was written in the same year, and not by the recent *Tomus ad Antiochenos* of 362, which he perhaps did not know. This formula however illustrates 'le genie du bien nommé Théologien' in his opposition to Sabellianism and his approach to Neonicenism and its *homousios*, which was then suspect to the Eastern Church, F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 300-2. Gautier (*ibid*. 420-1) rightly underlines Gregory's theological capacities, which had already emerged from the very beginning.

use of distinction and union: 'dividing them before combining them and not regarding the Three as a single individual (πρὶν συνάψαι διαιροῦντες καὶ πρὶν διελεῖν συνάπτοντες, οὔτε τὰ Τρία ὡς ἕνα). In fact the names do not lack subsistence (that is, they are not empty names), nor are they uttered with regard to one single hypostasis, so that the enrichment appears to affect only the names and not the things, but rather believing the Three to be a single entity (καὶ[56] τὰ Τρία ἕν)'.

Gregory expounds for the first time in Constantinople a true and complex profession of faith in oration 23, pronounced to quell unclear conflicts within the Nicene community. Gregory introduces it with a didactic tone and then expounds it in detail. First of all, the divine Trinity is simple and the Three are not separated from each other nor restricted to one, in the Sabellian manner (ch. 6). The Son and the Spirit are not without principle nor do they derive from another principle that is not the Father, but are γέννημα and πρόοδος, 'similar in nature and of equal glory' (ὅμοιοι τὴν φύσιν καὶ ὁμόδοξοι); the Father is their principle (ch. 7). In God the concept of 'principle' of the other two hypostaseis excludes any division, but establishes a relationship (σχέσις), which explains the expansion of the Monad in the Triad (ch. 8).[57] Speaking of the Son as γεννητός from the Father, who is ἀγέννητος,[58] does not introduce pathos into the begetting (ch. 9-10). Finally, Gregory summarizes (ch. 11) his doctrine: there is a relationship (σχέσις) (a fundamental term for the Nazianzen and the Nyssen) and an order (τάξις) within the Trinity; the Three are ἄναρχος, γέννησις and πρόοδος, corresponding to νοῦς, λόγος and πνεῦμα in man; a series of 'negative' definitions of God, which Gregory shows with the certainty of being a great orator, and therefore with the repetition of the same term in the singular and plural, to indicate the unique nature of God and the number of Persons (lives and life, lights and light, goodnesses and goodness, glories and glory etc.); the Three are God because of the identity of their movement and their nature (τῷ ταυτῷ τῆς κινήσεως καὶ τῆς φύσεως), and other definitions (ch. 11). In short, this 'formula of faith' is expounded, as Gregory polemically says (and with false modesty), 'to expound the doctrine and not to quarrel, in the manner of fishermen and not of Aristotle (ἁλιευτικῶς, ἀλλ' οὐκ ἀριστοτελικῶς), in a spiritual manner and not to do evil, in the manner of the Church and not of the public square, in a way that brings benefit and is not for show' (ch. 12).

Gregory's position at the end of the long homily on baptism (January 380) is analogous: having to explain to the catechumens the essential points of the Christian faith and already bishop of Constantinople, he assumes an authoritative

[56] I think that καί, which is in the text of SC 405, must be corrected to ἀλλά, as Martha Vinson does without any annotation in her translation.

[57] The meaning of σχέσις is introduced here for the first time; see also p. 252 (Gregory of Nyssa).

[58] Note that Gregory had no difficulty in using terms that Basil tended to exclude.

attitude (*Orat*. 40,41).[59] However, he cannot use strictly precise terms, because the situation does not allow him to: he is, in fact, speaking to non-expert people. For this reason, he repeats the expression he had already used many years before (*Orat*. 1,7): 'the only divinity and power that exists in the Three (τὴν μίαν θεότητά τε καὶ δύναμιν ἐν τοῖς τρισίν)' and clarifies the concept with his typical *tour de force* that combines opposite terms: εὑρισκομένην ἑνικῶς καὶ τὰ τρία συλλαμβάνουσαν μεριστῶς. Here again *ousia* is equivalent to φύσις (and not without reason): the union of the Three is called τριῶν ἀπείρων ἄπειρον συμφύϊαν; the Persons are τὰ τρία;[60] the fact that the Three are God indicates the consubstantial (ὁμοουσιότης), while the fact that the Three are thought together with each other (σὺν ἀλλήλοις) indicates the 'monarchy', so that the power of God is unique. The rest of the explanation dwells on the relationship between the one and the three. At first Gregory enunciates a real 'symbol' of faith (ch. 43). The Father is the first and is the origin of the being of the other Persons, who are equal to him; the Father is the principle and is 'greater' (*John* 14:17) in the sense that the three are ὁμοούσιοι. Gregory realizes, therefore, that, if we talk about three consubstantials, those he is addressing might fear that he will fall into Tritheism, but does not consider it appropriate, at that moment, to explain the matter. For this reason he says simply and with authority that 'this is the time to explain, not to discuss' (ch. 44), while in homilies 29 and 31 Gregory is addressing an audience of already baptized Christians, and can discuss the problem of Tritheism broadly and in detail.

Oration 42, written at the time of his abandonment of the Council of Constantinople (May 381), but probably reworked later, shows greater precision in Gregory's official declarations about Trinitarian orthodoxy. Gregory begins (ch. 16) reiterating the 'middle way' topos, which avoids the opposing excesses of Arianism and Sabellianism, put in parallel with the polytheism of the pagans and the erroneous monotheism of the Jews.[61] He therefore says that the Father the Son and the Spirit are ὁμοούσιά τε καὶ ὁμόδοξα (that the Spirit was ὁμοούσιον had been stated by him in oration 31, and that it was ὁμόδοξον

[59] Gregory declares that he has learned the true doctrine from a sage (*Orat*. 40,42), who was probably the Thaumaturge, cf. Cl. Moreschini's footnote in Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 38-41 (1990), 296; also E. Giannarelli, 'Donne, bambini, vescovi e santi' (2007), 181. According to L. Abramowski, 'Das Bekenntniss' (1976), 150-1, J. Rist, 'Basil's Neoplatonism' (1981), 208-10 and P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Éloge de Grégoire le Thaumaturge* (2014), 139-40, on the other hand, this 'sage' was the Nyssen: but in 380 the Nyssen could not yet have been considered a 'sage' – not even by Gregory Nazianzen, who was his friend (and quite a detached one, as McNeil observes).

[60] Of course, not in the abstract sense, as mentioned above, but we will speak more broadly about this further on. Perhaps τὰ τρία is suggested by the plural *prosopa*.

[61] It is probable that such an 'equidistance', like that between Arians and Sabellians, might not be convincing either for the pagans or for Jews (Ch. Beeley, 'Divine Causality' [2007], 207 n. 48 and A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* [2018], 253), but it is clear that the 'equidistance' was simply a topos.

was a more traditional concept).[62] The orthodox formula that Gregory recognizes is that of the One as regards the substance and Three as regards the hypostaseis, or persons – a term that some prefer (τὸ μὲν ἓν τῇ οὐσίᾳ τὰ δὲ τρία ταῖς ὑποστάσεσι, εἴτ' οὖν προσώποις, ὅ τισι φίλον): both are acceptable, because the precision of the words is of little interest, and πρόσωπον is considered equivalent to hypostasis, and is no longer Sabellian. So Gregory warns those who accept the doctrine of the three hypostaseis, lest they introduce three substances (οὐσίαι): introducing three hypostaseis does not mean introducing three substances, but claiming that the substance of the Three is one and the same, that is, rejecting Triteism, a problem that Gregory was deeply concerned about until the end of his activity as a homilist. He therefore addresses those who speak of πρόσωπα: perhaps they imagine a single reality, as if God were composed and endowed with three *prosopa* or human forms (ἓν οἷόν τι σύνθετον καὶ τριπρόσωπον ἢ ἀνθρωπόμορφον)? The anti-Sabellian polemic is evident, because πρόσωπον does not mean, here, 'person', but 'face': Basil too had contested the Sabellians, who believed that the divine persons constituted 'a single thing with many faces' (ἓν πρᾶγμα πολυπρόσωπον) (*Epist*. 210,3). Therefore πρόσωπον and hypostasis mean that there are three divine realities, distinguished not by nature, but by peculiarities. In this way those who agree in thought also agree in words, and the difference is only in syllables.[63]

The similarity between the homily and the composition in verse is evident in the profession of faith contained in the final doxology of the poem II 1,1, 624-30 (περὶ τῶν καθ'ἑαυτῶν), which was almost certainly written in Nazianzus. There Gregory asserts that the Father, besides having other traditional attributes is ἀγένητος ἄναρχός τε καὶ πατὴρ ἀρχῆς, that is of the Son, who is the principle of all things because he created them. The Son has the usual names, too, but he is also 'light from a similar light' (the term 'similar' must be understood in the Athanasian way), and 'goes' from one to one (ἐξ ἑνὸς εἰς ἕν) for indemonstrable reasons (i.e. he is united to the Father, not in the Sabellian manner), εἰκὼν ἀρχετύποιο, φύσις γεννήτορος ἴσῃ (a way of explaining homoousion), while the Spirit πάτροθεν εἶσι (it 'proceeds' from the Father).

The *Epistula fidei* of Evagrius can also be considered a profession of faith.[64] Evagrius depends on Gregory Nazianzen: indeed, he alludes to him at the

[62] See below, p. 269-70. The concept is traditional for the Nazianzen (above all) and for the Nyssen (ὁμοτιμία).

[63] Also in *Orat*. 39,11: 'For we will not become involved in a battle over names, as long as the syllables point towards the same notion' (trans. B. Daley).

[64] The *Epistula fidei* is numbered as Basil's n. 8 and the attribution to Evagrius has been maintained by Bousset, Frankenberg and Guillaumont.

beginning, asserting that he could only free himself of the error by taking refuge in his teaching. Gregory was 'the instrument of choice' of God and 'the mouth of Christ' ([Bas.], *Epist.* 8,1, I, 23,17-9 Courtonne),[65] so that Evagrius takes up the exegesis of some scriptural passages in the anti-Arian polemic, which Gregory had presented in homily 30: they are those on the divinity of the Son (ch. 4-9) and on the divinity of the Spirit (ch. 10-1); in the first part of the letter (ch. 2-3) he rejects Heteroousianism (or, in general, Arianism) and Tritheism, and consequently proclaims the homousion. He condemns the doctrine of the 'not begotten' and 'begotten', of the Father who is always and of the Son who is not always, of the Father, who is always Father, who however becomes Father (following the birth of the Son), and of the Holy Spirit which is not eternal (2, 23,7-10). He rejects both ὅμοιον and ἀνόμοιον, because these concepts concern qualities, and God does not have qualities (ch. 3, 25,1-4).[66] To them Evagrius opposes the ταυτότης τῆς φύσεως (like Gregory Nazianzen) and the ὁμοούσιον, which do not allow the 'compound' (τὸ σύνθετον) (3, 25,4-13): that the Trinity is not a reality 'composed' of three hypostaseis is also said by Apollinaris (*KMP* 18) and by Gregory (*Orat.* 2,37 and 23,10). The term 'consubstantial' is more exact than 'unique' (μόνος) and 'one' (εἷς), because 'unique' indicates the ousia of God, not the Trinity (3, 25,13-27,61), and 'one' can also be said with other meanings, for example, to indicate a material unity in opposition to the many, or 'one God' in opposition to the many gods, which therefore are not gods.

But already in this epistle, as Paul Géhin has observed, Evagrius presents doctrines which he will then develop in the writings composed in the desert, such as the fact that the last hour of the judgment, which only the Father, and not even the Son, knows, indicates the 'exact understanding of God's thoughts and the contemplation of the henad and monad (τὴν ἑνάδος καὶ μονάδος θεωρίαν)', which can only occur in eschatological reality (ch. 7, 30,6-8). Again in ch. 7,30-7 Evagrius says that 'for only then is our mind arisen, and awakened

[65] These expressions of enthusiasm will be repeated years later by Evagrius in the desert writings: 'our wise master' (*Prakt.* 89); 'the just Gregory' (*Gnost.* 44 and *Prakt.* 100), 'admirable man' (*Epist.* 46), as Paul Géhin observes, 'La place de la *Lettre sur la foi*' (2000), 39. I take this opportunity to propose in 8,1, 23,19 Courtonne the expunction of παρακαλῶ, a late and medieval term and a duplicate of the stylistically better αἰτούμεθα.

[66] Géhin (*ibid.* 31) notes that this statement derives from Aristot., *Categ.* 11a15. Even Marius Victorinus, to refute the Homoiusians, had stated that the 'like' cannot concern the substance (of God), but the quality. Géhin also observes (*ibid.* 32) that another assertion by Evagrius of similar philosophical content is in ch. 4,4-7: 'comparisons must be made between things of the same nature. We say that an angel is bigger than an angel, a man than a man…': this derives from Aristot., *EN* 1165a30-34. Evagrius is also familiar with the two etymologies of θεός (from τεθεικέναι τὰ πάντα and from θεᾶσθαι) (11,31-4): the second etymology is also known to Gregory of Nyssa (*Ablab.* GNO III/I, 44,9-45,4; *Eustath.* 14,6-12).

to sublime felicity, when it shall contemplate the "Oneness" and the "Aloneness" of the Logos':[67]

In fact, God knows what it is, and does not know what it is not, and if our Lord, according to the design of the incarnation and empirical knowledge is not the ultimate end desired; then our Saviour does not know the end, that is, the ultimate felicity. But not even the angels, He says, know; that is, not even the contemplation which is in them nor the principles of their ministries are the ultimate end desired. For even their knowledge, in comparison with the knowledge which is face to face, is dim and obscure.

The importance of the gnosis that man is capable of will be reiterated in the desert writings: rational nature is an 'essence that knows' (*KG* I 3). Higher knowledge, that which the ascetic achieves, is an 'essential knowledge' (γνῶσις οὐσιώδης).[68] Consequently Evagrius urges the friends in Constantinople, to whom he sends his letter, to devote themselves to intellectual activity:[69]

Let no one interrupt me and say: 'In your ignorance of things that are before your feet, you philosophize to us about bodiless and altogether immaterial substance.' For I consider it absurd that we should permit our senses to sate themselves without hindrance with their own material food, but that we should exclude the mind alone from its own particular activity. For just as the senses lay hold of things sensible, so the mind lays hold of things mentally perceptible.

'The first of all sciences is the science of the monad and the enad,' Evagrius said later (*KG* II 3). Intellectual knowledge is that of the Gnostic, but the Gnostic comes to it through purification (and this is said by the Nazianzen, p. 203-4).

After the *epistula fidei*, written still during the Constantinople period,[70] the Trinitarian theology of Evagrius Ponticus does not show particularly interesting

[67] Trans. R. De Ferrari, for the whole of this letter. The expression is unusual, because the two terms seem equivalent. For this reason Bunge (1989) proposed distinguishing the two meanings, arguing that the henad points to the absolute uniqueness of the divine essence, while the monad implies the trinity of the Persons. Bunge's explanation was rejected by A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 340-1 and by P. Gehin, 'La place de la *Lettre sur la foi*' (2000), 35 n. 37 and 41 n. 70, who maintains that Evagrius uses the term μονάς to refer to the fall of rational beings (ἐκπεσὼν τῆς μονάδος) and Origen uses, for that same concept, ἑνάς (*Princ.* II 1,1, 25-6: *qui ab illa initii unitate … deciderunt*; *Philoc.* 8,3,8: τῆς ἑνότητος ἐκπεσών): consequently Origen seems to prefer ἑνάς and Evagrius μονάς, but the two terms are equivalent. But it is not clear why Evagrius uses them both in the same context without a logic, so Casiday is right to follow Bunge's explanation, A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 214-5, that μονάς indicates union of the Trinity within itself and ἑνάς indicates the union of God with the world that he himself created.

[68] The term, foreign to Basil and used only once by Gregory, is typical of Evagrius, who uses it in the desert writings (P. Géhin, 'La place de la *Lettre sur la foi*' [2000], 51).

[69] *Ibid.* 49-50.

[70] This is, at least, the *communis opinio*. However recently Joel Kalvesmaki in a very intelligent article, 'The Epistula fidei of Evagrius of Pontus' (2012) tried to show that this letter was an

developments (a sign that the problem was not very congenial to him or dates back to a period of his life that Evagrius had now abandoned), and accepts without any difficulty the formula 'one substance – three hypostaseis'.[71] The discussion and the confirmation of the Nicene doctrine by Evagrius are transformed into a hagiographic tale by Palladius, who knew him well and gave us reliable information concerning him (*Hist. Laus.* 38,11, *recensio longior*).[72] In accordance with the environment in which he lived, and with his doctrine of demons that induce to evil, heresies are introduced by demons in clerical robes,[73] who tempt Evagrius in a dream. The first demon declares that he is a follower of Eunomius and asks whether the Father is unbegotten or begotten, to which Evagrius replies that the question is badly posed and that 'of the One who by nature is unbegotten no one says: begotten or unbegotten'. Another demon declares that he is Arian and asks him to explain the doctrine of the Holy Spirit. Evagrius' answer is in conformity with Basil's teaching in the *De Spiritu sancto*:

> The Holy Spirit is neither offspring nor creature. Each creature, in fact, is limited to a place and is subject to change and is sanctified by participation. The Holy Spirit, on the other hand, 'proceeds' from the Father (*John* 15:26) and 'fills all things' (*Wis.* 1:7) – I say: those in heaven and those on earth – without itself being sanctified by anyone. Therefore, what is not circumscribed and is immutable and essentially holy can neither be nor be said to be a creature.

This demon also questions Evagrius about the body of Christ according to the Arian doctrine. After him a third demon appears, a follower of Apollinaris. We will therefore examine the questions of the demon and the answers of Evagrius considering the Christology of Evagrius (p. 319-20).

Amphilochius of Iconium expounds his Trinitarian conception in the following way:

> There exist the Monad (μονάς)[74] and the eternal Trinity, the Father with the Son and the most holy Spirit, a Trinity very distinct in the Persons, Monad in the divine nature.

answer by Evagrius to the community of Constantinople when Evagrius was still in search of his true way of life, that is, in the period around 382, which is the most interesting, because it precedes his move to the desert. Evagrius responded to the community of Constantinople at a time when Gregory had already abandoned it, and tried to take the place of the new bishop, Nectarius, as a guide to the Nicenes, with the council of 383 imminent and the Nicene community no longer having an eminent personality representing it.

[71] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 337-42; A. Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology* (2013), 207-10.

[72] See Dom Cuthbert Butler, *The Lausiac History* (1898), I, 132-6.

[73] A polemical detail suggested by a desert monk? The cleric is also the subject of satire in medieval literature.

[74] That is, God as one ousia.

Do not confuse hypostaseis with the number, and do not divide nature when you honour God! Indeed the Trinity, in its nature, is absolutely not divided.[75] One is the Trinity, only one is the almighty God. This is the mystery of true faith, difficult to understand. Indeed, the road of truth is truly narrow, a steep path, little travelled: those who became lost far from this road shattered themselves in opposite directions, wandering in steep depths, like Sabellius, who turned his gaze to the Jews, and Arius, who imitated idolaters: the first confused the hypostaseis of the Persons, the other blasphemously divided the substance (τὴν οὐσίαν). But without losing yourself, keep the middle way, dividing (διαιρῶν) rightly and joining (συνάπτων) as it is lawful to do. In fact, the Trinity is joined without confusion (ἀσυγχύτως), just as the monad is separated without truncations. Divine Nature, in fact, is not truncated, while hypostaseis are always absolutely not confused (*Iamb. ad Seleuc.* 193-213).

These theological propositions derive from the teaching of Basil and Gregory Nazianzen: it is wrong to 'divide' and 'join' in the manner of Arius and Sabellius, because union must be implemented without confusion and distinction without separation: that is, 'a middle way' must be followed. 'Nature' and 'substance', 'hypostasis' and 'person' are used without particular precision, as Basil and Gregory do when they do not want to put forward a 'formula of faith'. Amphilochius also states that 'the three hypostaseis have one substance and nature' (*De Spiritu sancto*; SC 553, 299,9-10). Furthermore, as in the passage quoted above, he uses μονάς without the Sabellian meaning, but in accordance with the teaching of Gregory Nazianzen[76] and Gregory Nyssen (*Graec.* III/I 21,10; *Abl.* 41,2-4) and for the Three he uses both *prosopon* and hypostasis with the same meaning. Perhaps he also uses *homousios* in *De recta fide* (but the work is perhaps not authentic and is written only in Syriac, see CChrSG 3,314 etc.; 316). While the other Cappadocians believe that the terms 'separate' and 'divide' are incorrect, Amphilochius uses them.[77] It can be concluded that Amphilochius remained on the margins of the Trinitarian controversy and does not use a technical theological language, perhaps also because, of his writings, it is mainly the homilies that have come down to us and they did not lend themselves to a precise conceptual development, as seen in his homily 9.[78]

As a conclusion, these professions of faith mean that the Trinitarian doctrine of the Cappadocians was gradually being defined around the years 380-381.

[75] This verse is considered spurious by some. On the problem of the authenticity see A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 483.

[76] See above, p. 213.

[77] Cf. A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 484-90. Sometimes Gregory too employs these terms not with a heretical meaning.

[78] Cf. *ibid.* 187; 484-95.

A Crux in Basil's Trinitarian Theology

Reinhard Hübner's proposal, advanced in a study dating from a few decades past (and recently updated),[79] is well known, wherein he compares the meaning of *ousia* in *Against Eunomius* and in *Epistle* 38 by Basil, concluding (I summarize his conclusions) that this epistle, which in the manuscript tradition had also been attributed to Gregory of Nyssa (*Epist*. 4), was in fact by Gregory Nyssen because the concept of *ousia* advanced by Basil in *Against Eunomius* is explicable by bearing in mind Stoic conceptuality (*ousia* = *hypokeimon* = substance),[80] while in *Epistle* 38 it corresponds to that of Gregory Nyssen, for whom *ousia* is the being of Aristotle's *Categories*, as may also be seen in *De hominis opificio* 16 and *Ex communibus notitiis*.[81] In fact, in *Against Eunomius* Basil utilizes the Stoic concept of *ousia*, which is not to be taken as meaning 'undifferentiated substance' but rather as 'a substance characterized by its specific qualities' and overcomes the difficulties intrinsic to Homoiousian's theology, who interpreted *ousia* as an 'individual substance', as had Basil in his early years (*Epist*. 361, 3, 221,24-35 Courtonne; *Epist*. 9,3; *Hom. in S. Mamantem*; PG 31, 597C).[82] In *Against Eunomius*, instead, *ousia* and hypostasis are to each other what κοινόν and ἴδιον are. In this work, Basil also utilizes the Stoic term 'substrate' (ὑποκείμενον) – but, naturally, without the materiality implicit in Stoic doctrine being applied to God:[83] Peter and Paul have a common substrate and their hypostasis points to their mutual relationship (Peter and Paul are men, but different from each other, just as the Father and the Son are different hypostaseis, but are both God).[84] In fact, according to the Stoics material realities are not pure and simple substrata, but rather are differentiated among themselves by means of the addition of qualities: 'Der Begriff (Mensch) erscheint als Resultat der Addition von Merkmalen, die durch fortgesetzte Teilung

[79] R. Hübner, 'Gregor von Nyssa als Verfasser' = *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 245-89.

[80] This is likewise stated by Bernard Sesboüé, Basile de Césarée, *Contre Eunome* (1982), 76-83 and David G. Robertson, 'Stoic and Aristotelian Notions' (1998). The presence of Stoic *ousia* in Basil is also mentioned by Lenka Karfíková, '*Ad Ablabium quod non sint tres dei*' (2011), 160, with bibliography.

[81] R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 263-9. Hübner also bases himself on other details in the epistle, such as the interpretation of Sabellianism, which is found in *Epist*. 38,7, and which is different from that in other texts by Basil, in order to maintain that the epistle itself cannot be by Basil – but these observations have not received due attention on the part of scholars, who have disputed Hübner's hypothesis, because the controversy has focused almost exclusively on the concept of *ousia*.

[82] R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 271.

[83] Hübner's thesis has been objected to on the grounds that the application of Stoic substance to divine substance and hypostaseis conflicts with the fact that in the case of *Contra Eunomium* we are not dealing with a material reality, V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung* (1996), 64-5. But this was already clear in Hübner's position.

[84] R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 263-74.

gewonnen wurden'.[85] Likewise, in *De Spiritu sancto*, *physis* (which has the same meaning as *ousia*), represents κοινόν juxtaposed with εἶς, that is, the individual: κατὰ μὲν τὴν ἰδιότητα τῶν προσώπων εἷς καὶ εἷς (the Father and the Son), κατὰ δὲ τὸ κοινὸν τῆς φύσεως, ἓν οἱ ἀμφότεροι (18,45).

Here then is the passage in *Against Eunomius*, in which the concept of ὑποκείμενον is found, along with the relationship κοινὸν - ἴδιον:

So whenever we hear "Peter", the name does not cause us to think of his substance – now by "substance" I mean the material substrate[86] which the name itself cannot ever signify – but rather the notion of the distinguing marks that are considered in connection with him is impressed upon our mind[87] (Ὅταν γοῦν ἀκούσωμεν Πέτρον, οὐ τὴν οὐσίαν αὐτοῦ νοοῦμεν ἐκ τοῦ ὀνόματος – οὐσίαν δὲ λέγω νῦν τὸ ὑλικὸν ὑποκείμενον, ὅπερ οὐδαμῶς σημαίνει τοὔνομα – ἀλλὰ τῶν ἰδιωμάτων ἃ περὶ αὐτὸν θεωρεῖται τὴν ἔννοιαν ἐντυπούμεθα) (*CE* II 4, 577C).[88]

This interpretation gave rise to doubts on the part of many scholars: first of all, those of Hauschild,[89] then Drecoll,[90] according to whom Basil does not wish to give a general definition of *ousia*, but *only in that context* is *ousia* equivalent to *hypokeimenon*:[91] Drecoll therefore substitutes the Stoic interpretation with

[85] *Ibid*. 265. Basil may have taken the Stoic concept of *ousia* from a Stoic manual of his time, which contained elements of Aristotelian logic (*ibid*. 272). Holl had already observed that Basil's interpretation was not entirely satisfactory because it does not permit us to distinguish the substance shared by the Persons from the substance in the individual hypostaseis, K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 132-4. But Hübner himself acknowledges this, even if not explicitly, when he denies that Basil's use of philosophical categories corresponds to the actual utilization of philosophy, R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 322; and again: 'Man könnte ihm wohl kein größeres Unrecht tun, als seine theologischen Formeln metaphysisch misszuverstehen' (*ibid*. 274). Basically, Basil may be utilizing philosophical categories only in order to respond to Eunomius, but he is not likely to think that they are functional to theological explanation. However, would this not create a hiatus between the treatise *Against Eunomius* and the homilies and letters, in which Hübner sees opposition to the utilization of philosophy in the theological ambience, and thus Basil's *true* doctrine?

[86] 'Material substrate' therefore indicates the material body, as can be seen from the parallel passage by Basil, *Against Eunomius* I 15,548A.

[87] Trans. Andrew Radde-Gallwitz and Mark DelCogliano (2011).

[88] A little after the disputed statement in the passage by Basil, there is a further difficulty: the details that constitute the individual Peter do not represent his substance, taken as hypostasis (ὧν οὐδέν ἐστιν οὐσία, ἡ ὡς ὑπόστασις νοουμένη). Here it is important to note how substance and hypostasis appear to be equivalents of each other, which is rather inconsistent in Basil, so Böhm suggests correcting the text to: ἡ <οὐχ> ὡς ὑπόστασις νοουμένη or: ἡ ὡς ὑπο<κείμενον> νοουμένη, Th. Böhm, 'Basilius: *Adversus Eunomium* II 4' (1997) – and I prefer this second solution, in order to avoid the series of the hiatuses.

[89] See Basilius von Caesarea, *Briefe* (1993), I, 182-9.

[90] V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung* (1996), 297-331 (where the objections of other scholars to Hübner's explanation are indicated); the issue has been discussed anew by Drecoll in V.H. Drecoll and M. Berghaus, 'Introduction' (2008), XVI-XX (with bibliography) and by R. Hübner, who responds to the objections in *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 283-9.

[91] V.H. Drecoll and M. Berghaus, 'Introduction' (2008), XV.

an interpretation according to Aristotelian logic, as it had been elaborated by Porphyry (*Isag*. 2,20-2; 13, 14-21).[92] Radde-Gallwitz and DelCogliano maintained that when Basil uses the term 'material substrate' (ὑλικὸν ὑποκείμενον) (*CE* I 15 and II 4) it is not clear whether he wants his readers to believe that Stoic metaphysics is a suitable means for describing the relation between the Son and the Father.[93] The very use of the term ὑποκείμενον ('material substrate') as one of the meanings of 'substance' is not unknown in Aristotle (see *Metaph*. VIII 1, 1042a26-b8) and late-Antique Platonism. Maintaining that the use of this term means Stoicism is 'question-begging'.[94] On the other side, Hübner's interpretation was accepted by many scholars: Zachhuber, having considered the attribution of the epistle to Basil or Gregory as not crucial to his interpretation of *ousia*,[95] subsequently accepted the attribution to Gregory of Basil's *Epistle* 38,[96] and G. Maspero, M. Degli Espositi, D. Benedetto confirmed it by means of studies in Mathematical Linguistics.[97]

Nevertheless, the suggestion put forward by Drecoll of the presence of Porphyrys' logic in the schools in Athens, attended by Basil,[98] is hypothetical and, above all, in my opinion such a strong interest in Aristotelian logic on the part of Christian writers does not seem likely.[99] In addition, the structure of Stoic Physics must have appeared to Basil, due to its concreteness, to be the simplest for explaining the issue of the Trinity, which for him was collocated precisely in the controversy with Eunomius, against whom he was in fact writing his work. Therefore, I would conclude by saying that Hübner's interpretation of *ousia* is exact, but it does not correspond rigorously to Stoic logic: despite accepting Hübner's interpretation, Robertson observed that 'if this is Stoic conceptuality, then it is either confused or heavily adapted'.[100] Effectively, in *Contra Eunomium* Basil uses οὐσία not only with the Stoics' material meaning,

[92] V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung* (1996), 320-1 and 327-9.

[93] A. Radde-Gallwitz and M. DelCogliano, St. Basil of Caesarea, *Against Eunomius* (2011), 70-2.

[94] R. Hübner responds to this observation in *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 287 and, in my opinion, Basil's practice of Stoic logic is not attested to, as is stated by Robertson (see also Hübner, *ibid*. 286).

[95] J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 61.

[96] J. Zachhuber, 'Nochmals: Der „38. Brief" des Basilius von Caesarea' (2003).

[97] See G. Maspero, M. Degli Espositi and D. Benedetto, 'Who wrote Basil's *Epistula 38?*' (2014).

[98] V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung* (1996), 321n. Nevertheless, recently Mark Edwards, *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2018), 107-8, has also observed that Porphyry's *Eisagoghè* (and thus its use by Gregory of Nyssa) is a work dedicated not to the link between the hypostaseis (*atomon*), but to the language that identifies them.

[99] I think this without even speculating how the bad reputation Porphyry gained for having written against the Christians might be an obstacle to using his doctrines: In the West, Marius Victorinus and in the East, Cyril of Alexandria in *Contra Iulianum* accepted doctrines by Porphyry.

[100] D.G. Robertson, 'Stoic and Aristotelian Notions' (1998), 415.

but also with an Aristotelian meaning. Indeed, Basil speaks of an οὐσία τῆς ἀνθρωπότητος (*CE* I 18,552D), where ἀνθρωπότης is a concept and not a concrete reality, and states that God's οὐσία is the αὐτὸ τὸ εἶναι τοῦ θεοῦ (I 10,536C) (here too οὐσία is abstract: it means God's being, or existing, not his substance); furthermore, he maintains that it is wrong to interpret Scripture literally, because in this way one risks understanding God's substance as material (ὑλικήν τινα ἐννοεῖν τὴν οὐσίαν τοῦ θεοῦ) (I 14,541C). Furthermore, Basil cannot have used οὐσία in the Stoic manner, but rather with implicit modifications: the substance of God is the first substance (I 13,18), yet exceedingly above all other substances.[101] In any case, a rigorous philosophical formulation should not be expected of Basil, so the choice of the term *may* not have been made rigorously: it has already been seen, and confirmed previously, that Trinitarian terminology by the Cappadocians is not consistent.[102]

There is a further problem: the passage in *CE* II 4 had been disputed by Eunomius, who had accused Basil of formulating a materialistic interpretation of the substance of the Trinity, and for this reason it is defended by Gregory of Nyssa (*CE* III 5,21-22):

> Yet what sane man would add this to the argument, that where the names are different, the beings in question must also be diverse? Peter, Paul and men in general have different names, but the essential being of them all is one. Therefore, among the very great number we are all the same as each other, and we distinguish one from the other only by the observed characteristics of each individual. Hence the names too are not indicative of the beings, but of the particularities which characterize each one. So when we hear "Peter", our thought does not go from the name to the essential being (οὐσία) – by "essential being" *I am not here referring* to the physical substance (ὑλικὸν ὑποκείμενον) – but we receive the impression in our mind of the peculiar properties attributed to him.[103]

[101] B. Sesboüe, *St. Basile et la Trinité* (1999), 100-1 and 96-111. Italics mine.

[102] Hübner himself admits that Basil does not use *ousia* systematically (*Kirche und Dogma* [2017], 272 n. 102), while Markschies also states that 'the example (of Basil) does not imply that *ousia* means *constantly* (our italics) ὑλικὸν ὑποκείμενον', Chr. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (1994), 201; see also 205n. Hildebrand also observes that 'This definition of human *ousia logically may not be applied* (our italics) to divine *ousia*, with the result that Basil naturally denies that God is in any way material. But just as Stoic philosophy influenced his definition of human *ousia*, so too did it influence his description of divine *ousia*', S.M. Hildebrand, *The Trinitarian Theology* (2009), 47. Battlo also attributes a different meaning to *ousia*, depending on whether it occurs in a philosophical of theological context, X. Battlo, *Ontologie scalaire et polémique trinitaire* (2013), 90-100. He adds, 'We know that God exists and is the "primary substance", but we do not know what his substance is (which is the "secondary substance"): in a non-theological context *ousia* does not designate the subject or the primary substance' (*ibid.* 206-7). In this way, however, the meaning of *ousia* has nothing to do with the present issue.

[103] Trans. Stuart G. Hall, in J. Leemans & M. Cassin (eds), *Gregory of Nyssa* Contra Eunomium III (2014).

The problem is that the text in the citation by Gregory says the opposite to what Basil says and, unfortunately, in the continuation of the dispute against Eunomius, Gregory does not explain how he interprets substance. He simply says that, if it is true, as Eunomius maintains, that it is stupid to state, when speaking of men (who all have the same substance), that one is a 'man' while another is a 'horse', it is equally stupid, when speaking of God the Father and God the Son (who also have the same substance),[104] to say that one God is uncreated and the other God is created (III 5,26-27).

To solve the difficulty, Balàs asserts that the change had not been made by Eunomius, despite the fact that Gregory of Nyssa is quoting from his *Apology of the Apology*, but by Nyssen himself: Eunomius, in fact, had attacked Basil's text by emphasizing the materialism of *ousia* as meant by Basil, which could not be acceptable for the divine substance, so that Gregory of Nyssa, in order to answer Eunomius' obiection, added the negation.[105] Hübner finds confirmation of this: Gregory (above all, *tacite*) may have rejected Basil's interpretation by inserting on his own initiative the negation, precisely because he interpreted οὐσία in accordance with Aristotelian *Categories* and not according to Stoic conceptuality.[106] Instead, Zachhuber does not accept Balàs' explanation and does not think that either Eunomius or Gregory Nyssen knowingly modified Basil's text, for several reasons: Eunomius so as to demonstrate the materialism of Basil's concept, and Gregory because he had found it to be flawed by a 'scribal error', and corrected this *tacite*.[107] Indeed, in Basil's *CE* II 4 οὐσία does not carry the true Aristotelian meaning, as Hübner suggested, but rather (and a comparison with the doctrine of *Epistle* 38 confirms this) it may mean 'an entity immanent in the individuals and responsible both for their unity and for their specific identity' – that is, according to Zachhuber's interpretation of the 'divine substance', οὐσία means Porphyry's 'universal', namely, human οὐσία and divine οὐσία.[108] Consequently, Gregory may have thought that Basil meant οὐσία exactly as he did and, convinced that the negation had been omitted by a copyist, he himself added it without saying anything. The origin of this concept is probably Aristotle's Peripatetic interpretation, which Basil would

[104] Thus, Gregory Nyssen would appear to explain the difficulty by using 'substance' with the meaning that had been conceived of by Basil.

[105] D. Balàs, 'The Unity of Human Nature' (1976). Hübner's work was published before that of Balàs, but, as Hübner correctly notes, R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 261 n. 59, Balàs had already presented his own, in the Sixth International Conference on Patristic Studies (Oxford, 6th-11th September 1971).

[106] R. Hübner, *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 260-1.

[107] J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 102. It is not absurd to use the opposite reasoning and remove the negation from Gregory Nyssen's citation, which was not in Basil's original text.

[108] *Ibid*. 104.

have come across reading Porphyry's and Themistius' comments.[109] In this instance I would again make the same objections as I do in Drecoll's case: maintaining that Basil addressed the philosophy of his time, and more specifically Aristotelian logic, interpreted by 4th-century commentators, in order to explain the meaning of *ousia*, cannot be demonstrated and is thus difficult to accept for these very reasons. Zachhuber's interpretation seems like an archetype of the philosophical interpretation of Trinitarian theology, which had a following in the years to come.

I maintain, therefore, that it is very unlikely that Gregory wished to correct a copyist's error; rather, as Hübner explains, he may have felt it was necessary to correct Basil's passage, so it would be clearer that, in his opinion, divine *ousia* is not Stoic *ousia* but the Aristotelian one. Maspero also maintains (even though he does not dwell on an explanation of something that seems obvious to him) that 'Gregory distinguishes human nature from divine nature, and attributes consubstantiality to both, with the difference that he attributes corruptibility only to the former: its corruptibility is due to the fact that it is material. But … this defense would have been justified only if Basil had *always* conceived of the substance as a material substratum and Gregory, instead, conceives of nature as being immaterial and identified with the essence'.[110] Subsequently, Nyssen abandoned the issue of divine *ousia* because, like Gregory Nazianzen, he did not consider it useful for resolving the problem of tritheism which, in the immediate aftermath of Basil's death, had become important, and did not regard only the relationship between Father and Son, but also those among Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

Regarding *Epistle* 38, it thus logically seems to be by Gregory of Nyssa. But the epistle is not important only on account of the definition of *ousia*: in fact, it contains some terms, such as ὑπόστασις and πρόσωπον (*Epist*. 38,1, p. 81,2; 3, p. 83,31; 4, p. 85,36 and 44; 6, p. 90,13; 7, p. 90,7; 91,35 and 38; 8, p. 92,14

[109] *Ibid*. 76-93. Zachhuber's thesis is that οὐσία, taken as physis, is one of Porphyrys' universals, and an antecedent of scholastic logic: thus, according to Boethius, Plato possesses personal qualities that may be summarized in the term *Platonitas*, and universal ones that are contained in the term 'man', a category to which Plato also belongs. This problem was tackled subsequently by Robertson who, despite taking Hübner's observations into account, went in the opposite direction, whereby Basil does not suggest 'a consistent conceptuality derived from Stoic logic', but rather follows Porphyry's thought, which unites Stoic logic and Peripatetic logic: God's *ousia* has its roots in hypostaseis, almost like a collection of divine particulars (ἰδιοτήτων ἄθροισμα), D. Robertson, 'Stoic and Aristotelian Notions' (1998), 416-7. The influence of Stoicism on Basil has also been studied by Robertson in 'Relatives in Basil of Caesarea' (2001). Subsequently as well Zachhuber interprets οὐσία as 'unknowable substance to which qualities are added', which however he again links with Porphyry's logic, 'Stoic Substance, Non-existent Matter?' (2006). The interpretation that human nature – and therefore also divine nature – must be considered one of the universals is underlined again by Zachhuber in 'Universals in the Greek Church Fathers' (2013).

[110] G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 14-7.

and 26 Courtonne), which, over time, had become technical and which Basil had utilized rarely and only in the last period of his life.[111] It also contains some doctrines that are still *in nuce* in Basil, but far more developed in Nazianzen and Nyssen. These are pneumatology (38,4), which is similar to Gregory Nyssen's.[112] The term ἐκπορεύεται (*John* 15:26) is used there twice (85,26 and 30 Courtonne) to manifest the ontological reality of the Holy Spirit, while it is used by Basil only in *Epistula* 125,3 and in *De Spiritu sancto* as a Scriptural citation (9,22 and 16,38), and it is crucial for Gregory Nazianzen to expound the origin of the Holy Spirit from the Father.

Should one not agree that the author of this epistle is Gregory of Nyssa, despite the fact that Gregory is also indicated in some manuscripts, the radical conclusion put forward by Manlio Simonetti (without, however, sufficient explanations) ought to be taken into consideration: 'Epist. 38, with such a scholastic tone, typical of treatises, may not have been dictated by Basil, or his brother, but rather by an unknown person in their entourage, and from there it may have passed in an entirely natural manner under the authority of the leader, just like books *CE* IV and V, with the added *De spiritu*'.[113] In my opinion, it is very unlikely that another writer could have lived in Cappadocia capable of writing a text that tackles so thoroughly the difficult issues of Trinitarian theology.[114] In fact, the epistle seems to contain evident echoes of Gregory Nazianzen, so that it would be not unlikely to be by Gregory of Nyssa. One of these is the image of the various concentric circles in the rainbow (87,7-13 Courtonne) to illustrate the distinction and union of the divine persons, which is also used by Nazianzen (*Arcana* 6,1-7):[115]

> Even as a sunbeam, travelling through rain-heavy, calm air, encountering clouds in its refracted, revolving movements, produces the many-coloured rainbow curve; everywhere around, the upper air gleams brightly with many circles dissolving towards the edges; such is the nature of lights also, the highest light always shining brightly upon minds which are lesser beams.[116]

[111] Zachhuber has highlighted that to an even greater extent *Epistle* 38 contains terms that are typical of Gregory Nyssen, and not of Basil, both with regard to Trinitarian theology and the lexis, J. Zachhuber, 'Nochmals: Der „38. Brief" des Basilius von Caesarea' (2003), 80-6.

[112] See later, p. 266-7.

[113] M. Simonetti, review Drecoll (1998), 309.

[114] For instance, the anonymous author of the homilies on the creation of man (which, in my opinion are by neither Basil nor Gregory Nyssen) and the authors of the various *spuria* among Basil's homilies are of an extremely basic theological level. The problem of *CE* IV and V is different.

[115] The use of the example of the rainbow had also been observed by A. Cavallin which I have not been able to read: Hübner discusses it in *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 247 n. 12, and it is important that it be advanced by Gregory of Nazianzus.

[116] Trans. Sykes, St Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana* (1997).

To explain the generation and the *homousios* of the Son, the author of the epistle advances another image in this same context, that of light which, after having struck the surface of the water, is reflected back (88,19-20): 'For since it is in the nature of flame-like flashes of light, when they fall on something smooth, to recoil again upon themselves'. This image also has a parallel in Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 31,32):

I once heard a man describe it in terms of a sunbeam which throws its radiance on to a wall; its trembling results from the movement of water, a movement transmitted through the intervening air and caught by the beam. The beam is then checked by the resistance of the wall and becomes a quivering that surprises one with its rapidity of oscillation.[117]

The term 'chain' (ἅλυσις) to indicate the interlinking of the divine Persons among themselves (ch. 4, 86,70 Courtonne) is found in Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 10,1; PG 35, 828A) and used to indicate a spiritual link between the speaker and his (real or imagined) friends: Basil and Gregory Nyssen;[118] the play on words 'linked distinction and separate conjunction' (87,88-90; 89,59-60 Courtonne) is typical of Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 21,13; 31,9; 31,14: ἀμέριστος ἐν μεμερισμένοις; 31,29; 33,16; 39,11).[119]

In conclusion, were one to accept Simonetti's hypothesis, it would also be possible to maintain that this epistle is a summary of the doctrine, stabilized after the teaching of the Cappadocians, of the unique substance – three hypostases – in which the author utilizes a terminology and a conception that became current after Gregory of Nazianzus' works and, above all, Gregory of Nyssa's. However, this hypothesis is lacking more convincing elements to support it.

4. *Trinitarian Theology and Philosophy*

As has been seen, the best solution, according to some scholars, in terms of the Trinitarian issue, has to be sought out in Stoic logic (Hübner) or Aristotelian logic, updated by Porphyry or 4th-century Peripatetic commentators (Drecoll and Zachhuber), and thus in coeval philosophy. Indeed, Gregory of Nyssa (the only one taken into account, it would seem, by scholars) may have used texts that at the time constituted every cultivated person's basic knowledge;[120] the first stage in these 'basic' readings appears to have been Porphyry's *Isagoge*, while the second stage may have included *Organon* with the comments on all the works it contains. In my opinion, proof is missing regarding this scholastic

[117] Trans. L. Wickham and F. Williams, *Faith gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991).
[118] 'Chain' is also found in Gregory of Nazianzus, *Orat*. 36,1.
[119] See also Greg. Nyss., *Refut*. 6; *Epist*. 24,5.
[120] J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 10-1.

knowledge of Porphyry-based Aristotelianism. The idea of a Neo-Platonic derivation for the Trinitarian formula has found other supporters. Kevin Corrigan, although he is well aware of the danger of arbitrariness in identifying Neo-Platonism as the source of the Cappadocians' doctrine of the Trinity, states: 'My thesis is: the Trinitarian theology of the Cappadocians depends first of all on the mystery of God's love revealed though the incarnation, death and resurrection of Christ. But from a historical point of view this type of theology is not feasible without the complex intellectual climate that can help to frame it' – and this is correct; less convincing, however, is what follows: 'an indispensable part of this climate is the tension deriving from different strands of Neo-Platonism, among which the non-generation of the ultimate principle (for instance, in Iamblichus) and the need, above all from a Christian perspective, for this principle to also be *causa sui*, so that, while its substance remains unknown and unreachable by our thought, our thought may in any case specify certain peculiarities through all the proof arising from God's works in history, writing, and man's rational capacities'.[121] In this way, unfortunately, the influence of contemporary philosophy on the Cappadocians becomes preponderant, to the detriment of Christian tradition (even though it is not necessary to accommodate Rist's radical negation).

The philosophical framework (particularly along the lines of Neo-Platonic logic) is even more accentuated, if this is possible, by Richard Cross, who accepts and further investigates some points of Zachhuber's study,[122] but he maintains that the solution advanced by Gregory of Nyssa consists in considering divine *ousia* as an immanent universal in the Persons; this represents a deliberate polemic towards Porphyry's take on the theory of universals, for whom the universal had a 'collective' sense:[123] in Trinitarian theology this means that the three divine Persons constitute the 'universal', namely, God. Basil and Nyssen use this theory to defend the *homousion* against theological objections:[124] It was necessary to explain the unity of the Persons by basing oneself on the *derivation* of one Person from the other without this derivation implying subordination. The problem of divisibility is dealt with by claiming that not every relationship of derivation diminishes the substance of the source. The Father remains an indivisible monad and the Son derives from him through generation, without dividing the substance of the Father. In conclusion, according to Cross the term 'God' does not refer to the divine Persons, nor properly to the Father, but to the divine substance or essence. Divine essence is a universal immanent and the relationship between substance and hypostasis in the Trinity

[121] K. Corrigan, 'Οὐσία and ὑπόστασις' (2008), 116.

[122] R. Cross, 'Gregory of Nyssa on Universals' (2002). Cross explains the Cappadocians' philosophical background in 374-80.

[123] *Ibid*. 373.

[124] *Ibid*. 380.

is considered by Cross as a form of the relationship between the universal and the particular – he applies his interpretation also to the problem of divine monarchy in Gregory of Nazianzus, as well as the problem of tritheism.

Such strongly philosophical interpretations raise objections. First of all, it has to be noted that *ousia* taken in Porphyry's Aristotelian-Neo-Platonic sense remains an abstract entity, which has only to do with the field of logic (this is confirmed by Boethius, who derives from Porphyry). And above all, to Cross', Corrigan's and others' interpretation, I wish to counter with the objection that conceiving of a theology in which the universal entails the particular and is present wholly in each of them is extraneous to the Christian tradition.[125] The close connection between Basil and Gregory of Nyssa (as usual Gregory of Nazianzus is excluded by these critics) and contemporary philosophy, as suggested by them, is too strong: it overlooks the usual conviction in the Eastern theology that the Father is the divine nature and is therefore the fount of the other two hypostaseis. The problem with tritheism came about as a consequence precisely of the problem concerning one *ousia* and three hypostaseis, as the Cappadocians explained it, and may be linked after all to what is discussed above: that is, whether or not divine substance is universal.

Another solution suggested even before these, which look to Porphyry's logic, was to steer the Trinitarian formula of the Cappadocians towards Neo-Platonic ontology, which however was amended by Christian theologians in the 4th century by the exclusion of the hierarchical structure, which is so typical of Neoplatonism. Both Simonetti[126] and I[127] thought that the Trinitarian doctrine of the Cappadocians represented a recuperation, suitably adapted for the Christian religion, of Porphyry's hierarchy of the hypostases.[128] Simonetti is basing himself on the passage in Marius Victorinus that was shown above:[129] the divine Trinity 'is expressed by Greeks in this way: there are three hypostaseis from one substance (*idque a Graecis ita dicitur*: ἐκ μιᾶς οὐσίας τρεῖς εἶναι τὰς ὑποστάσεις)' (*Adv. Arium* III 4). I have also observed, however, that this formula does not exactly correspond with the Trinity formula attributed to

[125] Another example of interpreting Cappadocian theology as dependent on Greek philosophy is provided by Cross, *ibid.* 399 and note, who maintains that the use of the term μονάς in *Ad Ablabium* corresponds to Iamblichus' Neoplatonism and that it was used both by Iamblichus and by Proclus to underline the numerical indivisibility of the individual forms, even though one ought not to think that Gregory Nyssen derives from Iamblichus, but the term 'monad' characterizes the numerical indivisibility of the idea, and for Gregory Nyssen 'the unity of the divine substance is not less than numerical'. But μονάς is also frequently used in Gregory Nazianzen, as has been seen; it is used by Amphilochius and Apollinaris (*KMP* 1; 9 etc.), and even before by Marcellus of Ancyra in a Sabellian sense, and ever since the apologetics it had been commonly used.

[126] M. Simonetti, *La crisi ariana* (1975), 513. This interpretation has been criticized by Chr. Markschies, 'Was ist lateinischer »Neunizänismus«?' (2000), 251-3.

[127] Cl. Moreschini, *Storia della filosofia patristica* (2004), 516-7.

[128] See Porphyry, *Hist. Philos.* 221F-222F Smith.

[129] M. Simonetti, 'Dal nicenismo al neonicenismo' (2006), 281-2.

the Cappadocians. Against the interpretation advanced both by Simonetti and myself, according to which the Christian Trinity can be traced back to Porphyry, we counter with the observation that the hypothesis whereby the Porphyrian formula is a form of *praeparatio evangelica* had already been advanced prior to the Cappadocians' speculations, by Eusebius of Caesarea, and was taken up by Pseudo-Didymus the Blind (*De Trinitate* II 27; PG 39, 760B) and by Cyril of Alexandria (*Contra Iulianum* VIII 27 Kinzig – Brüggemann).[130] As he was convinced that Greek philosophy derived from Jewish revelation, Eusebius states that Plato's philosophy was preceded by the 'oracles' of Holy Scripture. In order to demonstrate this, Eusebius outlined a comparison between the second Platonic epistle, where 'three gods' are spoken of, as well as three worlds, or realms of reality, which are 'around' each of these, and the Christian doctrine of the divine Trinity (*PE* XI 20-21,1-3).

Markschies, instead, advances a solution that conforms to 4th-century Christian tradition, and yet also depends strongly on Neo-Platonic philosophy. The theology of the Cappadocians (he asserts) does not consist in the formula, one substance – three hypostases, never actually suggested by them, but represents a recuperation of Origen's doctrine of 'non-fused unity' (ἀσύγχυτος ἕνωσις). Like Holl,[131] Markschies maintains that what is lacking in the concepts utilised by the Cappadocians is effective philosophical penetration, a precise evaluation of their relations, and therefore accuracy: 'Basil does not possess any terminological means required in order to distinguish the specificities of the hypostaseis from the qualities of the substance…' Plus: 'Since "paternity" and "filiality" are not individuations of the same substance, how could the Father, insofar as he is a father, produce the Son's divine nature through generation?'[132] Such a conception would be a *monstrum* in Platonism (as Holl too had asserted).[133] The Cappadocians' conception could aspire to consistency only if it could draw on the image of the 'non-fused unity' of the three hypostaseis.[134] Such an image did not reach the Cappadocians directly from Origen, but is rather of Neo-Platonic origin. Even though the idea of the reciprocal co-presence of the three Persons of the Trinity has a certain basis in the Gospel, what we are dealing with here is also the Neo-Platonic idea of the reciprocal union of incorporeal reality, which nevertheless excludes confusion, keeping them well distinct one from the other. Origen's doctrine of the three hypostaseis, which was originally that of subordinance, and the Plotinian designation of the metaphysical principles as 'hypostaseis' may date back, despite all the differences in the details,

[130] See M.-O. Boulnois, 'Platon entre Moïse et Arius' (1997), 264-71; Cl. Moreschini, 'I sapienti pagani nel *Contra Iulianum*' (1999).

[131] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 133.

[132] *Ibid.* 148.

[133] *Ibid.* 131.

[134] Chr. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 234.

to a common source.[135] The doctrine of 'non-fused unity' can also be found in Nemesius' *De natura hominis* (p. 38,19-20 Morani), as a means of illustrating the relations of the soul with the body, which do not in fact represent a 'blending'. Since Nemesius depends on Ammonius Saccas (p. 38,16-44,21), Plotinus' and Origen's master, Plotinus and Origen – and hence the Cappadocians – might have gained this doctrine from him.

Markschies' explanation, yet, entails too many stages. His hypothesis, that Origen's conception of 'non-fused union' may have led to the Cappadocians' doctrine of the Trinity is likely, as a paradigm; but the path by which it appears to have reached the Cappadocians is extremely tortuous, passing as it does through Neo-Platonism, Ammonius Saccas, Plotinus and Porphyry. The passages by Basil adopted by Markschies as proof of the dependence of Basil's Trinitarian theology on Plotinus[136] are not decisive; there are more obvious one – even if few in number – in Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat.* 31,9: ἵνα τὸ ἀσύγχυτον σῴζηται and 31,29: ἵνα μὴ σύγχυσις ᾖ παρὰ θεότητι) and Gregory Nyssen (*CE* I 499; II 39). The conception of the 'non-confused union' exists, of course, in the Cappadocians, but it regards *the relationship* between substance and hypostasis, does not explain *the origin* of the hypostaseis. Finally, it should be remembered that the Cappadocians do not use the formula ἀσύγχυτος ἕνωσις as if it contained the true explanation of the Trinitarian issue; rather, they use it like one of many.

Tritheism

There is no doubt about it: 'The distinction between Persons on the same ontological plane *ipso facto* amounts to tritheism'.[137] The solution to this problem means defining Trinitarian theology because tritheism is, in fact, a misunderstanding of this. The doctrine 'one *ousia* – three hypostaseis' does not in itself differentiate between the Cappadocian Trinitarian doctrine and the homoiousian one: whether *ousia* is taken in its Stoic meaning, or whether *ousia* is to be understood in an abstract way, as the *ghenos* (something that the Cappadocians reject), then the three *hypostaseis* are three gods, as three belonging to the same *ghenos*. The accusation of tritheism made to the Cappadocians came from the Pneumatomachians, who were homoousians but were not willing to accept the divinity of the Holy Spirit, and in the wake of their opposition the Cappadocians further developed this discussion, formulating on a new basis their Trinitarian doctrine.[138] This occurred at the end of their activity, from 375, when

[135] H. Ziebritzki, *Heiliger Geist und Weltseele* (1994), 176-81.

[136] Chr. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 208-9.

[137] J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 158-9; see also 105-21.

[138] It is not clear why the Pneumatomachians, and not others, made this objection. In this case too, as so often, the issue of tritheism has been studied in Gregory of Nyssa, but far less in Basil

Basil wrote *De Spiritu sancto*, to about 383, when Gregory of Nyssa wrote *Contra Macedonianos*.

Basil seemed to be less informed about tritheism, perhaps because the charge was raised in the Constantinopolitan *milieu* more than in Caesarea or in Cappadocia, where he lived. The only time Basil explicitly mentions the term tritheism occurs in a context where he rejects Apollinarism. At the end of *Epistle* 132 (II 46,20-1 Courtonne) to Olympius, he states: ἡμεῖς … οὔτε τρεῖς θεοὺς λέγομεν οὔτε Ἀπολιναρίῳ κοινωνοῦμεν. Apollinaris had been charged with Sabellianism and consequently so was Basil, who was considered to be a friend of his by the Eustathians: in order to defend himself, Basil then accused Apollinaris of Sabellianism (*Epist*. 265,2). Basil uses the word 'tritheism' also in a homily whose authenticity is not certain (*Adversus eos qui per calumniam dicunt dici a nobis deos tres*; PG 31, 1488C-1496C) and the level of the theological discussion in the homily is low. Anyone who thinks that there are three Gods, Basil says, can also suppose that there are many others (1489B-1492A),[139] in which case he denies the formula that he professed at his baptism (1492A). The accusation is made by the Pneumatomachians: 'I am accused of a theological mistake because I do not leave the Spirit out of the divine nature and I do not place Him in the order of slaves … but tritheism is a mere pretence, and is caused by the fact that I condemn those who consider the Holy Spirit a creature' (1492BC). Nothing else is said here about the problem. In my opinion, this homily is a spurious piece of Basil's oratory.[140]

The charge of tritheism seems to have struck Gregory of Nazianzus more forcefully.[141] He explicitly mentions tritheism for the first time in Constantinople, in 379. In *Orat*. 25,18 he encourages Maximus the Cynic, 'not to be ashamed of being charged with tritheism, since there are others who can be charged with ditheism'.[142] And in *Orat*. 31,13 Gregory, turning to those who denied the divinity of the Holy Spirit, though they accepted the divinity of the Son, reproaches them for accusing the Nicenes of tritheism, since they can in turn

and even less again in Gregory of Nazianzus, despite the fact that both of them discuss it in an original manner.

[139] Which is to say that tritheism is a form of polytheism. Basil also makes this point in *De Spiritu sancto*, as we shall see soon subsequently.

[140] Current criticism seems to be convinced of its authenticity: a summary in R.M. Hübner, *Die Schrift des Apolinarius von Laodicea* (1989), 1 n. 2; A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 155-6; M. DelCogliano, who carries out a lengthy and detailed examination of the homily and its history, as well as the various opinions concerning its authenticity, 'Basil of Caesarea's Homily on Not Three Gods' (2011). In my opinion, the authenticity remains uncertain: the level of speculation in this homily is not up to Basil, even though, as has already been noted, Basil prefers not to entrust his theological considerations to his homilies.

[141] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 177-8.

[142] In a similar manner, he speaks brusquely to catechumens approaching baptism (*Orat*. 40,43): 'are you afraid of being reproached for tritheism? Keep your treasure safe, namely, the union of the three, and leave the task of fighting to me'.

be accused of ditheism. It is clear, then, that the persons envisaged here by Gregory are the Pneumatomachians. Tritheism was, Gregory says (*ibid.*), 'a long-dead enquiry which had yielded to faith;[143] we must nonetheless make a stand against babblers and not allow the case to go by default. If, it is asserted, we use the word "God" three times, must there not be three Gods? How can the object of glorification fail to be a plurality of powers (πολυαρχία)?'

The accusations made to Gregory of Nyssa are more subtle, and do not always speak explicitly of tritheism. In *Eustath.* (GNO III/I, 6,7-17) Gregory is accused of two opposite errors, that of 'dividing the hypostaseis' and that of using in a Sabellian way (μοναδικῶς) the terms of excellence of the divine nature. He states that he has been absurdly charged with both tritheism and Sabellianism (*ibid.* 5,3-14): in this instance, the traditional juxtaposition between Sabellius (or Judaism) and Arius does not take place, but rather between Sabellius and tritheism. The charge made to Gregory originated with the Pneumatomachians (7,8-16), as is also said in *Ablab.* 38,3-18. The charge set out in *Graec.* 26,6-28,8 and *Ablab.* 55,21-57,13 is more wide-ranging and detailed,[144] and also occurs in *Epist.* 5,8, and the whole of *Epist.* 24.[145] In *Refutatio* 194-5 Gregory clearly states that he has been charged with tritheism.[146]

Basil, Gregory Nazianzen and Gregory Nyssen were in agreement in their response to these charges, underlining the unity of nature of the divine Persons, but they used different reasonings to do this. The foundation of their critical considerations of tritheism is the concept of φύσις.

Physis

On their own, neither *ousia* nor hypostasis can provide a solution to the essential issue: how can the Son and, in second place, the Holy Spirit, be distinct from the Father if they are of the same substance? The fact that the Cappadocians do not use either *ousia* or hypostasis consistently is proof that they do not attribute to them a specific or definitive meaning, despite subsequent tradition encapsulating their Trinitarian doctrine in the formula, *ousia* (in preference to *hypokeimenon*) and *hypostaseis* (in preference to *prosopon* and *idiotes*). The concept of homoousion, as has been seen, was either avoided (Basil) or it was not used in a rigorous manner (Gregory of Nazianzus) or it was not considered important (Gregory of Nyssa). But above all, the formula does not fully express

[143] Gregory considers tritheism to be a similar case to the polytheism of the pagans.

[144] See J. Leemans, 'Logic and the Trinity' (2008).

[145] A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 38-53. He observes that the discussion of the issue of tritheism in Gregory of Nyssa is 'remarkably austere' because Nyssen only uses the abstract terms 'cause – caused' and avoids the language of generation and procreation.

[146] The collocation of tritheism in the context of the Trinitarian dispute is also touched on by M.-O. Boulnois, *Le paradoxe trinitaire* (1994), 267-73.

the theology of the Cappadocians, because *ousia* and *hypostaseis* remain abstract and 'philosophical' terms.

The solution may be found in the term *physis*, if it is taken in the right way. Regarding *physis*, Zachhuber states: 'In *Contra Eunomium* this item is referred to above all as οὐσία, but on a number of occasions *physis* and other terms (*hypokeimenon, dynamis*) are employed equivalently', but at the same time he attributes a logical meaning to *physis*, taking it as a 'universal' of Porphyry's logic (οὐσία may thus represent a reality similar to *physis*, which is juxtaposed with the hypostasis, which possesses both its own qualities and those of the substance). I have already stated that I do not agree with this; furthermore, Zachhuber examines above all Gregory Nyssen and, to a lesser extent, Basil, while he passes over Gregory of Nazianzus.[147]

The path to be followed was instead indicated by Anthony Meredith, who stated that, for the Cappadocians, οὐσία is indeed, in most cases, the equivalent of φύσις,[148] and for this reason it does not simply indicate a concrete, individual reality, a πρᾶγμα: both οὐσία and φύσις differ from πρᾶγμα insofar as they indicate 'that item which is specially responsible for the things individuality'.

[147] See J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 149-63. The heading of one of the sections of his study, 'Philosophical Background', 79-92 is telling. Zachhuber's interpretation of 'nature' as 'a universal item' is also accepted by Andrew Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 195 n. 11, and, in general, his interpretation of Gregory Nyssen's Christology. The concept and meaning of *physis* has been re-examined by L. Karfíková, '*Ad Ablabium, quod non sint tres dei*' (2011), 131-68, who, so it seems to me, partly follows that of Zachhuber: *physis* can be both a universal (that is, God's *ousia*) and a particular (the *ousia* present in the Persons) (*ibid.* 136-41). Nevertheless, Karfíková differs from Zachhuber, maintaining that the concept of 'nature' ought to be taken in a similar way to that of 'pleroma', as is found in *De opificio hominis* (22,205B), that is, in the sense of a totality, of a fullness of the divine reality made up of the Persons (*ibid.* 141). Nature is not 'materielle Stoff', but rather something independent of any type of individual or accidental determination, and therefore also removed from differences and non-enumerable, so that it cannot be subject to number and plurality (*ibid* 143). The concept of the *ousia* shared by the three divine Persons in Basil (*CE* I 19) is similar (*ibid.* 143 n. 57). However, if *ousia* is taken in this way, it is not all that different from Zachhuber's 'universal'. Karfíková sees the influence and the modification of Neoplatonic doctrines (*ibid.* 146-7), but it seems unlikely to me that the Cappadocians, despite recognising God's infinity (see above, p. 132-4), would have understood this infinity in such a way that, in the final analysis, is negative; that is, something indeterminate. In addition, the term 'pleroma', used to a limited extent by Gregory Nyssen to indicate humanity, is never applied by him to the divine nature.

As for *hypokeimenon*, Mark Edwards, *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2019), 116-28, goes into great detail on the use that Gregory of Nyssa makes of it (but not on that of the other Cappadocians), concluding that 'there is no sense … that can be uniformly assigned to the word *hypokeimenon* in Gregory's teaching on the Trinity' (*ibid.* 127). And this is true, but it is also typical of all the Trinitarian terminology used by the Cappadocians, while Edwards tried to trace *hypokeimenon* back to Aristotle, and only Aristotle.

[148] See A. Meredith, *Studies in the* Contra Eunomium *of Gregory of Nyssa* (1972). I have not managed to read this book, but I am basing myself on what Zachhuber refers to from it, *Human Nature* (2000), 73-5, who evidently agrees with this first part of Meredith's interpretation.

Maspero also recognizes the importance of the term φύσις, and not even he accepts the meaning that Zachhuber gives it: the divine φύσις that Gregory Nyssen speaks of is 'an authentic Christian transformation of the Neoplatonic logic and ontology': various passages from *Ad Eustathium* and *Ad Ablabium* (*Eustath.* 6,9-17 etc.; *Ablab.* 39,9-10 etc.)[149] substantiate this.

The difference between οὐσία and φύσις, therefore, is not conceptual, but rather involves ontology: φύσις possesses a greater number of meanings than οὐσία. In Greek itself, φύσις has more qualifying determinacy and more concrete uses than the abstract and almost exclusively philosophical οὐσία. In *Contra Eunomium* Basil had already used φύσις, both when he wanted to indicate the immaterial divine substance, and when he wanted to indicate human substance.[150] Also in *De Spiritu sancto* (18,45) φύσις is equivalent to οὐσία (ἐπὶ τῆς θείας καὶ ἀσυνθέτου φύσεως). Gregory of Nazianzus uses οὐσία alongside φύσις in a generic context (*Orat.* 29,13: Θεοῦ μίαν οὐσίαν εἶναι καὶ φύσιν), but when he wants to indicate the essence of the divine substance, which generates and is generated, he turns to φύσις (*Orat.* 29,10: αὕτη γὰρ φύσις γεννήτορος καὶ γεννήματος). God is the 'first φύσις' (*Orat.* 28,13-4). Φύσις, therefore, can indicate God's reality (φύσις θεότητος in *Orat.* 23,11) or is the equivalent of θεότης (*Orat.* 41,8), just as it also indicates the particular reality of the hypostaseis (*Orat.* 28,9; 29,14: ὁμοτιμία τῶν φύσεων). This fact, and that is, the greater wealth of meaning of 'nature' compared to 'substance', will also appear in subsequent considerations.

In conclusion, in order to understand the Trinitarian theology of the Cappadocians, it is crucial not to base oneself on the term that is poorer in meaning, which is substance (οὐσία), but rather on the one that is more specific and comprehensive, namely, nature (φύσις);[151] nature, however, ought not to be taken in a strictly logical sense, as has been suggested by Zachhuber, because in this way it would barely be distinguishable from οὐσία and its meanings in logic (Donaldson and Cross) and, ultimately, would annul any 'personal' element both in human nature and in the divine one. From the Father's divine nature (which is not a universal) derive the Persons (which are neither abstract nor concrete particulars). In this way φύσις expresses all its potential and thus enables the difficulties of tritheism to be overcome, along with one of its aspects, which was rejected by the Pneumatomachians, but firmly supported by the Cappadocians: accepting the nature, and thus, the divine origin of the Holy Spirit. It is no coincidence that neither of these difficulties appeared when Basil wrote *Contra Eunomium*, but rather when Basil, forced by the controversy

[149] G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 15.

[150] See *CE* II 14,49; 15,32; 16,38; 19,44 and 48 etc.

[151] That *ousia* is not very useful for an understanding of Gregory Nazianzen's theology has already been observed by Chr. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus on the Trinity* (2008), 10 n. 27 and 218.

provoked by his decision to support the divinity of the Holy Spirit, wrote *De Spiritu sancto*, in which he, like Gregory Nyssen and Gregory Nazianzen, has a disputation with the Pneumatomachians. Therefore, the charge of tritheism began when the pro-Nicenes also wanted to introduce the Holy Spirit into the divine nature, and so a 'third', which could not be 'subnumerated': this charge came, in fact, from the Pneumatomachians. For this reason, I do not believe that Gregory's dispute with the Pneumatomachians was caused by the necessity of smoothing away the differences between the Nicenes and the Marcellians, by showing how the divine monad could without absurdity be linked to the triad.

This will all be useful when it comes to reconsidering the issue of how the other two divine Persons had their origin in the Father.

Basil's Refutation of Tritheism

Basil's discussion of this problem clearly appears in the *De Spiritu sancto*, although there he does not employ the word 'tritheism'. In 16,38 he warns against believing that he is speaking of τρεῖς ἀρχικαὶ ὑποστάσεις, or, in other words, that his theology is constructed in a Neo-Platonic way.[152] In Neo-Platonism each ἀρχή derives from the preceding one, and does so, above all, in a hierarchical succession. Basil declines this doctrine: 'What, however, they call sub-numeration, and in what sense they (the Pneumatomachians) use this word, cannot even be imagined without difficulty. It is well known that it was imported into our language from the wisdom of the world' (*ibid.* 17,41). This passage, which is usually considered a (disputed) witness of Basil's Neo-Platonism, is basic

[152] In *Upon The Mother Of The Gods* (8, 168b) Julian asserts that Atthis 'is attended by the Corybants who are assigned to him by the Mother; they are the three leading personalities of the higher races that are next in order to the gods' (αἱ τρεῖς ἀρχικαὶ τῶν μετὰ θεοῦ κρεισσόνων γενῶν ὑποστάσεις) (trans. W. Cave Wright, LCL [1962]). Perhaps in this passage by Julian (who was well acquainted with Christian theology and the Trinitarian debates of his time), 'the three leading personalities of the higher races' may be interpreted according to Porphyry's teaching. 'On the three primary Hypostaseis' is the title in the fifth Ennead by Plotinus, but it is not an invention by Plotinus, even if it is found in the edition that Porphyry edited and probably in that by Eustochius. Consequently, 4th- and 5th-century Christian writers, who were interested in Plotinus' philosophy (as well as that of Porphyry) such as Eusebius, Cyril, Basil, and Augustine, use it commonly. Pierre Hadot (Plotin, *Traité 50* [1990], 24) has stated that the expression 'three hypostaseis' ought to be completely eliminated, because Plotinus never used it to designate the three principles of his universe. In Plotinus, the word 'hypostasis' generally means 'existence' or 'a product which has substance' of a transcendent reality; but it is never applied to the One, to the Intellect or the Soul. Therefore, the title 'On the three primary Hypostaseis' was applied to *Ennead* V 1 by Porphyry and, logically, the current meaning of the term 'hypostasis' derives from Porphyry. Thus, it seems that, alongside the 4th-century Christian writers, and probably not independently of them, given his Christian education, Julian also used the term 'hypostasis' in the Porphyrian sense, even though, in this passage 'hypostasis' does not refer to the metaphysics of Plotinus.

for his opposition to tritheism as well. In *De Spiritu sancto*, as in the homily *Adversus eos qui per calumniam dicunt dici a nobis deos tres*, Basil observes that we must be aware of the danger of polytheism. If we consider each Person as divided from the others, we may fall into the 'subnumeration' (ὑπαρίθμησις) (17,42), or into a misunderstanding of the doctrine of the hypostaseis (18,44). Therefore 'when our Lord gave us the doctrine of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit, he did not add the number: indeed, he did not say that we have to believe in the first, in the second and in the third (οὐ μετὰ τοῦ ἀριθμοῦ συνεξέδωκεν·οὐ γὰρ εἶπεν ὅτι εἰς πρῶτον καὶ δεύτερον καὶ τρίτον)' (18,44-45) a parallel which means that number, or better, separation by number, is not a suitable way to explain the nature of the Persons:

> What is unutterable must be honoured by the silence and what is holy must be numbered as devotion requires… We speak of each hypostasis in the singular (μοναχῶς), but when we have to number them together (συναριθμεῖσθαι), *we do not conceive the idea of polytheism, due to a wrong counting* (οὐχὶ ἀπαιδεύτῳ ἀριθμήσει πρὸς πολυθεΐας ἔννοιαν ἐκφερόμεθα). We do not count by addition, from one to many, nor do we speak of one and two and three, nor of first, second and third … we confess the peculiar element of the hypostasis, and yet we remain in the monarchy, since we do not divide the theology into a multiplicity of entities *separated from each other*.

And since the Pneumatomachians asked: 'How is it possible, when we speak of 'one' and 'one', that we do not mean two gods? (πῶς οὖν, εἴπερ εἷς καὶ εἷς, οὐχὶ δύο θεοί;)', Basil answers that 'we mean the King and the image of the King, not two Kings', according to *Col*. 2:15 (Christ is 'the image of the invisible God'). On the contrary, who asserts that divine substance is a γένος which contains three Persons as if they were three εἴδη is a tritheist: it is not admissible that the God of the universe is a general concept, knowable only through reason, and that his being does not exist in any hypostasis, but is divided into subjects or *species* (*De Spiritu sancto* 17,41).[153]

Not even Apollinaris had accepted the interpretation put forward by the homoiousians for *ousia*, which he found to be too divisive: he states that *ousia* contains within itself everything that belongs to it, so that the Son is present in the Father, and in Adam, insofar as he is a man, all men are present (*apud* Bas., *Epist*. 362).[154] The Father is a sort of ὑπόθεσις ('ground of being'), otherwise there is a risk of committing the error of taking the Father as a gender

[153] See on the passage R. Hübner, 'Basilius von Caesarea und das Homoousios' (1993), 74 = *Kirche und Dogma* (2017), 365.

[154] Apollinaris' solution is interpreted by Zachhuber in the sense that Apollinaris also seems to have understood *ousia* as a universal reality in accordance with Porphyry's doctrine (*Isag*. 1,18-2,10), *Human Nature* (2000), 35-40; see also *id*., 'Basil and the three-hypostases tradition' (2001), 84-5. However, this answer does not in actual fact correspond to Basil's question, who had asked how the *ousia* Homoians and Homoiousians were speaking about should be understood.

superimposed on individual species (namely, the Persons of the Trinity). This appears to correspond with the theology in *KMP* 18, where Apollinaris denies that the Trinity is the result of a σύνθεσις.[155] The important thing is that Apollinaris also sees in the Father the origin of the other Persons, and thus a reality rather than a logical concept.

Gregory of Nazianzus

Nazianzen's solution is different. He asserts that

> we have one God, for the Godhead is One, and towards that One they all incline who come from him. Yet we believe in the Three (καὶ πρὸς ἓν τὰ ἐξ αὐτοῦ τὴν ἀναφορὰν ἔχει, κἂν τρία πιστεύεται).[156] One is not more, another less, than God. One is not first, another later. There is here no diversity of will (βούλησις), or distinction in power (δύναμις). There is here none of the qualities of divisible things. If I have to sum it up briefly, I would say that the Godhead is undivided in three who are distinct. There is one mingling of the Light as there would be if three suns joined together. If we consider the Godhead, or the First Cause, or the Monarchy, then it is revealed to us as One. When we consider those realities in whom there is the Godhead, however, who before all time derive their being from the First Cause and are of the same glory as it, then indeed we have three subjects for our veneration (*Orat*. 31,14).[157]

This passage is crucial. The image of the three suns joined together is an example of how it is possible to believe in the three Persons of equal substance without falling into tritheism. It is advanced again in *Orat*. 40,5 (the light of the divine nature is what is contemplated in the three Persons, whose richness consists in the communion of nature and in the shared flash of their brightness:

[155] M. Vinzent, 'Pseudo-Athanasius, *Oratio contra Arianos IV*' (2015), 66. In P. Gemeinhardt, 'Apollinaris of Laodicea' (2006), 292-4, there is a correct interpretation of Apollinaris' theology as set forth in Basil's letters.

[156] The abstracts ἕν and τὰ τρία do not mean that the Son and the Holy Spirit do not come from the Father, but from the θεότης, as if they were abstract particulars: this is Cross' interpretation, to which I shall make an objection shortly.

[157] This is the translation by J. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 306, which corresponds to his interpretation: the opposite is the interpretation by Richard Cross, 'Divine Monarchy in Gregory of Nazianzus' (2006), 105-16, who therefore translates: 'For us there is one God, because there is one divinity, and the things that derive from the one (τὰ ἐξ αὐτοῦ, namely τὸ ἕν), which are believed to be three, have reference to it'. The image of the three suns, according to Cross, means that Gregory excludes any *causal relation* between the divine essence and the divine Persons. Indeed, light is not shared by the three suns as if it were their cause; the divine essence is shared by the three Persons without being divided. Sometimes, in fact, Gregory overstresses the communion between the Persons, as in *Orat.* 30,11: if *everything* is shared by the Three, nothing can be *specific* (here, however, we are dealing with perichoresis). I maintain here, and explain on p. 254-5, that this explanation is not possible: suffice it to say that for the Cappadocians and, in general, Christian writers, the Father, and not an impersonal substance, is the origin of the divine Persons.

ἡ συμφύϊα καὶ τὸ ἓν ἔξαλμα τῆς λαμπρότητος),[158] in *Arcana* 3,43: 'One God in his three gleaming facets keeping the universe on its whirling course (εἷς Θεὸς ἐν τρισσοῖς ἀμαρύγμασι κόσμον ἑλίσσον)' and *ibid*. 4,65: 'one equal gleam of excellence expressed in the threefold light of Godhead (τρισσοφαοῦς θεότητος δμὸν σέλας ἰσοφέριστον)' and more widely:

The single nature is firmly established in three lights (ἐν τρισσοῖς φαέεσσιν ἴη φύσις ἐστήρικται). It is not a unity unrelated to number, since it consists of three excellent forms, nor is it a Trinity to be worshipped as plural, since its nature is indivisible. The oneness inheres within the Godhead, those to whom Godhead belongs are three in number. Each of them is the one God, when you mention only one. Again, the one God is unoriginate, whence comes the rich quality of Godhead, when there is any reference to three, so as to bring about in mortal men a reverent proclamation of the three lights and also we may glorify the clear-shining unity of rule (ὡς τὸ μὲν εἷη / τῶν τρισσῶν φαέων σεπτὸν κήρυγμα βροτοῖσι) (*Arcana* 3,71-7).

Nazianzen more than once employs this image of the three suns: *Carm.* I 2,1,29: εἷς θεός, ἐν τρισσοῖσιν ἀνοιγόμενος φαεέσσι; II 2,4,88-9: ἧς (ἀληθείης) πρῶτον πύματόν τε Τριὰς θεότης μονόσεπτος, / ἓν φάος ἐν τρισσοῖς ἀμαρύγμασιν ἰσοθέοισι. The relationship between God and the divine Persons, states Gregory, is not that put forward by some of the most renowned Greek philosophers, namely, that there is one divine nature (θεότης), as there is one human nature (ἀνθρωπότης), which is the γένος in its totality.[159] The gods of the heathens, like humans, are many, and they possess unity only as an abstraction (ἐπινοίᾳ θεωρητόν). Individual humans are effectively divided by time, passions and power, the Persons of the divine nature are not (*Orat*. 31,15-6).

Gregory turned his attention to tritheism early on. In a passage from a homily (*Orat*. 2,37) which was delivered in 362, while defining orthodoxy, he does not employ here the usual antithesis between Arianism and Sabellianism; instead, he introduces a list of three illnesses: atheism, which, in his opinion, means Sabellianism; Judaism, which is compared to Arianism, and a non-perspicuous 'polytheism'. This polytheism certainly is not the usual one, since Gregory is speaking here of the Christian faith. It is the sickness which affects 'some people who, in our community, are too orthodox'. Gregory has in mind such people as 'speak of three hypostaseis that are extraneous to each other and lack an order or principle; that are, so to say, rival gods' (ch. 38). They admit the divine hypostasis, since they are labelled as 'orthodox', but they are 'even too orthodox', that is, 'wrongly orthodox'. Their mistake is a kind of polytheism: they admit the existence of three hypostases, but are not able to understand their interrelation and their dependence on divine nature. According to

[158] Cf. J. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 296 and note 355 (where, however, the reference to 'Filioque' and 'western theology' is inappropriate).

[159] This had already been denied by Basil (*De Spiritu Sancto* 17,41, see above, p. 247).

Bernardi,[160] they might be the monks in Nazianzus, who a short time later accused Gregory the Older of having subscribed to a Homoean formula. In 362 it is Gregory who levels the charge of tritheism; later, as we have seen, Basil and Gregory himself will be censured in the same way.

Gregory of Nyssa

Unlike with Basil, Gregory of Nyssa tries to resolve tritheism by insisting above all on the unity of the Persons in their manifestations:[161] 'yet their nature is one, at union in itself, and an absolutely indivisible unit, not capable of increase by addition or of diminution by subtraction, but in its essence being and continually remaining one (ἡ δὲ φύσις μία ἐστίν, αὐτὴ πρὸς ἑαυτὴν ἡνωμένη καὶ ἀδιάτμητος ἀκριβῶς μονάς, οὐκ αὐξανομένη διὰ προσθήκης οὐ μειουμένη διὰ ὑφαιρέσεως)' (*Ablab*. 40,24-41,7).[162] The passage in 1*Cor*. 1:24 (Christ δύναμις and σοφία of God) ought to be interpreted in the sense that the Son, who is the δύναμις, exists in God in a hypostatic union.[163] The concept of unity of will, operation and life in God is underlined several times: *Catech*. 5 (GNO III/IV, 16,9-30); *Graec*. (GNO III/I, 47,21-48,19); *Ablab*. (GNO III/I, 44,19-21; 50,20-51,15); *Epist*. 5,6 and 8-9.[164] Gregory Nyssen takes up the image, put forward by Gregory Nazianzen, of the three suns or three radiances inseparably connected together (*CE* I 533-4; *Refut*. 213).[165]

[160] Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 1-3 (1978), 137 n. 9.

[161] An exegetic tendency interpreted, more or less legitimately, as a sense of (relative) sympathy for Sabellianism.

[162] See M.R. Barnes, 'Eunomius of Cyzicus and Gregory of Nyssa' (1998); *id*., 'One Nature, One Power' (1997); *id*., *The Power of God* (2001), 296; G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 41, n. 167; A. Radde-Gallwitz, 'Gregory of Nyssa and the Three Gods' (2018). Barnes rightly uses a Scriptural passage, which interprets as 'transcendent causality', to develop his interpretation of Gregory of Nyssa's Trinitarian theology: as Chr. Markschies observes in another context, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 208, 'diese Dimension patristischer Argumentation [*Mt*. 28:19] wird leider selten wahrgenommen'. A. Radde-Gallwitz sets up a parallelism between the divine Persons and God's *propria*, *Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nyssa* (2009), 184-5, in the sense that the Persons are inherent to the divine substance exactly like its *propria*. Nevertheless, I feel that this interpretation sacrifices the personal aspect of the hypostaseis to the advantage of the interpretation of God as substance (and not the Father), so that it is not surprising that he approves of Cross' interpretation concerning universals in Gregory of Nyssa, R. Cross, *Gregory of Nyssa* (2002), 216-7.

[163] See G. Maspero, *Trinity and Man* (2007), 29, 38-40. *Ad Ablabium* had also been examined by Chr. Markschies, 'Gibt es eine einheitliche „kappadozische Trinitätstheologie"?' (2000), 221-6, together with *Ad Eustathium* and *Ad Graecos*, but not with the intention of finding the explanation for the origin of the divine hypostaseis.

[164] A. Radde-Gallwitz, '*Ad Eustathium de Sancta Trinitate*' (2011), 95-9.

[165] Cl. Moreschini, 'Is it Possible to Speak' (2018), 155; Andrew Radde-Gallwitz, 'Gregory of Nyssa and the Three Gods' (2018), 199 observes that it is the unity of activity (*energheia*) – as opposed to the unity of nature – that confutes tritheism, which strictly speaking is correct, but Gregory Nyssen has the unity of activity derive from the unity of nature.

Barnes explains Gregory Nyssen's understanding of divine unity thus: 'there is mind, νοῦς, which is described as a power or faculty, δύναμις; this faculty produces and monitors many different operations, ἐνέργειαι. Neither the case of a multiplicity of powers nor that of a multiplicity of operations is evidence of fundamental divisions – i.e., different essences – in the existent that acts, whether mind or God … since the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit can be shown to possess the same power, they must then have the same nature'.[166] Ayres also maintains that God's power is linked to his activity and causality, and constitutes the basis from which the paradox of God's diversity and unicity may be faced. God's activity and causality – or rather, the Father's – are inherent to his nature and so God is not divided into three distinct hypostaseis.[167] Gregory is convinced, as he states in *Ad Ablabium* in a dispute with the Pneumatomachians, that the divine nature is inherently productive: divine power, simple and unitary, is intrinsic to the indivisibility of nature.[168] For this concept Barnes and Ayres look to an intuition previously put forward by Karl Holl, who stated that 'Gregory interprets the Trinity of divine Persons that intervene in the history of salvation above all with the comprehensive term 'vivifying power (or 'nature') (ζωοποιὸς δύναμις or φύσις)', which is found in *Cant.* (GNO VI, 292,9); *Eun.* I 315; *Refut.* 206; *Oratio de Spiritu sancto sive in Pentecosten* (PG 46, 697A).[169] This concept of Gregory's (Barnes continues) may have had an antecedent[170]

[166] M.R. Barnes, 'Divine Unity' (2003), 51. See also L. Ayres, 'On not three people' (2003), 16. Barnes distinguishes between an Athanasian concept, whereby the Son is God's Power, and a concept of Gregory Nyssen, according to which Father and Son have the same power, so they also have the same nature (cf. *Eustath.* GNO III/I, 5,18-9; 6,10-1) (M.R. Barnes, 'One Nature, One Power' [1997], 219). However, also in Gregory Nazianzen δύναμις is often united with οὐσία (*supra*, p. 213), and his treatment of it is more forceful and contentious than that of Gregory Nyssen who, even though he too disputes with the Pneumatomachians, is nevertheless addressing a sympathetic listener such as Ablabius.

Anna Marmodoro tackles the issue from a different, purely Platonic-Aristotelian point of view: how can something be one *and* many? ('Gregory of Nyssa on the Metaphysics' [2019]) and rightly challenges Cross' hypothesis (which was not put forward in the afore-mentioned studies, but in her 'Two Models of the Trinity?' [2002], 280), maintaining that in this way Gregory of Nyssa came up with a new solution.

Ilaria Ramelli, 'Divine Power in Origen of Alexandria' (2017), 186-97 has kept away from the issue of divine power in the Trinity.

[167] In his study, even if he initially makes a reference to the 'social' (*ibid.*) and psychological similarities (man/divinity), Ayres does not attribute any particular importance to them – and in any case these 'similarities' are of no great use in this issue.

[168] L. Ayres, 'On not three people' (2003), 27-9.

[169] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 209-10. I have modified the indications regarding Holl's citations, conforming them to modern editions. The topic was re-examined by M.R. Barnes, 'Eunomius of Cyzicus' (1998), 83 and L. Ayres, 'On not three people' (2003), 28. Eunomius, instead, subordinated δύναμις to substance, because God also dominates δύναμις. Eunomius' interpretation is rejected by Gregory Nyssen (*CE* III 7,8-9).

[170] Or rather, a parallel. The key-word is φύσις (of God), and φύσις is not in Plotinus.

– in Plotinus:[171] V 1 and V 4, which were (above all V 1) very well known by Christian writers.[172] In this way Barnes does not use Porphyry's texts either on logic or the universals to explain Trinitarian theology.[173] According to Plotinus, δύναμις is potentially intrinsic to the One's nature and is 'around' it, just as heat is produced by fire and is around it:[174]

> How did it come to be then, and what are we to think of as surrounding the One in its repose? It must be a radiation from it, while it remains unchanged, like the bright light of the sun, which, so to speak, runs round it, spinning from it continually while it remains unchanged (V 1).

It follows that the Father, thanks to His nature, is 'the cause' of the other two Persons, who are 'caused'.[175] This doctrine of Nyssen's had a precursor in Gregory Nazianzen: the Father is αἴτιον (*Orat*. 29,3 and 29,15) and πρώτη αἰτία (*Orat*. 23,6-7); the prime cause has as a prerogative that of being the principle of divine nature (θεότητος ἀρχή), and thus the principle of the other two Persons:[176] to this (ἐκεῖσε, even if it is abstract, indicates the Person) return the γέννημα (that is, the Son) and the πρόοδος (that is, the Holy Spirit). Existing within the *physis* of the Father, who is their origin, the Persons are connected among themselves by a relationship (σχέσις): as Maspero observes,[177] the original term used in Greek philosophy receives a new semanticization both from Basil (*CE* I 7; II 9; II 22) and, more frequently, from Nyssen and Nazianzen (*Orat*. 23,8; 23,11; 26,19; 29,2 and 16; 31,7 and 9).[178] The inter-Trinitarian

[171] M.R. Barnes, 'Eunomius of Cyzicus' (1998) 81; L. Ayres, 'On not three people' (2003), 28.

[172] Plotinus, *Ennead* V 1 is used by Basil in *De Spiritu Sancto* 16,38.

[173] M. Edwards, instead, traces this concept back to Aristotle and Porphyry, *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2019), 105-11. Edwards states that according to Nyssen, *dunamis* in the Trinity is inseparable from *energheia*, because Nyssen gives *dunamis* and *energheia* a further ontological sense, which did not exist in Aristotle (*ibid*. 101-2). Edwards' interpretation is not very different from that of Barnes, whom I have just mentioned ('for Gregory, the Son is not a product of *dunamis* but the very *dunamis* of the Godhead' [*ibid*. 103]), even though he collocates it in a different philosophical context.

[174] M.R. Barnes, 'Eunomius of Cyzicus' (1998), 61, 74-5, 81-2. Barnes shows that the example of fire that produces and generates has some parallels in the *Chaldaean Oracles*, *The Power of God* (2001), 287-8, but the example was common from the Apologetic onward. I am not convinced either by Dillon, who suggested that the *Chaldaean Oracles* influenced Gregory of Nazianzus' Trinitarian theology, J. Dillon, 'Logos and Trinity' (1989).

[175] See for example Greg. Nyss., *Ablab*. (GNO III/I, 56,3-10); *Comm. not*. (GNO III/I, 25,3-7); Greg. Naz., *Orat*. 40,43. This terminology can already be found in Basil (*CE* II 20).

[176] As I shall demonstrate subsequently, the term θεότης does not indicate an abstract reality, but rather is the equivalent, neither more nor less, of θεός, so it can be stated that the Father is the origin of the Trinitarian God.

[177] See the lengthy discussion in G. Maspero, *Essere e relazione* (2013), 141-65.

[178] The Aristotelian and Stoic origin of σχέσις has been discussed, in Gregory Nazianzen, by A. Richard, *Cosmologie et théologie* (2003), 201-10; it is mentioned in passing in A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's* (2018), 84-6; for Amphilochius see A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 333 n. 292.

relationship on the one hand encompasses cause, while on the other it indicates reciprocal inherency of the individual Persons.[179]

Evagrius

Evagrius' explanation is different. In *Epistula fidei* (Bas., *epist*. 8) he bases himself on Gregory Nazianzen's statement (*Orat*. 31,15),[180] who rejects the fact that the Christian Trinity might be compared to the theology of the best among the Greeks who, in their turn, asserted that there exists only one divine nature, namely, the genus, but numerous individuals, just like there exists only one human nature and numerous men (ἀνθρωπότης μία, τὸ γένος ἅπαν, ἀλλ'ὅμως θεοὶ πολλοὶ καὶ οὐχ εἷς). Indeed, Evagrius also says that God is one, but his unity is in his nature, not in his number: οὐ τῷ ἀριθμῷ, ἀλλὰ τῇ φύσει (ch. 2). He means that, among corporeal things, unity in number is only an abstraction, because what is considered one as a matter of fact is a multiplicity. For instance, the world, which is composed by many elements, is one in number but not in nature. Something similar can be said of the human being, who is divided in body and soul, or angels, and so on. God is quite different, because God is one in his nature. Therefore, nobody can accuse the Christians of worshipping three gods, because they do not say that God is one in number. Number, indeed, involves quantity (τὸ ποσόν), and quantity is inseparable from bodies, as number is typical of matter (this is an old tenet from Pythagorean and Platonic philosophy). Μονάς and ἑνάς manifest the simple and unlimited nature of God,[181] although Evagrius does not explain how he conceives the relation between the one God and the three Persons, as Gregory had done.[182]

Against Tritheism: Divine Unity and Monarchy

The dispute with tritheism prompted Gregory of Nazianzus to clarify the concept of 'monarchy': if he is the origin of the Son and the Holy Spirit, for this

[179] Thus, and rightly so, G. Maspero, *Essere e relazione* (2013), 141-4. The metaphysical meaning of the relationship among the divine Persons is not accepted by M. Edwards, *Aristotle and Early Christian Thought* (2019), 109-10, which attributes a merely logical meaning to σχέσις, that is, a way of knowing things, and not a way of being for things, in conformity with Porphyry's doctrine.

[180] Gregory follows Basil's *De Spiritu Sancto* (18,45).

[181] Μονάς also in Gregory's *Orat*. 6,22 and *Arcana* 3,74. Already in Basil, *CE* III 6, PG 668CD, and also subsequently Gregory Nyssen, it means that God's nature is not compound but 'unified in itself and not divided (αὐτὴ πρὸς ἑαυτὴν ἡνωμένη καὶ ἀδιάτμητος)' (*Ablab*. GNO III/1, 41,3).

[182] These observations take up and develop my previous ones (Cl. Moreschini. 'Is it Possible to Speak' [2018], 139-64); while that article was at the proof stage, the following was published: B.E. Daley, 'Evagrius and Cappadocian Orthodoxy' (2016), which arrives at the same conclusion as I do, adding a further passage by Evagrius (*KG* VI 10-13).

reason does the Father also possess 'monarchy'?[183] Is the origin of the hypostasis the Father or the divine nature? Is the Father both divine nature and hypostasis?[184]

First of all, the concept of monarchy is above and beyond the number, and thus does not imply tritheism:

> Monarchy is not that which is delimited by one person, because it is possible that even a single reality may become a multiplicity, if it is discordant within; the monarchy of which we speak is constituted by the equal dignity of the nature (of its constituents), agreement of will and identity of movement, by the simultaneous tending to unity on the part of those that come from it (πρὸς τὸ ἓν τῶν ἐξ αὐτοῦ σύννευσις), which is impossible for a nature that undergoes becoming,[185] so that, despite differing in number, the monarchy is not truncated in its substance (*Orat*. 29,2).

Considering this passage, together with *Orat*. 31,14, Cross stated that Gregory ascribes the prerogative of the monarchy to the divine substance, which is considered to be common to the three Persons and a universal, in which the Persons are the particulars. Cross observes that Gregory never uses the term 'monarchy' to determine only the Father's activity, but rather to oppose polytheism with the Trinity both in *Orat*. 29,2 (the passage just cited) and in *Orat*. 31,14 (see also *Orat*. 39,8 and 40,41).[186] Yet, *Orat*. 29,2 says exactly the opposite. It does not say what Cross maintains, namely, that if the Son and the Holy Spirit proceed from the Father, this means that God's being is intrinsically relational, and thus the Father does not produce the Son and the Holy Spirit. Nor does it say what Cross concludes, namely, that the causal priority does not belong to the Father and that, to refute the Eunomians' objection, Gregory upholds the indivisibility of divine substance, considering it coordinatively shared among all three Persons. But as I am not persuaded that divine substance is a logical concept, for the same reason I do not think that divine monarchy is not the prerogative of the Father, since he is the source of the existence of the Son and of the Holy Spirit (and I think that the concept of 'monarchy' should not be overly emphasized, as, in my opinion, it is more a metaphor than a doctrine).[187] Indicating in a non-personal way, but with the neutral 'the simultaneous tending

[183] The concept of divine monarchy had been introduced by Apollinaris of Laodicea, if indeed the fourth book of *Contra Arianos* by Athanasius can be attributed to him (cf. IV 1, 44,4 ss. S.), in a dispute with Eusebius of Caesarea, M. Vinzent, 'Pseudo Athanasius, *Oratio contra Arianos IV*' (2015), 67.

[184] The *status quaestionis* has been outlined by Chr. Beeley, 'Divine Causality' (2007), 199-204.

[185] As the meaning suggests, I prefer to read γενητῆς with a manuscript family, instead of γεννητῆς, with other manuscripts and the last editor, Paul Gallay.

[186] R. Cross, 'Divine Monarchy' (2006), 107-10.

[187] See also J. Meyendorff, *Byzantine Theology* (1974), 183; J. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 294 n. 352; 296 and 296 n. 355; 305-6 and 306 n. 396 (on *Orat*. 31,14); Chr. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 201-17.

to unity on the part of those that come from it (πρὸς τὸ ἓν τῶν ἐξ αὐτοῦ σύννευσις)' does not indicate that the tending of the divine Persons, which elsewhere Gregory defines with the neutral (τὰ τρία), should be understood on the logical level rather than the ontological one.[188] According to Gregory, the Persons derive from unity, which is the Father, 'so that, despite differing in number, the monarchy is not truncated in its substance'. Here too 'monarchy' is the Father, who is not truncated in *his* substance'; and if immediately after an enlargement is mentioned of the μονάς in the δυάς, ending in the τριάς, the reasoning is certainly abstract, but it does not imply that there is a derivation of the Three from one preceding divine substance. The neutral does not mean that Gregory is speaking of the relationship between the universal and the particular: it also appears in *Orat*. 20,6: 'Do not reduce everything to a μία ὑπόστασις for fear of introducing a multiplicity of gods; do not reduce τὰ πάντα to ἕν'. Τὰ ἐξ αὐτοῦ in *Orat*. 29,2 and τὰ πάντα in *Orat*. 20,6 are the Persons, which come from the one reality, which is the Father: with the same meaning, ἕν is unity, which is the Father, and τὰ ἐν οἷς ἡ θεότης (*Orat*. 31,14) are the three Persons 'in whom lies' the divine nature in a communion of glory, so that they are the three objects of our adoration. There are other occasions when Gregory Nazianzen indicates the divine Persons with abstract formulae: 'the divinity is one in three, and the three are one – those three in whom the divinity exists, or to put it more accurately, who are the divinity (ἓν γὰρ ἐν τρισὶν ἡ θεότης, καὶ τὰ τρία ἕν, τὰ ἐν οἷς ἡ θεότης, ἤ, τό γε ἀκριβέστερον εἰπεῖν, ἃ ἡ θεότης)' (*Orat*. 39,11).[189] Thus, the statement in *Orat*. 31,14 says: 'If we consider the divine nature, the first cause (πρώτη αἰτία) and divine monarchy, we can apprehend the ἕν': 'divine monarchy', is the monarchy of the Father.

Nazianzen tried to highlight, as few succeeded in doing before him, what exactly the unity of nature within the Trinity consists of, and above all the simultaneous returning to the origin – that is, the Father – on the part of the other two Persons, who originated from him:

> The single nature is firmly established in three lights. It is not a unity unrelated to number, since it consists in three excellent forms. Nor is it a Trinity to be worshipped as plural, since its nature is indivisible. The oneness inheres in Godhead; those to whom Godhead belongs are three in number. Each of them is the one God, when you mention only one. Again, the one God is unoriginated, whence comes the rich quality of Godhead, when there is any reference to three (*Arcana* 3,71-77).

In *Orat*. 39,12 Gregory states that the Pauline formulae in *Rom*. 11:36 ('For from him and through him and to him are all things') and 1*Cor*. 8:6 ('for us

[188] This was also stated by Beeley, although in a Christological context: Gregory Nazianzen uses εἷς or ἕν indifferently, 'Gregory of Nazianzus on the Unity of Christ' (2008), 108-9; in any case see A. Hofer, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 94-5.

[189] Trans. B.E. Daley.

there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things, and one Lord Jesus Christ, through whom are all things') correspond to each other, and to highlight the correspondence he adds a third member to the formula in 1*Cor*. 8:6, so that it may also contain the Holy Spirit ('and one Holy Spirit, in whom are all things'). The three members of the formula do not divide their individual natures – for then there could be no change of prepositions or of the order of the words[190] – but rather express the peculiar characteristics of one unconfused nature'. In *Orat*. 42,15 as well, delivered to mark an important occasion after having presided over the council of Constantinople, Gregory, once again adopting *Rom*. 11:36, states that the Father is the union of the Trinity, and it is from Him that the other two Persons come and to Him that they return, who are not confused with the first Person, but united; nor are they divided by time or by will. This, indeed, is a crucial point in Gregory Nazianzen's Trinitarian theology: *the Father is the origin*, and it is in this that divine monarchy lies, so that the Son and the Holy Spirit, who derive from the Father each with their own relationship, constantly tend to return to unity, instead of proceeding towards further differentiation.[191]

From Monad to Triad

Once the divine monarchy had been established, Nazianzen tries to explain the origin of the Persons from the Father:

The perfect Trinity, made up of three perfect realities, in the sense that the monad[192] proceeded forth on account of the abundance (of its divine nature) (μονάδος μὲν κινηθείσης διὰ τὸ πλούσιον), then it moved beyond the dyad (in fact, it is above and beyond matter and form, from which derive bodies), and consequently is defined as a triad on

[190] These words of Gregory's are unclear, despite B.E. Daley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2006), 233 n. 494 explaining: 'if the Persons were in fact different in their being, presumably these expressions of relationship would be more fixed', that is, they could not have been altered.

[191] My conclusion aligns with that of J.A. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 306-7 and Chr. Beeley, 'Divine Causality' (2007), 211-4, even though Beeley advances a partially different explanation. In fact, as S. Coakley, 'Introduction – Gender' (2003), 4, states, the problem as to how the Father can be both substance and Person does not exist because the trinitarian persons are neither prototypes of Enlightenment 'individualism' *nor* exemplars of a 'personalism' that somehow precedes and transcends 'substance' (a false disjunction)'; Chr. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 205 also rightly notes: 'it is the special property of the Father to be both the source of himself – in the sense that he is self-existent Divinity […] – and the source of the Son and the Holy Spirit, and thus the cause and source of the Trinity as a whole'; and is also against the distinction 'personalism – essentialism' (*ibid*. 212); and previously also André de Halleux, 'Personnalisme ou essentialisme trinitaire' (1990), 215-6.

[192] Mossay's translation is erroneous: 'une monade étant à exclure à cause de la richesse de la réalité, une dyade étant depassée'. I here interpret κινηθείσης as in *Orat*. 29,2 and I suppose that the sentence: 'in fact … derive bodies' is an interpolation, because it has nothing to do with the problem.

account of its perfection. Given that it is primary, it indeed goes beyond the composition of the dyad, so that the divine nature may not be restricted, nor yet that it might spill over limitless (εἰς ἄπειρον χέηται) (*Orat*. 23,8).

Gregory is dealing here, therefore, with an expansion of the Father's nature, manifested in the two verbs, κινέω and χέω. The verb χέω ('spill over') means the effusion of the divine nature of the Trinity:

And when I say the word 'God', I mean Father, and Son and Holy Spirit, because the divine nature *does not spill over* (χεομένης), lest we introduce a whole crowd of gods, nor as held within limits short of them, lest we be accused of being stingy with divinity – speaking like Jews by emphasizing the divine monarchy,[193] or speaking like Greeks by emphasizing the divine abundance! (*Orat*. 38,8).[194]

In *Orat*. 29,2 Gregory presents the same formula: 'for this reason, from the beginning the monad *proceeded forth towards* (κινηθεῖσα) the dyad and stopped at the triad. And this means the Father, Son and Holy Spirit'. Here the process of expansion of the divine substance, expressed in *Orat*. 38,8 by means of the verb 'spill over' (χέω), is indicated by the verb 'move' (κινέω), as in *Orat*. 23,8. The reason for this change is due to the fact that Gregory saw that 'spill over' is not fitting in this issue; in actual fact it is quite ambiguous, because it was used in pagan philosophy. In fact, Plotinus had spoken of the 'overflowing (ὑπέρχυσις) of goodness' in a passage dedicated to the doctrine of the first principles (V 1,6): ὑπέρχυσις is quite near to χέω. Gregory refused to accept Plotinus' doctrine and therefore also rejected the verb that was associated with it:

For we shall not venture to speak of 'an overflow of goodness' (ὑπέρχυσιν ἀγαθότητος), as one of the Greek Philosophers dared to say, as if it were a bowl overflowing, and this in plain words in his Discourse on the First and Second Causes.[195] Let us not ever look on this Generation as unwanted (ἀκούσιον), like some natural overflow,

[193] In this passage the term 'monarchy' has a more general meaning, similar to that of 'monotheism', and it does not regard the relationships among the divine Persons (so it has nothing to do with the issue of whether the divinity is the Father or a divine substance, as mentioned above).

[194] Trans. Daley with modifications.

[195] Gregory states that this word can be found in the treatise "on the First and Second Causes", a title which is close to that of the Arabic version of Plotinus (*Theologia Aristotelis* X 10: 'The first cause and the things that originate from it'), whereas the Greek title in Porphyry's edition sounds περὶ γενέσεως καὶ τάξεως τῶν μετὰ τὸ πρῶτον (see Henry and Schwyzer' edition). It is possible, therefore, that Gregory was acquainted not with Porphyry's edition, but with an alternative one, which is preserved in the Arabic text. See Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 51. That this passage demonstrates the dependence of Gregory's theology on Plotinus was noted already by Dräseke and posited also by J. Rist, 'Basil's Neoplatonism' (1981), 215-6, but rejected by Moreschini (*ibid*. 52-3). Jean Reynard, 'Plato's *Parmenides* among the Cappadocian Fathers' (2013) and K. Corrigan, 'The Importance of the *Parmenides*' (2013) are superficial and uninformed regarding the issue.

hard to be retained (δυσκαθεκτον), and by no means befitting our conception of Deity (*Orat*. 29,2).

Gregory most likely took the simile of the 'bowl' from Plato (*Timaeus* 41d);[196] yet 'the Greek philosopher' who properly spoke of the overflow of goodness was not Plato, but Plotinus (V 2,1):[197]

This, we may say, is the first act of generation: the One, perfect because it seeks nothing, has nothing, and needs nothing, overflows, as it were, and its superabundance makes something other than itself (ὂν γὰρ τέλειον τῷ μηδὲν ζητεῖν μηδὲ ἔχειν μηδὲ δεῖσθαι, οἷον ὑπερερρύη καὶ τὸ ὑπερπλῆρες αὐτοῦ πεποίηκεν ἄλλο).

It is probable that here Nazianzen confuses Plotinus with Plato, assigning to the former the image of the bowl which had been employed by the latter: he did not quote another unknown platonic philosopher, as has been supposed. Nyssen asserts the same: 'For they are one (the Father and the Son), and the one is observed in the other, neither exceeding nor falling short (οὐχ ὑπερπῖπτον, οὐκ ἐλαττούμενον), and not changed or altered in any divine and good feature' (*CE* III 1,65). 'Neither exceeding nor falling short' means the derivation of the divine Persons from the Father, who is their source.[198]

Did the Father Want to Generate the Son?

Since the generation of the Son is not the product of the overflow of goodness of the Father, and as a consequence unwanted, did the Father generate the Son because he wanted to?[199] This is impossible, because if it had been so,

[196] The 'bowl' of *Oration* 29 (which was wrongly attributed to Plotinus by Nazianzen) may have been taken from the *Chaldaean Oracles*, which Gregory knew thanks to Porphyry, who commented on them, according to Ruth Majercik, 'A reminiscence of the *Chaldaean Oracles*' (1998). Yet, I think that it is sound to maintain the hypothesis of a derivation from Plotinus, who is indicated as one of 'the Greek *philosophers*' – not a composer of *logia*, the so-called 'Chaldaean Oracles'; furthermore, Plotinus was known to the Cappadocians, while *Oracula Chaldaica* were not (even though Nazianzen was familiar with a pagan oracle and cites it in *Carm*. II 2,7, 253-5, observing ironically that Apollo's ability to predict the future came to an end with the coming of Christ, who is the true source of knowledge of the future).

[197] This parallel between Gregory of Nazianzus and Plotinus had already been found by Henry and Schwyzer in their edition of Plotinus.

[198] It has been observed that the adjective 'unwanted' (ἀκούσιον) (*Orat*. 29,2) is an addition by Gregory that does not perfectly grasp Plotinus' thought, according to whom the overflowing of the One is a necessity of nature or superior to nature, A. Richard, *Cosmologie et théologie* (2003), 418-20.

[199] This seems to have been Meijering's (wrong) interpretation, E.B. Meijering, 'The Doctrine of the Will and of the Trinity' (1975), 105: Gregory of Nazianzus does not accept Plotinus' doctrine of a generation which implies a contradiction to the will of the Father; more in Meijering's book and its inclusion of Origen and Athanasius (*ibid*. 103-13). Meijering is rightly criticized by M.R. Barnes, 'Eunomius of Cyzicus' (1998), 82 n. 93; 84 n. 99. Further discussion of the problem in M.R. Barnes, *The Power of God* (2001), 245 n. 96.

there would have been a moment or an intermediate reality (the will) between the reality of the Father and the generation of the Son.[200] In his explanation Gregory distinguishes between the will and whoever is willing and, ultimately, even if cautiously, he puts forward another solution: 'What belongs to God transcends even all these cases. For him begetting *perhaps* entails the will to beget; however, there is nothing in the middle (between the will and the generation), if we accept this explanation in its entirety, but it must be ascertained whether generation[201] is superior to will' (*Orat*. 29,6). That the Father does not generate the Son as a consequence of his will is stated also in *Arcana* 2,26-7: 'For what is prior to God, be it time or will, is to me a division of Godhead (ὃ γὰρ πάρος ἐστὶ Θεοῖο / ἢ χρόνος ἠὲ θέλησις, ἐμοὶ τμῆξις θεότητος)'.[202]

It may be that Gregory has come up against an *impasse*: if the Son was generated by the Father's will (even if outside of time), this means that the Son is a creature; but if the generation is above and beyond will, that is, if will is excluded, the generation of the Son appears to be a 'mechanical phenomenon', an overflow 'hard to be retained (ἀκούσιον)', as Plotinus suggested, which was also unacceptable.[203] For this reason the generation is as natural as the will to generate, that is, the will is intrinsic to the Father's nature, and therefore 'the generation is superior to the will'.[204] In this way Nazianzen somehow corrects Origen's assertion that the Father's very intention is sufficient to bring the Son into existence, although Origen did not state as well that the will is separate from the Father: *sicut voluntas procedit e mente neque partem aliquam mentis secat neque ab ea separatur aut dividitur, tali quadam specie putandum est Pater Filium genuisse, imaginem scilicet suam* (*Princ*. I 2,6).

Excluding the Father's will means excluding every διάστημα within the divine nature: in this way Gregory responds to the charge coming from the Eunomians and the Nicenes, that the generation of the Son meant a

[200] E.P. Meijering, 'The Doctrine of the Will' (1975), 112 n. 43; Fr.W. Norris, with a translation by L. Wickham and Fr. Williams, *Faith Gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991), 45 and 198.

[201] This is the translation I suggest for the Greek text: ἀλλ' οὐδὲν μέσον, εἴγε καὶ τοῦτο δεξόμεθα ὅλως, ἀλλὰ μὴν καὶ θελήσεως κρείττων ἡ γέννησις. Gallay translates: 'si nous admettons totalement cette idée et si la génération n'est pas supérieure à la volonté', which to me seems to contradict Gregory's line of thought. A scribe of one of Gregory's best manuscripts (A: Ambrosianus E 49-50 inf. gr. 1014, 9th century) had already grasped the difficulty and corrected ἀλλὰ μὴ to ἀλλὰ μήν, and I have gone along with this correction.

[202] My translation. The problem is also tackled by Athanasius (*CE* III 61-2), who was followed by Ambrose (*Fid*. IV 9,102-6), as Anne Richard observes, *Cosmologie et théologie* (2003), 416-8.

[203] Above all, the central idea of Plotinus' philosophy seemed unacceptable to the Cappadocians, namely that the production of the hypostaseis determined their ontological inferiority.

[204] The Father's generation of the Son does not proceed from a natural basis (the *ousia* or divine essence), but from his personal relation, 'His Fatherhood', J.A. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 291 n. 336.

διάστημα.[205] Gregory Nyssen also denies the existence of a διάστημα in the generation of the Son (*Ablab.* 51,18-21; 52,1-2; *CE* I 533: οὐ χρονικῷ τινι διαστήματι τοῦ γεννητοῦ φωτὸς ἀποτεμνόμενον, ἀλλὰ δι'αὐτοῦ μὲν ἐκλάμπον, τὴν δὲ τῆς ὑποστάσεως αἰτίαν ἔχον ἐκ τοῦ πρωτοτύπου φωτός) and rejects the hypothesis that the Father's will was necessary for the generation of the Son, as if this implied some movement on the part of the Father:[206]

If (to take a hypothetical example) someone were to give a flame the power of free choice, it would be clear that the flame would wish, along with existing, also to emit light from itself, and having willed it would surely not lack the power, since its natural power would accomplish the purpose with the light at the same time as constituting the flame; for undeniably, if it were granted to it to start the flame deliberately, it would encompass the combination of all together, the kindling of the fire, willing the light, and the light itself, since the movement of free will would in no way impede the instant existence of the light. In the same way, just as in the example provided, if you also grant to the Father the will for good, you cannot separate the Son from the Father by that act of will (οὕτως … καὶ τῷ πατρὶ τὸ ἀγαθὸν θέλημα συνομολογῶν οὐκ ἀποστήσεις διὰ τοῦ θελήματος τοῦ πατρὸς τὸν υἱόν) (*CE* III 6,19-20).

Therefore, the Father's will is (we might say) 'obliged' by His very nature. Just as, according to Plotinus, the One's generation was determined by his seeking and having nothing, the generation of the Son is produced by the perfection and sufficiency of the Father, who could not, as such, but generate. The overflowing of goodness has its effects only *ad extra*, that is outside the Divinity, not *ad intra*, in generating the Son or in 'producing' the Holy Spirit.[207] As he found that the verb χεθῆναι did not fit the generation of the Son, Gregory used it to express the irradiation *ad extra* of the divine nature, in accordance with the principle *bonum est diffusivum sui*:

And since it was not enough for Goodness to be set in motion simply by contemplating itself,[208] but the good needed to be *spilled over* (χεθῆναι) and issue forth, so that there might be a greater number of beings that might partake of its benefits (this, in fact, is proper to the highest Good), it first thought of the angelic, heavenly powers' (*Orat.* 38,9).[209]

The same idea and the same verb in *Orat.* 40,5: 'light that spills over (χεόμενον) but a little onto the realities that lie outside of it'; similarly: πηγάζων θεότητα

[205] See Aetius, *Syntagmation*, in Epiph., *Panarion* 76,11,3; also Eun., *Apol.* 10,1-17; 22,1-15.
[206] Cf. M.R. Barnes, 'Eunomius of Cyzicus' (1998), 84-5.
[207] This interpretation of the two passages that are connected to each other (*Orat.* 29,2 and 38,9) had already been advanced by Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letteratura* (1997), 52-3.
[208] About the Aristotelian 'contemplation of itself', see *Arcana* 4,64.
[209] Trans. Daley, with modifications.

('God poured forth from His[210] source his own Godhead') (*Arcana* 4,81);[211] God is πηγὴ φάεων (*Arcana* 6,8).

The Origin of the Holy Spirit

The confutation of tritheism allowed the Cappadocians to explain not only the generation of the Son, but also the procession of the Spirit, Who is inextricably united with the Father and the Son.[212] Basil had discussed the question of the Holy Spirit briefly in the third book of the *Contra Eunomium*, where he had not investigated the problem of His origin from the Father.[213] He explains that the Fathers in Nicaea did not discuss in detail the nature and origin of the Spirit because that problem had not yet arisen, but that in any case we must follow the formula of faith of Nicaea, which places the Holy Spirit as the third in the symbol.[214] Being third in the order in the symbol of faith does not mean being third in the order of nature, as Eunomius would have it.[215] In the following years Basil included the Spirit in the 'one substance – three hypostases' scheme. In *Epistle* 125, which contains the symbol of faith jointly espoused by Eustathius and Basil, it is stated that the Spirit is not extraneous (ἀλλότριον) to the divine nature and the baptismal formula shows that He is not separate from the Father and the Son (125,2-3).[216] The Spirit is neither ungendered, because only the Father is ungendered, nor generated, because only the Son is generated, 'and having been taught that the Spirit of Truth proceeds from the Father (ἐκ τοῦ Πατρὸς ἐκπορεύεσθαι), we confess Him to be from God without any act of

[210] I do not agree with D.A. Sykes' translation 'its', and I am not convinced by the explanation he provides: 'God, as the source of divinity, graciously allows it to gush forth', St. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana* (1997), 168.

[211] Regarding the concepts of ἀρχή and πηγή in the theology of Gregory and of the Neo-Platonists see Ugo Criscuolo, 'Interferenze fra neoplatonismo e teologia cristiana' (2005). D.A. Sykes, St. Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana* (1997), 168-9 observes that the verb πηγάζω would later be frequently used by Proclus.

[212] Apollinaris had already stated that the Holy Spirit is God, see K. McCarthy Spoerl, 'Apollinarius on the Holy Spirit' (2001), 573; however Gregory Nazianzen rebutted Apollinaris, because (he asserts) the latter had instituted a gradation within the divinity (*Epist*. 101,66).

[213] The problems discussed from here until the end of the chapter are those relating to the origin of the Spirit, in accordance with what is discussed in this context; we do not deal fully with Cappadocian pneumatology; in our opinion the most profound and stimulating discussion is that of Christopher Beeley, 'The Holy Spirit in the Cappadocians' (2010).

[214] This doctrine of faith had also been taught to him by his family, he said (*Epist*. 223,3).

[215] On the subject, which of course has a very extensive bibliography since the time of Karl Holl's study, see the explanation given by V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung der Trinitätslehre* (1996), 130-43, on *CE* III and 183-224, on *De Spiritu sancto*. In fact, Basil also repeated this consideration in *De Spiritu sancto* (18,44).

[216] *Epistle* 125 is of 373: as early as 362, Gregory Nazianzen had clearly stated the origin of the Spirit as πρόοδος; but he did not have, in 373, and still less in 362, the authority that Basil, the Bishop of Caesarea, had.

creation (ἐκ τοῦ Θεοῦ εἶναι ἀκτίστως)'. The origin of the Spirit of Truth is to 'proceed' from the Father, and consequently to derive from God without having been created. The term 'to proceed' (ἐκπορεύεσθαι), taken from *John* 15:26, which seems to be used here for the first time by Basil to indicate the origin of the Spirit, immediately became canonical: Gregory Nazianzen uses it considering it the term that best indicates the origin of the Spirit from the Father, distinct from that of the Son, which occurs by generation. However, Basil could not explain how procession differs from generation: also subsequently he was uncertain on this point, while Gregory Nazianzen faced the issue in a more decisive way, resorting to the image we have seen above, of the conjunction of three suns. In *Epistle* 105 Basil states (as later in *De Spiritu sancto* and as Gregory of Nyssa repeated) that the Holy Spirit exists, since He comes from God (ἐκ Θεοῦ ὑπάρχον), He is the source of the holiness and power that gives life; He is totally united with the Father and the Son (συνημμένον Πατρὶ καὶ Υἱῷ κατὰ πάντα), an affirmation repeated in *Epist*. 226,3. Basil later stated (*Epist*. 159,2) that the Holy Spirit, 'glorified together' (συνδοξαζόμενον) with the Father and the Son, as a participant in the same honour, cannot be considered extraneous to their nature: the concept of the 'equality of honour' of the Spirit, which should be proof of His divine nature, became the *Leit-motiv* of Basil's pneumatology and was taken up in the Constantinopolitan symbol. Within the unique divine οὐσία there are three distinct hypostaseis, characterized by specific peculiarities (ἰδιότητες): the 'paternal condition' (πατρότης) and the 'filial condition' (υἱότης), as Basil had already said in *CE* II 12 and 28; a specific peculiarity must also be found for the Spirit, parallel to that of the other two Persons (*Epist*. 214,4).[217] However Basil fails to indicate what this peculiarity is, so he confines himself to underlining the sanctifying power of the Spirit.

In *De Spiritu sancto*, Basil repeats that the Spirit proceeds from the Father and God, not in the way of generation (γεννητῶς), like the Son, but as a spirit of His mouth (πνεῦμα στόματος αὐτοῦ) (*Psalm* 32:6) (16,38 and 18,46). Therefore, the Son and the Spirit come from the Father in a distinct way; the Spirit comes from the Son exactly as He comes from the Father (ἐκ τοῦ θεοῦ προελθόν) but the way of His existence (τρόπος τῆς ὑπάρξεως) remains inexpressible (18,46).[218] Basil tried to clarify what he had left undefined in *Epistle* 214: 'And as Paraclete He expresses in Himself the goodness of the Paraclete Who

[217] According to R. Hübner (*Kirche und Dogma* [2017], 362 n. 3), Basil, in *Epist*. 214,4, had already implicitly also referred consubstantiality to the third Person. However, Gregory Nazianzen did not share this opinion: he wants to be the one to affirm openly the consubstantiality of the Spirit at the beginning of homily 31.

[218] This part of the *De Spiritu sancto*, as is known, is an area of controversy as regards the origin of the 'Filioque'. However, this problem does not interest us; without addressing the enormous bibliography, see, on Basil, the discussion of Pruche (Basile de Césarée, *Sur le Saint-Esprit* [1968], 208-11) and, more recently, Cl. Moreschini, 'Osservazioni sulla pneumatologia dei Cappadoci' (2015).

sent Him, and in His own dignity manifests the majesty of Him from Whom He proceeded (τὴν μεγαλοσύνην τοῦ ὅθεν προῆλθεν)' (*ibid.*). The Spirit of knowledge is inseparable from the vision of God, because He gives the strength to see the image of the Father to those who wish to contemplate the Truth: 'and no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost' (1*Cor*. 12:3), and this knowledge procured by the Spirit is confirmed by *Psal*. 35(36):9 (fundamental in Cappadocian pneumatology): 'in thy light shall we see light' (18,47). The path of the knowledge of God begins with the Spirit, Who is one, and through the Son, Who is one, reaches the Father, Who is one; in the opposite path, natural goodness and sanctification according to nature and royal dignity spread (διήκει) from the (ἐκ) the Father, through (διά) the Only Begotten, to the (ἐπί) Spirit. The Spirit is holy in substance and the source of sanctification, therefore he is not a creature (*ibid.*).[219] In the *hom. in Psalm.* 33,4 (PG 29, 333A) Basil argues with those who deny the divinity of the Spirit and separate him from the creative power and from the union with the Father and the Son. True subsistence (ὑπόστασις) must be attributed to him (333B).

In conclusion, Basil proposes a twofold relationship of the Spirit: He is the Spirit of the Son and comes from the Father, Who is the source of the divine nature; the divinity of the Spirit certainly falls within the dogma, but how His 'proceeding', His 'coming' from the Father should be understood remains uncertain.

The *status quaestionis* that the Nyssen discusses is no different from the one Basil had had to discuss, that is, the divinity of the Spirit, contested by the Pneumatomachians.[220] Consequently the Nyssen's pneumatology is a continuation and a reworking of Basil's and different from the Nazianzen's, even if the Nyssen paid more attention to the problem of tritheism than Basil had done.[221]

Epistle 125, signed both by Basil and Eustathius, had perhaps had the meaning of a 'manifesto', almost a dogmatic epistle for their followers: therefore the Nyssen also states that the Spirit cannot be confused either with the Father according to the property of having been ungendered or with the Son according to the property of being Only Begotten, but must be considered in and of Himself, according to some of His peculiar properties. The affirmation that the Spirit has equal honour (ὁμοτιμία) with the other two Persons (Greg. Nyss., *Maced*. 95,5-9) and that divine nature originates from the Father (ἐκ) and reaches (ἐπί) the Spirit through (διά) the Son (*Maced.*; GNO III/I, 100,9-11)

[219] Ch. 18 was strongly influenced by Apollinaris, according to R. Hübner, *Die Schrift des Apolinarios* (1989), 10-1.

[220] See A. Meredith, 'The Pneumatology of the Cappadocian Fathers' (1981); A. Radde-Gallwitz, '*Ad Eustathium de Sancta Trinitate*' (2011), 100-1. Nyssen is defined as 'Basil's heir' by A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 15-7.

[221] On the Nyssen's pneumatology see also G. Maspero, 'The Fire, the Kingdom and the Glory' (2011); *id*., *Dio è trino perché vivo* (2018).

also derives from Basil's *De Spiritu sancto* (6,15; 17,42).[222] The three prepositions (ἐκ – διά – ἐπί) of doxology are connected with the condition of the individual divine Persons, as was said by Basil (*Spir. sanct.* 16,38) and is repeated by Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat.* 39,12). Consequently, divine grace proceeds from the Father through the Son and the Spirit and reaches those who are worthy of it and are sanctified by the Spirit (*Maced.* 106,5-8; 30-2). This statement also derives from Basil's (*Spir. sanct.* 18,47): 'the natural Goodness and the inherent Holiness and the royal Dignity extend from the Father through the Only-begotten to the Spirit'.[223] Therefore, the Father is the origin of goodness, sanctification, royal dignity: these qualities reach the Spirit through the Son, of Whom both Basil and Nyssen underline the mediating function within the divine nature. The Son is the mediator and the Spirit perfects (*Ablab.*; GNO III/I, 47,21-48,8), and also Gregory Nazianzen says that the thought of the Father 'was an action, brought to fullfillment in the Word and made perfect in the Spirit' (*Orat.* 38,9). The Nyssen states, as Basil had already done in *Contra Eunomium* and in *De Spiritu sancto*, that the dignity of the Holy Spirit cannot be eliminated only because the Spirit was numbered by the word of God after the Father and the Son (*Maced.* 93,3-14). Also when discussing the problem of numbering, Nyssen follows Basil, who had maintained (*Spir. sanct.* 17,41-43) that it was also necessary to 'connumerate' (συναριθμεῖν) the Spirit with the other two Persons,[224] rejecting the doctrine of the Pneumatomachians, to 'subnumerate' (ὑπαριθμεῖν) the Spirit, that is, enumerating the Spirit together with the Father and the Son, but placing Him on a lower plane. Whoever welcomes the Spirit sees in him the glory of the Only Begotten (*Maced.* 110,24-30); if he sees the Son he also sees the image of the One Who is invisible[225] and through the image he has the archetype in his mind (*ibid.* 107,9-16).[226]

[222] This is the formula of the Nyssen's pneumatology: 'through (the Son)' is in *John* 1:6 and 'in the Spirit' in 1*Cor.* 12:3, and also in Apollinaris, *KMP* 4. On this formula, see M.-O. Boulnois, 'Le cercle des glorifications mutuelles' (2008), 29. There are more problems with the formula in *Orat.* GNO VII/II, 42,14-43,15 Callahan, which states that the Spirit comes from 'the Son' (ἐκ τοῦ) (the text is contested, because it was interpreted as a confirmation of the *Filioque*, however it is attested in a very ancient age). In the passage from *De oratione* there are other similar formulas, but, as we said, the problem of the *Filioque* cannot be dealt with here. According to Panagopoulos, in the Nyssen's early works, like *De dominica oratione*, in which there is the term in question, the origin of the Spirit from the Father is indicated with ἐκ, without the use of the technical term ἐκπόρευσις, G.D. Panagopoulos, 'Die Vermittlung des Sohnes beim Ewigen Ausgang des Heiligen Geistes' (2011), 388. In fact, ἐκπόρευσις and similar terms seem more typical of the Nazianzen than of the Nyssen; however, as has been seen, Basil also knew them.

[223] Trans. Ph. Schaff.

[224] The term συναριθμεῖν is also in Apollinaris, *KMP* 8.

[225] E. Mühlenberg, *Die Unendlichkeit Gottes bei Gregor von Nyssa* (1966), 134 n. 1 had proposed correcting ἀοράτου in Müller's text to ἀορίστου, but 'invisible' is confirmed in passages from Basil (see the following note) and is used in *Col.* 1:15.

[226] See again Bas., *Spir. sanct.* 9,23: The Paraclete, 'like the sun, will by the aid of thy purified eye show thee in Himself the image of the invisible, and in the blessed spectacle of the image thou

As for the origin of the Son, so too for the Spirit, the Nyssen resorts to the doctrine that the Father's δύναμις develops hypostatising itself in the other two Persons. He states (*Maced*. 100,1-3) that 'the source of power is the Father, and the power of the Father is the Son (1*Cor*. 1:24) and the spirit of power is the Holy Spirit.' This union is confirmed by the example of the Son, Who is anointed to be King, and of the ointment, which is an instrument of anointing and is the Spirit, and therefore is inseparable from the One Who is anointed. The anointing and the One Who is anointed are understood in a hypostatic way and their connection means that there is no interval between the Son and the Spirit (*ibid*. 102,17-103,13),[227] in fact, the Spirit unites the Son with the Father (*Cant*. *hom*.; GNO VI, 467,2-17).[228] The Father cannot be conceived without the Son and the Son cannot be understood without the Spirit (*Maced*. 98,28-99,1).[229] As the generation of the Son is not produced by the will of the Father, but is inherent in His transcendent perfection (and this was also stated by Gregory Nazianzen), so the Spirit is inherent in the nature of the Father, Who is the source of the divine nature. The Spirit is closely united with the other two Persons, as is illustrated by the example of the three lamps which are lit going from the first to the third through the second, whereby also the third is fire like the other two (*Maced*. 93,1-10),[230] therefore the dignity of the Holy Spirit cannot be eliminated only because the Spirit was numbered after the Father and the Son (93,3-14). Also in *Refut*. 213 Gregory of Nyssa uses the

shalt behold the unspeakable beauty of the archetype'; *Epist*. 226,3: 'Our mind being enlightened by the Spirit looks up at the Son, and in Him as in an image beholds the Father'. As an image of the Son, Who in turn is an image of the Father, the Spirit is the creator in the same way as the Son, thanks to the unity of action with the other two Persons. That the Spirit is creator has also been affirmed by Athan., *Epist*. *Serap*. II 10 (which dates back to about fifteen years before the Nyssen's treatise) and taken up by Basil (*Hexaem*. II 6), who is followed by the Nyssen (*Hexaem*. 19). The latter, however, corrects this affirmation, reserving creation to the whole Trinity in the passage quoted several times from *Maced*. 99,29-100, G. Maspero 'The fire the Kingdom and the Glory' (2011), 247-9.

[227] On anointing as a characteristic of the action of the Spirit see G. Maspero, 'The Fire, the Kingdom and the Glory' (2011), 259-63: it is a means of surpassing 'the ontological ladder that unites God and the world' (*ibid*. 262); on the other terms which manifest the Spirit's perichoresis with the other two Persons see M.-O. Boulnois, 'Le cercle des glorifications mutuelles' (2008), 21-40. Andrew Radde-Gallwitz, instead, thinks that 'anointed' and 'anointing' are names that indicate the dignity of the Spirit (eternally donated by the Father to the Spirit), according to a long tradition dating back to Irenaeus, and in any case widespread in Gregory of Nyssa's environment, 'Pneumatology in Context: The Spirit as Anointing' (2011).

[228] See G. Maspero, 'The fire the Kingdom and the Glory' (2011), 268.

[229] See also Bas., *Spir*. *sanct*. 18,47.

[230] The image of the three lights explains the relationship between the three Persons: the first light is the cause (αἰτία), and the third is lit through (διά) the second, and so the Spirit originates from the Father through the Son. In *CE* I 532-4 the Nyssen also affirms the Son's position as intermediary between the Father and the Spirit (see K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* [1904], 213-5; M. Simonetti, *La crisi ariana* [1975], 499-500; G. Maspero, 'The Fire, the Kingdom and the Glory' [2011], 253-5).

image of fire and heat, analogous to that of the three lamps which light up from each other, which indicates the origin of the Son and the Spirit, and of the three suns joined together, which the Nazianzen had proposed.

The divine Persons are united in a reciprocal relationship of σχέσις (*Ablab*. 56,6-10), as the Nazianzen had also said.[231] If the hypostaseis are not different in nature, they are different in relation to the cause and the caused.[232] Within this difference there is still another difference. One (that is, the Son) derives immediately from the first while the other (the Spirit) derives through the one who derives immediately from the first, so that the Son has the prerogative of mediator, but does not prevent the Spirit from having a relationship of nature with the Father. And in any case, speaking of 'cause' and of 'that which derives from the cause', does not mean two different natures, but a difference in the way of being: the Son does not exist without a generation and the Spirit does not exist through a generation.[233] The cause, therefore, is the conceptual tool for distinguishing the divine Persons.

As has been said (p. 236), [Basil]'s *Epistle* 38 shows a highly developed pneumatology, probably not typical of Basil: the author of the epistle also considers the location of the Spirit within the divine Trinity especially from the point of view of the knowledge of Him which the faithful reach. The Spirit is closely united to the Son and is the Spirit of the Son, and the knowledge of the Son and of the Spirit are obtained thanks to each other: 'For the Son, by whom all things are, and with whom the Holy Spirit must always be conceived as inseparably associated, is of the Father. For it is impossible for a man, if he has not been previously enlightened by the Spirit, to arrive at a conception of the Son' (I, 84,19-22 Courtonne). As Nyssen had said that the Son is mediator between the Father and the Spirit, so the author of the epistle also states that the Son is placed between the Spirit and the Father as a sort of intermediary: this role belongs not only to the economy of salvation, but also to the eternal relationship that exists between the three Persons: 'Since, then, the Holy Spirit, from whom the entire supply of blessings gushes forth to creation, is united with (ἤρτηται) the Son and with Him is inseparably produced, He has His being attached to the Father as a cause, from whom indeed He proceeds' (85,23-9). The indissoluble union of the Spirit with the Son is always reaffirmed, in the sense that the Spirit is the Spirit of the Son: when we speak of the Spirit, we also mean at the same time the one of whom the Spirit is the Spirit: the Spirit is of Christ and comes from God, as Paul says (*Rom*. 8:9). All this would seem to confirm that *Epistle* 38 should be attributed to Nyssen.

[231] See above, p. 252; G. Maspero, *Essere e Relazione* (2013), 278-318; L. Karfíková, *Ad Ablabium* (2011), 157-8.

[232] The term 'cause' (αἰτία) indicates the Father, as the origin of the divine nature (cf. also *Graec*. 25,3-14). This terminology can be traced back to Basil (*CE* II 20). For further details, cf. *inter alios* M. Simonetti, *La crisi ariana* (1975), 471.

[233] This had also already been stated by Basil; Nyssen also in *CE* I 278.

In conclusion, Nyssen draws on the pneumatology of Basil's *De Spiritu sancto* including it in his conception of the δύναμις and the ἐνέργεια of God; instead, he uses the language of the procession quite rarely, which is characteristic of the Nazianzen, probably because he did not find it adequately expressed by the concept of δύναμις.[234]

Pneumatology had much greater importance for the Nazianzen than for Basil and the Nyssen. Gregory's path in tackling this problem was longer and much more tortuous than that of the other two Cappadocians and in the end he was unsuccessful, because his proposals were not accepted by the Council of Constantinople.[235] Beeley believes that Gregory contributed more to pneumatology than to Christology.[236]

Also for Nazianzen, Basil's *Epistle* 125 has the value of a 'dogmatic' authority. He also says that the Spirit came from the Father, Who is the source of the divine nature, but not in the manner of the Son, who is Only Begotten, so there must be a second way of 'deriving from', which is not that of generation. This manner is indicated by Scripture (*John* 15:26), and Gregory explains it with many other terms having a similar meaning: πρόοδος (*Orat*. 20,11; 23,7; 23,11; 25,16), πρόβλημα (*Orat*. 29,2), ἔκπεμψις (*Orat*. 25,16) and ἐκπόρευσις (*Orat*. 31,8); the Father is the προβολεύς of the Spirit (*Orat*. 23,7); the Spirit is προϊόν (*Orat*. 25,15; 26,19; 30,19; 39,12) or προελθόν (*Orat*. 25,15; 30,19); ἐκπορεύεται (*Orat*. 39,12) and is ἐκπορευτόν (*Orat*. 21,13; 42,17; 31,8) and ἐκπορευόμενον (*Orat*. 29,2). Nevertheless, these terms indicating the origin of the Spirit from the Father, despite their abundance and their variety, repeat the same concept and are closer to the letter of John's Gospel, while the concept implicit in the hypostatic (σχέσις) 'relationship' and the 'cause – caused' connection are newer, albeit less used.

Basil's *Contra Eunomium* did not influence Gregory's first orations, those of the Nazianzen's period, since *Contra Eunomium* was written later (364AD). A specific terminology for the Spirit had already been proposed by Gregory as early as his declaration of faith in the second oration, which was written in 362 and therefore before Basil's works: 'the Father is the beginning of the divine being, which is contemplated in the Son and in the Spirit: in the former, as Son and Logos, in the latter, as πρόοδος and indestructible Spirit' (*Orat*. 2,38). Gregory, therefore, is the first of the Cappadocians who asserts that the way in which the Holy Spirit originated is one of His own personal characteristics able to distinguish Him from the Son.[237] The word πρόοδος, similar in meaning to ἐκπόρευσις, and therefore justifiable, is used by the Nazianzen in a formular

[234] K. Holl, *Amphilochius von Ikonium* (1904), 213.
[235] See the different opinion of L. Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy* (2004), 258.
[236] Chr.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 153-4.
[237] *Ibid*. 153-66.

way, and, above all, with an ontological meaning even before Basil. In doxologies, which are more traditional, Gregory also includes the Spirit, together with the Father and the Son (*Orat*. 3,6); those of *Orat*. 8,23 and 9,6 comprise the formula 'with the Holy Spirit', which was known to Basil (cf. *De Spiritu sancto* 1,3).

The summary of the Trinitarian doctrine of *Orat*. 6,22 insists on the usual antinomy between Arius and Sabellius, which is contrasted with the true doctrine of the three real and distinct hypostaseis, even if it does not explain the derivation of the Spirit from the Father. Subsequently, in the profession of faith that Gregory proposed for the first time as bishop in 372 he underlined the presence of the Holy Spirit (*Orat*. 11,6): *Oration* 11 is pronounced in the presence of Basil, who cannot have been very pleased to hear a statement that was not in line with his pneumatology. That the problem was urgently felt by Gregory is attested by the well-known conclusion of *Oration* 12 (ch. 6): 'How long do we keep the lamp under a bushel (cf. *Luke* 11:33) and do not let others know the perfect divinity, while it must be placed above the candlestick, so that it sheds light on all the churches and the whole world?': there is evident impatience in the face of Basil's 'economy', considered a lack of courage. Consequently, the doxology of *Orat*. 14,4, in which reference is made to three hypostaseis united in one single glory and in one splendour, expresses in a more open way the divine nature of the Spirit. *Oration* 12 was contemporary with the exchange of letters between Basil and Gregory, concerning the divinity of the Spirit (Gregory's *Epistle* 58 and Basil's *Epistle* 71): as is known, Gregory wanted to proclaim the full divinity of the third Person, but his haste, which appeared to be untimely in that difficult situation, was opposed by Basil, who instead of accepting a clear affirmation of the divinity of the Spirit, proposed ὁμοτιμία, that is, 'parity of honour' (asserted, in fact, in the *De Spiritu sancto*) from which would descend, but only as a consequence, the divine nature, which is possessed by the other two hypostaseis. Later, subject to the obligations of the panegyric, Gregory explains – in a way, despite its apparent serenity, affected by the previous disputes – that Basil's reticence was due to an 'economy', while for himself, Gregory, who occupied a much less important position within the Church, greater freedom of speech was permissible (*Orat*. 43, 68-9).[238] At Nazianzus in 372, Gregory did not enter into controversy with the Pneumatomachians, of whom he probably still had little knowledge.[239]

The period in Constantinople, on the other hand, shows a greater variety of themes and a more careful theological study. Basil's *De Spiritu sancto*, written

[238] Drecoll, however, believes that Basil's motivation was very different, and inspired by his controversy with the Sabellians, V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung* (1996), 279-80 and note 34. In that case, Gregory didn't notice it, because he does not say anything about it in his letters.

[239] See Cl. Moreschini, 'Aspetti della pneumatologia in Gregorio Nazianzeno e Basilio' (1983), 567-78.

in 375, and probably also Basil's late theological letters may have influenced Gregory. His insistence on the divinity of the Spirit had to appear as something new in Constantinople.[240] The first time, in praising Athanasius, Gregory underlines that Athanasius had already proposed a pneumatology analogous to his (*Orat*. 21,33): in order to prove it, Gregory based himself, not so much on the more famous *Epistles to Serapion*, but on the *Epistle to the Emperor Jovian* (330-333 Opitz).[241] Elsewhere, Gregory uses, but without giving it undue importance, the concept of ὁμοτιμία: ὁμοτιμία τῆς φύσεως (of the Spirit) (*Orat*. 29,14), and ὁμοτιμία of the Spirit (*Orat*. 34,11).[242]

Oration 41, pronounced for Pentecost of 379, constitutes a first summary of pneumatology, in which Gregory 'considers himself the new hierophant of pneumatology and of the conception of progressive revelation, presented in 41,2 and 41,13, before oration 31'.[243] This oration was pronounced in a difficult moment: Gregory was speaking in Anastasia in a hostile environment, dominated by the Arians, and was forced to speak with friendship to the Pneumatomachians, because they had the merit of not agreeing with them. After mentioning the goodness of the Spirit Who, invoked, will come to inspire him (but the Spirit's willingness to help must not be interpreted as a sign of His servile attitude towards those who request it, as some would have it – and here the allusion to the Pneumatomachians is uncovered) (*Orat*. 41,5), Gregory begins his controversy with those who lower the Spirit to the rank of creatures and make Him a 'fellow servant with other creatures'. He still accepts Basil's 'economy', but surpasses it: in fact, he distinguishes between those who consider that the Spirit is actually God (among whom is Gregory himself) and those who only affirm it: among these, some affirm it in front of sensible people, and therefore they are sensible (like Basil), while others affirm it without caution, and therefore they are imprudent:

> Those who consider God the Holy Spirit are undoubtedly men inspired by God and with an enlightened mind; those who also call Him God, if they do it with sensible people, also have elevated spirits, while if they do it with those who are mean, they do not take

[240] J.A. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 244.

[241] This is asserted by F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 383-7. However, I am not convinced by Gautier's chronological location of *Oration* 21, or by his assertion that Gregory, already in that oration, was announcing the consubstantiality of the Spirit: see also Chr.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 279-80. Nor am I convinced that Gregory's pneumatology in this oration derives from Athanasius: Gregory cites Athanasius to show that also the Bishop of Alexandria, more famous than him, namely, Gregory, supported the divinity of the Spirit, but Gregory does not take up Athanasius' pneumatology. Subsequent orations demonstrate this.

[242] The same is stated in *Orat*. 42,16: 'beings of the same substance and the same glory' (ὁμοούσιά τε καὶ ὁμόδοξα).

[243] See J.A. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 275, according to whom (*ibid*. 276-7), Evagrius helped Gregory of Nazianzen to prepare *Oration* 41, for example suggesting the scriptural occurrences of the number seven, but this is only a hypothesis.

into account the advisability (οὐκ οἰκονομικοί): they entrust the pearl to the mud and an echo of thunder to a rotten ear and the rays of the sun to very weak eyes and solid food to those who still drink milk.

For this reason, Gregory will not present the most perfect doctrine about the Spirit (ch. 6). This means that he still does not want to break off relations with the Pneumatomachians, who, at least, do not contest the divinity of the Son (ch. 8): in fact, although they do not admit that the Spirit is Lord, no do they accept the consequence of His being a servant (so Eustathius of Sebaste had said).[244] Gregory instead proclaims that the φύσις of the divinity is unique (ch. 8). Finally, after many hesitations, there follows the full affirmation of the prerogatives of the Spirit (ch. 9), of which the ἐνέργειαι (ch. 10) are also later celebrated. The operations of the Spirit are manifested, first of all, in the sanctification of the angelic natures, then, in the inspiration of the fathers and prophets, and finally, in His presence in the incarnated Christ as His ὁμότιμος (the term here is applied to Christ and not to the Spirit) and in inspiring His disciples.[245] The presence of the Spirit in the world took place, however, step by step: first in a dark way, then in the type, finally in the fullness of His substance after Christ's coming to earth. The Holy Spirit is Paraclete, but He is 'another Paraclete' (*John* 14:16) after Christ, so that his ὁμοτιμία (the key term that derives from Basil) and His being *homousion* can be made clear to us (and in saying that the Spirit is *homousion*, Gregory goes a step forward with respect to Basil). There follows (ch. 12-5) a very extensive documentation of the scriptural texts that speak of the Spirit. The Spirit collaborates with the Son in the creation of the world (*Psalm* 33:6; *Job* 33:4) and in the resurrection (*Psalm* 104:30; *John* 3:5) (ch. 14). The moral and spiritual change in David, Amos, Daniel, Matthew, Paul are the effects of such a spiritual regeneration.

The full divinity of the Spirit is openly proclaimed in *Orat*. 39,12, of January 6, 380. After quoting the Pauline formula (1*Cor*. 8:6): 'for us there is one God, the Father, from Whom are all things, and one Lord Jesus Christ, through Whom are all things', Gregory adds a third member, so that it should also include the Holy Spirit:[246] 'and one Holy Spirit, in Whom are all things'.[247] Thus, this formula corresponds to that of *Rom*. 11:36 ('from Him, and through Him, and to Him are all things: to Him be glory for the ages. Amen') whose member εἰς αὐτόν (to whom) is interpreted by Gregory as equivalent to ἐν αὐτῷ (something possible in Hellenistic Greek), and both formulas refer to the three united

[244] A fairly friendly attitude towards the Pneumatomachians is also to be found in Gregory of Nyssa, *Deit. Evag*. (GNO IX, 331-41), perhaps for the same reasons.

[245] The santification of the intellectual creatures is not stable: in fact the angels themselves can fall; cf. also Evagr., *Epist. fidei* 10,30 (see *infra*).

[246] Basil had already interpreted 1*Cor*. 8:6 with reference to the Holy Spirit; Gregory of Nyssa did the same (*Epist*. 5,5), A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 46-8.

[247] See also p. 256.

hypostaseis. Gregory then introduces the ἰδιότητες of the hypostaseis. That of the Spirit is to 'proceed' (προϊόν) from the Father, but not in a filial way, because it does not come by way of generation but by way of procession (ἐκπορευτῶς) (and he underlines the novelty of the adverb ἐκπορευτῶς, which he himself seems to have proposed for clarity).[248] The Spirit does not change in the Father or in the Son, because He proceeds and is God (even if many do not believe it): in fact, the peculiarity of the individual Person is immutable. The ἀγεννησία and the γέννησις are not natures of gods that have the same name (ὁμωνύμων), because otherwise we would have to consider different, by nature, Eva and Seth, who had a different origin (39,12) (the same example is proposed in the following *Oration* 31).

Later, in *Oration* 31, Gregory once again alludes to Basil's *De Spiritu sancto*, but, at the same time, he surpasses it. He first considers the objections to the divinity of the Spirit: it is not demonstrated by any scriptural text and is extraneous to the Christian tradition (ξένον καὶ παρέγγραπτον, ξένον θεὸν καὶ ἄγραφον). Basil had also had to take into account that objection (*De Spiritu sancto* 1,3) and justify faith in the divinity of the Spirit on the basis of the Christian tradition (*ibid.* 27,66: τὰ μὲν ἐκ τῆς ἐγγράφου διδασκαλίας ἔχομεν). Those who are not so obstinate in fighting the divinity of the Son, Gregory continues, are however irreducible when they reject the divinity of the Spirit: they are the Pneumatomachians. Two other observations (31,3) are close to Basil's exegesis: *Psalm* 35:10 is interpreted, like Basil (*De Spiritu sancto* 18,47), in the sense that in the light given to us by the Spirit we will see the light, which is the Son, and Gregory connects the words of the Psalm to the affirmation (*John* 1:9) that 'That was the true Light, which lighteth every man that cometh into the world', namely, the true Light is the Father, the Son and the Spirit. The Nazianzen declares that he wants to climb 'on a high mountain' to proclaim the divinity of the Spirit: it is a revenge, now that he is in Constantinople, for the silence he had had to observe ten years earlier, when he was subject to Basil's authority and he had been forced to 'hide his lamp under a bushel'. In fact, a divinity that is not complete in all its three components cannot be perfect (and therefore truly divine). This reasoning will then be taken up by Gregory Nyssen in a similar context (*Maced.* 91,3-12). If in fact the Spirit does not exist *ab initio*, it does not distinguish itself in any way from creatures: so how can it sanctify us and lead us to God? (31,4).

Some hypotheses are then rejected: namely, the absolute negation of the existence of the Spirit and His existence only as ἐνέργεια, proposed by some pagan philosophies.[249] If the Spirit is not ἐνέργεια, He is substance; but if it

[248] 'If one must create new terminology for the sake of clarity'. Also in *Orat.* 31,9 Gregory cautiously proposes (ἵν'οὕτως εἴπω) the term ἔκφανσις ('manifestation') about the Spirit.

[249] Perhaps Gregory is referring also to the interpretation of Eusebius and Cyril of Alexandria, of the Spirit as a cosmic soul, insofar as it is the spirit that 'gives life' to the world, as the soul gives life to the animated being.

must be substance, then either He is God or He is a creature: *tertium non datur*, as he had already said in *Oration* 41. But if He is a creature, once again, how can we believe in the Spirit or be made perfect by Him? (31,6).

The objection of the Pneumatomachians is that the Spirit is either unbegotten (and so there are two beings without a beginning) or is generated; if He is generated, either is generated by the Father (and so there are two Sons), or He is generated by the Son (and then we have a God who is a grandson). Gregory replies to this dilemma by observing that relations between the divine Persons do not take place in human ways: the Son is a son according to an infinitely higher relationship of filiality than ours (31,7). The only solution is to consider the Spirit not as a Son, but as 'the being Who proceeds' (τὸ ἐκπορευτόν) from the Father, according to *John* 15:26. Hence, the Spirit, inasmuch as He 'proceeds', is not a creature and as He is not generated, He is not a Son.[250] However, what this 'procession' consists of remains as obscure, as the Father's ungenerated being and the Son's being generated (31,8): it can only be explained as a 'relationship' (σχέσις), which is different from the relationship of the Son with the Father: it is not true that something is 'missing' in the Spirit in order to achieve the dignity of the Son. Thus, the three hypostaseis remain distinct and there is no falling into the error of Sabellius and the Pneumatomachians (ch. 9).

Having established this, it only remains to proclaim the Spirit *homousion* with the Father and with the Son (31,10),[251] and if the adversary opposes this proclamation, observing that two beings of the same origin who are not the same cannot be *homousia*, Gregory replies citing, as in *Oration* 41, the example of Eve and Seth, who are both derived from Adam, though differently (31,11). In conclusion, there is only one God, because the divine nature (θεότης) is unique, and the realities that come from it refer to this one nature, even if they are three (καὶ πρὸς ἓν τὰ ἐξ αὐτοῦ τὴν ἀναφορὰν ἔχει, κἂν τρία πιστεύηται).[252]

[250] Gregory denies that the Father was forced to 'produce' (προβάλλειν) or not produce the Holy Spirit (*Orat.* 25,17).

[251] This proclamation, about whose importance many have written, has seemed strange, among others, to J. Bernardi, *Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (1995), 227 and to F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 388-95, the latter observing that Gregory's *ex cathedra* preaching in Constantinople will never affirm the consubstantiality of the Spirit, but will only assert His divinity (*ibid.* 394), and that the assertion of consubstantiality in *Oration* 31, goes back to a period after the Council (Jerome also reports that *Oration* 31 was pronounced separately from other theological homilies) (*Viris ill.* 117). The first part of the statement is a *petitio principii*, while the fact that Jerome considers *Oration* 31 independent of the others simply means that it was united to the others by Gregory himself or the collector of *Orationes theologicae*, while before it was not, it does not mean that Gregory proposed a new doctrine nor that it was delivered after the Council.

[252] The use of the neuter to indicate the Persons has already been discussed above (p. 255). The ἀναφορά which is being spoken of here is another way of presenting the concept of σχέσις.

In 31,17 Gregory combines – which Basil had not done – the problem of pneumatology with the problem of tritheism: the question, moreover, had been proposed by the opponents of Basil and the Gregories, the Pneumatomachians themselves. In fact, they reject the union of the Persons (ἕνωσις) – which Gregory, on the other hand, defends – and they deny the legitimacy of the connumeration (συνάριθμησις) of the Spirit with the Father and the Son, because, they claim, only the consubstantial realities connumerate (συναριθμεῖσθαι φῇς τὰ ὁμοούσια), while the nature of the Spirit is different, and connumeration means to bring together various substances into unity (συναρίθμησιν λέγων τὴν εἰς ἀριθμὸν ἕνα συναίρεσιν).[253] Gregory replies (31,18) that the number indicates only the quantity of the subjects, not the nature of the things that are numbered (πᾶς ἀριθμὸς τῆς ποσότητος τῶν ὑποκειμένων ἐστὶ δηλωτικός, οὐ τῆς φύσεως τῶν πραγμάτων), while, according to the Pneumatomachians, only beings who have the same substance and also have the same name (συνεκφωνεῖται) can be connumerated: three men and three gods, not three different things (τρία τάδε καὶ τάδε): therefore it is not possible to count together the Father and the Son, Who are God, on the one hand, and the Spirit, who is not, on the other hand (31,19). But then, Gregory replies, Peter, Paul and John are not three, because they are single realities and therefore they are not connumerated;[254] nor are they consubstantial, if they are single entities:[255] only three Pauls, three Peters and three Johns can be consubstantial. What the Pneumatomachians want for the names implying a γένος (the human race), that is, only those belonging to that γένος should be connumerated: this also applies to the terms that indicate an εἶδος, that is, the species that is included in the γένος: Peter, Paul and John are the εἴδη (singles) of the γένος (the whole, that is, humanity). Thus the evangelist John has connumerated three beings that are not consubstantial: the spirit, the water and the blood (1*John* 5:8). In conclusion (31,20), if the number two is formed by one plus one and divides into one plus one, and if the connumerated realities are consubstantial, while those that are divided are of different substances, it happens that the same realities (two) are at one and the same time of the same and of different substances, because they can be united and divided. This is the absurdity which results from the προαρίθμησις (the numbering of the first two Persons) and the ὑπαρίθμησις (the numbering of the lower reality, that is, of the Spirit): both of which are maintained by the Pneumatomachians.

[253] I would prefer to translate it like this, rather than as Gallay does, more weakly: 'les réunir dans un même nombre'. In fact, it is evident from Gregory's treatment that the problem of connumeration has to do with tritheism.

[254] It is the same example as the Nyssen's, *Ablab.* (GNO III/I, 38,8; 54,3-4). It is difficult to say whether Gregory's homily 31 or the Nyssen's *Ad Ablabium* comes first. I would be inclined to consider Gregory's homily as having preceded the Nyssen's work.

[255] Meaning 'consubstantial' in the sense of three belonging to the same kind, not in the sense of the unity of substance.

This controversy against sub-numbering had already been mentioned by Gregory in a previous oration, no. 22. In it, Gregory had used the terms ὑπερσέβοντες and ὑποσέβοντες, in ironizing about the 'wise in these things' (22,12). These are the Pneumatomachians, who start from the διαίρεσις of the Arians and invent a new kind of subdivision (ὑποδιαίρεσις), that is, they accept the Arian principle of the division of the Divine Persons and they propose a secondary division: on the one hand the Father and the Son, on the other, the Spirit. In combatting the Pneumatomachians, Gregory intends connumerating (συναριθμεῖν) the three hypostaseis (*Orat.* 34,15). In the same oration (22,10), Gregory accepts the ὁμότιμον and rejects the ἀπαρίθμησις (which I would like to correct in ὑπαρίθμησις).

In his reply, Gregory took up Basil's discussion (cf. *De Spiritu sancto* 17,41-3). Basil had also observed that the principle of sub-numbering, of which the Pneumatomachians speak, derives from pagan wisdom, that is, from Neo-Platonism, which connumerated the three 'main hypostaseis', however arranging them in a descending order.[256] The sub-numbering cannot be a division of a genus into different species, a division of what is common in what is placed under it (τοῦ κοινοῦ εἰς τὰ ὑπεσταλμένα), that is, of the divine nature as a common reality in the Persons Who, being part of it, would be under it.[257] The Pneumatomachians maintain that connumeration is suitable for things that have equal honour,[258] while for different and inferior realities (that is, the Spirit) the applicable term is 'sub-numbering'. Basil replies that this theory would give a number such an efficacy that it would increase or decrease the value of the numbered things: in fact, the brass obol can be numbered with the golden stater, and in this case an inferior coin is numbered – and therefore equalized – with the more precious coin. The Pneumatomachians reply that they are not speaking of two coins together (that is, they do not make a connumeration), but of two different coins (one coin and another one), and so they do the sub-numbering: but in this case, Basil replies, there is no subnumeration, because all the objects are said in the same way, both the gold coin and the silver one, that is, they constitute a γένος. So, if you enumerate each object in isolation, there follows a parity of honour: the gold stater and the brass obol are of equal value, because they would be counted in the same way (one plus one); if you count them together (two), instead, you combine them in dignity. In conclusion, the sub-numbering cannot be applied to God, because the order, expressed by the baptismal formula comprising the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit, is not a sign of the

[256] Thus, rightly, Pruche, Basile de Césarée, *Sur le Saint-Esprit* (1968), *ad locum*. Also in *De Spiritu sancto* 17,42 Basil speaks of a ἀλλόκοτος σοφία.

[257] See above (p. 247), about the fact that Basil denies that the divine nature is a γένος superimposed on the hypostaseis.

[258] Basil speaks of ὁμότιμα because he means the Spirit: it should be noted that, instead, Gregory speaks of consubstantial realities.

Spirit's inferiority, because the three names are coordinated (*De Spiritu sancto* 27,68).[259]

In *Oration* 31, the Nazianzen is once again influenced by Basil: he resumes the controversy against the 'sub-numbering', reluctantly accepts, if necessary (not only in *Oration* 41, but also in 31), the 'parity of honour' of the Spirit, but tries to clarify inter-Trinitarian relations more than the other Cappadocians had done, even if starting from Basil's formulas. It is important to him that his critics who protest it is not within the Christian tradition to 'pray to the Spirit' (31,12) have not understood the dynamics of revelation which the New Testament speaks about (*John* 4:24; *Rom.* 8:26; 1*Cor*. 14:15). All prayer and worship is, *de facto*, 'in the Spirit'.[260] However, also in this *Oration* (31,28) Basil is alluded to as 'a man of God'.

Up to this point, we have the pneumatology of Gregory Nazianzen. The Council of Constantinople, a few months later, would not have followed him, but would have affirmed a different pneumatology, which even Gregory, in the absence of something better, would have been forced to accept, very unwillingly and with many recriminations, including personal ones, presented especially in the poems of those years.[261]

And finally, Jerome (*Vir. illustr*. 133) certifies that Amphilochius had written a book on the Holy Spirit and had made him read it: hence, we are in 381, and therefore after Basil's death. Perhaps for this reason, Amphilochius (if Jerome's account is trustworthy) was closer to the Nazianzen than to Basil: *nuper mihi librum legit De Spiritu sancto*, quod Deus *et quod adorandus quodque omnipotens sit*. 'Quod Deus' means that also Amphilochius openly asserted the divinity of the Spirit. Not much else can be gleaned from Amphilochius' works (see *De recta fide*, CChr.SG 3, 314-316; *Hom*. 10.6, SC 553, 205) for a reconstruction of his pneumatology, apart from the usual assertion that the Christians and the Church are sanctified and illuminated by the Spirit.[262]

Evagrius, in *Epistula fidei*, also follows Gregory Nazianzen and Basil. He says that every creature is a servant of God, but he who is a servant possesses holiness by acquisition (ἐπίκτητον) and, consequently, is not immune from the danger of

[259] In *Contra Eunomium* Basil had said that being third in the order of the baptismal confession did not mean being third in nature.

[260] J.A. McGuckin, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 305.

[261] See J. Bernardi, *La prédication des Pères Cappadociens* (1968), 177-83; *id*., *Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (1995), 227; F. Gautier, *La retraite et le sacerdoce* (2002), 389-99; *id*., 'Grégoire l'Innovateur?' (2007).

[262] See A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 464-82, above all 457-66. According to Chr.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 167 n. 45, Amphilochius 'despite the fact that he had been a disciple of Basil' supported the Nazianzen's doctrine at the Council in 381, but it is not clear why Beeley claims this.

also acquiring wickedness. Instead the Holy Spirit, since He is holy in substance, is the 'source of sanctification', therefore He is not a creature. But if He is not a creature, He is consubstantial with God (10, 33,7-14 Courtonne): this is Gregory of Nazianzen's reasoning, but a little simplified, because it is not mandatory. The Spirit does not have a mutable nature, Evagrius continues, because otherwise He would be like the angels (10, 34,16-20): Basil had also said that the Spirit, Who is holy, procures sanctification for the angelic natures. As we observed above (p. 253), Evagrius was not particularly interested in the Trinitarian problems, for which he thought his master Nazianzen had been the best teacher.

Chapter V
The Incarnate Christ

With the Cappadocians, the Christological problem takes on a new impulse to respond no longer only to Arianism, which had substantially continued to adhere to the traditional interpretation of the Logos-*sarx* type (the incarnate Logos had united with human flesh), but also to adapt to the revolution brought about by the speculation of Apollinaris (or Apollinarius) of Laodicea. The anti-Apollinarist polemic of the Cappadocians lasted only a few years, having started only late in the life of Basil (around 376) and then continued in the late works of the Nazianzen and the Nyssen. Apollinaris' fame as a supporter of the Nicene creed meant that he was probably respected by the Cappadocians and had kept them from polemicizing with him, and probably also the fact that they had not acquired significantly broad knowledge of Apollinaris' Christology immediately after the beginning of his heresy, but only a little at a time, and in different ways from each other.

However, it would be wrong to identify in the Cappadocians *tout court* a Christology with an anti-Apollinarist polemic, as if the former could not have existed without the latter. We will be able to see it by distinguishing the two moments, that of the formulation of Christology and that of the anti-Apollinarist polemic.

1. *Humanity and Passions of Christ*

The problem of the passions of the incarnate Christ, insofar as they are inherent in the human nature that he assumed, was solved simply by Arianism, which considered them clear evidence of the non-divinity of the Son. This seems to have been the first Christological problem dealt with by the Cappadocians, certainly in polemic with the Arians, but Apollinaris of Laodicea seems to anticipate their speculation in this regard. In fact, his *Epistula ad Iovianum*, sent in 363,[1] contains a sufficiently broad discussion (as far as the literary genre of the epistle allowed) of the πάθη of Christ (2, 251,15-252,3 Lietzmann), and anticipates what Basil will say a long time after, around 375, in *Epistle* 260: Christ suffered for us in the flesh (*Rom*. 8:32), but remained ἀπαθὴς καὶ ἀναλλοίωτος in his divine nature, as we read in *Mal*. 3:6 (2, 252.1-3 Lietzmann). Given the importance of the problem, Apollinaris concludes his exposition, which aims to inform the emperor Jovian about the true faith, with considerable solemnity, through a series of anathemas that anticipate the fundamental problems of his

[1] On this epistle see V.H. Drecoll, 'Apollinarius, *Ad Iovianum*' (2015).

Christology and are directed against those who assert that there were two sons: one, the Son of God, the other, a man born of Mary, so that one, the Son of God, was a son by nature, the other, the man born of Mary,[2] was a son through grace. The anathemas are against those who say that the flesh of the Lord descended from heaven and did not come from the Virgin Mary (3, 253,7-12);[3] those who assert that divine nature changed into flesh or became confused with it or transformed; who say that the divine nature of the Son underwent passion or that the flesh of our Lord is not adored because it is the flesh of a man, and do not say that it is adored because it is the flesh of the Lord and of God. In later works Apollinaris insists that the body of Christ was holy from the beginning, unlike any human body (*De unione* 1, 185,9-10 Lietzmann), but seems to contradict the previous anathema by stating that Christ had a heavenly body, because Christ came down from heaven (*John* 3:13), and the Logos joined the body which originated from the earth (*De unione* 4, 186,20-187,2).

One proof of the humanity of Christ is constituted by the fact that he experiences passions, including fear in the face of death (*Apodeixis* fr. 101-3 Lietzmann; *Anacephalaiosis* 29, 245,30-216,10). However, unlike what happens to other men, Christ is not subject to affections against his will: he offers himself up to death of his own will, while for other men death is forced on them by nature and by the πάθη (fr. 102 Lietzmann). For this reason Apollinaris, if he claims the παθητικὸν τῆς σαρκός (*KMP* 2), on the other hand, specifies that 'God was incarnated with human flesh, Intellect who remained unconquered by the passions of the soul and the flesh' (θεὸς … σαρκωθεὶς ἀνθρωπίνῃ σαρκὶ … νοῦς ἀήττητος ὢν τῶν ψυχικῶν καὶ σαρκικῶν παθημάτων) (*ibid.* 30). The impassiveness of the flesh of Christ therefore occurred after his death (*ibid.* 3). Apollinaris polemicizes against those who attribute passion to the divinity and the progress and glory that was the consequence of the passion (προκοπάς τε καὶ πάθη καὶ δόξαν τὴν ἐπιγινομένην).

Basil

Basil does not elaborate on the problem of Logos made flesh, but limits himself to the distinction Logos – *sarx*. His Christology has as its primary, though not unique, goal soteriology,[4] which he states in *Epist.* 261,3: 'just as death, that is, death in the flesh, which was transmitted to us through Adam, was swallowed up by the divine nature (κατεπόθη ὑπὸ τῆς θεότητος), so too sin was

[2] This was the doctrine of Diodorus of Tarsus, against which Gregory of Nazianzen will polemicize fifteen years later (p. 297-9 and 303).

[3] A statement that was understood by Apollinaris' disciples in the sense of his flesh having descended 'from heaven', as we read in Epiphanius (*Panar.* 77,20-24) and Basil (*Epist.* 261,2).

[4] This, to be honest, can be repeated for Gregory of Nazianzus (*Epist.* 101,32: 'that which has not been assumed has not been healed') and Gregory of Nyssa (B.E. Daley, '"Heavenly Man" and "Eternal Christ"' [2001]).

destroyed by the righteousness which is in Christ Jesus, so that we in the resurrection resume the flesh that is neither liable to death nor subject to sin'. However, Basil also realizes that the human flesh of Christ could not be the flesh of any man, but had to be a particular flesh, so that he too poses the problem of incarnation:

> The words of the Psalm: 'the Most High sanctified his tent' (*Psalm* 45:5) perhaps mean the flesh as bearer of the divinity, sanctified by union with God (τὴν σάρκα τὴν θεοφόρον, ἁγιασθεῖσαν διὰ τῆς πρὸς τὸν Θεὸν συναφείας), so you will interpret the tent of the Most High as the epiphany of God through the flesh (*Hom. in Ps*. 45,4; PG 29, 424B).

Basil seems to have been disinterested in Christological questions, according to what can be read in letter 258, sent to Epiphanius in 376,[5] in which he asserts that he does not want to depart from the faith of Nicaea, except in pneumatology, and he ironically apologizes for not being able to understand, because too deep for his intelligence, the doctrines (probably of Apollinaris) 'but the teachings which are interwoven in that Creed about the incarnation of the Lord (τὰ προσυφαινόμενα τῇ πίστει ἐκείνῃ δόγματα περὶ τῆς τοῦ Κυρίου ἐνανθρωπήσεως)'.

Basil too, not unlike Apollinaris, is interested in the problem of the correct interpretation of the passions of the incarnate Christ. The humanity of Christ and his created soul are bearers of human passions, growth and progress and also of not knowing the last day:

> Then, moreover, to one who examines intelligently the Lord discourses with men from His human side also (ἀπὸ τοῦ ἀνθρωπίνου μέρους): for example, 'Give me to drink' (*John* 4:7) is an expression of the Lord satisfying his bodily need, and yet He who asked was not flesh without soul, but Godhead which had made use of flesh endowed with soul (οὐχὶ σὰρξ ἦν ἄψυχος, ἀλλὰ θεότης σαρκὶ ἐμψύχῳ κεχρημένη). So now also, if anyone takes the fact of ignorance as applying to Him who had received all things according to the dispensation (i.e. the incarnation) and was advancing in wisdom and grace with God and men (*Luke* 2:52), will not be carried beyond a conception consistent with piety (*Epist*. 236,1, to Amphilochius).[6]

The passions of man are suffered either by the flesh or by the flesh united to the soul, or, ultimately, by the soul, in that it uses the body as an instrument. Flesh as a material reality can be dissolved; the flesh that bears the soul can tolerate fatigue or pain, hunger and thirst, and finally the soul with the body as

[5] Epiphanius is to some extent favourable to Apollinaris, because he considers his merits in defense of the Nicene faith and tries to induce his disciples to a change of mind (cf. *Pan*. 77,14,1-4; 24,8-9). He himself had been a friend of his (*Pan*. 77,19).

[6] The humiliations of the human nature of Christ are also listed by Nazianzen (*Orat*. 29,18), together with the *crux interpretationis* of Christ's ignorance of the last hour (*Orat*. 30,15-6), where Gregory refers exactly to the interpretation proposed by Basil in this letter. It was a well-known topos of the polemic between pro-nicenes and anti-nicenes, which concerned the inferiority of the Son, see, *inter alios*, M. Simonetti, *La crisi ariana nel quarto secolo* (1975), 278-9, 282; A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 217-20, 243.

its tool is subject to anger, anguish and worries. One part of these conditions (i.e. those of the body) is natural and necessary for a human being, the others originate from a wrong choice and insufficient virtue. The rational soul, therefore, is an instrument of God in the incarnation of the Son.[7] While some passions are taken by Christ to demonstrate the truth of his incarnation, others, which are stains on his moral purity, have no place in him.[8]

In *Epistle* 261, sent to the clergy of Sozopolis, Basil returns to the problem of the pathos of Christ *qua homo*: divinity as such cannot suffer, only those who are unable to think logically can say that the affections have passed from the flesh to the divine nature (*Epist*. 261,2). What is scandalous here, seems to be the possibility of attributing human passions to Christ, and the solution proposed by the heretics had been to think that Christ had a celestial body, which, therefore, would have been immune from passions. Apollinaris, however, in his letter to the emperor Jovian had not ruled out the presence of passions in Christ and had condemned those who had asserted that the flesh of Christ descended from above and did not come from the virgin Mary. Basil does not seem to see clearly the danger of the solution proposed by the Apollinarists, which, however, Gregory of Nazianzus will highlight a few years later (*Epist*. 101,15-6),[9] stating that, if it descended from heaven, the flesh of Christ already existed before the incarnation and passed through Mary as if through a channel. Basil therefore limits himself to distinguishing three types of 'passions': those of the flesh alone, which is material flesh, can be divided or diminished or destroyed; those of the flesh with a soul, which suffered fatigue, pain or hunger; those of a soul that uses a body, which can experience pain or anxiety. Passions are divided into those that are natural and necessary for every human creature and those that come from an evil will due to life that is unregulated or not exercised in virtue. Therefore the Lord assumed the natural πάθη, to confirm that his

[7] This doctrine had already been enunciated by Gregory Nazianzen in *Oration* 2 (2,23), which precedes Basil's *Epistle* 236 by fifteen years.

[8] As Grillmeier observes, it is clear that Basil considers the soul of Christ as a reality with which Basil himself can respond to Arianism and maintain the transcendence of the Logos. Athanasius had not found the way to achieve this, but even Basil is unable to appreciate all the implications of the existence of a human soul in Christ: he cannot make it a positive tool for our redemption, in order to put in it the spiritual decisions that are necessary for it. The fundamental point of the value of the soul in Christ, of which the *Dialogue of Origen with Heraclides* speaks (which Basil did not know), remains unknown to him. Grillmeier is essentially critical of the achievements of Cappadocians in Christology, A. Grillmeier, *Jesus der Christus im Glauben der Kirche* (1990), 536.

[9] According to Chr.A. Beeley, 'The Early Christological Controversy' (2011), 380, Gregory Nazianzen does not dwell particularly on this subject, and only recalls it in *Epist*. 202, because he probably did not think it was a doctrine of Apollinaris. Gregory of Nyssa will also emphasize this polemically, rejecting the Apollinarist conception of the 'heavenly man' (ἐπουράνιος ἄνθρωπος) in *Antirrh*. GNO III/I, 191,8; 213,14; 147,20-2; 182,26-183,3 (passages that are contested by Beeley, *ibid*. 380-1: 'The tenuousness of the Cappadocians' claims have every appearance of a caricature, which may have resulted from the extremity of some of Apollinarius' associates').

incarnation was true, and not illusory, but rejected those who came from evil, because they are unworthy of He who did not commit sin (*Hebr*. 4:15).[10] For this reason the Scripture says that Christ 'was made in the likeness of the sinful flesh' (*Rom*. 8:3): he took on our flesh with its natural πάθη, but did not commit sin.[11]

Again in *Epistle* 262 to the monk Urbicius Basil polemicizes against those who try to corrupt with their perverse opinions the true doctrine of the incarnation. He rejects the claim that God himself changed into the flesh and did not assume Adam's leavened mass through Mary, but remaining in his divine nature he was changed into a material nature. Basil does not think it necessary to make a long refutation of this absurdity, but he thinks that it is enough to quote *Mal*. 3:6: 'For I am the Lord, I do not change' (a passage that Apollinaris had also used in his epistle to Jovian), and to emphasize that if our body had not been united, in Christ, to the divine nature, we would not have been able to escape the dominion of death, and therefore the benefit of the incarnation would have been in vain. He who changed has created for himself his own body, which subsisted following the thickening of his divine nature, even if the immensity of God could not be contained in the smallness of the human body. So the body of Christ was not a heavenly body, that is, a body that did not feel the passions. In fact, Apollinaris had stated, precisely on the basis of *John* 3:13, that the body of Christ is not truly a created body (*De unione* 1-2, p. 186): 'it cannot be properly said that the body is a creature, fully separated from the one of whom it is a body (οὐκ ἔστιν ἰδίως κτίσμα τὸ σῶμα εἰπεῖν, ἀχώριστον ὂν ἐκείνου πάντως οὗ σῶμά ἐστιν)'.

The same problem is also discussed by Basil in *De Spiritu sancto* 5,12, which is contemporary with *Epistle* 262: Paul's words (*Gal*. 4:4), "made from a woman (γενόμενος ἐκ γυναικός)" should also be understood as "born through (διά) a woman": the Apostle 'corrects *obiter* the error of those who supposed that the body of the Lord was a spiritual body, and, to show that the God-bearing flesh was formed out of the common lump of human nature, gave precedence to the more emphatic preposition'. The problem of the celestial body of Christ will continue to concern the anti-apollinarist polemic, in Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa.

Gregory of Nyssa

Gregory of Nyssa, showing himself a faithful follower of Basil also in Christology, takes up again in his *Epistle* 3, of 381, the problem of the passions of Christ. The first passion can already be considered the 'progress (προκοπή)'

[10] That the body of Christ was uncontaminated, not because our body is corrupt (so that it was necessary for Christ to assume a different body from ours), is also asserted by Epiphanius (*Pan*. 77,14,6-7), with reference to 1*Peter* 2:22.

[11] The same reasoning in Gregory of Nazianzus, *Epist*. 102,11.

of Christ, who, as a child, progressed in wisdom and goodness, as Luke recounts (*Luke* 2:52). The problem of the progress of Christ, which implies a passion and the change of the body, was also discussed by Apollinaris (fr. 168,16 and 238,3 Lietzmann),[12] Athanasius (*CA* III 51-53),[13] Epiphanius (*Pan*. 77,26-27), also referring to *Hebr*. 4:15 and, as usual, insisting on the materiality of the body of Christ (*Pan*. 77,28-29), and finally by Basil, as we have just seen. Basil had said that change can also concern the soul clothed with a body, and the Nyssen also thinks that change also affects the soul of Christ, who progresses in wisdom and goodness. However, this does not mean that the human nature that was present in Christ gradually became transformed into the more divine element (πρὸς τὸ θειότερον μεταποιεῖσθαι), that is, that Christ became God gradually, but means that the Lord was truly in our leavened mass (φύραμα) and carried out a real theophany, in which the presence of God was revealed more and more clearly and finally manifested itself openly with the resurrection (3,16-22; GNO VIII/II, 23,28-26,11). In fact, divine nature did not become corrupted as a result of being found in a corruptible body, and did not become different in order to change (εἰς τροπὴν ἠλλοιώθη), did not modify itself as a result of having healed the changeable element of our soul: indeed, the doctor also treats our diseases, but does not become sick. For this reason Christ had everything that is typical of our nature, except sin. Sin, in fact, is an accident (ἀπότευγμα) from nature, not a peculiarity, as are disease and mutilation, which did not exist at the beginning: evil must be considered a mutilation of the good, but it has no existence, because it is found in the absence of the good (ἀπουσία τοῦ ἀγαθοῦ) (it is the typical Nyssenian conception of the non-existence of evil). Hence He who transformed (μεταστοιχειώσας) our nature into divine power healed it and rejected the mutilation that had resulted from the choice (προαίρεσις) (of nature itself). This did not happen only later,[14] because the man who was in Mary, in whom Wisdom lived, and who came from the leavened mass subject to passion (ἐκ τοῦ ἐμπαθοῦς φυράματος), from the very beginning, thanks to the coming of the Holy Spirit and the habitation in Mary of the Power of the Most High (*Luke* 1:35), became He who dwelled in man's nature. In this way the divine nature was joined with what was beneath it (τῷ ὑποκειμένῳ) (i.e. the human being[15] in which it had come to be), and consequently the body is also called 'Lord', due to the divine nature that was

[12] Pasquali *ad locum* had already observed this. The possible presence of Apollinaris' doctrines in this letter from the Nyssen will have to be reconsidered regarding the problem of when the Nyssen heard of Apollinarism (p. 313-4). Maraval, in fact, omits this *locus parallelus*, because he does not think it has anything to do with Apollinarism, Grégoire de Nysse, *Lettres* (1990), 136-7.

[13] As observed by P. Maraval, *ad locum*.

[14] That is, at the moment of the resurrection.

[15] Man as such, or only the body? It is more likely that man should be understood, despite the neutral and material ὑποκείμενον.

in it. Divine nature mixed with ours, so that our salvation was complete. The Nyssen, like Basil, also distinguishes between some 'passions' which are typical of man, but which do not cause shame: eating, drinking, sleeping, the growth of the body, everything that characterizes our nature, and others that come from the weakness of the flesh and from the perversion of the will. The man of Christ, who was formed in Mary, was subject to the 'passions' of the first type, with the exclusion of sin, but not the passions of the second type (*Epist*. 3,18-9).

The Nyssen explains his doctrine, that the passions of the body must be distinguished from those of the soul, also in the third book of the *Contra Eunomium*, which is contemporary to the third epistle:

> In truth nothing is passion, unless it tends to sin, nor would one properly speak of passibility as the necessary limitation of nature, if one observes the composite nature progressing in an ordered logical sequence. … Properly speaking we call passion only what is contrary to the impassibility of virtue, and do not believe that the one who bestows salvation upon us also remained without a share in our nature: he was "tempted in all things in the same way without sin" (*Hebr*. 4:15). In what is truly passion, which is a disease of the will, he had no part. "He did no sin", it says, "neither was guile found in his mouth" (1*Peter* 2:22; *Is*. 53:9). Those features of our nature however, which by custom and usage are given the same name, "passions", those we confess the Lord did share in: birth, nurture and growth, sleep and fatigue, and whatever other bodily stresses the soul by its nature is liable to suffer, since appetite extends the desire of the one in need from the body to the soul; the feeling of pain too, and dread of death, and all that kind of thing, provided it does not lead on to any sin as a consequence (*CE* III 4,28-9).[16]

The natural passions, therefore, are called 'passions' simply inappropriately. In Christ there were also passions of the soul, which however were not a manifestation of evil, but of the weakness of the human soul, which he had assumed:

> When we hear that he is Light, Power, Righteousness and Life, and that all things were made by him, we regard all these and similar things as credible, attributing them to the Word as God; when on the other hand we hear of pain, sleep, want, distress, bonds, nails, spear, blood, wounds, burial, tomb, and other such things, even though they are contrary to the previous conclusions, we accept that these are no less credible and true, having regard to the flesh, which we have received in faith associated with the Word. For just as we may not ascribe the peculiar properties of the flesh to the Word who is in the beginning, so conversely we may not observe the peculiarities of the deity in the fleshly nature (*CE* III 4,7).

Again in *Refut*. 181, written in 383, the Nyssen speaks of both the passion of the body and the passion of the soul: hunger, thirst, fear, desire, sleep, disturbance,

[16] Trans. Stuart G. Hall, here and below, in Johan Leemans & Matthieu Cassin (eds), *Gregory of Nyssa* Contra Eunomium III (2014).

tears. The same distinction recurs in *Catech.* 16,6-8 (GNO III/IV, 46,3-13 and 48,2-9).

Gregory of Nazianzus

Gregory of Nazianzus does not concern himself with showing that the divinity of Christ incarnate did not take on the passions of the flesh. In fact, he attributes them to His soul: he already asserts it in the second oration of 362 (therefore long before Basil's discussions with the Apollinarists), taking from Origen the doctrine that the soul of Christ was the mediator between divinity and flesh: 'for this reason God mixed with the flesh through the soul that was intermediary (διὰ μέσης ψυχῆς ἀνεκράθη) and separate realities united through the affinity that this intermediary had with both (τῇ πρὸς ἄμφω τοῦ μεσιτεύοντος οἰκειότητι)' (*Orat.* 2,23). Gregory repeats that the rational soul was intermediary between God and the flesh also in *Orat.* 38,13: Christ incarnated 'through the mediation of a rational soul standing between divinity and the coarseness of the flesh (διὰ μέσης ψυχῆς νοερᾶς μεσιτευούσης θεότητι καὶ σαρκὸς παχύτητι)'.[17] And since the intermediary soul was an intelligent soul, it is simply called 'intellect' (*Orat.* 29,19: διὰ μέσου νοὸς ὁμιλήσας σαρκὶ καὶ γενόμενος ἄνθρωπος ὁ κάτω θεός).

Finally, Amphilochius also assumes a position on the problem of Christ's passions, polemicizing against the Arians, who interpreted fear and weakness before death in the sense of the Son's inferiority: these passions must be referred back to the salvific economy of the Son (*Hom.* 6 and *Hom.* 10). The Christology of Amphilochius, therefore, appears somewhat backward.[18]

2. *Mixing, Union and Identity*

The union of the two natures in Christ is expressed with the term 'mixing' both by Apollinaris and by the Cappadocians. Apollinaris states that 'it is admitted that in Christ one element, the created one, united with the uncreated element and the uncreated one in the mixing with the created one, and that on both sides it resulted in a unique nature (ὁμολογεῖται δὲ ἐν αὐτῷ τὸ μὲν εἶναι κτιστὸν ἐν ἑνότητι τοῦ ἀκτίστου, τὸ δὲ ἄκτιστον ἐν συγκράσει τοῦ κτιστοῦ, φύσεως μιᾶς ἐξ ἑκατέρου μέρους συνισταμένης)' (*De unione* 5, 187,5-8); as in the human body, the two incomplete parts make up a single nature (*Ad Iovian.* fr. 9 and 10 Lietzmann).[19]

[17] This is a typical conception of the Nazianzen: the Nyssen does not employ it, as J.-R. Bouchet, 'Le vocabulaire de l'union' (1968), 563 and A. Hofer, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 114 and 120 observed.

[18] This is also stated by A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 455-6, who sees in these words a veiled anti-Apollinarist allusion, which however escapes us.

[19] Chr.A. Beeley, 'The early Christological Controversy' (2011), 381-2.

The meaning of the term is debated, and this is logical, given the importance it has for the incarnation of Christ. It is known that it varies according to its interpretation, that is, if it indicates a true union of the parts or a juxtaposition of them: it is clear that union leads to monophysism and juxtaposition to diophysism, and the two meanings derive from Stoic philosophy and Aristotelian philosophy.[20] And yet a precise use of the two terms μίξις and κρᾶσις becomes important in the Christological discussions of the fifth century, while it still appears variable in the Cappadocians, even if they understand the 'mixture' logically as a union in which divine nature has the predominant part.

The fact that both indicate other forms of mixing than incarnation, proves this variability: for example, man, union of spirit and matter, is κρᾶσις (*Orat*. 38,13: ὧ τῆς καινῆς μίξεως, ὧ τῆς παραδόξου κράσεως), as does the fact that other, more generic terms are used for the incarnation. Gregory Nazianzen asserts at first (that is, before the anti-Apollinarist controversy) the union of man with Christ, without him feeling the need to go more deeply into the problem. Christ incarnate is the compound of flesh and soul, τὸ σύνθετον:[21] 'you must predicate the more sublime expressions of the Godhead, of the nature which transcends bodily experiences, and the lowlier ones of the compound' (*Orat*. 29,18).[22] The overcoming of the Logos-sarx Christology is clearly manifested here, because the passions of Christ do not concern his flesh, but his humanity. Later Gregory again expounds all the various passions of Christ, and his conclusion is important in its conciseness:

> What He was He destroyed; what He was not He assumed; not that He became two, but He deigned to be One made out of the two (ἓν ἐκ τῶν δύο),[23] For both are God, that which assumed, and that which was assumed (τό τε προσλαβὸν καὶ τὸ προσληφθήν); two Natures[24] meeting in One, not two Sons (let us not give a false account of the blending) (ἡ σύγκρασις) (*Orat*. 37,2).

In this homily (one of Gregory's last) he uses a well-established vocabulary for Christology. To indicate the reality that is expressed by the term τὸ σύνθετον (the union of divine with human nature), by the προσλαβόν (the divine nature that assumes the human one) and by the προσληφθήν (the assumed human nature) he had already used the concept of 'mixing' in the above mentioned *Orat*. 2,23, recognizing that it had a new meaning (ἡ καινὴ μίξις, Θεὸς καὶ

[20] Andrew Hofer discussed it exhaustively taking into consideration Aristotle, the Stoics, Alexander of Aphrodisias, Plotinus, Porphyry and Nemesius, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 96-106.

[21] The term is not admissible for the Trinity, but it is for the incarnation.

[22] Also Apollinaris, *Ad Iovian*. 232,21; this doctrine was already in Origen, *CC* I 66 and III 41.

[23] Christ, in fact, was 'twofold' (διπλοῦς) (*Orat*. 30,8; 38,15), cf. Chr.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus on the Trinity* (2008), 142-3; A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 254 n. 38.

[24] Φύσις, does not, of course, exclude the person, as normally in the Nazianzen; see also *Carm*. I 2,1,149.

ἄνθρωπος); or only μίξις (*Epist*. 101,36 and 49; 102,9 and 11). But does the mixing of which Gregory speaks retain the weaker element or does it imply that the weaker element is lost and cancelled in the larger one, that is, human nature in divine nature? In the first case the term has the meaning found in Aristotle (*Gen. et corr*. 328a27-9), in the second case it has the meaning asserted by the Stoics, but the Nazianzen, using the two terms interchangeably, does not seem concerned with linguistic precision, apparently unlike the Nyssen, who almost always uses μίξις. In some passages Gregory uses κρᾶσις as a term indicating the union that retains the distinction, as in *Orat*. 34,10 (ἵνα τὸ ἐμὸν λαβὼν (Christ) τὸ ἑαυτοῦ χαρίσηται διὰ τῆς καινῆς ἀνακράσεως); *Orat*. 30,6 (ἵνα καγὼ μεταλάβω τῶν ἐκείνου διὰ τὴν σύγκρασιν) and *Carm*. I 2,1,152-4. In stating this the Nazianzen believes that an exchange of divine and human properties takes place between the Logos and man[25]: in these cases the term 'mixing' indicates the union that preserves the distinction between the human and the divine element, naturally with the prevalence of the more powerful one, but without the weaker part being destroyed. It would seem, therefore, that the Nazianzen is closer to the Aristotelian conception of the mixture as κρᾶσις, than to the Stoic one of μίξις.[26]

Gregory of Nyssa

It is no wonder, therefore, that the ambiguity of the terms μίξις and κρᾶσις to indicate the hypostatic union of Christ occurs in the Christology of Gregory of Nyssa,[27] so that he was considered a precursor now of Nestorius now of Eutyches.[28] *Epistle* 3 and the third book of *Contra Eunomium*, which are contemporary, use the term κρᾶσις without hesitation, but without specifying what is relevant to the fundamental problem, that is whether this 'mixing' of the weaker element with the more powerful one produces or not, the annihilation

[25] On the identity of God and man in the incarnate Christ according to Gregory Nazianzen see Chr.A. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 122-43; more generally, *id*., 'Cyril of Alexandria and Gregory Nazianzen' (2009). Segneri also believes that Gregory Nazianzen, while distinguishing the two natures of Christ and attributing passion to the human one, nevertheless clearly underlines the unity of Christ, God and man, as a Person, A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 300-19.

[26] A. Hofer, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 117 and 121.

[27] Gregory of Nyssa's concept of 'blending' and its derivation from Aristotelian and Stoic philosophy was examined by J.-R. Bouchet, 'Le vocabulaire de l'union' (1968), 544-9 and 554-6. More recently the term has been studied by Morwenna Ludlow, *Gregory of Nyssa Ancient and (Post)Modern* (2007), 98-100, Andrew Radde-Gallwitz, '*Contra Eunomium* III 3' (2014), 306-9, *id*., *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 175-6 and Miguel Brugarolas, 'Theological Remarks on Gregory of Nyssa's Christological Language' (2017); *id*., 'The Incarnate Logos' (2018), 211-5.

[28] Amphilochius also shows a divisive attitude in Christology, A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 400.

of the first in the second, that is, of human nature in the divine one. This uncertainty appears when the Nyssen states that Christ 'brought the whole ray of divine nature through our whole compound, that is, through the soul and the body, and united it to its light, making human reality in its totality (ὅλον τὸ ἀνθρώπινον) that which is he himself, through mixing with himself (ἀνάκρασις πρὸς ἑαυτόν)' (*Epist*. 3,15). In the *Homilies on the Canticle of Canticles* there are mentions of Christology, but Gregory, in accordance with the homiletic style, expounds it without discussion and without specifying the terms he uses. In *Cant. hom*. IV (GNO VI, 108,1-4) he interprets *Cant*. 1:16 ("also our bed is green") in the sense that the bride understands, with a translated meaning, the carnal union that takes place in the bed as the 'mixing' of human nature with the divine being, just as the thalamus indicates the union of the Logos with the human body (*ibid*. 180,9). Perfect illumination means that true light shines on those who sit in the darkness and in the shadow of death: this illumination is caused by the mixing (συνανάκρασις) of light with our nature (*ibid*. 145,6-9). 'The house', which the bride invites the groom to enter (*Cant*. 5:4-5) indicates human life, while the groom's hand (*Cant*. 1:4) symbolizes the creative hand of the universe. The hand lingered in the house, shrinking in the small and humble reality of our life. For this reason one asks how God could appear in the flesh, how the Logos became flesh, how there was a birth in the virginal condition and a virginal condition in the mother, how the light joined (καταμίγνυται) to the darkness and life mixed (κατακίρναται) with death (*Cant. hom*. IV; GNO VI, 338,2-12). Gregory uses both καταμίγνυται and κατακίρναται, precisely because in a homily he did not feel compelled to specify the meanings.[29] This means that the incarnate Christ was a θεοδόχος ἄνθρωπος (*Catech*. 32,4; GNO IV/IV, 78,10), that is, he was a man who took God within himself, and had a θεοδόχον σῶμα (GNO VI, 388,22 and 391,2).

The Nyssen professes a Logos-man Christology, clearly surpassing that Logos-flesh, which had been typical of the Nicene Athanasius, even if his perspective is sometimes distorted by the Logos-flesh schema, and defines man's death as the separation of the body from the soul (a traditional concept for the Greeks). He therefore states that in the period between the death of Christ and his resurrection there was the constant union of his divine nature with each of the parts of his human nature, body and soul: Pottier defines this union 'double union'.[30] The assertion that the death of Christ was the separation from his human soul and from his human body (*CE* III 3,68) is coherent with this Christology, as is the recognition, in Christ, of the passions of the body and those of the soul and the fact that Christ accepted the mortal condition, typical of our fallen nature. However, both the concepts and the terminology

[29] 'Blending' again in *Catech*. 16,8 (GNO III/IV, 48,2-9) and 26 (67,14) etc.

[30] See B. Pottier, *Dieu et le Christ* (1994), 301-2, which refers to the homily *De Christi nativitate* (PG 46, 1136-41).

are not used with the clarity that modern critics, accustomed to the Christological discussions of the fifth century, would like to find in the Nyssen. He certainly wants to assert the union of the Logos with man and the supremacy of the divine reality in union, so that the incarnate Christ remains God, but his affirmations sometimes give an impression that tends towards an *ante litteram* Monophysitism, in the sense that human nature 'loses itself' within the divine nature, which is infinitely greater. Others, however, believe that Gregory lays the foundation of the Chalcedonian formula, in that some passages of his works already employ three of the four adjectives that constitute it:[31] 'not confused, unchangeable, undivided', and for 'inseparable' Gregory uses similar terms. Gregory of Nyssa 'speaks … in a variety of scriptural and philosophical images which were richly suggestive for him, but which were used for different purposes by both sides of the Christological conflicts a half-century later'.[32] Moreover, even if he wants to support the presence of the incarnate Son in the *whole man* (ὅλον τὸ ἀνθρώπινον in *Epist*. 3,15), yet he sometimes refers to man with expressions that seem to mean only the material element of him, not also the human person. However, this does not imply that the Nyssen wants to speak only of the corporeal element of man, in the manner of Athanasius, and not of man as a whole. In his day the term 'flesh' had not yet appeared inadequate or incomplete to indicate the man constituted by flesh, and Gregory often neglects to remember the soul when he speaks of the incarnate Christ. He is quite clear about this ambiguity, both linguistically, when he says:

> And if they quote the word of the Gospel, namely that 'The Logos became flesh', so as to argue that the inanimate element, that is, the flesh, was assumed by the Lord, as no mention was made also of the soul, let them learn that the Holy Scripture has the habit of understanding the entire whole together with the part (*Refut*. 180)

and conceptually, when he asserts that a flesh without a soul does not exist:

> Our position is, that God was born subject to both movements of our nature; first, that by which the soul hastens to join the body, and then again that by which the body is

[31] From the oldest, such as Tixeront or Kelly, to the most recent: for example, according to B. Pottier, *Dieu et le Christ* (1994), his Christology, as Cappadocian, is midway between the school of Alexandria and that of Antioch. According to Grillmeier, on the other hand, if compared to the Christology of the Nazianzen, that of the Nyssen is strongly Dyophysite, A. Grillmeier, *Jesus der Christus* (1990), 540-1; explicit in maintaining the Dyophisitism of the Nyssen Th. Alexopoulos, 'Die Christologie Gregors von Nyssa' (2014), 477-88; A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 259-63; Chr.A. Beeley, 'Gregory of Nyssa's Christological Exegesis' (2018), 107-8 (unlike Gregory of Nazianzus, who was hostile to the Dyophisitism of the Antiochenes). Even the interpretation of Basil's criticisms of Apollinarism is made from this perspective by John Behr, *The Nicene Faith* (2004), 321-4, while Miguel Brugarolas notes that 'Gregory illuminates *together* the truth of the absolute divinity of the Word and the truth of human nature taken on by the Incarnation', 'The Incarnate Logos' (2018), 208.

[32] B.E. Daley, 'Divine Transcendence and Human Transformation' (1997), 88.

separated from the soul; and that when the concrete humanity was formed by the mixture of these two, I mean the sentient and the intelligent element, through that ineffable and inexpressible conjunction, this result in the Incarnation followed, that after the soul and body had been once united the union continued for ever. For when our nature, following its own proper course, had even in Him been advanced to the separation of soul and body, He knitted together again the disunited elements, cementing them, as it were, together with the cement of His Divine power, and recombining what has been severed in a union never to be broken. And this is the Resurrection, namely the return, after they have been dissolved, of those elements that had been before linked together, into an indissoluble union through a mutual incorporation (trans. Ph. Schaff) (*Catech.* 16,6-8; GNO III/IV, 48,2-22; see also *Catech.* 32; GNO III/IV, 77,15-21).

The fundamental point, for the Nyssen, is to emphasize the great miracle that was accomplished through the union of man with the Logos, thanks to his goodness, so that man was raised in dignity and honour, changed into a nature worthy of veneration. The clearest formula is the following:

He who says, 'Exalted by the right hand of God', is plainly revealing the ineffable economy of the mystery, that the right hand of God, which makes all that is, which is the Lord through whom all things came to be, and without whom no being came into existence, also itself took up the man united with him to his own exalted place, by that combination making him also what by nature it is itself (*CE* III 3,44).[33]

The term 'mixture' recurs constantly in the *Contra Eunomium* to emphasize the union between man and God, so it may seem that the Nyssen did not bother to assert the conservation of the human person of Christ, which would be lost in the divine person, but this is contradicted by the fact that Gregory always adds that this mix is 'without confusion':

For our part we both see the marks of the fleshly dispensation on their own, and we also recognise the divine power by itself, and for his part, just like us, he says that he who was Word in the beginning was made manifest in the flesh (*CE* III 3,62).
The beatings belong to the slave in whom the Master is, and the honours to the Master enclosed in the slave, in such a way that by the bond and conjunction both belong to each, as the Master takes to himself the bruises of the slave, and the slave is glorified with the honour of the Master (*CE* III 3,66).

This union causes Christ to be one person in two natures. Christ shows us in his person a human nature transformed by the divine nature that is within it. As he said in *Epistle* 3, human nature exists in its totality in Christ, but it is difficult to imagine this human nature as an abstract totality, which does not also imply the *individual* human nature of Christ, so that his passions were different from those of another man. His human nature remains ours: although it has been glorified with passion and resurrection, it is not suppressed:

[33] Stuart Hall translates ἀνάκρασις with 'combination', but in this way avoids rendering the ambiguity of the term in English, as mentioned above.

For our part, we say that the body also, in which he accepted the passion, being combined (κατακραθέν) with the divine nature, was by that commingling (ἀνάκρασις) made into that which (ἐκεῖνο ὅπερ) the assuming nature is. So far are we from belittling the Only-begotten God, that, whatever of the lower nature was taken up because of his Economy of love towards mankind, we believe it was also changed to something divine and pure (*CE* III 3,34).

When Wisdom built her house (*Prov*. 9:1), the Scripture refers to the human flesh of the Lord, and precisely to the house of the Virgin within which he built that flesh:

Here he puts first in his argument what was united from both (τὸ ἑνωθέν), from the house I mean and Wisdom who built the house, that is, from the Man and from the Deity combined with (ἔκ τε τοῦ ἀνθρωπίνου καὶ τῆς θεότητος ἀνακραθείσης) the Man, and to each he attributes appropriate and fitting sayings, as can be seen happening also in the Gospels, where the book, in telling its tale with due regard to the subject-matter, indicates the divine by a more elevated and God-befitting form of expression, and the human by the earth-bound and lowly (*CE* III 1,44-5).

Gregory also expounds his concept of mixing in the homily *Tunc et ipse Filius* (GNO III/I, 108,5-12) and in *In diem nat.* (GNO X/II, 239,16-240,4).

3. *The Revolution of Apollinaris of Laodicea*

Christology was a doctrine for which Apollinaris was famous ever since his death, and even today it has attracted the attention of scholars, so much so that it has also aroused interest in his Trinitarian theology. It is not our intention to review it *in extenso*, but to consider the reactions and responses to it of the Cappadocians. Their polemic against Apollinaris was not unanimous, but shows diversity, just as one cannot speak of a Cappadocian Christology as something uniform.

Basil

Apollinaris had always been an uncompromising defender of the Nicene faith and of the Trinitarian doctrine, in order to avoid both Arianism and modalism. Basil had an epistolary exchange with him on the problem of the 'consubstantial', even if he subsequently disavowed his previous friendship, feeling compelled to do so by the need to reject his Christology. But Basil, as we shall see, when he rejected Apollinaris' Christology was not yet sufficiently conversant with it. Much has been written on the events of their polemic, but in the present context we want to recall briefly that pamphlets were circulating about Basil, which he declared to be manifestly false (τὰ περιφερόμενα καθ'ἡμῶν ταῦτα συντάγματα) and that in a treatise circulating anonymously in 373 some parts about Apollinaris were written by Basil himself, as he admitted (μέρη … περὶ

τοῦ Λαοδικέως Ἀπολιναρίου γεγράφθαι); but he also claimed that those parts were in the midst of others that had absolutely not been written by him (*Epist*. 131,1, to Olympius). Basil also refers to these falsehoods attributed to him in *Epistle* 224,2, and does not deny his previous relations with Apollinaris; but his enemies circulated a letter which had, it is true, been sent by him to Apollinaris, but had been deliberately modified (μεταποιηθεῖσα); that letter, he says, was from twenty-five years before (and therefore it cannot be one of those we know), but was a letter sent 'by a layman to a layman': consequently, Basil considers it a falsehood, created for the purpose of showing the affinity between his doctrine and that of Apollinaris and condemn both for Sabellianism.[34]

Some years later, in *Epistle* 244,3 he explains to Patrophilus what his position towards Apollinaris had been in the past: he had never considered him an enemy, indeed, in some respects he had reason to respect him (and this is confirmed by the epistolary exchange we know), but he was never united to him to the point of participating in the accusations that were made against him, and Basil himself, having read some of his works, had some criticisms to address to him. He never asked him for a book on the Holy Spirit, nor did he receive a book sent to him by Apollinaris on that subject. He was told that Apollinaris was an extremely fruitful writer,[35] but that few had read his books; as for him, he had no time to search for them, and shuns carefully reading more recent books (or doctrines), also because of his bad health.

Basil had been informed that the errors of Apollinaris' doctrines agitated some local communities, as can be seen from the letter 261, to the clergy of Sozopolis, and from n. 262, to the monk Urbicius: these are the letters we have already examined for the problem of the presence of passions in the incarnate Christ. Basil shows that he does not yet have a precise knowledge of the Christology of Apollinaris, but he contests it in an increasingly decisive way over the following years. This occurs mainly in letters 260-263. In letter 260, sent to Bishop Optimus, Basil explains some scriptural passages and refers to Apollinaris without naming him:

> Since, then, men do not cease contending about the incarnation of our Lord, some concluding that He had assumed a body, while others maintain that His advent was without body, and some holding that He had taken on a body capable of sensations, while others held that He fulfilled through a sort of phantasy the functions which the body performs; and some say that His body was earthly, but others that it was heavenly;

[34] All this is said briefly by us. Regarding the question of Basil, Eustathius, Apollinaris and Basil's letters relating to it see E. Mühlenberg, *Apollinaris von Laodicea* (1969), 26-45; also R. Poucet, *Basile le grand et son univers d'amis* (1992), 489-501 (which does not however provide solutions); Ph. Rousseau, *Basil of Caesarea* (1994), 245-54; A. Radde-Gallwitz, 'The Letter Collection of Basil of Caesarea' (2018), 73-4.

[35] This is repeated in *Epist*. 263,4 and by Gregory Nazianzen (*Epist*. 101,73), who gives more details on Apollinaris' works, some of which cannot be considered heretical, at least judging by the subject (of course, we do not know any more).

and some claim that His beginning was from eternity, but others that He had His beginning from Mary. On this account He is 'For a sign that shall be contradicted' (*Luke* 2:35) (*Epist*. 260,8).

So, in addition to the problem of the 'passions', the body of Christ was the subject of interpretation now in the docetist sense now in the Sabellian sense. Indeed, some claimed that the body of Christ performed its functions 'through a sort of phantasy' because it was not earthly, but heavenly, others claimed that 'He had His beginning from Mary', that is, only from Mary and not from the Father. The charge of Sabellianism against these followers of Apollinaris was probably a polemical distortion of his thought by Basil himself, who wanted to avoid involvement in Apollinaris' doctrine, which was what those who had constructed the falsehood, of which he complained in *Epistle* 131, had tried to insinuate. Apollinaris was not at all Sabellian, but strongly Nicene.

The mention of a celestial body is taken up again in the following letter (n. 261, to the Christians of Sozopolis), and this time also connected with a discussion on how the various characteristics of the person of Christ should be understood. In Sozopolis, in fact, there were some 'who abolish the saving dispensation of our Lord Jesus Christ in so far as they can, and reject the grace of the great mystery, which was unrevealed from the ages but made manifest in His own time' (*Epist*. 261,1). For this reason Basil recalls the events of Christ's life on earth, stating that He himself prepared his work, initially through the patriarchs, the examples and rules intended for those who wanted to follow him, then through the Law given to Moses for the succour of men, then through the prophets who foretold the future salvation. 'In the last days Christ was made manifest in the flesh, "made of a woman, made under the law, that He might redeem them who were under the law, that we might receive the adoption of son"' (*Gal*. 4:4-5). This scriptural quote is intended to emphasize the human reality of the body of Christ: 'For if the flesh which was ruled over by death was one thing, and that which was assumed by the Lord was another, death would not have ceased accomplishing his own ends' and we would not have been redeemed thanks to his suffering. 'And what need was there of the Holy Virgin, if the God-bearing flesh was not to be assumed from the material from which Adam was moulded', but, as some had maintained, recalled in the previous letter, had he descended from heaven? Basil repeats that this means again advocating docetism, of which the Gnostic Valentinus had been an advocate, understanding the 'slave form (μορφὴ δούλου)' (*Phil*. 2:6-7), in which Christ was clothed by the incarnation, not as a concrete reality of the flesh, but as an apparent form (*Epist*. 261,2).[36] In those same years, Epiphanius also

[36] This interpretation had already been put forward some time earlier by Marcion, who also understood the passion of Christ in the docetic sense (cf. Tertull., *AM* V 20,3). Christ took the form of a slave as Lord, says Apollinaris (*KMP* 28, 178,3) and was called a 'slave' due to contact

expands on Apollinaris' heresy and attributes to his followers the doctrine that Christ caused his body, which was consubstantial with his divine nature (*Panarion* 77,20-4), to descend from heaven. Basil's objection to the docetism of the Apollinarists is repeated by Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 32,5: τὸν φαινόμενον, and *Epist*. 102,14-5). In reality, the accusation against Apollinaris of saying that the flesh of Christ had descended from heaven was false. He explicitly denied that the flesh of Christ had descended from heaven and stated that Christ had assumed human flesh from the Virgin (*De fide* 3, 194,19-22: οὐ γὰρ δὴ καὶ ἀσώματον γενέσθαι σῶμα δυνατόν, ὥσπερ ἀφρόνως ἕτεροι λέγουσιν): only after its union with the Logos had it become divine. The difference between the flesh of men and the equally human flesh of Christ consists only in the fact that it is united to the divine element (fr. 160-1 Lietzmann). Challenging Apollinaris Gregory of Nyssa subsequently states that the 'slave form' means the human person of Christ, not only his body (*Antirrh*. GNO III/I, 133,12; 148,29; 173,13).[37] Basil probably had not read that text of Apollinaris (in our opinion, not even other texts), but had contested the consequences that the Apollinarists drew from the postulate that there did not exist two sons (as the Antiochenes seemed to assert) and that therefore the body of Christ was that of the Logos, that is, necessarily not material, but 'heavenly'.

In *Epistle* 263, addressing Westerners, to ask them to help him in his attempt to resolve religious disputes in the East, Basil informs them that three heresies are tearing the East apart: that of Eustathius of Sebaste, that of Apollinaris and that of Paulinus (of Antioch), to which he adds that of Marcellus. Basil dedicates a refutation to each heresy, and, as regards Apollinaris, he repeats (as also in *Epist*. 244,3) that he has written many books, based, yes, on Scripture, but with a completely human character and content.[38] Furthermore, Apollinaris takes up Jewish doctrines in a ridiculous manner:

> but there are also his writings about the resurrection, composed in the manner of myths, or rather in the manner of the Jews, wherein he tells us to return again to the worship which is according to the law, and again to be circumcised, and to observe the Sabbath, and to abstain from meat, and to offer sacrifices to God, and to worship in the temple at Jerusalem, and in general to become Jews instead of Christians. What could be more ridiculous, or rather more foreign to the teaching of the Gospel, than these things? (*Epist*. 263,4).

(τῇ συναφείᾳ) with the form of a slave and with the body that had been formed (*De unione* 4, 187,3-5).

A reference to Valentinus, Marcion and Montanus precisely to assert the reality of the body of Christ can also be read in Epiphanius (*Pan*. 77,15,2; 25,1-2), who very coarsely further explains that the body of Christ, although he had the same needs as the body of other men, was not a corrupt body because of this (*Pan*. 77,15-6).

[37] H. Grelier, 'Comment décrire l'humanité du Christ' (2011), 547.

[38] Here Basil quotes *Prov*. 10:19, as also in *Epist*. 265,2.

The accusation of taking up again Sabellianism and some Jewish customs, now rendered useless thanks to the advent of Christ, is also the subject of the letter to the exiled Egyptian bishops (*Epist.* 265). Apollinaris' heresy afflicts Basil all the more since its perversion arose from one who at first 'had been one of ours' (reference to Apollinaris' previous orthodoxy), and whom Basil expected to be a true champion of the faith (265,2). On the contrary, Apollinaris introduced perverse doctrines, which are harmful to those who want to save themselves, and he divided the Church, sending his followers to the various Christian communities to weaken the authority of their bishops and raise the laity against them. His books renew Sabellius' impiety:[39] 'He calls Father and Son and Spirit the same'. Basil continues with accusations that remain, however, very much on the surface: 'Has not the doctrine of the incarnation been destroyed by him? Has not our Lord's saving dispensation been made ambiguous to the many because of the turbid and cloudy question he raises concerning the incarnation?' The hope of the resurrection is perverted by Apollinaris, who introduces words of silly old women and the fairy stories of the Jews. Indeed, he proclaims the future reconstitution of the Temple, the observance of the Jewish Law, a high priest according to the typos, despite the fact that Christians have the true high priest in Christ (*Hebr.* 7:15-28), a sacrifice for sins, despite the fact that Christians have the sacrificial Lamb, a new baptism and other Jewish prescriptions. If now the Law of the commandments has been made vain by Christ's teaching, it is clear that at the end of time (i.e. in the millennium) the doctrines of Christ will be annulled in the norms of the Law. That these Jewish themes, and particularly the need to return to sacrifice in the Temple and circumcision, were part of Apollinarism is also asserted by Gregory Nazianzen (*Epist.* 101,63-5). Some believe that Judaism and millenarianism were not supported by Apollinaris himself, but by his followers, as we can gather from Epiphanius (*Pan.* 77,36-8),[40] because according to Apollinaris 'the heavenly man' will always remain in the form he had on earth. So in part for this reason the Apollinarists were accused of millenarian expectations: paradise must be a corporeal place, if Christ and his Church find their fulfillment there.[41] However Epiphanius attributes these doctrines to Apollinaris himself,[42] although it remains unclear why Apollinaris linked millenarianism with Judaism.

[39] It has already been said above that this accusation against Apollinaris could not hold up, and it does not seem to us that it can be inferred from these words of Basil.

[40] This is said in the *Apodeixis*, see Greg. Nyss., *Antirrh.* (GNO III/1, 228,12-22).

[41] Millenarianism is explained by Daley in the sense that Apollinaris had said: if after the resurrection Christ becomes God and is no longer human, how can the Son of man send his angels? And how will we see the Son of man come with the clouds of heaven (*Matth.* 24:30-1)? Cf. B.E. Daley, '"Heavenly Man" and "Eternal Christ"' (2001), 486. The explanation does not seem clear to me.

[42] Apollinaris was influenced by millenarianism, characteristic of Asian Christianity, according to Emanuela Prinzivalli, 'Il millenarismo in Oriente da Metodio ad Apollinare' (1998), 141-51;

In conclusion, Basil came to know Apollinarism, probably that taught by the followers of Apollinaris and not by Apollinaris himself, only in the last years of his life and focuses his polemic on some non-essential or poorly understood points:

– the dependence of Apollinarism on Sabellianism, for which, moreover, Basil takes a (wrong) interpretation of others;[43]
– the denial of the existence of passions in Christ, and therefore the denial of his humanity;
– the taking up of some themes of Judaism and millenarianism.

Basil, therefore, does not fully understand the more specific reasons for Apollinarism, probably because Apollinaris' Christology spread in the last years of Basil's life,[44] when he was deeply involved with other problems: the need to condemn the Arians and his distress at the lack of help from the Westerners in the Antioch question, so that he did not have time to pursue the matter, which had been presented above all by his enemies as a personal *affaire*. The generic nature of his objections is also explained by the fact that, due to his untimely death, Basil was not informed of the deliberations of the Council of Antioch in 379, which seems to have been the first, in the East, to condemn the Christological doctrines of Apollinaris.

Gregory Nazianzen

Newer and more interesting, however, is Gregory Nazianzen's contribution to the controversy: Gregory mentions Apollinarism in some of his orations (nos. 22, 32 and 37) of his stay in Constantinople, before dealing with it thoroughly in the so-called 'theological epistles'. In the first of them (*Orat*. 22,13) Gregory expresses his opinion regarding a dispute that existed in the Nicene community and that had arisen recently: Apollinarism had spread in Cappadocia around 376-377, as we learned from Basil and had probably reached Constantinople shortly before. He wants to remain friends with both sides because the discussion takes place between brothers in the faith. Both contenders, Gregory says, dishonour both God and man (i.e. the incarnate Christ): in fact according to one of these two groups Christ[45] was not born in his entirety (ὅλως) for us and

see also J.N. Guinot, 'Théodoret et le millénarisme d'Apollinaire' (1998), 159-79; A. Capone, 'Apollinaris, Basil and Gregory of Nyssa' (2013), 318-9.

[43] A highly questionable dependence, as is observed by K. McCarthy Spoerl, 'Apollinarian Christology and the Anti-Marcellan Tradition' (1994) and H. Grélier, 'Comment décrire l'humanité du Christ' (2011), 546 n. 19.

[44] Although some works, such as the *KMP* and the *Epistula ad Iovianum*, date back to fifteen years earlier. Apollinaris extensively proposes his Christology in *KMP* 12; 28-30; 35-6.

[45] That is, God (i.e. the incarnate Son of God), as the Greek ὁ μέν explains, and not man, as understood by Mossay, Grégoire de Nazanze *Discours* 20-23 (1980), 247. In this case Gregory's reasoning is completely distorted.

was not nailed to the cross, and therefore he was neither buried nor did he rise again: this is the opinion of those who love Christ erroneously (τῶν κακῶς φιλοχρίστων). Gregory means that, according to such people, the Logos is not present in the incarnate Christ, but only a man, and consequently they love Christ (that is, they want to honour his divinity) wrongly, by saying that only a man was crucified, and not also God (who did not become incarnate). In this way, God is honoured only in an area in which (ἐνταῦθα οὗ) honour consists in dishonour: an effective phrase, typical of Gregory's rhetoric and the meaning of which is difficult to explain: one believes one is honouring God by denying that He died on the cross, but in reality one is dishonouring Him because he is not attributing to him the greatness of the passion. For this reason, Christ is divided into two sons (the Son of God and the son of man) or is constituted by two sons. This part of the polemic is probably directed against Diodorus and the Antiochenes. Apollinaris had already argued against the existence of the two sons and denied (*KMP* 31) the existence of δύο πρόσωπα, and with even greater decision he had asserted (*De fide* 6-7, 198,25-199,24): οὐδεμία διαίρεσις τοῦ λόγου καὶ τῆς σαρκὸς αὐτοῦ ἐν ταῖς θείαις προφέρεται γραφαῖς, ἀλλ' ἔστι μία φύσις, μία ὑπόστασις, μία ἐνέργεια, ἓν πρόσωπον, ὅλος θεός, ὅλος ἄνθρωπος ὁ αὐτός. Οὐσία γὰρ αὐτοῦ κατὰ μὲν τὸ ἀόρατον ἡ θεότης, κατὰ δὲ τὸ ὁρατὸν ἡ σάρξ.[46] … ἓν γὰρ καὶ ταυτὸν τὸ σῶμα καὶ ὁ θεός, οὗ τὸ σῶμα. Apollinaris had also denied the existence of two natures in Christ (*Epist. ad Dionysium* I, 258,15). Epiphanius, who rejects the existence of two sons (*Pan.* 77,29,5), writes in the same way, that is, against Diodorus, even if he does not name him.

Gregory continues: there is another Christ (ὁ δέ), that is, the man, who according to the adversaries has not been assumed by the Son of God and is not perfectly honoured, but is humiliated and stripped of his main part, if it is true that the main part of the man consists in what has been done in the likeness of God and in the power of the intellect (ἡ τοῦ νοῦ δύναμις). This Christology too is the object of Gregory's irony:

> It was necessary, in fact, that, since divine nature is a unity (θεότης ἥνωται), human nature be divided and that they, who for the rest are so intelligent, were devoid of intellect regarding the intellect (περὶ τὸν νοῦν ἀνοηταίνειν), and that I wasn't saved in my entirety (ὅλον),[47] despite having sinned and been condemned in my entirety following the transgression of the protoplasts and the theft of the Adversary,[48] so that both the grace of God and my salvation has diminished.[49]

[46] In this distinction between λόγος and σάρξ the flesh must be understood as having an 'intelligent soul'; indeed the Gospel says that the Logos 'became σάρξ', it does not add 'and soul'.

[47] That is, in the body and in the intellect.

[48] By inducing the first parents to sin, the devil takes possession of man, and 'steals him from God'.

[49] This entire sentence is a continuation of the previous one, said in polemic with the Apollinarists, and should not be put in a new line, as Mossay does.

Gregory therefore wants to reject both opposing Christologies of the Apollinarists and of the followers of Diodorus,[50] and ironically attributes the lack of intellect to the Apollinarists, who claimed that the incarnate Christ was devoid of intellect (just as he attributes being 'furious of massacre (*ares*)', ἀρειομανεῖς to the Arians), as in *Epistle* 101 some years later. The reference to the two opposing doctrines in a homily of that same year 379 is analogous, but shorter: according to the quarrelsome Christians of Constantinople there are many Christs, and not just one: among others, the man without intellect (τὸν ἄνουν ἄνθρωπον) (*Orat*. 32,5).

On the other hand, in *Homily* 37, written at the beginning of the year 381, only the existence of two sons is excluded: here it seems that Gregory refers only to the Antiochens.[51] The Son of God assumed what he was not, that is, humanity, but in the incarnation there are not two sons, because God is the two realities together, the divine and the human:

> Christ annihilated what he was (*Phil*. 2:7) and assumed what he was not, but did not become two, because he accepted to become one composed of two. Both realities, the one that assumed and the one that was assumed are in fact God (Θεὸς γὰρ ἀμφότερα), two natures (δύο φύσεις) that converged in a unity, not two sons (οὐχ υἱοὶ δύο): the mixing (σύγκρασις) should not be misunderstood! (*Orat*. 37,2).

In 382 Gregory returned to the controversy against the opposing positions of Apollinaris and Diodorus, as he had done in 379 with the homilies 22 and 32. In *De vita sua* (611b-630), a poem that has a narrative character, the style is quite didactic and not elevated: it avoids refinements and 'acutenesses'. Referring first to Apollinaris, Gregory condemns those who destroy the mixing of the Logos and God with us (πρὸς ἡμᾶς τοῦ Θεοῦ κρᾶσιν Λόγου), who assumed, without undergoing change (οὐ τραπείς),[52] a man possessing soul, mind and

[50] The opposition between Apollinarists and followers of Diodorus had already been remarked by J. McGuckin, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 237 and footnote; Chr. Beeley, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 127 and 292; *id*., 'The Early Christological Controversy' (2011), 398-406; V.H. Drecoll, 'Apollinarius, *Ad Iovianum*' (2015), 51-2 and 54 and S. Elm, 'Apollinarius of Laodicea and Gregory of Nazianzus' (2015), 17, according to whom the passage is 'little noted': in reality it is well known. This had already been the opinion of the ancients, such as Iohannes Grammaticus and Severus of Antioch: I derive this fact from M. Heimgartner, 'Neue Fragmente Diodors von Tarsus' (2015), 198. On the Christology of Diodorus a summary in Chr. Beeley, 'The Early Christological Controversy' (2011), 388-95, who is of the opinion that Gregory is much more polemical towards Diodorus than towards Apollinaris (*ibid*. 396-7) (Beeley also maintains that in theological epistles Gregory polemicizes with Diodorus and not with Apollinaris – see p. 302-3 – on which I do not agree).

[51] Thus, correctly Chr. Beeley, 'The Early Christological Controversy' (2011), 400-1. This opposition to Apollinaris and Diodorus together is also maintained by J. McGuckin for the theological epistles, *Saint Gregory of Nazianzus* (2001), 391-2, but in our opinion what applies to homily 22 does not apply to the epistles, in which, as in the poems, Gregory takes a different position, referring only to Apollinaris.

[52] The change of Christ was the problem already discussed by Basil (*Epist*. 262).

πάθη, that is, the entire original Adam, except for sin (cf. *Hebr*. 4:15): thanks to the mixing with my soul, says Gregory elsewhere (*Carm*. II 1,54; PG 37, 1399,17-8), I have become God (αὐτὰρ ἔπειτα θεὸς θεότητι μιγείσης / ψυχῆς), which is a theme, that of deification, particularly dear to Gregory. Apollinaris, on the other hand, introduces a God without intellect (ἄνουν), as if he feared that the intellect would fight against God: on the contrary, it is the flesh, if anything, that is most opposed to God. Or Apollinaris fears that, while all the rest of man is in need of salvation, it is inexorably established that the intellect perishes, precisely that which most needs to be saved by God, since it was the intellect that sinned, and in a pre-eminent degree, when the first man was created. In fact, he who had received the law was also he who transgressed it and he who was the transgressor was also he who had to be assumed (ὁ δ'ἦν παριδών, τοῦτο καὶ προσλήψιμον).[53] Consequently, Gregory hopes that the Logos will not save me halfway, since I have suffered the entire misfortune of condemnation, and that God will not be despised, as if he had not assumed all of me, but only the mud (i.e. the flesh) and a soul without a mind, which is the soul of an unreasonable animal.

The polemic against the Antiochenes (631-651b) follows on the basis of the conception of the middle way between the extremes (which had also already been put forward in *Oration* 22). The Apollinarists stumble with more or less equal risk, but in the opposite direction to those (the Antiochenes), who thoughtlessly introduce two Sons, one who comes from God and the other from the Virgin: both share the fortunate connection (between the Logos and the man) effected on earth (that is, the incarnation of the Son of God), the Apollinarists, on the one hand, 'scraping away' the man from the incarnate Christ, the others instead duplicating (the Son) badly. In fact, if there are two sons, the consequence will be that we worship two gods instead of one, or, to avoid this error, we have to exclude composition from God (τὸ σύνθετον).[54] Indeed, if the son of man is separated from the Son of God, the divinity could not experience (πάθοι) any of those sensations that are proper to the flesh; on the other hand, human nature has participated in the whole of divinity, not as is the case in a prophet or another inspired person, who did not have participation in God but rather in God's prerogatives;[55] the flesh instead had divinity in its substance (οὐσιωθεῖσα), as the sun is present in the rays. Let them go to ruin if they do not worship man-God as a unity (ὡς ἓν ἄνθρωπον Θεόν), the one who assumed together with what was assumed (τὸν προσλαβόντα σύν τε τῷ προσλήμματι),

[53] The extremely rare adjective προσλήψιμον indicates the assumption, by Christ, of human reality, and the sentence anticipates the famous one of *Epist*. 101.

[54] The term is equivalent to that of 'mixing'. Apollinaris had used the term 'contact' (συνάφεια) in *De unione* 12.

[55] The question of the two sons and the question of the difference between the incarnation of the Son of God and the inspiration of the prophets will then be discussed in *Epistle* 101; the discussion in Gregory of Nyssa's *Epistula ad Theophilum* is analogous.

the one who is outside time and that which is penetrated with time (i.e. humanity), the one who came from one Father and the one who came from one mother, two natures that have merged into one Christ, one Christ and the Son, not one nature (οὐ φύσιν μίαν).[56]

The homily, since its aim is to teach and inform a vast public that does not have specific knowledge, cannot go more deeply into difficult problems, such as those of Christology; moreover, when he deems it appropriate, Gregory cannot help playing rhetorically with words. Therefore, Gregory's homilies provide only a few essential details – those that most affect the audience – of Apollinarism. To investigate the problem Gregory resorts to the use of the epistle (nos. 101, 102, and 202), because the epistle can also have doctrinal content, as it already had in both pagan, and finally, also Christian culture (an example is given by the epistles of Origen).[57] The so-called 'theological epistles', therefore, differ from the Nazianzen's other epistles, because the personal ones have a private character and a brilliant rhetorical and literary formulation, the theological epistles, on the other hand, are short treatises, in which thought is very dense; their importance is generally recognized.

Cledonius was a presbyter of Nazianzus, and Gregory sent epistles 101 and 102 to him in 382 to warn him of the apparently friendly propaganda that the Apollinarists were making in support of their theses. As we have seen from Basil's correspondence, Apollinaris also had numerous followers, and one of the most intelligent, as Epiphanius also recognized (*Panar*. 77,20,3), was Vitalis (or Vitalius), who had been a presbyter of Meletius in Antioch.[58] Probably due to the enmity that separated Meletius from Flavian, Flavian, when he became bishop of Antioch after Meletius' death in 381, refused to meet him (Sozom., *HE* VI 25,3). Vitalis had already gone to Rome previously in 376 to obtain support against Meletius, and Damasus, who had already condemned Apollinarism in

[56] A brief mention of Apollinarism is found also further on (vv. 1184-5), but it is of little use, because starting from verse 1164 Gregory summarizes all the existing and past (or possible) heresies. According to Beeley, this description of the two heresies, like the controversy contained in the theological epistles, is directed against Diodorus rather than against Apollinaris, 'The Early Christological Controversy' (2011), 397-8, but in *De vita sua* Gregory assumes the equidistance he had followed in orations 22 and 32.

[57] See above, p. 106-8. The manuscript tradition preserved these epistles among Gregory's orations, rather than among the letters, and this collocation was also accepted by some publishers of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. It was the Maurists who published them together with the other epistles and gave them the number that they still retain, but, once again, due to the different manuscript tradition, in our times they were published separately: they are not present in the edition of the letters edited by Paul Gallay for the Collection des Universités de France, but were published, again by Paul Gallay and Maurice Jourjon, in Sources Chrétiennes 208 (1974). It would be advisable, however, to keep them together with the others, because the literary genre is unique.

[58] A discussion of the events of Vitalis' life in E. Mühlenberg, *Apollinaris von Laodicea* (1969), 45-56 and U. Reutter, *Damasus, Bischof von Rom* (2009), 362-73.

the letter *Ea gratia*, asked him for a confession of faith. Vitalis expounds it in Περὶ πίστεως (fr. 172 Lietzmann):

> With regard to the economy of the Saviour in the flesh we believe that the incarnation for the renewal of humanity took place the God Logos remaining unaltered and not changed. In fact, remaining truly the Son of God according to the eternal generation from God, he also became the son of man according to the generation from a virgin and is one and the same perfect God according to the divine nature and consubstantial with the Father; the same became perfect man according to the generation from a virgin and consubstantial to men according to the flesh.

Then follow the anathemas for those who say that the Son has a body that comes from heaven or is consubstantial with God according to the flesh;[59] for those who do not admit that the flesh of the Lord comes from the Holy Virgin and is consubstantial to men; for those who say that our Lord and Saviour, born of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary according to the flesh, is devoid of soul or sensation or reasoning or intellect; for those who dare to say that Christ underwent passion in divinity and not in the flesh, as it is written; for those who divide and separate our Lord and Saviour and say that one was the Son the God Logos and another the man assumed and do not admit that he is unique and the same.

Indeed Apollinaris had asserted that Christ is consubstantial to both God and men, but he had clearly specified what consubstantiality consisted in, that is, in the body (*De unione* 8, 188,9-12: καὶ θεῷ ὁμοούσιος κατὰ τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἀόρατον, συμπεριλαμβανομένης τῷ ὀνόματι καὶ τῆς σαρκός … καὶ πάλιν ἀνθρώποις ὁμοούσιος (hence the term ὁμοούσιος is used in the manner of the Homoiousians). Elsewhere (*De fide* 3, 194,15-9) Apollinaris states that we must not consider the flesh of Christ as despicable as ours, under the pretext of the consubstantial, so that the consubstantiality with God of the flesh of Christ must not be understood as pure and simple human carnality, but as a union of the flesh with the divine nature.

After making his profession of faith Vitalis left Rome with a letter from Damasus for Paulinus (*Per ipsum filium meum*), whom Damasus supported in the schism of Antioch. It confirmed Vitalis' orthodoxy, but later Damasus sent a further two letters (*Illud sane* and the so-called *Tomus Damasi*) stating that only those who not only accepted the Nicene creed, but also affirmed that the Son of God had become all that we are, with the exclusion of sin, could be accepted in communion, so that an anathema should be pronounced on whoever taught that the Logos had taken the place of the intellect in the incarnate Lord

[59] We have already mentioned the doctrine of some Apollinarists that the body of Jesus comes from heaven; that it is consubstantial with the Son, had been maintained by some of them, as Epiphanius (*Panar*. 77,20) informs us, with whom Vitalis, therefore, does not want to have communion.

and that he who had existed before the centuries was not the same as he who was born of the Virgin, i.e. that there were two sons of God: that is, the very question that had also been important for Gregory.[60]

After Vitalis returned to Antioch, Epiphanius also went there, having in that year (377) completed his *Panarion*. In the *Panarion* (77,20-24) Epiphanius focuses on Apollinaris, praising him highly and expressing feelings of sincere admiration, but grieving for his doctrinal deviation. It seems, however, that Epiphanius wants to separate Apollinaris from his disciples, attributing to them the various heretical doctrines, including that according to which Christ had a body that had descended from heaven, as seen in Basil's *Epistles* 260 and 261, and that his body was consubstantial with the divine nature. Epiphanius had also have asked Vitalis for a declaration of faith on the Trinity and the humanity of Christ; Vitalis did not refuse to do so, and, when his accusers reproached him that he taught that Christ did not assume a complete human nature, he asserted with great solemnity that Christ, on the contrary, had actually assumed it. But when asked if a human intellect was present in Christ, Vitalis denied it and said that 'we say that Christ is a complete human being if we put divine nature in the place of the intellect', thus confirming the suspicions of Damasus.[61] Furthermore, Vitalis' insistence that the Logos and man are two distinct realities seems to be a response to the accusation that was made against him, that he dissolved humanity into divinity, so that it resulted in a "celestial man". Vitalis' statement also echoes that of *Tomus ad Antiochenos*, in which those who said that the Lord is 'without soul or without reason or without intellect' were anathematized (7,2).[62] In reality Apollinaris (*KMP* 31, p. 179,6-8) said that 'the Logos of God had made Himself man for our salvation so that we could obtain likeness with the heavenly (τὴν ὁμοίωσιν τοῦ ἐπουρανίου)', that is with 'the one who is in heaven ', not with a 'heavenly man', understood thus on the basis of *John* 3:13: 'And no man hath ascended up to heaven, but he that came down from heaven, even the Son of man which is in heaven'.

Gregory Nazianzen knows that some Apollinarists in Cappadocia are strengthened by the previous approval of Damasius, granted to Vitalis (*Epist*. 101,8 and 102,6), so that it is useful to turn our attention to Vitalis, as well as to Apollinaris. Vitalis' profession of faith was not criticized by Gregory (if he had read it),

[60] As observed by E. Mühlenberg, *Apollinaris von Laodicea* (1969), 53-4, Apollinaris was recognized as orthodox in Rome, and the accusations against him were brought in the East, as is attested also by Jerome, who, in *Epistle* 15 to Damasus counts Apollinaris among the heretics of Antioch. However, Jerome does not mention Apollinaris, but Vitalis, so that he is informed of Apollinarism on the basis of the events in Rome, and the question he is concerned about was the doctrine of divine hypostaseis, not Christology.

[61] On Vitalis see also A. Capone, 'La polemica apollinarista alla fine del IV secolo' (2011), 500-1.

[62] This raises the problem of whether Apollinaris had already formulated his Christology in 362 and therefore before the *Epistula ad Iovianum*.

who insists above all on the unity between the Son of God and man and the fact that there are not two sons. In our opinion, therefore, Gregory writes his letters to Cledonius, targeting above all the preaching of Vitalis, whose followers at Nazianzus had made it known that he had been approved by the bishop of Rome, although we cannot think that Vitalis' teaching was completely different from that of Apollinaris, who, among other things, is recalled by Gregory himself at the end of his *Epistle* 101. Gregory intervened with his epistle to Cledonius not because he sought the episcopal see of Nazianzus, but because he had accepted it out of a sense of responsibility towards the people of God troubled by the preaching of the Apollinarists: 'Because both the leaders and the people were agitated by the desire for a guide and because of those ruinous, senseless wild beasts that form a God devoid of intellect, which took on consistency inside human bowels (θεὸν ἀνδρομέοισιν ἐνὶ σπλάγνοισιν παγέντα / ἔκνοον ἦτορ ἔχουσι νόου δίχα μορφώσαντες)' (*Carm.* II 1,19,68-71; PG 37, 1276-7).[63] It does not seem certain to me that he knew Apollinaris' work *by direct reading*, even though he knows a book on the Trinity, written by him (*Epist.* 101,66)[64] and he is informed that there are many works written by Apollinaris, including a new Psalter (*ibid.* 101,73). In conclusion, we can only be certain that Gregory of Nyssa, who writes the *Antirrheticus* against the *Apodeixis*, had read Apollinaris' works directly.

The purpose of *Epistle* 101, not unlike *Oration* 22, is to contest above all two fundamental points of Apollinarism: that the Logos of God replaces the intellect in the incarnate Christ (and this had also been confessed by Vitalis), because otherwise there would be two sons, the divine and the human. Gregory had already argued against the Apollinarists over the first problem and against the Antiochenes over the second in *Oration* 22, but the problem of the joint presence of the son of man and the Son of God in the incarnate Christ could also involve Gregory, as he too, though not accepting a separate existence of the two, stated however that the son of man was man in his totality. This was a more difficult problem to solve, because the Apollinarists had also denied that there were two sons, so that, according to some scholars, Gregory polemicized against the Antiochenes and not the Apollinarists, with whom Gregory had many beliefs in common.[65] Apollinaris, in fact, had opposed the interpretation that two sons existed, saying:

[63] The usual play on words between the lack of human intellect of the incarnate Christ – one of the most striking points of the controversy – and the lack of intellect of the Apollinarists.

[64] Which it is is not clear. Perhaps the *Katà meros pistis*, which had certainly been written twenty years before (360/361), although the writing of which stretches over several years and seems to be a composite work.

[65] This is Chr. Beeley's opinion, *Gregory of Nazianzus* (2008), 285-92; *id.*, 'The Early Christological Controversy' (2011), 398-406 and that of S. Elm, 'Apollinarius of Laodicea' (2015), 18. But the letter 101 makes explicit reference to the Apollinarists who were in Nazianzus, not to the

There is only one Son, the same both before and after the incarnation, man and God, and both constitute a unity. And one must not think that the Logos – God is a person, Jesus man another person, but the Son who existed before the centuries subsisted in unity with the flesh coming from Mary, making himself a complete and holy man and free of sins (εἷς υἱός, καὶ πρὸ τῆς σαρκώσεως καὶ μετὰ τὴν σάρκωσιν ὁ αὐτός, ἄνθρωπος καὶ θεός, ἑκάτερος ὡς ἕν. Καὶ οὐχ ἕτερον μὲν πρόσωπον ὁ θεὸς λόγος, ἕτερον δὲ ἄνθρωπος Ἰησοῦς, ἀλλ᾽ αὐτὸς ὁ προϋπάρχων υἱὸς ἑνωθεὶς σαρκὶ ἐκ Μαρίας κατέστη, τέλειον καὶ ἅγιον καὶ ἀναμάρτητον ἄνθρωπον συνιστὰς ἑαυτόν) (*KMP* 36).

The same assertion can also be found in the previous *Epistula ad Iovianum* (253,3-7), and Drecoll observes that, if we limit ourselves to reading Apollinaris' statements set out in that epistle, he could hardly be accused of having professed the existence of a soulless Christ and an erroneous Christology. At that time Apollinaris had already polemicized against Diodorus, who claimed that the son born of Mary had been accepted by grace as the son of God.[66]

The fundamental point for Gregory, therefore, is to specify that the refutation of the Antiochenes must not consist in the way put forward by the Apollinarists. To say that 'the man of the Lord (κυριακὸς ἄνθρωπος)' is a 'man without intellect' (ἄνους ἄνθρωπος) is absurd. The 'man of the Lord', that is, the incarnate Christ, is not a man, but the Lord himself and God: with this assertion (οὐδὲ γάρ) man is not separated from divinity, but it is stated that man and the Lord are the same (*Epist.* 101,12-13). Therefore Gregory takes up the (Apollinarian) definition κυριακὸς ἄνθρωπος, but modifies it according to his thinking: the man of the Lord is a man in all respects, but not for this reason is he separated from the Son of God, as the Antiochenes believed:

Previously he was not a man, but only God and the Son of God; he existed before the centuries, not mixed with the body and all that belongs to the body, and finally he was also a man, a man assumed for our salvation, subject to passion in the flesh but free from passion in the divinity, circumscribed in the body but not circumscribed in spirit, (therefore) the same (was) earthly and celestial, was seen and was the object of our thought, contained and not contained, so that the whole man, who had fallen into sin, could be reconstituted by the one who was simultaneously totally man and totally God (*Epist.* 101,13-5).[67]

These words underline the duality and unity together of the incarnate Christ. It should be borne in mind that Gregory, even if he speaks of σῶμα and σάρξ, does not specifically mean the body or the flesh and all their characteristics,

Antiochens, and also mentions Apollinaris; Gregory also writes two other poems against the Apollinarists (see p. 309-12). Beeley's opinion is not accepted by A. Hofer, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 128-50.

[66] V.H. Drecoll, 'Apollinarius, *Ad Iovianum*' (2015), 43.

[67] See also *Epist.* 101,31.

such as passions,[68] but also the *human* person of Christ, even if the concept of 'human person' had not yet been clearly defined. This uncertainty had already appeared in the Trinitarian theology, where πρόσωπον had remained a vague and therefore little used term, and appears even stronger in Christology. The existence of only one incarnate Son of God, and not of two sons, is also asserted by Gregory immediately afterwards. If the Son of God is the son of man, it follows that the body of Christ is absolutely human and did not descend from heaven, as Basil had already disputed (*Epist*. 261,2).

Through a series of anathemas, Gregory insists on the humanity of Christ, the guarantee of salvation for all humanity. They were thoroughly studied by Andrew Hofer,[69] here we therefore limit ourselves to only a few of our observations. Mary must be believed to be the true mother of God (θεοτόκος), so that we must reject the opinion of those who think that Christ only passed through her, as if through a channel (σωλήν), which implies that Christ possessed a body not formed in the womb of the Virgin, but a heavenly body (οὐράνιον σῶμα), as Apollinaris claimed (101,15-6).[70] So he who was born of her is truly God, and not a man in whom God clothed himself,[71] because this would not be a birth, but the negation of birth (101,17), and there were not two sons, one generated by God and the other by the mother of God (101,18). There are, therefore, two natures, God and man, just as there are two natures, that of the soul and that of the body:[72] in fact, when Paul speaks of an inner man and an outer man (1*Cor*. 15:45-7), he does not mean that there are two men (101,19). Thus Gregory establishes a parallelism, that has remained famous, between Christology and Trinitarian theology, but in the opposite direction: the Saviour is

[68] Σάρξ is not only equivalent to σῶμα, but indicates the body with its vital principle: fr. 22, 23,24 Lietzmann, E. Mühlenberg, *Apollinaris of Laodicea* (1969), 150; every man is νοῦς ἔνσαρκος: fr. 69 and 72 Lietzmann.

[69] A. Hofer, *Christ in the Life* (2013), 131-47.

[70] Cf. *De unione* 1, Lietzmann 185. In the *Apodeixis* (fr. 34 and 36 Lietzmann = Greg. Nyss., *Antirrh*. GNO III/I, 150,25-151,4 and 154,23-7) Apollinaris emphasizes the celestial character of the whole Christ, but also specifies that Christ was the Son of man who descended from heaven (Greg. Nyss., *Antirrh*. 138,18-21 and 25-9) and therefore in the incarnation was the θεὸς ἔνσαρκος who 'entered man passing through the Virgin (παροδικῶς δι' αὐτῆς διεξελθόντα)' (*ibid*. 166,21-8). It is ambiguous that Gregory of Nyssa also rarely uses the formula 'mother of God' (θεοτόκος), to which he prefers 'she who had God in herself' (θεοδόχος) (on which, see above, p. 287); likewise the expression 'God who suffers passion' is rare, unlike in Gregory of Nazianzus. The term θεοτόκος, however, is also found in Apollinaris (*De fide* 4,195; 6,198).

[71] So might this be a form of adoptionism? This would explain the fact that Basil accused Apollinaris of Sabellianism (*Epist*. 265,2).

[72] This is an example to show that they are two distinct realities. Gallay *ad locum* understands these words as explaining only the word 'man', which precedes them, but in this case the parallelism is lost. Chr. Beeley, 'Cyril of Alexandria and Gregory Nazianzen' (2009), 401 means: 'There are two natures, God and humanity, since there are both soul and body', and therefore seems to understand the parallelism God – human nature (in Christ) in the same sense of the parallelism soul – body.

not ἄλλος καὶ ἄλλος ('one and another'), as in the Trinity, where there are two different Persons, but ἄλλο καὶ ἄλλο ('one reality and another'), one divine and one human that constitute the incarnate Christ.[73] Christ, therefore, is a single being, constituted by joint divinity and humanity (ἐν τῇ συγκράσει),[74] which, however, must not be considered autonomous entities, but are predicates of the one and the same Christ (101,20-1), so that Christ carried out his activity not by grace, as happens in the prophets, but because the two realities are joined according to their substance (101,22).[75] Once this point has been established, we must venerate the crucified Christ, who did not become perfect thanks to his works nor was he adopted as a son after baptism or after the resurrection:[76] all that had a beginning or was made complete at a later time cannot be God (101,23-4). Christ, therefore, did not abandon his flesh on earth at the time of the resurrection and did not leave it devoid of divinity, but he always exists with the flesh that he assumed, and in the last times he will be clothed with that same flesh (101,25). It was not set aside in the sun, as the Manicheans dream, and was not dispersed in the air: this is demonstrated by the fact that Christ was touched by his disciples after the resurrection (101,25-8). At the end of time his flesh will undergo a transformation, analogous to that which took place during the Transfiguration, because the divine nature is stronger than the human: in this way the transformation of the flesh of Christ is an example of the human body, which will be also transfigured after the resurrection (101,29). Having become lord of his flesh, Christ will no longer be subject to its limitations, but we will see him only with the intellect; during his earthly life, however, his flesh was of the same nature and origin as our human flesh, and did not descend from heaven (101,30) (see also 101,56; *Epist*. 202, 11-2).

The texts cited by the Apollinarists in their defense to claim that the body of Christ was heavenly (1*Cor*. 15:47 and especially *John* 3:13: 'And no man hath ascended up to heaven, but he that came down from heaven, even the Son of man which is in heaven')[77] refer to the body united with him who is in heaven (διὰ τὴν πρὸς τὸν οὐράνιον ἕνωσιν).[78] If Scripture says (*Eph*. 3:17) that

[73] The neuter ἄλλο serves to indicate that the two do not constitute the person. This separation is also denied by Apollinaris, *Epist. ad Iovian.* 3, with the distinction εἷς – εἷς and ἕτερος – ἕτερος.

[74] The term has a Christological meaning, as observed above.

[75] This is also said by Gregory in *De vita sua* (I 2,11,641-4). The same opposition is proposed by Gregory of Nyssa in the *Epistula ad Theophilum* (p. 316).

[76] All this can be understood as a response to Photinus, even if Gregory refers to the pagan practices of deification after death. But Basil had already accused Apollinaris of following Sabellius' doctrines: perhaps Gregory also repeats this accusation.

[77] See fr. 34 Lietzmann. Gregory, therefore, is as informed of the problem as Basil.

[78] According to Chr. Beeley, 'Cyril of Alexandria' (2009), 391-2 the term ἕνωσις is generally avoided by Gregory, who uses it only twice with reference to the incarnation because it had been used by Apollinaris, and gives it a meaning similar to that of 'hypostatic union', typical of Cyril.

Christ lives in our hearts, this does not exclude the existence of the visible flesh of Christ, but means the flesh that we think (but do not see), because the two natures are mixed, just as the names are mixed, and they perform "perichoresis" thanks to the essence of their union (κιρναμένων ὥσπερ τῶν φύσεων οὕτω δὴ καὶ τῶν κλήσεων καὶ περιχωρουσῶν εἰς ἀλλήλας τῷ λόγῳ τῆς συμφυΐας) (101,31). In this dense reasoning Gregory now speaks explicitly of the two natures in Christ and uses the concept of perichoresis to clarify their mutual relations.

The famous words (101,32) follow: that which has not been assumed has not been healed,[79] the necessary condition for refuting a fundamental statement of the Apollinarist doctrine, according to which the Logos was the νοῦς of the incarnate Christ. If this were the case, Gregory ironically objects, taking up what he had already observed in the homilies 22 and 32, the man Christ would have been devoid of intellect (ἄνους ἄνθρωπος) (101,31). The completeness of the humanity of Christ is an essential condition for salvation: the whole man had sinned, and the whole man had to be healed. The Apollinarists deny man complete salvation and attribute only the flesh to the Saviour, that is, they present 'a picture', an image, not the real man, because the real man is represented by the intellect: if man is without a soul, he cannot be a human being (101,32-3).[80] The Apollinarists take up the words of the Arians, who attribute the passion to Christ, because what moves the body is also what is subject to the passion (101,34-5).[81] If, on the other hand, Christ is endowed with a soul (understood as the principle of life), but is not rational, he cannot also be man (because man is an animate and rational being). It is inevitable, then, that the 'form' and the 'tent' which will be eliminated (2*Cor*. 5:1-14) indicate *only* the human body, and that the soul, instead, is of an irrational animate being; therefore an irrational animate being will be saved, but I, who am rational, will not. In fact, if the Apollinarists argue, to respond to the objections, that the divine nature (that is, the presence of the divine Νοῦς instead of the human νοῦς) was enough for the incarnate Christ, then the reality of Christ has nothing to do with man.[82]

[79] A famous aphorism, which had already been enunciated by Irenaeus (*AH* V 14,1-2). According to B.E. Daley, '"Heavenly Man" and "Eternal Christ"' (2001), 479, Gregory could have read it in Origen, who asserted: 'the human being would not have been saved in its entirety if Christ had not assumed the whole human being' (cf. Orig., *Heracl.* 7,7-8). But the formula is characteristic of Gregory.

[80] See also Greg. Nyss., *Antirrh.* 165,9-28.

[81] Gregory's polemical discourse is very concise: according to the Arians evidently the passion cannot be attributed to God, so the Son, who experienced it, cannot be considered God. Some of the arguments of the polemic against Arius are also used against Apollinaris, S.-P. Bergjan, 'Antiarianische Argumente gegen Apollinaris' (2011), 490.

[82] Apollinaris (fr. 150) stated that there are not two intellects in Christ, the divine and the human (and therefore there are not two persons in Christ).

The divine reality united to the flesh alone does not constitute the man Christ, just as the soul alone or the flesh and soul without the νοῦς do not constitute it. It is therefore necessary to maintain the principle that man is such in his totality and to unite the divinity to Christ the complete man (μίξον τὴν θεότητα) (101,36).[83] If the Apollinarists also state that the man Christ could not have contained two perfect, that is, not deficient, realities,[84] that is to say, the Logos and the complete man (which therefore contained the νοῦς), this principle applies to material, but not to non-material, realities, whose nature, on the contrary, is precisely that of being united with material realities in a way that is not bodily and without dividing itself (ἀσωμάτως καὶ ἀμερίστως).[85] For example, many sounds together can be heard with a single act of the human ear or our eye can see many things together, without diminishing the ability to hear or see (101,37-9). A greater reality (in this case, the divine nature of incarnated Christ) does not prevent the presence within it of a smaller one (the human intellect): a ray can exist even if the sun is present, and a drop of water can exist even in the river (101,40-2). The concept of perfection also varies: our intellect is perfect, but it is perfect with reference to the soul and body, and yet, if compared to that of God, it is not perfect, because it is his servant, and there exist other analogous cases of relative perfection (101,43-5).

And if the Apollinarists claim that our intellect was condemned by God, because sin was caused by it, so that Christ could not have used a human intellect, then the flesh was also condemned, and yet they consider it worthy of the incarnation. In reality, both the upper and lower elements were assumed by Christ to be sanctified and to save the whole man. Gregory, therefore, was accused of being 'worshipper of a man' (ἀνθρωπολάτρης), because he venerates the Incarnate Christ in his entirety (101,46-8). On the contrary: just as the rational soul in Christ is intermediary between God and man, so the (divine) intellect unites with the (human) intellect, in that it is closer and more familiar

[83] Here the term is used as in *Orat*. 38,13, as seen above, p. 285 and also in the poem I 1,10 (p. 310-1).

[84] If in Christ a real synthesis of human form takes place, that is, of a celestial and an earthly element, then these two elements must behave as parts of a whole. To this end Apollinaris follows the Aristotelian principle (*Metaph*. Z 13, 1039a) that 'two perfect beings cannot unite'. Apollinaris demands, in the interest of the unity of Christ, that the human nature of Christ be incomplete, that is, without the soul (the Nous). Since something new, a whole, was formed with the assumption of the flesh by the Logos, one can simply speak of 'parts' (*De unione* 5, 187,7-14 Lietzmann). The essential parts of man constitute a whole, and this whole can be called both 'flesh' and 'soul', without, as a consequence, one of its parts losing its substance. If the incarnate Christ is composed of a perfect divinity and humanity (τέλειαι), also asserted by Gregory of Nyssa (*Antirrh*. GNO III/I, 200,7), Apollinaris concludes (*Antirrh*. 199,18-20) that there exist two sons, and therefore there is a quaternity in the divine nature, H. Grelier, 'Comment décrire l'humanité du Christ' (2011).

[85] Like the soul, which in its nature is not linked to materiality, as Porphyry had asserted and therefore Gregory of Nyssa repeats in *De anima et resurrectione* (p. 170-1).

to it, and (unites) to the flesh through this (our intellect), which mediates between the divinity and the materiality of the flesh (101,49), that is, through the soul endowed with intellect, which is the human soul.[86]

Gregory then discusses the entry (of God) into a man (ἐνανθρώπησις), or, as his opponents say, the becoming flesh (σάρκωσις). It cannot be argued that this happened in order for God, who is infinite, to become finite and therefore to have relations with men, as had already happened in past times, as Scripture narrates (101,50). No, the incarnation occurred to sanctify the whole man, like with like, so it was necessary for Christ incarnate to have a human mind, as he had a human body and soul.[87] In Adam, in fact, the intellect not only had sinned, but had also shown the first symptom of sin (101,51), that is, it had succumbed to the temptation of the snake, for which it also had to be healed (101,52), and not only the part that had fallen ill (that is, the soul and the flesh, that had felt the passion of temptation) had to be healed (101,52-4). Furthermore, the Apollinarists, deceived by a literal interpretation of Scripture (101,55), insist that the Logos 'became flesh and lived among us' (*John* 1:14), to show that the incarnation means only the union between the Logos and the flesh, excluding the intellect (101,56), but Scripture, when it speaks of 'flesh' or of 'souls', commonly means the whole man, since it uses a synecdoche (101,56-9). The phrase that 'the Logos became flesh' should be understood in the same way that Christ is said to have become sin or malediction for us (2*Cor*. 5:21; *Gal*. 3:13): the Lord did not change into sin and into malediction, but assumed them in order to destroy them. So to say that the Logos became flesh means that the Logos descended to the most humble reality of man (101,60-1).

Gregory concludes by saying (even if this is a rhetorical form of modesty) that his letter is a first draft, in a provisional form, of his Christological conception: the haste is due to the need to prevent the spread of error in Nazianzus; later, if the opportunity arises, he will develop the topic (101,62): probably in the subsequent *Epistle* 102, which is slightly later, or, perhaps, also in the poems. Gregory is also familiar with the Judaic ideas of the Apollinarists, such as a second sacrifice and a second circumcision, and condemns them (101,63-5) as Basil had done. He refers to a book on the Trinity and to the large number of works written by Apollinaris, including a new Psalter (101,66): Gregory will also write many things in prose and verse (101,73).

This, therefore, is Gregory's longest and most detailed letter of refutation of Apollinarism. *Letter* 102 was also sent to Cledonius, who had asked him for a brief rule of faith to oppose the heretics: Gregory sent it to him insisting above

[86] As we have seen, for Gregory from *Oration* 2 on, the human soul functions as a mediator between the Logos of God and the flesh.

[87] The difference between the presence of the Logos in the prophets and the total presence of the Logos in the assumed man is also asserted by Gregory of Nyssa in the *Epistle to Theophilus* (see note 75).

all on some points. He recalls that Apollinarism had started about thirty years earlier, that is between 350 and 360 (*Epist*. 102,22); Nazianzen again denies the existence of two sons, and claims to believe in 'one and the same Son in the undivided divinity' (102,4). The concept of 'intellect of Christ' which 'we' also have, according to Paul (1*Cor*. 2:16), must be interpreted as the likeness to God that the Christian can obtain with his virtuous life (102,10). Gregory denies asserting the existence of 'two natures' in a struggle against each other, as the Apollinarists accuse him of doing (102,28), precisely because he appeared to them to be too close to the Antiochenes by claiming the existence of two sons in Christ.

Finally, *Letter* 202 was sent a few years later to Nectarius, bishop of Constantinople and Gregory's successor. Until then, Nectarius had been a layman, and understood little of complex theological questions: for this reason he had left the Apollinarists a certain freedom to gather and make propaganda, without realizing the danger they represented for the true faith. Since Nectarius was one of his superiors, Gregory turned to him with a tone of respect, but reproaching him for his tolerance of heretics; he also gives him some instructions about Apollinarism, but without going deeply into the question, which perhaps Nectarius was unable to understand.[88] In this epistle the following polemic can be highlighted:

> And then Apollinaris cites a sentence of the Gospel distortedly to confirm his absurdity and presents it saying: 'And no man hath ascended up to heaven, but he that came down from heaven, even the Son of man which is in heaven' (*John* 3:13), meaning that even before descending to earth He was the son of man, and he descended bringing his own flesh, that is, that which he also had in the heavens, a flesh prior to the centuries and substantiated with him (προαιώνιόν τινα καὶ συνουσιωμένην) (*Epist*. 202,11-2).[89]

In the poem *De incarnatione adversus Apolinarium* (I 1,10; PG 37, 464-70)[90] Gregory sets out the same arguments presented in *Epistle* 101 in poetic form:

[88] The election of a layman and man of the state administration, like Nectarius, is similar to that of Ambrose in the West, but Ambrose, as soon as he was elected, had immediately hastened to learn the Christian doctrine, and after a year or two was able to write his first exegetical works. Gregory of Nazianzus had expressed himself very critically about these hasty ordinations unjustified by previous spiritual preparation (*Orat*. 21,9). Radde-Gallwitz wondered what Gregory of Nyssa's attitude towards Nectarius could have been: even though he was against episcopal elections that took into account only wealth and social position, he was not however hostile to Nectarius, and this allowed him to remain in the court of Theodosius, who had been responsible for choosing Nectarius, A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 24. That the election of Nectarius was however the result of political and not strictly religious interests is currently supported by many scholars.

[89] Gallay quotes fr. 34 and 35 of Apollinaris. Gregory of Nyssa was also against this interpretation and believed that Christ had human flesh only during his stay on earth (*Antirrh*. 222,26-223,10). But the problem of Christ's heavenly flesh was already known to Basil.

[90] Or 'against the Apollinarists', according to the indication of another manuscript (and perhaps more than one).

it was probably written on the same occasion. Again in I 1,10 there is a sententious (and difficult to understand) brevity, as in *Epistle* 101. The excellent Mind (νοῦν τὸν μέγιστον) assumed all human nature, which is well organized, composed of three elements: soul, intellect and materiality of the body, that is, he assumed the first Adam with the exclusion of sin (*Hebr*. 4:15) (vv. 1-5). God who had been simple then became composed (συμπαγείς; Θεὸς μεμιγμένος) (vv. 10-2).[91] The envy of the devil affected all human nature (v. 17), so that the conception of God and his birth in the pure Virgin occurred. (The incarnate Christ was) 'whole God and mortal man; he saved me whole, because he was the Son who can only be thought of and the Son seen (Ὑιὸς νοούμενός τε καὶ ὁρώμενος)' (vv. 20-4). Again in this poem Gregory introduces the opposition between ἀνθρωπολάτρης, of which he is accused by the adversaries, and σαρκολάτρης εἰσάγων ἄνουν ἐμέ, for which in turn he reproaches them, using the same arguments of the *Epistle* 101 (vv. 25-9), as he repeats the assertion that the intellect is superior to the body, being ἐκ θεοῦ θεός / (χεῖρον γὰρ ἡ σὰρξ τοῦ κατ' εἰκόνα πολύ / … νοῦς γὰρ ἔγγιον θεοῦ)[92] (32-4) and the famous assertion ὁ μὴ προσείληπται γὰρ οὐδὲ σώζεται (v. 36). The Apollinarist, bitter defender of the Logos, does not tolerate those who divide God, that is, he does not admit that union[93] which, in his opinion, was the existence of two sons. But does he not also divide the composition (τὸ σύνθετον) of God, seeing in the incarnate Christ the intellect on one side and the flesh on the other? He concedes that in Christ there are some 'of my peculiarities', that is, the carnality, but takes others away, that is, the rational part; he unites the flesh with God and deprives (of God) the human intellect, as if he feared that, in its totality, he too had been composed (vv. 37-42).

Again in this poem Gregory addresses the problem of how a unity can contain two perfect realities (πῶς οὖν δύο τέλεια χωρήσει τὸ ἕν), and affirms that this question is absurd: it compares the case of Christ to that of a skin that tears when it has to contain two too voluminous things (43-4). The problem arises only for material realities, but not for the soul and intellect and, in any case, there are various types of perfection. In the case of Christ, the human intellect, although perfect, was infinitely less than the divine intellect (46-7: ποῦ δ'ὅλως σοι καὶ μέγα / νοῦς τοῦ Θεοῦ παρόντος;). In the birth from the Virgin the natures of two different beings united because the Spirit came to purify the Virgin and bring about the conception, and the Logos materialized within Mary becoming man. But since God cannot mix with the flesh, the soul and intellect are placed in an intermediate condition (ἐν μεταιχμίῳ), the soul akin to the

[91] And note the play on words: God was then nailed (παγείς) to the cross at the hands of his killers (v. 11).

[92] Here too the polemic is very concise: man's intellect is 'God', because it was made in the image and likeness of the intellect of God, the Son.

[93] Again the vocabulary of union (τὴν σάρκα κιρνῶν).

flesh, and the intellect akin to God.[94] Therefore God joined the intellect and had communion with the flesh thanks to the soul; the element that renders divine and that which is rendered divine in the incarnation constitute one God. In Christ an element was mixed (κερασθέν) with the heavy element, the other element, which was not heavy, participated in my things, except in sin.[95]

The content of I 1,11, *De Christi incarnatione* (PG 37, 470-1) is analogous. After a rapid polemical allusion to the Arians ('foolish he who the Logos of God the Lord, who always exists, does not venerate with divine honours equal to those of the Father in heaven'), Gregory continues with reference to Apollinaris: foolish is he who the Logos of God the Lord, who appeared here on earth, does not venerate with divine honours equal to those of the heavenly Logos, but separates from the great Father the Logos or the form of the Logos made man (ἀνδρομένην) (i.e. the 'form of a servant' of *Phil.* 2:6-7) and the thickness of our body. The Logos of the Father was God, but he became compact like the man we are (ἐπάγη … ἡμέτερος φώς), to mix (μίξῃ) God, just as he (man) himself was mixed with the earthly elements (μικτός χθονίοις). The incarnate Logos is one God in both parts (that is earthly and divine), he is mortal just as he makes of me, who am mortal, God. It is certainly impossible to explain this union between the Logos of God and man ('Of what interest is it for me the intellect and the inexpressible mixing? about God, oh mortals,

[94] Here too Gregory repeats that the rational soul is intermediate between God and man.

[95] In this poem (vv. 65-72) a famous doctrine, which Gregory will develop more widely in *Oration* 45,22, is briefly expounded. Gregory wonders how it was possible that the Father gave his 'approval' to the death of his Son to redeem humanity fallen prey to the Evil One. His explanation is of great significance, because it contains a personal meditation by Gregory on the subject, which, in fact, had not hitherto been frequently treated: 'Now we are to examine another fact and dogma, neglected by most people, but in my judgment well worth enquiring into. To Whom was that Blood offered that was shed for us, and why was It shed? I mean the precious and famous Blood of our God and High priest and Sacrifice. We were detained in bondage by the Evil One, sold under sin, and receiving pleasure in exchange for wickedness. Now, since a ransom belongs only to him who holds in bondage, I ask to whom was this offered, and for what cause? If to the Evil One, fie upon the outrage! If the robber receives ransom, not only from God, but a ransom which consists of God Himself, and has such an illustrious payment for his tyranny, a payment for whose sake it would have been right for him to have left us alone altogether. But if to the Father, I ask first, how? For it was not by Him that we were being oppressed; and next, On what principle did the Blood of His Only begotten Son delight the Father, Who would not receive even Isaac, when he was being offered by his Father, but changed the sacrifice, putting a ram in the place of the human victim? Is it not evident that the Father accepts Him, but neither asked for Him nor demanded Him; but on account of the Incarnation, and because Humanity must be sanctified by the Humanity of God, that He might deliver us Himself, and overcome the tyrant, and draw us to Himself by the mediation of His Son, Who also arranged this to the honour of the Father, Whom it is manifest that He obeys in all things? So much we have said of Christ; the greater part of what we might say shall be reverenced with silence'. The problem that Gregory poses is, therefore, that of knowing to whom the price of our ransom was paid, 'according to the economy'. It is significant that this reflection was included in the poem against Apollinaris.

love measure in speaking! It does not admit that many thousands of verses be written') (vv. 13-4).[96]

In conclusion, we believe it is possible to say that Gregory, if at first, in 379, he had polemicized with both the Antiochenes and the Apollinarists, and sometimes even only with the Antiochenes (in *Oration* 37), some years later, however, in the epistles and in the two poems considered above, he addressed only the Apollinarists: probably because there had been a concrete reason, the propagandizing of their ideas, which they made at Nazianzus in 382, on the authority of Vitalis.

Gregory of Nyssa, Again

The Nyssen had the first opportunity to expound his Christology with *Epistle* 3, in which, as we have seen, he discussed the presence of passions in Christ. In that letter he had to defend himself against the accusation of professing an unorthodox Christology, he therefore expounds his own. It has been asked whether Nyssen is in polemic with Apollinaris, and to answer the question one must take into account both some problems of a chronological nature as well as the contents of the epistle itself.

Mühlenberg thought that the Nyssen had come to know Apollinarism only after writing the third epistle. He admitted that it is almost improbable that Gregory had not heard of it before 385, but believed that the chronological data contradict this hypothesis: in *Epistle* 3 Gregory says that during the trip to Jerusalem in 380 he had to defend himself against the monks' accusations, which are probably those also recalled by Epiphanius (*Pan*. 77,20,1-4) and of which Basil speaks in *Epistle* 258,2 to Epiphanius. Although these doctrines are of Apollinarian origin, Gregory does not attribute them to anyone specifically. So his amazement at being accused of an erroneous Christology leads us to suppose that he had not yet heard of the controversy with Apollinaris. Also the refutation of Eunomius' Christology, which can be read in *Refut*. 173-81, does not name Apollinaris. Moreover, the passages discussed by Gregory of Nyssa are all quite similar to each other because they all concern the same problems:

– there are not two Sons of God, one divine and the other incarnate;
– how man was united to the Son of God with the incarnation.

And finally, the Nyssen addresses Theophilus of Alexandria in his letter, to ask him for advice and says he does not feel certain enough about Apollinarism. Consequently, it does not seem that he read Apollinaris' *Apodeixis* before writing the *Antirrheticus*, that is, before 385. The work of Nyssen might have contributed

[96] Polemical reference to Apollinaris, as in *Epist*. 101,73.

to the condemnation of the Apollinarians in 387.[97] Daley also believes that Gregory of Nyssa's first anti-Apollinarist work was his letter to Theophilus[98] and Maraval argues that Gregory in *Epistle* 3 did not have to defend himself against any accusation of Apollinarism, which had been brought against him by his enemies in Jerusalem, but simply put forward his Christology of the Christ-man type, with which he wants to replace that of Athanasius (Christ / flesh).[99] In fact, if the presence of the πάθη in the life of Christ and his progress (προκοπή) had been a problem for Apollinaris, as can be seen in fr. 168,16 and 238,3 Lietzmann (this had already been remarked on by Pasquali, see above, p. 282), it had also been a problem for Athanasius, who discusses it in *CA* III 51-3).[100]

However, in *Epist*. 3,24 Nyssen also defends himself against the attribution to him of Jewish and millenarian doctrines: they were considered Apollinarist by Basil and Gregory Nazianzen (now they are believed to be Apollinaris' disciples). So the accusation against him could actually be that of Apollinarism. For this reason, Capone rightly maintains that, already with *Epistle* 3 (which, in his opinion, was written in 383, not in 381), Gregory is polemicizing with Apollinaris. In fact, he had known Apollinarism as early as 379, when Meletius had summoned a council in Antioch to resolve the conflict with Paulinus.[101] *Epistle* 3, therefore, could be a reworking and a development of some interpretations that had already been Basil's, and since Basil had proposed them in polemic with the Apollinarists, those of the Nyssen are also, but as a consequence.

The question remains why Gregory does not name Apollinaris either in the third epistle or in the Christological passages of the third book of the *Contra Eunomium* or in the *Refutatio*, where the subject would have easily justified it. In our opinion, a polemical text against a specific opponent (in this case Eunomius) did not force Nyssen to explicitly name another who was extraneous to that polemic, especially if he was as authoritative as Apollinaris, whom the Cappadocians, at least initially, had hesitated to accuse (as did Epiphanius). Just as Basil had hesitated to name Apollinaris explicitly, so Nyssen in 381 thought

[97] E. Mühlenberg, *Apollinaris von Laodicea* (1969), 90-1.

[98] B.E. Daley, 'Divine Trascendence' (1997), 88-9.

[99] P. Maraval, Grégoire de Nysse, *Lettres* (1990), 36-7 and 132-41.

[100] *Ibid*. 136-7; analogous opinion of J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 220 and of A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 202-8; 215-7: Gregory had been accused of professing an unorthodox Christology based on *CE* III. The consequences are less convincing: Gregory would have developed his Christology in connection and in rapid succession to *CE* III in *Epistle* 3, which Radde-Gallwitz considers connected to the *Contra Eunomium*, so that the *Antirrheticus*, which was commonly dated around 387 and therefore later than the *Epistula ad Theophilum*, must also be put back to the years around 383 (*ibid*. 194-219). Radde-Gallwitz, however, is not familiar with Capone's article (not even regarding the problem of the chronology of the anti-Apollinarist polemic).

[101] See A. Capone, 'La polemica apollinarista' (2011), 503-4. The later date of *Epistle* 3, consequently, is not necessary and false.

that his polemic with Eunomius could also be valid against Apollinaris, even without naming him: Silke-Petra Bergjan, convinced of the similarity between the doctrines of Eunomius and those of Apollinaris regarding the two natures of Christ, also concludes that Gregory of Nyssa in the *Contra Eunomium* simultaneously rejects both.[102] Moreover, Eunomius is mentioned several times in the *Antirrheticus* and some doctrines of that work are similar to those of Epistle 3, such as that of the immutability of the Son of God. In the *Antirrheticus* (GNO III/I, 201,29-31) Gregory rejects the accusation of 'being ashamed of the cross', which already appears in *Contra Eunomium* (III 1,91-93 and 3,15-25) and in *Epistle* 17 (which also admits Radde-Gallwitz). If the *Epistula ad Theophilum* does not mention the *Apodeixis*, it is because the Nyssen saw no need to mention it. In conclusion, the *Antirrheticus* takes up and, on occasion, modifies what was said previously, in *Contra Eunomium* and in *Epistle* 3. Gleede, who rightly speaks of a first phase of Nyssen's anti-Apollinarist polemic, also disagrees with Maraval's interpretation, to which *Epistle* 3 would belong.[103] Subsequently to *Epistle* 3, therefore, even if only slightly, namely in the *Contra Eunomium*, the Nyssen tries to explain how human and divine nature united together in the incarnate Christ; the solution of the problem would be fundamental to avoid falling into the doctrine of the two Sons:

> The deity is emptied, so that it may be available to human nature; the human is renewed, becoming divine by mingling (ἀνάκρασις) with the divine. Just as a breath of air is not retained by water, when, dragged down by some heavy object, it is held in the depth of the water, but flows upward towards what is akin to it, and the water is often also lifted up by the upward flow of the air, swelling up in the surrounding air with the appearance of a fine membrane, so, when after the passion the true Life contained in the flesh flows back up to its own self, the flesh containing it is borne up with it, driven upwards from corruption to incorruption by the divine immortality. Just as fire, hidden from sight within the pile of wood, escapes the view of those who look and even of those who handle it, but when the fire flares up, it becomes apparent, so too when he was in death, he who separated soul and body operated with authority (κατ'ἐξουσίαν). He who said to his own Father, "Into your hands I commit my spirit" (*Luke* 23:46), is he who (as he says) has power to lay down his life, and has power to take it again (*John* 10:18). This one, who despised shame among men because he was Lord of glory, as it were concealing the tinder (ἐμπύρευμα) of life in the corporeal nature, by the dispensation of his death rekindled it and made it flare up by the power of his own godhead, warming up what came from the dead, and so, stirring that small first-fruit of our race into the infinity of the divine power, he made that also just what he himself was: the form of a slave, Lord, the man from Mary, Christ, the one who was crucified in weakness, Life and Power; and making all those things which in true religion are attributed to God the Word in the one whom the Word assumed. Thus these things might appear to be attributed distinctly to one or the other by itself, yet by mingling with the divine, the

[102] See S.-P. Bergjan, 'Anti-arianische Argumente' (2011), 490-7.
[103] B. Gleede, 'Der eine Christus vor, in und nach dem Fleisch' (2011), 532 n. 49.

mortal nature (τὴν ἐπίκηρον φύσιν) is renewed to match the dominant element, and shares the power of the deity, as if one might say that the drop of vinegar mingled with the ocean is made into sea by the mixing, because the natural quality of this liquid no longer remains in the infinity of the dominant element (*CE* III 3,67-8).

Gregory Nazianzen also stated in 380, as in this passage the Nyssen in 381, that the better element had won over the lower one (τοῦ κρείττονος ἐκνικήσαντος) (*Orat*. 29,19). The lower element (i.e. humanity) in the upper element, i.e. the divine nature, is lost like a drop of vinegar in the sea, the Nyssen repeats several times with an image that he himself later took up in other works against Apollinaris and which enjoyed considerable fortune even afterwards. In fact, it had the advantage of clearly demonstrating (much more than the ambiguous term μίξις) the preservation (and annihilation) of the weaker element (humanity) within the stronger (the divinity of Christ).

The passages of Christological content, already indicated above, and precisely *CE* III 1,44-5; 3,34 to 35; 3,62; 3,66-9 are the subject of discussion: the human nature of Christ (τὸ ἀνθρώπινον), which is spoken of there, is understood by some as that of the person of Christ, by others, instead, as human nature in its totality,[104] but in our opinion the alternative does not exist, because it is difficult to imagine a human nature of Christ different from human nature conceived in its entirety. Probably the Nyssen meant simultaneously the human nature of Christ in both senses, personal and general. To characterize the two natures of Christ, the Nyssen uses terms interchangeably which will be distinguished by subsequent discussions on Christology, but which are equivalent for him: on the one hand God, Logos, Son, on the other flesh, body, man, sin. Numerous examples of this distinction / union can be found in *Contra Eunomium* III 4,8; 4,10; III 3,64-7, so that, in our opinion, it is difficult to distinguish which of the two interpretations is correct.

Nyssen tackles the controversy naming Apollinaris explicitly in 385, when he wrote the *Epistle to Theophilus*. The Apollinarists accused him of professing the existence of two sons of God (as if he were a follower of Diodorus), because he asserted the existence of a complete humanity of the Lord (therefore also endowed with intellect), so that one Son had been such by nature, the other had become son later by assumption (GNO III/I, 120,17): it had been the same dispute that had divided the Antiochenes from the Apollinarists, as we have seen for Gregory of Nazianzus. For this reason the Nyssen, as already the Nazianzen in *Epistle* 101, defending himself, emphasizes that the incarnation of the Son of God was different from the numerous theophanies of the history

[104] See also J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000), 212-37, who takes into consideration the *Contra Eunomium,* the *Antirrheticus* and the *Oratio catechetica*, and A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018), 170-90. The same interpretation is offered by Lienhard for the ἀνθρωπότης discussed in the *Adversus Arium et Sabellium* (GNO III/I, 78,10-22), see J.T. Lienhard, *Contra Marcellum* (1999), 232-40, 236, with discussion of the preceding opinions.

of the Jewish people and from the presence of the Logos of God in the prophets. If the incarnation had not been something different from the theophanies, there would have been numerous incarnations: instead the incarnation of the Logos was the culmination of the theophanies, since those had not had the desired effect to heal fallen humanity, so that in the last times the *kenosis* of the Son of God himself was necessary. The epiphanies of the Logos in the prophets, above all, cannot be interpreted as proof that the Logos present in them was the incarnate Son of God, because only the Logos was present in them, while in the incarnation there was the Logos which assumed human flesh. As in the treatise on the perfection of man, in which the salvation and completion of humanity are conceived as the process of becoming like Christ through participation in all his moral and spiritual characteristics, so, in the epistle to Theophilus, Gregory believes that the process of salvation begins with the revelation of the glory of God and that the Son has accomplished this process in a new way.[105] The novelty consists in the fact that the Logos, while remaining transcendent and immutable, assumed human nature in the man Jesus and made it its own, so that all that, in our nature, was weak and corruptible, once it had 'mixed' with divine nature, lost its characteristics and became what it itself was:

> The first fruits (1*Cor*. 15:20) of human nature that was assumed were mixed (to itself, i.e. the diviniy) by the almighty divinity like a drop of vinegar in an infinite sea (οἷόν τι σταγὼν ὄξους ἀπείρῳ πελάγει κατακραθεῖσα) (as one might say using an image),[106] whereby human nature is found in the divinity, but certainly not with its own characteristics. In fact it would be reasonable to conceive a duality of sons if in the ineffable divinity of the Son one could recognize a nature of another kind with its characterizing signs, so that one would be weak or small or corruptible or temporary, the other, instead, powerful, great, incorruptible and eternal (*ibid.* 126,17-127,4).

The humanity of Christ does not dissolve, therefore, simply in the divinity, but has its own reality, even if no longer the earthly qualities, such that they are nothing compared to the divine qualities.[107] Hence in the incarnate Christ everything that makes general human nature an individual hypostasis or even a person or an individual is eliminated and replaced by divine qualities, such as power, wisdom, holiness, impassiveness (*ibid*. 127,8). Since there are only

[105] On this aspect of the Nyssen's Christology B.E. Daley, 'Divine Transcendence and Human Transformation' (1997), 87-95.

[106] The example had been presented already in *CE* III (see above). According to J.-R. Bouchet, 'À propos d'une image christologique de Grégoire de Nysse' (1967), 584-8, it comes from *SVF* II, 157,40-158,2 and Alex. Aphrod., *De anima libri mantissa*, Supplementum Aristotelicum 2,1 (Berlin, 1887), 140,22-141,5. Benjamin Gleede, 'Der eine Christus' (2011), 523 n. 13 argued the inaccuracy of Bouchet's interpretation, but the derivation from the Aristotelian and Stoic philosophy is undeniable.

[107] The question is whether this happens before or after the passion. Of course, the qualities of the body of Christ after the resurrection are analogous to those of the risen human body, B. Gleede, 'Der eine Christus' (2011), 525-6.

divine qualities in him, there is no reason to speak of two sons. The humanity of Christ is no longer shown in natural qualities because everything is filled by the lordship of God, who 'hath made that same Jesus, whom ye have crucified, both Lord and Christ' (*Acts* 2:36) (127,14-5), as Gregory himself had already explained in *CE* III 3,12-7. If Christ lived in a condition subject to the πάθη, and his lordship and his power were manifested only after the Passion, the exchange of names, whereby the same incarnate Logos could be said now Lord and Christ – that is God – now Jesus, that is man, was possible thanks to the union between the flesh assumed by God and the God who assumed it:

> Thanks to the perfect union between the flesh assumed and the divinity that assumed it, the names are exchanged, so that the human element can be named by means of the divine element and the divine element by means of the human element. Therefore the one who was crucified is called by Paul 'Lord of glory' (1*Cor*. 2:8),[108] and the one who is adored by all creation – by heavenly, earthly and underground creatures – is called 'Jesus' (*ibid*. 127,15-128,3).

Subsequent to the *Epistula ad Theophilum* is the *Antirrheticus adversus Apollinaristas*, written around 387. In this work, the Nyssen deals with the problem of the two natures of Christ in more detail, but the exposition and structure of the work have the defect of considerable confusion. He refutes the *Apodeixis*, that is, Apollinaris' Ἀπόδειξις περὶ τῆς θείας σαρκώσεως τῆς καθ' ὁμοίωσιν ἀνθρώπου (*Demonstration of the incarnation of God in the likeness of the man*). The refutation is carried out in detail (according to some, 'laboriously, and rather tediously'):[109] for this reason, if Apollinaris' work has already been accurately reconstructed, based on the Nyssen's *Antirrheticus*, by Lietzmann and Mühlenberg,[110] the *Antirrheticus* has so far not been expounded in detail. Gregory takes up the doctrine of his master Origen, claiming that the close union of the divine and human elements in Christ took place gradually, in the sense that his human nature progressed from a divided (divine and human together) to a unitary condition.[111] Origen (*Princip*. II 6,3) had argued that the

[108] See also *Acts* 2:22 and 10:38, equally cited by Nyssen in *CE* III 3,67. Some disciples of Apollinaris relied on these scriptural passages to support the existence of two sons: Epiphanius replies to them, again asserting that 'the divinity did not suffer because it is unchanged and immune from passion and consubstantial with the Father, but suffered the flesh; and in any case the divinity during the passion did not lose the possibility of being present in the incarnation' (*Pan*. 77,32).

[109] J. Behr, *The Nicene Faith* 4 (2004), 51. We follow Behr in the identification of the Christological doctrines of the Nyssen expounded in the *Antirrheticus*, but the contributions of J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature* (2000) and A. Radde-Gallwitz, *Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrinal Works* (2018) are also fundamental. Gregory's Christological lexicon in the *Antirrheticus* is more rigorous than that of Gregory of Nazianzus, and was studied by H. Grélier, 'Comment décrire l'humanité du Christ' (2011), 547-55.

[110] Cf. E. Mühlenberg, *Apollinaris von Laodicea* (1969), 74-91.

[111] We should therefore remember that when the Nyssen speaks, as he often does, of the 'body', he means man in his totality.

human soul of Christ, which is intermediate between the body and the divine nature, became, thanks to virtue, increasingly united to the divine nature, until it became confused with it, becoming like an iron glowing in fire. Also in the *Antirrheticus* Gregory, to explain the union of the human element with the divine one, employs (GNO III/I, 201,10-16) the image, already presented in *Contra Eunomium* and in the *Epistle to Theophilus*, of the drop of vinegar that loses itself in the immensity of the sea. The union between the two natures occurred with the resurrection, but before that the divine nature in Christ was real, without the possibility of change, and therefore free from passion. The human nature assumed was equally real, but without the presence of sin: consequently, in Christ there are not two persons, but one.

The Nyssen conceives of the flesh and the Logos each as one nature, so that flesh and Logos are two natures, in order to combat the Apollinarist doctrine of the one nature (*Antirrh*. GNO III/I, 154-8). The humanity of Christ is assumed by the Logos. Gregory is committed to explaining the theological meaning of the soul of Christ as a real principle of redemption for man (180-2; 166-8). Christ's death on the cross was the cause of the separation of the soul from the body, not that of divine nature from human nature (179,1-7; 224,13-24). Despite this strong emphasis on the difference of natures in Christ, which sometimes leads Gregory to employ Nestorian formulas (231,12-4), their unity is founded on the already discussed concept of 'mixing' (161; 171; 217; 225). On the other hand, we still find the idea of the divinization of the humanity of Christ by the Logos. As Power from Above, he took the form of the slave, that is, the hypostasis that was born of the Virgin, in order to raise it to his own condition and transform it into divine nature.

However, the attempt to defend the true reality of human flesh in Christ cannot be completely successful, because Gregory explains the unity of the two natures considering now one now the other and transforming human nature into divine nature. In fact, he believes that the flesh mixed with the divinity does not remain within its limits and in its qualities, but is assumed at the heights of the divine nature, which transforms all and transcends all (201,11-24). This transformation of humanity into divinity begins already with conception in the Virgin (223,25-224,24; 225,18-21) and therefore does not occur by means of a transformation of Christ in his life (as stated in *Epistle* 3). Not only that, but after earthly life and after the passion a new creation takes place, an even more sublime one (221,25), because the second advent of Christ is no longer in human form (227; 233,3-4): in this way however, the humanity of Christ runs the risk of disappearing.

Evagrius, Origenism and Apollinarism

According to Guillaumont, the Christology of Evagrius is obscure and difficult to understand: strongly impregnated with Origenism (perhaps it would be better to say with subordinationism to the Origenist manner), it was the object of repeated

anathemas at the ecumenical council of Constantinople in 553. 'Evagrius himself is aware of it, and when he expounds his Christology he resorts to the most sibylline expressions, and sometimes also to reticence'.[112] Already in the *Epistula fidei* (8,4,16-8) Evagrius had distinguished Christ, who lives among men, from the Logos of God, which is in him, and had said: 'But our Lord Himself is also the end, that is, the ultimate felicity, according to the design of the Word' (8,7,29-31).

Some of Evagrius' Christological propositions seem to be strongly influenced by Origenism. We will point out only a few of the themes. Christ is a rational nature, which however possesses in itself unity with God, and this unity is symbolized by the dove that descended on him when he was baptized by John (*Gnost*. IV 27). It is not right, therefore, to speak of two Christs (*KG* VI 16), as his master Gregory of Nazianzus had taught: therefore, it is no wonder that Evagrius differed greatly from Apollinaris, and that he criticized him.

Rational and incorporeal nature, Christ is essentially an intellect (*Gnost*. I 77). The intellect that is Christ is a "naked intellect", who, 'through contemplation concerning him is united with the gnosis of Unity' (*KG* III 6). The Christ, therefore, is, of all the intellects that were created in the first creation, the only one that did not know movement, that is, the fall into the world of matter, as had, on the contrary, occurred to the other intellects, according to the teaching of Origen (*Gnost*. II 43). The following is a cryptic statement, that manifests the inferiority of Christ to the Father: 'Christ is inherited and inherits, but the Father is only inherited', that is, He is absolutely transcendent and all are in need of Him (*Gnost*. IV 78). Subsequently, the incarnate Christ inherits the Logos, which is higher than Christ, because Christ is a created nature, while the Logos is in the Father (*Gnost*. IV 9).[113]

However, various elements of the christology of Basil and Nyssen also appear in Evagrius, as we read in the following tale by Palladius (*Hist. Laus*. I 132-6).[114] The demon who together with other demons tempted Evagrius to refute his true doctrine declares that he is Arian and wants to know what Evagrius thought of the body of Christ, and he answers:

> In the Scriptures there are and are said many things in relation to the fact that Christ's body comes from Mary: growth and circumcision, and the time of nine months in the womb, breastfeeding, and eating and drinking and fatigue and sleep, which are proper to a corruptible body; again, the fact that he was raised on the cross and that when he was pierced by the spear water and blood flowed (*John* 19:34).

[112] A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 375. This interpretation is contested by J.S. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 146-9, who reproaches Guillaumont for giving interpretations according to Catholic dogma and therefore according to the condemnation of the council of 553 – a contestation which, however, is not clear to me.

[113] On the Christology of Evagrius see A. Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au désert* (2004), 379-84, in part corrected by Augustine Casiday, *Reconstructing the Theology of Evagrius Ponticus* (2013), 186-9; more broadly J. Konstantinovsky, *Evagrius Ponticus* (2009), 109-52.

[114] See above, p. 227-8.

It would seem that in saying this, Evagrius wanted to deny that the body of Christ had descended from heaven, stating that it came from Mary, as Basil, the Nazianzen and the Nyssen had said. Then a third demon intervenes, who supports Apollinarism and affirms that Christ had no human intellect, but, instead of the intellect, God himself, due to the fact that a human intellect cannot win over "the prince of demons" (*Matth* 12:24). And Evagrius answers him following the teaching of the Nazianzen:

> If he had no human intellect, nor did he have a body. But if he assumed a human body from Mary, the holy virgin, then he became a man with a soul,[115] perfect in all things of humanity, "except sin" (*Hebr*. 4:15). The body, in fact, cannot be devoid of soul and intellect. If he didn't assume them, he cannot be said to be Christ. Indeed, Paul teaches the doctrine of the Immutable and of the human soul and body by recapitulating faith in unity and saying: "For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (1*Tim* 2:5).

Amphilochius of Iconium

Amphilochius does not seem to have examined further the problem of Christology. In fact, he lacks the typical traits of Gregory Nazianzen's Christology, that is, a strong emphasis on the soul of Christ, and the concept of mixing, supported both by the Nazianzen and the Nyssen, or the transformation of the human nature of Christ into the divinity.

Amphilochius' Christology is difficult to reconstruct from *Homily* 11.[116] He attributes, in the traditional manner, Christ's sufferings to the flesh and the miracles to his divine nature (*Hom.* 1).[117] Not much else is to be found. The only polemical reference of Amphilochius to Apollinaris might be found (perhaps) in *Hom*. 6,13. He remains on the threshold of the debate, without dealing *ex-professo* with the Christological theme.[118] It merely emphasizes above all the concept of salvific *oikonomia* (*Hom.* 10).[119] Some elements can perhaps be found only in the fragmentary homily 9.[120]

[115] A rational soul is meant.
[116] A. Segneri, *La controversia trinitaria* (2017), 420-1.
[117] *Ibid*. 294-8, 390.
[118] *Ibid*. 243.
[119] *Ibid*. 276-80, 440-1.
[120] *Ibid*. 442-3.

Chapter VI

The Cappadocians and the Latin West (the Fourth and Fifth Centuries)

The news of the teaching of the Cappadocians reached the West very early, a few years after Basil's death and when the two Gregories were still alive; there was no mention, however, of Gregory of Nyssa and Amphilochius; Jerome, in *De viris illustribus*, gives some information about Basil, Gregory of Nyssa and Amphilochius, but their doctrines were not present in the West; the name of Evagrius appears in the first decade of the fifth century thanks to Jerome, however, also in this case, shortly after his death. As early as 389, Ambrose made use of Basil's homilies, given about twelve years earlier, to compose his homilies on the Hexameron, as is well known. Nevertheless, it does not seem that the main interest of Westerners was directed to their Trinitarian doctrine and even less to their Christology: in fact Basil had remained extraneous to the West, as can be seen from Damasus' attitude towards the schism of Antioch and Basil's support for Meletius, and Ambrose had not shown himself friendly towards Gregory of Nazianzen or the Orientals, when in the Council of Aquileia of 381, probably to please Peter of Alexandria, he recognized, together with the few Western bishops present there, Maximus as Bishop of Constantinople. The Westerners, on the other hand, were interested in their ascetic doctrine, while for theology they continued to follow the tradition that went back to Tertullian. Between 380-400 the anti-Arian controversies of the Nicenes of the West learned little from the contemporary Eastern theological speculation: it would only be with Augustine that there would be a real doctrinal reworking of the theology of the Cappadocians. Every era, in fact, sought authority and support for its own cultural and spiritual needs of the moment, and those of the West at the end of the fourth century were not of a theological character, which in fact were little cultivated, but above all ascetic and spiritual. Let us therefore consider theology and asceticism separately.

1. *The Theology of the Cappadocians in the West*

Ambrose and Augustine

Ambrose makes use for his dogmatic works (which date back to the beginning of his career, and which do not represent the best of his production)[1] of Athanasius, for *De fide* (378-380, in five books) and of Didymus for *De Spiritu*

[1] A more positive judgement on them has been given by Chr. Markschies, *Ambrosius als Trinitätstheologe* (2000).

Sancto (381, in three books), discursive and simple works, especially the latter, which are intended for a non-specialist audience. Ambrose makes also use of Basil's *In Hexaemeron* and at least one of Basil's homilies (the one in *Psalmum primum*) in the first of the *Homiliae in Psalmos duodecim*, but in a way that is little more than a 'translation' according to the meaning that we will see later, of stylistic reworking.

Ambrose's homilies *In Hexaemeron* do not contain significant reworkings (for the beginning of the first, regarding the creation of the world and the existence of matter, he mainly uses manuals).[2] A passage by Ambrose, that shows the use of homily II 6 in Basil's *In Hexaemeron*, is more interesting. Basil proposes an unusual exegesis of *Gen*. 1:2: 'And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters'. Basil says that it had been proposed by a writer from Syria, alien to secular wisdom, but well-informed about scriptural exegesis. This writer was identified as Eusebius of Samosata or Ephrem the Syrian or Theophilus of Antioch or, as Naldini prefers, Diodorus of Tarsus or Eusebius of Emesa.[3] That exegete claimed that the movement of the Spirit over the waters meant that the Spirit warmed, fertilized (the Spirit being vital and vivifying power) the nature of the waters in the manner of a bird that hatches and infuses life force into the eggs subjected to its heat. Basil's passage is in Ambrose (*Hexaem*. I 8,29), and also in Augustine (*De genesi ad litt*. I 7,18): according to Altaner,[4] Augustine did not take the passage from Ambrose, but from the Latin translation of Basil's *Hexaemeron* made by Eustathius.[5] Altaner himself observes that later Augustine (*Contra Iulianum* I 5,18 and *Contra Iulianum Opus imperfectum* I 52) quotes a long passage from Basil's first homily *De ieiunio* (PG 31, 168A), in Rufinus's translation.[6] Augustine also quotes *(Contra Iulianum* II 6,18) a passage from Basil's homily 13 (*Exhortatoria ad sanctum baptismum*; PG 31, 428), attributing it by mistake to John Chrysostom.[7]

As regards Christology, Ambrose follows Didymus in the *De incarnationis dominicae sacramento*, and refers polemically to Apollinarism, probably on the basis of the condemnation by the Synod of Rome in 377, but is still quite cautious towards Apollinaris, whom he mentions in writing in 386 to Sabinus of Piacenza (*Epist*. 32,6), despite the fact that Apollinaris had already been sentenced five years earlier in Constantinople: *adversus Apollinarem legitima circumspectio*, he says simply. Apollinaris is repeatedly mentioned by Jerome as an exegete, never, it seems to me, as a theologian.

[2] This has been highlighted by Jean Pepin, *Théologie cosmique et théologie chrétienne* (1964).

[3] M. Naldini (ed.), Basil of Caesarea, *Sulla Genesi* (1990), *ad locum.*

[4] B. Altaner, 'Augustinus und Basilius der Grosse' (1957), 270-1.

[5] E.A. de Mendieta and S.Y. Rudberg (eds), Eustathius, *Ancienne version latine des neuf homélies sur l'Hexaéméron de Basile de Césarée* (1958).

[6] *Ibid*. 273.

[7] B. Altaner, 'Augustinus und Basilius der Grosse' (1957), 274-5.

Jerome

Jerome is witness to a Western theology (*Epist*. 15 and 17), which antecedes that of the Cappadocians and the so-called formula 'one substance – three hypostases'. For him, the term 'hypostasis' is equivalent to 'substance', so he cannot admit that we are talking about three hypostaseis, to which he prefers the term person: the theology to which Jerome wanted to remain faithful was that of Damasus.[8] From the desert of Syria (where he had probably received news of the theological discussions of the conflict of Antioch and the council which, apparently, was held there in 378-379) Jerome writes to Damasus, declaring that he wants to be in communion exclusively with him, as Peter's successor. After the *Alexandrinum decretum*, whose decisions are contained in the *Tomus ad Antiochenos* of 362, the inhabitants of the place where he finds himself, mocked as *Campenses*, demand that Jerome must speak of three hypostaseis, on account of which his interlocutors appear to him Arians: if he will not do so, he will be marked by the knife that cuts off the person and reduces them to one, as Sabellius did, which resolves the three hypostaseis into one unity (*cauterio unionis*).[9] Here are the most significant parts of the text of the letter:

I do not know Vitalis,[10] I reject Meletius, I ignore Paulinus.[11] Whoever does not gather with you (scl. Damasus), scatters, that is to say he who does not belong to Christ belongs to the Antichrist… After the faith of Nicea, after the decree of Alexandria, which united East and West, Campenses, offspring of the Arians, require from me, who am a Roman, a new word, that of the three hypostaseis. Well, we want to know what 'three hypostaseis' are thought to mean. They reply: 'three Persons who exist'. Then we reply that this is also our faith. But the concept is not enough: they demand exactly the precise word, because in the syllables is hidden I do not know what poison. We affirm that if someone does not confess three hypostaseis, in the sense of three hypostaseis connected to each other, that is, three Persons who subsist, it is anathema. And because we do not learn the words well, we are accused of being heretics. But if one understands the hypostasis as *ousia* and does not speak of a single hypostasis in three Persons, he is far from Christ, and with this confession we are marked, together with you (Damasus) by the knife of the one divine Person (*Epist*. 15,2-3).[12]

[8] According to Gemeinhardt, it is a theology that reflects that of Apollinaris of Laodicea, P. Gemeinhardt, 'Apollinaris of Laodicea?' (2006), 286-7, as well as Augustine's *De Trinitate*.

[9] Gregory Nazianzen had already complained about the misunderstandings raised among the Italics due to this terminology, which was understood differently than in the East (see p. 219).

[10] The disciple of Apollinaris.

[11] Meletius and Paulinus were the two opponents in the 'schism of Antioch', which probably was known by Jerome dwelling in Syria.

[12] *Non novi Vitalem, Meletium respuo, ignoro Paulinum. Quicumque tecum non colligit, spargit: hoc est, qui Christi non est, Antichristi est. … post Nicaenam fidem, post Alexandrinum iuncto pariter Occidente decretum, trium hypostaseon ab Arianorum prole, Campensibus, novellum a me homine Romano nomen exigitur. Interrogamus quid tres hypostases posse arbitrentur intelligi: 'tres personas subsistentes' aiunt. Respondemus nos ita credere: non sufficit sensus, ipsum nomen efflagitant, quia nescio quid veneni in syllabis latet. Clamamus, si quis tres hypostases, ut tria*

Consequently, on the basis of the equivalence between hypostasis and *ousia*, in which he believes, Jerome asks what is the right faith and the meaning of the only *ousia* of God. The doctrine of the three hypostaseis appears to him new and discordant from the faith of Nicea, because, according to grammar, which must be the basis of the correct Latin expression, hypostasis is equivalent to *ousia*, and therefore there cannot be three hypostaseis, because three divine substances cannot exist. *Ousia* can be translated both as *substantia* and as *essentia* (it is the ancient ambiguity of the Latin language, since the time of Hilary), as is also attested by the famous passage of *Exod.* 3:14, which speaks of the substance of God, Who is 'He Who is'. Accepting this new formula, namely, that of the three hypostaseis, means uniting the Orthodox (that is Nicenes) and the Arians, Damasus and Ursinus, Ambrose and Auxentius, it means accepting a text that hides the poison of heresy:

> May this not happen to the faith of Rome! May the devout hearts of so many peoples not commit such a sacrilege! May it suffice for us to say 'one substance, three Persons Who exist, perfect, equal, coeternal'. Do not speak of three hypostaseis, please, and keep only one hypostasis… May the faith we speak of be enough for us, or, if you think it is more precise, write (scl. Damasus) that we must speak of three hypostaseis, and explain to us what they are. We do not deny it, but, believe me, the poison is hidden under the honey; the angel of Satan was transfigured into an angel of light (1*Cor.* 11:14).

This profession of faith is substantially confirmed by the scarce and superficial hints that can be read in Jerome's subsequent works. There is no reason, therefore, to believe that Jerome learned the Trinitarian formula from Gregory Nazianzen.[13] One can only believe that, given Jerome's substantial lack of interest in the Trinitarian question, he only retained a few insignificant elements of the teaching of Nazianzen, with whom he was in Constantinople. After all, Jerome remembers the Nazianzen not so much as a teacher of theology, but of biblical exegesis, and prides himself on having learned the art of exegesis from him.

2. *The Cappadocians – Masters of Asceticism in the West*

Praeceptor meus: Gregory Nazianzen and Jerome

That Jerome had Gregory Nazianzen as his teacher in Constantinople, even if only briefly, where he stayed until after the conclusion of the Council of 381,

enhypostata, hoc est, tres subsistentes personas non confitetur, anathema sit. Et quia vocabula non ediscimus, haeretici praedicamur. Si quis autem hypostasim usian intelligens, non in tribus personis unam hypostasim dicit, alienus a Christo est: et sub hac confessione vobiscum pariter cauterio unionis inurimur.

[13] Differently from the opinion of G. Grützmacher, *Hieronymus. Eine biographische Studie* (1901), 179-80, who, for the rest, confines himself to observing that Gregory would have introduced Jerome to the study of Origen; see also F. Cavallera, *Saint Jérôme, sa vie et son œuvre* (1922), 116.

is known, if only because Jerome himself mentions Gregory Nazianzen as his teacher more than once in his writings.[14] He explicitly declares, in his news about Gregory (*Vir. Ill.* 117), who had died recently (390 AD), when he wrote that work (392 AD), that he had learned from him the art of Scriptural interpretation: but about Gregory's scriptural exegesis, unlike Jerome's, we are much less informed, because we have very few examples of it: apart from rules of exegesis set out in *Orat.* 45,10[15] and some references, a single homily, n. 37, is dedicated specifically to the exegesis of *Matth.* 19:1-12. We should not therefore believe that Jerome's references to Nazianzen, even if sometimes traceable with a certain likelihood (let us not say certainty), are only attributable to the medium of the written composition: Yves-Marie Duval observed that a fragment of Gregorian exegesis is in Jerome (*Comm. Eph.* 5,32; PL 26, 535-6), but in none of the writings of Gregory himself, and that Jerome takes it up (which, therefore, seemed convincing to him) in *Comm. Ion.* 1.3 b (SC 323, p. 182 ed. Duval), on account of which he rightly deduced that the contacts between Gregory and Jerome were mainly based on oral teaching, not on written texts of exegesis.[16] Matthieu, basing himself precisely on the references that Jerome makes to his learning the exegetical art from Gregory, hypothesized that the Nazianzen also gave, in addition to the homilies, lessons in a 'private' form or to a circle of friends or as in conversations.[17] And it is also possible that Gregory introduced Jerome to the study of Origen, and that Jerome then proceeded on his own way abandoning (at least in words) Origen, when he began to rely mainly on literal exegesis and the *Hebraica veritas.*

Lost Exegetical Texts: the Commentary on Isaiah

A brief and insignificant treatise that Jerome wrote during the years of his stay in Constantinople on the vision of Isaiah (*Is.* 6:3) was the result of his relations with Gregory Nazianzen. The treatise was hasty and improvised, composed under the guidance of his teacher for the benefit of his friends and to

[14] See also, in addition to the passages examined here, which contain real exegeses, the anecdotal, but still trustworthy, references of *Epist.* 50,1; 52,8; *Adv. Rufin.* I 13; I 30. See, generally, G. Grützmacher, *Hieronymus. Eine biographische Studie* (1901), I, 177-9; F. Cavallera, *Saint Jérôme* (1922), I, 59-62; J.N.D. Kelly, *St. Jerome. His Life, Writings and Controversies* (1975), 66, 69-71 etc. About the problem discussed here see Cl. Moreschini, '*Praeceptor meus*' (1988).

Why Jerome, who was in Antioch until 378, decided to go to Constantinople, remains unknown; of course, in Constantinople it was logical to approach the main exponent of the Nicene community, who was Nazianzen.

[15] See p. 55.

[16] Y.-M. Duval, *Le livre de Jonas* (1973), 366. The interpretation of that passage from Jerome has also been considered by J.-M. Matthieu, 'Grégoire de Nazianze et Jérôme' (1988), who, essentially, confirms what Duval had shown, that it can be traced back to Origen through the mediation of Gregory.

[17] J.-M. Matthieu, 'Grégoire de Nazianze et Jérôme' (1988), 119-20.

demonstrate his skills (*Comm. Es.* III 6,1, p. 84 CChr.SL). This youthful treatise could have been used a few years later (in 384) for the epistle 18 A, to Damasus, where we read the Origenian interpretation of the two seraphim who stand next to God, who indicate the Son and the Holy Spirit. Jerome is not persuaded by this interpretation, as he will reiterate, to confirm his consistency and demonstrate that he had never been an Origenist, a few years later to Pammachius and Oceanus (*Epist.* 84,3). A little further on (*Epist.* 18A,9) he presents an interpretation of *quidam Graecorum, vir in Scripturis adprime eruditus*, according to which the two seraphim could be two angelic powers. Labourt had already advanced the hypothesis that that erudite man could have been Gregory Nazianzen, and not Origen.[18] This hypothesis is likely, given that Origen had put forward a totally different interpretation in this regard, that is, he saw the two Persons of the Trinity in the two seraphim: even if it cannot be excluded that Origen had proposed more than one interpretation, however Origen's was more known than the one that Jerome approves. Now, there is a passage of Gregory's in which some elements of Jerome's interpretation can be found: it is the conclusion of *Oration* 28, which is of 380 (in that year Jerome was in Constantinople). In it the Nazianzen quickly traces (28,31) his angelology, listing various names of angelic powers: angels, archangels, thrones, powers, principalities, dominations, splendours – but he does not mention the seraphim. The angels are, however, "ministers of the will of God", that is, as Jerome says in the passage in question, *in diversa ministeria mittuntur*. This inaccuracy (i.e., the omission of seraphim) could also be explained as a testimony of oral teaching, especially since, a few years later, Jerome, while writing the *De viris illustribus*, in the item reserved for Gregory (n. 117), cites the following homilies by Gregory: 7, 14, 15, 24, 21, 25, 26, 29, 30, 31, 4, 5 – that is, not homily no. 28.

The Exegesis of 1Cor. 15:25

In *Epistle* 55,3 Jerome presents his interpretation of 1*Cor.* 15:25. After mentioning the previous exegesis of Hilary of Poitiers, who had discussed the matter at length in the eleventh book of *De Trinitate*, Jerome continues by observing that being submissive to the Father, of Whom the apostle speaks, is not such a humiliating thing, to attest to the inferiority of the Son with respect to the Father also in future centuries, as having been crucified. Christ is subject to the Father in those who are faithful, because all the believers, in fact, all mankind, constitute the members of Christ's body: 'But in those who have not yet submitted, that is to say in the Jews, in the pagans, in the heretics, Christ is said to be 'not yet submitted' (to the Father), because a part of His members is not

[18] Cf. J. Labourt (ed.), St. Jérôme, *Lettres* (1949), 64 n. 4.

submitted to the faith'.[19] But at the end of the world all the members, *id est corpus suum*, when they have seen Christ Who reigns, they will be subject to Christ, Who is their head, so that the whole body may be subject to God and to the Father. The apostle does not say 'so that the Father may be all in all', but 'so that God', which is the name of the Trinity and can be referred to both the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, *ut humanitas subiciatur divinitati*.[20] As for the meaning of the words 'so that God may be all in all', it is as follows: the Lord and Saviour is not all in all now, but is only a part in every single man. For example, He is wisdom in Solomon, mildness in David, patience in Job, knowledge of future realities in Daniel, faith in Peter, zeal in Phinehas and Paul,[21] in John virginity, in other men the other virtues (Christ, therefore, is the sum of the virtues, as for Gregory of Nyssa); but when the end of all things will come, then God will be all in all, so that every saint will have all the virtues and Christ will be all in all.[22] There is no trace of this explanation of Jerome in Hilary, although Jerome most probably knew him. Instead, the reasoning of the Nazianzen (*Orat*. 30,6) is in many respects analogous: God will be 'all in all' when we are no longer what we are now, a multiplicity of impulses and emotions, with little or nothing of God in us, but are fully like God, with room for God, and God alone.[23]

From the Adversus Helvidium

Another fragment of exegesis that shows an affinity with Gregory Nazianzen's homily 30 is in *Adv*. *Helv*. 6 (PL 23, 199A). Here Jerome explains 1*Cor*. 15:23 (see *Psalm* 109:1): 'For he must reign, *till* he hath put all enemies under his feet (donec *ponat omnes inimicos eius sub pedibus eius*)' with reference to the passage in *Matth*. 1:24-5: 'Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife: and knew her not *till* she had brought forth her firstborn son (donec *peperit filium*)'. The term *donec*, therefore, observes Jerome, does not indicate that a certain thing happens or does not happen only up to a certain point, and then it does not happen again; on the contrary, it can also indicate the continuation of this

[19] *In his autem qui increduli sunt, id est Iudaeis, ethnicis, haereticis, insubiectus dicitur, quia pars membrorum eius non est subiecta fidei*.

[20] See also *Epist*. 65,13: *non enim dixit: tradet Patri, ut videretur Filium separare, sed tradet Deo, ut sit Deus omnia in omnibus*.

[21] A traditional observation, which is also in Gregory of Nyssa (*An*. GNO III/III, 38,17-9).

[22] The same interpretation is presented by Jerome in the late *Dialogus adversus Pelagianos* (I 19).

[23] Trans. L. Wickam and Fr. Williams. Gregory's exegesis is inspired by that of Origen, which can be read in the passages collected and interpreted by Henri Crouzel, 'Quand le Fils transmet le Royaume' (1984); *id*., 'Origène a-t-il tenu que le règne du Christ?' (1986), 53-4.

activity, of this condition, even after that precise point: 'Perhaps the Lord will reign *until* His enemies begin to be under His feet, and after they are placed under His feet He will stop reigning? On the contrary, He will begin to reign just when his enemies will begin to be under His feet'.[24] And the Nazianzen had observed: 'you are in this sorry case thanks to your failure to recognize that "until" is by no means the logical contrary of what lies in the future; it states the point up to which something happens, but does not deny what goes beyond that point' (*Orat*. 30,4). The fact that Jerome asserts that Joseph did not know his wife even after the birth of Christ is, in any case, important for Mariology.

From the Commentary on Daniel

In *Comm*. *Dan*. III, IX, 14 (p. 862 CChr.SL) Jerome presents an interpretation of the 'sleep' of God, of which the Scriptures speak, observing that it should not be taken literally; it is instead an expression which recalls human passions: 'but when we are abandoned by God and we are not judged and we do not deserve the reproach of the Lord, then it is said that God is sleeping'[25]; and a bit further on: ἀνθρωποπαθῶς *hoc dicitur* (p. 863 CChr.SL). This observation from the *Commentary on Daniel* also returns in the later *Commentary on Jeremiah* (III 30,3): the sleep of God is called ἀνθρωποπαθῶς, 'not because God actually sleeps, since it is said of Him: "He Who protects Israel will not slumber and will not sleep", but because to those He abandons, God seems to be sleeping'.[26] The problem of the interpretations of scriptural terms attesting to a characteristic of God which must instead be brought back to the peculiarities of human nature, is discussed by Gregory Nazianzen in *Orat*. 31,22: 'we have used names derived from human experiences and applied them so far as we could, to aspects of God… In short every faculty or activity of God has given us a corresponding picture in terms of something bodily'.

These fragments of exegesis can be traced, at least hypothetically, to Gregory Nazianzen's teaching which was then written down in *Orations* 30 and 31 – and both of these orations appear in the list of Gregory's works outlined by Jerome in the *De viris illustribus*.

[24] *Numquid tamdiu regnaturus est Dominus* donec *incipiant esse inimici sub pedibus eius, et postquam illi sub pedibus fuerint, regnare desistet, cum utique tunc magis regnare incipiet, cum inimici coeperint esse sub pedibus?*

[25] *Quando vero a Deo deserimur et non iudicamur indignique sumus correptione Domini, tunc dormire dicitur (scl. Deus).*

[26] *Non quo Dominus dormiat, de quo dicitur: non dormitabit neque dormiet qui custodit Israhel* (*Psalm.* 120:4), *sed quo his videatur dormire quos deserit*. On the symbolic interpretations of the 'passions' of God see Cl. Moreschini, 'Gerolamo e la filosofia' (1989), 48-50.

The Ideal of Virginity

Jerome also drew upon Gregory's teaching regarding some aspects of his ascetic doctrine, and not only for exegesis. The grounds proposed by Jerome in defence of the superiority of virginal continence with respect to marriage and the emphasis on the contrast between the two conditions were not produced by a personal meditation nor can they be traced back to the Latin tradition, which gives other reasons in support of virginity, but were inspired by Gregory Nazianzen's teaching. Of course, certain ascetic formulations of the Nazianzen are also found in the Nyssen or in other coeval Greek Fathers (even if not in the same way), but the chronology, first of all, and the fact that Jerome had frequently seen the Nazianzen in Constantinople lead us to believe that the novelty of Jerome's formulation comes from Gregory. The information in *De viris illustribus* also lists, among Gregory's various works, 'a book in hexameters containing Virginity and the Wedding that contrast with each other'.[27] The poem, which is so defined because it contains a debate, that is, the *antiloghia* that is encountered in the second half of it, is, without any doubt, poem I 2,1 of the Maurists' collection, 'in praise of virginity'. Jerome himself, a few years before writing the section on Gregory, wrote a 'book' in the form of an epistle, dedicated to the exaltation of virginity: it is the famous *Epistle* 22 to Eustochius.

Immediately after the preamble, Jerome already refers to the subject of *molestiae nuptiarum*: one of the most traditional themes imaginable, widespread both in the Latin and the Greek environments and, even earlier, in the Cynic-Stoic diatribe. This topic goes even further, in paragraphs 15, 18 and 22. Jerome illustrates the distressing cases of the weakness of the flesh (ch. 3-4), referring to the contrast, effectively expressed by the apostle Paul, between the flesh and the Law (ch. 5). He reminds Eustochius that a fallen virgin can no longer be restored to her original condition (*ibid.*), and remembers his own experiences and the temptations in the desert (ch. 6-7); for every admonition, relevant to moral behaviour, he makes use of biblical *exempla* (ch. 8-10). We encounter affirmations of an apodictic character, typical of Jerome's style and way of reasoning: 'the first man, who came from Paradise, obeyed his stomach instead of God'[28] (ch. 10; cf. also ch. 18); the greatest strength of the devil lies in sex (ch. 11); there are numerous *exempla* of this diabolical force (ch. 12). A very convincing proof is provided, in fact, by the fall of the virgins (ch. 13). It then continues with a series of admonitions and precautions of a concrete nature, always reaffirmed by biblical *exempla* or by events from experience, which Jerome obtains, with the satirical verve for which he is famous, from the

[27] This poem is also mentioned by Jerome in *Adv. Iovin.* I 13: *et praeceptor meus Gregorius Nazianzenus virginitatem et nuptias disserens, Graecis versibus explicavit.*

[28] *Primus de Paradiso homo ventri magis oboediens quam Deo.*

observation of the customs of Rome, whereby he makes some sarcastic considerations on the society of his time (ch. 13-8).

Therefore, Jerome's *libellus* has a practical approach, and this ethical purpose is also confirmed by the fact that Jerome often uses the Tertullian model:[29] for example, in *Epist*. 22,15 the various *gradus pudicitiae* are derived from the *De exhortatione castitatis* (ch. 1), as with other expressions;[30] chastity is explained according to tradition, with the parable of one hundred, sixty, thirty for one (*Epist*. 22,19: 'my seed produces a harvest of one hundred to one').[31]

But since ch. 18 the discussion takes a completely different course. First of all, the virginal state is referred to as the *heavenly* state,[32] not only like the *angelic* state, which would have been an obvious and traditional reason; the loss of the virginal state, caused by the diabolical temptation, represents the repetition of Adam's sin, a new eating of the forbidden fruit: 'Should we not cry, should we not moan, if the serpent once again invites us to eat prohibited foods? If the man expelled from the paradise of virginity wants to dress in leather tunics? Elijah, returning to Paradise, threw them on the ground!' (22,18).[33] The same symbolic interpretation, which appears here, of the 'leather tunics', with which our progenitors, expelled from Paradise, dressed, is not typical of the Latin tradition: Tertullian knows it only when he argues with

[29] See, in this regard, Cl. Micaelli, 'L'influsso di Tertulliano su Girolamo' (1979); *id*., 'Ricerche sulla fortuna di Tertulliano' (1985). The passage in *Epist*. 22,8 (… *libido iuncta luxuriae. Prius venter et statim cetera*…) recalls Tert., *ieiun*. 1: … *ipsi prius uentri pudenda non adhaererent. Specta corpus et una regio est*. *Epistle* 22 and the imitations, contained therein, of previous writers (the most significant had already been observed by Micaelli and by the present writer) have been examined *sine fine* by Neil Adkins in various contributions for which we refer the scholar, who has time to waste and wants to read them, to the Année Philologique. See, if anything, the contribution of A.V. Nazzaro, 'Intertestualità biblico-patristica e classica' (1997).

[30] See also *Epist*. 22,16: *fuge quas viduas necessitas fecit, non quo mortem optare debuerint maritorum, sed quo datam occasionem pudicitiae libenter arripere*, which takes up *Exhort. cast*. 10,1: *rape occasionem, etsi non exoptatissimam, attamen opportunam, non habere cui debitum solveres et a quo exsolvereris* and *Epist*. 22,22: *cum apostolus sine intermissione orare nos iubeat et qui in coniugio debitum solvit orare non possit, aut oramus semper, et virgines sumus, aut orare desinimus, ut coniugio serviamus*, which imitates *Exhort. cast*. 10,2: *ideo Apostolus temporalem purificationem orationum commendandarum causa adiecit, ut sciremus quod ad tempus prodest semper nobis exercendum esse, ut semper prosit. Quotidie, omni momento oratio hominibus necessaria, utique et continentia, postquam oratio necessaria est*.

[31] *Meum semen centena fruge fecundum est*. For the interpretation of this parable, referring to different degrees of chastity, P.Fr. Beatrice, 'Il Sermone *De centesima, sexagesima, tricesima*' (1979).

[32] See G. Sfameni Gasparro, *Enkrateia e antropologia* (1984), 290-300. Sfameni Gasparro also cites other passages from Jerome, derived mainly from the *Adversus Iovinianum*, which reaffirm this conception of the original dignity of the virginal condition and the devaluation of marriage; cf. *Adv. Iovin*. I 16; I 29; I 37; II 15 (*ibid*. 296-8).

[33] *An non flendum est, non gemendum, cum me rursus serpens invitat ad illicitos cibos? Cum de paradiso virginitatis eiectum tunicis vult vestire pelliciis, quas Helias ad paradisum rediens proiecit in terram?*

the Gnostics, because for the Valentinians the 'leather tunics' meant the body of flesh with which the material element of man had been covered (*Valent*. 24, 2-3; *Resurr*. 7,2):[34] And Jerome: 'Let those stitch coats to themselves [i.e. the leather tunics] who have lost the coat woven from the top throughout' (22,19).[35]

This doctrine, that the virginal condition is the typical one of the protoplasts in Paradise, prior to their fall, is fundamental in the doctrine of virginity according to Jerome.[36] In addressing Eustochius, who, in fact, was a virgin, he says:

> Eve in Paradise was a virgin: after the leather tunics marriage began. But the region you have to live in is Heaven. Keep that condition in which you were born … and so that you know that virginity belongs to your nature, while the nuptials come after sin, the flesh is born a virgin from the nuptials, to restore in its fruit what it had destroyed in the root,[37]

that is, by reconstituting that virginity that had been lost in the – albeit necessary – moment of her conception (the 'root').

Jerome therefore formulates with precision the contrast between marriage and virginity: it is no longer due to merit or dignity, as it had been in the previous Latin tradition (for example, in Tertullian's *De exhortatione castitatis*, whose topic is still present in this epistle), nor as an exhortation to follow the figure of Christ, in Whom all the things that were at the beginning (as in Tertullian's *De monogamia*) are 'recapitulated'; the contrast that is found in *Epistle* 22 is of an ontological character, between a primordial condition, excellent because it was constituted by God Himself and prior to original sin, and a subsequent condition, not intrinsically evil, but certainly inferior in dignity as a consequence of sin, even if not directly caused by it, as the Encratites maintained. So much so that the divine precept 'grow and multiply', observes Jerome (22,19) became valid only after the fall (*post paradisum et nuditatem*); it ceases, instead, when the initial condition is restored (22,21) – on the contrary, according to Tertullian (*Exhort*. 6), the divine precept became useless only because 'But this I say, brethren, the time is short' (1*Cor*. 7:29) and the end is near.

This anthropological interpretation had been foreign not only to the Latin tradition, but also to the Greek one. Some passages of Athanasian epistles dedicated to the exhortation and celebration of virginity present similar elements; the identification of virginity with Paradise is also an Athanasian motif, but it is

[34] According to Tertullian, who professes a strong literalism, the 'leather tunics' are nothing other than the skin that covers human flesh (*Res*. 7,6). See, in this regard, P.Fr. Beatrice, 'Le tuniche di pelle. Antiche letture di Gen. 3, 21' (1986), 471-83.

[35] *Consuant tunicas qui inconsutam desursum tunicam perdiderunt*.

[36] Cf. G. Sfameni Gasparro, *Enkrateia e antropologia* (1984), 294.

[37] *Eva in Paradiso virgo fuit; post pellicias tunicas initium nuptiarum. Tua regio Paradisus. Serva quod nata es … et ut scias virginitatem esse naturae, nuptias post delictum, virgo nascitur caro de nuptiis, in fructu reddens quod in radice perdiderat*.

only eulogistic,[38] it does not have any implications or insights related to human nature in its original essence and in its conservation through the maintenance of the virginal state. It is probable, therefore, that in this epistle, after the first part (22,1-17) Jerome abandoned the traditional doctrine to reason differently. This is also demonstrated by an affirmation in the conclusion of the preceding section, that is, at the beginning of 22,23: after having cited his Latin sources, namely Tertullian, Cyprian, Ambrose, who had written on virginity and in Jerome's day represented the relevant authorities (22,22),[39] Jerome explicitly states: *nobis diverso tramite inceditur*, that is to say, from that moment on he follows a different path. In fact, *virginitatem non efferimus, sed servamus*: these words do not only indicate, according to their more immediate meaning, that the writer is teaching Eustochius the precepts to preserve virginity:[40] above all, they mean that Jerome is emphasizing that the virginal condition, which is man's original condition, must be preserved because it was created by God. If these words were intended as a treatise on how to preserve virginity, avoiding the temptations and occasions of sin, the difference with respect to the Latin sources and tradition would not be as great as Jerome wants us to believe; there would be little originality if he wanted to contrast the theme *de laudibus virginitatis*, common to previous writers, with that of *de virginitate servanda*, which would be the new theme, the one that interests him. This is so true that the precepts of Jerome to Eustochius are often the same ones that Ambrose uses in his precepts to virgins: the theme of the *molestiae nuptiarum* in *De virg*. I 6, 25-7; the condemnation of luxury and female ornaments in *De virg*. I 6,28-29 and 9,54-55; the illustration of the advantages of the virginal life in *De virg*. I 6,30-33.

[38] Shenoute, in the homily on virginity written in Coptic and published with a French translation by L.Th. Lefort cites a passage from a letter of Athanasius in which (as in other texts, after all) virginity is praised, 'Athanase, Ambroise et Chenoute sur la virginité' (1935); in the same work, there is (*ibid*. 58) a series of exaltations of virginity: 'O virginité, image de l'incorruptibilité et arbre divin… O virginité, qui es proche de Dieu, mais méprisée des hommes… O Virginité, région du Paradis et tente du Tout-puissant'. It is not much, as can be seen. Even less is found in the exhortations, enthusiastic, yes, but generic, published by Joseph Lebon, '*Athanasiana Syriaca* I' (1927); '*Athanasiana Syriaca* II' (1928). On the Athanasian epistle, cited by Shenoute, see Y.-M. Duval, 'La problématique de la Lettre aux vierges d'Athanase' (1975); M. Aubineau, 'Les écrits de S. Athanase sur la virginité' (1974).

[39] In fact, Ambrose's *De virginibus*, written a few years before *Epistle* 22 (namely, around 377), presents one of the most traditional topics. Remarkably disordered in its structure, the short work gives *exempla* of virginity, such as St. Agnes, the Holy Virgin Mary, Marcellina (Ambrose's sister), which alternate with precepts addressed to the virgins.

[40] *De virginitate servanda* is an addition that is found first-hand in D (Vat. Lat. 355-356, of the 9th-10th century) and second-hand, in the margin, in E (Turicensis Augiensis 41, of the 9th century) (I draw these indications from Hilberg's critical apparatus, in CSEL). The title of the oldest manuscripts, when they have one, is *ad Eustochium* or *ad Eustochium de virginitate*. It is true, however, that Rufinus (*Apol*. II 5) defines it as *libellus quidam de conservanda virginitate*.

At this point, we must go back to Gregory Nazianzen. In fact, we are led back to Gregory by Jerome, for whom, as he claims, the former had been his first great teacher. Moreover, Jerome had read the hexametric poem I 2,1, in praise of virginity. This poem is important in Gregory's poetic production, because it presents a justification, which is valid on an ontological and anthropological level, of that ideal of virginity that Gregory himself had so often recommended in some of his other works. Gregory's position is a position of principle analogous to that of Jerome in the epistle to Eustochius.

At the beginning of the poem, virginity is directly traced back to the essence of the nature of God and that of the angelic choirs (vv. 13-4). The idea, at a first reading, may seem outlandish, but there is a deeper meaning underlying it. The first 'virgin' is the Holy Trinity. In fact, the Son, Who is Lord, originated from the Father, Who is without beginning, but this generation was very different from the human generation (vv. 20-30). The reason, typical of Nazianzen's theology in the context of his controversy with the Arians, that is, that the generation of the Son was devoid of passion, is here very boldly applied to the essence of virginity. Therefore, virginity not only constitutes an ideal of the human condition from an ethical point of view, but it is an ideal in and of itself, as it is the typical condition of the divine generation and of the relationship between the Father and the Son (see also I 2,34,193-4). This conception becomes even more precise when Gregory resorts to a topical argument, that the virginal life is the angelic life par excellence (vv. 35-55). Then there is a justification based on Scripture: Gregory traces the narrative of Genesis, from cosmology (vv. 56-77) to the creation of man (vv. 78-99), to the differentiation between the sexes (vv. 100-7), from which marriage originated (vv. 108-16). The original condition of the protoplasts was analogous to that of the angels: created virgins, their virginity would be preserved for the duration of their life. The origin of humanity was also not due to passion, but to the goodness of God. Instead marriage was an excellent thing for as long as the earth needed to be populated by men, and this condition was not only valid in Paradise, but also after the first parents had sinned on their own responsibility and the impulse of the evil one (vv. 117-25). But since it had not been able to free itself from the chains of sin, in the end, at the behest of the Father and through the work of the Son, mankind obtained the honour of the incarnation of Christ (vv. 135-55). The salvation of man takes place, therefore, by reconstituting (ἀναπλάσσων, v. 162) the original nature of Adam (vv. 156-71); the previous condition was the product of marriage, the subsequent one is the product of virginity. Virginity, therefore, typical of the divine substance, also becomes the prerogative and pride of human substance, after it has been redeemed from sin.

In conclusion, the interest in virginity and the ascetic ideal, which inspire Jerome and Gregory Nazianzen, go beyond the somewhat narrow limits of the moral exhortation, as they tend to find an ontological justification. It is the problem of the origin of man and the evaluation of the sin of the first parents

which, even before the beginning of the Pelagian controversy, begin to arouse doubts and pose hitherto unknown problems. In realizing this and in proposing ontological solutions, the positions of Jerome and Gregory Nazianzen appear to be singularly allied.

Augustine

Interest in the theology of the Cappadocians appeared twenty years later, with Augustine's *De Trinitate*, and yet such research cannot be carried out here with due diligence, for reasons of brevity.[41]

The first five books of *De Trinitate* often refer to the Cappadocians' exegesis, but the writer Augustine refers to is always Gregory Nazianzen. Perhaps because he was the only one he could know thanks to Rufinus's translation, while he did not know Basil and the Nyssen? Yet, as we will see, this is not the way Augustine travelled. Augustine himself mentions in a generic way the difficulty of finding Latin texts dealing with the exegetical problems he wants to discuss in *De Trinitate*:

> But if what we have read upon these subjects is either not sufficiently set forth, or is not to be found at all, or at any rate cannot easily be found by us, in the Latin tongue, while we are not so familiar with the Greek tongue as to be found in any way competent to read and understand therein the books that treat of such topics, in which class of writings, to judge by the little which has been translated for us, I do not doubt that everything is contained that we can profitably seek… (*Trin.* III proem. 1.)

Among these exegetical problems is that of tritheism, which ends, as we see at the end of the following quote, with that from the divinity of the Holy Spirit:

> Some persons, however, find a difficulty in this faith; when they hear that the Father is God, and the Son God, and the Holy Spirit God, and yet that this Trinity is not three Gods, but one God; and they ask how they are to understand this: especially when it is said that the Trinity works indivisibly in everything that God works, and yet that a certain voice of the Father spoke, which is not the voice of the Son; and that none except the Son was born in the flesh, and suffered, and rose again, and ascended into heaven; and that none except the Holy Spirit came in the form of a dove. They wish to understand how the Trinity uttered that voice which was only of the Father; and how the same Trinity created that flesh in which the Son only was born of the Virgin; and how the very same Trinity itself wrought that form of a dove, in which the Holy Spirit only appeared. Yet, otherwise, the Trinity does not work indivisibly, but the Father does some things, the Son other things, and the Holy Spirit yet others: or else, if they do some things together, some severally, then the Trinity is not indivisible. It is a difficulty, too, to them, in what manner the Holy Spirit is in the Trinity, whom neither the Father

[41] In fact, it is a question of clarifying Augustine's Neo-Nicenism, not a small problem that requires a study in itself. It has been adequately written about by Christoph Markschies, *Alta Trinità Beata* (2000), 73-8 and Peter Gemeinhardt, 'Lateinischer Neunizänismus bei Augustin' (1999); *id*., '»Geboren aus dem Wesen des Vaters«' (2001) and others.

nor the Son, nor both, have begotten, although He is the Spirit both of the Father and of the Son.[42]

Another problem, particularly discussed both in the East and in the West since the early days of the Arian controversy, is that of the inferiority of the Son with respect to the Father. Augustine solves it in the traditional way, by asserting the equality of the Son as regards nature and inferiority as regards economy:

The Son of God, then, is equal to God the Father in nature, but less in fashion. For in the form of a servant which He took He is less than the Father; but in the form of God, in which also He was before He took the form of a servant, He is equal to the Father. In the form of God He is the Word, by whom all things are made; but in the form of a servant He was made of a woman , made under the law, to redeem them that were under the law (I 7,14).[43]

The crucial passage of 1*Cor*. 15:28 also concerns the problem of the inferiority of the Son: 'And when all things shall be subdued unto him, then shall the Son also himself be subject unto him that put all things under him, that God may be all in all'. Augustine discusses it extensively in accordance with the Nicene doctrine, stating that it does not indicate a separation of the Son from the Father (I 8,15-16). First of all, when he says: 'And when all things shall be subdued unto him', this does not mean that once He has led all things to the Father, He Himself will no longer reign (*tamquam cum posuerit non sit regnaturus*). Therefore, the expression: 'when he shall have delivered up the kingdom to God, even the Father' (1*Cor*. 15:24) is equivalent to: *Cum perduxerit credentes ad contemplationem Dei et Patris* (I 8,16). So if the apostle says: 'when he shall have delivered up the kingdom to God, even the Father', He does not take it away from Himself, since when He leads those who believe to the contemplation of God the Father, He will certainly lead them to contemplation of Himself

[42] *Sed in ea (scl. catholica fide) nonnulli perturbantur cum audiunt Deum Patrem et Deum Filium et Deum Spiritum Sanctum, et tamen hanc Trinitatem non tres deos sed unum Deum; et quemadmodum id intellegant quaerunt, praesertim cum dicitur inseparabiliter operari Trinitatem in omni re quam Deus operatur, et tamen quandam vocem Patris sonuisse* (*Matth*. 3:17), *quae vox Filii non sit; in carne autem natum et passum et resurrexisse et in caelum ascendisse non nisi Filium; in columbae autem specie venisse non nisi Spiritum Sanctum* (*Matth*. 3:16). *Intellegere volunt quomodo et illam vocem quae non nisi Patris fuit, Trinitas fecerit, et illam carnem in qua non nisi Filius de Virgine natus est eadem Trinitas creaverit, et illam columbae speciem in qua non nisi Spiritus Sanctus apparuit illa ipsa Trinitas operata sit. Alioquin non inseparabiliter Trinitas operatur, sed alia Pater facit, alia Filius, alia Spiritus Sanctus; aut si quaedam simul faciunt, quaedam sine invicem, iam non inseparabilis est Trinitas. Movet etiam quomodo Spiritus Sanctus in Trinitate sit, quem nec Pater nec Filius nec ambo genuerint, cum sit Spiritus Patris et Filii* (*Trin*. I 5,8).

[43] *Est ergo Dei Filius Deo Patri natura aequalis, habitu minor. In forma enim servi* (*Phil*. 2:7) *quam accepit minor est Patre; in forma autem Dei in qua erat etiam antequam hanc accepisset aequalis est Patri. In forma Dei Verbum per quod facta sunt omnia* (*John* 1:3); *in forma autem servi, factus ex muliere, factus sub lege ut eos qui sub lege erant redimeret* (*Gal*. 4:4-5).

(I 9,18).[44] The matter had been discussed by Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 30,4-5)[45] and it had also been taken up by Jerome, as we have seen above: 'until' does not mean that, after that moment, the Son would no longer reign, because He would reign together with the Father.

Another famous passage was that of not knowing the day and the end of the world, which no one knows, not even the Son, but only the Father (*Mark* 13:32). This problem had also been discussed by Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 30,15) and Augustine examined it in *De Trinitate* (I 12,23). Gregory had distinguished between the knowledge of Christ as God and His ignorance as man, Who at that moment was addressing his disciples; Augustine does not present the same distinction, but in any case he imputes Christ's ignorance to his human condition:[46] Christ would have indicated the time and the hour at the appropriate moment, but at that moment only he said that he knew, which it was fitting that they should know from him (*hoc solum se scire dicebat quod eos per illum scire oportebat*).

It was also necessary to explain the distinction between the statements said according to the form of God and those said according to the form of a servant (*Trin*. I 12,24-5). The affirmation of *Prov* 8:22 belongs to the former: the passage was among the most discussed texts in the dispute between Arians and ProNicenes. A particular of what is said according to the form of a servant, is when Christ said to the disciples who were concerned about their glorification in heaven: 'but to sit on my right hand, and on my left, is not mine to give, but it shall be given to them for whom it is prepared of my Father' (*Matth*. 20:23).

Further on (II 1,3) Augustine explains *John* 5:19: 'The Son can do nothing of himself, but what he seeth the Father do'. He rejects the interpretation that the Father possesses the ideal images of things and the Son realizes them:

> For He neither does other things in like manner, as a painter paints other pictures, in the same way as he sees others to have been painted by another man; nor the same things in a different manner, as the body expresses the same letters, which the mind has thought; but whatsoever things, says He, the Father does, these same things also does the Son likewise.[47]

Augustine also rejects the most banal solution, proposed by some ignorant people, namely that in this passage the Son is speaking *secundum formam servi* (*Phil*. 2:6). In reality, the Son is not less than the Father because He comes

[44] *Cum perducet credentes ad contemplationem Dei et Patris, profecto perducet ad contemplationem suam.*

[45] See above, p. 56-7.

[46] *Hoc enim nescit quod nescientes facit, id est quod non ita sciebat ut tunc discipulis indicaret.*

[47] *Neque enim alia similiter, sicut pictor alias tabulas pingit quemadmodum alias ab alio pictas vidit; nec eadem dissimiliter, sicut corpus easdem litteras exprimit quas animus cogitavit; sed: Quaecumque, inquit, Pater facit, haec eadem et Filius facit similiter.*

from the Father, and with those words it is not his difference which is shown, but his birth (*tenenda est et haec regula qua non minor Filius sed quod de Patre sit intimatur, quibus verbis non inaequalitas sed nativitas eius ostenditur*). Here too Augustine seems to keep in mind Gregory Nazianzen, who had explained those words of Christ in the sense that the Son draws his existence from the Father, excluding that Christ operated as one who looks at a model traced by another and ironically wondering when the Father had walked on the water and had done the other things that Christ did (*Orat*. 30,11).

At this point the question inevitably arises: did Augustine read Gregory of Nazianzus directly in Greek or did he use a Latin translation? The problem is that these references are to Gregory's oration no. 30, which however was not translated into Latin by Rufinus. Also later (*De Trinitate* XV 20,38), Augustine quotes a passage by Gregory Nazianzen (*Orat*. 29,6) on the generation of the Son: did the Father generate the Son according to His will or in a way extraneous to it? The passage was particularly important in the anti-Arian controversy, as was seen earlier (p. 258-61), and is quoted – from a Latin translation – by Augustine, but, unfortunately, not even *Oration* n. 29 was translated by Rufinus. The problem was considered by Altaner, who however was unable to provide a solution: he observed that *De Trinitate* XV 20,38 has a parallel in a passage of the *Liber de fide* (ch. 53) of the pseudo Rufinus (PL 21, 1123-54), but this parallel was only partial, so Augustine would hardly have used that source.[48] Unable to give a solution, Altaner assumed that there were other translations of Gregory Nazianzen, in addition to Rufinus's – and this must be all the more likely, given that Augustine translated (something not observed by Altaner, but that we have seen here) passages not only of *Oration* no. 29, but also from *Oration* no. 30. The issue, of course, remains hypothetical, and, at this point, one could also think that Augustine had really read those orations of Gregory of Nazianzus, not translating the passages accurately, but paraphrasing them, also because of his imperfect knowledge of Greek.

3. *Latin Translations*

A preliminary and, in any case, fundamental problem is the following: the interest in an authoritative text in Greek drives a Christian writer to make it known to his Latin-speaking audience. But it is a habit that the Latin writer, even if authoritative, like Ambrose, who does not need to "appropriate" the Greek text, presents it as a personal work. Thus Ambrose's *In Hexaemeron*

[48] B. Altaner, 'Augustinus und Gregor von Nazianz, Gregor von Nyssa' (1951) has carefully collected numerous other passages by Gregory in the works of Augustine, especially in *Contra Iulianum* and *Contra Iulianum opus imperfectum*, proposing that Augustine, in those works, had, instead, used Rufinus.

homiliae has a title that does not mean at all that it is a translation, and similarly it does not mean the *Explanatio psalmi primi*, which translates Basil's homily *In Psalmum primum* into Latin (PG 29, 209-28), including the extensive introductory discussion dedicated to the entire Psalter.[49] Ambrose's *De fide* and *De Spiritu sancto* also purport to be personal works, but they make extensive use of the Greek original, translated into Latin without the name of the source. Consequently, these works have an ambiguous status, because Ambrose and his readers did not consider the translation as such. Jerome asserts one thing that we can actually check, namely the strong dependence, the result of "looting" by Ambrose, on Basil's *Homiliae in Hexaemeron*, and also another thing, which instead escapes us and would have been much more interesting, namely the use of Hippolytus by Ambrose himself: 'Recently Ambrose ransacked Origen's *Hexameron* in order to follow above all the interpretations of Hippolytus and Basil' (*Nuper Ambrosius sic Exaemeron illius (scl. Origenis) compilavit, ut magis Hippolyti sententias Basiliique sequeretur*) (Hieron., *Epist*. 84,7). Therefore, Basil's exegesis has its natural continuation in Ambrose. Precisely for this reason Jerome considered Ambrose's operation when he wrote the *De Spiritu sancto* ambiguous, because, in his opinion, he had simply counterfeited and manipulated Didymus' work.[50] Marti includes this case in the category of those in which a writer has simultaneously been *interpres* and *auctor*.[51] According to Moretti,[52] Ambrose 'channels' the contents of the Greek patristics into his works.

And yet at other times Jerome himself considered Ambrose a translator, as, after all, he himself had been (in *Epistle* 112,20 in a list of Latin authors who had translated Origen Jerome included Ambrose); Rufinus also considered him as such. Elsewhere Jerome states (*Adv. Rufin*. I 2; CChr.SL 79,2-3) that Rufinus, if he had wished to justify the legitimacy of his own Latin version of Origen's *De principiis*, would have had to mention other Latin translators, such as Hilary, Ambrose, Victorinus: none of them, however, is the author of a version, neither intended in the modern sense nor intended in the ancient sense (the sense of *vertere*, which as early as Cicero's time did not indicate a literal translation, but a literary one). Ambrose, therefore, is aware of the limitations of his translation into Latin: it is inevitably weaker than the original (*Expl. Psalm*. 37.49); Latin is negatively affected by the traditional *patrii sermonis egestas* (*Expl. Psalm*. 118,12,45); Greek is *significantius*, that is, it is superior to Latin for expressiveness (*Expl. Psalm*. 36,4).[53]

[49] It has been studied by P.Fr. Moretti, 'Non harundo sed calamus' (2000).

[50] For further information, see L. Doutreleau (ed.), Didyme L'Aveugle, *Traité du Saint-Esprit* (1992), 138-40.

[51] H. Marti, *Übersetzer der Augustin-Zeit* (1974), 94-6.

[52] P.F. Moretti, 'Non harundo sed calamus' (2000), 84.

[53] *Ibid*. 86-9.

Jerome too had translated some Greek works: after a few homilies by Origen in his youth (around 376-377), subsequently Didymus' *De Spiritu Sancto*, and Origen's *De principiis* to set his version against Rufinus's, but only some fragments of it have come down to us, in which Jerome translates, probably precisely to differentiate his translation from Rufinus's, in a very literal way.

Basil and Jerome

Jerome does not give many details about Basil. He recalls the *egregii libri Contra Eunomium* and the work on *De Spiritu Sancto*, the homilies on the Hexameron, the *Ascetic Treatise* and the short homilies, of varying content (*breves variosque tractatus*) (*De viris illustribus* 116).[54] He did not make any real translation of the Cappadocian works.

Basil and Rufinus

Much more can be said about Rufinus, whose translation activity was, as we know, vast. It has aroused new interest in recent decades, in conjunction with and as a consequence of the attention with which translation has been considered a literary work.[55] Rufinus follows the traditional translation model, and therefore not only translates, but wants to solve the problems related to the Greek text.[56] For this reason, in his translations of Origen and mainly of *De principiis*, he wanted to respond to a need of Christian culture, that is to make the great theologian of the East known in the West. The translation, however, also posed another problem, that is, to see if the translator had expressed the genuine Origenian doctrine in Latin, or if he had modified it and for what

[54] In the fourth century, *tractatus* normally meant the written draft of the homily.

[55] As regards the activity of translating, the translators' intentions and a history of Late Antiquity Latin translations, the summary by P. Chiesa, '*Ad verbum* o *ad sensum?* Modelli e coscienza metodologica della traduzione tra tarda antichità e Medioevo' (1987), 1-51 is fundamental.

[56] After all, it cannot be excluded that Rufinus was, at least partially, influenced in his translations by what he found at his disposal. In fact, it does not follow that he had access to all the immense work of Basil or Gregory Nazianzen; furthermore, it is probable that already at the death of the two Cappadocians a 'classification' of the works considered of greater significance had gradually been imposed. There were probably partial editions very soon, and the problem is to know whether Rufinus had a partial edition, so he would have translated what he came across by chance, or rather he had not searched for what he wanted. For this reason, the choice made by Rufinus to translate one work instead of another may be questionable, but the choice may have been conscious and, at the same time, dependent on the circumstances: the diffusion of a text is not always due to its importance, but often also to its receptivity, to it being more or less easy, and the same criterion is applied to anthologies and partial editions. The same problem arises for Gregory Nazianzen, with regard to whom Thaddeusz Sinko, *De traditione orationum* (1917), 228-30 thinks that Rufinus was essentially guided, in his choice, by chance: an extreme opinion that does not convince me. A certain and definitive answer can hardly be given.

purposes.[57] So the problem that provoked Jerome's criticisms arose again: what was that translation's degree of fidelity to the original? Can it be used to learn about Origen's doctrines? If so, to what extent? The answer had been too one-sided: since Rufinus was almost exclusively the author of translations, we must rule out that he had his own personal thought. If it exists, it must be obtained either from the insertions or from the modifications he made to the translation from the Greek original, if they have a content and doctrinal value and are not due only to literary needs. Consequently, since Origen had been suspected of heresy, Rufinus, faithful to the orthodoxy established by the Roman Church in his time, intervenes on the Origenian text either to eliminate dogmatically unacceptable statements[58] or to add something that serves to understand Origen better.

Apart from his translations of Origen, Rufinus made the works of the Cappadocians known to the Latin West. He probably translated (but it has not come down to us) a selection of sentences from Evagrius Ponticus. So, from Basil, in 397 for the Abbot of Pinetum the first draft of the two monastic Rules; Rufinus's interest in monastic literature is also confirmed by the translation of the *Historia monachorum in Aegypto, sive de vitis Patrum*, composed between 403 and 410. He translated, in 399-400, eight of Basil's homilies for the noble Apronianus, to whom he also dedicated the translation of nine homilies by Gregory Nazianzen, probably in the same years.

As regards the translation of the Cappadocian homilies, Rufinus did not have to solve the problem he had faced for Origen: they were not dogmatically dangerous. In any case he did not translate Basil's dogmatic works, either because he did not know them or, above all, because he did not consider them suitable for his own purpose; instead, he found Gregory Nazianzen's homilies more suitable for the dissemination of Eastern theology, but, in any case, also the anthology of Gregory's homilies, which he translated, is not exclusively of dogmatic content, but also shows ethical and ascetic interests, and it is, on the whole, more varied than Basil's collection.[59] Instead, Basil was useful for Rufinus' purposes, as he was undoubtedly a master of spirituality and monastic asceticism and for this reason Rufinus had translated the *Regulae*.[60] From among Basil's thirty-seven homilies that have come down to us (and they were probably even more numerous),[61] apart from those on the *Hexameron*, Rufinus only translated eight of them (CChr.SL 20A),[62] or rather, seven, because one is not a homily, but a letter. It was probably a choice that had a purpose.

[57] For this problem, that is, the relationship between Origen and Rufinus and the Latin rendering of the Greek text, there is a large bibliography, which however has nothing to do with the subject of this work.

[58] P. Chiesa, '*Ad verbum* o *ad sensum?*' (1987), 21-2.

[59] Cl. Moreschini, 'Rufino traduttore di Gregorio Nazianzeno' (1987).

[60] P. Chiesa, '*Ad verbum* o *ad sensum?*' (1987), 22.

[61] See J. Bernardi, *La prédication des Pères Cappadociens* (1968), 91.

[62] I am using the edition edited by Carla Lo Cicero (2009). Previously another one had been published by Andrea Salvini: Rufino di Aquileia, *Omelie di Basilio di Cesarea* (1998). Salvini had

The preface to the translation is important because it allows us to see what the translator's intentions were. The work had been requested by the nobleman Apronianus, who, however, from what it has been possible to gather, had only wanted to know some Greek works generically, without specifying what could be useful or necessary to him: Apronianus, therefore, despite the customary praise with which Rufinus addresses him, as also in the prologue to his translation of the homilies of the Nazianzen,[63] must have been devoted to asceticism, but not particularly cultured. It would, therefore, have depended upon Rufinus as to which works were to be presented to him. Rufinus, however, although he was animated by practical (ethical and spiritual) intents,[64] wanted to give his translation a literary enhancement: in this he was following the Latin tradition, which had existed since the time of Cicero.

Reading Basil's work is not difficult, says Rufinus, because it is not made difficult by any dogmatic question, but it is very pleasant, because his style flows with abundance: *sed eloquentiae eius limpidissimum flumen lenibus et satis placidis fertur fluentis*.[65] Apronianus will surely be able to grasp this *flumen* also in the *paupertas Latini sermonis* which makes translation difficult, according to a well-known literary topos.[66] Jerome, in turn, had said of Cyprian's style: *instar fontis purissimi dulcis incedit et placidus* (*Epist*. 58,10). Moreover, Cyprian was a writer who enjoyed great fame in the fourth century: elsewhere (*Vir. ill*. 67) Jerome does not consider it necessary to cite his works with the title, because they are universally known. Rufinus asserts that the style of Basil's homilies is similar to Cyprian's (*hoc autem te scire volo quod stilus eius in Graeci sermonis splendore et dicendi gratia multum beato nostro similat Cypriano*).

based his edition on the collation of about fifteen manuscripts, one of which dates back to the sixth century, others, fragmentary, to the eighth, and one to the ninth; he also made use of the edition of the sermons of Maximus of Turin, edited by Almut Mutzenbecher (CChr.SL 23 [1962]), among which there is the third homily. The previous publisher, Julien Garnier, Sancti Basilii, *Opera Omnia* (1722), 713-44, had used only three manuscripts, that is, those he had been able to find on site, in the current National Library of Paris. Lo Cicero, who never mentioned Salvini's edition, nor even that of Garnier, never took any account of this work – either out of narrow-mindedness or for other easily imaginable reasons: one wonders how an edition that does not mention (probably on purpose) two previous editions can be defined 'critical'. This strange way of making a critical edition had already been noted by Aline Canellis, in her review (2011), 174-5.

[63] Rufinus must have been closely linked to Apronianus and his circle, which also included Melania, the protector of Rufinus himself. He also dedicated to Apronianus the translation of the Homilies on the Psalms of Origen and that of Sextus' *Sententiae*.

[64] But not exclusively, as M. Monica Wagner, *Rufinus the Translator* (1945), instead, maintained in her examination of the translation of Gregory Nazianzen's homily 2; it should, in any case, be borne in mind that Wagner was perhaps the first scholar to dedicate herself to examining Rufinus' translations of Gregory.

[65] The same praise of Basil's style can also be read in Anianus of Celeda, in the preface to his translation of John Chrysostom's thirty-eight homilies: I draw this information from H. Marti, *Übersetzer der Augustin-Zeit* (1974), 223-4.

[66] It also returns in the preface to the introduction of Gregory Nazianzen, cf. CSEL 46,1 (1910), 5,12-7 Engelbrecht.

After all, as regards the merits of life, Basil had not been very different from Cyprian: he had not obtained, unlike Cyprian, the palm of martyrdom, but he had obtained the *secunda palma*, that of confession, fighting every day against human vices and defects. Basil's speech, therefore, is above all moral and edifying (*est ergo sermo eius magis moralis, qui et instituere sufficiat animos ad bonam vitam et laboribus relevare*),[67] and for fourth-century Christianity the ideal of perfection is constituted by asceticism, rather than martyrdom. Furthermore, Basil's teaching was made even more pleasant by its simplicity, which also allows religious women to get closer to it, like Apronianus' admirable wife: she is Avita, the elderly Melania's granddaughter. It is interesting that Rufinus also presents as a homily (n. 7) one of Basil's epistles: n. 46, *Ad virginem lapsam*, because it was, rather than an epistle, a moralizing exhortation similar to a homily. Basil had sent it on the occasion of a serious episode, the violation of the monastic vows by a woman who was probably part of one of the "brotherhoods" he had founded. Given the drama of the case, therefore, and given the importance of Basil, who had written the letter, Rufinus considered it as important as if it were a homily because that epistle was current and possessed a great moral teaching. It served to accentuate the character of monastic asceticism, which was required by the Apronianus' religious environment.

Since, therefore, Rufinus had an ascetic and moral intent when he translated Basil's homilies, the modifications, additions, omissions, in short, everything that differentiates the Latin translation from the Greek original, that is, what distinguishes Rufinus from Basil, coincided with this purpose. Here are some examples.

The most interesting is the above-mentioned homily-letter 7 *ad virginem lapsam*. Due to the transformation from a letter to a homily it contains the most changes compared to the Greek original: the final part of the fifth chapter and the entire sixth chapter of the letter are completely omitted. In this way the Latin version stops towards the end of the fifth chapter, shortly after *Dan*. 7:9-10 has been quoted, with the grandiose vision of the universal judgment, which, as Rufinus teaches with a predicatory emphasis of remarkable drama, awaits especially sinners, including the guilty virgin. Basil, however, initially accused the woman, but after reaching the climax of the accusations by showing the universal judgment, he then gradually changed his tone. Eventually he had assumed the attitude of the comforter and spiritual adviser; he had admonished the woman to abandon her guilty life and had ended by insisting on the theme of divine mercy. In this way, the epistle that became a homily, ending with the vision of the universal judgment, appears more effective and more grandiose,

[67] The details of Basil's life are recalled by Rufinus also in *Hist. Eccl.* XI 9 (GCS IX, 2, 1014,10-1017,18).

but, above all, it takes on a much more marked moral and ascetic connotation than it had in Basil's original. The whole Latin version is characterized by the accentuation of the themes and ideas that lend themselves to a dramatic reworking in a highly rhetorical tone. The imagined scene is that of a court, before which Basil places the sinful woman; Rufinus accentuates the characteristics of this scene, assuming strongly rhetorical tones, with moments of *indignatio*, like that of *Hom.* 7,2, in which, after asking: 'How many times, in writing to the servants of God, have you asked them to pray for you', he adds sarcastically an observation that is missing in the Greek original: 'For what reason, tell me? To deserve God's gratitude for this unworthy corruption of yours, or to join the Lord because you have rejected corruption?' (*Cur, quaeso? ut infamis istius corruptelae gratiam consequi merereris, an ut Domino per incorruptionem iungereris?*).

Elsewhere (*Hom.* 7,5) the translator increases the series of *kola*, which Basil uses, to remind the woman of the possibility of obtaining forgiveness and salvation from God; each *kolon* of the Greek text is enlarged and the series of names, which highlight the meaning of a parable (that is, the lost drachma, the lost sheep, the prodigal son), is replaced and then expanded for greater clarity by a series of sentences each of which summarizes the essential fact of the parable itself. The description of the loss of the senses in the terrible moment of death is enriched by Rufinus with a series of rhetorical questions and with a wealth of pathos, which are not present in the Greek original; the sentences that arouse fear and bewilderment are accentuated and expanded. In short, the strong rhetorical reworking, which in this homily appears more accentuated than in the others, serves to strengthen the ascetic intent with pathetic and dramatic tones, which are greater in Rufinus than in Basil.

The first homily, in the Maurist edition by Garnier, deals with the first Psalm. This homily is above all of a didactic nature and the translation appears, on the whole, faithful to the original. On the other hand, the audience which Basil and Rufinus are addressing is different. While Basil had an assembly of faithful before him, as his exchange of remarks with his listeners often shows, with the translation there is the transition from the 'spoken' version to the written one, from the homily to the 'book'. Most of Basil's homilies on the Psalms were intended for a very large and heterogeneous Christian audience, within which the section made up of those who were actually Christians, that is, baptized, was small;[68] instead the homily on the first Psalm has a different purpose: it is a general introduction to the book of Psalms, and insists above all on the beginnings of the Christian life.[69] Rufinus has no interest in introducing significant

[68] Cf. J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 33-5.

[69] This characteristic of an introduction to the Psalms is underlined above all in the introductory chapter of the homily, so much so that it has had a greater manuscript tradition than the

changes, given that Basil's text already has an essentially didactic content, but since he has made the transition from the spoken text to the written one, from oral preaching to teaching aimed at educated people, he eliminated or reduced all the elements too closely linked with the liveliness of the preaching, which were in the Greek text, and he used, as always, a strong rhetorical accentuation, aiming at giving greater literary dignity to the text which he intended spreading in the environment of the ascetics. For example, he describes lust and threatens the condemnation of those who sin in the flesh with much less insistence than Basil, who held his homily in front of people he knew. Basil speaks (*In Psalmum 1*; PG 29, 225B) of men who prostituted themselves publicly in the square, while Rufinus translates the passage by eliminating everything and replacing Basil's violent words with other more bland words, which refer generically to malpractice and, more in particular, to the behaviour of dissolute men towards prostitutes: *aut non vides quomodo* (dissolute men) … *turpitudinum dedecora velut virtutum suarum praedicant ornamenta*? Basil describes and enumerates the various ways of lust very effectively and forcefully, while Rufinus who, on the contrary, in his homily on the sinful virgin had insisted on the moral condemnation of the sin committed, now softens the tones and, rhetorically lengthening the text with the addition of a sentence he himself invented, presents a less dramatic scene (*Hom.* 1,385-90).

The homily *Attende tibi ipsi* is the second of those translated into Latin, and corresponds with no. 3 of Basil. The words of *Deut*. 15:9, are quoted by Basil in the first chapter: 'Beware that there be not a thought in thy wicked heart'. Rufinus, probably, saw in the contents of the homily spiritual elements, in tune with his ascetic beliefs. The message is, therefore, above all of a moral character: man must look within himself, so that the word, a precious gift of God and an indispensable tool for the relationship with men, does not become an instrument of sin. Basil had also included numerous practical exhortations: do not pay too much attention to the flesh or wealth, take care of the poor (these were particularly important matters in his preaching in Caesarea, but which had to take on a more personal character, in addressing the behaviour of a private individual, like Apronianus and his friends, whom Rufinus was addressing).

The adaptations of this homily to the Latin public are numerous and varied. The second chapter gives us an example of how to present a Greek text to a Latin audience which does not know the language, so it is necessary to include an etymology: 'of the fawn (*damula*), which cannot be captured, because it has a very acute sight, on account of which the Greeks etymologically interpret its

homily itself: it served, therefore, as an explanation of the psalm as a literary genre. The homily too had become widespread, so much so that it was already known to Ambrose.

name (that is, δορκάς from δέρκομαι)' (*non incurrit in laqueum pro eo quod visum dicitur acutissimum gerere, unde et nominis sui* ἐτυμολογία *servatur in Graecis*) (2,105-7). Later on (2,400-2) Rufinus explains: 'but in yourself, as if you were a small and lesser world, you would discover the extraordinary wisdom of your Creator' (*sed in temetipso, velut in quodam parvo ac minore mundo, deprehendes magnificam creatoris tui sapientiam*). Basil's Greek διακόσμῳ does not imply the concept of 'microcosm' which is used here. Hence also the subsequent explanation seems closer to Rufinus than to Basil: 'In fact you mean God as the one Who is incorporeal and incomprehensible considering your soul, which is immortal, since not even your intellect as its first quality can be enclosed in one place, but is found in one place only thanks to the union with the body' (402-6).[70]

The fifth chapter contains descriptions of typically Roman situations and life, and picturesque details are included which, in fact, are missing in Basil. In the description of the great (but useless) things accomplished by the rich, who do not know themselves, we read (*Hom.* 2,5,245): *gerunt bella*, movent classica, and in the description of the banquets (2,5,260-1) there is an addition to the Greek text: 'Stop pouring insults to others into your drinking and, in the midst of your banquets and your dishes, speaking ill of the honest lives of others' (*desine poculis tuis aliena probra miscere et inter epulas ac fercula tua alterius vitae innocentiam lacerare*). The question is equally suitable for the Roman public: 'Are you powerful on account of your riches and are you proud of the consulships of your illustrious ancestors? Are you proud of the nobility of your country and your parents?' (*Divitiis flores et polles et illustrium proavorum consulatibus intumescis? Patriae parentumque nobilitate te iactas…?*) (2,5, 289-91). In the same way, a 'Roman' type of rhetorical *amplificatio* is performed with respect to the Greek text: *Ubi sunt? Quid agunt? Ubi fasces eorum? Ubi magistratus? Ubi diversarum infulae magistratuum?* (2,5,296-7).

Some other changes respond to a moral pedagogical intent, such as when Rufinus reaffirms his admonition by means of an addition: this biblical sentence he asserts, wants you to be cautious in your thoughts, and strong in your actions. Therefore, be self-vigilant (*prudentem te esse vult in consiliis, in actibus strenuum. Attende ergo tibi*) (2,4,224-6). Elsewhere he expands on the expression of the Greek original by adding to Basil's simple statement: 'you who are a soldier', combined with the quotation from 2*Tim.* 2:4, the consideration, drawn from the subsequent context that he is translating: 'Are you a soldier? Take care of yourself, so that, if you are a soldier of God, you do not let yourself be involved in the occupations of the world: you must please the one Who approved you, and you must collaborate with the Gospel, to exercise

[70] *Incorporeum namque et incomprehensibilem intellegis Deum ex ipsa anima quae in te immortalis est, quoniam quidem neque tua mens principaliter in loco aliquo continetur, sed tantum ex consortio corporis invenitur in loco.*

a good military service in the occupations of the world' (*Miles es? Attende tibi uti ne militans Deo implices te negotiis saecularibus, ut placeas ei qui te probavit, sed collabora Evangelio, ut milites in illis bonam militiam)* (4,207-9). In translating Basil's text ('against the passions of the flesh cover yourself with the whole nature of God'), in which the quotation of *Eph.* 6:13 is present, the whole Pauline image is enlarged with the addition of the previous verse (*Eph.* 6:12): *et adversus principes et potestates, adversus mundi huius rectores tenebrarum* (4,210-1); then Rufinus adds: 'and so also against the vices of the flesh you must take the shield of faith and all the weapons of the spirit; by wearing those weapons, you will be able to resist the fiery arrows of the devil'[71] (*Eph.* 6:16) (4,211-3). A little further on, Rufinus, in presenting, to his readers, Basil's consideration about the Christian's reprehensible habit of criticizing others' faults, without considering his own (5,255-6), translates the Greek expression: 'do not look only at the things around to you' in a clearer and more explicit way, 'that is, not to the faults and sins of those who are strangers to you' (*non eorum qui extra te sunt culpas et peccata*) (5,268-9). In the same context, Basil invites his listeners to carry out an examination of conscience before venturing to make gratuitous judgments on what others are doing: 'Be careful that your tongue has not sinned, preceding your mind; be careful that something unintentional has not been done in the works of your hands'. In order to make it clear to his readers, Rufinus explains what the error consists of: 'do not commit, in your actions and in the work of your hands, what may serve greed or anger or pleasure' (*ne quid etiam in actibus tuis et manuum opere commiseris quod vel avaritiae vel irae vel libidini ministratum sit*) (5,275-7). Basil invites the listeners to acknowledge their sins before praying to God and invoking His help: 'and if you find that there are many sins in your life, and you will surely find them, being the man you are, then repeat to yourself the words of the publican'. The Latin translation is more insistent and detailed: you will find many moral imperfections: 'you will have to correct them within yourself, and you will have to do penance for having committed them' (*quae intra te debeas emendare, pro quibus debeas poenitudinem gerere*) (5,278-9).

The title of the fifth homily *In principium Proverbiorum Salomonis, quam* (*scl. homilia*) *dixit cum esset presbyter iubente episcopo* contains information about Basil's life which, at least according to Garnier's indication, is not present in all the manuscripts, and which Garnier did not find appropriate to repeat. Based on this title, that is that the homily would have been pronounced by Basil, while still a priest, at the behest of his bishop, Rufinus added the sentence (3-4): therefore, let us obey to the High Priest (*et ideo obtemperemus summo sacerdoti*), which is not in the Greek text. But what Bernardi believes to be the most

[71] *Tum deinde etiam adversus vitia carnis assume scutum fidei, et omnia arma spiritus, quibus indutus possis resistere adversus ignita diaboli iacula.*

criticizable feature of the homily (and in fact it is), namely the disproportion between the text to be commented on and the comment itself, which appears long-winded and overabundant,[72] could have attracted the translator's attention because of the large number of moral considerations that Basil's homily contained. Bernardi is right in saying that Basil's homily has an excess of verbosity and an accumulation of rules and ethical suggestions, which had little to do with the first vers of the *Proverbs*. But it is likely that this 'missing exegesis' of Basil did not appear to be a fault for Rufinus, who found an authoritative text from which to draw, for his friends and readers, a series of didactic considerations certainly valid for him, although not very relevant with the introduction to the Proverbs. It seemed important to him that Basil reproposed the Origenian interpretation of the succession Proverbs – Ecclesiastes – Canticle being a growing gradation of spirituality (*Hom.* 5,1), which was of particular importance for Rufinus' Origenism. It is also possible that the definition of the term 'proverb' according to Solomon's understanding, which Basil proposed, could also have been useful to the Latin listener, for whom the proverb had the common meaning. 'For us Christians', says Basil (*Hom.* 5,2) 'the proverb is a useful saying, manifested with obscurity, and which has in itself a certain utility, and it conceals an even greater utility in its depth'; proverbs are exhortation speeches, which come in useful in all the circumstances of life. Therefore, Basil's didactic intent, based on the authority of Solomon, was useful for his friends in Rome. In explaining verse 2 ('with proverbs it is possible to know wisdom and discipline') (*Hom.* 5,2,31-3) Rufinus presents to his readers, as Basil had already done for his listeners, the etymology of the term *proverbia*, that is 'those words that we commonly pronounce by tradition, so to speak, of ancient times, as shown by the etymology of the Greek word' (*ea quae vulgo velut ex traditione quadam antiquitatis loquuntur, sicut ipsa apud Graecos* ἐτυμολογία *enuntiationis ostendit*).[73]

About half of the commentary is dedicated to the wisdom of the proverbs, and Basil first gives the definition of wisdom, following the universally widespread Stoic definition ('the knowledge of human and divine things') but, he adds: 'hidden in mystery', with an adaptation, therefore, to the Christian conception, as stated in 2*Cor*. 2:6-7. In *Hom.* 5,3 Basil resorts to the Stoic division between *sapientia* and *prudentia* to justify the expression *sapientia et disciplina* in *Prov*. 1:1. *Sapientia* is linked to the wisdom of God, the one with

[72] J. Bernardi, *La prédication* (1968), 56-7.

[73] It had also been proposed by Gregory of Nyssa, but in more detail: 'It is generally agreed that in scriptural usage the word 'proverb' is not applied to the manifest meaning, but is used of some hidden sense. Thus the Gospel calls puzzling and obscure sayings 'proverbs', so that there is a proverb, if one applies a rule to understand this word, when an expression points through some of its obvious senses to another hidden meaning, or when an expression does not directly draw out the intention of the thought, but delivers its teaching obliquely by some indirect meaning' (*CE* III 1,23).

which all things were created, *prudentia* is human wisdom, whereby one can be wise in an art. There is the highest wisdom, the one with which God created the universe and which therefore allows us to know the Creator. Next to this form of divine wisdom, there is a human one, which is the one implemented in everyday life, and Basil dedicates ample space to it in his homily. In particular, it should be noted that, among the forms of human knowledge, the first place belongs to philosophy, according to Basil, but this opinion does not take on a particular significance in Rufinus.

Basil in 4,393 A had simply said that Wisdom 'prepares the bowl', so that everyone can drink there; in the words: 'We talk about preaching, and you doubt that this word refers to the mystery of the Word?' (*Audis praedicationem dici et dubitas haec de mysterio Verbi referri*?) (144-5) there is the evident intention to underline the mystical aspect of the preaching of Wisdom, which has as its object God. This mystical interest also emerges from the slight modification to which Rufinus subjects the text: Basil commenting on *Prov*. 9:2 and *Psalm* 103:15 together had said: 'Scripture calls 'bowl' the common participation, of all the people, in the goods of God', and Rufinus: '(Scripture) calls the mystical participation in Wisdom "a purifying chalice"' (*craterem vero ipsum* purificatorium *nominat sapientiae* mysticum participium) (136-7). Or he adds to the quotation from *Prov*. 9:4 ('Whoso is simple, let him turn in hither') the words: *quae stulta enim sunt huius mundi vocavit Deus, ut confundat sapientes*, namely, the quotation from 1*Cor*. 1:27. In Ch. 8 Basil had simply said: 'the Proverb also gives us the possibility of understanding true justice', while Rufinus, dwelling on the theme of true justice, is more detailed and explicit:

> As, in fact, through the light of the world, namely, the apostles ('you', Christ, in fact, said, 'are the light of the world') we come to the true light, which is Christ, and as through the words of the wise we come to the true Wisdom, which is the Son of God, so it is through the teaching of justice, which we learn from the divine books, that we reach this true justice of which he speaks, which is Christ the Lord,[74]

modifiying the whole chapter, also with the omission of part of the Greek original.

Also in this homily, some unclear or ambiguous Greek terms must be presented to Latin readers. So in *Hom*. 5,11, in translating the text of *Prov*. 1:4 ('To give subtilty to the simple, to the young man knowledge and discretion') Rufinus must render ἀκάκοις and ἀκακία into Latin and for this purpose he uses *innocens* and *innocentia*, in order to convey effectively the reasoning, which insists on the ability not to do and not to conceive evil, which is proper to the child (518-25). A little further on (558-9) it is necessary to render

[74] *Sicut enim per lumen mundi, quod sunt apostoli (vos enim, inquit, estis lux mundi)* (*Matth*. 5:14), *pervenimus ad veram lucem, quae est Christus, et sicut per sermones sapientium pervenimus ad veram sapientiam, quae est Filius Dei, ita per eruditionem iustitiae, quam ex divinis libris edocemur, ad hanc quam dicit veram iustitiam, qui est Christus Dominus, pervenimus* (367-73).

πανοῦργος and πανουργία into Latin and to explain, using etymology, the meaning of the Greek word: *astutia ergo est … omnium operum artiumque peritia*, underlining, in a not entirely convincing way, that both the Greek word and the corresponding Latin one are essentially *voces mediae* and can have both a positive and negative value. In ch. 13 Rufinus wants to render adequately the Greek text in Latin, where prudence is said to give αἴσθησιν καὶ ἔννοιαν to παῖς νέος (626-35). Obviously αἴσθησιν is translated as *sensus* and *sensus* is interpreted, in good Latin, as meaning 'thought'. As for the superfluous Greek expression παῖς νέος, both Basil and Rufinus understand it with reference to the concept of the 'spiritual age', even if they had to resort to a grammatical annotation (627-8): *qui magis novus quam iunior designatur in Graeco*.

The sixth homily, entitled *De fide*, presents Christian doctrine in a very simple way, without resorting, that is, to a precise Trinitarian formulation. Speaking to an uneducated audience, Basil takes faith in a trinity of divine Persons for granted, and often underlines the absolute incomprehensibility of God, resorting, in the first chapter, to negative theology. But it is a very simple and popular negative theology, as required by the 'medium' or, in any case, not high and non-technical tone of the homily as an educational speech addressed to the people: so it was difficult for Rufinus to find theological doctrines in it.

In this homily, some linguistic details can be observed. In ch. 2,69 *Verbum sive Ratio vivens* is a necessary duplication for a Latin reader, inasmuch as he cannot immediately grasp the two meanings implicit in the Greek λόγος. A little further on, Rufinus translates: *omnia esse in imagine quaecumque sunt in prototypo, id est in eo cuius imago est* (77-8). The word *prototypus* is a strong Graecism, very rare in Latin, used for greater fidelity to the original (τῷ πρωτοτύπῳ): this fidelity is due to the fact that, here, a doctrine of faith is being proclaimed which must be as close as possible to Basil's text. The term *signaculum et imago* (91) to render σφραγίς is also rare in this sense. In ch. 3,142 θεολόγον is paraphrased (*id est verbi Dei praeconem*), probably because the word *theologus* in Rufinus' day was beginning to have the more common Latin meaning of 'theologian', losing the original one in Greek Christianity.

The stylistic changes of the translation are very interesting. In translating, Rufinus not only modifies the structure, but also adds brief considerations; the inclusion of biblical quotations has the aim of better confirming the reasoning; to obtain a greater pathos, he increases certain peculiarities or certain details, to which Basil had paid less attention, or which were presented by him without any particular importance. In the homily *Attende tibi ipsi* (ch. 3), he insists with a few words of explanation on the main concept, adding to Basil's simple admonition: 'be careful that, by dedicating yourself to the flesh, you do not give victory to the worst element', the words 'be careful that, in the battle of this war you do not give your support to the flesh and you do not provide it

with a large number of aids: in this way you will stimulate its power against the spirit and you will make sure that the best part of you is subjected to the worst part' (146-9);[75] or he adds, at the end of the chapter itself (157-9), a scriptural quotation: *Nam si is qui foris est homo noster foris rapitur, sed qui intus est renovatur de die in diem* (2*Cor*. 4:16), to conclude the discussion of the superiority of the spiritual element over man's carnal and bodily element. In the same homily Rufinus intervenes several times obeying rhetorical cues, as when he adds poeticizing expressions (193-4: feri ac palabundi *per aspera quaeque peccatorum* et devia *vagantur*), or even the Ciceronian style, which became usual in the rhetorical practice of the Imperial Age, at the beginning of homily 8: *consideranti mihi et providenti*. Grammatical information on the language are the translator's additions for the benefit of his readers: in the homily *Attende tibi ipsi* to the words: *nam et dammula non incurrit in laqueum* (2,105-6), in explaining *Prov*. 6:5 (*in medium laqueorum ingrederis*), the words *pro eo quod visum dicitur acutissimum gerere, unde et nominis sui etymologiam servat in Graecis* (105-7)[76] are added. As we stated (p. 344), these words are an example of the presentation of the Greek text to a Latin public that did not know Greek. Rufinus must explain to his readers that the Greek text plays on an etymology.

A study of the language of Rufinus' translations is still to be undertaken; only a few details have been observed, such as his lack of precision in the theological field in rendering the Greek text. A poetic expression is not rarely sought: in *Hom.* 4,4,148 (*pudicitiae tenax*); in 4,4,186 *contribules* (rare, and existing from the 4th century; Jerome felt the need to explain it in *comm. Zac*. 3,13 as a literal translation of σύμφυλον); in *Hom*. 4,6,292 and 5,4,137 the use of *participium* for *participatio* is remarkable (the TLL notes that it was a peculiarity of Rufinus, so much so that he used that word 35 times as opposed to 25 for *participatio*); in *Hom.* 5,10,499 there is the term *extorres*: it was poetic in pagan Latin, while it became not uncommon in Christian Latin, where it lost something of its solemnity (it was also used by writers not having a high stylistic level). In *Hom*. 5,14,677 there is *interminatio* ('threat'), which was used for the first time by Cyprian (*Epist*. 4,4), then almost only by Christian writers; *inconvertibilitas* (*Hom*. 6,3,112), which is also very rare, is encountered for the first time in Jerome's translation of Didymus' *De Spiritu sancto* (chap. 5) (a few years before Rufinus' translation), then it was used sporadically by Rusticus and Cassiodorus; in the same homily (3,122) Rufinus employs *ministerialis*: he seems to have been the first, later the word was rarely used in the fifth and sixth centuries. In *Hom*. 2,4, 209-10 he translates: *Adtende tibi, ut*

[75] *Vide ne forte tu in huius belli congressione manus accomodans carni et auxilia ei quam plurima subministrans, potentiam eius adversus spiritum erigas et meliorem tui partem deteriori facias esse subiectam.*

[76] It is the etimological note of δορκάς and δέρκομαι.

diligenter circumfodias infructuosam ficum (cf. *Luke* 13:8) *et adhibeas stercoris qualos*. The expression *et adhibeas stercoris qualos* is Rufinus' clarification of the Greek text, which is much more generic ('and you threw away everything that you need to produce fruit'). Furthermore, the word *qualus* ('large basket') was corrupted to *squalorem* in many manuscripts, evidently because its meaning was no longer known, while a twelfth-century manuscript (Auxerre, Bibl. Mun. 34, not complete) replaces it with *cophinum*, which is an obvious interpretation of *qualus*. *Qualus* was a technical word, because it was used by Columella, and of a certain antiquity, because it was already present in Cato. By imitation of the technical language it was taken up by Virgil (*Georg*. II 241) and by Horace (*Carm*. III 12,4), in the description of a scene of domestic life. Therefore, it was not only a technical term, but was also part of the family language, not vulgar, however; it was used in the same way by Apuleius (*Metam*. IV 22), in a passage in which Callebat speaks of 'family realism'.[77]

In conclusion, Rufinus followed the Latin tradition of *vortit barbare*, modifying and adapting the text to the society of his time and giving it a rhetorical colour, sometimes even strong, because that was the taste of both writers and readers of the Latin fourth century.[78]

Rufinus Translator of Gregory Nazianzen

The translation of the nine homilies by Gregory Nazianzen is also noteworthy. Mainly because it constitutes, together with that of Basil, the most important translation of dogmatically accurate texts, unlike not only those of Origen, but also of the *Sententiae* of Sextus and the pseudo-Clementine *Recognitiones*, which aroused, like that of *De principiis*, Jerome's criticisms. It was carried out in 399-400, perhaps before that of Basil.[79]

[77] L. Callebat, Sermo cotidianus (1968), 45.

[78] The literary characteristics and didactic intentions of Rufinus have been highlighted with regard to his translation of Basil, in the text that we have presented here and that was previously published: Cl. Moreschini, 'La traduzione di Rufino dalle omelie di Basilio' (1994); as far as Gregory Nazianzen was concerned, I came to the same conclusions even earlier, Cl. Moreschini, 'Rufino traduttore di Gregorio Nazianzeno' (1987). After the publication of those works of mine, the translations of Basil by Rufinus were also studied by Carla Lo Cicero in a detailed and sometimes even verbose way, but without achieving results that are substantially different from those I had already reached. Lo Cicero collected her contributions in a volume, *Tradurre i Greci nel IV secolo* (2008). The technique of *vertere* in Ambrose was studied by P.F. Moretti, 'Non harundo sed calamus' (2000). Since the problem of the Latin translation of Greek works in late antiquity is particularly complex, this is not the place to review it in detail, all the more, as far as Basil and Gregory Nazianzen are concerned, I had already grasped the fundamental characteristics of the matter in my previous works.

[79] See A. Engelbrecht (ed.), Tyrannii Rufini *Orationum Gregorii Nazianzeni novem interpretatio* (1910), XVI-XVIII.

Rufinus' translation can be considered one of the oldest confirmations of the great fame enjoyed by Gregory Nazianzen, having been carried out a few years after his death: a fame also confirmed by Jerome in those same years; finally, it was the only means for the Latin-speaking world to approach the work of the Nazianzen for several centuries. Also this translation, like that of Basil's homilies, was requested, from Rufinus, by the nobleman Apronianus: perhaps the name of Gregory was in some way known even to non-specialists, which Apronianus must have been. Although he was a person of considerable literary interests, like many of the Roman nobles of the late fourth century, either he did not know Greek, or only imperfectly:[80] however, this translation also responds to moral and ascetic needs, because it contains, among other things, Nazianzen's important homily 2, dedicated to the figure of the perfect priest (perhaps it was translated precisely for this reason). In the preface Rufinus asserts that Gregory's fame was due not only to his words (namely, his preaching activity), but also to his works (that is, to his Episcopate of Constantinople, which had remained famous, and probably also to his monastic life). The translator then outlines a succinct biography of Gregory, based on information probably derived from the poem *De vita sua* (II 1,11) and from the autobiographical poems II 1,12-3.[81] All this makes us aware of a slow and partial diffusion of Gregory's works in the Latin environment, similarly to what was happening in those same years with Jerome, who, in *De viris illustribus* (ch. 117), knew only some of the Nazianzen's most important homilies and some of the poems on virginity: a testimony of how difficult it was for a Latin to access all the work of a Greek writer, impeded by numerous objective difficulties which hindered contacts and relationships; it is probable that at the end of the fourth century there were only partial collections of Gregory's orations and poems: Augustin had to manage the same problems. Rufinus ends his preface by reiterating Gregory's correct faith, which was never questioned by anyone, in fact it would have been the norm by which to test the faith of others.[82] Therefore Apronianus could read without any scruple of faith the works of the Nazianzen (something that could never have been said for Origen).

Furthermore, in the *Church History* Rufinus dedicates a long chapter (II 9) to Basil and Gregory Nazianzen, in which there is news which, although it

[80] In fact, at the end of his preface Rufinus says that Apronianus was an expert in both Latin and Greek. Therefore, the request to translate Gregory would be due to the desire to give a wider dissemination to the Cappadocian's work in an environment that knew Greek less and less. It is also possible, however, that by saying that Apronianus was an expert in Greek, Rufinus wanted to compliment him and that the reality was less flattering than the writer suggests. Otherwise, what need was there to translate into Latin a Greek text that Apronianus could have read in the original?

[81] See Th. Sinko, *De traditione orationum* (1917), 228-9.

[82] In Tyrannii Rufini *Orationum Gregorii Nazianzeni novem* (1910), 1,17, where Gregory's life is told, it is said that Gregory saw two noble women in a dream seated one on his right, the other on his left. And Rufinus writes: *quas ille castitatis instinctu oculo torviore respiciens* etc. Should the text not be corrected to: *curiositatis instinctu*?

recounts the exact opposite of the way the events had actually occurred, was unlikely to have been an invention of Rufinus himself: Gregory would have convinced Basil, who was enthusiastic about rhetoric, to devote himself to the ascetic life, making him abandon the *doctoris cathedra* and therefore *per annos, ut aiunt, tredecim* he would have led the life of a hermit together with him, while it is well known that Gregory's stay in Pontus together with Basil lasted about two years, from 360 to 362, and not without interruptions. This news, Sinko observes,[83] cannot be derived from any of Gregory's works, and therefore Rufinus probably took it from a *Vita Gregorii* unknown to us, but which was probably composed immediately after Gregory's death: it mixes true news with patent falsifications, and narrates everything in an enthusiastic and hagiographic tone. Rufinus remembered having translated about ten orations of both.

Subsequently, some considerations on the text. How can one explain the choice of Gregory's orations? Sinko observed that the corpus of Gregorian orations is grouped into two families, each of which contains various orations in a particular sequence; he also added that the succession of the orations translated into Latin (namely nos. 2, 38, 39, 41, 26, 17, 6, 16, 27) at times comes closer to one of the Greek sequences and at other times to the other: he concluded, therefore, that Rufinus had made use of isolated editions of the Nazianzen's various orations, probably choosing with his own criterion those he could find, without drawing from an already established corpus (after all Gregory had died just ten years earlier). In fact, for some orations one can try to propose an explanation for this choice: the homily on the Christmas and on the Epiphany are among Gregory's most famous, and therefore it is possible that they were already well known while the author was still alive and in the first few years after his death; homily no. 2 contains a kind of programme of the perfect priest,[84] and it too, precisely for this reason, became famous. The oration for Pentecost (n. 41), having been pronounced on the occasion of a holiday, could also have been quite well known, certainly more than that dedicated to the Holy Spirit (no. 31), which is of a similar subject, but much more difficult; for the same reasons the other two theological orations, those which Jerome calls *contra Arianos* (nos. 29 and 30), are missing from Rufinus' collection; there is the first theological oration (no. 27), which is introductory to the next four but, like the following no. 28, it is substantially extraneous to the problem of Eunomius, so much so that Jerome knows the two orations against the Arians and the one on the Holy Spirit (no. 31), but he does not know either 27 or 28; no. 26 and no. 25 are

[83] See Th. Sinko, *De traditione orationum* (1917), 229-30 (it must be admitted, however, that this hypothesis is not based on anything concrete. Françoise Thelamon, *Païens et Chrétiens au IVe siècle* (1981), 441-2, instead, without advancing any hypothesis on the origin of Rufinus' error, is inclined to believe that all the news of *HE* II 9 was reworked by Rufinus for edification.

[84] A few years later, John Chrysostom also identified this particular characteristic in the Nazianzen's second oration.

dedicated to another important episode in Gregory's life, which perhaps had become famous, that of friendship and the subsequent enmity with Maximus; on the other hand, the reasons why the unimportant homilies 17, 6 and 16 were translated, are less clear; perhaps simply because they were in the collection of Nazianzen's works, as Sinko is inclined to believe. Therefore, if Rufinus did not use an ordered corpus of Gregory's homilies, such as those preserved in the two families of the Greek manuscripts, it seems logical to deduce that the text he translated could not correspond to that of either (**m** and **n**), formed in the upper Byzantine age. The same conclusion was reached, following Sinko, by Gallay[85] and Mossay.[86]

A comparison between the Latin text and that of the two families of the Greek text, as regards homilies 38, 39 and 41, taking as our basis our edition of them,[87] has confirmed this hypothesis:

Orat. 38,2 ἐπὶ τοῦ ὤμου **m**, ἐγενήθη ἐπὶ ὤμου **n**, *in humero eius*;
38,3 πρὸς ἑαυτὸν πάλιν ἐπαναγάγῃ **n**, πρὸς ἑαυτὸ πάλιν ἐπαναγάγῃ **m**, *ad se denuo revocaret*;
38,6 καὶ μύσται καὶ μυσταγωγοί **n**: καὶ μυσταγωγοὶ καὶ μύσται **m**, *et praedicatores et cultores*;
38,13 τρυφήσοντες **m**, τρυφήσαντες **n**, *ut percipere possitis*; τὸ ἐκμαγεῖον τοῦ ἀρχετύπου **m**, τὸ ἐκμαγεῖον τοῦ ἀρχετύπου κάλλους **n**, *figura vera et expressa substantiae Dei*;
38,16 νικῶντα **m**, νικῶντα τὸν πειράζοντα **n**, *sed vincentem*;
39,5 οὐ Θρακῶν ὄργια **n**, οὐδὲ Θρακῶν ὄργια **m**, *non orgia Thracum*;
39,8 ἀρχόμενοι **n**, om. **m**, *sumentes initia*;
39,14 καὶ ὁ δεῖνα καὶ ὁ δεῖνα **m**, καὶ ὁ δεῖνα **n**, *et alios atque alios memorant;*
39,17 προσώζεσαν **n**, προσώζουσιν **m**, *computruerunt*;
41,2 δὴ **n**, om. **m**, *hic vero honor*;
41,8 αἰτήσοντες **m**, αἰτήσομαι **n**, *deprecabimur*; πάντη **n**, om. **m**, *manifeste*;
41,12 ἐν τοῖς ἁγίοις **m**, ἐπὶ τοῖς ἁγίοις **n**, *in sanctis*.

As for the characteristics of Rufinus' translation, the problem was posed by Rufinus himself, who at the end of his preface (p. 5, 12-7) observes that the needs of the Latin translation greatly damage the splendor of the eloquence of

[85] See P. Gallay (ed.), Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 27-31 (1978), 22.

[86] See J. Mossay (ed.), Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours* 24-25 (1981), 211. However, a little scepticism is necessary when considering the documentation that Mossay sometimes presents, as when he observes that Rufinus renders a single Greek word with two Latin words: *Orat*. 26,3 *subrepticis … et persuasoriis* = συναρπακτικοῖς; *navem submergere* = καταδῦσαι; 26,10 *originem ducens* = ἐρχόμενον (or ἀρχόμενον: see the critical apparatus). It is certain that the 'two words' of the translation are equivalent to only one in the language of the Latin speaker, which Mossay does not seem to have noticed.

[87] Cl. Moreschini (ed.), Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 38-41* (1990).

the Greek original. This defect could be traced back to the insufficient skills of the translator (*nostri sermonis paupertas*), as he admits with the rhetorical modesty that befits a preface.

More than one hundred years ago, August Engelbrecht, the publisher of this collection in CSEL, devoted his attention to the problem of Rufinus' artistic translation,[88] resolving it in a way that nowadays certainly appears unsatisfactory, precisely because, when he published it, no one gave adequate consideration to the Latin writers' criteria in translating from Greek: now the situation has changed and studies on the translating technique are numerous – but not regarding the translation of Christian texts. Therefore, Engelbrecht, in referring to what Rufinus had observed at the end of his version of the Origenian commentary on the Epistle to the Romans, noted that the translator had admitted that he had added something (*addere aliqua*) to the Greek original, that he had filled (*explere*) what seemed to be missing, so that the Latin reader could have a perfect understanding of the text, and also, on the contrary, to have abbreviated what Origen had said at greater length, but without an intrinsic necessity (*breviare quae longa sunt*).

After having found these characteristics of the translation, which, in any case, had already been acknowledged by Rufinus, Engelbrecht tried to find the differences between the Greek original and the Latin translation, and concluded that it had been carried out in a great hurry,[89] agreeing with the *communis opinio* of the time on the ability of Latin writers to understand and interpret Greek texts. The first mistake Engelbrecht claimed to have found is simply a misunderstanding of the part of Engelbrecht himself, who reproaches the translator for having written (*Orat.* 39,12): *non enim generatur* (*Spiritus*), *sed procedit, si tamen etiam in rebus tam arduis et tam difficilibus explanationis gratia uti novis appellationibus fas est*: Rufinus apologized for using new words without having rendered in Latin what in the Greek text were actually new words, that is, οὐδὲ γὰρ γεννητῶς, ἀλλ' ἐκπορευτῶς. But the novelty that is found in the text that is being translated is not only in the two adverbs γεννητῶς and ἐκπορευτῶς, which for the Nazianzen had been the only ones of unusual use, but, for the Latin public (this is the point of the greatest importance), precisely in the verb *procedere*, which had indicated the origin of the Holy Spirit from the Father. The addition was therefore justified.

Again, Engelbrecht notes that, as appropriate, Rufinus changes the Greek text a little, without trying to explain, however, why he had done so:[90] but this behaviour was normal in Latin translators and we have already found it in the

[88] A. Engelbrecht (ed.), Tyrannii Rufini *Orationum Gregorii Nazianzeni novem* (1910), XVIII-XXV.

[89] *Ibid.* XIX.

[90] *Ibid.* XX.

translation from Basil. Or Rufinus simplified what seemed more difficult to understand in the Greek text:[91] likely, but for what reason this happened, Engelbrecht did not try to tell us.

We focused on this shortcoming of Engelbrecht's edition, in other respects excellent and meritorious, not to provoke a facile controversy after a hundred years, but to indicate how necessary it is to take into consideration what had once been studied superficially with the assumption of the insufficiency of the Latin writer towards Greek. This assumption has been called into question, albeit in a cursory way, by Studer, who at first,[92] starting from a new evaluation, previously proposed by some scholars,[93] of Rufinus' translations of Origen, observed that, in the context of an adaptation, rather than a translation in the strict sense, certain syntagms were used, such as *Dominus Salvator*, which corresponded with the ideology of the Christian Empire of his time; and in a slightly later study he focused on the meaning which, in the field of theology, certain characteristics of Rufinus' translation of the *De principiis* could have had, that is, on the particularities and modifications that a post-Nicene theologian was induced to bring almost of necessity to the text of a Greek writer who had lived more than 150 years earlier.[94] In the same way, Fr. Winckelmann considered above all the theoretical position taken by Jerome and Rufinus in the face of the problem of translation from Greek into Latin.[95] The same problem was later considered by H. Marti,[96] who illustrated the general criteria that inspired the translations of Christian writers of the 4th and 5th centuries. For this reason Winckelmann rejected some conclusions arrived at by M. Monica Wagner,[97] that is to say, that the Nazianzen's translation had been carried out above all with edifying – that is, moralizing – criteria. In fact, what Wagner said was true, but it was not the only principle followed by Rufinus, who was also guided by the need to inform his readers of the details of Greek Christianity, the Greek language and theology. It must therefore be determined whether, even where the Greek text did not pose problems of orthodoxy, it was necessary to modify, in the Latin translation, the Greek original and, secondly, whether the non-theological changes responded to a specific criterion.

[91] *Ibid*. XX-XXI.

[92] B. Studer, 'À propos des traductions d'Origène' (1968), 137-55.

[93] In particular, by G. Bardy, 'Recherches sur l'histoire du texte' (1923); *id*., 'Traducteurs et adaptateurs au IVe siècle' (1940).

[94] See B. Studer, 'Zur Frage der dogmatischen Terminologie' (1972).

[95] See Fr. Winckelmann, 'Einige Bemerkungen zu den Aussagen' (1970).

[96] See H. Marti, *Übersetzer der Augustin-Zeit* (1974), whose investigation, however, is limited to programmatic declarations, and does not deepen or, in fact, find the customary practice of translation. Nonetheless, Marti's work is useful for a knowledge of the problem of Latin Christian translations. It was, however, surpassed by the study of P. Chiesa, '*Ad verbum* o *ad sensum?*' (1987).

[97] See M.M. Wagner, *Rufinus the Translator* (1945).

As regards the translation of theological concepts, most of the modifications of the Greek text are, of course, not changes to adapt it to orthodoxy, but fall within what we consider 'paraphrasing', not a translation conceived according to modern criteria.[98] The changes in this order are due to the need to clarify the Greek text for the Latin reader. This is demonstrated by some passages of theological content from Gregory's *Oration* 2 (= 1 for Rufinus):

> It was this aim[99] which engendered the new Law, which teaches us; for this purpose the prophets intervened, intermediaries between the Jewish law and Christ; for this purpose Christ intervened, perfector and end of the spiritual law, this is the result of the annihilation of the divine nature (*evacuata divinitas*);[100] this is the result of the assumption of the flesh (*carnis adsumptio*)[101] (*Orat*. 2,33).

There follows this statement: *hoc est quod ex utroque mercamur*, which is not in Gregory: this is a constant practice of Rufinus, and already indicated by him in the preface, to add (or remove) what seems appropriate to him. Then the text continues: *haec est nova illa commixtio Dei et hominis*, that is, ἡ καινὴ μῖξις, Θεὸς καὶ ἄνθρωπος. Gregory states: ἓν ἐξ ἀμφοῖν καὶ δι' ἑνὸς ἀμφότερα, Rufinus, instead, wrongly attributes this determination to men, who receive the beneficial effect of the incarnation of the Lord: *ut per unum utrumque habere possimus* and adds: *propterea namque Deus* corpori anima mediante *commixtus est*; here, once again, the terminology is precise: it renders διὰ μέσης ψυχῆς.

In 2 (= 1), 36 (Gregory's *Oration* 2 is the first in Rufinus) Gregory presents the Nicene doctrine as the only right faith, the middle way between the two deviations of Arianism and Sabellianism; consequently Rufinus writes (1,31,6-25): *uti ne vel in unam subsistentiam ac personam sermone contracto tamquam deorum multitudinem vitans*, where the two terms *subsistentia* and *persona*, joined together, must render the single Greek term ὑπόστασις: behind this apparently innocuous duplication there is the problem of how to render the term ὑπόστασις in Latin, for which Rufinus, following the same method he uses much more systematically with Origen, has preferred to add *persona* to *subsistentia*, to be sure that the reader understood the 'person' and not the 'substance' of God: *subsistentia*, in fact, indicated the divine Person from the time of Marius Victorinus. The Greek text which immediately follows is rendered with sufficient fidelity: *uti ne … sermone contracto tamquam deorum multitudinem vitans quis solas appellationes nominum putet, et eundem Patrem et Filium et*

[98] Heinrich Hoppe was the first to pose the problem of Rufinus' artistic translation with greater sensitivity, even if he solved it in a somewhat obvious and traditional way, by contrasting "artistic translation" and "literal translation", in an essay that, albeit only in a fragmentary way, correctly mentions certain problems, H. Hoppe, 'Rufin als Übersetzer' (1937).

[99] That is, the aim of attaining Christian perfection.

[100] The term renders very well the Greek ἡ κενωθεῖσα θεότης.

[101] In this way the Greek words ἡ προσληφθεῖσα σάρξ are translated.

Spiritum Sanctum aestimans nominari. But immediately afterwards he adds: *ad Sabellii impietatem ex huiuscemodi confusione de permixtione declinet*. These words are not found at this point in the Greek original, but further on. Rufinus, therefore, preferred to shorten the comparison that Gregory made between Sabellius and Judaism, on the one hand, Arius and polytheism, on the other hand, perhaps because he thought it was difficult for the Latin reader to understand and in any case it was of secondary and extraneous value to the fundamental concept, which wanted to underline how the Nicene faith was the happy medium between the two extremes. The description of Sabellius' impiety (1,31,10-27) conveys in quite a clear way a certain terminological difficulty of the Greek discourse. For this reason, also here, the translator resorts to simplification: Gregory found in the Sabellian heresy the error of the ἀνάλυσις (namely, of the detachment of the Person of the Son from the Father) and of the σύνθεσις (that is, of the return of the Son to the Father, at the end of the centuries, so that the peculiarity of His Person will be destroyed), while Rufinus only speaks of *confusio ac permixtio* (31,10), that is, he only refers to σύνθεσις. However, it may be a simplification, not a betrayal of the original text. There then follows the description of polytheism and Arianism (and here Rufinus is forced to omit the play on words which, instead, was understandable for a Greek, that is, the allusion to Arius' 'bloody madness').[102] Arianism consists in attributing divine nature only to the ungenerated, Gregory says with the technical terminology (ἀγέννητος) which is not frequent in him, while Rufinus specifies: *ingenito Patri*, for a Latin reader who was not accustomed to the Cappadocians' theology. After this explanation, certainly there is a useless repetition, the clarification at the beginning of Chapter 38 (1,31,26-7): *neque in tres substantias alienas a se invicem et diversas fas est dirimi deitatem secundum Arrium*, because this had already been said earlier. This repetition contrasts with the remarkable precision and fidelity with which Nazianzen's theology is presented in the rest of Chapter 38, except for some abbreviations and summaries in the final part, where, among other things, the technical term of ἰδιότης, namely, the specific property of each of the three Persons, is not translated into Latin. Rufinus is not afraid, when translating, to shorten or omit, provided that the substance of the doctrine remains intact. Therefore, not a criterion of precision and absolute fidelity to the text, but an intent of serious diffusion, also taking into account the comprehension skills of his audience, which certainly was less expert than the Greek-speaking audience in doctrinal matters. He wrote for Apronianus and for ascetics, not for theologians.

That the inaccuracies with respect to the Greek text are often occasional and produced by the context, or due to the need for diffusion and simplification,

[102] This is a play on words typical of the anti-Arian literature; see only Gregory Nazianzen, *Orat*. 20,5-6; 21,13; 25,8; 34,8; 43,30; *Carm*. II 1,11,577 etc.

can also be deduced from the fact that sometimes, vice versa, one finds an extremely precise and exact translation. This is the case with the passage from *Orat*. 39,12 (= 3,121,23-123,11), which, extremely precise in Gregory, appears equally clear and exact in the Latin version. Similar observations can also be made for the "theological" chapter of *Orat*. 38,7 (= 2,92,4-16), in which the concept is rendered quite well in Latin, apart from some imprecisions and omissions. For example, the expression ὅλον … συλλαβὼν ἔχει τὸ εἶναι of the Greek text is simplified: *esse enim ipsius totum est et semper est*. But the famous definition of God as πέλαγος οὐσίας is rendered precisely as *substantiae pelagus*. Instead, the translation of ἄλλη ἐξ ἄλλου φαντασία συλλεγομένη εἰς ἕν τι τῆς ἀληθείας ἴνδαλμα in: 'so that the very aspect of truth is contemplated not on the basis of the truth itself, but on the basis of what is close to it' (*ut ipsa veritatis species non tam ex ipsa veritate quam ex his quae veritati sunt proxima contempletur*) is slightly generic and imprecise; οἰκείοις … προσομιλῇ is translated and clarified as follows: *domesticos facit etiam in conloquiis et sermonis participes*; the simple ὁ λόγος is enlarged and embellished: *fragilitatis nostrae sermo*; but on the whole the translation is satisfactory in terms of fidelity and accuracy.

In the strictly theological sphere, therefore, as far as Gregory Nazianzen's text is concerned, it seems to me that Rufinus has produced a good diffusion; he certainly did not translate according to our criteria, but took care not to change or disfigure Gregory's text. Perhaps we can say that Rufinus was more careful where he realized that the text was theologically important.

As regards, however, the passages with a content that is not strictly theological, Rufinus behaved towards the Greek original with the freedom that was typical of Latin translations, modifying and adapting to the needs of his readers what apparently seemed, to him, less appropriate or less functional.[103] Of course, in this context, the assessment of the discrepancies between the Greek original and the Latin version is difficult, because it depends upon unclearly specified reasons: for what reason, for example, was a section or a passage of the Greek text omitted, why, vice versa, was it expanded or added to, why was the translation not accurate, as we conceive it, but approximate? We can try to provide some examples which would hypothetically respond to an objective evaluation criterion.

For example, some changes seem to be due to the different culture of the translator, who was not at ease or did not consider certain forms typical of Gregory's style or thought pertinent. Such, for example, is the expression, typically

[103] Similar freedom, which consists in adapting to a circle of ascetic readers and educated people what Basil had said speaking to a multifaceted public, is found in the translation of the eight homilies by the Bishop of Caesarea, dedicated by Rufinus to Apronianus himself, as seen above.

Gregorian, of θεὸν ποιῆσαι, which is rendered, in a very banal way and not corresponding to Gregory's thought, with *hominem filium Dei facere* (*Orat*. 2,22 = Rufin. 1,23,13). The concept of man's ascent to God, typical of Gregory's thought, is also omitted in Latin: *Orat*. 2,14 (= 1,17,4) is simply translated as: *et ascensus nobis quidem putandus est vita haec*, and with this translation the Greek expression ἐπίβασιν ἀεὶ ποιεῖσθαι τὸ ἐν ποσὶ τοῦ ἐξῆς is simplified, but above all it takes away the idea, characteristic of the Nazianzen, of the ascent by degrees. Rufinus makes Gregory's expression, of Platonic inspiration (*Phaedr*. 230a), explicit: ἄνθρωπον … τὸ πολυτροπώτατον τῶν ζῴων καὶ ποικιλώτατον, by saying: *(homo) qui certe est inter omnes animantes maxime et moribus varius et voluntate diversus*, adding *moribus* and *voluntate* to the Greek original (*Orat*. 2,16 = 1,18,19). In *Orat*. 2,21 (= 1,23,9) the expression: *incitare animam ad virtutem* changes the Gregorian image of the soul's wings (also of distant Platonic ancestry): πτερῶσαι ψυχήν. Or the Greek original is expanded by means of additions, which have a mainly exegetical function. In *Orat*. 2,7 (= 1,11,27) Rufinus' translation is strangely literal: *et operi optimo vitiosum nomen infligunt philosophiam cenodoxiam vocantes*, whereby, probably in order to explain to his readers the term κενοδοξία, the following words are added: *et praeclara sapientiae studia iactantiae appellationibus infamantes*. But also in the translation of *Orat*. 38,18 (= 2,107,1-3) we find: *sed et in templo eum imitare interrogantem seniores et docentem ignorantes. Imitare etiam eum effugantem et eicientem de templo eos qui religionem Dei quaestum esse arbitrantur et vendunt ea quae in domo Dei geruntur*, as if he feared that the sophistic excessive conceptuality of the Greek (which simply says: δίδαξον ἐν τῷ ἱερῷ, τοὺς θεοκαπήλους ἀπήλασον) would not be clear to the readers. Similarly, a little earlier (*Orat*. 38,17 = 2,106,13-14), in the interpretation of *Psalm* 23, which, according to a particularly widespread exegesis in the Nicene context, refers to Christ, Rufinus adds, to explain why angels raise the doors in honour of the return to heaven of Christ, of its King: *in honorem Regis a magnifico proelio cum triumpho redeuntis*. In *Orat*. 39,7 (= 3,117,1-2) there is another exegetical amplification of the Greek original: the words εἰς τοιαύτην καταφεῦγον ἀπολογίαν, τὰ προσκυνούμενα are translated as: *verum etiam instar divinae similitudinis duceretur, nec ultra prorsus arguendum videretur quod deorum imitatione gerebatur*. In *Orat*. 39,17 (= 3,108,8), to clarify John's baptism, the Latin text expands: *sed hoc solum addit, quod in paenitentiam baptizat*, and a little further on, because it is clear that Christ gave those who believed in Him a way of life, the translator adds the words drawn from Christ's encounter with the mother of Zebedee's sons and the question, which he addressed to them, if they were able to drink the cup that he himself would have drunk and to be baptized with his own baptism: however, these words are not in oration 39, but in n. 37 (Ch. 14): did Rufinus know it, even if he did not translate it ? All this is missing in the Greek original, and was added for greater clarity or simply to insist on a particular concept.

There is no lack of inaccuracies (*Orat*. 41 = 4,2,142,13): the Pythagorean *tetraktys* is rendered with a certain simplification as *quartus numerus* (but it would have been difficult to present the true meaning of the Greek word to an audience of non-philosophers); or in *Orat*. 38,2 (= 2,28,29) *materia* is a somewhat cursory rendering of the Greek αἴσθησις. The omissions are also numerous, both of single words and of sentences; for example, Ch. 13 of *Homily* 41 is considerably abbreviated: in particular, Gregory's *Homilies* 41, 27 and 26 undergo cuts and abbreviations.

It was necessary to examine the Greek original and the Latin version side by side to become aware of the work performed by Rufinus (this possibility is missing, however, in large part, for his translations from Origen). The validity of his cultural operation is ensured by the fact that his translation was the only one that allowed the Latin West to know something of the Nazianzen's work (with the exception of an anonymous translation that we will briefly consider shortly), and his literary qualities were recognized not only by Augustine, who used his translation[104] but also by a judge who was certainly not biased, like Jerome, who had to admit (*Apol. contra Ruf*. I 30): *responde cur scribere aliqua ausus sis et virum disertissimum Gregorium pari eloquii splendore transferre*.

Evagrius

Evagrius was remembered with hostity by Jerome (*Epist*. 133), who unites Evagrius and Rufinus in his controversy, because Rufinus was a friend of Evagrius and both had been Origenists; also in the preface of *Dialogus adversus Pelagianos* Jerome speaks of the 'impassiveness' advocated by Evagrius, and traces it back with great nonchalance and imprecision to Pelagius' *impeccantia*. Jerome is either not well informed, or does not want to see things as they are, which often happens to him when he wants to argue: in *Dialogus* he combines anti-Origenism with anti-Pelagianism, because Jerome considers Pelagius' doctrine a *ramusculus Origenis*.[105] In the Commentary on Jeremiah (IV 1 introd., CSEL 59) Jerome states: 'When suddenly the heresy of Pythagoras and Zeno, concerning the lack of passions and the lack of sin, began to come back to life. This heresy was once killed in Origen and recently in his disciples, that is to say in Grunnius and Evagrius Ponticus and Jovinian',[106] thus uniting Rufinus (remembered with the unfriendly title of *Grunnius*) with Evagrius and Jovinian (who, being contrary to asceticism – certainly, to what Jerome advocated – appeared in Jerome's eyes as an enemy of 'impassiveness').

[104] See the brief review of the Augustinian passages outlined by Engelbrecht, in *Orationum Gregorii Nazianzeni novem* (1910), 288.

[105] See on this topic G. Caruso, Ramusculus Origenis (2012).

[106] *Cum subito heresis Pythagorae et Zenonis* ἀπαθείας *et* ἀναμαρτησίας*, id est impassibilitatis et impeccantiae, quae olim in Origene et dudum in discipulis eius Grunnio Evagrioque Pontico et Ioviniano iugulata est, coepit reviviscere*.

An Anonymous Text, Presented in a Provisional Edition

In contrast with Rufinus' translation, characterized by the literary and rhetorical elaboration, common to the Latin tradition, there is an anonymous translation, certainly much later than the former, preserved in a few manuscripts (while Rufinus' is preserved by many) and which had little diffusion in the Middle Ages. It is a translation carried out by a writer not having particular literary skills:[107] it includes Gregory Nazianzen's *Orations* 45 and 19, the *Epistles* 102 and 101 and the *Poem* I 2,3 (translated, however, in prose). Engelbrecht referred to this translation in his edition of Rufinus, basing himself on what Emily Gaar had communicated to him, so his indications appear somewhat inaccurate. He reports that the manuscript Urbinas lat. 60, of the fifteenth century, not personally seen by him, also contained, after Rufinus' translations of Gregory Nazianzen, the (evidently spurious) short work *De inventione capitis sancti Iohannis Baptistae eiusdem Gregorii Nazianzeni*; then the orations 45 and 19 (the latter, by mistake, is indicated by the scribe of the manuscript as *Contra Iulianum imperatorem*, while it can only be *Ad Iulianum tributorum exaequatorem*, because the sheets that contain it (ff. 110r-116r) are not sufficient for either of the two invectives against the Apostate;[108] then *Epistles* 102 and 101 and the *Epistola ad virginem nobilem*, that is, the *Poem* I 2,3 (PG 37, 632-40). The same works by the Nazianzen, in Latin translation (and, probably, in the same translation), are to be found in Laurentianus 17,31, also from the fifteenth century.[109] What Engelbrecht had observed secondhand and imperfectly was repeated by Sinko in his study of the tradition of Gregory's orations.[110] Finally, Paul Oskar Kristeller, an indefatigable researcher of manuscripts and ancient and humanistic texts, recorded the situation with exemplary clarity, identifying, among some humanistic manuscripts, the oldest one (Laurentianus San Marco 584, of the 9th-10th centuries). It should be borne in mind, however, that Kristeller's conclusions had been prepared by the investigations that another worthy of this type of study, Cardinal Giovanni Mercati, had previously conducted.[111] Currently this anonymous translation is being studied by Alessandro Capone, who is preparing the critical edition, rightly observing that it will be a necessary confirmation, given its age (6th century), for the constitution of Gregory

[107] When I published it in 1987 I wanted to propose only a provisional edition, that is, without an investigation into the manuscript tradition: it was then placed in *Filosofia e Letteratura* (1997), 267-305. After my first publication, one was proposed by Benoit Gain, *Traductions latines de Pères grecs* (1994), but what he assumes is a critical edition appears to be very deficient. I refer the reader who has the time and desire to see how not to read (or not understand the work of others) to my considerations on the aforementioned essay by Gain, Cl. Moreschini (1995).

[108] This had escaped Engelbrecht, Tyrannii Rufini *Orationum* (1910), XLII.

[109] *Ibid.* XLIII.

[110] Th. Sinko, *De traditione orationum* (1917), 231.

[111] In any case, for greater convenience, see P.O. Kristeller and F.E. Cranz, *Catalogus Translationum et Commentariorum*…, vol. II (1971), 47 and 60-1.

Nazianzen's text.[112] In order not to further delay this study, it was not considered appropriate to wait for its publication.

I present a first revision of this anonymous translation, leaving the task of completing the critical edition to my colleague. Since the main purpose is to make this text, which is an interesting literary document, known, we used our previous edition, which was based exclusively on the oldest manuscript. It is an extremely literal translation: it preserves, for example, the comparative Greek genitive, or the gender of the Greek original for some terms that are of a different gender in Latin, so the reader is forced, if he wants to have a more accurate evaluation of the style, or even (sometimes) to understand the meaning of the Latin phrase, to keep in mind Nazianzen's original. This literal adherence to the Greek text leads us to wonder, of course, what kind of public this translation was intended for: certainly not for a cultured public, especially since many linguistic details of the translation are undoubtedly typical of a vulgar Latin. Apart from the vulgar aspect of the style, there is also the fact that the scribe of the manuscript Laurentianus San Marco 584 appears, in turn, uncultivated and illiterate: many times it is necessary to intervene in the text, which would otherwise be incomprehensible. And one wonders, therefore, if the vulgar aspect of the Latin translation has not been compounded by the copyist's ignorance: for example, is the use of the ablative for the accusative of motion, which is often encountered, due to the copyist or the Latin translator, who was writing in the sixth century, when the endings in the language were no longer fixed, but oscillating? Is the use of *tradit* in the present tense instead of *tradet* in the future after another future due to a barbarism of the copyist or the translator's mediocrity?

There is a positive aspect, however: the extreme adherence to the Greek original by the Latin translator puts us in a more favourable condition as regards the problems of the *recensio* of Gregory's text, rather than Rufinus' translation, with its highly literary elaboration, but also free and far from the Greek, as seen above. Unfortunately, for *Orations* 45 and 19 we do not yet have a reliable critical edition. In *Oration* 45, however, it can be observed (if one accepts Maurists's critical notes) that the Latin translator, in the title, does not render ἅγιον, like some Greek manuscripts; in Ch. 2 *honorificatus* of the Latin translation seems to confirm τιμώμενον in comparison with the other lesson τεμνόμενον; the conclusion of Ch. 2 (ἔσται δὲ ὁ αὐτὸ διὰ τὸ κόρον), missing in some Greek manuscripts, is also missing in the Latin translation. The repetition of Ch. 3-9, which in *Homily*

[112] See A. Capone, 'Per una nuova edizione della versione latina dei testi gregoriani' (2015); *id*., 'Sulla versione latina delle *Epistole a Cledonio* (2015); *id*., 'La versione latina del *De salutari epiphania contra Apolinarium*' (2017); *id*., 'Greg. Naz. Or. 19: versione latina e testo greco' (2019); *id*., 'Appunti per un lessico grecolatino tardoantico' (2019); *id*., 'Note critiche alla versione latina dell'or. 45' (2019); M. Muccigrosso, 'La versione latina del *Carmen* I, 2, 3 (*Ad virginem*)' (2017).

45 was taken up with very few changes from *Homily* 38 (Ch. 7-13), is largely omitted by the Latin translator, who retains only chap. 45,3 (not complete), corresponding with 38,7; a deliberate omission or a particular stage of the manuscript tradition? In Ch. 11, the words *ab ea quae facta est … natura* are closer to γεννητῇ φύσει than to θνητῇ φύσει of Maurists. In Ch. 13 the sentence: *non solum autem, sed et sicut <h>orarum parentem, <h>orarum (id est virtutum) circumvolventem* shows that the two lessons of the Greek tradition ἀρετῶν and ὡρῶν, one of which was probably marked in the margin in the antigraph, came together in the literal and not very perspicuous translation of the original τὸν τῶν ἀρετῶν κύκλον. Furthermore, the Latin text presents as the first epistle to Cledonius what for the Maurist and for some Greek manuscripts is the second (n. 102), and vice versa (but also the most recent edition of of the epistles, presented by Gallay, is not very precise in the titles of the Greek manuscripts). Some other observations in this area. In Chapter 15 of *Epistle* 102 the Latin text: *apostolica voce … quae dicit* seems to agree with φωνῇ … νοουμένῃ τῇ λεγούσῃ of Gregory's manuscript A (Ambrosianus E 49-50 inf., Gr. 1014, of the 9th century), against … φωνῇ … νοουμένῃ ἢ λεγομένῃ of the other manuscripts and Gallay, and a little further on: *significetur vel intellegatur* corresponds to δηλουμένου καὶ νοουμένου against δηλουμένου of Gallay. In Chapter 18 once again the Latin translation (*non asperi sint nobis*) seems to agree with manuscript A, due to the presence of *nobis*, which is omitted by almost all of the Greek manuscript tradition (however, also another very ancient manuscript, the Parisinus gr. 510 (B), also from the 9th century, seems to read ἡμῖν; perhaps the word was preserved at a high stage of the tradition (9th century), to be lost later. As regards the *Poem* I 2,3, the Latin translation is even more clumsy, if possible, than the Greek original, which is one of Gregory Nazianzen's most infelicitous attempts at poetry, so much so that the authenticity of the poem is questioned by some. Here too, pending a reliable critical edition, we can see that *convivas* of the Latin translation seems to confirm συζήσῃς of the Greek text, corrected by Combefis and the Maurists as πάντα ζήσῃς (v. 3).

Having considered the text of the translation, it would now be appropriate to turn to its origin. It should be borne in mind that Nazianzen's works are in the manuscript Laurentianus San Marco 584 together with others of Athanasius (or attributed to him), of Basil of Caesarea, of Gregory of Nyssa, of Pseudo-Chrysostomus, of Cyril of Alexandria and of Proclus of Constantinople, constituting a collection, which must have had a specific theological purpose. Benoit Gain suggested that such a collection had been gathered by one or more dyophysite theologians, probably of an Alexandrian tendency, active in Constantinople between the end of the fifth and the beginning of the sixth century. It had been translated about the mid-sixth century in the Lombard area, probably by a cleric of the entourage of the Bishop of Milan, Datius, who died in 552.[113]

[113] B. Gain, *Traductions latines de Pères grecs* (1994), 368-90.

Appendix Chapter VI

[33r] INCIPIT SERMO
BEATI GREGORII NAZIANZENI
DE PASCHA

1. Supra custodiam meam stabo, dixit admirabilis Abacuc, et ego hodie cum ipso, data mihi ab Spiritu potestate et speculatione, et speculabor et agnoscam quid videbitur et quid loquetur[114] mihi. Et steti et speculatus sum, et ecce vir ascendens super nubes et hic excelsus valde et visio eius sicut visio angeli; stola eius sicut splendor corrusci pertranseuntis, et elevavit manum suam contra Orientem et clamavit voce magna. Vox eius sicut vox tubae, et in circuitu eius sicut multitudo militiae[115] caelestis, et dixit: «Hodie salus mundo», quantus est [33v] visibilis[116] et quantus est invisibilis. Christus ex mortuis consurgit, Christus in semetipsum sursum scandit; Christus ex sepulchro, et liberamini vinculis peccatorum; portae inferi aperiuntur et mors dissolvitur et vetus Adam deponitur et novus consu<m>matur. Si qua in Christo nova creatura, renovamini. Haec ille quidem dicebat, alii autem decantabant laudem, quam et primum, quando apparuit nobis Deus per eam quae deorsum est nativitatem: «Gloria in excelsis Deo et in terra pax hominibus bonae voluntatis». Cum quibus et ego in vobis eadem proloquor. Utinam autem acciperem[117] et vocem angelicae dignitatis, quae[118] in orbis[119] terminos resonaret.

2. Pascha Domini; Pascha et, iterum dico, Pascha. Dignitas Trinitatis ista nobis, sollemnitas sollemnitatum et festivitatum festivitas, tantum supergrediens non solum humanas[120] et terram repentes, verum etiam ipsas Christi et quae in ipso aguntur sollemnitates, quantum stellas[121] sol.[122] Bona igitur nobis et hesterna fuit dies, luminum accensione et splendore vestita, quantum et private et publice constituimus omne genus hominum, parvulorum et omnis dignitas, largissimo igne noctem luminantes in magni[s] luminis instar, quantum caelum desuper iubar infundit, universum mundum splendificans his, quae apud ipsum sunt, pulchritudinibus, et quantum illud supercaeleste, sive in angelis prima lucida natura post primam, eo quod ex ipsa sicut ex fonte rigatur, et quantum in Trinitate, apud quam[123] omne lumen consistit quod ex indivisibili lumine dividitur et honorificatur. Melior autem hodierna et magis conspicua, quomodo externa quidem praecursor fuit magni luminis resurgente lumine et velut iocunditas quaedam antecedens sollemnitatem. Hodie autem ipsam resurrectionem celebramus, non adhuc sperandam, sed iam factam et totum sibi mundum congregantem. Alius igitur aliud fructificet tempori et donum afferat, donum sollemnitatis, maius aut[124] minus, spiritalium donorum et quae

[114] loquitur L
[115] malitiae L
[116] visibilis *ex* invisibilis L
[117] acciperet L
[118] dignitatisque L
[119] urbis L
[120] humanas *ex* humanos L
[121] sitillas L
[122] sol *ex* sola L
[123] quem L
[124] aut: est L

accepta sunt Deo, prout unus quisque deitatis habet; quantum autem ad dignitatem, vix angeli consequuntur, primi intellectus et mundi superni[125] gloriae inspectores et testes, si vel apud ipsos universa comprehensibilis est laudis decantatio.

Nos autem introducamus verbum quod habemus optimum et honoratissimum, maxime quia et Verbum collaudamus[126] pro beneficientia rationalis naturae. Incipiam autem hinc. Nec enim patior, de magna victima et magnifici diei immolans verba, non ad Deum recurrere et inde facere initium. Sed et vos mihi emundate vestram et mentem et auditum et intellectum, quicumque istis deliciari vultis, quia de Domino et divinus est sermo, qui[127] abscedatis repleti deliciis quae non evacuantur.

3. Deus quidem erat semper et est et erit, magis [34r] autem est semper: nam «erat» et «erit» nostri temporis concisiones sunt et effluentis naturae, ille autem est semper et hoc ipse se ipsum nominat, Moysi[128] responsum in monte reddens. Totum enim in semetipso ΣΥΛΛΑΒΩΝ (id est congregatum) habet esse, nec incipiens nec deficiens, velut quoddam essentiae pelagus infinitum et interminabile, omnem excedens intellectum et temporis et naturae, mente sola praevalens adumbrari, et hoc valde subtiliter.

10. Sed quid ista[129] nobis? dicat forte aliquis multum sollemnitatis amator et cal[l]idior. Circa metas[130] age equos;[131] ea, quae festivitatis sunt, dissere[re] nobis. Atque hodie praesidemus. Hoc autem et faciam, etsi modice superius: ita me verbo et desiderio <…>[132] nec deterius autem et bona a[ni]mantibus arbitrantur de ipsa appellatione Paschae pauca praeloqui. Efficietur enim forsitan haec non inutilis auditui subintroductio.[133]

Pascha istud magnum et venerabile, P<h>ascha ab Hebraeis appellatur secundum eorum linguam, indicat autem haec vox transitum, historice quidem propter ex Aegypto ad Chanaan[134] fugam et regressionem, spiritaliter autem propter ab his qui deorsum sunt ad superna[m] et ad terram repromissionis iter praevium et ascensum. Quod autem saepius inscribitur evenire, invenimus: animus manifestis transmutatur aliqua nominum †ad manifesti ad magis decora. Hoc etiam et hic inspeximus. Salutaris enim passionis nomen hoc esse quidam arbitrantes, ad Graecam locutionem transferentes vocem atque commutantes litteras, pro Φ, Π, et pro ΚΑΠΠΑ, X[ri], Pascha appellaverunt hunc diem. Accipiens autem iam consuetudo vocem, validiorem fecit concurrente[m] multorum auditu[m] sicut <a>d magis pium verbum.

11. Et quidem omnem legem umbra<m> esse futurorum et eorum quae intellegenda[135] erant, divinus ante nos apostolus pronuntiavit, et qui loquebatur ante ipsum ad Moysen Deus, tunc cum de istis legem daret: «Vide enim, inquit, omnia facies secundum exemplar, quod tibi ostensum est in monte», adumbrationem quandam et discriptionem invisibilium ostendens esse visibilia. Et suadeor nihil horum sine causa

[125] superne L
[126] *ante* collaudamus *scripsit* in, *deinde del.* L
[127] que L
[128] moyses L
[129] ista *ex* istud L
[130] metus L
[131] ageve quas L, ageve quo L^2
[132] *lacunam indicavi*: βιασαμένων *Gregorius*
[133] subintroductio *ex* subintroductia L^2
[134] chanaan *ex* canaan L^2
[135] intellegentia L^2

neque inrationabiliter nec humi repens[136] ordinatum esse, nec quod indignum esset et Dei constitutionibus et Moysis ministerio, etsi difficile est singulis figuris singulas invenire inspeculationes subtiliter indagantem, quemadmodum sunt ea quae de ipso tabernaculo et mensuris et materia eius dicta sunt, et portantium eam Levitum et ministrorum et quaecumque de victimis vel de emundationibus, sive ΑΦΑΙΡΕΜΑΤΩΝ [34v], id est abstractionibus, constituta sunt. Et haec solos[137] inspeculari posse credo qui secundum Moysis[138] meritum sunt aut vicinissimi illius eruditioni,[139] quia et in ipso monte, ubi Deus hominibus imaginarie cernitur, aliquantum quidem ipse a[d] propria mensura descendit, aliquantum autem nos ex ea, quae deorsum est, humilitate elevat, ut vel mediocriter ab ea quae facta est possit capi natura, et, quantum possibile est, inca[p]pabile[m] capi. Neque enim aliter in cogitatione Dei effici materiale corpus et inligata mens crassitudine,[140] nisi adiuvetur, potest. Tunc igitur non omnes eumdem, sicut apparet, meruerunt ordinem et dispositionem, sed hic quidem† emundationis, alter autem ad mensuram singuli, ut arbitror, secundum virtutem suam; aliqui autem et omni modo proturbati sunt[141] et supernam tantum vocem audire permissi,[142] qui efferati erant moribus et divinis mysteriis indigni.

12. Verum tamen nos in medio eorum gradientes, qui omnino crassioris intellectus sunt, vel qui valde sursum elevati speculantur, ut nec omnino pigri et immobiles maneamus, nec curiosi plus quam oportet s[c]imus et decidamus atque alieni efficiamur ab his quae praece<du>nt. Illud enim Iudaicum quodammodo et abiectum, hoc autem deiudicantium somnia et utraque reprobabilius. Sic aliquo[143] modo de istis disputemus secundum quod nobis possibile est et non valde recedamus a[d] loco nec derisui s[c]imus multis. Arbitror enim quia cadentes nos ab initio per peccatum et raptos per iocunditatem usque ad idolatriam et inlicitorum sanguinum[144] sacrificia, oportebat iterum revocari et reduci nos ad principium per viscera misericordiae Dei Patris nostri, nullo modo[145] perferentis[146] tantum damnificari opus manus suae, hominem. Quomodo ergo se plasmaretur et quid fieret fortitudo? Quid enim? Medicinae desperationem afferebat, quippe cum nihil profuturum et quo repercutere peccatum posset, offerret propter longi tumorem[147] et crementum temporis, tranquillitate autem curationis et mansuetudine dispensationis ad corrigendum indigebat. Neque enim id quod distortum est ad rectum adducere subita permutatio et violenta corrigentis manus potest (facilius enim maior plaga efficitur quam corrigitur), neque ferventem equum et grandioris aetatis violenta refrenatio sine aliquibus blandimentis et palpationibus. Propter hoc data est nobis lex in adiutorium, quasi aliquid intermurale inter Deum et idola, ab illis quidem

[136] repens *ex* repetens L^2
[137] solus L
[138] moyse L
[139] eruditione L
[140] crassitudine (πάχος *Gregorius*): crescidine L
[141] sunt: est L
[142] *ex* permisi *corr*. L^2
[143] aliquo *ex emend*. L^2
[144] sanguinem L
[145] nullumodo L
[146] perferente L
[147] longi tumorem *ex* longetumorem *corr*. L^2

nos abstrahens, ad istum autem adducens, et concedit aliquid ab initio ut accipiat id quod maius est, concedit victimas ut constituat Deum, deinde autem suo iam tempore dissolvit et victimas sapienter commutans, nos per modi[35r]cas subtractiones et transferens ad evangelium iam praeexercitos ad credulitatem.

13. Sic ergo et propter hoc subintravit scripta lex, congregans nos in Christo, et haec est sacrificiorum ratio, sicut se mea habet ratio. Ut autem sapientiae profundum et divitias investigabilium iudiciorum eius non ignoremus, nec ipsas omnimodo sine sacris aut imperfectas reliquit, nec usque ad purum[148] procedentes[149] sanguinem, sed magnum, sed (ut ita dicam) insacrificabile sacrum, sicut quod est super primam naturam, legalibus[150] victimis commixtum est: non parvae orbis partis, nec ad modicum tempus, sed totius mundi et perpetualis emundatio.

Propter hoc accipitur agnus, propter innocentiam et propter indumentum antiquae nuditatis. Talis etenim pro nobis victima indumentum incorruptionis et est et vocatur, perfectum autem, non solum propter deitatem, qua nihil perfectius est, sed et propter adsumptionem, quae uncta est deitate et facta est, si dicas hoc, quod unxit aut, ut audacter dicam[151], et condivina. Masculus autem, sicut quod pro Adam offerebatur, maxime pro fortissimo robustior[em], quia primus sub peccato ceciderat et quia nihil femineum aut non virile in semetipsum affer[e]t, sed vividum et †vitae[152] rumpentem[153] vincula virginalia ac materna, secundum multam potestatem, et generatus masculus ex prophetissa, sicut Esaias evangelizavit. Anniculus autem, sicut iustitiae sol[em] aut exinde exortus aut visibili circumscriptus et in semetipsum conquirentem et coronam gratiarum benedictam et[154] undique sibi ipsi aequalem ac similem. Non solum autem, sed et sicut <h>orarurn parentem, <h>orarum (id est virtutum) circumvolventem, leniter concretarum et commixtarum[155] in invicem, lege amicitiae et ordinis. Immaculatum autem et impollutum, sicut medicinale macularum et venientium ex malitia delictorum et coinquinamentorum: nam etsi peccata nostra accepit et infirmitates nostras portavit, non tamen ipse aliquid pertulit medicina dignum, et temptatus quidem est per omnia secundum similitudinem nostram, praeter peccatum. Qui enim persecutus est, id quod videtur in tenebris lumen non comprehendit. 14. Quid deinde? Mensis introducitur primus, magis autem principium mensuum, sive hoc apud Hebraeos ita principio fuit, sive postea hinc factum est et a mysterio ut primus esse accepit. Decima autem die mensis (hic enim in numeris perfectissimus est, ex monadis prima monas, unitas perfecta et genetrix perfectionis); servatur autem usque ad quintam diem, revera quia mundatio sensuum est mea victima, per quos peccavi et circa quos bellum est qui suscipiunt aculeum peccati. Eligitur autem non de agnis tantum, sed ex deteriori specie et [35v] sinistrae manus haedis, quia non propter iustos solum, sed et pro peccatoribus immolatur – forsitan autem propter ipsos magis, quantum et maiore indigemus misericordia; nihil autem mirum est si per singulas domos agnus exquiritur; <sin > minus[ne], et per

[148] puram L
[149] procidentes L
[150] regalibus L
[151] ut audacter dicam *correxi*: de dicere L
[152] vitae: vide L
[153] rumpentem *ex* rumpententen L^2
[154] et *ex* est (*ut vid.*) L^2
[155] concretorum et commixtorum L

domos familiarum propter inopiam mendicantium, quia fortissimum[156] est unumquemque sibi maxime sufficere ad perfectionem et oblationem vivam, sanctam, beneplacitam offerre viventi Deo semper et in omnibus consecratam[157]. Si autem non, et cooperatoribus in hoc uti necesse est, qui secundum meritum virtutum cognati et unianimes sunt: hoc enim mihi videtur velle ut communicent his qui vicini sunt victimam, si indigeant. 15. Hinc sacra nox et praesentis vitae confusae nocti contraria, secundum quam primitivae dissolvuntur tenebrae et ad lucem omnia atque ordinem et speciem veniunt, et decorem prima deformitas accepit. Hinc Aegyptum fugimus, verecundiae nostrae causam et persequens nos peccatum, et Pharaonem invisibilem tyrannum et amarissimos operum datores, ut ad supernum reformemur[158] decus et de luto ac lateribus liberemur,[159] incertae et noxiae carnis huius allegatione, et quae nec levissimis, palearum modo, cogitationibus in multis retinetur. Hinc agnus occiditur et consignantur pretioso sanguine actiones et rationes ve<l> habitus et operatio, ostiorum nostrorum po<s>tes – dico autem motiones mentis et dogmatum, quae bene aperiuntur et clauduntur ex speculatione, quia mensura quaedam est et assumptionis. Hinc ultima et gravissima persecutoribus plaga et prorsus nocte digna et ploratu, primogenita propriarum cogitationum et actionum Aegyptus, sicut et semen Chaldaicum amputatum ab Scriptura nominatur et parvuli Babyloniae adliduntur ad petram et dissolvuntur, et omnia vocibus plena et clamoribus Aegyptiis, et a nobis discedit huiuscemodi illorum exterminator,[160] reverentia et timore unctionis. Hinc et septem dierum amputatio fermenti; iste enim est magis mysticus numerorum et mundo isti ΣΥΝΣΤΟΙΧΟΣ, id est consonus; fermenti autem veteris et acidi,[161] non panifici et vitalis, ut nequaquam de Aegyptio saginemur fermento et de emortua et sine Deo Pharisaeorum disciplina. 16. Et illi quidem plorent, nos autem [m]agnum comedamus; ad vesperum autem, quia in fine saeculorum Christi passio est. Communicat enim discipulis ad vesperum, dissolvens peccati tenebras. Non elixum autem, sed assum, quatenus nihil ΑΘΕΩΡΗΤΟΝ (id est nonspeculativum) nec aquosum sermo in nobis habeat [36r] nec dissolubile, sed ut totus consistens et robustus et purgatorio igne examinatus et omnino a materialibus liber. Ne[c] superfluus sit,[162] bonis carbonibus adiuvemur ad intellectualem nostrum succendendum et purgandum ab eo qui venit ignem mittere in terram, et valde festinantes ad accensionem nostram, ut consumi laboriosi actus possint. Quidquid ergo carnale est verbi et vescibile cum interioribus et occultis mentis comeditur et consumatur[163] et in spiritalem digestionem redditur usque ad caput et pedem, id est eorum quae prima sunt in deitatis speculatione et postrema sunt in incarnationis cogitatione. Nihil autem proiciemus nec in mane relinquemus,[164] quia nec proicienda sunt ad eos qui foris multa nostrorum mysteriorum, nec praeter noctem istam emundatio aliqua est, et dilatio in alteram vituperabilis est his qui participant Verbo. Sicut enim pessima est totius diei iracundia, sed eam ante solis occasum dissolvi bonum est et Deo amicum, et temporaliter et ΑΝΑΓΩΓΙΓΩΣ (id est

[156] fortissimum *ex* fortissimus L
[157] beneplacitum … consecratum L
[158] reformemus L
[159] liberamur L
[160] exterminator *ex* exterminatorum L^2
[161] acidi *ex* acidae L^2
[162] sunt L
[163] consumetur L
[164] relinquimus L

aeterne) – non enim tutum[165] est occidere nobis iustitiae solem – sic huiuscemodi commestionem nec pernoctare nec in aliam reponere opus est diem. Quantumcumque vero ossosum est et invescibile et nobis ad speculationem difficile, neque conteretur male divisum et intellectum (praetermitto enim dicere quia nec secundum historiam Iesu contritum est, etiam cum hi qui crucifixerunt ad mortem eius propter sabbatum festinarent). Neque proicitur et distrahitur, ut dentur sancta canibus et malis dissipatoribus[166] Verbi, sicut nec porcis[167] id quod praeclarum et gemmatum est verbi, sed igne consumetur quo et holocaustomata, id est spiritu, qui omnia scrutatur et scit ea quae subtiliantur et salvantur, non quae pereunt in aquis et quae disseminantur, sicut caput vituli apud Moysen adumbratum <ab> Israhel in duritiae vituperatione. 17. Dignum autem est nec commestionis modum transcurrere, quia nec lex usque ad historicam[168] speculationem in scribendo studiosa fuit. Consumamus enim victimam festinantes, et azyma cum amaritudinibus comedimus et praecingimus lumbos nostros et calciamenta habebimus in pedibus et sicut presbyteri baculo utimur. Cum festinatione autem, ut non patiamur quod Loth ille prohibitus est a mandato, ut non circum inspiciamus nec stemus in omni circa regione[m], sed in monte salvemur, ut non comprehendamur a Sodomitico et peregrino igni, ne in statua salis coagulemur[169] per eam, quae ad <d>eteriora est, conversionem, quod operatur in futurum dilatio.[170] Amaritudinum autem commestio,[171] propter amaritudinem vitae quae secundum deum esset, et quae occurrunt maxime incipientibus et [36v] quae voluptatibus excelsiora sunt, quia etsi suave est iugum novum et leve onus, sicut audis, sed[172] propter spem et propter retributionem, quae multo largior atque effusior est ab huius temporis passionibus: alioquin quis non dicat quia multo legalium dispositionum operosius est Evangelium et laboriosius, quippe cum Lex fines peccatorum prohibeat, nos autem etiam ipsas peccatorum causas propemodum sicut actus impedimur?[173] Non moecheris, inquit Lex: tu autem ne concupiscas ex curiositate aspectus et ex studio accenderis passione[m]. Non occides, illa; tu nec repercutias, sed te ipsum praebeas caedenti. Quanto ista illis amiciora sapientiae! Non periurabis, illa; tu autem nec iuramenti initium capias, nec maius nec minimum, sicut iuramentum periura generantem. Non coniungas domum ad domum, illa,[174] et agrum ad agrum, per potentiam opprimens pauperem. Tu autem vende et quae iusta possides festinanter,[175] et nudare pauperibus, ut vacuus tollas crucem et locupleteris invisibilibus. 18. Lumbus[176] autem inrationabilibus quidem solutus et liber sit, neque enim habent rationem quae retineat voluptates[177] (nondum autem dico quia et ipsa<e> terminum sciunt naturalis motionis); tibi autem zona et castitas suspendat et subtrahat et concupiscentiam et id

[165] totum L
[166] dissipatoribus *ex* dispensatoribus L
[167] postis L
[168] historicam *ex* historiam *corr*. L
[169] coaculemur L
[170] delatio L
[171] commixtio L
[172] audisset L
[173] impetimus L
[174] illa *ex* illam *corr*. L^2
[175] festinantes L
[176] lumbos L
[177] quae retineat voluptates *Costa*: quaerenti ne voluntates L

quod hinnibile est, sicut divina dicit Scriptura, detrahens, huius passionis pudenda, ut mundus comedas Pascha, mortificans membra quae sunt super terram et Iohannis zonam imitans eremitae et praecursoris et magni praeconis veritatis. Scio et aliam succinctionem, militarem dico et virilem, secundum quam bene accincti Syriae quidam et solummodo accincti nominantur, secundum quam et Iob responsa reddens dixit Deus: 'Accingere sicut vir lumbos tuos et da responsum virile', qua et divinus David praecinctum se esse virtute a Deo gloriatur, et Deum ipsum introducit indutum virtute et accinctum videlicet contra impios – nisi forte quia amicum est id quod supereminet virtutis sic[178] quasi suspensum et restrictum indicari quemadmodum et lumine amictus dicitur, sicut vestimento:[179] id enim, quod incomprehensibile est virtutis eius et luminis, quis sustinebit? Quaero aliquid commune lumbis et veritati: quid autem sentit apostolus, cum dicit: 'State ergo succincti lumbos vestros in veritate'? Nisi forte quod id, quod speculativum est in nobis, concupiscibile nostrum constringit et non permittit ferri ab[180] alio. Non[181] enim vult amorem alicubi deditum ad alias voluptates eandern virtutem habere. 19. Calciamentis autem his quidem, qui sanctam intraturus[182] est terram, discalciari oportet, sicut Moyses ille supra montem Syna, ut nihil quod morticinum efferat nec quod medium sit inter Deum et hominem, sicut et si quis discipulus ad evangelizandum sapienter et non super[37r]flue mittitur, quem oportet sine aere et sine baculo et cum una tunica, adhuc autem et nudis[183] esse pedibus, ut appareat quam speciosi pedes evangelizantium pacem et omne aliud bonum. Qui autem Aegyptum fugit et ea quae Aegyptiorum sunt, calcietur et propter alias munitiones et propter scorpios et serpentes, quos multos[184] Aegyptus nutrit, ne noceamur ab his qui calcaneum custodiunt et quos conculcare iubemur. De baculo autem sic habeo et de eius aenigmate: scio quidem ministeriale, scio pastorale et magisteriale baculum, quod rationales oves convertit. Sed tibi nunc [sunt] …[185] excelsiorem lex iubet, ne forte circumducaris, sive inludaris quasi Dei advocatus, sed inverecunde et indubitate comede corpus, bibe sanguinem, si concupiscentiam habes vitae, et nec his quae[186] de carne sunt sis incredulus verbis, **[187] quae de passione sunt, nocearis. Immobilis consiste, ambulans solide, in nullo movearis ab adversariis neque suasoriis abstraharis verbis.

In excelsis tuis consiste, in atriis Hierusalem statue pedes tuos, supra petram firmam, ut non moveantur, quae secundum Deum sunt, vestigia tua. 20. Quid ais?[188] Sic placuit, egredi Aegyptum, fornacem ferream, relinquere ibi multos deos et qui non sunt dii, sub Moyse agi et sub illius legislationem et militiam. Introduco aliquid et non <m>eum, magis autem valde meum, si spiritaliter adtendas: commoda[189] ab Aegyptiis vasa aurea

[178] scio L
[179] vestimentum L
[180] ad L
[181] non: dum L
[182] intraturus *ex* tancturus L^2
[183] nudis *ex emend.* L
[184] multas L
[185] *nonnullarum litterarum lacuna in* L
[186] qui L
[187] *nonnulla desunt : an* <neque his> *?*
[188] ait L
[189] quomoda L

et argentea. Cum his iter age, ex alienis onerare, magis autem tuis: tibi merces[190] servitutis et laterum; excogita aliquid et tu ad repetitionem; bene fraudare, concedo. Miserabilis hic factus es[t], luto, pugna[191] laboriosa et sordido[192] corpore, et civitates aedificans alienas et noxias, quorum memoria perit cum sonitu. Quid et gratis egrederis et sine mercede? Quid autem relinquis Aegyptiis et contrariis potestatibus quae male adquisierunt et peius consummant? Non sunt illorum, rapuerunt vi, abstulerunt ab eo qui dixit: 'Meum est argentum et meum est aurum, et dabo illud cui voluero externo'. Illorum fuit; permissum est enim; hodie tibi competit et datur a Domino, qui bene usurus es[193] et salubriter. Adquiramus nobis ipsi amicos de inimico mamona, ut quando defecerimus, recipiamur in tempore iudicii. 21. Et, si quidem Rachel aut Lia <es>, patriarchalis et magna anima, etiam idola aufer, si inveneris patris tui, non ut serves, sed ut disperdas. Si autem sapiens Rachel,[194] ita ad terram repromissionis transfer[et],[195] ut et propter hoc doleat persecutor et agnoscat inlusus quia non bene opprimebat et in servitutem redigebat meliores. Si sic feceris et sic egressus fueris [37v] Aegyptum, bene novi quia columna ignis et nubis[196] deduceris nocte et die. Lenis efficietur eremus, mare tibi dividitur, Pharao mergitur, panis de caelo pluit, petra vertitur in fontem, Amalec debellabitur, non solum armis, verum etiam inermibus iustorum manibus, orationem simul figurantibus et trophaeum; dividetur etiam fluvius, sistetur[197] sol, retinebitur luna et sine aliquo bello[198] †constructionemur, id est ruentur; scrabrones praecurrent viam, parantes Israheli et debilitantes atque enarcentes[199] allophylos, et alia omnia quae supra haec vel cum istis refert historia, ut non in longum extendam sermonem, a Deo tibi dabuntur.

Tali hodie frueris festivitate, tale istud super te nativitatis sidus est et eius qui pertulit epitaphium; tale tibi est Paschae mysterium, haec lex subscripsit, ista Christus implevit, dissolutor litterae, perfector,[200] quibus pertulit pati discens, quibus glorificatus est conglorificari donans.

22. Reliquum est deinceps inquirere etiam rem et dogma quod a multis quidem despicitur, mihi autem valde investigandum est: cui, et propter quid pro nobis effusus est sanguis magnus et ubique conclamatus Dei et sacerdotis et victimae. Detinebamur enim a maligno, venumdati sub peccato et recipientes mercedem malitiae, voluptatem. Si ergo pretium non alterius alicuius nisi detinentis fit, quaero cui hoc inlatum est et propter quam causam. Et si quidem[201] maligno, fuge iniuriam! Non enim nisi soli Deo, sed et Deum ipsum redemptionem deceptor accepit et mercedem sic supereminentem suae tyrannidis, propter quod et nobis parci iustum erat. Si autem Patri, primum quidem, quomodo? Non enim ab ipso detinebamur. Deinde quae ratio est Unigeniti sanguine

190 mercis L
191 pugna *ex* pugnas L
192 sordido *ex* sordida L
193 est *ex* es L^2
194 *an* Israhelites? *sic quidem Gregorius*
195 *ex* transfere *corr*. L^2
196 nubes L
197 sistitur L
198 aliqua bella L
199 enarbantes L : *ex* ἀνείργουσαι *Gregorii correxi*
200 perfector <Spiritus> *con. Costa*
201 quidem L, quod est L^2

delectari Patrem, qui nec Isaac sucepit a patre oblatum, sed commutavit victimam, arietem reddens pro rationali victima? Autem manifestum est quia accepit quidem Pater, non petens autem nec indigens, sed propter dispensationem, quia oportebat sanctificari per id quod humanum est Dei hominem, ut ipse nos eriperet a tyranno a quo vi detenti sumus, et ad se ipsum revocet per mediatorem Filiun et in honorem Patris istud dispensantis cui et omnia deferre videtur. Et Christi quidem talia sunt, et quae ampliora sunt, silentio colantur. Serpens autem aeneus[202] pendet quidem contra serpentum mortem,[203] non autem ut figura eius qui pro nobis pertulit, sed sicut contrarius, et salvat aspicientes in se, non quia creditus salvat, sed quia mortificatus est, et commortificat quae sub ipso sunt virtutes, dissolutus sicut erat dignus. Et quod condecens a nobis ei epitaphiuin dicetur? 'Ubi est, mors, [38r] aculeus tuus? Ubi est, inferne, victoria tua?' Cruce percussus es, a vivificante mortificatus es, sine spiritu es, mortuus, immobilis, inefficax, etiam si figuram servas serpentis, in sublime †depompatus.

23. Communicemus autem Paschae, nunc quidem typice adhuc, etiam si veteri manifestiore (legale enim Pascha audeo et dico; figura adhuc figurae era[n]t subtilis et obscura), post paululum autem perfectius et mundius, quando nobiscum illud Verbum bibet novum in regnum Patris sui, discooperiens et edocens quae[204] nunc mediocriter ostendit: novum enim erit semper quod nunc agnoscimus. Qui autem potus, vel quae refectio, nostrum quidem discere, illius autem edocere et communicare suis discipulis: nutrimentum est enim doctrina etiam eius qui nutrit.

Venite autem, et nos participemus legem evangelice et non secundum literam, sed perfecte, non imperfecte, sempiterne, non temporaliter; faciamus nobis caput, non eam quae deorsum est Hierusalem, sed quae sursum est metropolim; non eam quae nunc ab exercitu calcatur, sed quae ab angelis glorificatur; immolemus[205] non novos vitulos neque agnos[206] cornua producentes et ungulas, in quibus multum est emortuum et insensibile, sed immolemus Deo hostiam laudis in superno altari cum eo, qui sursum est, choro laudantium; pertranseamus primum velamen, secundo propinquemus, inspiciamus in sancta sanctorum, dicam id quod amp[hi]lius est, nos ipsos immolemus Deo, magis autem et immolemus per singulos dies, et omnem motionem, omnia pro Verbo sustineamus, passionibus passionem imitemur,[207] sanguine sanguinem veneremur, prompte crucem ascendamus; dulces sunt clavi, etsi valde pleni doloribus, cum Christo et pro Christo pati magis eligendum est quam cum aliis deliciari.

24. Si Simon[i] es Cyrenaeus, tolle crucem et sequere; si crucifigeris sicut latro, sicut benivolus, Deum cognosce; si ille propter te cum impiis reputatus est et propter tuum peccatum, tu pro illo efficere legitimus; adora eum; propter te suspensus est. Etiam suspensus, lucrare aliquid et a malitia, eme morte[208] salutem; cum Iesu in paradiso ingredere, ut discas unde decidisti; inspice quae ibi sunt pulchritudines, dimitte extra murmuratorem cum propria mori[209] blasphemia. Et, si Ioseph ab Arimathia es, pete

[202] aeresus L
[203] mortem *ex emend.* L^2
[204] qui L
[205] immolamus L
[206] agnis L
[207] *ex* emitteremur *corr.* L^2
[208] morte *ex* mortem L^2
[209] propriam ori L

corpus a crucifigente, tua efficiatur mundi purgatio; et, si Nicodemus es, nocturnus[210] Dei venerator, aromatibus eum conde; et, si Maria es aliqua, vel alia es Maria aut Salome aut Iohanna, plora, se[38v]quere, occurre ad monumentum diluculo, videre prima revolutum lapidem, forsitan et angelos; Iesum ipsum aliquid adloquere, vocem audieris; et si audieris[211] «non me tangas», longe consiste, revereri[212] Verbum, non tamen contristeris; scit enim quibus primum appareat. Intima[213] resurrectionem; auxiliare Evae primum cadenti, primum ipsa Christum ΑΣΠΑΣΑΙ, id est adora, et indicans discipulis. Efficere Petrus aut Iohannes. Ad monumentum, ΕΠΙΧΘΗΤΙ, id est festina, antecurre, concurre, certans bonum certamen, et, si praeventus fueris[214] velocitate, vince festinatione: non inspicias tantum in monumentum, sed intro ingredere, et, si quemadmodum Thomas relictus fueris, congregatis discipulis quibus Christus adparet, quando videris, non discredas; et si non credideris, dicentibus crede; quod si nec ipsis, vel figuris clavorum ad credulitatem adducere, et, si in inferno descenderit, condescende; cognosce quae etiam ibi sunt Dei mysteria et quae dispensatio duplicis descensionis, vel quae ratio: simpliciter salva<t>[215] omnes apparens, aut[216] et ibi eos qui credunt.

25. Et si in caelo asce<n>derit, simul ascende; iungere cum deducentibus angelis aut cum suscipientibus praecipe tolli portas, et excelsiores effici, u[n]t eum qui pro passione excelsiorem capere possint. Dubitantibus de corpore et de passionibus, cum quibus non descendit et cum quibus ascendit, et propter hoc interrogantibus: «Quis est iste rex gloriae?», responde quia: «Dominus fortis et potens» in omnibus quae semper fecit et facit in praesenti bello atque victoria circa humanitatem, et da duplici interrogationi duplicem responsionem, etiam si admirantur dicentes secundum Isaiae tragoediam: «Quis est hic qui[a] venit ex Edom?», id est ex terrenis, «vel quemadmodum rubra sunt vestimenta eius, qui sine sanguine et corpore est, sicut in torculari ambulantis et qui plenum calcavit torcular?». Profer admirabilem stolam eius, quod pertulit, corporis, quod pulchritudine[m] decoratum est et divinitate splendificatum, quia nihil amabilius neque speciosius.

26. Ad haec qui<d> dicunt nobis calumniatores, amari deitatis ratiocinatores, accusatores laudabilium, tenebrosi circa lumen, indisciplinati circa sapientiam, pro quibus Christus gratis mortuus est, ingrata possessio maligni? Huius culpa[n]s beneficientiam? Propter hoc abiectus est, quia ad errantem pastor venit bonus, qui[a] animam suam ponit pro ovibus suis, super montes in quibus sacrificabas errantem invenit et inveniens accepit in humeris, in quibus et lignum, et accipiens elevavit ad supernam vitam et elevans his qui permanent connumeravit, qui[a] accendit lucernam, propriam carnem, et scopis purgavit domum, mundum a peccato emundans, [39r] et dragmam requisivit, id est regalem imaginem condefossam passionibus, et advocat amicas sibi virtutes ad dragmae inventionem et communicatrices facit exultationis, quas et dispensationis secretarias faciebat, quia praecursore<m> lucerna<m> lumen sequitur, quod superexplendet, et vocem Verbum et paranymphum sponsus, instituentem Christo populum substantivum

[210] nocturnus *ex* nocturnos L^2
[211] audieris *ex* audietur L^2
[212] consistere vereri L^2
[213] intima: ἐγκαίνισον *Gregorius*
[214] fueris *ex* fuerit L^2
[215] salvum, *ut vid.*, L^2
[216] aut *ex* ait *corr.* L^2

et praeemundantem per aquas ad spiritus[217] baptismum? Haec improperas Deo? Propter haec deteriorem suspicaris, quia linteo praecingitur et lavat pedes discipulorum, optimam esse[218] docens viam sublimitatis humilitatem, quia propter inclinatam animam ad pavimentum humiliatur, ut sustollat id quod deorsum vergit sub peccato? Illud autem est: quomodo non accusas quia cum publicanis manducat et apud publicanos et docet publicanos, ut et ipse aliquid lucretur? Et quid hoc? Peccatorum salutem – nisi forte et me[n]dicum accuset quis quia inclinatur ad passiones et foetorem tolerat ut de<t> salutem laborantibus, et eum qui propter beneficientiam est inclinatus in foveam, ut, quod ceciderat, iumentum[219] secundum legem resalvificet.

27. Missus est quidem, sed sicut homo; duplex enim erat: nam et laboravit et esurit et sitit et in agonia fuit et flevit corporis lege; si autem et sicut Deus, quid hoc? Bonam Patris voluntatem missionem arbitrare, ad quem refert ea quae sua sunt et sicut principium intemporale honorat et ne videatur esse contrarius[220] Deo: nam et traditus dicitur, sed et semetipsum tradidisse scriptum[221] est; et resuscitatus esse a Patre et adsumptus, sed et se ipsum resuscitasse et ascendisse iterum dicitur: illa beneplaciti, ista potestatis. Tu autem ***[222] dicis, sublimantia transcurris, et quia pertulit quidem reputas, quia voluntarie autem, non addis. Qualia patitur et nunc Verbum! Ab aliis quidem sicut Deus honoratur et coniungitur, ab aliis autem sicut caro exhonoratur et separatur: quibus irascatur amplius? Magis autem quibus remittat? Coniungentibus male aut concidentibus? Etenim et illos dividere oportebat et istos coniungere, et illos quidem numero, istos autem deitate. Impingis in carnem? Hoc et Iudaei. Et Samariten[223] vocas? Ut quod deinceps est taceam. Incredulus es[t] deitati? Hoc nec daemones. O et Iudaeis infidelior et daemonibus insipientior! Illi filii appellationem unius honoris voce<m> existimaverunt, isti persequentem se Deum[224] reveriti sunt. Suadebatur enim eis ex his quae patieba<n>tur. Tu autem nec aequalitatem esse suscipis nec confiteri<s> deitatem. Melius tibi erat (ut et ridiculum aliquid dicam) et circumcidi et daemonem esse, quam in praeputio et sanitate agere dolose et sine Deo. Et istud quidem ad[39v]versus illos proelium est: aut ut dissolvantur sero, saltim resipiscentes, si voluerint, aut eiciantur, si noluerint, et habeantur sicut se habent: prorsus nihil timebimus pro Trinitate cum Trinitate decertantes.

28. Nunc autem necessarium nobis est sic recapitulare sermonem. Facti sumus ut bene haberemus; bene habuimus, quia facti sumus. Paradisus nobis creditus est ut deliciaremur; mandatum accepimus ut servantes eum bene placeremus, non ignorante Deo quod venturum erat, sed legem ponente libero arbitrio. Seducti sumus, quia invidiam sustinuimus; decedimus, quia transgressi sumus; ieiunavimus, quia non ieiunaveramus a ligno cognitionis detenti. Antiquum enim mandatum est et nobis contemporale, animae quidam[225] paedagogus exsistens et deliciarum temperantia, quae praecepta est

[217] spiritui L
[218] optimam esse: optima est L
[219] iumentum *corr. Costa*: lumen tuum L
[220] contrarias L, contraria L^2
[221] scriptum *ex* scriptus L^2
[222] *lacunam indicavimus*: τὰ μὲν ἐλαττοῦντα *Gregorius*
[223] samaritanus L^2
[224] se Deum *ex* secundum *correxi*
[225] quaedam L

nobis condecenter, ut non servantes expellemur, custodientes reciperemur. Indiguimus Deo incarnato et mortificato, ut revivisceremus; commortificati sumus ut emundaremur; consurreximus, quia commortificati sumus; conglorificati sumus quia consurreximus, 29. multa siquidem istius temporis miracula: Deus crucifixus, sol obscuratus et iterum resplendens (oportebat enim creatori compati et quae creata sunt), velum discissum in duas partes, sanguis et aqua de latere profluens: illud quidem ut hominis, illud autem sicut super hominem. Terrae commotio, petrae scissae, mortui resuscitati ad fidem ultimae et communis resurrectionis. Quae in sepultura signa, quae post sepulturam quis tam digne conlaudet? Nullum tamen miraculum quale salutis meae, paucae sanguinis guttae totum mundum replasmantes, et efficiuntur sicut coagulum lacti<s> omnibus hominibus, in unum nos conligantes et congregantes. 30. Sed [h]o[c] Pascha magnum et sacrum et totius mundi emundatio (sicut animatum te adloquar); o Verbum Dei et lumen et vita et sapientia et virtus (gaudeo enim omnibus istis nominibus); o magni Dei generatio et OPMHMA, id est egessio et imaginis expressio! O verbum quod intellegeris et homo qui[226] videris, qui omnia portas reconlegans[227] verbo virtutis: nunc quidem habe sermonem hunc, non initium, sed completionem prorsus nostrae fructificationis, gratificatorium eumdem ipsum et deprecatorium, ut nihil patiamur mali praeter illa quae necessaria sunt et sacrata, quibus conviximus, et resiste corporis, quae[228] adversum nos est tyrannidi (vides, Domine, quantae[229] et quemadmodum incurvanti[s]). Si in tua sorte et a te amputemur, et constituamur[230] digne desiderio, et suscipiamur in caelestibus tabernaculis, forsitan et ibi [40r] sacrificabimus susceptibiles hostias super sanctum altare tuum. O Pater er Verbum et Spiritus Sanctus! quia tibi omnis gloria et honor et potestas in secula saeculorum, amen.

Explicit beati Gregorii Nazianzeni de Pascha. Deo gratias.

[40r] INCIPIT EIUSDEM BEATI GREGORII NAZIANZENI DE SERMONIBUS ET DE MARTYRIBUS ET IN IULIANUM PERAEQUATOREM

1. Quae est haec tyrrannis, per quam ex caritate semper subicimur servituti? Quae mea sapientia et disciplina, per quam in omnibus sollemnitatum congregationibus oppugnamur? Ego etenim nullam invenio, undique me ipsum discutiens et delinians, verum tamen istud unum mihimet ipsi conscius sum, et[231] forsitan minime noxium, etiam si hoc quidam modestiam nominent, volui si quidem in tempore vanae gloriae et se ipsos amantium id quod humile est sapere, et maxime omni tempore mortificari huic vitae, et illi vivere quae abscondita est in Christo et effici quidam magnus negotiator, omnium quae habeo pretiosa<m> comparans margaritam et commutans effluentia et transeunda cum his quae permanent et caelestibus. Haec est enim negotiatio maxima et

[226] quod L
[227] portas reconlegans: portasse conlegans L
[228] quae: qui L
[229] quantas L
[230] constituamur: constitue nos L, *fortasse recte*
[231] et: eo L

firmior, his videlicet qui intellectum habent, sed, si possibile est istud[232] tollerare, relinquere cathedram cupientibus, ipse autem in omni vita puer esse et discipulus, quousque honorabilibus[233] sermonibus salsidinem mei oris abluerem. Et unum quidem ac primum istud est meae philosophiae sive modestiae, secundum autem quod et maximum. 2. Quia verbo multorum sermonem et aviditatis casum, qui omnes detinet in docendo ac loquendo quae Spiritus sunt sine spiritu, cohibere idoneus non sum, aliud, sicut mihi ipsi persuadeo, melius et superius iter ingrederer et erudirem omnes ad quietem taciturnitatis exemplo, si quidem magnum[234] de me aliquid arbitrantur, eminentiam erubescentes, si autem modicum et quantum dignum est, aequali<s> in honorem mediocritatem sectantes. Ista est ratio mei silentii, istud patientiae nostrae secretum. 3. Sed quid patior? Unus hinc, alter inde distrahunt me atque discerpunt et de meis altercantur laboribus et velut quoddam aliud debitum inrecusabiliter peragunt exactionem, et diligunt me magis quam ego ipse et sunt omnes me sapientiores ampliusque quam ego cognoscentes tempus loquendi et tacendi et locuntur incessabiliter, sicut ferro igniferam petram tundentes nos contumeliis, quousque ex modica scintilla magnum comprehendant sermonum ignem. Iam autem aliqui[40v] ex ipsis et pollicentur meliora et magna proponunt verbis certamina, primum quidem semetipsos benevoli dantes Deo et nobis ut fructificent in verbo, deinde istos omnes, meam per descriptionem sortem (si tamen mea[m], quae paterna est), meum gregem, cui multum forsitan praeiudico, si non eos omnibus modis ad bonam operationem promptos efficio. Sed et aliud optimum, quia propter hoc quod multum laboraverunt oportet eos in directum verbis adducere. Haec sunt quae inferunt pro sermonibus nostris. O quam bona concertatio, in qua me vincere contendunt! O quam laudabilis relaxatio! Videte quantum opus est silentii mei: ipsos vobis sermones amabiliores efficit. Cernite fructum ingloriationis meae: utinam efficiatur talis etiam sermonum utilitas qualis silentii! 4. Quia vero istud[235] placet, et vicistis invincibilem et trophaeum erexistis adversum meam philosophiam, adferte quod adloquar vobis a silentio melius. Adloquar enim non dissolutum aliquid et operimento dignum, ne<c> qui suavis est multis, concentum carminum (nec enim bene respondeo amatoribus meis, sic disputans), sed valde virile atque continuum, et forsitan meliores efficiemini, ad spiritum a carne translati et sufficienter mentibus sublimati. «Filii hominum, usque quo graves corde?» (adsum[m]am enim principium ad vos de magnivoco David); «Ut quid di<li>gitis vanitatem et quaeritis mendacium?», praesentem vitam et delicias et modicam gloriolam et humilem potestatem et fallacem hilaritatem magnum aliquid suspicantes. Quae non[236] minus eorum a quibus habentur non sunt, quam eorum a quibus sperantur, sed nec eorum magis a quibus sperantur quam illorum a quibus nec <ex>spectantur, quae velut pulvis sub turbine ab alio in alios ventilantur atque iactantur vel sicut fumus discurrunt aut sicut somnia inludunt et quemadmodum umbrae non tenentur, quae neque dum absunt disperabilia sunt his a quibus non possidentur, neque dum praesto sunt fidelia his a quibus habentur. 5. Non respiciemus sursum in caelum ad superna modice evigilantes, neque oculorum circumauferimus sordes? Non cognoscimus quae sunt verae divitiae et quae vera claritas et ubi illa, quae numquam decidit,

[232] istos L, *fortasse recte*
[233] honorabilium L, *dubitanter correxi*
[234] magnum *ex* magno L
[235] iste L
[236] non: nos L

dignitas et quae interminabilis felicitas et ubi caeleste bonum quod nec transferri nec dolis subiacere possit? Non consequimur [et consequimur] ista, multis, si ita emerserit, sudoribus atque laboribus? Nequaquam, <si> iam oportet hinc deliciari, deliciemur spebus. Non cognoscimus sanctos martyres et omnes alios qui universum orbem sortiti sunt et eum sicut communia quaedam vincula conligarunt[237] et quorum praesens sol[41r]lemnitas est? Propter quid vulnera et vincula et tormenta et ignis interminationem et aciem gladii et ferarum rabiem et famem et tenebras et profundum et substantiarum rapinas et membrorum amputationes, ad postremum[238] et mortem et omnia prompte sustinuerunt, sicut in alienis corporibus concertantes? Ut quid efficiantur et quid hereditent? An omnibus, etiam si nos taceamus, nota sunt? Numquid non cum eadem spe, sub eodem praemiatore et propositore certaminis contra eundem praeparabimur tyrrannum, amarum et tunc et modo persecutorem animarum, invisibilem inimicum et noxium? Non ergo viriliter agimus, simili modo que<m>admodum in communi theatro, hoc mundo, quamvis non in summo statu periculi positi, cuius etiam adceleratus est exitus, sed in singularum dierum certaminibus et exercitiis, ut aut eisdem aut proximis digni efficiamur coronis?

6. Ego quidem omnibus praecipio, et viro et mulieri, et seni et iuveni, et urbano et rustico, et privato et administranti, diviti et pauperi (etenim id ipsum certamen vocat omnes), ad istud prompte expoliamini et non mollescatis et quasi in futurum differatis tempus, quod iterum invenire impossibile est. Operationis enim praesens tempus est, futurum autem retributionis. «Surgite, eamus hinc», audistis Salvatore nostro dicente, non magis eos qui tunc erant discipulos de Iudaeae loco educens, sed omnes quos postea hinc transmigra<t> et ad se ipsum exaltatum trahit, sicut eius est ipsa promissio. Sequamur bonum Dominum, fugiamus seductorem mundum et mundi rectorem, efficiamur pure eius qui †sancto[239] nos. Honoremus imaginem, revereamur vocationem, communicemus vitam. Quid nos ipsos humiles efficimus, facti sublimes? Quid visibilibus inhaeremus? 7. Unusquisque, prout sibi possibile est, corde fructificet Deo in omni tempore et in omni speci[a]e et in omni vita atque circum[in]stantia[m], secundum mensuram eius, quae unicuique adest, virtutis et secundum datam sibi gratiam, ut omnibus virtutum mensuris omnes quae illic sunt mansiones replere[240] possimus, tantum messuri quantum seminavimus, magis autem tantum in divinis torcularibus[241] reposituri quantum in agro dominico laboramus. Inferat unusquisque quod potest, hic quidem divitias, at[242] ille pauperiem, alius ΠΡΟΘΥΜΕΙΣΘΑΙ, id est promptum devotionis affectum[243], alius ΤΟ ΤΩΝ ΠΡΟΘΥΜΟΥΜΕΝΩΝ, id est ea, quae promptorum sunt, ordinate suscipere, hic laudabilem actionem, ille speculationem perfectam atque optinentem [41v], et ille quidem sinceritatem verbi, ille autem rationabile silentium, ille inculpabilem doctrinam et vitam non contradicentem, ille credulum auditum bonae conscientiae, ille virginitatem castam et se a mundo funditus absci<n>dentem, hic bene rationabiles nuptias et non omnimodo a Deo separantes, hic ieiunium sine typho,[244] ille

[237] conligarunt *dubitanter correxi*: conliciarum L, conlicia<ve>runt *con. Costa*
[238] postremum *ex* postremom L^2
[239] sancto *corruptum: an* sancit? (Gregorius: τοῦ ποιήσαντος)
[240] repleri L
[241] torcolaribus L
[242] ad L
[243] effectum L
[244] tifo L

relaxationem disciplinatam, alius in orationibus continuis et spiritalibus hymnis, alius in patrociniis indigentium,[245] omnes lacrimas, omnes emundationem, omnes ascensum et in his quae anteriora sunt extendi. 8. Bona est et simplicitatis fructificatio et pudicus risus et iracundiae retunsio et visus sub paedagogo constitutus et intellectus qui errare non sinitur. Nihil est sic parvum ex his quae inferuntur Deo, etiam si minimum est, etiam si multum a dignitate inferius, ad quod non accedat omnimodo et suscipiat, etiam si ap<p>endere novit[246] iusto iudicio, misericordiam. Suscepit et Pauli plantationem, sicut Pauli, et Apollinis rigationem, et duo minuta viduae et publicani humiliationem et Manas<s>is totius peccati confessionem. Moyses tabernaculum deorsum configebat secundum caelestis exemplar, et omnes inferebant quod praedic[a]tum erat, aliqui autem et sponte: hic quidem aurum, hic argentum, alius[247] lapides pretiosos in superhumerale; mulierum aliae byssum distortum et filatum coccum, alii purpuram alii pelles arietum rubricatas, aliae id quod vilissimum atque extremum est, caprarum pilos, in opus tabernaculi unumquemque vel unamquamque quod habere contigerat; omnes tamen inferebant et nullus indevotus extitit, etiam pauperrimus. Ita et nos honorabili Dei tabernaculo, huius Ecclesiae, quam fixit Deus et non homo, quae diversis virtutum decoribus aedificatur, qui modicum qui maximum, omnes similiter inferamus in opus perfectum, in domicilium Christi, in templum sanctum, compositi et compaginati per Spiritus operationem. Numquam autem tantum inlaturi sumus quantum accepimus, etiam si omnia inferamus, quia et esse nobis a Deo fuit, et nosse Deum et habere hoc ipsum quod inferamus. Quod autem pulcherrimum et humanissimum est, non dignitate oblationis, sed virtute[248] et dispositione fructificantis incrementa metitur Deus. 9. Non ergo expectes fieri bonus, sed ecce efficere, nec quia dignitas deest, omnia desint, sed aliud quidem infer, ad aliud inferendum esto promptus. Pete de aliis donare veniam infirmitati. «Non apparebis», inquit, «in conspectu meo vacuus»; nemo sit va[42r]cuus neque infructuosus, nulla sterilis anima et sine filiis; unusquisque ex his quae praesto sunt fructificet <et> de propriis Deo: peccator immutationem vitae, bene currens continuationem, iuvenculus abstinentiam, senis prudentiam, dives largitatem, pauper gratiarum actionem, qui in potestatibus sunt, ut sine typho[249] sint, qui in actionibus sunt, mansuetudinem. «Sacerdotes, induamini[250] iustitiam» aut, ut verius loquar, induamur; non dispergamus oves pascuae et corrumpamus, pro quibus animam posuit bonus pastor, qui cognoscit proprias et cognoscitur a propriis, vocans singulas per nomen, qui inducit eas et educit ab infidelitate ad fidem et de vita hac ad eam quae inde est requiem. Timeamus ne a nobis incipiat iudicium secundum interminationem, ne suscipiamus de manu Domini duplicia peccata, nec ipsi ingredientes et alios, qui possunt ingredi, prohibentes. 10. Oves, nolite pascere pastores nec elevemini supra vestros sermones.[251] Sufficit vobis, si bene pascamini; nolite eos, qui sunt iudices, iudicare, nec statuatis legislatoribus leges: non est enim Deus dissensionis et inordinationis, sed pacis et ordinis. Nemo ergo sit caput, vix forte manus aut pes esse sufficiens aut aliquid magis infimorum

[245] indigendum L
[246] movit L
[247] alios L
[248] sed virtute: servitute L
[249] tifo L
[250] intuemini L, *ut vid.*
[251] sermones *ex* sermonem L^2

membrorum corporis, sed unusquisque in quo ordine vocatus est, fratres, in eo permaneat, etiam si sit melioris dignitatis, in eo amplius conlaudandus, quod praesentem amplectitur, quam si illam quaereret quam non accepit. Qui sine periculo[252] sequi potest, praecedere cum periculo non desideret, nec dissolvatur subiectionis lex quae et caelestia continet et quae super terram sunt, nec amputemus principatum multis principibus.[253] Qui in sermone sunt, non valde sermonibus confidant nec superfluis sophismatibus ultra rationem, nec desideretis vincere omnia, etiam male, sed patimini in aliquibus etiam bene vinci. 11. «Contenti estote stipendis vestris, milites», et nihil supra quam quod vobis constitutum est exigatis. Ista vobis praecepit nobiscum Iohannes, magnus veritatis praeco et praecursor Verbi vox. Qui<d> dicens stipendium? Imperiales annonas et sufficientiam, [42v] videlicet donum ex lege dignitatibus datam. Quod autem superest, cuius sit, me quidem, quod blasphemum est, piget dicere, vos autem novi quia intellegitis, etiam si ego parco. «Reddite quae Caesari<s> sunt Caesari et quae Dei sunt Deo»; huic quidem tributum, illi autem timorem; vos, inquam, qui curiae pronomen habetis; timorem quando dico, avaritiam cohibeo. Forte dicitis: quid ergo nos lucrabimus magnum? Aliquid et omnibus melius, si vultis et me mediatore[m] bonas spes, audite, et ea quae prima sunt supernae civitatis, non istius modicae et minimae in civitatibus, cuius, ut mediocriter dicam honorans quemadmodum eam quae me nutrivit,[254] nec principatus satis aliquid venerabile aut praeclarum est. Illuc effici primi velimus, commutemur ad illam, quae ibi est, claritatem, in Abraham sinu pro his, quae hic sunt, visceribus misericordiae requiescamus. Iudicemus iustum iudicium, eripiamus inopem et pauperem, viduae et orphano misereamur, redimamus occidendos et, ut id quod omnino mediocre est dicam, non ipsi occidamus. Non despiciamus supplicantes nobis usque ad mensarum micas; non transcurramus ulceratum et proiectum in nostris ianuis nec deliciemur,[255] aliis in malis passionibus constitutis, neque subsan<n>emus conservum. Nolite, amici, nolite, fratres, non efficiamur in illius divitis partem, nec cruciemur in flamma nec dividamur a sanctis interposito chasmate nec indigeamus Lazari pauperis extremo digito refrigerari ardentem linguam nostram et nec ipsum obtineamus. Efficiamur boni, misericordes, compatientes, imitemur[256] bonitatem Domini, qui oriri facit solem suum super iustos et iniustos et pascit[257] pluvia omnes similiter. Non amplectamur divites effici aliorum inopia nec usque ad hoc decidamus a divina aequalitate nec commisceamus divitias nostras alienis lacrimis, per quas sicut veneno et tinea consumantur aut, ut id quod Scripturae est dicamus, funditus evomuntur. Sed sumus, in[i]quis, super id quod necesse est avidiores? possumus et bene esse cupidi. Demus hinc aliquid modice [43r] ut ibi divites efficiamur.

12. Et ista quidem communia praecepta sunt, non tantum his qui in curia vel militia positi sunt, sed omnibus : communis enim aegritudinis communia sunt etiam medicamenta. Tu autem, censitor omnium quae nostra sunt, cense nos iuste. Cense non meos sermones, diligenter ventilans, in quibus aut nullum aut modicum lucrum est, nisi forte ad auditus gratiam et suavitatem; sed meum populum misericorditer cense et sancte

[252] periculo *ex* periculus L^2
[253] principibus *ex* principatibus L^2
[254] nutribit L
[255] deliciamur L
[256] emitemur L
[257] parcit L, *dubitanter correxi*

reveritus, et si non aliud, vel tempus ipsum, quia et Salvator in discriptione[258] census generatur. «Exiit», enim inquit, «edictum a Caesare Augusto ut describeretur universus orbis», et describebantur.[259] «Ascendit autem et Ioseph in Bethleem cum Maria coniuge sua ut describeretur, propter quod esset de domo et de patria David». Et tunc Salvator gignitur, quod mirum est, omnium conditor et Dominus, in parvo et in vili diversorio. Timeamus mysterium, revereamur dispensationem, et nos in tempore aliquid simul inferamus. Nunc angeli gaudent, nunc pastores splendore circumdantur, nunc stella ab oriente currit ad maius et inaccessibile lumen; nunc Magi adorant et dona offerunt et regem omnium cognoscunt et bene per stellam aestimant eum qui caelestis est; nunc Herodes[260] insanit et infantes necat et propter datorem libertatis interficit eos quos libertatem adipisci oportebat. Efficiamur et nos cum his qui adorant et offeramus ei qui pro nobis pauper factus est usque ad corpus, etiamsi non thus aut aurum aut myrham offerentes, illud quidem ut Deo, hoc autem ut regi, myrham vero quomodo illi qui gustavit pro nobis mortalitatem: [43v] mystica praemia et super id quod apparebant[261] – sed offeramus saltem nihil accipere nec permittere aliquid opibus contra paupertatem, nec praeiudicare ei qui plasmatus est propter eum qui plasmavit.

[44r] 13. Cum Christo distribuis, cum Christo tributum statues,[262] cum capite examinas, cum verbo numeraris. Christus tibi modo nascitur et Deus est et homo fit et cum hominibus conversatur. Quid hinc significante sermone? Sicut mihi videtur, ad ammonitionem eorum qui ista credunt, quia ubi maiores gubernationes sunt, Deus simul semper ingreditur, ut eos qui describunt revereri faciat. Ob hoc autem hominibus et carni conloquitur; ut autem consolaretur nos propter servitutem et ut legem bonae voluntatis instituat (neque enim et hoc despiciendum est) persolvit et ipse didragma nec pro se solum, sed et pro Petro, pretiosissimo discipulorum, quia et homo factus est propter nos et formam <servi>[263] accepit et pro impietatibus nostris perductus ad mortem est. Ista quidem ille, sicut Salvator, qui et sola voluntate, sicut Deus, salvare poterat, quia et omnia praecepto constituit, sed quod maximum et expetibilius est, etiam compassionem nobis introduxit, quasi qui unius honoris simus. Quid autem nos, Christi discipuli, mitis et misericordis[264] et qui tantum nobis sacrificium obtulit? Non imitabimur dominicae viscera misericordiae? Non erimus boni[s] conservis, ut et nos adipiscamur talem circa nos Dominum, me[n]tientem nobis que<m>admodum mensi fuerimus? Non possidebimus animas nostras per mansuetudinem? Sufficit servire liberis et tantum distare ut de eodem pulvere alius[265] quidem dominetur, alius dominationi subiaceat et alius quidem tributum solvat, alius autem describat et illis quidem praeiudicare liceat et malefacere, illi autem timeant et concertentur ne mala patiantur;[266] et haec esse circa unam imaginem unius dignitatis, eiusdem vitae cohaeredes, pro quibus Christus similiter mortuus est. Sufficiant ista liberis, non adgravetur iugum nec primi nostri poena peccati.

[258] discriptione *ex* discriptionem L^2
[259] describebuntur L
[260] herodis L
[261] apparebant *ex* apparebat L^2
[262] statues: *cfr. Gregorii textum* (λογίζῃ)
[263] *add. Costa*
[264] misericordes L
[265] aliud L (*et mox*)
[266] patiuntur L

14. Ut pereat magis malitia et prima eius constitutio et quae dormientibus nobis superseminavit inimicus zizania ut initium mali fieret neglectus boni, quemadmodum et tenebrae lucis recessio. Lignum haec omnia et amarus gustus et invidus serpens et inoboedientia in sudore vultus vivere adiudicata. Hinc nudus ego et foedus et nuditatem agnovi et pellicia tunica circumamictus sum et de Paradiso decidi et in terram conversu[ru]s sum de qua sumptus eram, unum istud pro deliciis habens, mea mala cognoscere, et adiudicatus sum interminabili moerori propter modicam voluptatem et bello[267] adversum illum cum [44v] quo male amicus effectus sum et qui me per gustum supplantavit. Ista sunt praesto malitiae meae; hinc in gemitu[m] generari, hinc vivere et dissolvi; haec mater est necessitatis, necessitas autem avaritiae, avari<ti>a bellorum, bella tributorum patres, tributa vero id quod adiudicationis est gravissimum. Nos autem non extendamus poena<s> nec mali efficiamur aliis, sub ipsa adiudicatione iacentes; humanitatem a nobis eam quae invicem est expetit Deus, etiamsi ab ipso corripimur.

15. Est et alia quaedam inscriptio et alter censitor, <si> quem librum audis vivorum et librum eorum qui salvantur: ibi omnes scribemur,[268] magis autem iam ibi scripti sumus unusquisque secundum dignitatem qua hic conversatus est. Non ibi divitiae plus habent, non paupertas minus, non gratia, non inimicitiae describunt nec aliquid aliud ex omnibus quibus hinc quod iustum est furto rapitur. Digito Dei omnes scripti sumus et aperietur nobis liber in die revelationis; minor et maior ibi sunt et servus simul cum domino suo, ut id quod Iob[269] est loquar, et imperator subiectorum et descriptor descriptorum et claritas in propinquo. Et id quod asperum dicto est, taceo; verum tamen, quomodo scribimus, sic et scribemur. Istam meliorem tibi praepara scripturam, bonus nobis apparens et humanus.

16. Quid ad haec dicis? Quid scribes, amicorum et eorum qui coaetanei sunt, optime, particeps doctorum et disciplinarum, etiamsi nunc in meliori nos parte constituit Deus, ut ista vos in potestate positos[270] erudire possimus? piget enim me dicere graviora.

O piissimae patriae piissimum genus, o sanctorum parentum sacrum germen, o radix filiorum magis <sacrorum>,[271] quemadmodum suscipis meos sermones? Putas, aliquid persuasimus aut maiori praecantatione supplicatio indiget? Et hoc quidem non arbitrari, sed nosse opus est, quia apud te sermones nostri ex <s>uperfluo sunt nec alteri alicui sic fiducialiter loqueremur, quia in ipsis sermonibus, qui te ad bona omnia facillime adducunt, aut praecedentem te aut sequentem habemus. Hoc est enim in quo hii qui sapiente<s> sunt discernuntur a multis. Ego autem modice aliquid his quae dicta sunt addam; tu quidem dedisti mercedem sermonibus meis. Quam[272] iam dedisti, quam autem tibi dant mercedem et repraesentant sermones nostri pauperes? Omnem coronam sacerdotum, coronam philosophorum, nulli vinculo deorsum obligatos, sola possidentium corpora, sed nec ipsa omnimodo; nihil habentes Caesari, sed omnia Deo, hymnos, orationes, vigilias, lacrimas, possessionem quae non tenetur, mori mundo, vivere Christo, evacuare carnem, animam [45r] a corpore abstrahere. Istis parcens aut

[267] bellum L
[268] scribamur L
[269] Σολομῶντος *Gregorius memoria lapsus (cfr. enim Iob 3:19)*
[270] possitor L
[271] *ex Gregorii verbis* (ῥίζα τέκνων ἱερωτέρων) *ita supplevimus*
[272] quam: quem L (*num ex* μισθός *masculini generis?*)

etiam mundos[273] reddens Deo divinos ministros et secretarios et caelestium speculatores, primitivam generis nostri praelibationem, coronas terrae, margaritas pretiosas, templi lapides, cuius fundamentum et angularis lapis Christus, bonae huius Ecclesiae plenitudinis dico, id quod optimum est et istis et tibi ipsi et nobis omnibus consules. Sed et tibi quid oro? Tales per nos effici magis divitias quam multos auri atque argenti thesauros, qui nunc adsunt, post modicum futuri non sunt. 17. Ista vobis est sermonum meorum fructificatio, etiam si ab spe minor, secundum meam tamen virtutem sufficiens. Vos autem reddite[274] mihi ab his, quae a me inlata sunt maiora, bene suadibilem animum vestrum et quatenus inter alia etiam minus meis indigeatis sermonibus, vosmetipsos invicem circuminspicite ad incitamentum caritatis et bonorum operum, ut bonam et misericordem, quae illuc est, conscriptionem adipiscentes et circa omnium principem ducentes choros, ea quae solum his, qui illic scripti sunt, operatio est, oblationem offeramus Deo, unam Patris et Filii et Spiritus Sancti et aspicientes et exaltantes deitatis gloriam et claritatem, quia ipsi gloria et honor et adoratio in saecula saeculorum, amen. Explicit.

[45r] EPISTOLA BEATI GREGORII NAZIANZENI AD CLEDONIUM PRIMA

1. Quoniam multi accedentes ad tuam venerationem satisfactionem fidei quaerunt, et propter hoc adfectiose a nobis expetisti[275] compendiosam aliquam definitionem et regulam nostrae sententiae, ideo[que] scripsimus tuae venerationi id quod et ante epistolas cognitum habebas, quia nos Nichenae[t] fidei[276] sanctorum Patrum, qui ibi congregati sunt ad amputationem Arrianae haereseos, nihil proposuimus[277] aliquando neque proponere possumus, 2. sed illius sumus fidele<s> et erimus Deo propiti[ati]o, adiungentes id quod ab illis de Sancto Spiritu omissum est, ob hoc videlicet, quia nec mota huiuscemodi quaestio ipso tempore fuerat, quia unius deitatis credere nos oportet Patrem et Filium et Spiritum Sanctum, Deum etiam Spiritum agnoscentes. 3. Qui ergo ita sapiunt et docent, habeto communicatores, sicut et nos; qui autem aliter habent, aversare et alienos existima a Deo et a catholica Ecclesia. 4. Quia vero de divina inhumanatione sive incarnatione movetur aliqua quaestio, hoc omnibus doce[278] de nobis, quia Filium Dei natum ex Patre et postea de sancta Virgine[279] Maria in unum adducimus, et non duo nominamus filios, sed unum eundemque indivi[45v]sibili deitate et honore adorandum. Si quis autem non consentit istis vel modo vel postea, ipse reddid<er>it rationem Deo in die iudicii. 5. Et haec quidem est atque ita se habet ad [d]eam, quae sine intellectu est, eorum de intellectu opinio, nostra in brevi intentio atque oppositio: soli enim propemodum quod dogmatizant vere et patiuntur, intellectum sine intellectu concidentes.

[273] mundus L, *ut vid.*
[274] *ex* reddidite L^2
[275] expedisti L
[276] fides L
[277] proposuimus *ex* porposuimus L^2
[278] doce: decere L
[279] virgine *ex* virginem L

6. Ne autem detrahant de nobis, quasi dilectissimi Vitalis fidem, quam expetitus a beato Damaso, Romanae civitatis episcopo, in scriptis dedit, primum quidem susciperemus, modo autem abnuamus, et de hoc brevis sermo reddendus[280] est. 7. Isti enim quando familiaribus et secretariis suis discipulis de ineffabilibus Dei loquuntur, quamadmodum Manichaei his quos electos vocant, omnem langorem suum discooperiunt et vix carnem Salvatori concedunt; 8. quando autem communibus de inhumanatione opinionibus, quas Scriptura repraesentat, redarguuntur et capiuntur, pias quidem locutiones confitentur, <de> intellectu autem maligne operantur, 9. nec inanimatum quidem nec inrationabilem nec sine intellectu nec imperfectum confitentes hominem, animam autem et rationem et intellectum ipsam introducentes deitatem, quasi ipsa sola carni contemperata sit, non autem et intellectui nostro, id est humano, etiam si id quod sine peccato est melius sit a nobis et nostrarum purgatio passionum. 10. Sic ergo et illud: «Nos autem sensum Christi habemus» aliter interpretantur, male et omnino sibi consuete, sensum Christi deitatem dicentes, et non, sicut nos, arbitrantes quia qui proprium intellectum emundant ad imitationem illius intellectus quem pro nobis Salvator suscepit et ad ipsum se, prout possibile est, coaptant, isti sensum Christi habere dicuntur; 11. quomodo et carnem Christi testificari oportet habere eos, qui in disciplina carnem redigentes, secundum hoc concorporales et comparticipes facti sunt Christi, ut «sicut portavimus imaginem terreni, sic portemus imaginem eius qui de caelo est». Quomodo autem et perfectus illis homo est, non temptatus per omnia quae nostra sunt praeter peccatum? Sed hoc quod dicitur, ex Deo et carne comparatio dogmatizatur. Hoc enim, inquiunt, quid perfectius? 12. Id ipsum autem, et de ea voce quae dicitur, "inhumanari", maligne operantur, inhumanari non in homine fieri, quem ipse sibi circum fixit, exponentes, secundum id quod dictum est: «Ipse enim sciebat quid esset in homine», sed hominibus conlocutum et conver[46r]satum esse dicentes et docentes et ad illam refugientes vocem, quae dicit: «Post hoc super terram visus est et cum hominibus conversatus est». 13. Et quid contendat quis amplius, quando et hominem destruentes et interiorem imaginem, id quod exterius nostrum est et per vacuam, quae vide[n]tur, personam, solummodo emundant? 14. In tantum autem sibi ipsi repugnantes sunt, ut aliquando quidem propter carnem et reliqua crasse et carnaliter exponant. Hinc enim eis secundus iudaismus exoritur et stultae mille annorum in Paradiso deliciae et propemodum eadem ipsa iterum in isdem ipsis praesumere nos; aliquando autem putativam, magis quam veram, carnem introducunt, ac si nihil nostrum pertulerit nec quaecumque peccati sunt libera, 15. ad hoc utentes apostolica voce, non apostolice intelligentes, quae dicit in similitudine hominum Salvatorem nostrum factum et habitu inventum ut hominem, quasi non in istis humana species significetur vel intellegatur, phantasia autem magis et putativa sit[281] seductio.

16. Quia ergo eaedem ipsae voces, bene quidem intellectae piae sunt, male autem interpretatae impietatem habent, quid mirum si et dilectissimi Vitalis verba nos quidem secundum id quod ad pietatem est suscepimus, ita eos qui cupiunt persuadentes,[282] alii autem ad intellectum eorum quae scripta sunt exasperantur? 17. Quod mihi videtur etiam Damasus ipse postea edoctus, et in prioribus eos expositionibus permanere agnoscens, mox eos impraedicabiles fecit et conscriptionem fidei ipsius in anathema esse

[280] reddendum L
[281] putatiba sit *ex* putati basit L^2
[282] ita eos … persuadentes: οὕτω τοῦ θέλειν πείθοντος *Gregorius*

constituit, exasperatus erga ipsam eorum subreptionem, quam pertulit ex simplicitate. 18. Istis ergo manifeste redarguti, non asper<i> sint nobis, sed erubescant, nec mentiantur[283] adversum nos, sed perficiantur, et deleant de ianuis suis magnam illam et admirabilem scripturam et praedicationem orthodoxiae suae, mox cum inquisitione et discri<p>tione occurrentes eis[284] qui ingrediuntur: «oportet», inquiunt, «adorare non deiferum hominem, sed Deum carniferum». 19. Quid autem his erit inrationabilius? Etiam si dictum magnificent nobis veritatis praedicatores, quod quidem aliquam sophismatis <gratiam> habet conversionis ipsius velocitas et numerosae ratiocinationis[285] prodigium, ineruditos oblectans. Est autem risibilium omnium risibilius et immoderatorum [46v] immoderatius. 20. Si quis commutans[286] "hominis" vocem et "carnis" in Deo, ex quibus aliud nobis placet, aliud autem illis, et postea admirabili conversione ista et Deo cognita utatur,[287] quid collegitur? Oportere adorari non carnem deiferam, sed Deum hominiferum. 21. Inordinationis occultissima post Deum sapientiae hodie adnuntiant, supra quod et lacrimari dignum est. 22. Si enim ante triginta istos annos fides coepit, quadragentis fere exemptis annis quo Christus ostensus est, inane est tanti temporis evangelium nostrum, inanis et fides nostra, 23. inaniter autem et martyres martyrizaverunt, inaniter et populis praefuerunt tales ac tanti patroni, et erit carminum[288] gratia, non fides. 24. Quis autem non adducat[289] eos ab eruditione, cum manifeste ipsi ea quae Christi sunt dividant, et id[290] quidem quod natus est et quod temptatus et quod esurivit et quod sitivit, laboravit et dormitavit, humanitati applicent, 25. id autem quod ab angelis glorificatus est et quod temptatorem evicit et populum pavit in heremo, sed et quod supra mare ambulavit, 26. deitati ascribunt? Sed et illud: «ubi posuistis Lazarum?» nostrum esse dicunt, «Lazare» autem «veni foras» exclamare et quatriduanum mortuum resuscitare, supra nos; 27. id quoque, quod in agonia fuit, et crucifixus est et sepultus, velaminis esse, id autem quod audacter et resurrexit et ascendit, occultae potestatis. 28. Et post haec detrahunt nobis, quasi duas naturas separatas et compugnantes introducentibus et quasi partientibus admirabilem et ultra naturam divinam [m]unitionem. 29. Oporteret autem aut non facere quod accusant, aut non accusare quod faciunt, <si> sibi ipsis saltem consequentes debere esse cognoscerent. 30. Nam et propria[291] dicere et contrariorum, inrationabilitas eorum est qui, veritatem impugnare volentes, nec quia in semetipsos impingunt aut intellegunt aut erubescunt. 31. Si qui vero arbitrantur ista nos sponte aut scribere aut dicere et non tyrannice compulsos, aut contra unitatem nos studere et non magis ad eam omni modo festinare, maligne sapiunt, nec intuentur desiderium nostrum, 32. quibus nihil est aut fuit honorabilius pace, quomodo ipsae saltem suadent res †quas faciunt iuveniter[292] adversum nos intercludentes omnimodis concordiam. Amen.

[283] *post* mentiantur *rasura in* L
[284] eis *ex* ei L^2
[285] numeros veratio cinationis L
[286] commutans *suprascr*. L^2
[287] notatur L
[288] *ex* carnimum L^2
[289] adducat: ἀγάσαιτο *Gregorius; verbum* ἄγαμαι *ex* ἄγω *intellectum*
[290] ad L
[291] proprios L
[292] iuvenitur L

EXPLICIT EPISTULA BEATI GREGORI NAZIANZENI
AD CLEDONIUM PRIMA.
[47r] EPISTULA[293]

1. Vellemus addiscere quae sit haec nova erga Ecclesiam adinventio, ut liceat omni volenti et pertranseunti, secundum quod scriptum est, 2. dispergere gregem bene congregatum et furtiv[a]e congregare rapacibus supervenientibus, magis autem latrocinantibus et inrationabilibus doctrinis. 3. Si enim habebant aliquid in quo reprehenderent nos circa fidem, qui nunc supervenerunt, neque tunc praeter commonitionem nostram oportuit ista praesumere. 4. Suadere enim opus erat aut suaderi (si aliquis et noster sermo esset, sicut Deum timentium, et qui laboraverint pro verbo et qui aliquid Ecclesiae profuerint), et tunc, si revera opus esset, nova adinvenirent, quamvis et satisfactio aliqua esse posset forsitan iniuriosis. 5. Quia vero et in scriptis et praeter scripturam et hic et longius et cum periculo et sine periculo fides[294] nostra praedicata est, quomodo hi[c] quidem praesumunt talia, alii autem quiescunt? 6. Nec dicunt aliqui iniquum esse certe quod iniquum est, aut propriam vanam gloriam homines simplicioribus animis per maligniores reponunt, sed quia et de nobis mentiuntur, quasi similia sentientibus et similia sapientibus, 7. velut hamo escam superponentes et tali adornatu male suam voluntatem adimplentes, ac nostram simplicitatem, per quam eos fraterne attendimus et non alienos existimamus, malitiae subreptionem facientes; 8. non solum autem, sed et ab occidentali synodo susceptos se esse dicunt, quemadmodum percontantes didicimus, a qua primum erant adiudicati, sicut omnibus manifestum est. 9. Si ergo suscepti sunt, aut modo aut primum, ea quae Apollinaris sunt sapientes, hoc ostendant, et nos amplectimus: manifeste enim quia recto dogmati consentientes suscepti sunt, neque enim possibile erat aliter, si hoc adsecuti sunt. 10. Ostendant ergo omni modo aut per synodicum tomum aut communicatoriis litteris: ista enim est synodorum lex, 11. Si autem sermo hoc atque confictio est, ob decorem ac persuasionem quae ad multos adinventa est propter dignas fide personas, disce illos quiescere, et redargue:[295] tuae enim conversationi et orthodoxiae hoc arbitror convenire.

12. Non seducant homines neque seducantur, hominem sine intellectu suscipientes dominicum, sicut ipsi dicunt, magis autem Dominum nostrum et Deum: 13. neque enim hominem separamus a deitate,[296] sed unum eundemque dogmatizamus. Primum quidem non hominem, sed Deum [47v] et Filium solum, eum qui ante saecula est, inmixtum[297] corpori et quaecumque sunt corporis, 14. in novissimis autem et hominem adsumptum propter nostram salutem, passibilem deitate, carne impassibile<m>, circumscriptum corpore, incircumscriptum spiritu, 15. eundem terrenum et caelestem, visibilem et intelligibilem, capabilem et incapabilem, ut toto homine[m], eodem ipso et Deo, totus homo reformaretur qui ceciderat sub peccato.

16. Si quis non Dei genitricem Mariam suspicatur, extra deitatem est. Si quis quasi per fistulam cucurrisse[t] per Virginem, et non magis in ipsa plasmatum esse dicit, divin[a]e atque human[a]e (divine quidem, quia sine viro, humane autem, quia simili

[293] *titulus: post* Epistula *add. L² in rasura:* non scribatur: non est Gregorii Nazianzeni
[294] fides *ex* fide L^2
[295] reddar zuae L
[296] *ex* deitatem *corr.* L^2
[297] in quo L, ἀμιγῆ *Gregorii textus,* in- *negativo sensu.*

conceptus lege), similiter sine Deo est. 17. Si quis primum plasmatum hominem et tunc indutum esse Deum dicit, adiudicatus est: neque enim nativitas Dei istud est, sed fuga nativitatis. 18. Si quis introducit duos filios, unum quidem eum qui ex Deo et Patre est, secundum autem eum qui ex virgine, et non unum eundemque, et ab adoptione decidat, quae promissa est recta credentibus. 19. Naturae enim duae, Deus et homo, quia et anima et corpus, filii autem non duo neque dii: neque enim hic duo homines, quamvis Paulus et quod interius et quod exterius est hominis sic appellaverit. 20. Et si necesse est compendio dicere, aliud quidem et aliud ea ex quibus Salvator est (neque enim idem est invisibile visibili et intemporali id quod sub tempore est), non autem alius et alius: absit! 21. Utraque enim unum contemperatione, Deo quidem inhumanato, homine autem deificato vel quomodo quis nominare vult. Dico autem aliud et aliud dissimiliter quam in Trinitate se habet: ibi enim alius et alius ut non subsistentias confundamus, non autem aliud et aliud: unum enim tria, et id ipsum deitate.

22. V.[298] Si quis quemadmodum [in] propheta dicit «secundum gratiam» ΕΝΗΡΓΗΚΗΝΑΙ (id est operatum esse) et non secundum essentiam coniunctum et complasmatum esse, sit vacuus melioris operationis, magis autem plenus contrariae.

VI. Si quis non adorat crucifixum, anathema sit et adnumeretur[299] cum Dei interfectoribus.

23. VII. Si quis ex operibus perfectum esse et aut post baptismum aut post resurrectionem a mortuis adoptionem meruisse dicit, secundum eos quos pagani adscriptos introducunt, anathema sit. 24. Quod enim elevatur aut proficit aut perficitur, non est Deus, etsi propter eam, quae paulatim facta est, [48r] ostensionem sic dicitur.

25. VIII. Si quis deposuisse nunc carnem dicit et nudam esse deitatem corpore et non cum adsumptione et esse et venturam[300] esse, non videa[n]t gloriam praesentiae eius: 26. ubi enim corpus nunc, si <non> cum eo qui illud suscepit? Neque enim secundum Manichaeorum stultos in sole repositum est, ut honorificetur per contumeliam, 27. aut in aerem effusum est et dissolutum, sicut natura vocis et odoris exhalatio aut coruscationis cursus[301] non permanens. 28. Ubi autem est et quod palpatus est post resurrectionem aut quod videndus est aliquando ab his a quibus confixus est? Deitas enim per se ipsa invisibilis est, 29. sed veniet quidem cum corpore, secundum meam rationem, talis autem qualis visus est discipulis in monte aut demonstratus est, supervincente id quod carnale est deitate. Quomodo autem ista dicimus destruentes suspicionem, sic ad illa conscribimus emendantes novam adinventionem.

30. VIIII. Si quis dicit carnem de caelo discendisse et non hinc esse et ex nobis, anathema sit. Illud enim quia «secundus homo de caelo» et «qualis supercaelestis, tales et supercaelestes», et «nemo ascendit in caelum, nisi qui de caelo discendit, filius hominis», et si quid aliud huiuscemodi est, propter eam quae ad caelestem est unitionem aestimandum est dici, 31. quomodo et illud, quia «per Christum facta sunt omnia» et «habitare Christum in cordibus nostris», non secundum id quod [in]visibile est Dei, sed secundum id quod intelligibile, contemperatis quemadmodum naturis, ita et appellationibus, et capacibus[302] ininvicem consertionis ratione.

[298] *anathematismatum capita hinc tantum incipiunt*
[299] *ex* annum eretur *corr.* L^2
[300] vetutum L
[301] *ex* curtius *corr.* L^2
[302] capatibus L

32. X. Si quis in eum qui sine mente est hominem speravit, certissime sine intellectu est et omni modo indignus salvari. Quod enim adsumptum non est, curatum non est, quod autem unitum est Deo, hoc et salvatur.[303] 33. Si medius[304] peccavit[305] Adam, dimidium est et quod adsumptum est et quod salvatur: si autem totus, omni generato unitus est, totus salvatur. Non ergo adfascinent in nobis plenam salutem necossa solum et nervos et picturam[306] hominis Salvatori circumponant: 34. si enim exanimis homo, hoc et Arriani dicunt, ut super deitatem passionem adducant, sicut illo patiente a quo movetur et corpus. Si autem animatus, siquidem sine intellectu, quomodo est homo? Neque enim animal sine intellectu est homo, 35. et necesse est schema quidem humanum esse et tabernaculum, animam autem caballi alicuius aut bovis aut alterius eorum, qui sine intellectu sunt. Hoc ergo est et quod salvatur, et seductus sum ego a veritate, altero hono[46v]rificato al[i]ter glorians. Si autem intellectualis et non sine intellectu homo, desinant vere sine intellectu esse. 36. Sed sufficiebat, inquit, deitas pro intellectu. Quid ergo ad me istud? Deitas enim cum sola carne non est homo, sed nec cum sola anima nec cum utroque praeter intellectu<m>, quod et magis est homo. Custodi ergo totum hominem et uni deitati, ut me perfecte beneficet. 37. Sed non capiebat, inquit, duo perfecta. Revera, si corporaliter intueris: vas enim modiorum quattuor octo modios non capit, neque enim unius corporis locus duo aut plura corpora capit. 38. Si autem, ut intellegibilia et ut incorporea intueris, vide quia et animae et rationis et sensus et Spiritus Sancti ego ipse capax sum, et ante me et Patris et Filii et Spiritus Sancti mundus iste, collectionem dico visibilium et invisibilium. 39. Talis enim est intelligibilium natura, incorporee[307] atque indivis[a]e et invicem et corporibus misceri, quia et vocum multarum auditus unus capax est, et multarum facierum idem visus, et ea quae odorum sunt, odoratus, neque sensibus abinvicem angustatis aut vi espressis neque sensibilibus imminutis multitudine susceptionis.

40. Qualis autem est perfectio intellectus hominis vel angeli ad comparationem deitatis, ut aliud vi exprimatur praesentia potioris? Neque enim splendor aliquis ad solem neque ros modicum ad fluvium, ut ante quae minora sunt amputemus, domus quidem splendorem, terrae autem ros, et sic capi possint maiora et perfectiora. 41. Quomodo enim capiunt duo perfecta, domus quidem splendorem et solem, terra autem rorem et fluvium, istud pertractemus. Est enim causa multa cogitatione digna. 42. Aut ignorant quia id quod ad[308] aliquid perfectum est ad aliud imperfectum est, quemadmodum collis ad montem et granum sinapis ad fabam, aut sicut aliud maiorum seminum et eiusdem generis maius dicitur, si autem vis, et angelus ad Deum et ad angelum homo? 43. Perfectus ergo et noster intellectus et principale animae atque corporis, sed non simpliciter. Perfectus Dei autem famulus et subiectus nec simul cum Deo regens, nec similis honoris, 44. quia et Moyses Pharaoni quidem deus, Dei autem famulus, quemadmodum scriptum est. Et stellae[309] quidem nocte resplendent, in sole autem absconduntur, ita ut ne si sint quidem in die agnoscantur, 45. et lampas modica maiori foco adiuncta neque

[303] salvator L (*et mox*)
[304] *ex* melius *corr.* L^2
[305] *ex* peccavi *corr.* L^2
[306] *ex* figturam *corr.* L^2
[307] incorporea L
[308] aut L
[309] et stellae *ex* est et stellae *corr.* L^2

perit neque apparet nec separatur, sed totum est ignis magnus et vincente[310] id quod eminens est.

46. Sed adiudicatus est, inquit, noster intellectus. Quid autem? Caro adiudicata [49r] non est? Aut et istam distrue propter peccatum aut et illum adiunge propter salvationem. Si quod deterius est adsumptum est ut santificaretur propter incarnationem, quod potius est non simul adsumetur ut santificaretur propter inhumanatione<m>? Si lutum fermentatum est et «nova consparsio» facti sumus, o[s] sapientes, imago non fermentabitur et ad Deum admiscetur deificata per deitatem? 47. Et illud adiciamus, si spretus est omnimode[311] intellectus, quomodo peccator, et adiudicatus, et propter hoc corpus quidem adsumptum est, intellectus autem relictus, ignoscendum est his qui offendunt in intellectu. Testificatio enim Dei manifeste ostendit curationis impossibilitatem. 48. Dicam amplius: tu quidem propter hoc exhonoras, o optime, meum intellectum, sic ut cultor carnis (siquidem ego cultor hominis), ut co<n>liges Deum ad carnem, quomodo qui non aliter conligari posset, et propter hoc amputas medium parietem. 49. Mea autem ratio quae est, insipientis et indisciplinati?[312] Intellectus intellectui adiungitur, quomodo viciniori et magis domestico, et per hunc carni, mediante meo intellectu deitati et grossedini.

50. Quae autem eis sit ratio inhumanationis videmus, sive incarnationis, sicut ipsi dicunt.

Siquidem, ut possit capi Deus, aliter incapabilis existens, et quasi sub velamento carnis hominibus loqueretur, bellulum eorum † cariteum[313] est et comoedia fictionis, ut non dicam quia et aliter loqui eum nobis possibile erat, sicut in rubo ignis et in humano aspectu, sicut primum. 51. Si autem ut adiudicationem peccati solvere<t>, simile simili sanctificans, quomodo carne indiguit propter carnem, quae adiudicata est, et anima propter animam, sic et intellectu propter intellectum, non solum offendentem in Adam, sed et qui primus pertulerit quod medici dicunt in infirmitatibus. 52. Quod enim mandatum accepit, hoc et mandatum non custodiit; quod autem non custodiit, hoc et praevaricare praesumpsit; quod autem transgressum est, hoc et salutem magis indiguit; quod autem salutem indiguit, hoc et adsumptum est. Intellectum ergo adsumptum esse nunc ostensum est, 53. etsi non volunt, geometricis (sicut dicunt) necessitatibus et probationibus. Tu autem facis simile aliquid velut si, oculo hominis offendente, pedem quidem curares, oculum vero incuratum relinqueres, aut pictore aliquid non bene pingente[m], id quidem quod pictum esset immutares, [49v] pictorem autem quasi corrigentem praetermit<t>eres. 54. Si autem ab istis cogitationibus expulsi, ad illud confugiunt, possibile esse Deo et praeter intellectum salvare hominem, possibile quoque erat et praeter carnem sola voluntate, quem ad modum et alia omnia operatur et operatus est, incorporalis utique, et misereri cum intellectu etiam carni, ut sit tua perfecta dementia. 55. Sed seducuntur a littera et propter hoc carni adcurrunt, consuetudinem Scripturae ignorantes; nos autem eos et istud doceamus.

56. Quia vero ubique in Scripturis et homo et filius hominis appellatur, quid necesse est scientibus dicere? Si vero pertinaciter[314] adfirmant, dicentes: «Verbum caro factum

[310] τοῦ ὑπερέχοντος ἐκνικήσαντος *Gregorius*
[311] omni modis L
[312] *ex* indisciplinato *corr.* L^2
[313] *verbum corruptum, ex glossemate* (χαρίεν τι) *ortum, ut videtur;* κομψὸν τὸ προσωπεῖον *Gregorius*
[314] pertinatiter L

est et habitavit in nobis» et propter hoc circumradent id quod optimum est hominis, quemadmodum coriarii crassiora[315] pellium, ut Deum carni conglutinent, 57. adtendant dicere[316] ibi posse et carnium solum[317] modo Deum esse Deum, non et animarum, quemadmodum scriptum est: «Sicut dedisti ei potestem omnis carnis» et: «Ad te omnis caro veniet» et: «Benedicat omnis caro nomen sanctum eius», id est omnis homo; 58. aut iterum incorporeos et invisibiles discendisse patres nostros in Aegypto et animam Ioseph solam alligatam esse a Pharaone, propter quod scriptum est: «In septuaginta quinque animabus descendisse eos in Aegypto» et: «Ferrum», inquit, «pertransivit[318] anima eius», res quae ligari non poterat. 59. Ignorant enim qui ista dicunt quia modo synecdochis ista nominantur, a parte totum significante, sicut: «Pulli corvorum invocant Deum», ut volatilis significetur natura, et Pliades et Esperus et Arturus[319] commemorantur pro omnibus sideribus et eam quae erga ipsa est dispensationem, 60. praesertim cum non aliter arbitrantur Dei in nobis manifestari dilectionem, nisi commemoratione[m] carnis et quia propter nos usque ad deteriora descendit: carnem enim animae contemtibiliorem esse omnis bene sapiens confitebitur. 61. «Verbum» ergo «caro factum est» talem mihi videtur habere virtutem qualem[320] et illud quod et peccatum factus esse dicitur et maledictum, non in istis Deo commutato: quomodo enim aliter, nisi quia ista suscepit, iniquitates nostras ipse acciperet et infirmitates nostras ipse portaret? 62. Et haec quidem sufficienter quantum ad praesens dicta sint, propter hoc, quia et manifesta sunt et multis facile[s] susceptibilia. Neque enim libros componere volentes, sed seductionem compescere, ista scribimus, perfectiorem[321] autem ex his sermonem, si placet, et longiorem dabimus.

63. Sed nec illud omitti[t] necesse est, quod istis[322] gravius est. «Utinam et absci<n>dantur qui vos conturbant» et secundum[323] Iudaismum et secundam[324] circumcisionem et secunda sacrificia introducunt. 64. Si enim ista, quid prohibet iterum nasci Christum, ut haec inrita fiant, et tradi iterum a Iuda et crucifigi et sepeliri et resurgere, ut compleantur omnia secundum eandem consequentiam et secundum paganorum revolutionem eandem, ipsa circumferentem isdem astrorum motibus? 65. Quis enim finis, aliqua quidem fieri de his quae tunc emerserunt, aliqua autem seponi? Ista doceant sapientes et hi qui propter codicum multitudinem honorantur. 66. Quia vero de Trinitatis ratione inflati mentiuntur de nobis, quasi non sanam habentibus fidem, et seducunt[325] multos, illud cognosci necesse est, quia Apollinaris deitatis quidem nomen Spiritui Sancto dans, virtutem deitatis non servavit. 67. Ex magno enim et fortiori et maximo consistere Trinitatem, quemadmodum ex splendore, radio et sole, Spiritus et Filii et Patris, sicut manifeste in eius libris scriptum est, scala[326] est deitatis, non in coelum elevans, sed

[315] grassiora L
[316] dices L
[317] solam L
[318] pertransibit L
[319] *ex* tarturus L^2
[320] *ex* quale L^2
[321] perfectionem L
[322] *ex* isti L^2
[323] *ex* secundus L^2
[324] secundum L
[325] seducant L
[326] scala *ex emend.* L^2

de coelo deducens. 68. Nos autem Deum cognoscimus Patrem et Filium et Sanctum Spiritum, haec autem non puras[327] appellationes,[328] concidentes honorum aut virtutum inaequalitatem, sed unam eandemque,[329] sicut appellationem, sic et deitatis naturam et essentiam et virtutem.

69. Si quis autem ista quidem recte dici arbitratur, arguit vero haereticam communionem, ostendat quis istud[330] nostrum fecit, et aut persuadeamus aut discedamus. Ante iudicium autem nec aliud aliquid noviter adinveniri firmum est, ne dicam rem tantam et de talibus. 70. Nos ergo de his et protestati sumus Deum atque hominem et protestamur, neque nunc, sicut bene nosti, ista forsitan scriberemus, nisi videremus Ecclesiam dissipari et concidi et aliis quidem blandimentis, sed et nunc «consilio vanitatis». 71. Si autem aliquis, nobis ista dicentibus et protestantibus, aut propter utilitatem aliquam quis aut propter humanum[331] timorem aut propter pusillanimitatem[332] inordinatam aut propter quia pastor et gubernator non est aut propter peregrinorum gratiam et novarum adinventionem apparatum, 72. respuit quidem nos sicut nullius momenti dignos, accurrit autem ad huiuscemodi et dividit bonum corpus Ecclesiae, [50v] portabit[333] ipse iudicium, quicumque est ille, et reddet Deo rationem in die iudicii. 73. Si autem maiores libri et nova[334] psalteria et contra David canentia et metrorum gratia tertium testamentum esse creditur,[335] et nos componamus psalmos et multa scribamus, faciamus et carmina. Arbitramur enim et nos Spiritum Dei habere, si Spiritus gratia est istud et non hominum nova adinventio. 74. Ista te volumus protestari multis, ut non adgravemur, sicut qui talia mala despicimus[336] et per nostrum taedium iniquum dogma et pascua et virtutem accipiat.

Explicit epistula beati Gregori Nazianzeni ad Cledonium secunda.[337]

[50v] BEATI GREGORII NAZIANZENI AD VIRGINEM

Virgo sponsa Christi, glorifica tu<u>m sponsum semper. Munda temet ipsam in verbis et sapientia, ut splendidior splendidis convivas in aeternum. Verior enim ista multo[338] a corruptibili coniunctione. Intellectuales in corpore virtutes imitata es; ad angelicam translata es super terram conversationem. Et legatio et solutio corporalis et corporum est, sursum autem unaquaeque unitas indissolubilis, qui primi[339] sustinent radium mundissimae Trinitatis, spiritus et ignis, † terminata sunt Dei praeceptionibus. Semper autem effluens natura materiae commixtionem invenit, cui mensuram Deus

[327] puras: patras L, putas L^2
[328] appellationem L
[329] eandem quae L
[330] *ex* istum L^2
[331] *ex* humanam L^2
[332] pusilli animitatem L
[333] portavit L
[334] nova *ex* natu a (*ut vid.*) L^2
[335] creditor L
[336] despitimus L
[337] *post subscriptionem add.*: mentitur: non est eius L^2
[338] ista multo *ex* istam ulto L^2
[339] primi (οἱ πρώτοι) *correximus*: prium L, primum L^2

legem statuit nuptiarum; tu autem opus materiae fugiens, superioribus coapta te, quemadmodum mens aptatur menti divinae concentus, et carni repugnans adiuvas imaginem. Flatu enim creata es Dei, etiam deteriori colligata, ut luctaminis et victoriae coronam possis accipere, sursum ponens mentem bene subiectam[340] spiritui. Proponantur tibi et <nuptiae et> quae ante nuptias et incorruptio; nuptiae indulgentia passionis, castitas[341] autem splendor; nuptiae parentes sanctorum, castitas autem ante indulgentiam passionis. Congruis sunt quidam honorati temporibus: Adam in Paradiso, Moyses legem rectitudinis ponens, Zacharias praecursori<s> pater. Nuptiae et virginitatis radix Dei sponsae, sed est tamen cooperimento carnis servitus. Quando erat lex et umbra et temporales Dei culturae, tunc habebant primatum et nuptiae, quemadmodum adhuc parabolae. Quando autem explosa est littera et subintroductus spiritus et Christus pertulit carnem, procedens ex virgine, tunc resplenduit castitas, adbrevians mundum; solum ibi transmutari oportet cum Christo ascendentibus. Bene [51r] iter agens, virgo, in monte salvam te fac; non ad Sodomam converteris,[342] ne congelascas in statuam salis; non valde teneat te carnis natura, nec multum rursum praesumas, ut possis aliquando dissolvi. Scintilla accendit cannetum, extinguit autem flammas aqua: habe[n]s multa medicamina pudicae verginitatis; timor Dei te corroboret, ieiunia evacuent, congruae atque aptae vigiliae, lacrimae, cubile terrenum; amor tibi sit ratio vigilans, ad Deum apte disposita et obdormiscere faciens amorem alienum. Sursum, qui corruit, elevetur; tu autem bene naviga, vela spei expandens. Non eorum qui deorsum sunt, qui decidunt, sed eorum qui sursum[343] feruntur, ad quod reliquorum quidem pennae defluunt, multi autem prospere percurrunt. Cecidit Lucifer, sed non homo: angelus autem erat; Iudas traditor fuit, undecim autem luminaria. Totam te solummodo castam custodi[t], virgo, ne coinquines immaculatam Dei tunicam. Pudicus obtutus, virginalis sit tibi lingua; ne mens fornicans, ne petulans risus, ne pedum inordinatus incessus; magis in te revereor laboriosam vestem et siccam atque squalidam comam, quam gemmarum et sericae[344] vestis ornatum bonum. Flos verecundia et magnus decor est pallor. Magnam sic quaedam[345] coronam plectunt universae virtutis. Adulterent aliae[346] coloribus imaginem quam ex Deo habent; animata haec et depicta imago horribilis est rerum[347] praesentium accusatrix. Tibi vero etiam[348] quam habes pulchritudinem multum mortificari necesse est, splendifica autem pulchritudinem animae a Deo adornatae. Faciem virorum fuge, si possibile est, etiam castorum, necubi vulnereris vel ictu[s] sagittae.[349] Non des oculos oculis neque protrahas verbis verba nec genis ad genas fiduciam praestes. Nihil tibi et gusto ligni adiudicati[o], ne a vita te serpens foras emittat. Illud etiam tibi persuadere necesse est, virgo, ne cui commaneas, quasi patrono, Christum habens sponsum: zelatur etenim tuam castitatem. Quid mihi carnem fugienti ad carnem iterum retorqueri? Non

[340] subiectam *ex* coniectam L^2
[341] castitate L
[342] converteris *correxi*: coarteris L
[343] cursum L
[344] sirice L
[345] quidam L
[346] alii L
[347] *ex* rererum L^2
[348] etiam *ex* ea L^2
[349] sagittae *conieci*: agitate L, τοῦ Βελία *Gregorius*

omnes splendorem tuum capiunt. Sicut rosa in medio spinarum, sic inter multos enutriris et super dolosos pertransis laqueos. Alius enim erigit thalamum, altera iungit sponso, alter fit etiam pater, alter avus. Inspice quantum in his malum sit; imperfecti frequenter atque infructuosi dolores sunt coniugum. Zelus sorori non numquam amicitias enutrire, etiam filios edocere [51v] et postea contemni et amaras recipere dolorum retributiones. Tibi autem una cogitatio est, Deum semper aspicere. Necessarium autem modicus victus et parvolum operimentum. Per haec etiam Christo temptationem temptator etiam obiecit, petens ab esuriente in panes saxa converti. Numquam praeter haec aliquid turpe sustineas; non deficiet tibi credenti capsacis olei tui; corvus te pascet sicut Heliam in deserto. Novis Theclam[350] et ignem et a feris effugisse. Disce Pau[lu]lum prompte non solum esurientem, verum etiam algentem. Ad Deum tantum, virgo, aspice, qui in heremo pascere milia hominum novit. Marcescit pulchritudo, transcurrit gloria, divitiae infideles res sunt, potestas ad modicum est; tu autem, miserabiles mundi delicias fugiens, intra in sancta sanctorum exsultans, et cum angelis choros ducens incessabile tripudium, meliorem sortita locum a filiis et filiabus. Sed o virgines, Christum sustinete vigilantes et splendificatis Sponsum suscipite lampadibus et ingredientes cum eo decorem thalami videatis, et his, quae sursum sunt, possitis misceri mysteriis.

Explicit beati Gregorii Nazianzeni ad virginem. Deo gratias. Amen.

[350] novis Theclam: novi sechiam L

Conclusion

As stated in the Introduction, the aim of this work is to consider not so much the moments, thoughts, speculations with which the so-called 'Cappadocian Fathers' proposed a unified doctrine, but the points and moments, the doctrines in which they disagreed. Is it possible, one wonders, to speak of agreement and, at the same time, of differences? Is it useful to change, at least in part, an established opinion, that of the 'Cappadocian theology', and try to find 'chiaroscuros'? The examination of the various problems, which has been carried out in the previous chapters, leads to an affirmative answer; this response is also confirmed by the development of historical events.

Some facts are clear: Basil was the common teacher, accepted as such by all those concerned. Being in agreement with Basil in the doctrines was certainly sought after, at least in words, by everyone, but the one who consciously implemented this project was the Nyssen: not only in the doctrines, but also in practical terms, in at least two cases, completing with the *De opificio hominis* and the *Explanatio in Hexaemeron* what Basil had left unfinished. The Nyssen would not have done it, if he had not thought of having (and wanting) to continue the path started by his brother. The *Contra Eunomium* was also written in defence and in continuation of Basil's similar work. In theological speculation, the Nyssen took up many of his doctrines (for example, pneumatology). It has been rightly said that the Nyssen was truly Basil's heir. And yet even the Nyssen sometimes did not agree with Basil (for example, regarding the doctrine of ousia, or certain cosmological questions).

The same cannot be said – and always on the basis of the concrete facts, as well as his thought – of the Nazianzen. At the beginning of his theological speculation, the Nazianzen did not seem to have followed Basil in a particular way: Basil had devoted himself to the ascetic life from young age, and had only started writing later, both in facing theological problems in the *Contra Eunomium* and delivering his first homilies, when he was still a priest. Gregory's homilies in this period do not show, beyond the proclaimed and not always heartfelt affirmations of esteem, a particular influence of Basil, although Basil had become Bishop of Caesarea from 370, and therefore had authority over Gregory: probably Gregory, while recognizing the strong personality of his friend since the time of their stay in Athens (but this too will have to be reconsidered), in actual practice did not feel the need to imitate him, either in the contents of his homilies or in his theological conception. It is a fact, moreover, that Gregory only reluctantly and briefly kept Basil company in his ascetic life. Subsequently, the well-known events of Gregory's life would create a real fracture between the two: the problem of the divinity of the Holy Spirit, grudgingly admitted by Basil, even if he defended and defined it in a very intelligent

way in the work intended for this subject, had been considered by Basil himself as being within his purview, which Gregory should not have touched because of his lack of sufficient theological reflection (and this judgment, expressed by Basil in his *Letter* 71 certainly had hurt Gregory). The thing, therefore, must have left a bitter aftermath in Gregory: when Basil wrote the *De Spiritu sancto*, Gregory had already broken relations with him and had retired to Seleucia. If the question of the divinity of the Holy Spirit was close to Gregory's heart, he did not seem, in those years, to have had any more interest in it. Furthermore, there was the well-known question of the Bishopric of Sasima, for which it suffices to recall the testimonies of the two interested parties, about each other: Gregory, a few years later, when Basil was already dead, and in any case just before he gave Basil's epitaph, expressed himself in the sarcastic verses of *De vita sua*, describing, with hostility, Basil's arrogance and his taste for power, by which Gregory himself was tyrannized (II 1,11,414-62). And Basil, in turn, with the break that occurred in those days, had written, as follows, to Eusebius of Samosata (*Epist*. 98): 'I, too, was anxious that our brother Gregory should have the government of a Church commensurate with his abilities; and that would have been the whole Church under the sun gathered into one place. But, as this is impossible, let him be a bishop, not deriving dignity from his see, but conferring dignity on his see by himself. For it is the part of a really great man not only to be sufficient for great things, but by his own influence to make small things great' – which evidently Basil, who certainly liked to command, did not consider Gregory capable of. Since then there was hardly any relationship between the two. Basil in *Letter* 217, to Amphilochius (p. 209 Courtonne), recalls, in a few words, Gregory, who suddenly withdrew (to Seleucia); Gregory's letters around 379, which refer to Basil's death, say very little, and in the poem *De vita sua*, in 382, what other criticisms could he make?

Consequently, the tradition, which underlines Nazianzen's friendship for, indeed, his devotion to, Basil, was based above all on the *logos epitaphios* for Basil, recited by Nazianzen three years after his death and probably with political intent, polemicizing with Bishop Helladios (*Orat*. 43). The reading of that oration leaves, in the end, uncertain. Everything is rebuilt with a considerable dose of credibility, but Gregory does not hide his personal opinions. Unfortunately, Gregory's oration is the only one that informs us extensively about what he thought of Basil, even if Gregory certainly does not skimp on the compliments for his friend. Their stay in Athens is presented from the point of view of Gregory, who, when he says that Basil left Athens before him, does not say what the reasons had been, and uncertainty remains, especially as Basil, on returning to his homeland, devoted himself to rhetoric, following, one might say, the teaching of Libanius. Only a few years later his conversion to asceticism took place, and Gregory mentions it, but not exhaustively, probably because he was not entirely convinced that Basil's choice had been the best one – for Gregory, it certainly had not been, so much so that he did not follow him,

if not in a limited way, and in the first letters sent to Basil he referred to his asceticism ironically. After all, according to Gregory's *Oration* 43, Basil's training had been analogous to Gregory's: learning rhetoric, medicine, astronomy, philosophy, and all in the same place, that is, in Athens. It has been said that traditional education, that of rhetoric, had provoked a negative reaction in Basil, unlike the response it had aroused in his brother, the Bishop of Nyssa, and in his friend Gregory of Nazianzen. In fact, there were relative differentiations: this is one of the areas in which the *concordia discors* appears more *concordia* than *discordia*. But if Basil left Athens before Gregory, stating that Athens was 'a vain happiness', it is evident that he was going through a crisis, which was not the case with Gregory, so much so that he continued to celebrate pagan Athens for the rest of his life, while Basil considered those years a period of dissipation. Therefore it cannot be denied that the cultural formation of Basil and Gregory, despite being the same, was more unbalanced in a profane sense for Gregory, even if it is not legitimate to make Basil a kind of desert ascetic, as the Greek paideia continued to be present also in his ascetic writings. And strangely enough, in the case of Gregory of Nyssa, who more than the others had a philosophical education, we do not know where he received it: we are forced to believe that he had studied philosophy in the school of Caesarea in Cappadocia, because he did not go to Athens, unlike the other two. In short, the one who was the deepest philosopher among the Cappadocians did not learn philosophy in Athens. And it would be interesting to know why Gregory's parents did not consider it appropriate to let him follow a curriculum similar to Basil's.

The effects of a common literary education can be seen in Basil and Gregory, in spite of the different paths they travelled, despite the emphasis placed on Basil's ascetic experience and on ascetic monotropy (according to Francis Gautier's thesis) by Nazianzen; Nyssen did not seem to consider the problem of the contrast between Athens and Jerusalem, because he lived in both cities without any difficulty: he appears to have been a friend, without any qualms, of Libanius and pagan sophistry, that Libanius and the sophists were strangers to Christianity had not moved or worried him. Assuming the unity and diversity of the literary formation of the Cappadocians, the second chapter of this book is concerned with finding some typical characteristics of their homilies, their correspondence and Gregory Nazianzen's poetic production. Evagrius uses literary genres in a very particular way, partly in agreement with the other Cappadocians, partly differentiating himself from them. Evagrius, 'philosophe au désert', but also an ascetic, is not interested in long treatises, but in shorter compositions, consisting of concise and impressive sentences, and seems to have been, if not the inventor, certainly the popularizer of the centurial structure of the sentences, which are essentially addressed to the milieu in which he lived, while when he writes to those who also live outside the desert, he uses the letter, also presented in a literary way. Amphilochius of Iconium, on the other hand, seems

unimaginative in this regard, having dedicated himself almost exclusively to homilies – and in any case he did not refrain from writing poetry, perhaps in imitation of the Nazianzen.

If we deal with the subject of Christian philosophy, which all Cappadocians, from Basil to Evagrius, cultivated in more or less depth, it seems that there were no differences between them regarding the use of philosophy. However, I am forced to recommend caution. That they had been prudent in confronting philosophy may seem obvious, but critics have thought otherwise: the most recent studies have increasingly turned to pagan philosophy as the place where the Cappadocians found the solution they proposed for theological (and other) problems. These studies have shown, and still show, a high degree of subtlety, intelligence and exegetical ability; the scholars who have availed themselves of it have used well-known texts, such as Plato's, and lesser-known ones, such as those of Plotinus and Porphyry, but all taking for granted one fact: that the attempt by Christian writers to resolve the problems that arose, in that particular historical environment, could not have succeeded without resorting to philosophy, if the same methods and philosophical doctrines were not used. For the most part this was true: the typical problems of fourth-century (and even earlier) thought and philosophy could not be overlooked by the Cappadocians. Nevertheless, this could not happen indiscriminately and without adequate mediation: it was what Heinrich Dörrie had tried to show forty years ago, certainly arriving at excessive conclusions, when he said that there had not been a Christian Platonism, and that it could not even have existed, because Christianity and Platonism were on opposite positions on certain problems. Dörrie's conclusions had been partly contested, but it cannot be denied that he had touched on a crucial point. The reception of pagan philosophy by Christians was not, therefore, only a formal and external process (that is, in the final analysis, superficial), which would have nothing to do with the content: the Christian writers had certainly made a selection of Platonic doctrines they used. Precisely this sorting was an essential critical method also for the Cappadocians, despite the fact that at present Christian doctrines tend to be interpreted *more philosophico* (see Reinhard Hübner's justified reservations in this regard).

Philosophy cannot be ruled out even in the formulation of Trinitarian theology, and its use has been the subject of repeated discussions: one wondered if it was Stoic philosophy, Platonism and / or Neo-Platonism, and in particular the influence of Porphyry's *Isagoge*. Certainly I did not want (nor could I have done so) to re-examine the fundamental problem of Cappadocian theology, the Trinitarian one, for whose formulation (according to tradition: one substance and three hypostaseis) and whose solution (the 'consubstantial') (in whichever way formulation and solution must be understood) they have remained famous. However, I wanted to add some considerations which, following the criterion that has guided this study, highlight the relationships between the Cappadocians, namely the analogy (very often more presumed than real) and diversity (real,

but which never, however, comes to the point of being an opposition) that characterize their solutions.

It is known that Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa were particularly interested in formulating a current Christology for their time, which would surmount the outdated Arian one, and they dedicated themselves particularly to the definition of the human nature of the incarnate Christ. However, Basil, who had also insisted on this point, had not gone beyond the assertion that the incarnation had not meant a change in the divine nature of the Son. Nazianzen and Nyssen – but apparently without influencing each other on this issue – insisted first of all that the flesh of Christ was truly the flesh of man and worthy of being worshiped as much as the divine nature of the Son, also to respond to the Apollinarian Christology that was spreading since 375. In this insistence, Nyssen underlines above all the humanity of Christ, distinguishing it from his divine nature in a way that has given rise to antithetical interpretations: whether the Nyssen was preparing a dyophysite or monophysite Christology. Does speaking of the humanity of Christ mean resorting, also in this case, to the universal of Porphyry's philosophy, which some scholars had used with regard to the divine nature? Does Nyssen see in Christ the peculiarities of human nature as a whole (not to be interpreted, however, as if it were a Platonic idea) or of the single man Christ, the incarnate Son of God? On the contrary, the Nazianzen, while clearly distinguishing between the two natures, insisted much more on their union, and perhaps had a clearer conception of the divine person of Christ than Nyssen. But our research was not meant to be a study of the Christology of the Cappadocians: it wanted above all to see how they reacted to the Apollinarian Christology. Basil, for whom this Christology occurred in the last years of his life and who was involved in other problems, did not devote particular attention to it, but appears somewhat distantly and incompletely informed, perhaps knowing more about the Christology of some unidentified followers of Apollinaris, also known to Epiphanius in those years, than the works of Apollinaris himself. Gregory Nazianzen has a clear understanding of Apollinarian Christology and at the same time contrasts it with that of Diodorus, but, perhaps, even he had not personally read the works of Apollinaris himself (he does not even mention a title); perhaps he had known above all the disciple of Apollinaris, Vitalis. It was in following Vitalis that the Apollinarians were troubling Nazianzen's community. Only Gregory of Nyssa appears to have been personally informed, until the last years of his life, of Apollinarian Christology, so much so that his *Antirrheticus* is the answer to a specific work of Apollinaris. Finally, Evagrius also knew Apollinarianism well, and his answer appears to be conducted along the lines of Nazianzen's. In conclusion, the Cappadocians' response to Apollinaris was manifold and different. Amphilochius appears to have had much less interest in Christology.

And finally, since the Cappadocians enjoyed enormous fame in the Byzantine world, it would be very useful to search for their presence also in the

Latin-speaking world. Surely, it was necessary to study this topic thoroughly, but the scale of the problem was such as to render an in-depth investigation beyond the scope of this work, forcing to stop a few decades after their death, in the period of Ambrose and Augustine, that is from 385 to 425 approximately. The only Cappadocians who were initially known in the West were Basil and Nazianzen; Jerome also brought in, but superficially, Gregory of Nyssa, and also, not only superficially, but also inaccurately for polemical reasons, Evagrius, whose Origenism, however, he rightly understood. Gregory of Nyssa, instead, was not present in those years – certainly because of the difficulty of his works and his isolated position. At first the Westerners (Ambrose, Jerome, Rufinus) saw in Basil and Nazianzen not so much theologians, but masters of spirituality: for them the true theology remained the Western one, and the formula of the one substance and of the three hypostaseis was not convincing. Instead of 'hypostaseis', it was necessary to continue talking about 'Person'. Only Augustine went a step further, considering, in part, Gregory Nazianzen the theologian, but, apparently, in a sporadic and secondary way. Certainly it would be useful to continue these studies on the Cappadocian *Nachleben* also in the Latin Middle Ages, during which they were known mainly thanks to translations, either direct (and therefore the problem also involves considering translators, such as Dionysius Exiguus and John Scotus), or of writers who quote and / or mention the Cappadocians (such as John Damascene). As regards the Greek Middle Ages, it is known that, apart from the Holy Scriptures, perhaps the best-known works were those of Gregory Nazianzen – but these are problems which require other, longer considerations.

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